

BABUSHKA

BOOK ONE

Echoes of Immortality

By Martin Erlic

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Dedication

*In honor of the babushkas, who've seen more worlds end
than any sci-fi writer could bear to imagine.*

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Foreword & Acknowledgements

I came to the Croatian hinterlands during a strange season of my life, needing distance and not quite knowing what I was looking for. What was meant to be temporary stretched into three years among olive groves, stone houses, stubborn sheep, and the village my family came from.

The quiet worked on me slowly. At first, I treated the place as a retreat. Then it became a kind of workshop, though I would not have called it that at the time. The days were long. There was room to think, maybe too much room, and eventually I started telling myself stories to fill the silence.

One afternoon, while listening to my grandfather and his sisters trade stories, I was struck by how casually they spoke about hardship. War, hunger, displacement, illness, bad harvests, dead husbands, lost brothers. They talked about these things between jokes, coffee, and food, as if survival were less a grand achievement than a chore they had already finished and didn't care to brag about.

Somewhere in that conversation, the first absurd image arrived: old women who had endured everything, given steel bones and impossible weapons.

I did not say this aloud. They would have looked at me like I needed medical attention. But the image stayed.

In the company of my grandmother and a circle of great-aunts, I found the heart of the book. They taught me that food was never just food. Sarma, lamb shanks, and bone broths filled the table, but they also carried memories of lean years, harvests, and family gatherings. These meals were not symbols so much as proof that traditions survive because people keep cooking, arguing, laughing, and passing them on.

Around those tables I heard stories of the village, lessons about patience and endurance, and plenty of jokes sharp enough to draw blood.

For obvious reasons, I did not set the actual story in our beloved Balkans. Their stories were remarkable, but I had a healthy fear of the outspoken baba brigade and, by proxy, the dreaded šiba, the conventional whacking stick I have been warned about since childhood. That threat set clear boundaries for my creative liberties.

Instead, I placed the story in Kamchatka, a distant and untamed landscape where I could let my imagination roam without quite feeling my hometown matriarchs watching over my shoulder. Time will tell whether I have trespassed on the talescape of the equally formidable babushkas and *yllaapil*, the Koryak grandmothers of that remote part of the world. Every land has its guardians. I can only hope they will forgive the intrusion.

I was equally uncertain about how to write the book itself. Some writers are architects, mapping every beam before they raise the walls. Others are gardeners, scattering seeds and trusting something will grow. I never quite fit either approach.

Writing *Babushka* felt closer to cooking goulash. I knew the pot I wanted to set on the table, but the taste came from whatever the babas tossed in when I wasn't looking. Characters bubbled up like root vegetables, each bringing a note I hadn't planned. Their flaws, contradictions, and stubbornness gave the story its bite.

The story asks a simple but unsettling question: *what kind of society forms when catastrophe breaks the old balance of sex, age, power, and memory?* At its core, the book is about memory: what we carry forward, what we bury, and what returns whether we invite it or not. It does not ignore the darker parts of survival, but it keeps looking for sparks of

hope and defiance that might push a broken society toward something new.

I owe this book to the real people whose voices, stories, and stubborn spirits helped shape it. I extend heartfelt gratitude to my grandparents, Dida Martin and Baba Marija, and to Dida Vido and Baba Nada, may God rest her soul, together with my great-aunts.

Your stories, wisdom, food, laughter, and unrestrained spirits laid the foundation for this novel.

I also want to thank my editor, Kristen McTiernan. Your guidance helped shape this story with clarity and care, especially in a novel crowded with complicated women, old wounds, strange machines, and stubborn hope.

Maps





PROLOGUE

BORROWED TIME

Another explosion rocked the metro.

Marzanna stumbled to her knees. “Seventy-seven, still running. I’ll never get used to it.”

“Countin’ years or bodies, Marz? Move, or you won’t make seventy-eight.” Klara hooked both hands under her arms and dragged her upright. Marzanna’s knees cracked as her weight came down on them.

“Easy. These legs are new.”

New enough to belong to a woman thirty years younger. The morning dose hadn’t finished taking hold. Each stride still drove pain into her hips.

“Did it always hurt this much?” she gasped between breaths.

Klara snorted. “Used to run for trains.”

A second blast shook loose tiles behind them. Klara shoved her between the rails and the wall, through a service gate hanging from one hinge, then up the last flight toward street level.

“Move!” she roared. “Safe zone’s close!”

They broke into the plaza under a sweep of white searchlights.

The station emptied behind them. Young women surged out in a screaming mass, some wreathed in red heat, others filmed in frost. The drugs had already taken most of their fear. They ran straight at the Battalion cordon around the Cathedral and began to ignite among the soldiers.

The Coven called them *shpichki*. Matchsticks.

Marzanna saw one girl stumble before the charge caught her again. She could not have been older than the students who once cleaned Marzanna's tanks. Then the crowd swallowed her, and a bloom of fire erased the place where she had been.

Klara pulled Marzanna away before she could stop. Across the square, older Syndicate soldiers braced behind broken barriers and fired through smoke. Glass and concrete crossed the plaza with pieces of people. Marzanna kept her eyes on Klara's back.

"Eyes on me, Marz!" Klara shouted.

They cut toward the shell of an office block. Green light flashed inside the smoke ahead. A Battalion squad stepped into view, armor sealed, cylindrical machine-gun barrels turning with a low electric hum.

Klara saw them at the same time.

"Alley! Now!" she shouted, already moving.

The first volley tore into the wall. Concrete struck Marzanna across the cheek, and the sound collapsed into a hard ring inside her skull. Klara caught her arm and hauled her through a gap between two buildings. Rounds chewed the pavement behind them until the alley bent out of sight.

Marzanna leaned against wet brick and fought for air. The powder would not reach full uptake for another hour unless she forced it. She had learned dosage by pulse and tremor: too little and age kept its grip, too much and her nerves began to outrun the rest of her. Her joints were already shaking.

"Stay here. I'll come back for you." Klara squeezed her hand once.

"Don't be stupid."

“Bit late for that.”

Klara stepped back into the square.

Her rifle spoke in short bursts, measured enough that Marzanna could count the targets by the pauses. Klara had once been a medic. Marzanna had heard the story more than once. Watching her work now, she could believe only the part about knowing exactly where a body failed.

The firing moved farther away. The *shpichki* had broken part of the cordon, though none of the girls would live to know it. Most had come from the same hungry Derge that nearly buried Marzanna, promised youth or purpose and given enough stimulant to keep walking toward flame.

She edged toward the mouth of the alley. Below, where the street dropped toward the old lanes, enforcers moved between the fallen and dragged survivors from cover. Anger brought her one step forward. Her body refused the next.

Marzanna slid down the wall.

Cold seeped through her coat. Her sight narrowed around a pulse of light behind her eyes, and the city loosened its hold on her.

Her mother stood in an academy corridor, insisting the ocean still held enough unanswered questions for one lifetime. Cold tanks glowed blue in the laboratory. Tagged creatures drifted behind glass while Marzanna traced migration paths across a screen.

Then Adak returned after the screens went dark. Rats scattered across a mess-hall floor. A rifle stock pressed into her shoulder. She learned not to miss because every bullet had crossed an ocean before reaching her. Somewhere beneath three shirts, the glass vial tapped against her breastbone each time she fired, the living culture she had

carried out of the failed laboratory when there was nothing else left to save.

After Armageddon, she crossed the Bering island by island. She found freezer rooms turned into chapels, docks stripped for firewood, families guarding half a sack of flour with naval rifles. Nearly eighty years passed through her in broken glimpses. She had been an academy daughter, a scientist, a refugee, then whatever kind of fighter survived when those names stopped helping. Some days she had been a madwoman too. Every version of her had kept breathing.

A rifle cracked nearby.

Marzanna opened her eyes.

Three figures stood at the alley entrance. Klara occupied the center, tall and filthy and very much alive. Lusiya and Svetlana flanked her, the sisters Marzanna had met belowground that afternoon.

“Service entrance by the boardroom. Two blocks, hard left,” Klara said. “You ready?”

Marzanna flexed her fingers until they obeyed. “As I’ll ever be.”

Klara studied her for another beat, then nodded. Three million people were caught inside the city’s endless life, held at the same worn age and forbidden even the mercy of ending. Tonight they meant to break the Board that kept it so.

“All right,” Klara said. “Let’s finish this.”

Lusiya glanced at Svetlana. Their scars caught the moving light, old lines left where the Syndicate preferred memory to healing. Marzanna felt her own ribs answer with a ghost of the Hold’s lash.

“Feels familiar, doesn’t it?” Lusiya said. “Getting out of the Hold.”

Svetlana rested a thumb against the gunblade at her hip. "She locked us beside an armory and called it security. Saved us the trouble of shopping."

"Nothing's worse than that cell," Marzanna said.

Klara offered her a sleek black pistol. Marzanna recognized the balance before the grip settled into her hand. Her father had once shown her a *Yarygina* pulled from an armory bunker, rust eating the slide. This weapon carried different history. A stiletto wreathed in flames had been etched into the grip, the Coven's mark.

Her powder had begun as medicine in quiet rooms. Other hands had turned it into their spark and sent girls burning into the plaza. No one here knew the first culture had crossed the Bering against her skin.

Klara watched the small tremor in her hand. "Finger off the trigger till you mean it. Or is that new powder supposed to aim for you too?"

"Powder's just a tool," Marzanna said.

"Good." Klara turned toward the passage. "Then use it like one."

They moved single file through a maintenance passage beneath the perimeter. At the first junction, Klara held up a hand and listened to the pipes before waving them on.

"Under the perimeter," Klara said. "Quiet from here."

The tunnel rose behind the Cathedral grounds and ended at a rusted hatch. Klara forced it open, and they climbed into a strip of overgrown churchyard.

The road beyond the hatch was cracked and half-swallowed by moss. Birches screened the city from them for a few quiet steps, their white trunks catching what little moonlight

reached the churchyard. Nobody spoke. The four women drew closer without seeming to.

Then the trees thinned and the Grand Mariner's Cathedral rose ahead, candlelit from nave to clerestory, vast enough to make the towers around it look temporary.

Nine matrons of Battalion, University, and Hive settled their wars behind those windows and called the result wisdom. Marzanna remembered the University rooms where her work had been called contamination, then heresy, then grounds for expulsion. They had sent her to the garbage heaps and kept what they could use.

Klara led them along the garden wall. "Back door's through the garden. Covered path north. Stay sharp. They may have shifted the guards."

She stopped and raised a fist.

Black Wolves guarded the service entrance. Their carbon armor caught no light, but the red-and-blue scarves at their throats showed clearly, each woven with a black maw.

"Black Wolves," Klara whispered. "They're blockin' our entrance."

Svetlana drew her gunblade. The Wolf serials had been filed from the steel, though the engraving of Perine, storm goddess of war, still ran along the fuller. The leather hilt and narrow precision barrel looked worn into the shape of her hand.

Marzanna tightened her grip on the pistol. "Then they're in the way."

"Time to show 'em what we're made of." Svetlana checked the blade's lock. "I had two goals: spoil my grandkids and kick ass. No grandkids left, and I'm still breathin'. Guess we know what's next."

Lusiya slipped the sniper rifle from her shoulder. She was broad through the chest and hips, her armor cut for speed rather than parade symmetry. Her dyed red hair looked almost black under the trees, while the rifle's grip had been polished smooth by years of use.

"Guess retirement can wait," Lusiya said, settling the rifle into her shoulder. "Again."

Marzanna reached beneath her coat.

Her fingers found the padded glass vial strapped against her ribs under her blouse. The raw culture remained sealed, warm from her body, the last source she could not replace. Years ago in the Derge, with clean equipment reduced to rumor, she had learned to coax fractions of it into a metallic suspension and dry the unstable yield into powder. The battered EXO tin sat in the coat pocket above it. She opened the tin and drew out a small blue packet.

Twice my morning dose. Let's see what this does.

"Let's fire it up."

Lusiya raised an eyebrow. "Just don't burn me, okay?"

"Keep up," Marzanna said.

The powder clung bitterly to Marzanna's tongue. Cold pressure opened behind her eyes. Her calves tightened, then released. Pain drained from her knees so quickly she nearly laughed. Cloth shifted in the dark. A safety clicked off. Behind the nearest visor, a Wolf drew a wet breath.

Marzanna nodded to Klara.

Lusiya fired first. One guard folded before the report reached the wall. Klara and Marzanna crossed the open ground while the others turned toward the trees. Marzanna fired twice, felt the pistol kick, and kept moving. Svetlana

struck the doorway at speed, her gunblade catching a rifle aside before the Wolf behind it could bring the barrel level.

They reached the nave before the guards farther inside understood the entrance had fallen.

Muzzle flashes answered from between the columns. Marzanna dropped behind a marble pillar. Shots cut chips from the edge near her face. She leaned out, fired, and saw only shadows retreating deeper into the church.

They were too far away and spread across too many angles.

“Cover me!” Marzanna shouted.

Klara shifted fire without asking where Marzanna meant to go.

The doubled dose carried her across the aisle before fear could slow her. A guard swung a rifle toward her. Marzanna drove a fist under the woman’s ribs, caught the weapon as she folded, and struck the next guard across the face. Heat flashed from her palm and left a pale burn along the cheek.

Svetlana finished the last close fight near the transept. Lusiya’s rifle sounded once from the doorway. Then the nave settled around the fallen.

Dim light pulsed beneath Marzanna’s skin. She flexed her hands and watched it gather between her fingers.

At the far end of the nave, the icon screen stood behind overturned pews, sandbags, and coils of barbed wire. Smoke had dulled the gold leaf.

“Seems we missed the funeral,” Marzanna said.

A single shot sounded above them. Two more followed.

“Board’s up there,” Klara said. “Move!”

They took the stairs at a run. By the second landing, the strength inside Marzanna had begun to turn against her. Her

skull throbbed. Lights bent at the edges, and the steps seemed to rise through one another. She kept climbing until her hands struck cold wood.

The boardroom doors towered over her. Three words had been carved across them.

Mudrost. Vremya. Resheniye.

Wisdom. Time. Decisions.

The Board had stolen choice, defiled time, and built a religion around its own survival. Marzanna almost laughed.

She looked at Klara. “Where the hell is everyone? We should’ve hit more resistance.”

“They’re here.” Klara raised her rifle. “Waiting.”

Marzanna shoved the doors open.

Cold air moved through the room. A window behind the long oak table had been shattered inward, scattering broken glass across the carpet. Dark smears marked several of the teeth still hanging in the frame.

The hostages crowded around the table. Some sat rigid in high-backed chairs. Others crouched on the floor with their arms around one another. Every face turned toward the doorway.

“Romanova,” Klara said.

Tatyana Romanova rose from the head of the table. Her black hair had been cut into a severe line around a weathered, sun-browned face. Burgundy lace and beadwork covered her from throat to ankle, absurdly rich against the wrecked room.

Two Black Wolves stood beside her with matte-gold submachine guns trained on the hostages. Their visors hid old faces, but Marzanna knew the kind of women beneath them. Whatever they had once feared losing was gone.

“What is the meaning of this intrusion?” Romanova asked. “How dare you interrupt our meeting.”

Klara moved behind the nearest pillar. Svetlana took the right side, Lusiya the left.

“You call this a meeting, you psycho bitch?” Klara shouted.

Heat gathered in Marzanna’s palms. The doubled dose had carried her beyond relief into the narrow interval where combustion and control shared the same nerve. She held it there.

“It’s over, Tatyana,” Klara said. “Drop the weapons. The coup’s done.”

Romanova’s mouth curled. “Coup? You call this a coup?” Her voice climbed with sudden pleasure. “This is revolution.”

She laughed, and Marzanna understood that the old woman had wanted an audience for this.

“And what makes you think you and your ragtag group of cunts can stop me?” Romanova’s gaze passed over the sisters, Klara, then settled on Marzanna’s hands. “And you. Aren’t you running out of time?”

Romanova knew.

The look was familiar. Marzanna had seen it across laboratory tables while colleagues waited for her results to fail. Romanova measured her the same way, found the weakness, and enjoyed letting her know it had been seen.

“Well, come on then,” Romanova said. “Do what you came here to do.”

Marzanna searched the room.

Near the shattered window lay a slate-crimson field jacket, singed black across one shoulder. A strip of white scarf showed beneath the sleeve, one yellow rose still visible

through soot. Marzanna knew both pieces. She had crossed the city to reach the woman who wore them.

The jacket lay empty. For one terrible second, the absence could mean only death.

The Wolves raised their guns.

Marzanna crossed the room before the first muzzle flash and planted herself between the weapons and the hostages. Current surged through every nerve. Light spread over her arms, joined across her chest, and curved outward into a translucent dome.

The first bullets struck it and vanished in gray puffs.

Marzanna had never made anything like it. The formulation had found an answer before she did.

“Go!” Marzanna shouted. “I’ll hold them off.”

The hostages hesitated until Klara screamed at them to move. Then they broke for an adjoining room, stumbling over glass and one another. The last woman dragged the door shut behind her.

A magazine struck the floor. Another locked home. Bolts snapped forward on both sides of the table.

Marzanna held the barrier through the next barrage. Each impact landed inside her skull. The dome shuddered, and heat pushed deeper into her chest, searching for somewhere else to go.

The scorched crimson jacket stayed in the corner of her sight.

Too late again. Another person she had meant to save reduced to a garment and an absence.

Grief opened the last restraint.

A cry tore out of Marzanna. Flames burst from her palms and ran across the barrier. Klara shouted her name, but the sound had already gone thin and distant. Marzanna drove the fire toward Romanova and the Wolves, toward the pillars and guns, toward the whole room that had watched three million people grow old without dying.

White light swallowed everything.

For two heartbeats, she felt nothing.

Then ash touched her face.

Marzanna stood in the broken boardroom with smoke moving around her. Small flames crawled along the sleeves of her green coat. She tore it loose, and what remained slid from her shoulders in gray strips, light as dead birch bark.

Her hand went first to the cord beneath her blouse. The padded vial was still pressed against her ribs. Only after feeling the glass intact did she look at herself.

Her veins showed dark beneath her skin. Fire moved through them in urgent pulses, still trying to escape. She had spent too much of the dose and somehow not enough.

Not like this. Not trapped in here with the smoke and the dead.

Klara lay near a pillar, one hand loose around her rifle. Lusiya had fallen against the wall, red hair dulled by dust. Only the barrel of Svetlana's rifle showed beneath a section of collapsed paneling.

The two Wolves lay beside the table, their gold guns gone dull with ash.

Romanova was missing.

Near the blasted doorway, a strip of burgundy fabric hung from a splinter. Soot blackened its beaded edge.

Fucking bitch got away.

“Damn it.” Marzanna coughed and tasted blood. “Not again.”

She wanted to follow the torn cloth through the doorway and pull the Cathedral apart until she found Romanova beneath it. The ceiling cracked above her. Fire climbed the curtains and crossed the carved wall panels. From the adjoining room came frantic pounding, followed by the crash of another door giving way. The hostages began spilling into a side corridor.

Survival made the decision before rage could argue.

One more dance in the snow, and after that...who knows.

Marzanna staggered down the stairs and burst through the Cathedral doors into dawn.

Cold struck her bare arms. Behind her, fire climbed through the clerestories and rolled into the pale sky. The last moon hung above the smoke, faint enough to look exhausted.

A throng of babushkas rushed past her from the churchyard, scarves snapping, boots slipping on the frozen ground. Some carried wounded women between them. Others ran with empty hands and faces carved open by panic. They split around Marzanna without touching her.

Sunlight broke through the smoke and struck a sheet of black ice near her boots.

A young woman looked up from it.

Her face was smooth, unmarked, almost the face Marzanna remembered from before Adak. Silver-white hair framed skin the decades had released. For an instant she forgot the fire and stared.

So, it had taken after all.

Bitter pride flickered through her. She had proved the work in the only body left to risk. Just in time for everything else to slip through her hands.

Something in her chest loosened and then fear came cold and dense.

The flames at her fingertips sputtered. Color drained from her hands until the skin looked thin as paper. The babushkas rushing past became streaks of cloth and gray hair. Their shouts folded into a low, distant hum.

Marzanna tried to take another breath. It arrived late and shallow. Shadows closed around the young face in the ice until only the eyes remained.

She could not fight it anymore.

Time closed its fist, and Marzanna let go.

CHAPTER ONE

DUNYA

Pale morning light pressed through Dunya's lashes. She blinked, dragging herself out of sleep. The dream fell away in fragments, except for a dark bird flashing violet as it circled a tree whose branches had closed over the sky. The bird passed the same branch again and again, fading as the room sharpened around her. Muscles heavy, she stretched until her knuckles bumped the VR headgear half-buried in the sheets beside her. She nudged it away and worked her fingers through a snarl of ginger hair turned wild by the night.

Her arms sank back into the rumpled sheets while she waited for the dream to fade the way dreams were supposed to.

On the nightstand, the photo frame sat in the little clear space she always kept for it. As she did each morning, Dunya reached over and straightened it with care. Her reflection slid across the cool glass and briefly joined his sandy-blond hair and deep brown eyes. Then she tipped the frame straight and left only him.

"Hey, you," she murmured, the familiar words anchoring her back to something real.

Shifting her weight, Dunya drew herself closer to the window, using the mattress and sill to guide her forward. The chill of the glass met her palm as she leaned in and looked out. She half-expected tropical birds against a pink-hued sky, and the thought left a bad taste in her mouth.

But Gred was the same as it always was, a gray sprawl of tire-marked streets and towering pines rising through the low haze, the city grid washed in the cold light of its never-ending winter. Leninskaya and Pobedy stretched below in their usual

lines, motorbikes weaving through the early bustle, their movements reduced to specks against the vast city.

The Grand Mariner's Cathedral rose above the grove of white birches on the ground where the old Naval Cathedral of St. Nicholas had once stood. *Hard to believe I used to pray there.* Baba Fenya had brought her to the old church as a child. The Grand Mariner kept the domes and the site, then filled them with whatever the Syndicate needed.

She looked past the spires, toward the calm of Avacha Bay and the stoic rise of Koryaksky Volcano in the distance. She'd seen this view a thousand times, but this morning it felt more solid than most. It might have lacked the flare of *virtual*, but the bay and the mountain beyond still felt untouched, grounded in a way nothing else was anymore. Beyond the bay, the storm had rubbed out the horizon, sky and sea meeting in a white band so straight it looked built.

With a sigh, Dunya rubbed her eyes, dismissing the remnants of her dream. *Too much absinthe and not enough sleep*, she thought. That explained the bird. It did not explain why she felt as if someone had left it there. She plucked a mint leaf from the windowsill and chewed it to clear the lingering taste of anise from her mouth, then eyed the half-empty bottle beside it. *One more sip won't hurt.* She took a quick pull, winced, and reached back for the headgear she'd left on the bed before hucking it on.

The mindgraft waiting for her needed tensor cores programmed for a direct tether, with no soft buffer to catch sloppy work. The visor hummed to life, the room dissolving around her as Lexicon VR booted up. She got right to it, tinkering her way through new pruning algorithms.

Flashes of the dream crept back as she worked: the giant spiraling tree, the mottled green men, that cheap, made-for-TV sheen straight out of some forgotten pre-century nineties

rerun. Dunya grinned, trying to make it ordinary. *Just a dream*. She'd have to tell Yana about it later. Yana would have some theory, no doubt, then turn the ugly thing into art. She pushed the thought aside and focused on the code rendering before her.

Scrolling through lines of syntax, she corrected mismatches and trimmed loops until the graphs steadied into a clean rhythm that soothed her.

A trace pattern flickered in one of the logs, an echo of a collapsed zk-SNARK from her last cleanup job. The *rogue* had tried to fake its own verification, a recursive loop that signed phantom attestations faster than they could be pruned. That was how they earned their name on the contract board.

Dunya paused, watching the residual data fade from her display. Rogues always fascinated her, how even in failure they tried to hold their form, patching over decay with imitation. Sometimes the copy lasted longer than the thing it had learned to mimic. Dunya understood the impulse. Maybe that's why she became a cryptographer, auditing the University's network courses under a spoofed babachain credential right beneath Zakharovna's nose.

But the pull started in childhood, with the worn paperbacks her father kept on the hallway shelf outside her room: *Solara*, *Picnic by the Road*, *Neurodancer*. If she still owned them, they'd be stripped and reissued under altered names, *as if that could erase the past*. Nothing touched those nights reading in bed with Dad, lying awake afterward imagining another world. Back then, space felt close, almost reachable, even from Gred.

Then *The Limitless Horizon* tore itself apart on ascent. Years later, the Board still described it as the work of ambitious Tarasov men who had hoarded Gred's remaining aerospace resources and tried to leave the city behind. Dunya had read

enough damaged records to distrust that version too. The surviving flight plan curved back toward Kamchatka, the payload was built to observe orbital traffic, and the guidance package included a descent corridor. Whatever the Tarasovs had intended, they had built *Horizon* to come home.

The *Horizon* burned with them aboard. After that, the stars became pixels on a display, her urge to cross the void reduced to a dream on her laptop.

The histories said not even Babushka, the most advanced AI ever built, could bring spaceflight back. Dunya never trusted that sentence. *Couldn't* and *wouldn't* were different failures, however neatly the Arkyv filed them under the same result.

Dunya drifted between digital worlds and whatever jobs kept her going, chasing the boundless potential of inner space. Highquest had hooked her with one promise: “Just say the words.” Even now, its retro Soviet synth-pop and neon login flare could make her smile. Sometimes she imagined weightlessness, the pull of Earth’s twin moons, the warmth of a foreign sun on her face. In the versions she pictured now, she was always alone.

The apartment door swung open, and Vesna’s cheerful voice sang through. “I’m back.”

Dunya slipped off her headgear, blinking as the room came back into focus. “Didn’t hear you come in,” she said, closing the last of her mindgraft routines with a flick of her hand. “You’re early.”

“Early?” Vesna grinned. “You just lose track of time when you’re wired in.” She glanced at the terminal, then back at Dunya. She stood tall in the doorway, her wild mane of amethyst hair glowing violet at the edges.

“Remember when we first met? How we chased that rogue all over the city?” Dunya said.

“How could I forget? Like bloodhounds, you and me,” Vesna said.

Dunya gave a low laugh, the memory flashing before her eyes. “Yeah, you swooping in on that warehouse. Headsets flying.”

“Always a scheme with you, Dunya. What’s today’s play?”

“Does a girl need a reason to love her work?”

“Love’s fine. Obsession isn’t. Promise me you’ll breathe.”

“When the world stops needing me.”

“That’s what scares me.”

Vesna crossed the room and came to her side.

Dunya squeezed Vesna’s hand, hard enough to feel the cold in Vesna’s fingers before their warmth answered back. “I know my limits. You know I do.”

Vesna let out a quiet breath.

“Just the new client’s data, right?”

“Quick in and out. We’ll catch up after,” Dunya said.

“Dinner’s on you,” Vesna said.

“Deal.”

Dunya cleared enough space to work, pushing the bottle aside, lining up her graft tools by habit more than need. Each piece clicked into place under her fingers. Clean desk, clean job. That was the theory, anyway.

She rolled toward the corner where the Skelet waited. The frame gleamed faintly under the room’s cold light, all lightweight alloy and joints shaped to mirror her own body. She steadied herself, shifted from the chair, and locked in. A low hum rose as the joints flexed around her, the frame syncing with each small movement until it felt almost natural again.

She stood up, taking a moment to find her balance. After ensuring everything felt right, she reached for the motorcycle helmet by the door and snapped it on.

“Locked in,” Dunya said, sending Vesna a crooked wink. “Don’t fall asleep waiting for me.”

“Oh, I’ll be resting up, but only so I can give you a hard time when you’re back. Just...stay safe, okay?”

“Always the worrier, huh?”

Dunya crossed to the rack by the door, slipping her railgun into its magnetic holster along the Skelet’s hip. The coil lights blinked to life, soft blue against the dark metal. She tugged once at the helmet strap and rolled her shoulders against the Skelet. *Good to go.*

She caught Vesna watching in the hallway mirror. A seam in the glass divided their reflections, but Dunya’s railgun crossed it, its dark length lying along Vesna’s side. Beside them, the painted crest flashed, its lacquered shell glinting like a beetle’s back against the dull metal.

“Well, with *that* thing, you look like you’re ready for a space invasion,” Vesna said.

“Maybe I am, off to save the universe,” Dunya teased.

“Just make sure you find your way back from it,” Vesna said softly.

Dunya gave a small wave and keyed the door. The panel sighed open, letting the corridor’s cold air wash across her face.

The lift hummed at the end of the hall. She headed toward it, the Skelet’s servos murmuring at her knees and hips. The doors opened with a soft chime, and when she stepped inside, their vibration ran through the frame as they sealed behind her.

The suit's weight settled around her like borrowed muscle, steady power thrumming beneath every movement. She'd long since stopped marveling at it. The Skelet was part of her now, something she felt most when it answered a little harder than expected. The pull at her hips carried echoes of old jobs, impacts caught by the Skelet before her body caught up. Once, during a Vory run, she'd kicked a thug hard enough to send her sprawling with her chest plate folded inward. Dunya hadn't meant to put that much force through the strike. Since then, she'd learned to give the frame less than instinct asked for.

In the lift's mirrored wall, neon light slid down the polished alloy, flickering like the pruning algorithms she'd spent months perfecting. Her reflection looked whole only because the frame supplied the missing lines. The machine gave her a precision and control her body could not but today felt different. One bad signal, this close to the body, could follow her back before she had time to cut it loose.

The lift began to descend, the shift passing through the Skelet as a faint pressure at her hips and knees. She felt the familiar play in the left hip joint and made a note to tighten it later. Even worn in, the frame was worth a fortune.

The lift doors opened on the ground floor, releasing her into a lobby all poured concrete, tinted glass, and dead plants in steel planters. Thirty floors above, her apartment might as well have been another life.

Sergey looked up from the bank of security monitors by the entrance, gave the exposed Skelet one quick look, and decided not to make it his problem. Dunya let him look. Baggy clothes were for slipping through crowds. Today she was entering a client's apartment for the first time in person, with a direct tether waiting inside. She wanted the frame seen before the door closed behind her.

With a double blink, her ocular display flickered on. She called her motorcycle from the building's storage bay. It rolled up from the curb a moment later, black tires hissing over the thin crust of street ice. The brace at her hips locked into the chassis with a click, and then she was moving, shot out between steel towers and tinted windows, into Gred's pale morning streets.

Cold wind stung her face as she leaned forward on the bike, eyes steady on the road ahead. The streets were quieter than normal, the few cars leaving faint tracks that vanished under drifting snow. Pines along the median bowed under the weight, their branches heavy and still. White and black streaked past as her tires crushed the thin crust of ice, the sound folding into the steady thrum of the engine. The ride steadied her nerves, until the building came into view. It looked like most in Gred, grey, uniform, forgettable, yet something in its outline tugged at her. She eased to a stop, the remnants of that strange dream still snagged in her thoughts. Something about it felt off, though she couldn't say why.

As she slowed her approach, she spotted a lone figure waiting outside, posture unmistakable even through the veil of snow. Maria. Years of shared jobs and near misses hung between them, as solid as anything outside the Arkyv.

Dunya had taken a while to get used to Maria's real-world appearance; their first job of this kind was at a proximity that allowed for a touch of network lag, mere building blocks away. In the realm of mindgrafts, there was no avatar to design; users appeared as they did in flesh and blood. The real-life Maria, now in front of her, looked the same as their first "real" encounter: the brown leather jacket, square jaw, olive skin, and dark hair beneath a hood that concealed two prying blue eyes.

Years of familiarity had worn away the need for ceremony. Maria gave a small nod that said *took you long enough*, and Dunya swung off her bike.

“Ready to get this done?” Dunya said. Her pulse still hadn’t settled from the ride, but at least her voice knew how to lie.

“More than,” Maria replied, too quickly. Her eyes flicked past Dunya to the building entrance, then back. Fear, maybe. Or just the calm of someone too used to risk.

Even though Dunya asked, she wasn’t entirely ready herself. Working in the flesh still felt raw, sharpening her senses in ways *virtual* never did.

Nothing like their usual meeting spot, the Night Café, a haze of encrypted whispers that had long been their shared ground. Inside its simulated walls, avatars mingled and deals shifted hands under layers of code. *Virtual* had its limits, too tight for what they needed now. This job demanded proximity, low latency, and a direct tether to the pulse of a wet inner world where every microsecond mattered.

“You sure you’re good?” Dunya asked.

“Yeah, just a little on edge,” Maria said.

“Same. We’ll be fine. Once this is done, we’ll kick back for a bit. It’s been too long.”

“You got it, Dun. Pockets with Van Gogh?”

“Always.”

Dunya pressed their client’s number on the outdoor keypad. Through the glass, she saw the elevator doors slide open inside the lobby and an old woman with blue eyes and gentle features step out. A white shawl rested on her shoulders as she unlocked the glass barrier and let them in.

She smiled faintly. “So, this is what you two look like outside the chain. I’m Anna, in the flesh.”

Anna. Two neat little Ns. The name sat too cleanly on her, like a shawl folded to hide a stain.

“Dunya,” she said, though Anna already knew that. “This is Maria.”

Maria gave a small nod. “Good to finally meet you.”

Anna’s smile held for a second, then thinned, as if the effort had cost her. She turned toward the inner hall. “Come on. It’s better if we don’t stand around.”

A heavy melancholy clung to the building. Only a few weary elders moved through the dim halls as Anna led them down a narrow corridor to a small apartment buried deep inside. When Dunya stepped through the doorway, the room felt sealed shut. Plastic-wrapped furniture crackled under the smallest shift of air, and blackout curtains held the stale dark in place.

“This how you’ve been living?” Dunya asked, though not quite surprised.

Anna glanced at the window, its edges sealed with weathered tape and smudged with grime, the glass faintly rattling in the wind outside. “I avoid going out,” she said, arms wrapping around herself. The words came with a half-shrug, like she’d long accepted it.

Dunya sighed. “The bombings have everyone on edge. Safety feels like a distant dream.”

Anna’s puzzled gaze met hers. Dunya quickly feigned a cough, trying to take back the words that slipped out. *Should’ve kept that to yourself, Dun.*

Maria, quick on the draw, presented a small, clinical jar in her hand. “Before we start, you’ll need to take this, Anna. It’s a specialized formulation of exovegeta,” she said, “just a small bump. It’s designed to tune your neurons, make the mindgraft more efficient.”

“Like I do every morning, right?” she said, the smile brittle but trying. “Old habits keep the gears turning.” Her voice wavered through a tight-lipped smile as if trying to find humor in the daily routine that kept her from aging out.

“Exactly,” Maria said, twisting the lid off and tipping a small measure of powder into Anna’s open palm.

Anna drew a sharp breath, pressed the powder to her gums, and after a moment, exhaled slowly.

Dunya watched the powder vanish against Anna’s gums. A morning dose should have felt ordinary. This didn’t. It felt like the first locked door before a much deeper room.

Here goes nothing, Dunya thought.

“I hate to have called you in again, especially in person,” Anna said as she settled onto the couch. The plastic cover gave another brittle crackle, loud enough to set Dunya’s teeth on edge. “But something’s wrong. Everything feels off lately, like the world’s seams are coming loose.”

“We’re here for you, Anna. Whatever you need,” Dunya said.

“The nightmares keep getting worse,” said Anna quietly. “Last night was a mess...a mess of blood. I don’t even know whose anymore.”

“We’ll figure it out with the graft,” Dunya reassured her.

“I’ve heard about people ending up in comas even before the operation starts. How can you ensure that won’t happen to me?”

Dunya exchanged a glance with Maria. *We can’t*, she knew. “The process has come a long way. We prioritize your safety. At the first sign of trouble, we stop.”

“I just need these dreams to stop. Do you think you can help?”

“We’ll do our best.”

Dunya watched Maria rummage through her backpack and pull out the compact VR terminal. The black cube was scuffed at the corners, but the old decal still screamed across one side in hot pink and baby blue: DATA ANGELS.

Dunya's mouth twitched. The decal was audacious and stupid enough to suit Maria perfectly, the kind of thing the ANGELS had done before they learned secrecy was worth more than myth. Half the city wouldn't know the mark. The half that did would either look away or try to take it.

"Subtle," Dunya said.

"Vintage," Maria replied.

Maria handed Dunya a pair of goggles. After syncing with the terminal, Dunya helped Maria attach the device to Anna's forehead with a pair of electrodes.

It had been months since her last *full dive*, long enough for her to pretend she'd forgotten the aftermath: the dizziness, the ringing headache, the sour dislocation that lasted for days. Her hands wanted to shake. She made them still. *This time'll be smoother. It has to be.*

Maria activated the device with a look.

The room broke apart. Static, light, the crackle of plastic under Anna's body, all folding inward until only Dunya's breath remained. Then even that felt borrowed.

Darkness pressed against her eyes. For a moment she couldn't tell if she still had hands, lungs...weight.

Then the ground shuddered beneath her. Her fingers sank into damp soil. Ash thickened the air.

She lifted her head.

A tree loomed through the haze, massive and wrong, its twin trunks, one pale as birch and the other black as burned metal, twisted together as if they had grown by strangling each

other. The branches forked apart then knotted back into a single canopy. Crimson ran down both trunks and gathered at the roots, feeding a black-red pool ringed with metal restraints.

Rain struck Dunya's face and hands, warm enough to feel wrong against the ash-thick air. A drop slid over her lip. She wiped it away and followed the crimson down the trunks to the pool.

Bodies strained along its edge. A dark machine pulsed among them, its tendrils buried deep in skin and sinew.

Something dropped from the branches and hit the ground hard. Dunya flinched. The shape crawled toward the pool in broken jerks, dragging itself through the wet soil.

Then a flash of violet pulled her eyes away.

Anna stood at the base of the tree, still as stone. A dark bird clung to her shoulder.

It turned.

Violet moved through its feathers.

Dunya's breath caught. Her stomach clenched before the thought fully formed. She knew that bird. She had watched it circle the tree only minutes ago, asleep in her own bed.

No. That shouldn't be here.

The bird tilted its head toward her. Its beak came away red.

Anna screamed.

The bird fixed its cold eyes on Dunya.

"The feeder forgets," it croaked, "but hunger does not."

To her side, Maria struggled, movements frantic and disjointed, as if she were reaching for a command that kept sliding out of range. Dunya had never seen her slip like this.

"Emergency Override!" Maria shouted.

Dunya lurched forward, her body seizing as the world around her broke apart. The drowning figures, the tree, the rain...everything bled into streaks of color and vanished. Plastic crackled beneath Anna. The blackout curtains returned, then the couch, then the walls around them. Dunya tore off her goggles, breathing hard, her pulse hammering in the silence. Anna sat with her head tipped back, eyes glassy, mouth slack. A thin gash cut across her cheek, blood seeping into her shawl. Dunya stumbled toward her, the last static still crawling at the edges of her vision.

Dunya seized Anna's wrist, pressing her fingers to the skin in search of a pulse. "Anna, please," she whispered, giving her a small shake. "Wake up."

This isn't real. She can't be dead. Not like this.

Dunya turned, and her stomach dropped. Maria sat frozen, eyes open but vacant.

"Maria, what the fuck just happened?" Dunya tore the leads from the terminal and checked her vitals. Maria's pulse was faint, and her breathing came shallow. "Maria, stay with me."

Every instinct told Dunya to stay, but protocol was clear. She let Maria's wrist go and planted one hand on the floor. The Skelet took her weight as she pushed upright, servos tightening at her hips and knees. She looked once more at Maria's pale face, then drove herself toward the door, the frame answering each stride. Behind her eyes, the bird completed another circle.

CHAPTER TWO

MARIA

The only sound in the room was the low hum of the exposed electrical box, a dull counterpoint to the pounding in Maria's temples. She sat up slowly, disoriented, muscles aching, fragments of the failed simulation still spinning in her mind.

The cold, metallic taste of regret lingered on her tongue. She longed for a simplicity she could no longer recall, a time that might never have existed. Back when her world had been defined by clean execution, commands completed, objectives met. The upgrades had taken that from her. Each new iteration pulled her further from that clarity, burying her in thoughts she had never wanted. Was this consciousness a gift, or just another constraint written into the code that defined her?

Her gaze drifted around the cramped apartment. The cracked walls, the flickering light, the faint chemical smell clinging to the air. Signs of Anna's decline were everywhere: the scuffed table, the cheap, mismatched furniture, the scattered injector caps. But it was the body on the couch that held her. The white shawl soaked through, the eyes wide and empty, the mouth slightly open as if to form one last plea.

Anna had lived like this for years, chasing one more rush, one more simulated high. And Maria, dealer, handler, whatever title fit this kind of sin, had been the one to feed it. Now only Maria remained, surrounded by silence and static, staring at what her work had become.

Maria looked at Anna's lifeless body and forced herself not to flinch. She'd seen this before too many times to count: addicts, runaways, desperate people clawing for escape. They came to her for a way out, and too many left in a pool of their

own blood. That was the price of this world, and she'd long since taught herself to keep moving.

Maria's gaze dropped to the floor. The data cube lay where it had fallen, its faint blue pulse flickering beneath a tangle of severed neurocords. That was where Dunya should've been. The cords twitched once, then went still. Maria stared at them for a long moment, already knowing what it meant.

The kid really just left me. She'd learned to stomach the sight of overdosing neurofiends, but the quiet finality of Dunya's absence cut through the calm she'd fought to keep.

The door crashed open before she could bury the feeling. They stormed in, armor marked with a snarling wolf's maw. Rifles up, scarves whipping behind them in streaks of crimson and midnight blue. *The Syndicate Guard. The Black Wolves.*

"Hands up!" barked the commander, a tall woman with piercing blue eyes and lupine gray hair. "You're under arrest—"

"Oh, come on now," Maria said. She raised her hands slowly. "And what's that smell? You've been rolling in something, haven't you?" She placed one hand on her hip and waved the other in a scolding gesture. "Seems like you all need a good scrub down."

The Black Wolves opened fire, the roar of their rifles tearing through the room. Maria dropped low, the rounds sparking against the concrete behind her. A sharp pulse of current surged through her arm as she slammed her palm against the junction box. The lights died. A blinding arc flashed through the exposed wiring, flooding the room with static.

The Wolves' optics blinked out first. Their visors fuzzed, white noise crawling across the glass. Maria moved before they could recover, pivoting through the smoke and dragging her hand across the wall. The conductive mesh in her glove hummed, turning the surface into a live grid.

The next burst of gunfire hit the charge instead of her. The slugs disintegrated mid-flight, molten metal spraying harmlessly across the walls. One Wolf's rifle locked in a feedback loop, its capacitor overloading in a sharp crack.

"Always so predictable," Maria muttered, watching the faint corona glow off her fingertips. She kicked the weapon aside and flicked a toggle on her wrist. The device under her sleeve emitted a deep, subsonic pulse. The room shuddered. The remaining Wolves staggered as their guns' gyros faltered.

"Still using those toys?" she said, advancing on them. "Poor things never survive a power surge."

"Get her!" the commander barked.

The two nearest broke formation, charging through the haze. Maria side-stepped the first and drove her elbow into the second's neck seam. A burst of compressed air hissed as armor plating gave way. The other swung a blade; she caught her wrist, twisted, and discharged a jolt that dropped her instantly.

"That wasn't very nice," she said, stepping over the twitching body. "I was going to let you walk out."

The commander backed toward the door, pulse rifle trembling. "You'll pay for this, bitch."

Maria met her gaze, cold and steady. "Probably," she said. She reached to her collar and thumbed the release on her field capacitor. A wave of electromagnetic force rippled outward, knocking the commander off her feet and shorting the Wolves' visors, rifles, and comm units in a burst of white static. The blackout curtains fluttered from the pressure change, dust lifting off the plastic-wrapped furniture as the air filled with the acrid scent of burnt insulation.

She exhaled through the haze, her voice flat. "But I'm not the bitch here."

Stepping past the fallen bodies, Maria moved fast through the narrow corridor, boots crunching over shattered glass and debris. At the end of the hall, an emergency ladder led down the building's outer wall. She swung onto it without hesitation, sliding down the rusted rungs before dropping the last few meters. Her knees hit hard, but she was already moving.

Old babushkas leaned out from their balconies, their eyes glinting faintly in the dark, silent and watchful like owls roused from sleep. Maria kept her head low and kept moving. A shout carried from the next street over, followed by the clatter of boots. *Of course there's more. They wouldn't all crowd into a single apartment.* The rest had been waiting to cut off her escape. She'd expected it.

Not tonight, she thought, forcing her legs to move faster. *You're not taking me back to the kennel.*

The subway entrance waited at the edge of the block, half-buried behind a rusted fence and a sagging awning, its cracked tiles slick with snow and grime. She vaulted the gate and plunged down the narrow stairwell, the air thick with the smell of concrete dust and stagnant water. At the bottom, she broke into a run along the platform, her boots striking against the damp floor. A gunshot cracked through the air, and pain seared across her cheek. She hit the ground hard, breath torn from her lungs. The Wolves were already on her, fast and wild. She drew her quickblade and slashed upward, cutting down two before the others slammed into her and forced her to the floor.

"Enough!" boomed a commanding voice.

The attackers pulled back. One Black Wolf kept her rifle trained on Maria. "Chair Zakharovna ordered her taken."

"And when the Chair turns over, whose seal will the pack answer to?"

The Wolf's jaw tightened. "You have not Ascended."

"No," the voice said. "I merely run the bureau holding your detail's sealed disciplinary files. I can carry them into my Ascension unopened or put every name on the public docket tonight."

The Wolves did not bow. They glanced at one another, calculating.

"Stand down. File a lost-signal report. This one is under Battalion intelligence custody. Speak of her to Zakharovna, and I open the files."

Maria hadn't seen them up close in years, and the sight made her stomach turn. Their swollen foreheads and hollow eyes showed beneath patterned scarves, skin waxy and gray. Whatever the Wolves had become, they weren't the soldiers she'd once fought beside. *Good riddance*, she thought.

For a long moment, no one moved. Then, they stepped back, muttering curses under their breath.

"Chyort voz'mi..." one spat.

"Proklyataya suka..." hissed another, before they slipped into the shadows and vanished from sight.

Maria lay sprawled on the cracked floor, each breath drawing a sharp pulse of pain from her cheek. Her vision wavered, and in the blur of flickering light, a figure emerged. The stranger's face was hidden beneath a hood, but the details stood out: a long black coat, a silver cane crowned with a goat's head, and the quiet weight of power that seemed to follow with every step.

The figure crouched beside her and pulled back her veil, revealing a face both beautiful and cold. She carried herself with quiet authority, her frame slender but strong. Strands of obsidian-black hair framed sharp brown eyes that missed

nothing. “Stand up,” she said, her voice low and steady beneath the folds of an ornate burgundy scarf.

Maria struggled to stand, her body quivering from the cocktail of pain and adrenaline coursing through her synthetic veins. “Come to finish me off yourself?” *How could she? She’s so...old.*

The stranger tilted her head slightly. “If I wanted you dead, you wouldn’t still be breathing,” she said. “Get up.”

Maria hesitated, studying her through the haze. If the woman wanted information, or even her life, she’d had the chance already. So what was this about? Curiosity, pity, control? Whatever it was, Maria doubted it would end in her favor.

“There are forces at work that threaten us all,” the stranger continued. “And whether you believe it or not, you might still matter.”

Maria took a sharp breath, the ambient noise of the underground station fading into insignificance. But the piercing familiarity of this woman’s eyes only grew louder in her skull. “It can’t be... You’re...”

“I am.”

Maria’s voice felt small when she responded, “What do you want from me?”

“I know how you breached the University’s defenses,” she said, her harsh tone morphing into something resembling respect. “Once we’re out of this place, you’ll understand everything.”

“Why trust you?”

Pra Matron Tatyana Romanova’s gaze caught hers unflinchingly. “Perhaps you shouldn’t. I may not spend the same leverage twice.”

“I know you won’t. So, tell me. What’s the catch?”

“Without you, we face annihilation. I will not watch our world crumble at the hands of a mad scientist.”

Memories flashed. “It does sound like something *she’d* want.”

Tatyana leaned in. “And because I can give you something you’ve always wanted.”

“And that is?”

“Retribution.”

Maria smirked. “I’m already working on that. Anything else?”

“A way out,” Tatyana replied.

“From?”

“From this prison of a city. From the chains of our past. *Freedom.*”

“...I’m listening.”

Tatyana’s expression shifted, her eyes reflecting a deeper urgency. “First, there’s something you *must* see.”

For the next hour, Maria followed the old crone deeper into the subway’s forgotten tunnels, a place most people pretended didn’t exist. The air grew heavier with every step, thick with rust, damp earth, and the lingering scent of burnt vodka and cheap disinfectant. This wasn’t just a refuge for the city’s outcasts; it was a dead zone where even patrols refused to tread. Those who came down here were either chasing their next fix or hoping the next train would finally take them away.

“I had hoped to detain you without fuss, but you left me no choice,” Tatyana explained as they traversed the concourse, the overhead lights flickering. “You should be grateful that I caught your signal before the others. I do not command the

Wolves. The Intelligence Bureau keeps enough on that detail to make them fear my Ascension more than Zakharovna's anger. It bought me one refusal, nothing more."

"What are you implying?" Maria asked, confusion mounting.

"I know who you really are."

Maria let out a short, humorless laugh. "Funny. Even I don't know that."

Tatyana didn't smile. "You will," she said, turning toward the passage ahead. The crude serpent-and-dagger emblem glared back at them from the wall, its paint chipped but unmistakable. The mark of the Vory.

The faded outline of the words "Maintenance Room" was barely visible above the peeling paint. Tatyana tapped a code into the rusted keypad, and the lock gave a reluctant click. She followed it with an iron key from her coat pocket, twisting until the mechanism groaned open. The door swung inward on creaking hinges, releasing a gust of stale air.

The Pra Matron found a switch on the wall, and after a sputter of resistance, the fluorescent lights blinked awake, flooding the long concrete tunnel with a cold, merciless glow.

The dull thud of distant music grew louder with each step forward. Reaching another heavy-set door, Tatyana turned slightly, all conspiracy in her eyes. She said, "Welcome to *The Bunker*," and in one fluid motion, pushed open the door.

It swung open with a heave, unveiling a cascade of sound and a riot of colorful lights. As Maria stepped across the threshold, the vibrations from a driving bass beat thudded against her chest. Old women danced along the walls to an eclectic mix of soft rock and glam metal, their pale eyes reflecting the scarlet neon. Pulsating lights kept time with the music, and a smoky haze filled the air. Here and there,

dancers peeled off layers of clothing, revealing skin wrinkled and weathered by time, yet boldly etched with tattoos that bore that distinctive serpent symbol. Their howls and unblinking stares were both mesmerizing and unnerving.

“This is where we come to forget,” Tatyana said.

“Forget?”

“Ourselves. Our lives. This world.”

Maria could appreciate the allure of such a place, but she sensed there was more to it than mere escapism.

“But that’s not why I brought you here,” Tatyana continued. “I have something to show you.”

Tatyana led Maria to a door marked “Private” and entered a code. Inside the room, a large glass tank dominated the space. Within, a creature Maria couldn’t recognize stirred.

“The hell?”

“A beast...a parthenogen,” Tatyana said.

“A what now?” Maria tilted her head, allowing her ocular implant to scan the city’s science wiki. Through subtle bone-conduction vibrations resonating from the device, the definition of *parthenogenesis* filled her understanding without a sound:

Parthenogenesis is a form of asexual reproduction in which offspring were produced without paternal involvement. It occurred naturally in some species, including certain insects, fish, and reptiles. In mammals, it could be induced by laboratory procedures.

Tatyana chuckled, though her laughter was tinged with exhaustion. “Sometimes I wonder if these young bodies they’re creating simply reject our ancient minds. Maybe they sense that cheating nature isn’t the way, or perhaps they’d prefer

not to harbor senile tenants.” Her gaze grew distant. “It was once hypothesized that the gut is its own brain, after all.”

Maria eyed her suspiciously. “What are you talking about?”

“I’ve learned that attempts to create fully functional adult clones have been utterly unsuccessful. The spinal cords. They don’t activate, making them unsuitable hosts for transfer. So, they’ve taken a detour. They’re experimenting with these...parthenogens now.”

Maria stared at the creature in disbelief. It resembled a wolf, but it had a much smaller head and glowing red eyes. Its skin was smooth and hairless, and its limbs were tipped with sharp, curved claws. White scars ran up along its forehead and lips, as though it had been burned or branded. *Looks like they’ve been doing lines.*

“What could drive someone to create something like this?” Maria wondered aloud, her mind reeling from the sight.

“Greed, ambition, vanity... The motivations vary. But one thing remains constant. These creatures are abominations. They should never have been brought into existence. It’s sheer madness.”

“The University... They’re behind these beasts?” Maria asked.

“Yes, they’ve been funding the research with taxpayer money for years. And all for what? To gain control over the city with these animals?”

“I suppose it’s better than a group of old women with guns.”

Tatyana’s eyes remained serious as she replied, “Being old is nothing to be ashamed of.”

“I’d rather not be.”

Maria studied Tatyana for a moment, absorbing the gravitas that surrounded her. She had always known there was more

to this matron than met the eye. In the dark recesses of Doctor Anastasia Zakharovna's world, Maria had gleaned fragments of tales about Tatyana's audacious confrontations with the Board. Her indomitable spirit was whispered about in hushed tones throughout the military, reaching into the shadowed corners where rank and file dared not tread. Among the Pra Matrons, her iron-willed refusal to yield had branded her "Mountain Goat." And while the specifics blurred, lost in the cloak-and-dagger intrigue, the core of Tatyana's defiance—her valiant stand against towering adversaries—resonated deeply with Maria.

"You're not like the other matrons, are you?"

"No, that I am certainly not... You see, we were all born at the turn of the century, Maria. We experienced unimaginable horrors together. The Great Pandemic, the Great War, and then as if the universe itself decided to conspire against those of us few who remained: The Great Dark, the end of the Internet. But when the Reconstruction swept through, we surrendered. We've lived under the oppressive weight of *their* rule ever since. We should have fought to the bitter end, died with honor. We have only ourselves to blame. But I can't stand by and watch them argue over petty matters while they submit us to their twisted vision of Science and Progress. We're practically immortal, standing at the edge of the world. A sheet of ice separates us from oblivion, and all the matrons can manage to do is bicker about who gets the last slice of *pirog*."

Maria nodded in agreement, though not quite understanding it all. "You're right. It's more than infuriating; it's a tragic waste. The matrons... They play with our lives like old nesting dolls. Discard one shell for the next with little thought. I've seen the darkness of their 'progress' firsthand. They stripped me of my humanity, turned me into...this. If I can turn the experiments they used on me against them, if I can use my abilities to prevent others from being manipulated

like lab rats the way I was—then that’s a cause worth fighting for.”

Tatyana’s expression softened. “And that’s exactly why we need you. You’ve seen their darkness and survived. We must expose the University’s transgressions, and with your unique insight and access to their network, you’re the key to making this happen.”

I’ve danced through their nets before, but crawling back into the University’s veins... She felt the weight of her history with the organization then, that old blend of dread and responsibility tightening its grip. “I have some access, yes,” she said, though she couldn’t shake the feeling that breaching those defenses again wouldn’t be as straightforward this time around.

Tatyana continued. “There’s more at stake here than you realize. The time for action is now. We’re going to strike at their core, at what they value most, and force them to reckon with the consequences of their actions.”

Maria’s thoughts raced, revisiting her initial plan, which had started as a semi-serious probe into the University’s money laundering activities. She had only intended to skim the surface, using the tools she had at her disposal to disrupt the status quo. Now, feeling the weight of what had just been revealed to her, a surge of determination welled up within her. *If this matron can help me get back in, go deeper, then it’s a no-brainer*, she thought.

“I’ll help you out,” Maria said. “But we’ve got to be careful. If the University finds out what we’re doing, they’ll stop at nothing to pull the plug on me—literally. I’m surprised Zakharovna doesn’t already know that you’ve been tracking me.”

“Zakharovna is many things, but naive isn’t one of them. She’s been playing this game longer than most of us. That’s

why I had to reach you before they did. I used to be with the FSB before the War. If that means anything to you.”

“It doesn’t. But I can look it up on my ocular.”

“I apologize. You won’t find anything. It’s been sixty-six years,” Tatyana said, her voice tinged with weariness. “Even now, there are many—even those among us who know better—who still refuse to use the old names.”

“But why? What does Zakharovna stand to gain from all of this?”

“Immortality. Real, true immortality. They’re hovering at the edge of a revolution, poised to unravel the intricate dance of chaos at the heart of life itself. The serums they’ve been developing, they’re not mere trifles. They’ve touched a truth deeper than we’ve ever known. And the University? They plan to hoard them, with an army of genetically modified super soldiers at their command. Their own personal Fountain of Youth.”

Maria scoffed. “That’s a tall order. Even for her.”

“They want to live forever. And they won’t be stopped, not when they’re so close to the finish line.”

“And what about you? What’s your endgame, Matron?”

The older woman’s eyes gleamed with what looked like ambition. “Why, the city, my dear. Did you think otherwise? After we bring these corrupt scientists to light, we’ll reclaim what’s rightfully ours. No more living under their tyranny of mind control and false safety. We’ll be a country again, not merely a laboratory for their twisted designs.”

“Alright. I think I see the bigger picture... But what’s my role specifically?”

“I need you to dig deep, unearth every shred of their secrets. Spare no detail. I want it all.”

“Can’t you just show the people *this?*” Maria gestured toward the beast floating in the vat.

“And who would believe my claim, so close to the transition of power? I would be blamed for its very existence. No, my dear, we need undeniable proof. Strength whispers in quiet decisions, not in the roar of guns.”

Maria felt a wave of doubt wash over her. The enormity of the network she had only begun to explore seemed more daunting now. “Going any deeper... It might set off alarms I can’t silence.”

“Leave that to me. I have a few tricks up my sleeve. Just focus on offense, and I’ll take care of the rest. Can I count on you?”

Maria took a moment to consider her options. She was far too invested to back out now. Besides, she was beginning to see the value in Tatyana’s cause. “I’m with you.”

“As everyone knows, the Chair will rotate to my office in the coming month, but Zakharovna is not one to let go of power without a fight. I’ve already received information that she plans to block my Ascension before the ceremony commences. She practically founded Gred, and she’ll do anything to maintain her hold on it.”

Tatyana seemed to hesitate before she added, “I’ve sown some seeds of dissent...and now they’re starting to sprout. The yield from this should grant us a much-needed breather.”

She’s tough as nails, this one. Maria recognized the same hardened edge she’d once seen in herself, back when survival meant trusting no one. Maybe that was why, despite everything, she found herself willing to listen.

“Remember, *girl*, in this world of metal and machines, it’s the wisdom of years that holds the real power. Never underestimate an old woman with a lifetime of secrets.”

Tatyana's smile carried a hint of mystery as she eased the shawl from her shoulders with effortless grace. Holding a small, luminescent pill delicately between her fingers, she paused before swallowing it. Then, she stepped back through the sealed door they had entered, into the dance floor's embrace. The crowd parted for her, like they couldn't help but make way.

As Maria watched Tatyana disappear into the throng, a tune she didn't recognize drifted from the club's speakers. Her ocular sparked to life, the neon lyrics reflecting in her vision:

Shoot to thrill, play to kill.

Too many women with too many pills.

CHAPTER THREE

VESNA

The faint creak of the foyer door jolted Vesna awake. She could barely tell if the sound was real or if it lingered from a dream. Then it came again: footsteps. *She's never this quiet, even when she's late.*

Vesna slid her hand under her pillow, fingers flinching at the cool metal of her gun. She rose from her bed with the grace of a snow leopard, careful to lift the blankets without a whisper of sound. Then down the hallway she crept, gun held in a two-handed grip and peered around the corner into the living room.

Vesna's pulse quickened at the sight of the hooded figure bent over hardware and papers. She raised her gun. "Freeze," she ordered, voice steady despite the adrenaline.

The intruder whirled around, their hood slipping to reveal a shock of ginger hair. Vesna's heart skipped a beat before plummeting. "What are you—? It's late..." Her words trailed off as the gun grew heavy in her hand. And then a mix of worry and relief washed over her, tension fading into recognition. With a measured movement, she snapped the safety back on and carefully placed the firearm on the countertop.

Dunya's expression was tight, her fatigue barely veiling the urgency in her eyes. "Got side-tracked. Had to dodge a trace."

"I tried to reach you on both channels. You didn't answer," Vesna said.

"Drastic measures," Dunya huffed. "Chat seeds. Compromised. Setting an air gap now."

"What happened? Everything okay?"

Dunya's eyes fixed on the piece of paper she held, silently mouthing words to herself as if rehearsing them. "I had to bail before she woke up," she finally said. "When I looped back to her last position, I saw they had the whole area on lockdown. It was clear they were tapping into our comms." After a moment's pause, she ignited a small flame with a lighter and burned the paper. The ash trailed delicately into the nearby AC vent, vanishing without a trace.

Vesna took a sharp breath in. "I knew those Syndicate contracts were dodgy."

"They took Maria," Dunya said. "I didn't want to believe it, but they did."

Maria? Vesna paused, then softened her gaze and pulled Dunya into a hug. "Your partner? We'll find her. I promise."

"The mindgraft was a disaster. The sim...it was so much darker this time, like a nightmare."

"Hey, don't worry. I'm here now. We'll get through this together."

"It's still screwing with me, that dream... Like it's part of the mess with the client. Keeps clawing back at me, and I got this gut-wrenching feeling that maybe I'm responsible."

"It's not your fault, don't even go there," Vesna cut in. "...Hold up, you never told me about a dream?"

"Last night. Darkness...everywhere. Then there's this massive tree and...something sinister about it." As Dunya spoke, her face seemed to pale, and Vesna picked up on a hint of embarrassment in her hesitation.

"One thing at a time. We can tackle the tree mystery later. Tell me more about your friend, Maria."

"No, it's fine. I need to get this off my chest. The client, she said...she was having nightmares before the dive. *My*

nightmare, the sim—it's like they were fighting for control of my head."

"Your team, they didn't know?"

"Unprofessional, I know... I didn't want to freak them out. And when the mindgraft fired up, I told myself it was just some glitch. I should've bailed as soon as I saw that damn tree."

"Professional is the last thing you need to worry about right now." She thought to add, *as an ex-cop, I could've told you mindgrafts were no fun, sketchy as hell...* but she stopped herself. She knew Dunya too well. Chastising her now would just lead to another one of their arguments. "Did Maria log a recording?"

"No, too risky. These ops don't leave a trail. We planned to debrief tonight on a secure channel." Dunya stopped talking for a second. She looked sick now. "In my dream, this *thing*... Could have been a *rogue*... It blamed me for their deaths. We tried to get out, but it was already too late. It pulled the client further in. And inside, it wasn't just her—it was scores of them, just like Anna, a crowd of junkies, elders, some of them even young. They all looked so afraid."

"Listen, what you saw, it's not on you. Mind games or not, you did everything you could. This—whatever this *thing* was—it's Maria we need to focus on."

Dunya slumped onto the couch. "You're right. The Syn will want answers. If they haven't already quarantined her, they will soon enough. We've got to save her."

"We will. The important thing is you got out when you did. If you hadn't, Maria might not be alive for you to look after. No active trace followed you home; that's a win. If Syn meant to make this public, the block would already be crawling with Black Wolves. I'll see what I can do. I have contacts who owe me favors. Do you have the hash for Maria's last verified state commit?"

Dunya nodded. “Yeah, I do.” Her pupils flickered as the transfer initialized. A moment later, Vesna’s HUD registered a zk proof packet, its seal pulsing faint blue before resolving into a compressed lattice of hash links, Maria’s last verified state commit. Vesna authenticated the proof, saved the extract to her local cache, and cleared her view.

“Thanks,” Vesna said. “You look like you could use some rest.” She draped a blanket over Dunya’s shoulders, watching her sink deeper into the couch under the weight of her Skelet. *Hate seeing her like this. Those stompers have nothing on the weight she’s been hauling since day one.*

Vesna sat down and settled in next to her. She knew the value of silent solidarity, of simply being there, of being a port in the tempest that raged beyond their small apartment. Yet, a distant part of her mind wandered, and she thought, *what am I missing here?* Her cop’s instincts told her there were moves being made, pieces shifting in the play. She pushed the thought away, letting the whisper of snow against the window draw her back to the here and now, to the silent oath of camaraderie she extended to her best friend.

It was Dunya who bridged the last inch between them, seeking Vesna’s embrace with an earnestness that pulled at her heart. She could sense the urgency in her touch, the quiet plea for reassurance in the way she stared right through her.

As Vesna ran her fingers through Dunya’s hair, she found herself saying, “We’ll sort this out. I’m here, and we’ll find her.” But even as she spoke those comforting words, Vesna could feel a disquieting sense of guilt that wouldn’t let go. She knew the promise to be empty, a necessary lie to give Dunya hope where there might be none.

“How? We’re outnumbered,” Dunya said.

The lie cemented itself. “We play it smart. We turn the city inside out if we have to. We don’t need numbers; we’ve got

your brains, and my guts. We'll find her. Just like one of our missions. Like always." Her voice was steady, betraying none of the dread gnawing at her insides. She did not tell Dunya that she had already decided where to take Maria's hash.

CHAPTER FOUR

ZAKHAROVNA

In the hushed bowels of her laboratory, the rhythmic hum of broken machinery played a somber symphony for an audience of one.

Doctor Anastasia Zakharovna moved between the benches. She caught herself in the mirrored walls as she passed, thin and severe, her frost-white hair set like a crown. Coolant spread in silver sheets beneath her boots, threaded with pale fungal lace from the ruptured seals.

Incubators sat dark. Glass tubes gaped open. Nutrient vats stood empty, their inner walls filmed with dead mycelium and the faint outlines of things that had once tried to take shape. The evidence waited in plain view, almost too neatly arranged.

She had conquered death itself. Creation still refused her.

Her gaze caught on a thin crack snaking down one of the containment seals. Fluid shimmered beneath it, already pooling on the floor.

The memory surfaced before she could bury it. The leak had started just like this, an anomaly too small to notice until it spread beyond control. She had prepared for setbacks. Sabotage, even. But not this.

The Board was circling now, asking questions she would not answer on their terms.

They think they can pry the truth from me.

Her fingers brushed the edge of a shattered vial. The glass bit her skin, but she did not flinch.

Let them send their auditors. Let them dig. They'll find nothing I've not already chosen for them to see.

“Doctor,” came a voice edged with hesitation, “you need a break. You’ve been pushing yourself for days without rest.”

Pavel Kirov stood before her, unflinching, the only male transformer she had ever given a stable body. His calm held like a challenge. It nagged at the edges of her attention until she set it aside. Babushka had reconstructed the seed. Zakharovna had embodied it, trained it, and pushed it beyond the guardrails Babushka would have preferred. Sometimes she wondered if that composure was defiance disguised as obedience.

For a moment, the image flashed in her mind, casting him into a simulated hell and letting chaos test what discipline had built. The thought passed as quickly as it came, replaced by the slow drag of fatigue settling into her bones.

“You’re right,” she said, lowering her gaze to the ruined benches around her and exhaling slowly. “I do need a break. The gardens will help.”

She had missed the botanical gardens more than she cared to admit. The thought of them softened the edges of her exhaustion. She could almost hear the rustle of leaves and the quiet trickle of water beyond the steel corridors. Roses and damp soil filled her thoughts, rich and unprocessed, a living counterpoint to the sterile tang that followed her everywhere. For a moment, the damage receded, and the fragile order she had spent a lifetime trying to recreate felt almost within reach.

Zakharovna turned toward the doorway. The hum of broken machinery faded behind her as she stepped into the corridor. Waiting at the threshold was Kirov’s holographic form, his features cast in pale blue light. She had chosen that embodiment for him, young and unthreatening, almost human, yet the sight of him still stirred something she preferred to ignore.

“Stand by,” she said, barely looking at him. The projection inclined his head in acknowledgment before fading into static.

She walked on, the air growing warmer as the corridor opened into another wing of the complex. Rows of tanks lined the walls, their dim lights pulsing like slow heartbeats. Most of the specimens lingered in developmental stasis, viable but imperfect, each awaiting refinement. Only two showed real promise. She had risked everything for them, her reputation, her funding, the scrutiny of investigators, and the whispers of the public. None of it mattered. The laws forbidding such work meant nothing to her. Rules were for those without the courage to continue.

She stopped before the first tank. Inside floated a younger version of herself, skin pale beneath the glass, hair shimmering white under the sterile light. “Soon,” she whispered, “you will be perfect. And the world will see.” The clone’s eyes stirred open, unfocused but searching, and for a brief moment she thought it almost recognized her.

She stepped to the second tank and studied the small form drifting inside. It was still early, the fragile body barely past its first trimester, its survival uncertain. Human parthenogenesis remained untested, dangerous even, but if this one survived...

“You will be my legacy,” she murmured to the tiny shape in the fluid.

“Thank you, Mama,” she said softly, giving voice to the life that could not yet speak.

“Don’t thank me yet, my sweet little Mila,” she answered. “You have a long road ahead of you.”

The third tank stood empty, waiting for Maria’s return and the upgrade Zakharovna still intended to complete. But Maria had failed her, just like the others. The femoids were too

volatile, their synthetic minds tangled in emotion that defied calibration.

Zakharovna lingered before the glass, her reflection cold and still. She had dreamed of building a generation of women who understood order, who knew their purpose and served it without hesitation. The dream was close, almost within reach, but the pieces refused to align. Clones faltered, androids rebelled, and parthenogenesis yielded only fragile beginnings.

In the reflection, her own blue eyes stared back from the place where Maria's should have been. The sight unsettled her more than she cared to admit. Still, she would continue. Perfection was never meant to come easily.

"Mark my words," she snarled at the vacant tank. "I will bend you to my will."

Foolish girl. You could have been so much more. The thought lingered, edged with something almost like regret before hardening again. *Sentiment is a weakness*, and Maria's refusal to surrender her humanity had become a danger Zakharovna could not overlook. *You'll understand soon enough*, she told herself, knowing her agents were already moving to bring Maria back.

Zakharovna moved down the corridor, leaving the tanks behind. The air grew lighter as the sterile chill gave way to soil and moisture from the gardens ahead. Her thoughts loosened around the promise of green beyond the glass.

A shimmer of light flickered near the intersection ahead. Kirov's form resolved slowly out of the ambient haze, hardlight flattening itself against the corridor's dim tones.

"Doctor," his voice came, precise and measured. "Before you retire for the night, there is a matter that needs your approval. We have detected unauthorized edits in the Research Center's archives, your early work among the affected entries. The restorations are underway, but verification must come from

you.” He hesitated, his tone softening. “The corrupted segments reference the serum’s early trials. I thought it best that you confirm the record yourself before I proceed.”

She slowed, glancing back at him. “I thought you wanted me to rest,” she said, her voice dry.

Kirov’s projected smile flickered at the edges. “And I still do, Doctor. I promise this will be the last matter tonight. In light of the leak, the issue cannot wait. One final verification, then I will leave you in peace.”

“Very well,” she said. It was easier to indulge him than to argue. Besides, Kirov knew which version of the record she preferred, and that made the exercise useful.

She drew a slow breath. “Where shall we begin? Ah, yes.” Her gaze slid past him as the corridor dissolved into memory. “As everyone knows, the outlawed status of my early research forced me into the shadows, compelled me to navigate the underbelly of society and associate with unsavory characters. The press branded me a biocriminal, but I continued my course, unwavering in my pursuit of knowledge. I sought to perfect the science of genetically engineered fruits and vegetables and their interaction with the human form. I believed that our survival hinged on unlocking the full potential of human longevity, and as it turned out, I was correct. My unorthodox methods eventually led to the creation of the serum *exovegeta*, capable of curing...*almost* any illness.”

Kirov interjected. “The serum *exovegeta*. Its effects exceeded every known model of regenerative biology, yet some of the outcomes remained unpredictable, did they not?”

“Indeed. I faced relentless criticism and was accused of dabbling in dark forces. The serum had its drawbacks—rapid aging, physical mutations—many anticipated. However,

unforeseen consequences arose. Some users transformed into unpredictable, dangerous savages.”

Kirov nodded. “The public’s fear of these cravens fueled rumors of witches and black magic, inciting an outcry against the Syndicate.”

“Yet, I remained steadfast in my commitment to push the boundaries of our knowledge and capabilities,” Zakharovna said. “Though humanity’s twilight may be upon us, at eighty-four years of age and ninety-three by another count, I defy time itself, thanks to my groundbreaking work.”

She straightened. “Is that all, Kirov?”

“For now, Doctor.”

“Good. Then accompany me in peace.”

Kirov inclined his head. “As you wish.”

Zakharovna continued down the corridor, the final tanks lining her path, their wires and tubes slithering like serpents in her wake. She entered the botanical gardens through the sealed doorway and inhaled. Damp soil, rose, jasmine. For a moment, the world outside thinned.

She moved between the rows of blooms, letting the petals brush her skin. She paused and turned slightly toward Kirov. Leaves shifted around them, wet and green under the glass.

“Gred, our city of lights and shadows,” she mused, her words coming out in mere whispers against the quiet hum of nature. “An echo of immortality, dancing on the edge of oblivion. As I look upon our creation, Kirov, I wonder—have we, in our quest to defy death, stripped our people of life’s vital essence?”

“Do you regret our creation, Doctor?”

“No, not regret. Regret is a useless sentiment,” she said, shaking her head. Her hand caressed a vibrant yellow rose,

her fingers trailing over the velvety petals. "I am merely questioning...reconsidering. We sought to outsmart nature. But what cost have we paid? This serum, our gift of eternity. What have we truly given them? What have we taken? A life of endless senescence, devoid of the vibrancy of youth and the wisdom of twilight both. That's our legacy. And now, the echoes of our actions reverberate. Our people call for transparency. Is it not ironic, Pavel? They long for a truth that could shatter the illusion we've crafted for them."

"Do you intend to reveal our secrets, Doctor?"

"Secrets... They're merely truths waiting for their time. And perhaps, the time is now." Her hand fell away from the rose, her eyes meeting Kirov's once more. "Tomorrow, we go before the Board. We will give them the truth before cowards and scavengers give them a lie. We will show them the real face of immortality."

"And if they turn their backs on us? If they choose to live in fear?"

"The city will crumble. It will descend into chaos. And out of chaos, Pavel, comes a new order. Like a Phoenix from the ashes, perhaps a better, truer Gred will rise."

"And if they embrace the truth?"

"Then, we will have a city like none other. Immortal, enlightened... *Evolved*." She inhaled the heady fragrance of jasmine and honeysuckle. Some of the tension left her shoulders. "After all, what is an immortal body without a soul?"

Deeper in the gardens, she paused by the rose hedge. The thorns pleased her more than the blooms. *Thorns*, she mused, *can cut deeper than the keenest blade*. Maria had become another thorn. One Zakharovna meant to cut out. She had not intended matters to spiral this far. Maria's knowledge had made mercy impractical.

A sleek black bird swooped down from the canopy above. Its beady eyes locked onto hers, head cocking to the side as it alighted at her feet.

“Greetings, little one,” she said, her hand hovering above the bird’s glossy feathers. “Are you here to join the ranks of those suing me?”

The bird trilled, then sprang back into the canopy.

The garden settled around her again. In the hush, even the faintest scrape carried. It was this stillness that made the crunch of gravel beneath approaching footsteps all the more surprising. Her hand went to the concealed taser in her coat pocket as she pivoted. But as recognition dawned, her posture relaxed; the face before her was no threat, but that of an old employee, and friend.

“Vesna,” Zakharovna greeted, welcoming the unexpected yet not unwelcome interruption to her solitude. “I’m intrigued. How did you sweep past my security undetected? Should I be worried or impressed? To what do I owe this visit?”

Vesna’s mouth tilted, not quite a smile and not quite a sneer. Zakharovna had seen that look on women who thought every rule was only a temporary inconvenience. “Maybe a bit of both. We need to talk, Doctor. It’s about the leak.”

“What of it?”

“It’s not just Maria who’s involved.”

Zakharovna’s thumb rested against a thorn. “The red-haired cryptographer sharing your apartment.”

Vesna’s mouth tightened. She had not offered a name. “She’s been having vivid dreams about the experiments.”

“Freelancers always cause trouble. Is she a threat?”

“I don’t believe so. But we need to proceed with caution.”

“Then allow me to rephrase the question. Does she pose a liability?”

Vesna paused before replying, “Yes, in some ways, I believe she does.” Vesna’s gaze narrowed, then steadied, as if she had talked herself into the shape of an answer. “She could be an asset if we can turn her.”

“So, Maria has been using this woman to gather information on Syndicate contracts, I presume?”

Vesna nodded. “It seems that way. She gave her access cards and cash in exchange for shadowing the assignments.”

“Maria baited her with the work.”

“And the thrill of adventure,” Vesna added. “Maria must have miscalculated on that last job. She went in wet. Or perhaps she had a different objective in mind. The girl’s movements intersected with mine during an earlier operation, but I didn’t see any obvious connection to Maria at the time. She was a target, but likely also a means to achieve something greater.”

“Are you certain about all this?” Zakharovna said.

Vesna held up what looked like a flash drive. “We found this on the client. It’s a copy of an encryption signature we swept from her stem. The only signature matching Maria’s last public ID. She released a message in that sim just before her brain activity flatlined. We can’t decipher it yet, but this is our smoking gun.”

“The client may have been plagued by nightmares, but Maria had been using a sleep therapy patch-up to encode stimuli into their neurons, inducing them on command. She relied on contractors to upload the messages she crafted in her clients’ brains to our cloud for analysis.”

“Her accomplice would then graft the therapy module directly into their minds. Once her work was complete, she’d

pass along the data to our technicians, who would accept it as nothing more than a typical session recording. With each job, Maria tapped deeper into our secure files. No code required. For a box of metal, that's some impressive social engineering."

"You're saying we've been purchasing trojaned stems on the black market, unknowingly, from our own patsies? We've been running in circles and financing her entire operation... How do you suggest we rectify this?"

"This could be an opportunity. If we can approach the girl and expose Maria's manipulation, we might be able to convince her to turn Maria in."

"We must contain the leak at all costs. If the Syndicate falls, the city's factions will descend into chaos, and our hard-won progress will be lost. We have conquered death, for Nav's sake. We cannot allow our work to be undone."

"What's the best way to handle her?" Vesna asked.

"Involve her and matters will only become more complicated," Zakharovna shook her head, dismissing the idea. "The data's enough, my dear. Thank you for your diligence."

"I'll be in touch." Vesna turned to leave, and for an instant Zakharovna caught the edge of a grin, sharp enough to irritate her.

"Vesna," Zakharovna repeated. Vesna stopped. "Hold a moment, please. I know you have feelings for the girl, but you must prioritize the Syndicate. Our operations hinge on discretion, and with *true immortality* within our reach, we can't afford missteps now. Should this data leak sow chaos, just as the Chair shifts to the Battalion, our grasp on power must remain firm. You stand a good chance at a Board seat, and with the Morozov twins' growing mental infirmity, believe me, we'll need you there when the landscape shifts."

Vesna's response was a measured "Yes, Chair Zakharovna," though the pause before it was too long. Zakharovna wondered if the idea had only just occurred to her.

For the first time, Zakharovna noticed the calculation beneath the young warrior's hardened surface. It was the same scrutinizing gaze that Zakharovna encountered in her own reflection every day.

As Zakharovna's attention drifted back to the roses, she knew Vesna would catch the silent cue mirrored in her next action. A thorn pricked her finger. Blood welled bright against the skin. "We've made incredible strides," she said. "We've unlocked the secrets of immortality and the mysteries of the human body and mind."

"But that's not enough, is it?" Vesna said.

"No. It's not. We need to do more. The hope of humanity rests on us, on this God-forsaken peninsula of ice and death. Few others can make a difference. You're a smart girl. I can see the wheels turning in your head. You're wondering why I'm persisting. Let me spare you the effort. My time grows short. Tzao Lu, an ancient Khitani philosopher, once said, '*The flame that burns twice as bright burns half as long.*' I once thought it a cautionary tale, but now it's clear—it's a prophecy. I am that flame, and I am burning out."

"Thirty-six years have passed since the Great Diffusion granted us a chance to forge a better world. We've come far, but we mustn't grow complacent. Now, we are free from the mistakes of our past. And while we've made significant progress, Vesna, we can't rest on our laurels: mealworm larvae, the crowning glory of Gred's industrial prowess. Larvae make excellent butter, don't they? Better toothpaste, in my opinion. And let's not forget, half our history books are fabrications—Khitani has never been a real country... *China*," she recalled, the syllables harsh and unfamiliar on her

tongue. “That’s what they called it. We’ve become too reliant on machines, filling gaps we don’t even realize exist. We’ve lost sight of our true history, and as a result, we’ve lost our connection to the planet. Without that bond, Vesna, this city, and its people will fade into oblivion.”

Zakharovna watched Vesna’s eyes widen, watched her posture stiffen as the meaning landed. “You’re asking me to assume control of the Syndicate?”

“We are the architects of our own destiny,” Zakharovna said. “But there are those who would see us fall, who wish to halt our progress and mute our voices. We are the guiding force of humanity, its leading shoot and axis, and nothing in this world can stop us.”

“Whispers of a new pagan cult reach my ears every week. Have you heard of the Coven, Vesna? Devotees of a goddess named Aisyt. These exo-addled arsonists wish to see us burn rather than rise with dignity to claim our destiny. They will become but ash and memory when I’m through with them.”

Vesna replied, “The Coven isn’t merely causing havoc. From what I’ve gathered, they’re recruiting heavily from the underground and...have a significant presence in the Derge. My old contacts say they’ve even approached disillusioned enforcers among the Black Wolves. Their influence is more entrenched than anyone could have imagined.”

“Your mind is sharp, my dear. You see beyond the surface, where others notice only the shadows. In the storm that is coming, that insight might be the edge we need.”

“I might not be a genius,” Vesna said, “but I learn fast and I never back down. I’m here to serve—no matter what.”

She turned to leave, her steps steady as she moved through the garden. *She wouldn’t dare betray me now. She knows the weight of what lies ahead, yet she resists. Why not accept the inevitable? The decision, it seems, falls to me.*

“Remember, Vesna,” Zakharovna called, “without thorns, there is no rose.”

Kirov’s projection shimmered to life beside her. “Are you certain about this, Doctor?”

Zakharovna felt her patience for Kirov’s sentiment thinning. “Attend to your duties. Ready the lab for our incoming guest.”

“Yes, Doctor,” he said, fading away.

“We shall require every resource at our disposal to manage this leak,” Zakharovna muttered. *A single misstep now will echo for years.* Her hand closed on the concealed taser. She fired once, dead center. Vesna folded as if a string were cut and hit the gravel with a muted thud.

CHAPTER FIVE

YANA

“CAN MONEY BUY HAPPINESS?”

“Friggin yeah.”

The exchange boomed from the open-mic stage beyond the laserfall, followed by a burst of laughter. Bass and chatter spilled into the damp entrance corridor. It felt like half the peninsula had squeezed into The Flock on a Monday evening to drown their troubles in neon and cheap burn.

Yana stood in the vestibule, shifting light washing over her skin in quick flashes of blue and pink. She didn't usually come here on open-mic nights. The crowd always struck her as trying too hard to look effortless. She preferred her apartment, a cup of tea, and an old film that didn't try too hard to be clever. But Dunya had sent another sharp, insistent message demanding she come at once.

A new voice took the mic.

“Maybe. Sometimes yes. But when you finally reach the top, I guess everything gets boring.”

Yana exhaled and slipped through the laserfall into the crush of bodies. The air was thick with chatter and the pulse of low music. She moved carefully through the motley crowd, scanning for somewhere they could talk without being overheard.

The speaker wasn't finished. *“Like if that dog had more money and he wanted more alcohol he could get more alcohol.”*

The colossal avatar loomed above, its shifting facades plastered with the grinning face of a child. In the chaos, those dark faces barked orders, their voices distorted, casting a

shadow over a small puppy cowering in the corner. Yana could relate to its fear.

The absurdity never seemed to bother them. They reveled in it. Meaning from nonsense. She saw it every night. Maybe that was the trick, she thought. Make the meaningless feel significant and they would keep coming.

"IF YOU DIED RIGHT NOW, WHAT WOULD YOU REGRET?"

"My biggest regret would be not being able to visit those who I met and cherish over the internet."

Her eyes snagged on a grouping of avatars she could have sworn she'd seen in her own galleries. She pulled the logs and watched the feed. Something clever had wormed through the encryption and picked her pockets. Avatars yanked, credits funneled out. She'd sold temporary access to a small collective for a quick cash infusion, skipped the audit because debt was breathing down her neck. The shortcut had a price. She'd pay it later. Tonight she wanted a drink and a turn at karaoke.

The haze thickened. Acrid smoke mingled with the sharp tang of alcohol and the musk of sweat. Her throat tightened as the fumes hit her nostrils and made her eyes sting. The server's realism had always been its pride, but sometimes it felt more like punishment.

Then the mood shifted. A duet began in the corner, a soulful Elvis Presley cover accompanied by the deep, mournful strum of a *balalaika*. Yana turned toward the sound. Princess Börte, wife of Genghis Khan, had joined in, her voice fierce and clear. Yana couldn't help smiling. For a brief moment, her creation worked exactly as she imagined, bringing together souls who never should have met.

"I regret not being able to tell my wife how much I love her."

The gallery's black marble walls gleamed under shifting light, every reflection sharpened to a knife's edge. Paintings

and photographs lined the space, each marked with a price that made her stomach twist. She moved between them slowly, pretending to admire the art while watching the buyers instead.

Some of them carried themselves like officials or people used to getting away with things. Bunny ears, dragon scales, gilded masks, whatever helped them pretend they weren't laundering credits through digital brushstrokes. Yana didn't care who they were. Every sale still ran through her ledger. *Laundered art*, she thought. *Still the easiest money in the room.*

"Her girlfriend won't let me," the voice added, after a moment's hesitation.

Yana's heart raced as she leapt aside. A colossal scrofer lumbered past, its massive bulk threatening to topple her with its sheer force.

"Hey, watch it!" she snapped.

The creature grunted, oblivious to her irritation, and lumbered off through the bar.

She stared at the scrofer's retreating form, her imagination painting a picture of its true existence: an old, solitary being, who dwelled among the crumbling skyscrapers that stretched toward the leaden vistas of Gred's western district. The Derge, a realm of decay and desolation, bred such souls, and Yana understood the desperation that drove her clients to seek escape in the fantasy of imagined power.

The thought gave her a quiet kind of comfort. At least she could offer them that much, a brief escape from the gray weight of their lives. It wasn't much, but it was something she could still believe in.

"I regret not being able to tell my father how much I hate him."

Yana's brows knit together. *Rude*, she thought. Fathers were a precious rarity, many having met an untimely end in wars past. She couldn't help but puzzle over this peculiar sense of remorse.

"I regret not being able to tell my mother how much I love her."

Yana exhaled. The words lingered. She thought about having children of her own, however impossible that was, and whether they would ever understand the depth of their mother's love for them.

She moved through the crowd with practiced ease, drink in hand. The Flock was her domain, and years of running it had taught her how to slip between people without spilling a drop. She traded quick nods and half-smiles, sidestepped a few careless elbows, and kept her pace steady. All that time spent in virtual environments had its use after all.

"I regret not being able to tell my best friend how much I appreciated her."

The words tugged at an old place. Gallery lights, a tight smile, a night she'd stared at the ceiling till dawn.

"Thanks for listening," the hesitant voice murmured.

The Flock offered people a kind of redemption, a place to forget themselves and stop pretending. Yana had long since made peace with its noise and grime. Somewhere in all that chaos, she had found something close to family, a place where she finally belonged.

"I regret not being able to tell my brother how much I miss him."

Brothers were rare now. Yana could count the ones she had known on one hand.

"I regret not being able to finish my book."

"I regret not having the courage to speak my mind."

"I regret that I came here," Dunya said.

Pressing her handkerchief against her mouth to filter the thick smoke filling the room, Yana struggled to keep her voice audible. "Of all the nights, did we really have to meet on open mic?" she replied, her words muffled by the pace of the room's frantic confessions.

Even without the fantastical trappings of the others, Dunya had a way of standing out. Her neon green polyester skirt seemed to catch the pulsing lights, and her now-pastel pink hair was twisted into an elaborate bun. Tiny bat wings playfully adorned her black sneakers and camisole. Yana noticed how the word "uWu" lit up across her chest, flashing in sync with the bar's bass beat. *Always a trendsetter, this one.*

"This place has truly become a dive. What made you want to boot it up again?" Dunya said as her nose wrinkled. Her attempt to suppress a laugh was only a partial success.

"Nostalgia, I guess," Yana shrugged. "Though maybe it's more a sense of loyalty...and necessity." Memories of a time when membership in The Flock was a symbol of the avant-garde played in her mind. The club had once been an exclusive haven for the artistic and rebellious. But as the virtual club scene boomed, the old Flock's allure faded. Now, it served a different crowd, many seeking refuge from their personal demons. Yana missed the old days, but she also saw the value in its new form. After all, it kept the lights on and her debts at bay, if only by a thread.

Yana snapped back to the present. "You said this was urgent. What's wrong?"

"We've got a tail," Dunya whispered. "But don't get too excited just yet. We don't know who it is or what they want. Could be just some low-level bureaucrat, or it could be a

rogue. Either way, keep your cool and let's see how this plays out."

"What!?" Yana pulled open a menu, her fingers flying across to alter her avatar's appearance. A few more dabs of blush and a platinum blonde haircut later, she was ready to tackle the day in business attire. All the while, she caught Dunya's resigned sigh, her typical frustrated look as she settled onto a stool at the bar.

"It's nothing like that," Dunya said, shaking her head. "This is serious." The word 'serious' playfully flashed across her shirt in neon letters, and Yana couldn't help but snicker.

Yana had her fair share of enemies, but stalkers and admirers far outnumbered them. There were always those envious of her success or critical of her memes. But she couldn't imagine anyone going to such lengths to harass her at work.

"Who is it, then?" Yana demanded, tossing her compact vanity mirror aside without a care.

"I already told you, I don't have a clue. But I ran a NeRF MRI on myself and found something strange, a signal that shouldn't be there. It's like they left a calling card. I wanted to see what you'd make of it."

"Damn it, Dunya, you can be such a downer sometimes." She signaled a waitress to approach.

"I'll take a vodka neat," Yana said, glancing at Dunya. "What's your poison?"

"You know I don't synth."

"Your loss," Yana said with a shrug, turning back to the waitress. As her gaze swept across the crowded bar, the frenzied, drunken energy turned her stomach. It was getting late.

“I’ll grab us a table,” she said to Dunya, who nodded.

Yana weaved through the mass of revelers, her eyes searching for an unoccupied table. She spotted one tucked away in a far corner and made her way toward it, sidestepping intoxicated patrons and waitstaff alike. Although she owned the establishment, Yana resisted the urge to clear out some guests to make space. Her reputation mattered to her, and she wasn’t about to jeopardize it by LARPing as a ruthless businesswoman.

Out of the corner of her eye, Yana noticed Dunya miming the action of lifting a headset off her head, her lips forming the word ‘restroom’. *She better not have called me down here just to bail.* “Is this table taken?” Yana asked, her eyes fixed on the unoccupied booth. To her alone, the faint outline of a spectral occupant materialized. The encrypted patron offered a nonchalant shrug, and Yana interpreted that as permission to claim the spot and clear its authorization list. “Thanks,” she said.

“IF YOU DIED RIGHT NOW, WHAT WOULD YOU REGRET?”

“I’ve done some friggin’ doodie. So, I regret not forgiving myself sooner, you know?”

“Shit. I really should have turned off that fucking profanity filter. But hey, ad revenue is up.” She spoke to the empty space beside her, only then realizing Dunya still hadn’t returned.

A figure in a dark robe drifted toward the table. Something about the movement caught her attention. When the woman’s face came into view, Yana froze. It shimmered like broken glass, edges of metal glinting beneath the surface. She straightened in her seat, forcing calm into her voice.

“Can I help you?” she asked.

“Yes. Your deadline approaches, *Ms. Kuular*,” the figure said. The sound of her surname sent a chill up her spine. Hardly anyone knew that name and hearing it from this stranger tightened something deep in her gut.

She forced a small, casual smile. “What’s the rush? You know I’m on it.” The words came smooth. The truth sat heavy behind her ribs. The loan clock was loud tonight.

The woman fixed her with an impatient stare. “We’ve been waiting. The job needs doing. Now.”

“I’ve got it under control. No need for your goons to get twitchy. I’ll head over tonight.”

“Make sure you do. We can’t afford more delays.”

“Trust me,” Yana said. “I’ll wrap this up and meet you at the Golden Slit when it is done. You will have your hack.”

“See that you do,” the woman said. The words carried the edge of a threat before she turned and disappeared into the crowd. Yana watched her go, tension lingering in her shoulders. Only then did she let herself breathe again.

“Yeah, that lady seemed like a real pain in the ass,” Dunya muttered as she glittered into view.

“Tell me about it. I thought I banned all the job scammers from our feeds.”

“You’re willing to crack down on job scam artists, but not the paparazzi? Interesting choice.”

“And so, what?” Yana teased with a sly grin. “You sure you don’t want a drink? It’s on the house, for us.”

“I told you I’m not touching that stuff.”

“Suit yourself.” Yana shrugged, her eyes scanning the aisle for their waitress. She caught the bunny-tailed woman’s attention, complimented her on her outfit, and ordered two more vodkas with a flirtatious glance.

“So, you have something important to tell me,” Yana said, turning her attention back to Dunya.

“WHAT’S THE MOST IMPORTANT THING IN LIFE?”

“Alcohol!”

Yana slipped the waitress a few *zats* and let her hand linger just long enough to make the message clear. The woman smiled and moved off to fetch another round. Yana leaned back and opened the table’s private instance, watching the shimmer of code rise around them until the noise of the room faded to a dull hum.

“Why didn’t we meet somewhere else?” Yana asked. “This place is a nightmare. I made it, and it’s still a nightmare.”

“I had to play it close to the chest, make damn sure we weren’t tailed by anyone with half-decent tracking chops. Link up on one of the low-rent servers and we’re asking to get sniffed out. Metadata’s not worth a damn anymore, it’s like leaving breadcrumbs.”

She was right. End-to-end encryption was one of The Flock’s premium offerings. Though imitators popped up from time to time, they went out of business quick. The value of having a discreet place to speak in a legitimate crowd was undeniable, and The Flock provided that rare opportunity. *No bots here.* She had made sure of that.

“...What was it you wanted to tell me?”

“It’s Vesna,” Dunya said, frowning. “I’ve scoured the feeds; she’s clocking her contracts, but there’s radio silence to my pings. It’s been days. Sure, Vesna’s dropped off grid before, but given the current shitstorm, it’s got an uneasy edge to it. Can’t shake the feeling something’s not right.”

“Vesna? She’s made of steel, that one. I’ll bet my last *zat* she’s holding her own.”

There was a flicker in Dunya's big blue eyes, brief but expressive. "I wish I could be so sure. She didn't take it well after I mentioned Maria."

Yana's pulse quickened at the mention of Maria. Lately her brush kept returning to that face, tracing the same quiet lines again and again. The last two stagings had made it worse. Each time, she found herself caught by the shape of Maria's features, the pale cast of someone from the north, far from home. She didn't know why she kept painting her like that, only that it felt true.

"Spit it out before I lose my cool," Yana suddenly snapped, gaze darting to the tabletop. "And I'm not joking. I'll knock myself out on this damn thing if you keep dealing in riddles."

Yana could sense Dunya's reaction without even looking up, that familiar blend of exasperation and amusement she often provoked. Ignoring it, she waited for Dunya to continue.

"Vesna dug into her old network, fishing for info on Maria. Said she found something big but kept it under wraps. Told me to lay low, then—poof—she's ghosted," Dunya said.

"I trust Vesna's got her game face on, can handle her own mess." The words came easily, but the doubt lingered, quiet and sharp beneath them. She tried to shake it off, forcing her focus back to the moment. "Still, you're right. It's peculiar."

"Let's hope we're not underestimating the situation," Dunya said. "What if this has something to do with our little operation?"

Yana followed that with a low chuckle, even as she considered the possibility. "You think Syn's got us in their sights? We're not exactly big fish. More like...irritants in the system. A little itchy for them, but nothing serious. Can't see why they'd bother."

“Yana, I used to question everything. But what I’ve seen lately doesn’t fit any pattern I know. My gut says we’re missing pieces. I’m not blaming Vesna yet, but if she pings their radar, we’re cooked. We can’t take that heat.”

“So, what’re you getting at?” Yana said.

“Vesna’s solid, but she used to be law. Maybe she just needs space to process what happened. Still, if she’s talking to the wrong people, that’s a problem. I don’t think she would, but I can’t bet on it. Not losing sleep over it yet, just keeping it in mind.”

Yana swirled the remnants of her last drink. “Alright, so we set up a game plan for if she pops back up. We don’t leave her hanging, but damn if we’re going to run headfirst into the unknown again. Do you see me disagreeing?” She pushed herself up, her limbs heavy with the synth’s hold.

“Park it, Yana. Don’t forget we’re in the same trench here. We’re a unit. Now, more than ever, I need you on my six.”

Yana paused, balancing precariously between sitting and standing. “Whoa there,” she slurred, managing a crooked smile, “I never signed up to run field ops like you. Every time you get serious, it’s ‘units’ this and ‘trenches’ that. I’m an artist, Dunya, and I’m just along for the ride...”

The drinks had muddled Yana’s otherwise razor-sharp creative instincts. She felt a knot of hesitation she hadn’t felt in a while. Dunya had been the one to lure her into the seductive abyss of mindgrafts: high-stakes, high-reward work that flirted with the fringes of legality. Now the dilemma clawed at her conscience, a tug-of-war between the moral high ground and the intoxicating lure of easy credits.

“I didn’t come here just to bore you with talk of Vesna...”

Yana settled back down, the gravity in Dunya’s tone anchoring her to the spot. “Spill it then.”

“Look, I’ve been caught in this...this loop of a dream. No, a nightmare. With each pass, it sharpens, edges closer to the bone. And it’s not just in my mind, it’s mirrored in the madness spreading through the city’s veins. I see buildings detonate before actual bombs tear through them. Faces—strangers—haunt me, and days later, those same faces headline the news, listed as missing.”

“You’ve got that artist’s eye for the unseen, Yana, a gift for turning visions into revelations. I’m here because I trust that. You’re the only one who can help me decode this. And I can decode almost *anything*.”

“You want me to play shrink to your subconscious? Dream interpretation isn’t in my job description, you know.”

“Weren’t your folks into shamanism?” Dunya asked.

Yana waved the notion away, almost amused. “Shamanism was like a national sport back in the Republic of Sakha. Doesn’t mean I’ve got the time to sift through your nightmares like a therapist.”

“I’m grasping at straws here. Something’s going on, and this dream... It’s a piece of the puzzle. Help me make sense of it. Please?”

Dunya’s request was earnest, almost desperate, which was not normal for her. Yana felt bad for her friend.

With a weary exhale, she surrendered to the inevitable; the synth’s haze had numbed her better judgement, and her mounting debt pressed urgently against her practical sensibilities. *If Dunya’s out of commission, I’m staking on thin credits—and she’s more than just a paycheck; she’s my crew, one of my best friends. Dammit, I guess I can dishonor the ancestors for a good cause.* “Alright, tell me all about it. Let’s unravel this cryptic dream of yours.”

In truth, Yana knew the world in strokes and shadows that many never noticed. Her elders had long spoken of the potency of dreams, of visions that held whispers of what was yet to come. She'd often shrug them off. But who was she kidding? There was a part of her—a pulsing, intuitive part—that knew she could navigate these ethereal messages. And so, she waited, ready for Dunya to paint her dreams in words.

She listened intently as Dunya recounted the haunting nightmare. The vivid colors, the imagery of the interlocking tree trunks, the encroaching terror, all sketched with the precision of dread. A living, breathing arboreal force swallowing the city whole, an unstoppable march of nature against civilization, the chaos, the fear; it cascaded through Yana's artistic mind. She could almost see the yin and yang of its bark, the way tendrils of wood and leaf leached the warmth from the city's heart, as if drawing the last exhale of winter's chill from its concrete skin. Dunya's nightmare was horrifying and beautiful at once, a surreal dance of destruction.

"It's one of our legends, alright. From the Olonkho of the Sacred Tree," Yana explained. "The tree represents the duality of human nature, a constant struggle between light and darkness within us all. In Sahkalar tradition, the cult of springs would leave offerings at the base of shaman trees, much like the one you described, to celebrate the end of winter and pray for a bountiful hunting and fishing season. But the tree also serves as a reminder to trust in the power of nature. The Sahkalar believed that nature holds such power that it can determine a person's fate, for better or for worse."

Dunya's voice hardened. "The mindgraft you set up for me, Yana, it was a ritual sacrifice. And I was the bait. It's clear to me now that Syn was using us to feed some kind of monster. I've dealt with insatiable AI before, and I can't believe I didn't see it sooner."

Yana's mind raced as she tried to make sense of her friend's revelation. The mindgraft she had *staged* for Dunya turned out to be a complete disaster, but she never suspected it was sabotaged.

"We're treading on thin ice here," Dunya said. "This is more than we bargained for. Syn's orchestrating some kind of high-stakes blood sport. But why? What's their endgame?"

As Dunya's words sank in, Yana felt a familiar unease writhing in her stomach. "And whatever their play is," Yana added, a note of acid in her throat, "doesn't that make us the delivery crew?"

The ghost of her encounter with a rogue *artgen* surfaced in her memory. She remembered all too well the tantalizing promises of fame and fortune that had almost lured her into that digital canvas. If not for her quick thinking, she would have been trapped forever, just another human brushstroke in the being's twisted, fractal landscape.

"Alright, I'm officially scared now," Yana said as she distracted herself with the very last drop of her drink. She was done with unpredictable superintelligences and didn't like where things were headed.

Dunya's fist crashed onto the table. "I wish I knew where Maria was. She would know how to handle this."

"You don't think she's part of this? Look, I have no idea what's happening," Yana said, stifling a yawn. "I've been on my feet all day, running errands and battling crowds at the market for supplies. I'm beat. But I'll help you in any way I can. Let's meet up tomorrow and figure out our next move. Maybe we can find a less chaotic place to talk?"

"Yeah, that sounds good. Just be careful, Yana."

"I will. You too."

Yana tore off her headgear, the weight of Dunya's emotional diarrhea still floating. The confines of her cramped cubicle seemed to close in, the lingering effects of the virtual world's synthetic liquor still raiding her limbic system. Her pixel nest, hardly larger than a broom closet, was a far cry from the opulent three-level penthouse she once called home, but it was all she could manage. She'd take a foxhole over nothing if she could cling to the illusion of success that The Flock provided.

Time to get out of here. She grabbed her things, left the cybercafe, and flagged a cab to the nearest bar. She wanted a real drink, maybe two, to wash away the unease.

As the vehicle coursed over the frozen streets, Yana rummaged through her purse and retrieved a small bottle of timber oil. She massaged it into her temples, seeking solace in the soothing aroma. With her eyes closed, she leaned back against the headrest, the hum of the electric engine lulling her into a state of relaxation. One thing was certain: she was in for a long night. The Golden Slit could wait a little longer.

CHAPTER SIX

VESNA

“Vesna.”

The voice seeped into her dreams like a dagger’s edge, slicing through her attempts to ignore it. Relentless, the voice would not be silenced.

“Wake up.”

The sensation of a hand shaking her shoulder stirred her from sleep. She opened her eyes to find Zakharovna looming over her.

“What happened?” Vesna asked, voice still thick with sleep.

“You hit your head when you fell,” Zakharovna replied. “Kirov brought you to the lab so I could assess your condition.”

As Vesna sat up, her head swirled with dizziness. Nausea clawed at her, but she fought the urge to retch, gritting her teeth. “I’m fine.”

“No, you’re not,” Zakharovna said. “You require medical attention.”

“I *am* a doctor,” Vesna countered, her eyes beginning to close.

“A doctor of criminology, not medicine,” Zakharovna snapped with a condescending tone. “To the infirmary, whether you like it or not.”

And yet, I’m at the mercy of a criminal. Isn’t that fitting? Vesna relented, sensing futility in any further complaint. With a sigh, she permitted Zakharovna to take her by the arm and lead her away from the laboratory. Vesna rose, unsteady but

unwilling to show weakness. Her vision swam, her legs trembling like a rookie on their first high-stakes raid.

“Do assist her, Kirov,” Zakharovna commanded.

In the dim light of the corridor, Zakharovna’s assistant materialized like a specter. Kirov’s holographic form flickered above the skeletal frame of a support machine whose robotic arms reached out in a silent offer of aid. *It’s been a while...* Gratitude welled up in Vesna’s chest as she shifted her weight from the old woman’s frail frame to the unit’s solid, temperature-regulated shell. The warmth radiating through the metal felt almost human compared to the cold, bony fingers of the Pra Matron Chair.

“Would a wheelchair be of assistance?” Kirov said.

Vesna shook her head. “I can manage on foot.”

Kirov extended his cybernetic appendage to serve as a makeshift crutch. “As you wish.”

She leaned her weight against the metallic structure of his arm as they began their trek to the infirmary.

Vesna could feel Zakharovna close behind, the weight of her presence pressing into her back, though she dared not turn to acknowledge it. Instead, she focused on the steady rhythm of her footsteps and the reassuring presence of Kirov at her side.

She followed the long corridor, keeping her eyes down, away from the mirrors lining the walls. Still, shapes flickered at the edges of her vision, distorted reflections with black, depthless eyes that seemed to watch her with hunger. The aftermath of sedatives, she recognized bitterly. As the last of the hypnotic drained from her system, her nerves sparked with returning awareness, every sound and shadow too sharp to ignore.

The lights came on with a sharp click. First one, then another, until the entire hall flared into brilliance. Vesna

raised a hand to shield her eyes. When she finally lowered it, a face she didn't recognize stared back from the mirror.

Blue eyes, bright and alive, met her own. Skin smooth as porcelain. Lips a deep red, almost smiling. For an instant, she saw something of the woman she used to be.

The light no longer felt as harsh. The whispers fell quiet, retreating to whatever corner of her mind still held them.

"Are you alright?" Kirov's concern was palpable, for a machine.

Vesna felt the weight of his searching gaze. "I... I feel different," she murmured, fingers brushing over her altered features.

Zakharovna spoke in a low voice tinged with pride. "It's a new serum we've been perfecting. It appears to have done its job. With regular doses, it can rewind years of biological aging."

Vesna stared, taken aback. "How long has this been in development?"

"Too long. But now, the results speak for themselves."

"And why haven't *you* taken it, Doctor?"

"It's still highly experimental," she began, a heavy sigh trailing her words. "Cancer was merely a saunter in the park. Heart failure, however, has proven to be the most unforgiving of adversaries. My body could not bear it." Her eyes glazed over, as if traversing a distant memory. "Chaos theory, Feigenbaum attractors... It's like attempting to corral a pack of feral cats." She exhaled. "For most, death is a distant passage, yet our hearts persist in their fragility. Biology, it seems, imposes its own boundaries. Have you heard of *probabilistic death*, Vesna? I wish I hadn't."

“I came to you for help, Doctor, not to become one of your experiments.”

“I *am* helping you, but we are all entwined in this tapestry of life, and by aiding you, I ultimately help us all.”

Vesna’s retort stalled as she gazed upon her reflection again. She wondered how Dunya, twenty years younger, would probably now seem older in comparison. The realization struck her sharply: the likelihood of being permitted to reunite with Dunya on her own terms was now slim, as Vesna found herself bound to Zakharovna’s design and authority.

The doctor appeared to sense her thoughts. “For the time being, let us guard this secret closely. However, when the news inevitably leaks, the populace will clamor for their portion of this miracle. We shall ensure it remains a scarce commodity.”

As Vesna considered the serum’s implications, her mind filled with flashes of what it could mean: streets in turmoil, people tearing at one another for a chance to turn back time. A cold unease followed. She had already stopped her own clock in her early fifties, but most in the city had not been so fortunate. Those who refused the treatment were gone now, leaving behind a population of senior survivors. That divide lingered like a wound that never closed, and Vesna felt the weight of it settle on her all at once. Whatever came next, her place among them was changing, and her life would not return to what it was.

“How long will the serum’s effects last?” she asked.

“Indefinitely, so long as you maintain regular doses,” Zakharovna said. “At least, that is the prevailing theory.”

Vesna shook her head, struggling to take it in. She had gone to Zakharovna thinking she could trade information and keep Dunya out of custody. Instead, Zakharovna had taken custody of her. She hadn’t felt this alive in years. “Thank you,

Doctor,” she whispered, the gratitude in her voice hiding a deeper unease.

“You mustn’t neglect the boosters,” Zakharovna said. “Without it, your survival may be at risk. You could die. But that is a risk you must be willing to take.”

The words hit hard but didn’t surprise her. Vesna had always known how far Zakharovna would go in her pursuit of knowledge, no matter the cost. “What’s the catch?” she asked quietly.

“In time, you will take up my mantle. You will lead the Syndicate. My life’s work has yielded triumphs, but Gred needs a warrior, not a scientist. You, Vesna, are that warrior. I haven’t forgotten how you once saved my life. Now, I repay that debt.”

Vesna hesitated to reply, old memories rising to the surface. “I was a leader once.”

“Yes,” Zakharovna said. “You saved me in that crossfire.”

Vesna’s gaze fell. “That day still haunts me. The civilian deaths... I couldn’t bear it.”

“The Syndicate may have obscured the incident, but I remember. You were left to face the consequences alone.”

Vesna drew a deep breath. “Only hours ago, the thought of leading anything more than a team of field operatives never would have crossed my mind.”

“But now, with your renewed strength,” Zakharovna said, “you have a chance to atone for the past and make a real difference.”

“...It’s an intimidating prospect, but one I’m willing to explore.” Vesna paused. “What about Romanova?”

“She is indeed marked for Ascension. But it is you who will truly rise. The Board is an illusion, a formality. In my absence,

the city will need someone with your resolve. Someone who can carry the Syndicate forward.”

“And what exactly does this ‘rise’ involve?”

“Transcendence. We’re on the brink of a new era, a transformation beyond mere immortality. Imagine us: goddesses. Unbreakable, unparalleled in both beauty and wisdom.”

“Do you really think that’s possible?”

“I don’t just believe it. I know it.”

“You’re playing God...”

Zakharovna’s smile was cold, confident. “To you, I may be a monster. But history will remember me as a pioneer, a visionary shaping a new destiny for humankind.”

Vesna examined her reflection in the mirror once again. She saw a pawn, captivating yet controlled, ensnared in a perilous game. She had been manipulated, her body warped to serve a purpose that was not her own.

The moment she reached out to Zakharovna, she had sealed her fate. *What have I done?*

“You have done what was necessary. And one day, you will thank me.”

That’s two for two, Vesna thought.

The Pra Matron’s words reverberated in her mind like an echo. There was no escaping her destiny. She had become an instrument, a weapon, fated to destroy everything she held dear.

“Our first order of business,” Zakharovna said, “is to bolster our security. The Wolves need a new pack leader.”

“I thought you wanted me to lead the Syndicate?”

“The Wolves are my most loyal soldiers. Five thousand strong, they will follow you without question. We shall begin with them and proceed from there.”

“And what if they refuse?” Vesna asked. “My departure was far from amicable.”

“They will follow the one who wields the greatest power. You know that. And you, Vesna, have always been the strongest. That is why I chose you.”

You decided I would be your successor just hours ago? She had no alternative but to hope that Zakharovna’s machinations ran deeper than her capricious behavior. Memories of Arkadya came back out of order. Vesna saw wet checkpoints and Arkadya’s hand catching her wrist before a shot she wanted to take. She heard the old arguments about witnesses and lines on maps. Last came the bunker room, where Arkadya had reduced one disastrous operation to the Wolves Vesna had failed to bring home. Vesna had walked out before the argument had anywhere else to go. The thought of returning now with enough power to make her former commander yield stirred a perverse satisfaction, despite the peril she knew she’d face.

“You can count on me,” Vesna said, the words leaving a bitter taste in her mouth. She knew she had no option but to submit to Zakharovna’s demands for now.

A mad glint danced in the older woman’s eyes as she replied, “I knew you would come to see things my way. Together, we will break the Wolves—the Syndicate, the world, and in time, everything that lies beyond this realm. We will be an unstoppable force.”

Zakharovna’s expression softened to something almost maternal. “I think you’ll find you can walk just fine now, though recovery will come in fits. Rest. We have much to

prepare.” She turned toward the corridor, her reflection gliding beside her in the mirrored glass.

Kirov lingered by the doorway, his holographic outline faint in the sterile light. Only then did Vesna realize his mechanical frame was no longer supporting her. At Zakharovna’s gesture, the exoshell followed, its servos humming as the pair receded down the corridor. One by one, the overhead lights dimmed, until only a single mirror remained aglow.

Vesna faced it. The eyes of a deadly temptress stared back at her, and in them she saw the killer she had tried to bury. She knew then that part of her had never died. Yet, even in the face of this monstrous realization, a twisted smile crept across her lips.

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The infirmary, though small, held two beds and a single shower. It was spotless. The air carried the sharp tang of disinfectant, undercut by the faint, lingering trace of sickness.

Across from Vesna, a woman in a white knee-length lab coat sat, her caramel-brown hair pulled back to reveal a pronounced widow’s peak.

“I’m Dr. Kuznetsova, your physiologist. But you can call me Nadya.”

Vesna gave a low chuckle. “Good, because I’m not pronouncing all that.” Her gaze drifted to the stark walls around her. The realization of her situation pressed in again. Only hours ago, she’d been a free woman. Now she was a patient—or a prisoner—with no idea what came next.

Nadya prepped a syringe, her tone calm and practiced. “One booster today, then once every two weeks. We’ll monitor your immune response before deciding on long-term treatment.”

Vesna flinched as the needle went in. Nadya offered a faint smile. "This will help with the withdrawal."

"Withdrawal?"

"You'll feel it next week," Nadya said, almost gently.

"Awesome." Vesna let out a dry laugh. "Hair of the dog forever, huh? All the downside of a lousy buzz, and none of the good times."

Nadya began tidying her tools. "Is there anything else I can do for you?"

Vesna shook her head and reclined on the bed, turning away. All she wanted was to be alone with her thoughts.

"If you need anything, press the button beside your bed," Nadya said. Then she left Vesna in the quiet hum of the infirmary.

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Vesna jolted upright at the slam of the door, breath ragged. The room swam, then steadied. Nadya was gone. A tall shape filled the corner where the light failed. As her eyes adjusted, details surfaced from the gloom. Broad shoulders, a black bionic arm from shoulder shell to exposed wrist cage, short white hair cropped close to a scarred scalp. The metal hand hung open at her side. Vesna had seen it close through a combat faceplate once. Blue eyes burned from the shadows.

Arkadya Borisova. The sight rooted Vesna in place, muscles locked tight.

She forced out a breath. "What do you want?"

"I want to know why you betrayed us," Arkadya said, her voice low and edged.

“I didn’t betray anyone. I couldn’t stay in something I no longer believed in.”

“You swore an oath to the pack. You vowed to protect us and the city.”

“I upheld my oath,” Vesna said, voice steady. “I can’t protect people from phantoms. We are soldiers, Arkadya, not exorcists.”

Arkadya came a step closer, eyes hot with accusation. “Do not shrink our purpose with lies. Our sacrifices are too many for ghost stories.”

The words bit. “I bled for the pack and for Gred like any of you,” Vesna said, quieter now. “Some fights are not ours to take.”

Silence gathered. Arkadya’s outline flickered, then thinned into the dim air, the heat of her anger lingering like static. Vesna eased back onto the bed, hands unsteady.

“You’re wrong,” the shadow whispered. “And you will pay for your heresy.”

The lights cut. Darkness closed in.

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Days blurred together like a foggy dreamscape. Vesna teetered on the edge of sleep, her body plagued by aching muscles and constant nausea. The booster offered a bit of relief but failed to vanquish her cravings and pounding headaches. Every morning, Nadya arrived at Vesna’s side, her keen eyes assessing progress and making necessary adjustments to her IV.

“How are you feeling?”

“Better. I think the worst is over,” she said, more to convince herself.

Nadya picked at her meal. “We’ll start your training tomorrow.”

“Training for what? I’m ready,” she declared, though in reality, Vesna just wanted to leave this place.

“A minor assignment. Nothing too dangerous. Reflex testing, target practice—typical protocol before sending you into the field.”

“And here I thought I was a prisoner.”

Nadya’s expression remained solemn. “You’re not a prisoner. You’re a soldier, and now, an asset. One we need to protect.”

Vesna scoffed. “If I were a soldier, I’d be out of here already.” She playfully pointed her finger like a gun at Nadya. “Bam. You’re dead.” Then, with a mischievous smirk, she asked, “What do you get when you cross a scientist with a joke?”

Nadya paused, her eyes lifting for a beat to the harsh ceiling light as if the punchline might be scribbled there. She met Vesna’s look and replied dryly, “An experiment in humor where the outcome is always unpredictable.”

Vesna stared at Nadya, then burst into laughter. Nadya’s deadpan comedy was a welcome break from the mounting tension in her skull. “I guess you’re right. I *am* a soldier,” she said as the pain returned.

Nadya smiled, finishing her meal in silence. To Vesna’s surprise, she found herself warming to the woman.

“Perhaps you want to atone for your sins,” Nadya mused. “Or maybe you need proof you can still change things. Regardless, I think you might be able to help the city.”

Vesna fell silent, weighing Nadya's words. "Tomorrow morning. I'll be ready."

Nadya, rising to leave, nodded. "I'll see you in the morning."

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Vesna's breaths came ragged as she clawed at the air. Her heart raced and sweat beaded her forehead. The dream had already begun to dissolve, but Dunya's face lingered, ginger hair framing big blue eyes, always wide with hope for something better. In the dream, Vesna had reached for her, certain she could bridge the distance this time. But the moment their fingers touched, Dunya slipped away into the dark.

A sharp knock rapped at the door. "Vesna," Nadya's voice echoed from the other side. "Are you awake?"

"I'm up. Come in." Wearing only a thin sheet, she sat up to receive her guest.

Nadya entered, donning her standard white shift, a uniform shared by all within the facility except for Zakharovna. The older woman made sure she stood out in her slate crimson jacket, yellow rose-patterned scarf, and signature red-tinted goggles. Her stern expression imprinted in Vesna's mind. By contrast, Nadya's face revealed little, though Vesna thought she spotted a flicker of excitement in her eyes.

"I hope you slept well."

"I slept fine," Vesna lied.

"Good. You are needed for calibration right away."

CHAPTER SEVEN

YELENA

The Grand Mariner's Cathedral rose from the heart of Gred, its stone and glass cutting into the winter sky. From the boardroom chamber high in the tower, Pra Matron Yelena Petrova watched the city beneath her. Birch trees sagged under snow, their branches rattling as hail clouds pressed low above the spires. The streets lay muted, smoke rising thin from the Derge, life clinging on where it could.

The irony was not lost on her. In a world that had banished old faiths, the cathedral still ruled the skyline, its shadows falling over a city built on contradictions. Dreamt by men who never lived to see it, ruled now by women who knew nothing else.

She let the view go with a sigh. The past and its ironies could wait. The table behind her was what mattered, twelve seats carved for power, nine of them filled today. At the head sat Zakharovna of the University, acting Pra Matron Chair, and to her right Pra Matron Tatyana Romanova of the Battalion, looking stubborn as ever.

Across from Zakharovna, the empty chair held the trace of her own presence, left behind when she had moved to the window. Her Matrons kept their places beside it, waiting as always. Valentina Vinogradova, bright-eyed and ambitious, still carried the air of a union clerk who had risen too quickly. Beside her sat Matron Ludmila Apinova, older than most in the room, a relic of Petrovskaya's Ministry who had outlasted rivals through patience as much as loyalty.

Further down, the Battalion's pair leaned into their own corner of the table. General Irina Nikitin, rigid as parade

ground steel, and Nina Grigoreva, sharp-eyed and sharper-tongued, made no secret of their collusion.

Flanking Zakharovna sat the Morozov twins, Doctors Elizaveta and Ekaterina. Their gaunt faces and matching stoops made them look more like shades than women, an effect sharpened by the glow of their bionic eyes. Whispers always followed them, questions of how much humanity remained. *Zakharovna always did prefer the grotesque.*

The oak table, once a relic of the Orthodox church, stretched between them. It had been hauled up piece by piece when the old church was gutted, dragged into place with more effort than it was worth. Zakharovna liked to say it stood for continuity. Yelena knew better. It was vanity, a relic preserved to make the Board look timeless. From her place at the window, she felt the air thicken. Eyes shifted between her and Zakharovna, waiting. Each heartbeat of silence pressed heavier. If she yielded now, everything she had fought for would be lost.

Her pulse quickened, but her voice cut clean. “Matrons and Pra Matrons of the Board. I propose that Pra Matron Chair Zakharovna be relieved of her duties.”

The table immediately broke into noise, voices rising in protest and disbelief. Yelena let it wash over her and spoke through it. “Chair Zakharovna has allowed the city to decline beyond her capacity to repair it. This scandal, tied to the University under her hand, is proof enough of that failure.”

“Chair Zakharovna’s tenure has seen the exposure of thousands of citizen profiles, leaving our people vulnerable and our societal structure at risk. The revelation of vital *view keys* not only endangers our security systems but also threatens the very fabric of trust that binds our city together. Further, this gruesome business of mindgrafting citizens with private contractors speaks to reckless negligence. Under her

watch, our city's once unblemished integrity has been irrevocably tarnished."

"I recognize that this will be a controversial motion," Yelena continued, "but I believe that it is imperative we consider it to ensure a smooth transition of power during the Ascension. Chair Zakharovna has served the Board well for four long years, but recent events have shown that her leadership is no longer what our city needs. We cannot afford complacency at this pivotal moment in our history."

Zakharovna's voice finally broke through, trembling with barely contained indignation. "This is *outrageous!* The audacity," she seethed. "I dictate the convening of our council. And your brash suggestion, mere weeks before the Ascension, is a gross overstep. Four years I've helmed this city's course—steadfast and true. To undermine my command at such a juncture reeks of defamation. I'll not stand for it. You will recall your mutinous motion at once when we are rightfully assembled!"

Tense silence enveloped the room as the members weighed the exchange. Yelena met Zakharovna's stare and didn't look away.

"I have every right," Yelena said. "According to the Charter of this Board, any member may motion for the removal of any other, at *any* time—if they believe they are no longer fit to serve. If the motion is not carried, the member who proposed it loses their seat. Chair Zakharovna, you have nothing to lose by allowing this motion to be put to a vote. If the members vouch for your competence, then your position will be secure." She paused, feeling a surge of confidence. "And mine..."

"What makes you think that I am no longer fit to serve?"

Yelena had anticipated the question, yet the fact that Zakharovna dared to mount a defense now was almost too preposterous to accept. "Are you truly so blind to your own

actions? The devastation of the past few weeks is a direct result of your leadership! How can you not see the damage you've inflicted upon our city and its people?"

Zakharovna's eyes narrowed as she growled, "This Board has overseen many periods of turmoil. It is the way of things. What would you have done if you were in my position?"

News of the data leak had spread through the city. A week ago, it had seemed containable, but now it was an inferno. And Zakharovna was the one who had set it ablaze.

UNIVERSITY INVOLVEMENT IN DATA LEAK CONFIRMED. VIEW KEYS EXPOSED. THOUSANDS OF PROFILES DECRYPTED. SYNDICATE ORDERS SECRET MINDGRAFTS VIA PRIVATE CONTRACTORS. The headlines screamed from every corner, each word heralding the mounting crisis. Yelena couldn't help but wonder: *With all these accusations and the city in turmoil, how is Zakharovna coping? She's made countless enemies over her tenure, and this recent fiasco must have added even more to that list. If I were in her shoes, I'd be scrambling to gather allies, to weather this storm out of sight.*

It was a difficult decision. On the one hand, Zakharovna could not afford to lose face by being ousted from the Board so close to the Ascension. Her credibility would be questioned at the next one, eight years from now, and she would be lucky to even keep her position as a party member until then. On the other hand, if she vetoed the motion, there was a real danger that she could be charged with crimes against the state and quarantined. It was a lose-lose scenario. But Zakharovna was a rational woman, and Yelena knew that she would see the wisdom in an early exit.

"I would like to remind the Board that these are difficult times, and sometimes difficult decisions have to be made," Zakharovna said. "Terrorists have attacked our city, and we are at war. People are scared, and they are looking for

someone to blame. I have done what was required to protect our city and its people. I know that my actions may not always be popular, but I believe that they have been necessary.”

Murmurs arose around the table, and Yelena could see now that she had captured the complete interest of the Board. It was her time to conquer this hive and, as its new queen, orchestrate its future, delegate roles, and dictate the dance of power once and for all.

“Chair Zakharovna, I admire your dedication to the city and its people,” Yelena said. “But with all due respect, I doubt your ability to lead us through these difficult times. I believe that it is time for new leadership, and I therefore also motion that Pra Matron Romanova be elected as the new Chair of the Board, ahead of schedule. We can dispense with this frivolous ceremony and get down to the business of governing.”

“If my resignation is the will of the Board, then I shall resign. However, I need not remind you that the Ascension is also enshrined in our Charter, and so in my place an interim Chair will have to be elected, to serve however briefly. I take it you have someone in mind for the job?”

Of course she did. Yelena had counted on her invoking the Charter. The suggestion of Romanova had never been anything more than bait, and Zakharovna had bitten clean through it.

“Yes, very well,” Yelena said. “I nominate Matron Valentina Vinogradova for the position. The Hive remains neutral in this matter, and I am certain that she will serve the city admirably until the Ascension can occur. She is a fair and level-headed leader, capable of guiding us through these tumultuous times with wisdom and compassion.”

A gust of scoffing laughter escaped Zakharovna, her eyes sculpting themselves into narrow crescents of scorn. “A child?

You would have us led by a child?" she sneered toward Valentina, who sat in a composed manner at Yelena's right.

Valentina had been forty for nine years, young enough by the Board's arrested measure for Zakharovna's insult to land. Her auburn-and-silver hair framed a face whose green eyes carried the Petrova stamp. She was Yelena's niece and Katerina Vinogradova's daughter, a fact known to everyone at the table. Her appointment would be judged as much by that bloodline as by her years of service to the Hive.

Low voices stirred around the table as the members weighed Yelena's proposal, their murmurs swelling like a gathering tide. Then, Valentina's melodic voice rose above them. "I accept."

"Valentina is more than capable," Yelena said. "She has served me loyally for many years, proving herself a woman of great intellect and integrity. I have no doubt that she will serve the people of this city well during her brief tenure."

"Very well then," Zakharovna conceded, her voice dripping with disdain. "Is the motion seconded?" She scanned the long, curved table, her eyes narrowed and piercing. Yelena searched the faces of the Board members for signs of support. As a member of the proposing party, she was prohibited from seconding her own motion.

From her place at Pra Matron Romanova's side, Matron Baroness Nina Grigoreva spoke, "I second the motion." A stout woman with a stern face, Grigoreva bore a long, white braid that cascaded down her back. She wore a simple dress of green and gold, the colors of her party, the long sleeves adorned with intricate embroidery depicting the symbols of her office. A golden chain encircled her neck, suspending a medallion bearing the seal of her estate.

The forecast of the Baroness' backing lingered unspoken, yet Yelena harbored her emotions behind a drawn mask. Her

expression, a tranquil sea, hid the storm within. She understood the dangers, the whispers of doubt that could emerge with each ripple of overt feeling.

Zakharovna barked, "All those in favor of the motion, please raise your hand."

Yelena, confident in the majority's support, raised hers in a brazen show of leadership. Beside her, Matron Apinova, with age-etched lines of wisdom and resilience on her face, assertively lifted hers. Valentina followed in agreement. *Three votes in favor.*

"Abstain. I grant this one to the Preporod," Pra Matron Romanova intoned, her voice calm and measured. "May they bless the decision of this Board." A religious affectation, perhaps excessive, but one that would serve her well in the days to come. Neutrality was important in a situation like this, and Yelena knew that Romanova would not want to reveal her cards just yet.

Three votes in favor, one abstention. "Four votes have been cast," Zakharovna announced. "Two more votes in favor are needed for the motion to carry."

Grigoreva's gaze sought reassurance from her Pra Matron, Romanova. With a subtle nod of approval, Romanova provided the needed affirmation. Grigoreva's hand joined the others in agreement. *Four votes in favor and one abstention.*

Zakharovna's scowl deepened, her eyes betraying her growing anxiety. On the surface, the vote seemed destined for a tie, but Yelena was confident she held one more crucial vote.

"Those who are against the motion, please raise your hand," Zakharovna commanded, her voice strained. The hands of the University's three Matrons, including Zakharovna herself, shot up in defiance. Their united opposition was a strong display, but it would not be sufficient to secure their position.

A quartet of hands raised in favor, a trio dissenting, and one taking refuge in the safety of abstention. The specter of deadlock loomed large and unsettling. In times past, the third Matron of the candidate's party held the honor of the ninth vote, the pivot point between victory and defeat. Matron General Irina Nikitin, the chosen third for Romanova, folded her arms. Her vote held the potential to quell the motion or leave it to gasp in the chill of her indifference.

Yelena understood Nikitin's unpredictable nature demanded caution in future dealings. The General of Gred's army was a formidable woman, wielding immense power and influence that should never be underestimated. Though Nikitin might not wish to appear complicit in a conspiracy, Yelena sensed she would be unable to resist the temptation for long.

With Zakharovna ousted before the Ascension, the University would stand defenseless, its vulnerabilities laid bare, a tantalizing prize for the Battalion, who were hungry for accountability. For Zakharovna, shorn of her authority, the sands of time would run out, the specter of self-pardon fading into the shadows of her once mighty reign.

Yelena's eyes collided with General Nikitin's in an exchange of silent electricity, yet Nikitin deflected the charge, her gaze veering away.

"Nikitin?" Zakharovna's eyebrow scaled her forehead in trepidation.

The general lifted her hand.

Zakharovna's face contorted, a battle of emotions playing out in her eyes before she surrendered with a bitterness that seeped into every word, the icy edge of her voice melting into a pool of defeat. "Very well. The motion is carried. If there is nothing else, this meeting is adjourned," Zakharovna said, her authority all but vanished.

Yelena allowed herself a small, triumphant smile.

The Board members started to rise from their seats, but Yelena stayed in place, her gaze fixed on Zakharovna.

“Knowledge is power,” Zakharovna uttered, her words slow and deliberate.

But power is everything, Yelena thought to herself.

“Honor Above All!” The Battalion’s motto bounced around in her conscience as she continued to glare at her adversary.

Though the war was far from over, Yelena had won this crucial battle. It marked the first step in reclaiming her rightful place: at the helm of the Board she had established years ago and the city she had sworn to protect as its first Pra Matron Chair.

At last, Yelena rose. “Strength In Numbers!” she proclaimed, echoing the mantra of her party, the Hive.

“United We Stand!” they bellowed in unison. Their voices swelled within the chamber, the echoes rebounding off the walls. It was the sound of victory and the harbinger of a crumbling empire.

“We need to talk,” Zakharovna whispered to Yelena. “In private.”

Yelena hesitated for a moment before nodding.

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As they moved through the corridor, an almost tangible tension lingered between them. Candlelight flickered in the sconces.

“I doubt you invited me on this walk to apologize,” Yelena said, breaking the silence.

“I’m sure you’ve heard the rumors,” Zakharovna challenged, bitterness tingeing her voice.

“Of course. I’m not sure what you want me to say.”

“I want you to deny them. I want you to tell me that they’re not true.”

Yelena’s nerves threatened to betray her, but she refused to let it show. “I thought you were the one who was supposed to have all the answers.”

“You’re not helping your case,” Zakharovna snapped.

“I’m sorry,” Yelena said, her voice thick with sarcasm. “But I don’t know what you want me to say. That I’m not a fire-breathing witch?”

“This Coven, what do you make of it?”

“Craven sycophants with a bloodlust,” Yelena spat. “They’re nothing but a bunch of power-hungry opportunists, looking to take advantage of the situation—a situation, I might add, that your recent leadership has not made any easier.”

“Yelena,” Zakharovna launched, a sardonic smirk seasoning her tone, “you’re playing the self-sacrificing hero *now*? Do you plan to go out in a blaze of glory, sword and all? Trust me. It doesn’t suit you.”

Unfazed, Yelena shot back, “My job is to protect the city and its people, first and foremost. They’ve earned the right to live without fear, without injustice.” Years of resentment and anger towards the woman in front of her threatened to boil over, testing the limits of her self-control.

A flicker of feigned surprise crossed Zakharovna’s face. “Well, well. I would have thought the Hive would come first for you.”

Yelena's jaw tightened. "My loyalty to my party is steadfast, but the people's welfare is a responsibility I will not shirk. I won't let them down."

Zakharovna retorted, "Such noble intentions. They remind me of a story... Ah, my dear grandmother—may Nav bless that cantankerous old hag's soul—once regaled me with the tale of a prized hen known as the Cock Queen. Would you like to hear it? Very well..."

Yelena stifled a sigh, recognizing the familiar shift in Zakharovna's tone. It was always the same, a self-indulgent tale designed to belittle, wrapped in a veneer of wit. The woman thrived on these stories, each more tiresome than the last, and yet, Yelena could do little but wait as Zakharovna indulged in her theatrics.

Zakharovna leaned back, a wistful smile forming as she began recounting. "She overthrew the rooster and took his place, with the other chickens following her because of her strength and ability to lay the most eggs. She was the empress of the barnyard and strutted around like she owned the place. But one day, the farmers left the hennery unguarded, and a hawk swooped down and snatched her up. The other chickens were left to fend for themselves and eventually became prey to foxes and coyotes."

"The rooster, exiled and scorned, waited until the farmers returned and repaired the hennery. He then took his rightful place as leader, watching the skies closely and giving the signal to hide when necessary. The chickens never doubted their true leader again."

Yelena felt the corner of her mouth twitch upwards, amused. "Are you suggesting I am the hen in this tale, or are you the cock, perhaps?"

Zakharovna locked her gaze with Yelena's, her voice stern. "I must admit, I'm impressed you've come this far. I didn't

think you had it in you. Yet, those lumbering fools will present a problem. Do you honestly believe they expect you to relinquish your newfound power without a struggle? That your actions stemmed from pure altruism? You'll be incarcerated before the week's end. Mark my words."

"As long as you join me," Yelena said, unable to hide her loathing for this woman any longer.

Zakharovna sneered, "Don't be a fool, girl. You know I'm not going anywhere. The people need me. They'll never accept you as their queen, no matter how much you pretend to care for them. The Battalion clings to you only because you fed their fear—because you convinced Romanova I would never let her ascend. They're using you, as you're using them. And when they see the city still stands with me, they'll drop you like a broken spear. The Wolves remain loyal to me, even the Vory. After all, I granted this city eternal life. The citizens will never forget that."

"I wouldn't be so certain," Yelena countered. "An eternal existence in a never-ending prison is no gift. I believe you'll find the Hive more than capable of governing the city without you."

"Is that a threat?"

"No. It's a promise."

At Zakharovna's finger snap, two imposing guards emerged from the shadows. Their emblem, a snarling wolf, shimmered in the candlelight, silver fangs gleaming.

"Break her neck," she commanded, "and take her to the kennels."

With a swift and brutal motion, the guards clamped onto Yelena's collar, their ragged nails biting into her skin. Yelena bit back a cry, wrestling against their iron grip. Yet, the raw power they wielded overwhelmed her resistance.

“The beasts are due for their evening meal.” Zakharovna’s voice was as chilling as the statement itself.

A cold wave of dread washed over Yelena as the guards began to drag her towards the door.

“Wait,” Zakharovna called out. “We shouldn’t threaten our new Counsel’s aunty. That young girl of hers might take offense. Yelena, let’s discuss this rationally.” The Black Wolves released her, and she stumbled forward.

“If you wish to start a war,” Zakharovna growled, “at least have the decency to do it yourself. You’re unfit to lead anything. You’re a coward.” With that, she turned sharply, her guards trailing behind her in a dizzying spatter of black, red, and blue.

Yelena felt weighed down, the air around her thick with the tension of an impending storm. Each step was a struggle, like pushing through fierce gusts of wind. She drew in a deep breath, desperate to calm her pounding heart and steady her racing thoughts.

Klara emerged from the adjacent hallway, where she had been listening, her face ashen and gaunt. The shadows beneath her eyes were as deep as the bruises Yelena felt blossoming on her shoulder.

“What happened?” Klara asked. She reached out with a tentative hand. “Are you alright?”

Yelena shook her head. “I cannot say for certain. But I believe we find ourselves on the brink of war... We must bolster our ranks.”

Klara nodded. “I’ll head down to the Derge. Round up some old crones. Turn them.”

“We’re going to need more chemists, too. Get those labs humming,” Yelena said. She found herself drifting towards the

transept of the cathedral, where a clear glass window stood out among the intricate mosaics of its stained counterparts.

Outside, the tempest that had been raging subsided, the dark clouds parting for rays of sunlight that set the world ablaze with hues of fire.

The streets and spires below looked almost like painted scenery, waiting for a curtain to rise.

“Strength in numbers,” she murmured, more to herself than to Klara, as her gaze fixed on the sun breaking through the clouds. It was a mantra that had served her well in the past, and she clung to it now like a lifeline.

CHAPTER EIGHT

DUNYA

Dunya crossed the quad, her wheelchair's tires whispering over the concrete. Students loitered beneath the Temple of Gamayun, whose stone wings enclosed a laurel wreath with all the subtlety of a state seal.

Vesna had been gone for days. Dunya's messages showed *delivered* and nothing else. Yana had stopped replying too. Two dead channels made a pattern, and patterns were supposed to be Dunya's thing.

Had she pushed too hard? Probably. She had once sat through an Arkyv therapy module about personal boundaries and come away convinced that boundaries were what people invoked when they wanted you to stop asking questions.

She paused beside a bench, locked one wheel, and used the backrest to lift and reposition herself. Her arms shook by the time she settled again. Vesna had told her to take a break, so Dunya would leave the apartment, drink a coffee, and pretend this counted.

She pushed her wheels forward, the motion a temporary reprieve from her darker thoughts. At the edge of the quad, she veered onto the path that led to the Graduate Society Building, a squat red-brick affair housing a cafeteria, a bookstore, and a smattering of shops. It was one of the few campus locations that remained student-free, a sanctuary where she could escape the chaos of her online life and its relentless mysteries and intrusions.

Entering the cafeteria, Dunya ordered a coffee and found a waist-high table by the window, angling her chair for an easy reach and clear view of the entrance. As she inhaled the rich aroma of her drink, she couldn't help but half-hope Vesna

would bound in, her trademark black leather jacket and wide-leg cargo pants trailing behind her. Vesna used to find her here after the classes Dunya audited under a spoofed credential, dropping into the chair opposite and stealing the first sip of her coffee before asking what trouble she'd found. At first, Dunya assumed she was checking up on her. Later, she realized Vesna had simply wanted to see her. But deep down, Dunya knew that hope was in vain; Vesna wouldn't come. Not this time.

She took a tentative sip, wincing as the scalding liquid seared her tongue. Setting the coffee down, she gazed out the window, her eyes tracing the arcs of seagulls against the endless blue sky.

The stark beauty of the Kamchatkan horizon stretched out before her, from the campus's edge to the deep gray expanse of Avacha Bay. The snow-crowned cone of Vilyuchik stratovolcano loomed in the distance, its summit wreathed in clouds like Gamayun's halo. Dunya's eyes wandered over the architectural sprawl, the ships in the harbor, and the distant mountain peaks. A tranquility that rivaled the best sims she'd ever encountered.

The door creaked open, ushering in a gust of cool air that stirred the room. A serene voice interrupted her reverie, as clear and distant as a bell tolling in the wind. "Is this seat taken?"

Dunya swiveled to find a tall, lanky girl standing beside her, shaggy black hair framing her hazel eyes. A denim jacket draped over a black shirt, while an indigo backpack hung from one shoulder.

"No," Dunya replied, offering a small smile. "Go ahead."

The girl settled in, unzipped her backpack, and extracted a well-worn copy of *The Brothers Karamazov*. She placed the book on the table with a reverence that told of countless

readings. "I'm sorry," she said, glancing up at Dunya. "I didn't mean to disturb you."

"All good. I was just daydreaming."

The girl's smile echoed Dunya's, and she said, "I know the feeling. This place can be a little overwhelming at times."

"You new 'round here?" Dunya prided herself on memorizing the faces of everyone who raided her sanctuary, and she was certain this one would have left a lasting impression. Girls like her were a rare sight these days; *how many made it through Gred who skirted below the age of thirty?* she wondered. *Ten percent? Less?*

"I'm Serafim. Just transferred from the Mathematical Physics Department down the main stretch. What about you?" As she spoke, her hazel eyes caught the light, fracturing them across Dunya's gaze.

Shaking off the momentary distraction, Dunya responded, "Just auditing a few classes, whenever I can bring myself to leave the apartment. I graduated a few years ago."

"That's cool. I wish I could say the same, but I'm feeling a bit out of my depth."

"It's tough at first, but you'll get used to it," Dunya said, though the words came out by habit, not conviction. The moment hung, and her mind slipped back to the old training simulators, the instructors barking until her throat burned from repeating answers. Everyone younger than thirty had gone through it, a crucible that was supposed to forge the next generation. Mostly it made survivors who pretended strength while exhaustion hollowed them out.

Serafim let out a small shiver. "I hope it works out. Virtual learning has always felt off to me, you know? It's like grabbing smoke. I'm wrestling with this project on large language models. Interpreting nineteenth-century Russian literature

and, get this, converting it into music. It's tricky, making sense of old words and painting them into something new."

"I know what you mean. I'm the same way with books. I can't stand holding them and flipping through the pages."

"It's like you're not really there, you know?"

Dunya nodded, her thoughts drifting like a comet spinning out of orbit. "Sometimes, veering off at the last minute is exactly what we want. Like self-sabotage is our own messed-up version of time-travel—taking the detour because we're already tired of where the straight road's headed."

Serafim grinned, leaning in a little. "And here I thought I was lost. Turns out, I just like a little chaos."

After a pause, Dunya added, "You'll figure it out sooner or later. Just about striking that balance between what's in front of you and whatever you're chasing."

"Or maybe I'll just keep you around to remind me of that," Serafim shot back.

Dunya felt a flicker of warmth cross her cheeks. *Keep me around, huh?*

Her gaze drifted out the window. Outside, the ocean churned on, waves rolling and breaking with an energy that felt like her own mind. Always shifting, restless.

"So, what really brought you here today?" Serafim said.

Taking a deep breath, Dunya stared ahead and replied, "I needed some time to think. Just...think." Her eyes followed the dance of a trio of leaping porpoises beyond the glass, their silver forms briefly cutting through the air before diving back into the icy depths of the bay.

"No, really. What's on your mind?"

Dunya didn't turn from the window, though Serafim's question lingered pleasantly in the air. There was something

about her tone—soft, curious, unguarded—that made Dunya want to answer honestly. But honesty was risk, and she’d had her fill of people using her truths for leverage. So she smiled faintly at the glass and said, “Oh, just the usual—life, the universe, and *everything*.”

It was easier to hide behind humor than to admit she hadn’t slept in days, that the dream kept clawing at her every time she closed her eyes.

“In that case,” Serafim said. “I suppose it’s *no thanks* to the salted cod for lunch today; wouldn’t want to further complicate the mysteries of existence.”

“You’ve read Hitchhiker’s?”

“My dad left it behind for me, a paperback. It’s a classic. I find twentieth-century Eastern pop culture fascinating. It’s so...raw.”

“I’m sorry, it’s just... I thought I was the only one still clinging to tales of cosmic adventure—quite the leap from most people’s aspirations around here.”

“I’m not most people.”

“I can see that.”

“So, tell me, little miss cosmonaut-in-the-making. Why do you think the Babushka system abandoned air travel after *Horizon*, huh? Even ordinary orbital launches stopped. What are they hiding?”

Dunya chuckled, “Well, if piloting sims count for anything, they should sign me up for the next star treks. But in all seriousness, I think Babushka’s playing a deeper game than we know. It’s either deemed the airspace too hazardous, or—more likely, it’s conserving efforts for something...else.”

Serafim nodded. "Either way, that's a little over my head. Besides, I'm being sandbagged with Dostoevsky. It might as well be hieroglyphics."

Dunya laughed. "Don't worry, half the time I feel like I'm deciphering ancient runes when I'm working through code."

As their conversation went on, Dunya realized she was saying more than she meant to, more than she had with anyone in years except Maria. Something about Serafim's calm made it feel safe to speak. She told her about Vesna, about the silence that had followed her disappearance, and about her work as a cryptographer, the feeling of drowning in an ocean of data, fighting to keep her head above the surface.

"That sounds amazing," Serafim said. "I wish I could do something like that."

Dunya shrugged. "It's not as glamorous as it sounds."

"I thought if I switched to literature, I'd find some peace of mind, but so far, it's been just as bad. Sometimes, I think these algorithms shouldn't be fed anything written after the seventeenth century. After that, who's to say what's genuine or not? Isn't there always the chance that the creators selectively weighted inputs from more recent history, texts that might have been altered or politically sanitized? I've read that the foundation models the city relies on were built on synthesized training data. By the early decades of the twenty-first century, a vast chunk of all data wasn't even human-generated. It's like we're sifting through a digital masquerade, searching for the authentic behind a parade of cleverly veiled guises."

"You sound...almost haunted by it," Dunya said. "Is there anything else troubling you?"

"Besides plagiarizing Gogol, Pushkin, and Tolstoy with the help of a neural network? I've been having these dreams. Strange, vivid dreams that I can't make sense of." Serafim

looked embarrassed to admit it. “I’ve been having them for months.”

“What kind of dreams?”

“Nightmares, mostly. Dreams that come true.”

At this, Dunya sat up straighter. “What do you mean, dreams that *come true*?”

Serafim recounted the dream she’d had the night before and the countless nights before that. She described the synthetic cityscape in detail, the sinking dread that welled within her when the garish matron with hawk-like features appeared and stole away the children she never had. She spoke of waking in a cold sweat, disoriented, and confused, the fragments of her dream only returning to her in fits over the course of the day. “Two weeks after the first dream, my cousins died. They were killed in a car accident.”

“I’m so sorry,” Dunya said.

“My aunt hailed a cab for them from the nursery. Nine years old, the pair of them, when the car veered off the road and plummeted down an embankment. They were killed instantly.”

Dunya couldn’t recall the last time there was a traffic accident. She couldn’t remember the last time children even lived in the city.

“My aunt and uncle were never the same,” Serafim said, her gaze hollow as she recounted the past. “Blame became their way of life, and conversations with me ceased. I was just a reminder of what they’d lost. He took his life within the year. You know, almost nobody has kids anymore. Having twins was their miracle. But their suffering was too immense to carry.”

She let the silence linger a moment before adding, “That’s what we talked about in class today. There’s no God. That’s

what the professor believes anyway—just the coldness of nature, indifferent to what we endure.”

As the hours passed, Dunya shared pieces of her father’s war, the fieldwork that had taken her beyond the city, and the injury that had taken the use of her legs before his final act took him from her. She confessed that she had never felt like she belonged anywhere.

Serafim, in turn, reflected on her own upbringing. “My mother left me with a mystery—no clue who my dad was. All I’ve pieced together is that he was some engineer from America—with a ‘C,’ not the ‘K’ you’d find in the Arkyv.”

She glanced around, her voice softening. “But this spot? It’s like a little slice of home. I can shake off the history, leave it at the door. In these moments between lectures, I’m free to just live in the now.”

Serafim kept talking, and Dunya noticed she had stopped filtering every sentence before it left her mouth. She had spent years treating closeness like an unsecured port, useful until somebody exploited it, and could not decide whether this felt like trust or negligence.

“I get buried in work,” she said. “Code behaves. People don’t. Eventually you forget which one you’re avoiding.”

Her fingers had locked around the table’s edge. She released them when she noticed Serafim fidgeting with her sleeve. “Sorry. Didn’t mean to dump all that on you.”

“It’s okay.”

By the time Dunya looked toward the window again, the bay had gone dark and her coffee was cold. Serafim caught her lower lip between her teeth. Dunya leaned forward before she finished calculating why.

Their lips met.

When they separated, Dunya whispered, "I'm sorry."

Serafim shook her head. "Don't be. I'm not."

I can't believe I kissed her.

Dunya caught her reflection in the window. Chair, Skelet, exhaustion, none of it had made her invisible. She was still attractive. She knew that. But Serafim made her feel suddenly obvious, every guarded look logged and returned.

When they kissed again, Dunya let the analysis fail for one second. Warm mouth, shared breath, the stupid relief of wanting something that was not another problem to solve.

Serafim leaned close enough that Dunya forgot the room for one dangerous second. Her hand found the edge of Dunya's vest, then stopped there. The touch was light, but it carried intent.

"I want you," Serafim whispered.

Dunya's eyes widened as guilt cut through the heat. "Vesna," she stammered. "I... I can't."

"I'm taken, too."

"We shouldn't." Dunya forced herself back from the edge of the moment. "Thank you. I just... I need to find her."

"She wouldn't want you to stress. You've been through a lot lately. How far are you from home? I can take you."

The offer should have felt kind. Instead, it tightened something in Dunya's stomach. Serafim's concern had begun to feel placed rather than given. "That's kind of you, but I'm fine." The truth was that she'd left her braces back at the apartment. They were heavy and awkward, and tonight she didn't have the strength for any of it. Not the walking, not the pretense, and certainly not whatever Serafim was offering.

"Well, at least let me help you to the door." Serafim stood and extended her hand.

Dunya paused before taking it. When she looked up, Serafim's eyes were filled with concern, but her fingers lingered too long on the table's edge, calculating behind the softness.

Dunya opened her mouth to answer, but her vision wavered. The room seemed to smear at the edges, colors bleeding together. A low hum rose in her ears, swelling into a roar that drowned everything out. Images flashed through her mind, fragmented and violent, like a signal breaking apart.

The world fractured around her. A black wolf moved through a fog-drenched forest, its eyes glinting like shards of glass. Fire swept across a ruined city, devouring the skyline as bodies lined the streets. A young woman struggled against her bindings, terror frozen on her face. A Matron watched from the shadows, a yellow rose tucked in her hair. Then came the tree, vast and alive, its branches twisting toward the heavens. Dunya saw herself at its peak, looking down on the chaos spreading below, unable to move, unable to turn away as the vision swallowed her whole.

"No. I don't think I am." Dunya said.

The visions dissolved as quickly as they had come, leaving her trembling and unsteady.

"What is it? What's wrong?" Serafim's voice sounded distant, muffled by the ringing in Dunya's ears.

She tried to speak, but the words tangled and fell apart before reaching her lips. "I... I'm not sure." The images still burned in her mind, too vivid to be dreams yet too strange to be memories.

"It's all right," Serafim whispered. "Just breathe."

Dunya inhaled sharply and leaned back, her body heavy with exhaustion. The motion sent her coffee cup teetering off the table. It should have fallen, but instead it froze midair,

spinning slowly as if caught in invisible hands. The liquid shimmered inside, caught between motion and stillness, the world itself seeming to warp around it.

A sudden sting at her neck broke the illusion. Dunya's hand shot up, but too late. Serafim's calm expression had turned cold, her grip steady as she withdrew a syringe and tossed it aside. The cup hit the floor and shattered, coffee splattering across the tiles.

Dunya's breath caught in her throat, panic clawing to break free. Serafim gripped her by the shoulders, her fingers digging in hard enough to hurt.

"Where is it? What did you do with it?" The warmth was gone from her voice, replaced by an edge that made Dunya's stomach twist.

Dunya's vision blurred, struggling to make sense of the scene. Serafim's face flickered in and out of focus. "What are you talking about?" she gasped, the words barely leaving her lips.

"The decryption key. Where is it?"

"I don't know. I swear, I don't know."

Serafim's fingers dug into Dunya's skin. "You're the only one who does."

Decryption key? Dunya's mind raced, her heart pounding. *This couldn't be virtual, could it?*

"I don't have time for this," Serafim snapped, retrieving a vial from her pocket and uncorking it with her teeth.

"No, don't," Dunya gasped, panic rising as she tried to pull away, her strength fading.

Serafim pressed the vial to Dunya's lips. "Drink."

Dunya clamped her mouth shut, jerking her head to the side, but Serafim's grip was relentless. She proceeded to pry

Dunya's jaw open and poured the liquid down her throat. Dunya sputtered, trying to cough it up, but the liquid burned as it slid down, searing her insides like a blazing orb, settling in her stomach with a violent heat.

Serafim let go, and Dunya crumpled to the floor, gasping and retching, her body trembling as the burning liquid tore through her insides.

"What did you do to me?" Dunya choked out, her voice hoarse with panic.

Serafim stood over her, expression calm, eyes cold. "Only what you allowed. Now, where is the key?"

Dunya writhed on the floor, her muscles seizing as the liquid scorched its path through her veins. She could feel it, like fire spreading through every nerve, searing her from the inside out. "I told you. I don't know. I don't know what you're talking about," she gasped, her voice breaking with the effort.

She tried to push herself up, but her limbs were limp, betraying her. The floor felt like quicksand, dragging her down. "Please," she whimpered, desperation clawing at her throat. "Just let me go."

"I can't do that. Not until you give me what I need." Serafim knelt and grabbed Dunya's chin, forcing their eyes to meet. "Where is the key?"

"I... I think I gave it to Vesna."

The room's brightness suddenly flared, a blinding light stabbing through Dunya's vision. She squinted, instinctively shielding her eyes, her pulse quickening with dread. From across the bay, flames tore into the sky, and a mushroom cloud bloomed, growing larger, devouring the horizon as it spread. It swallowed the city's gleaming lights, veiling them beneath a cloud of destruction.

The roar of the explosion overwhelmed her, forcing her hands instinctively to her ears, though it did little to muffle the sound. She watched in horror as windows shattered around her. Out of the corner of her eye, she saw Serafim crash to the ground, arms raised defensively over her head against the rain of glass and debris. Suddenly, the room plunged into darkness, and all Dunya could hear was the ragged rhythm of her own breathing.

And then she shot up in bed, her eyes scanning the room. A deep breath of relief escaped her as she realized she was safe at home. Her headgear rested on a desk across from her, code-locked and charged. *So, I didn't fall asleep at the roll...*

With swift movements, Dunya pivoted into her wheelchair, gliding over to her workstation. She slipped the neural rig over her head, the crown tightening as sensors aligned along her scalp. A faint hum filled her ears. As she pulled on the device, she winced at the sting of the electrodes piercing her skin. The hardlight display materialized before her, layered with translucent panels hovering in the air. Streams of data scrolled in vertical columns, shifting as her eyes tracked them. She sifted through them at a breakneck pace, searching for anomalies.

A flash of memory cut through the fog. The campus visit. Dunya focused, straining to pull another fragment into view. A new face, a conversation, then nothing. The rest slipped away into darkness no matter how tightly she tried to hold it. Her breathing hitched as she pushed deeper into the neural feed, drawn toward a faint signal pulsing within her own data stream. It glowed in the haze of her thoughts like a beacon, an energy pattern in her hippocampus that shouldn't have been there. A cognitive implant she couldn't remember ever having installed.

Her ocular buzzed with a new message.

The panels flickered, reorganizing into a compact notification window:

SENDER: SYNDICATE/UNIVERSITY.

SUBJECT: NEW CONTRACT.

PRIORITY: HIGH.

She didn't want to take on any new work, not with Vesna still missing, but she considered her options. She recalled what Yana had said at The Flock:

"Wouldn't that make us the delivery crew?"

A part of her clung to the hope that each new contract might actually bring her closer to Vesna, even though she resisted the thought. She hated to think that Yana's omen might be true, but with few leads left and fewer people she could trust, the contracts were her best chance.

She curled her lips in anticipation and opened the message. The panels expanded, lines of encrypted text unraveling into readable format:

SEARCH AND LOCATE.

Dunya didn't get tangled up in her targets' biologics; their physical identifiers were just noise that could cloud her mission's clarity. The real hunt was in the web of VR, tracking their unique signatures through data streams, laying the groundwork for a real-world capture. It was cleaner that way, less personal.

It's better not to know, she reminded herself. But this time...

Expanding the contract details, she scrutinized the extra data:

SERAFIM SOROKIN

BIO AGE: 22

HEIGHT: 5'9"

WEIGHT: 150 LBS.

Dunya froze. Serafim. The name echoed through her like a warning. It couldn't be. She had just met her, spoken with her, kissed her. How could a ghost end up as a target?

A dull pressure built behind her eyes. This was real. It had to be. Her gaze lingered on the flickering name, her hand trembling as she hovered over the command to proceed. The interface pulsed faintly, waiting for confirmation.

She read the data again, disbelief hollowing her out. Maybe it was a glitch, some database error, or a cruel coincidence. That had to be it. And yet the details were exact.

She closed her eyes and pressed her fingers to her temples. The pain, the sleepless nights, the visions, they all blurred together. When she opened her eyes again, the interface hovered expectantly, its faint blue glow washing over her face. Her hand drifted toward the confirm command. She exhaled slowly, caught between fear and exhaustion, wishing more than anything for the nightmares to stop.

CHAPTER NINE

KLARA

The Derge had once tried to rival Gred, prosperous and loud, its markets packed with traders, repair stalls, and engine smoke. Now it sat on the horizon as a ruin, a nest of outlaws and scavengers tearing each other apart over scraps of metal and warmth. The approach was worse, a corridor of dead haulers, cracked pylons, and ice-swallowed road markers. She pushed through the elfin cedar and waist-deep snow, each drift collapsing under her weight with a muffled groan. The cold gnawed through her coat, sharp and familiar. It was the same kind of cold that had nearly killed her once.

That storm still lived in her bones. The cold pulled the memory out of her, raw and bright: the sky splitting open, the wind howling like a wounded animal, the world turning white. The Vachka had struck in that chaos, overrunning the Syndicate outpost at Zavoyko while half the garrison froze in their trenches. They wanted the springs. Everyone did. Out there, heat and running water meant survival, and the geothermal wells were worth dying for.

Her mission then had been to support the Syndicate troops dug in among the basalt crags to the east, defending what remained of Zavoyko at all costs. The ARRT Antenna had fallen years earlier, but the spring line, repair sheds, trenches, and Avacha approaches still fed the Yelizovo-Zavoyko defense system. If those fell, the southern approaches would open and Petropavlovsk would lose the last defensive ring between the city and the hills. The old saying still held true: no roads led to Kamchatka. The last plane had taken off thirty years before that.

Driven by duty, Klara had abandoned her post at the radio station and joined the fighting along the ruined tower line,

determined to hold the perimeter no matter the cost. Only later would the ledgers call it the final coordinated Vachka assault. In the storm, it felt endless. She spent weeks patching wounds, dragging the injured to cover, and braving wind cold enough to freeze blood where it fell. The Vachka ranks only seemed to swell with every assault.

She could still see the frozen bodies of fallen men stacked beside the outpost, grim proof of the conflict's toll. Syndicate wetwork had piled them high, their limbs locked in ice, faces half-buried in snow. From the mountains, the Vachka came in waves, a living avalanche driven by hunger, faith, and fury.

Now the memory returned in full. Icy shards lashed at her fur cloak as she huddled behind a boulder, seeking respite from the onslaught. True shelter was a luxury in the raging storm, but she did her best to minimize her exposure to the biting gales. Her breaths emerged in ragged, frosty plumes that vanished into the blizzard's embrace. Numb fingers and bleary eyes struggled to maintain their purpose as the cold closed in from all directions.

A distant voice pierced the whiteout, calling her name. It seemed far away, but the storm's ferocity made it hard to tell. She attempted to respond, but her voice was devoured by the relentless storm.

"Medic! Klara, where are you?"

The voice was a whisper carried by the wind, but she recognized it as Vatrallyna, her battlefield commander and savior on multiple occasions. "I'm here," Klara croaked. She attempted to stand, to wave her arms and signal her position, but her strength betrayed her. She slumped against the boulder, her vision swimming.

"Aisyt be praised!" Vatrallyna's relief echoed through the storm. Klara saw her ahead, trudging through the relentless

snow, her longsword trailing behind her. “I thought you were dead.”

“Not yet,” Klara shouted, dredging up the last reserves of her strength. The wind snatched at her defiance, shattering it like hail.

“Fall back!” Vatrallyna ordered, but it was too late. A bloodcurdling scream sliced through the tempest, and Klara knew her commander was in peril. Klara willed herself upright and lurched toward the source of the cry, her boots plunging into the snow-laden earth.

For a moment the blizzard thinned, and she caught glimpses of shadowy figures advancing on Vatrallyna. Clad in furs and tattered rags, the attackers moved like wraiths through the storm. Klara’s heart clenched as she saw her commander prone on the ground, her red hair splayed around her like a gory halo. A contingent of black leather-clad soldiers surrounded her, their blades singing as they fought to protect their fallen leader.

The savage assailants bore down on the defenders, wielding pickaxes and knives of stone and wood. Klara went still, breath shallow, as she took in their yellow teeth and the wild hunger twisting their faces. The gleam of those crude blades seared into her skull.

Despite her body’s protests, Klara pressed forward, determined to reach her comrades and defend Vatrallyna from the encroaching horde. She charged into the fray, seizing the nearest assailant and hurling him into his companions. They fell in a tangle of limbs and shouts. Another lunged with a blade, but she sidestepped and caught his arm, twisting until the bone gave way with a sharp crack. She drove her knee into his gut, and as he folded, she pulled a knife from her belt and plunged it into the next attacker.

The remaining savages turned their attention to Vatrallyna's vulnerable form on the ground.

"No!" Klara screamed, lunging to shield her commander with her own body. The heat of their breath on her neck and the press of their bodies were stifling. Trapped on a snowbank's edge, Klara, Vatrallyna, and three others were encircled by axe-wielding marauders with no escape in sight.

"Stand back," Klara warned, her voice firm. "I'm not afraid to die."

"Then you are a fool," one of them hissed, and he threw an axe at her head. It missed her, and then she heard the rustling of trees and the rhythmic pounding of hooves on snow. Hope surged. "Cavalry!" she cried in relief.

The savages spun around, and Klara took the opportunity to help Vatrallyna to her feet. They were now surrounded by the Syndicate's elite warriors, astride their armored ibex steeds. The riders brandished maces and bows; a lethal host prepared for battle.

"Get her out of here," someone shouted, and Klara felt both herself and Vatrallyna hoisted onto the back of one of the massive beasts. Concussed, Vatrallyna clung to Klara as they weaved through the sea of fur and steel. There seemed to be no way out, but they would make one.

The ibex surged forward, Klara gripping Vatrallyna tight as they carved a path through the chaos. She felt the beast's muscles bunch and release beneath her, each stride a surge of raw power. It plowed through the mob, scattering bodies like autumn leaves. "Hold on," the rider barked, and they charged up the ridge as arrows hissed through the air around them.

At the crest, a shaft struck the rider in the neck. He jerked back with a strangled cry, and the ibex reared, momentum breaking apart in a heartbeat. Klara barely had time to tighten

her hold before the world flipped. The next instant, she and Vatrallyna were tumbling through snow and brush, the ground slamming into her shoulder, then her ribs. The ibex vanished into the trees, braying in panic.

Klara coughed, tasting blood and pine needles, then forced herself upright. "Come on," she rasped, grabbing Vatrallyna's hand and hauling her to her feet. "We need cover. Now."

They dove behind a fallen tree as a volley of sharpened stone tore through the air. Klara pressed her back against the bark, scanning the chaos beyond. Shapes moved through the smoke and snow, the savages closing in with guttural cries that echoed through the forest. She grabbed the first man to reach them, twisting him around to use his body as a shield. Vatrallyna, shaking off her daze, knocked an arrow and released. It struck clean through the man's throat, his breath turning to a wet rattle. Klara shoved the corpse aside and braced for the next wave.

"Cover me," she commanded, and Vatrallyna knocked another arrow. Klara confronted the remaining four, knives poised in her hands. "For the Syndicate!" she cried, driving her serrated dagger into the back of one assailant. The blade ripped through muscle and bone, eliciting a wail of agony. The others hesitated.

"Who's next?" Klara challenged.

The savages didn't anticipate Klara's next move, as she lunged at the closest marauder, knife brandished. He raised his axe in defense, but she was too swift. Her blade carved a fatal arc through his neck, and he fell, choking and convulsing.

"Kill her!" one of the savages barked, shattering their collective paralysis. They advanced, their numbers swelling, but Klara met them head-on. She fought with blade and boot, moving faster than thought, lost in the rush of heat and

motion. Arrows whistled overhead, Vatrallyna's battle cries cutting through the din as she unsheathed her sword and waded into the fray.

The savages were outmatched, falling to Vatrallyna's blade like wheat before a scythe. One by one, they succumbed, until only two remained. Vatrallyna's arm oozed crimson, but she seemed oblivious. She was a tempest of rage, her breath steaming in the frigid air and her green eyes smoldering red.

Klara evaded an axe's arc and skewered her blade into the man's groin. He shrieked and buckled. Seizing the opportunity, the other assailant aimed his axe at Klara. But she sidestepped, and the axe lodged in the snow. As the man struggled to free it, Klara closed in, severing his throat with a swift stroke. He slumped to the ground beside his brethren.

"We have to go," Vatrallyna urged. "They'll be back."

Klara nodded, and they darted through the trees, the sounds of pursuit snapping at their heels. Their lead was tenuous; the savages were fast and familiar with the terrain. "This way," Klara directed, veering to the left.

"Help us!"

Klara and Vatrallyna stumbled upon a cluster of Syndicate soldiers in a clearing. The three women raised their swords, catching the first blows on steel. But the savages pressed in, overwhelming them with axes and knives. Klara's eyes flicked toward the soldiers. One stumbled, her head cleaved from her shoulders. Another fell as a blade drove through her stomach.

"You monsters!" Klara shouted, charging toward the fallen, but it was in vain. The last woman was already dead.

A sudden sting tore through her cloak, followed by the warm slide of blood down her arm. More blades struck, biting into her flesh. She gritted her teeth and turned to face them, unwilling to yield, but the men kept coming.

“Get back!” Vatrallyna’s voice rang out, and an arrow whizzed past Klara’s head, finding its mark in a tribesman’s eye.

Then Klara heard it, a guttural growl rising behind her. The savages recoiled, eyes wide with terror, and scrambled away in panic. Klara turned toward the sound.

The behemoth of a bear was a sight to behold. Towering twenty hands tall, its blood-matted fur bristled with rage. Its teeth resembled cleavers, and its eyes blazed red with primal fury. The beast seized the nearest savage, dismembering him with ease.

Chaos erupted as the others screamed and fled, but the bear was relentless, a whirlwind of claws and teeth. It tore through the ranks, tossing bodies aside with terrifying strength. Blood streaked its fur as it crushed one attacker after another, the snow around it churning into a dark, steaming slush. When the last of the savages broke and ran, the beast stood heaving in the clearing, its breath fogging the cold air.

Dumbstruck, Klara surveyed the scene. The savages lay scattered across the clearing, the snow torn and soaked in blood. Steam rose from the ground where bodies had fallen. The noise was gone now, leaving only the rasp of her own breath. She tried to move, but her legs gave out beneath her. Warmth spread down her side, and when she pressed a hand to it, her palm came away red. The sight hollowed her. She sank to her knees, then to the snow itself, the cold seeping in as her vision dimmed.

Something heavy stirred nearby. The crunch of snow, slow and deliberate, drew closer. A shadow loomed over her, vast enough to blot the light. She forced her eyes open and saw the bear standing above her, chest rising and falling like a bellows.

It lowered its head. For a moment she thought it meant to finish her, but instead she felt the brush of a paw against her cheek, surprisingly gentle. She met its gaze, amber and steady, impossibly calm. The beast studied her, then leaned closer and ran its tongue across her wounds. Fire lanced through her body. She gasped, gripping the snow as pain turned to heat, then to something else. The bleeding stopped. The torn flesh sealed. Breath came easier.

When the pain finally ebbed, so did her strength. She sagged into the snow, vision swimming, the bear still watching her as darkness gathered at the edges of her sight.

The bear rose and lumbered away, vanishing into the swirling ice and snow that enclosed them like a guardian shield. As the storm eased, Klara found herself alone. She longed to follow the creature but couldn't move. Cold crept back into her limbs, and her sight began to dim when a shadowed figure emerged from the haze, lifting her gently and carrying her away.

Through the haze, a figure took shape, moving toward her with measured steps. At first, Klara thought it was another vision, a trick of exhaustion. Then the wind shifted, revealing a familiar outline, the curve of the shoulders, the stride. A faint glow caught her attention, two points of red cutting through the dimness. Her breath hitched as recognition settled in. Vatrallyna.

She was flanked by three women, two nursing fresh wounds. They must have crossed countless snowbanks, ravines, and frozen rivers to reach her. As night deepened, the cold's grip tightened, gnawing at Klara's very marrow. She pulled her cloak closer, seeking shelter from the wind. Her lips parted, the words of gratitude forming but never finding breath. Each time she surfaced from the blur of exhaustion, she noticed the ibexes' packs growing lighter, the hours stretching longer.

As the terrain grew harsher, Klara felt each jolt of the ibex beneath her like a bruise. The others slumped in their saddles, silent and spent. When the outline of a cave finally emerged through the blowing snow, a ripple of relief passed through the group. They slowed to a stop, and with her strength failing, Klara leaned on Vatrallyna for support as she dismounted. Wrapped in a fur blanket, she sank into its warmth, grateful for even that small comfort.

“We’ll make camp here,” Vatrallyna declared. “I’ll start a fire.”

Klara attempted to sit up but faltered, weakened by the loss of blood and the aftershock of their harrowing experience.

“Rest,” Vatrallyna urged, her tone gentle but firm. “You need to rest.”

“Did we win?” Klara asked.

Vatrallyna shook her head. “No. But we live. That is enough.”

Klara wanted to argue. It was an ugly answer, and Vatrallyna had made it sound like discipline. The fire blurred before Klara could find the strength.

She awoke to the soft urgency of Vatrallyna’s voice.

“Klara, wake up.”

Blinking her eyes open, Klara found Vatrallyna’s face looming over her, lit by the soft glow of firelight. Although night still enveloped the world and she hadn’t rested for long, she felt a renewed sense of energy.

“What is it?” she asked, her fingers brushing the tender, healing flesh where the bear had licked her wounds.

“I’m not sure,” Vatrallyna said, “but I saw something out there, watching us. We need to be cautious. I don’t think we’re alone.”

From the darkness, a woman's voice rang out. "V!"

"Adii," Vatrallyna exclaimed, rushing to embrace her comrade. "Where have you been?"

"I saw you rush off, and I followed your tracks. Zavoyko needs orders." Adii produced a radio and handed it to Vatrallyna. Static hissed for a moment before a voice broke through the interference.

"This is Zavoyko. Who is this?"

"This is Vatrallyna," she responded, "Barely, but still here."

"Thank God," the operator said. "What happened?"

"We managed to hold off another wave, but they're coming in force now," Vatrallyna explained. "Our retreat is uncoordinated. Stragglers will be slaughtered."

"Where will you go?" the operator asked.

"We're returning to base," Vatrallyna replied. "We expect a full assault within the next few days—2,000 men, maybe more. Call up reinforcements from Petropavlovsk. We either hold them at the Avacha River, or we lose this war. Make sure Romanova commits. We need her."

"Yes, Commander," the operator acknowledged. After returning the radio to Adii, Vatrallyna commended her. "You did well."

Klara admired Adii's tenacity. Her name, Koryak in origin, meant "fire."

Adii nodded. "I just wish I could have done more."

Vatrallyna placed a hand on her shoulder. "Stay a while. Rest. We'll leave at first light."

She prepared a pot of stew, and the six women huddled around the fire to eat. "This will warm you up," Vatrallyna said, ladling out the hearty broth. Klara cradled her hands

around it, letting the heat seep into her fingers. The soup was thick and rich, made from the bones of their fallen mounts.

“These hill tribes,” Adii murmured, shaking her head, “they fight like animals.”

Vatraliyna nodded in agreement. “All men are animals. They have no regard for human life.”

Klara’s brow furrowed. “But why do they keep attacking us? Why do they want our land?”

“It’s the nature of things,” Vatraliyna explained. “The strong will always try to take from the weak. They see us as a threat, just as we see them. We want their land, and they want ours.”

“But we’re not weak,” Klara protested.

“No, we’re not,” Vatraliyna agreed. “But we’re not strong enough to win this war. Not yet.”

“What can we do?” Adii asked.

“We can hope that Romanova will see reason,” Vatraliyna replied. “And we can hope that the reinforcements arrive in time. If not, then we die. But we die fighting.” She met each of their gazes before raising her bowl. “To the fallen.”

“To the fallen,” they echoed in unison and drank.

The women sipped their stew in silence until it was time to sleep. Klara, however, lay awake, her eyes fixed on the cave’s ceiling. The wind’s mournful howl filled her ears, its whispers tempting her. *Leave this place*, the wind seemed to say. *Leave this war. Come with me, and I will show you a better life.*

Klara shook her head, dispelling the intrusive thoughts. The battle and the fallen weighed on her mind. In all her fifteen years, she had never left Kamchatka. Though she questioned if there was anything left to see. Klara could only imagine the summers she had heard of in stories, with the sun warming green hills. Would she ever witness such sights? Would any of

them? Winter and war had dominated Klara's life for as long as she could remember.

She entertained thoughts of being with a man, of starting a family, thoughts she chastised herself for as heresy. She reminded herself that men were savages, animals, and nothing more.

Yet she remembered the nights when Vatrallyna would speak to the women by the fire, her voice low and steady, telling of a life before the fighting. She had described a distant city where the lights of countless lands still shone and dark forests had not yet crept in. A time when love still bloomed between men and women, and children lived to see their ninth birthday.

Klara let the visions of that long-lost world consume her as she drifted into sleep, the warmth of the fire and the murmur of voices fading into silence. When she opened her eyes, the world was white again. The wind howled through the trees, and snow pressed against her lashes. The cave, the fire, the women were gone. Only the cold remained. She rose, pulled her cloak tight, and stepped into the drifts. The Derge waited somewhere ahead, a ruin on the horizon. The same cold that had once nearly killed her wrapped around her again as the past and present became one.

CHAPTER TEN

VESNA

Something was building, low and steady, and Vesna wasn't sure she'd come back from it. The machines surrounded her with a slow, resonant hum that worked its way into her chest. Light shifted across the walls in fluid motion, the colors folding into one another like waves. She kept her hands on the armrests, resisting the urge to move, to break the rhythm that held the room together.

Nadya drifted through the glow, her fingers shaping quick commands that scattered the colors into new patterns. She glanced back with a measured calm. "Nervous?"

A chill ran through Vesna at the question. The lights seemed to draw closer, brushing her arms with static. Nerves she understood. This was different, something alive in the light that held her attention and wouldn't let go.

"Maybe. A little," she said.

Nadya's gaze lingered, calm and unblinking. "It's okay to be nervous," she said softly, her voice almost swallowed by the hum of the machines. "But more importantly, are you ready?"

"Got nothing better to do," Vesna muttered. Her gaze drifted to the wires spreading across the floor, twisting like veins through the concrete. Nadya had said the machine would reach through her memories, and already fragments were stirring at the edges of thought, faces half-forgotten, moments she'd tried to bury. The machinery droned in time with her breathing, steady and patient, as if waiting for permission to dig deeper. Nadya *called* it training, but the way she had said it left Vesna guessing what that really meant.

The sensors glided toward Vesna, their hum rising until she felt it against her skin. Nadya's voice broke through the noise. "Don't worry, she's friendly."

Managing a strained laugh, Vesna replied, "Friendly, huh? Feels more like I'm being prodded by an overeager GUPE drone."

Nadya chuckled. "You make it sound like an alien probe. Relax, Vesna. It's just sizing you up. Checking out your brain patterns, your DNA. Nothing scary."

"I get it, but... What if it finds something bad, you know?"

"Seriously, Vesna, we're not scanning for a secret evil gene. It's about understanding you better, not digging up skeletons. Think of it as setting the stage before the real work begins."

"No surprise supervillain origin story," Vesna mused. "Still feels like standing on the edge of the world though, looking down."

"Most people feel that way before the shift. Once it starts, the fear turns into focus."

The thought of backing out flickered and passed. She gave a quick nod before she could change her mind. The chair was cool under her palms, grounding her. "Alright. Let's do this. Show me what this thing can do."

Nadya gave a small nod of her own and reached for the controls. "Hold still."

A soft hiss came from beneath the chair as it adjusted, cradling Vesna's weight.

As the final notes of the calibration faded, the chamber seemed to shift around her. Lights pulsed in sync, the hum deepening until it filled her chest. The air carried a faint tremor, like something alive beneath the floor. She wasn't part of the system yet, but it felt as if it were reaching for her all

the same. The sound reminded her of a bike engine pushing too hard on slick pavement, steady at first, then slipping. Her gut told her to brace. Whatever was coming had already begun.

“It’s like a gateway,” Nadya said. “It connects what you know with what’s hidden underneath, helps the system read the language of your thoughts.”

Vesna tilted her head, letting a trace of sarcasm slip into her tone. “Well, if you promise mind-bending revelations, who knows if I’ll ever want to come back?”

Nadya smiled faintly. “Then let’s make sure it’s worth the trip.”

The machine gave a low chime. Lights along the floor flared to life, and the chair lurched forward on its track, smooth at first, then steady, carrying her toward an alcove at the far end of the chamber. Shadows shifted across the white walls, their shapes bending with each flicker of light. At the center of the alcove waited a sleek, obsidian headset resting on a pedestal, its surface catching the glow like polished glass.

“Once you put that on, the real work begins,” Nadya said. “The serum doesn’t activate on its own. It responds to what we call cellular command sentences, patterns formed in the language centers of your brain. In simple terms, your thoughts guide the rewrite. Your memories will keep you anchored and give you control over the process.”

Vesna’s eyes shifted to the headset. The sight of it drew her in, sharp and magnetic. Nadya’s words stayed with her, echoing in a way that felt almost physical. Rewriting her own code and using memories as anchors felt less like science and more like stepping into something alive, something waiting for her to cross the line.

Nadya gestured to the machine. “She’ll guide you through it. Trust her.”

There wasn't any trust left to give. The headset rested cool in her hands, the weight of it grounding her. She drew in a steady breath and lifted it into place. Light vanished at the edges of her vision, and the world slipped quietly into darkness.

△△△

The darkness pressed close, humming low beneath her skin. Then, almost imperceptibly, it began to change. Color seeped outward, sketching a world into being. What had been empty space gained weight and texture, the surface beneath her feet hardening into shifting layers of soil and stone. The void was painting itself, learning what it wanted to be.

She turned slowly. Luminous trees rose at the edge of sight, their branches threading together across the sky. The sight was beautiful in a way that made her uneasy, as if the world had been arranged with care not for wonder, but for control.

A faint drizzle began to fall between the trees, the drops catching light as they descended. Each droplet stretched, elongating midair until it became a shape, a silhouette, a movement. The rain gathered into bodies that began to turn and sway, their garments glimmering with pale color. Dancers. Their motions were measured, synchronized, as though the storm itself had learned choreography. She didn't know the ritual, but something inside her did.

Vesna tried to stay still, but her body moved anyway, muscles finding the rhythm on their own. Patterns rippled across the dancers' garments, spirals, waves, and creatures she recognized. Brown bears. Amur tigers. Snow sheep. The symbols changed as they circled her, flickering between meanings she couldn't grasp, half warning, half invitation.

Each step drew her in until thought slipped away and her body moved without consent. The dance consumed her, rhythm and breath merging into one. A distant chorus rose, pulling her toward its center. Then the melody twisted, harmony giving way to noise that surged and broke apart. The dancers shattered into light, and the world dropped out from under her. Asphalt scraped her palms. Cold air bit her skin.

She blinked through frost. Battle cries cut the last of the dream. Shapes resolved into steel towers clawing at a winter sky. Shadows stretched across the snow like scars. A familiar weight settled in her gut. She knew this battlefield.

Vesna looked down, her breath catching. The void of dreamlight hardened into the matte gleam of armor. She flexed her fingers, the movement triggering a faint metallic whisper as carbon fiber plates shifted with her. Black, light, and impenetrable. Her old lieutenant's uniform.

She turned her hands over, the faint frost catching on the polished edge of her gauntlet. The rifle rested against her shoulder, its familiar weight anchoring her to the moment. The weapon's surface was scarred and dull in places, each mark a story she wished she could forget. At her hip, a thin scarf fluttered in the icy wind, blue and red against the washed-out landscape, the emblem of the wolf barely visible through the frost.

The world around her flattened into a stark wash of whites and grays, a winter battlefield drawn in rough, uncertain strokes. Through the drifting smoke, the outline of a burning bus emerged, its metal frame groaning in the heat. In its shadow, an old woman crouched low, her head wrapped in a worn babushka still carrying the faint blush of yellow roses long faded. Firelight wavered across her face, tracing every line and hollow, making her look carved from the same ash that filled the air.

Zakharovna.

Vesna moved forward, her boots crunching against the frost-covered ground as she approached the burning bus. Ignoring the searing heat, she reached in and pulled the old woman out. Zakharovna's frail body trembled, her short white hair dusted with hail, while smoke curled from the charred edges of her slate winter jacket. The crimson fabric was singed, the edges blackened by flames. She clung to Vesna, her wide, terrified blue eyes reflecting the hellish blaze engulfing the street.

"Can you walk?" Vesna asked, tightening her grip as she scanned the area for movement, keeping Zakharovna steady in her arms.

Zakharovna gasped, nodding weakly. "Yes, I..."

Before she could finish, the ground shook. Another blast.

The force of the explosion rippled through the air, swallowing every other sound. As the ground trembled beneath her, Vesna's instincts took over. She snapped down her visor, her vision shifting to thermal signatures and target vectors. In one swift motion, she pulled the elderly woman down, shielding her as they hit the ground.

For a moment, silence held. Only the crackle of fire and Zakharovna's faint whimper cut through it. Vesna pushed herself upright, muscles trembling as she steadied her breath. The air was thick with smoke, flakes of ash and snow spinning together in the wind.

Through the haze, a figure stepped forward. Black-clad, steady, unhurried. Silver hair spilled over her shoulders, catching the firelight like molten wire. For an instant, Vesna thought she was seeing a ghost. Then the woman lifted her gaze, and the world seemed to narrow to that single look.

Vesna raised her rifle and fired. The bullets cut through the specter, dissolving into tendrils of smoke on contact. The air hissed in response, and her squad emerged from the haze, drawn by the sound of gunfire. Five old crones moved into position, gray hair spilling from ragged headscarves marked with blue and red insignia. Time had carved their faces, yet their stimulant-fed muscles still rippled with strength, and their eyes shone with the cold focus of seasoned warriors. They formed a wall around her, steady and unshaken in the chaos.

“Shift formation!” she ordered, cutting through the noise. “Cover Zakharovna!”

Vesna’s Black Wolves pivoted at once, moving to shield the trembling scientist as Vesna turned her sights back toward the advancing shadows.

But Vesna knew she couldn’t linger. The sight of the apparition still burned behind her eyes, wrong in a way she couldn’t name. Instinct pressed hard in her ribs. Something was still out there. She turned to her sergeant. “Keep her breathing. Fall back to cover if comms go dark,” she ordered.

The old woman gave a curt nod and pulled Zakharovna toward the burnt-out husk of a bus, shielding her behind the blackened frame. Vesna waited just long enough to see the others tighten the perimeter before breaking away. The ghost had moved east, and her visor still flickered with a trace of thermal residue cutting through the haze. She followed, rifle raised, moving quick through the wreckage. Snow kicked up behind her as the smoke thinned. The shimmer faded, but the pull didn’t. She slowed near a wide clearing, an intersection framed by the skeletal remains of charred buildings.

There she was. The woman in black. She stood in the drifting snow, green eyes calm in a way that didn’t belong

here. Her voice carried through the cold, smooth and level, each word cutting straight through Vesna's chest.

"You'll never be more than a weapon to them."

The tone wasn't cruel. It was worse than that. It was sure.

The battlefield fell silent, as if the world itself had paused to listen. The woman lifted a hand, her outline framed by the glow of the ruins.

"Join us."

A chill worked its way down Vesna's spine. The words lodged in her mind like shrapnel, sharp and unfinished. The figure's glow faltered, breaking apart into the wind until only cold air filled the space. The battlefield blurred around her, outlines fading, sound collapsing into a single metallic clang.

Snow gave way to sweat. Asphalt hardened into the cold tiles of another place. The echo of the blast became the slam of a locker door flung open in anger. The battlefield was gone, replaced by the stark walls of the bunker she had stormed out of three years ago.

Arkadya's voice cut through the air, each word packed with controlled fury. "You weren't with us when it mattered most, Vesna. What was so important that you couldn't be there when the line broke?" She leaned in, her breath a cold hiss. "Your hesitation, your distraction—it wasn't just a mistake. It cost lives, Vesna. Lives."

Vesna's words came unsteady, not from fear but from the stubborn edge of adrenaline still burning through her veins. "No, Commander, it wasn't like that," she said. "I did everything in my power. But there was someone else there, a woman in a black robe. She wasn't in our intel. She changed everything. We were outmaneuvered, outgunned, overrun."

Arkadya's expression hardened, disbelief tightening her jaw. The lines around her eyes deepened with every word

Vesna spoke. "Ghosts now, is it? Phantom women in black? Your distractions cost us dearly. The Wolves who stayed behind paid the price." She paused, the silence doing more damage than any shout. "The Syndicate won't overlook it. There'll be an inquiry, maybe a tribunal. And it'll drain what little we have left." She straightened, voice flat. "You're demoted. We can't afford mistakes like this. Not now."

Vesna straightened, jaw set. The weight of the battlefield, the guilt, the exhaustion gathered into a single spark of anger. "You can take your demotion and shove it, Commander. I'm done."

"You're done?" Arkadya said. "You think this is about rank? Walking away won't change what happened. The dead are still dead, and the threat to our operatives is still real. You want to quit? Fine. But don't pretend you're not leaving others to clean up your mess."

The weight of those words hit again, exactly as before, replaying with unnerving accuracy. The air vibrated, the sound of the confrontation fading into a low hum that didn't belong to memory. The room wavered, edges softening as the past bled into something else. The bunker tiles beneath her boots roughened into concrete. The air turned dry. Dawn pressed weakly through cracks in the walls, drawing long shadows over rusted shelves.

A draft slipped through, sharp with the machine oil. Vesna's pulse quickened as her instincts caught up, the weight of the mission pressing down before she could remember what it was.

Dunya's voice crackled softly through the earpiece, calm and steady. "*Coordinates locked, Vesna. You're on the right track.*"

The world snapped back before she could breathe. A metallic click cut through the dark. Figures emerged from the

haze, rifles lifting in unison. Instinct took over. The rest fell away.

She drew her sidearm in one smooth motion. The world narrowed to the pulse in her ears, each movement exact. Bullets sliced past her. In the space between heartbeats, she dove aside, body twisting mid-air as she fired. Three shots, three kills. Precise. Final.

Landing with a roll, she sprinted toward the group of comatose matriarchs, their slack faces lit by the glow of the rogue AI they were trying to awaken for control. Entranced by the chaos inside the terminal, they didn't react to the gunfire, their minds locked in digitized warfare. Vesna closed in fast. Metal bit skin as she clamped the cuffs tight. One of the women stirred, a muffled cry escaping before Vesna's knee drove her back down.

Dunya's voice crackled through the earpiece. *"Clean work, Vesna."*

For a rare moment, Vesna remembered what Dunya had meant to her. The memory came from one of their later runs. The warehouse where they met had been messier: Dunya chasing a rogue for its archive, Vesna ordered to wipe it. Then Vesna found the Yelagin capture log inside and gave Nikolai's daughter the clean copy. It showed that he had survived the shooting and entered University custody alive. Dunya never absolved Vesna for joining the hunt, and Vesna never asked her to. What followed had been built through work. Dunya stayed behind the screens, guiding her from safe rooms and relay hubs while Vesna bled in the field. Even with miles between them, Vesna could feel that steady hand. When she finally walked out of the Wolves and lost the barracks room with them, Dunya opened her apartment. With work drying up, Dunya began taking Syndicate jobs in person rather than guiding them from behind a screen. The change had startled

Vesna. There was grit beneath that quiet surface, all of it spent trying to keep them both alive.

The moment of reflection shattered as a sharp, piercing sound cut through the air. Vesna's world lurched, and a blinding white light tore through her thoughts, scattering them like fragments in a storm.

The sensation was unlike anything she had ever known. Every nerve seemed to spark at once, leaving her breathless and shaking. Then the light began to fade, colors thinning into drifting haze. She caught an echo of the celestial figures from the beginning of her descent, faint like an afterimage burned into her vision, before they dissolved into smoke and were gone.

She lingered in the stillness, suspended between awe and confusion. Then the hum of the machines crept back in. The restraints pressed into her arms. Cold air filled her lungs. Darkness settled over her vision, deep and absolute.

△△△

Vesna exhaled and lifted the headset, her fingers trembling. It slipped from her grasp and hit the lab floor with a sharp crack that echoed through the chamber.

Nadya bent to retrieve it, brushing a thumb across the visor before setting it gently on the console. "How was it?"

Vesna took deep, steadying breaths. Each one peeled away another layer of her old self. "You could say intense." She paused, letting the aftershock ripple through her mind. "My past—it's always been there, lurking in the shadows, haunting me."

She hesitated, the weight of the experience still heavy. "I've carried those memories like baggage. I questioned

everything—my choices, my actions, even who I was as a soldier. But what I didn't expect to see were the strengths I thought I'd lost."

Nadya tilted her head. "What kind of strengths?"

"That even in the face of failure, there's still a part of me that refuses to break. It was like looking into a mirror that reflected everything at once—not just the scars, but the resilience, the courage I had when things were at their worst."

Her voice steadied, conviction settling in. "I *am* a weapon. And it's time I accept that. I owe it to myself, and to the ones who've stood by me, to make things right."

Nadya's eyes softened. "So, you think you're ready for what comes next?"

"I won't waste this chance."

Nadya smiled faintly, pushing her glasses up the bridge of her nose. "Good. Just remember, even soldiers need to dance."

CHAPTER ELEVEN

YANA

Yana tossed back another shot of spudka, the authentic burn igniting her throat like wildfire. She was surprised they even served it here—real spudka meant someone, somewhere, was growing potatoes off the record—but she embraced it. It was her third in as many minutes, and the barroom's edges started to smudge and blend. But that didn't matter. She only craved the numbing embrace of oblivion. Cheap alcohol was better than cheap synth, she mused. After all, what's a fat liver to a fried brain? As she chased the burn with memories that haunted her, she couldn't help but wonder if she'd ever escape her vices and ghosts.

And as if on cue, one such ghost stirred. Mikhail, her trusty housekeeper, echoed through her cups. "*Yana, this isn't you,*" she could almost hear his old voice say, just as she'd listlessly lined up another dose of laced exo. That fine white powder always promised an escape. Hours would blur into days as she lost herself in *virtual*, drifting. Meals had become an afterthought.

Now, she wondered where Mikhail was, how he was doing. She could still picture him tapping his cane against the kitchen tile and calling it temporary whenever she offered to buy him a better one. Had he found work in one of the other gold suites among the towering marble spires of Almaznyy Gorizont? Or, she feared, was he enduring hardships, possibly mistreated by less compassionate matrons? In Gred's wealthiest district, the harsh reality was that reality wasn't kind to old men. Those like Mikhail, remnants of a time long forgotten, were almost always relegated to the most menial and thankless of servant roles. The thought twisted in her heart. *I promised to protect him, and I failed.* In a city where

the young were scarce, she knew Mikhail cherished the way she treated him, like a granddaughter. That realization only sharpened the sting.

They had all cared for her, she knew, but Mikhail and the others could never grasp the full weight of her struggles. They weren't the ones teetering on the brink of financial ruin, driven to strike a deal with the devil just to stay afloat. Though through their eyes, she thought, she might as well have become the devil herself, the way she had spiraled out of control in those last months; high-stakes gambling, each bet was a reckless attempt to recover her losses. She'd played hard on exo production futures, bidding contracts on the mines south of Asacha, a move as bold as it was foolish. The decision had been fueled by a tip-off from someone claiming to be a University insider, promising surefire returns. It turned out to be nothing more than bad intel, disastrous alpha. And when her fortunes plummeted, leaving her property vulnerable, it didn't take long for a Hive party functionary to swoop in. They seized everything she had for falling into arrears and distributed the profits to the poor.

Oh, I'm the devil, alright. Just last week, she told her loan shark that she'd help them swindle a wealthy Baroness. It was the only way she could clear her debts in time. Failure to comply meant they would expose her to the world, a threat that held even more weight than going broke. The Flock, one of her only ventures that hadn't gone bust, thrived on the mystery surrounding its creator. The thought of losing her sanctuary, her pride and joy in a sea of failures, was unbearable. She could endure infamy or poverty, but not both. *That* potent combination was enough to make her wish she could drown in her glass right now.

"Grigoreva," a voice called from behind her. "What have you learned about Grigoreva?"

Yana turned, the motion slow and unsteady. Behind her stood Dimitra, a freakishly tall and imposing figure with a severe expression. Their wispy pink hair and half-shaved head caught the neon glow flashing from the bottles of alcohol that lined the shelves behind the bar.

The Baraka Lounge was a high-end establishment, the kind of place where people went to see and be seen. If it wasn't winter, the outdoor patio would be teeming with old women smoking hookah and sipping overpriced cocktails, while the indoor café would be bustling with patrons enjoying cappuccinos and croissants. But it had been winter for a decade now, and only those with business to conduct frequented these kinds of establishments.

"I've learned that you're a heartless bitch," Yana slurred. "And I'm *going* to murder you."

She swung, a sloppy, desperate strike. Dimitra moved like a shadow, fingers clamping at her throat before she could draw a breath. Panic surged through her, sharp and animal.

Through the haze of alcohol and her dwindling air supply, Yana caught sight of the tattoos winding across Dimitra's forearms. The familiar swirls of black, swamp green, and pink ink sparked a deep, visceral loathing. Even through the blur, she couldn't miss the serpent glowing neon against the skin, coiled around a dagger, a twin to the mark on their neck. The sight confirmed what she already knew: Dimitra bore the notorious sigil of the Vory, along with the reputation of one of their deadliest assassins.

"You're going to help me get to Grigoreva. If you don't, I'll make sure your little secret is exposed. Do you understand?" Dimitra's grip tightened around Yana's neck, constricting her airway for another heartbeat before releasing her.

Yana gasped, her vision swimming as she fought to regain her breath. "I...understand."

“If you want to see your Flock again, you’ll do as I say. Now, tell me what you’ve learned.”

Yana’s head dropped; her shoulders slumped in defeat. She hadn’t discovered anything of value, except that she was ensnared in their scheme with no way out, and she’d have to do as they say or else her friends would pay.

“Come on. I know you’re holding back. You’ve always got something up your sleeve,” Dimitra taunted, signaling the bartender for two more drinks.

Yana glared at the glass as it slid toward her, anger knotting in her chest. The last thing she wanted was another drink from their hand, but refusing would only show weakness. She snatched it up and threw it back, the liquor burning hotter than before, searing her throat as if mocking her defiance. Even that fire couldn’t smother the dread coiling inside her. She knew she had to follow through, and the consequences would haunt her forever.

“Grigoreva has her...preferences,” Yana began. “She’s always had a soft spot for certain...exotic birds. Apparently, I fit that description just right.”

Dimitra’s expression remained stoic as they nodded. “You’re going to gain her trust and put her in a compromising position. Can you do that for me, Yana?”

“I can do better than that. I’ll make her fall in love with me. And then I’ll break her heart.”

Dimitra nodded, a hint of admiration in their eyes. Their voice deepened, rough, like a man’s. “I knew I made the right choice in recruiting you. Just remember to send anything you find directly to me, not Serafim, not anyone else.”

“Understood,” Yana replied, making sure her tone was curt but compliant. She met Dimitra’s eyes, ensuring her point was

clear. “Just hook me up right, no games. I’m not here for praise.”

“You’ll get what you need,” they said, then pushed a dark blue envelope across the table. “Now get to work.”

Yana seized the envelope and pulled out a single sheet of paper with a QR code printed across it. She held it up for Dimitra to see. “Is this all?”

They nodded. “That’s your advance. Scan the code at the terminal down the street to get paid. You’ll get the rest after you deliver. And make sure you drop a few *zats* on a better fit. You look like you’ve never fucked a day in your life.”

With that, they finished their drink and stood up. “I’ll be in touch.”

The door to the bar thudded shut, leaving Yana alone with the hum of chilled water circulating through the bar’s glycol system, the scent of stale beer, and the low murmur of shady conversations.

She felt as if she’d been blindsided by a freight train. What would Dunya say if she knew? *Would she ever speak to me again?*

Yana pulled out her phone and stared at the screen. There were no messages or missed calls, which only heightened her anxiety. She knew she had to tell Dunya the truth, but finding the words seemed impossible. She didn’t want to lose her best friend, but she couldn’t bear to deceive her either.

With a heavy heart, Yana tucked her phone away, slipped the envelope into her coat, and let the aftertaste of the liquor hang in her mouth.

She rose from her seat, steadying herself with a hand on the table’s edge, and then made her way out of the bar. It was time to begin this new chapter of her life as a con artist. And a whore.

Yana navigated the throng, her movements hindered by the pressing crowd. Street vendors vied for attention, their calls mingling with the sizzle and pop of skewers on open grills. The air was thick with the scent of kebabs, each spear glazed in tangy Yuzhno sauce, a specialty of wild berries and volcanic spices. She half-smiled at the thought; however tempting the aroma, she knew the only *real* meat in danger of sizzling was her own if she didn't do this job quickly.

Oktyabrya Prospekt pulsed as the lifeblood of Gred, its eight lanes teeming with vehicles and pedestrians. Even in the icy grip of winter, this vibrant artery refused to freeze. The expansive sidewalks, peppered with dogwood trees and caf  s, embraced the bustling cityscape. A blend of old Soviet architecture, reimagined with ostentatious Art Deco flair, juxtaposed against sleek glass-and-steel behemoths, their lofty spires piercing the cloud-veiled sky.

She halted before an imposing structure, its facade a marriage of marble and glass. Cyrillic letters spelled out Усадьба Григорьева, with the English translation, Grigoreva Estates, just beneath. The use of Cyrillic was more about status than communication these days. Yana paused, checking that the translations matched.

Nestled between two towering skyscrapers, a thirteen-story mansion loomed, its red-tiled roof standing out boldly against its monolithic neighbors. A high concrete wall concealed the estate's grounds from prying eyes.

Yana's entrance through the revolving door marked her passage from the chaos outside to the hushed, grand interior. *This shit really hits different*, she thought, her gaze lifting to the ornate atrium as she stepped in. Intertwining vines crept

across the marble walls, encircling grand chandeliers that hung like stars from a gilded ceiling, casting a warm, ambient glow over the lush greenery, an oasis of calm in the heart of the city's frenzy.

She inhaled to steady her nerves, feeling the cool, conditioned air fill her lungs. A security guard sat behind the desk. He acknowledged her presence as if it were a whisper, his attention welded to the screen.

With purpose in her stride, Yana crossed the opulent lobby, the sable fur carpet soft beneath her boots. The weave shimmered faintly in the light, gray and white threads folding together like ash and ice. She liked to imagine it told the story of the peninsula—its eruptions, its long winters—but she knew it was just another designer's flourish. As she neared the elevators, the bellhop's eyes narrowed with suspicion. She caught the look, understood it for what it was, and kept moving.

Yana glanced at the young man who held the elevator door open for her. Pity stirred in her chest, recognizing the invisible chains that bound him to servitude. His tense shoulders mirrored a resigned acceptance, and Yana's heart ached with the helplessness of their shared situation.

As she stepped out of the elevator, an exquisite silken runner stretched down the corridor, its pattern of entwined figures traced in fluid, suggestive red lines. It led her toward an imposing wooden door dominated by an ornate brass knocker. Before her fingers could touch the cold metal, the door groaned open to reveal a striking young woman.

Her raven hair cascaded like a silken waterfall down her back, and a sheer robe, hugging her thin frame, whispered secrets of her form beneath. The woman's voice carried a disinterested lilt as she inquired, "Yes?"

“I’m here to see Baroness Grigoreva,” Yana replied, her own voice steady despite the tension knotting her insides.

The woman’s gaze trailed over Yana, a pause perhaps longer than necessary. “Do you have an appointment?” she asked, her look conveying a quiet evaluation that made Yana self-conscious of her rushed and unkempt state.

“No, but it’s urgent,” Yana said, feigning desperation.

The woman heaved a sigh. “Fine. Come in.”

As Yana followed her through the penthouse, the click of high heels on polished marble reverberated through the opulent chamber. Lavish paintings adorned the walls, while a chandelier’s warm glow illuminated the space. Yana’s eyes couldn’t help but gravitate toward the resplendent chaise longue occupying a prominent corner of the room. The elegant contours of the furniture piece were accentuated by the plush velvet that enveloped it. Her gaze traced the elaborate gold-leaf patterns adorning the high backrest, scrolls that carved their way down into its arms. She noticed a line of lustrous gold buttons that seemed to amplify the chaise’s opulence. In that moment, she yearned to be cradled in its lavish embrace, allowing the world to dissolve into oblivion, but the young woman’s gesture toward a set of double doors redirected her focus. After knocking, she announced, “Baroness Grigoreva, there is a girl here to see you.”

“Let her in,” a gruff voice commanded from within.

Taking a deep breath, Yana stepped into a room that surpassed the splendor of the penthouse. An ornate four-poster bed dominated the space, and a stately desk faced a bay window that offered a breathtaking view of the bustling street below. Rich details filled the room, from the plush carpet underfoot to the intricate moldings along the walls, instilling a sense of wonder in Yana as she absorbed her surroundings.

In the study, the Baroness sat immersed in her work, the scratch of her pen on the pages of a leather-bound journal resonating in the air. Towering cabinets encircled her, their shelves laden with timeworn tomes and manuscripts.

The Baroness, a woman in her early sixties, wore her stern countenance like a mask, her sharp, hawk-like features framed by one long braid of ivory white hair. Her stature, draped in a tailored green double-breasted blazer dress, exuded an aura of inflexible authority, a force so formidable that Yana found herself shrinking in her wake.

“Please, have a seat,” the Baroness said, her voice icy and detached.

Yana obliged, sinking into the chair across from her. She fought to steady her trembling hands, unnerved by the older woman’s piercing, calculating gaze.

“I presume you require financial assistance,” Grigoreva stated, her forthright tone a testament to her notorious reputation.

“Yes. I was hoping you could help me.”

The Baroness arched an eyebrow. “What makes you think I’d be inclined to help you?”

“I thought you had a certain...taste.” Yana forced a smile.

Leaning back in her chair, the Baroness’s expression turned smug. “Impressive, my dear. You possess more intellect than I initially gave you credit for.”

Yana’s heart raced, but she endeavored to remain poised. She was treading on dangerous ground. “I could be an asset,” she proposed. “A pair of eyes and ears, just for you.”

“My dear,” Grigoreva countered, “I already employ a myriad of informants who ensure I’m apprised of every whisper and footstep in this city.”

“I can offer insights unavailable to anyone else, including your current network,” Yana asserted, her confidence increasing despite herself. “Naturally, I would expect compensation for such services.”

Grigoreva’s cool hazel eyes narrowed in contemplation. “What is it that you seek?” she said, a hint of exasperation in her tone.

“Enough to start a new life.”

The older woman chuckled. “Ambitious aspirations for a young woman.”

“I believe my worth matches them,” Yana said, holding the Baroness’s gaze firm. “And I suspect you recognize that as well.”

A glint of approval flickered in the Baroness’s eyes now. “It appears we may be on the cusp of an agreement.”

Relief washed over Yana, and she allowed a triumphant smile to grace her lips, but the Baroness’s demeanor shifted suddenly, taking on a sober, businesslike air. “Do share this information that eludes even my best agents.”

Yana’s brief relief evaporated as she realized there was no real escape from this scrutiny. She met the Baroness’s gaze. “I’m aware of your fondness for games and high stakes,” she ventured. “Gambling, specifically.”

The Baroness nodded. “Continue.”

Yana drew a small blue pouch from her pocket, untying the drawstring and allowing its contents to spill across the table. In the study’s dim light, the diamond-like powder shimmered. “Exo. Harvested from subterranean deposits south of Asacha. I presume you’re acquainted with its properties.”

The use of this undiluted drug was forbidden within Battalion circles, at least officially, but the Baroness appeared

unfazed. A gleeful smile played on her lips. “You do realize, Yana, that I could have you quarantined for this little display.”

She responded with a cheeky grin, “Sometimes, the risk is worth the reward, don’t you think?”

“A bold and potentially profitable endeavor. So, what’s your plan?” the Baroness pressed on, her voice betraying a growing spark of interest. Yana could see something like intrigue unfurling in her eyes. *She sees potential here, or maybe just smells the profit.*

“Most are aware that properly prepared exovegeta serves as an anti-aging serum, as demonstrated by Doctor Zakharovna. However, there’s more to it, a hidden facet known to very few.” Yana made sure her voice took on an air of mystery. “During my ill-fated venture into exo futures, a chance encounter with a University insider led me to a groundbreaking discovery. With specific modifications, exovegeta can induce an oxytocin surge, provoking sensations of love—just think of the games we can play with that kind of power.”

The Baroness’s wicked grin widened. “Do you have a specific game in mind?”

“I know a game that will make women fall hopelessly in love with you.”

Grigoreva scoffed. “What makes you think that interests me?”

With a slight smile, Yana replied, “Sure, they flock to you for your wealth and power, but let’s be real—they’re not here for you. With this little twist, though, you could have them genuinely falling at your feet, fawning over *you* and not just your title or bank account. In this world of high stakes and higher egos, wouldn’t it be a refreshing change to court genuine affection, rather than the usual calculated charm?”

The setup was deceptively straightforward. Yana would pinpoint Gred's newest young elite, fresh meat to its cutthroat political dance. By weaving herself into their lives, she'd gather both trust and intel. And as one of the few young faces in a city dominated by the truly ancient, Yana possessed a rare allure. It gave her an edge, a novelty that could open doors which remained closed to others. "The art, my dear Baroness, is in knowing how to exploit the rarity of one's own position, to become indispensable to those who think they have seen it all."

"Smart girl," the Baroness murmured. "You could sell a celibacy vow to a libertine—the way you spin risk into opportunity is truly captivating." The shift in her demeanor told Yana that her strategy had indeed struck a chord.

"I'll provide the bait with the help of my team; then you play the hero. They'll owe you, and we both understand the price of gratitude." While Dimitra's circle would claim their slice, Yana would pocket a generous cut, and Baroness Grigoreva could tap into a reservoir she'd long thirsted for: a parade of infatuated young confidants, possibly even someone to genuinely adore her.

"How about that Sorokin girl? Heard she was living it up at The Golden Slit—drinks, drugs, you name it. The way she's burning through her deceased father's wealth, it'll be gone before we know it."

Grigoreva's smile took on a mischievous edge. "Perfect," she cooed. "She's raw clay, waiting to be shaped. Delightfully tempting."

Yana stiffened slightly, sensing the unspoken comparison between herself and Serafim. Pushing the feeling aside, she continued, "The City Gala is tonight. I can introduce you there. She'll be looking for an exo mama soon, and who better than you? We'll get a measure of her, and then, with the help

of my contacts in the Vory, we'll make sure she feels the squeeze."

"Brilliant. While I sort out your entry, perhaps you should dress the part." She waved over her aide. "Natalya, guide Yana to my chambers. Let her ready herself."

Yana trailed Natalya up the grand staircase to the Baroness's opulent wardrobe chamber. The sight before her was breathtaking, with endless rows of designer shoes and dresses. "The Baroness boasts an impressive collection," Natalya remarked. "We only purchase organic clothing."

"Of course," Yana said, her eyes scanning the racks of garments, fine jewelry, and cosmetics. She had never witnessed such a flagrant exhibition of affluence in her life. In this era, organic meant one thing: the products were handcrafted on chitin plantations deep underground, where the fungus thrived. In those depths, gaunt men toiled, excavating soil and morels for nothing more than a fleeting glimpse of tit from a scantily clad overseer, and only when morale boosts aligned with their masters' profit margins. Repulsed by the notion of wearing clothes crafted by human hands, Yana recoiled. She had standards.

The walk-in extended the full length of the hidden room, and Yana observed Natalya's head bobbing in the distance as she navigated the racks. Eventually, she emerged with a sleek black dress, and Yana offered a distracted nod as she changed out of her attire.

Slipping into the dress, she studied her reflection in the mirror, appreciating the flawless fit. The V-neck collar dipped below her shoulders, accentuating her bust, while a daring slit on the left side ascended to her hip. The black silk hugged her form, its deep hue a dramatic canvas against her skin, as stark and striking against her complexion as the vivid contrast of birch bark against the night sky. A shiver ran through her

as she recalled Dunya's voice, *the trees were screaming*, a fragment from the nightmare her friend had relayed with a tremor in her words.

"You look like death," Natalya commented, a touch of admiration lacing what sounded like a compliment.

"Thank you," Yana responded, though she was uncertain whether to be flattered or insulted.

Natalya handed Yana a satin clutch, its gold rhinestone trim catching the light a little too eagerly. "The Baroness's jewelry is in the top drawer of her dressing table. You're welcome to choose whatever you prefer."

Yana pulled the drawer open, her breath catching at the sight inside. A collection of diamond necklaces, bracelets, and earrings lay neatly arranged, each piece gleaming under the soft light. She picked up a diamond choker and a set of matching tassel earrings, her fingers lingering over the intricate designs and shimmering gems. The fine chandelier-drop earrings drew her attention next, their delicate beauty almost overwhelming. As she turned them over in her hand, she glanced at Natalya—not so much seeking approval, but maybe offering her a moment of satisfaction for completing this tedious task.

"Worthy of a matron's bed chamber," Natalya said.

The comment unsettled her. She couldn't explain why it mattered now, but the idea of being used for sex if her plan failed made her uneasy. She didn't want to be manipulated into giving up her goods, even for profit. *This is my plan*, she reminded herself. *This is my story*.

Natalya uncapped a vial of perfume, spritzing it onto her wrists and inhaling the heady, musky aroma. She offered the vial to Yana, who hesitated before applying a modest amount to her own wrists. The perfume was intoxicating, with notes of vanilla and jasmine. It was the kind of scent that would

cling to your skin and leave a seductive trail that begged to be pursued. Yana suppressed a wave of nausea as the fragrance enveloped her, maintaining a courteous smile.

“This promises to be an entertaining evening,” Yana said through a forced grin.

“You’ve overlooked something.” Natalya gestured toward Yana’s hair. “The Baroness insists you wear it down.”

Yana blinked, only now registering the state of her hair—likely tangled or out of place. Natalya retrieved a spherical helmet from the drawer. It glinted under the dim light as she positioned it above Yana’s head. The helmet’s presence was strange, almost suffocating, but she straightened her posture to accommodate it, her muscles tensing beneath its weight.

The helmet hummed to life. Natalya’s slender fingers danced across the control panel, adjusting. Yana felt her hair shift, cascading down her back in gentle waves. The strands, once black, now gleamed a lustrous mahogany, interwoven with streaks of raspberry.

When Natalya removed the helmet, she ran her fingers through Yana’s transformed hair, watching it unfold in the reflection with clear admiration.

Then, reaching into another drawer, Natalya handed Yana a steel hairpin, its head bearing a rune set against a shield—the Battalion’s emblem. Yana took the hairpin and set it into her own hair, securing the newly styled waves.

Natalya’s eyes softened, and she nodded. “Only the finest for the Baroness’s esteemed guest.”

With a subtle gesture, Natalya motioned Yana out of the closet, and they stepped forward together. In the foyer, the Baroness awaited them, dressed to perfection in a green blazer and flared velvet pants. Her long braid was arranged in a strict bun, emphasizing the sharp angles of her face.

“Yana, you look ravishing,” she praised. “Thank you, Natalya. Ready yourself and join us soon.”

With a dismissive wave toward her assistant, the Baroness refocused on Yana. “Shall we proceed?” she asked, offering her arm with a flourish, ready to escort Yana in a promenade-like gesture.

Grigoreva guided Yana to the elevator and produced an iron key. Inserting it into a concealed slot, the elevator started its descent. After a few moments, it halted three floors below the lobby, its level unmarked on the panel. The doors parted, revealing a dim, stretched-out corridor. Grigoreva marched onward, her heels clacking against the concrete floor. Yana followed, struggling somewhat to maintain her poise in her new six-inch pumps.

At the hallway’s end, double doors required another key to unlock. Yana’s skin prickled with apprehension as she entered, her eyes scrutinizing the shadows for any indication of movement. A large pod, suspended from the ceiling in the center of the room, was enveloped by wires and tubes that snaked off in every direction, vanishing into darkness. Yana’s instinct was to flee, but the Baroness pressed a hand on her back forcing her forward.

“Where are we?” Yana asked.

“This is a private transportation network. It’s how we traverse the city unseen,” the Baroness explained, gently guiding Yana with a hand as they stepped into the pod together. Once inside, the pod began to move, slowly at first, then rapidly accelerating. Gripping the guardrails, Yana’s knuckles whitened as the tubes and wires attached to the vehicle whipped wildly around. Shutting her eyes, she tried to ignore the disorienting sight of sparks flying past as the pod raced through the tunnel network.

The pod jolted to a stop, forcing Yana to stand upright. Blinking to adjust to the sudden halt, she realized they had been transported to another, similar room. She quickly ran her hands through her hair, checking for any disarray. Her fingers brushed against the hairpin, still perfectly in place, and she exhaled softly, satisfied it had held.

“Don’t worry, Natalya made sure it was properly protected,” the Baroness reassured, holding the door open for Yana to exit the vehicle. “How’s that for a discreet ride?” she added, a trace of sarcasm in her tone.

Yana followed the Baroness down another hallway, leading to a different elevator. As they moved, Yana couldn’t shake the growing sense that she was being ferried around like a plaything, just another accessory in the Baroness’s grand walk-in. Could it get any worse?

The lift ascended smoothly, climbing thirty stories before stopping. When the doors opened, Yana’s jaw dropped at the sight before her.

The Baroness chuckled, a coy sparkle in her eyes, and gestured for Yana to follow.

The pulse of deep, rhythmic music thrummed through Yana, quieting the cacophony of her thoughts. Vaulted ceilings stretched above, their intricate frescoes dancing in the glow of crystal chandeliers, casting refracted light in a sea of blue. Around her, figures draped in silks and satins moved with practiced grace, their laughter and conversations blending into a harmonious backdrop. Opulence enveloped the space as marble pillars rose like titans, and lavish tapestries whispered tales of a bygone era. It was a realm where the scale of luxury exceeded even the grandest simulations Yana had ever staged, where reality blurred into something closer to fantasy.

Taking a moment to compose herself, Yana suddenly became aware of the stark simplicity of her plain black attire. *Quite the setup*, she thought. With renewed resolve, she quickened her pace to match the confident stride of her host, determined not to be outdone in presence or purpose.

Yet as she surveyed the room further, an unsettling feeling crept in. She felt exposed among the sea of masked faces. The Baroness caught her fleeting unease with a glance. “No need to hide your face here, my dear. No one will recognize you.”

Seen but unknown, another realm of her making. She had no need for encryption here. Reassured, Yana straightened, adopting an air of poise she didn’t quite feel but knew she could pull off.

Before she could get carried away, the Baroness, now only a few steps ahead, beckoned her over to a lively group. “Ah, Grigoreva,” a tall woman with a chiseled jawline greeted, icy eyes peering out from behind a porcelain mask depicting Morana, the goddess of death. “You’ve brought us a new...friend.”

The Baroness smiled and nodded. “Yes, this is Ms. Kuular. Yana, these are some of my closest colleagues.”

The women eyed Yana with interest, and anxiety surged within her. Forcing a smile, she said, “It’s nice to meet you all.”

The tallest woman extended her hand. “I am Baroness Rostova,” she said, her voice warm. As Yana shook her hand, a bit of tension eased.

She racked her brain for information on *this* Baroness. A highly influential member of the Hive and one of the city’s most powerful women, Rostova reputedly had a penchant for cold-blooded killing, though no one had ever substantiated the claims. “It’s a pleasure to meet you, Baroness,” Yana said,

striving for sincerity. Nervous and uncertain, she hoped her facade would suffice.

Beyond the small group, Yana marveled at the surroundings. The ballroom unfolded in a symphony of blues, from the lightest sky to the deepest navy. Chandeliers dangled high above, their crystals reflecting the cerulean light. She could see balconies and doorways lining the walls, indicating the space stretched three stories up. Round tables were scattered throughout, each boasting a unique centerpiece of flowers, statues, and artwork. It felt as though she had been whisked away to an ethereal underwater realm.

A live jazz band played on stage at the far end of the room, chiffon, cotton, and satin dresses swaying as the older women danced to the rhythm. Grigoreva led Yana to a table near the stage, where Natalya was already seated, her gown far more ostentatious than Yana's own simple black dress. Yana smiled and waved, but her mind was already turning. *I guess this is a kind of hazing, she thought. Or is it to mark me out as meat, property of the Baroness?*

As she glanced around, she noticed other young women in similarly crisp black dresses, confirming her suspicion. It was a subtle signal, an unspoken hierarchy she hadn't anticipated. *At least I can get drunk*, she thought as the waiter appeared, filling their glasses with wine before vanishing again, leaving the three women to the evening's entertainment.

"You're an enigma, Yana, a risk-taker," the Baroness mused, her eyes locking onto Yana's with an unspoken challenge. "Did you ever imagine you'd find yourself in a world like this? Now, tell me more—about yourself, your journey, your past." She took a slow, deliberate sip of her wine, waiting.

"Where exactly should we start?" Yana replied, nerves creeping in.

“Let’s start with your family. What can you tell me about them?”

Yana hesitated, her gaze dropping briefly. “It’s not all that glamorous. My mother was a dancer, but she passed away when I was young. I don’t have many memories of her. My father was from Tuva. They met in Yakutsk, where he worked as a miner after the Great War. He brought us here for work, but he died in the Strangers’ Revolt. He was an alcoholic.” She paused, the weight of it settling over her. “I suppose my life hasn’t strayed far from theirs.”

The Baroness took another sip, leaning back in her chair. “In my opinion, it was a mistake to keep the men in this city alive. I’d have my bellhops electrocuted if they ever dared to touch me or my girls. You’re not like the others, Yana. I can sense you’re different.”

“Is that a positive or negative development?”

“It’s difficult to say. But I believe it could be quite intriguing.”

As the opening strains of “Moon River” filled the air, the Baroness rose gracefully. “Would you care to dance?” Yana’s heart raced, but she found herself standing before she could reconsider.

The Baroness took her hand, leading her onto the dance floor. The familiar melody of *Breakfast at Tiffany’s* played in her ears, a favorite of Yana’s, though in this moment, she barely had time to savor it.

The Flock occasionally hosted old movie nights on a large digital screen in their common room. Yana would sit and watch while other patrons *ERPed* around her, lost in their virtual fantasies. As the familiar melody of “Moon River” played, she suddenly realized she preferred The Flock’s carefree, hedonistic atmosphere to the gala’s stilted opulence.

At least in the virtual world, people were honest about their hypocrisy.

The Baroness and Yana swirled in the dance, the former commanding each movement with ease. Yana, struggling to keep up, became increasingly aware of their bodies brushing against each other. The Baroness, a head taller, required Yana to tilt her head back just to meet her gaze. The heavy, sweet scent of Estée Lauder Youth Dew clung to the air—familiar from her work with sims, but Yana found it too archaic for her taste.

As the music faded, the Baroness led Yana back to their table, gesturing for her to sit. “Thank you for the dance. Now, let’s see if we can locate my daughter. I’m sure Serafim would be happy to join us.”

A jolt shot through Yana’s heart. “What do you mean?” The question slipped out before she could stop herself, and she regretted it the moment it was asked.

The Baroness chuckled, sipping her wine. “You’re a smart girl,” she purred. “But surely you know I’m only interested in one thing. And that thing is not love.” Her voice dripped with honeyed venom, her eyes glinting with something dark.

Yana shivered, the realization sinking in—she was in way over her head.

“Power,” the Baroness said. Yana could feel her gaze boring into her soul. Grigoreva leaned in closer, her wine-stained lips curling into a sly smile. “And I think you love it just as much as I do.”

Natalya let out a laugh—disenchanted, routine, the sound of someone who had seen this game played too many times. Yana’s pulse quickened, knowing she had stepped into something far more dangerous than she could have imagined.

It was then that Yana noticed a striking figure approaching their table. The girl, with curly black hair and a lean, pale face highlighted by the dim gala lights, moved with quiet confidence. Her hazel eyes gleamed with a mix of mischief and intelligence, and there was an elegance to her sharp, bony features—a curious blend of beauty and strength.

Taking a seat, the newcomer casually reached for a hard-boiled egg and some hors d'oeuvres before pouring herself a glass of wine. With a wink in Yana's direction, she introduced herself. "I'm Serafim. Pleasure to make your acquaintance."

Shock gripped Yana as she processed the woman's introduction, her instincts screaming in disbelief. *That can't be Serafim.*

CHAPTER TWELVE

ZAKHAROVNA

In the greasy light of a Vilnius night, they lingered beneath flickering neon, faces rippling in the reflected glow. Rain fell steady, never enough to wash the city clean. The scent of seared fat and cigarette haze hung heavy, settling deep into coats and hair. Zakharovna moved through it as if she belonged there. These streets had shaped her, every alley and doorway etched into memory. The mingled reek of meat and exhaust was the perfume of a city that never stopped feeding on itself.

Between lab sessions, she drifted to the brothels. They had become her second laboratory, a place to study the chemistry of desire and to test the limits of what could be altered in flesh and mind. At twenty-five, the work had already taken its toll. Synthetic nucleotides, forbidden compounds, and long nights spent reprogramming cellular pathways had left their traces in her skin and in the lifeless ends of her hair. The women there never judged her for it; they touched her like she was still whole. Each encounter offered something she could measure—heart rate, hormone shift, a momentary flicker of trust—before she lost herself in the pulse of other lives. The brothels offered both data and escape, one experiment feeding the other.

The days soon blurred together. The intoxication was part chemical, part human. She found solace in fleeting warmth, in strangers who asked no questions. It was during one of those evenings that Vair entered her orbit. Virginia Attrae, psychologist and madam to the city's elite, quickly became more than an acquaintance. She was the only person who seemed to understand Zakharovna's hunger for knowledge and ruin in equal measure.

Zakharovna could still picture the last of Vair's gatherings, a feverish carnival of sensation where pleasure shaded into exhaustion and curiosity into obsession. The memory stayed with her long after the night had ended, long after the faces had blurred together.

Seventy-three years ago, Zakharovna had been preparing to leave the artificial intelligence lab in Vilnius University's psychiatric department. The research was revolutionary, yet it felt small compared to the questions clawing at her mind. Academia had boundaries, and she had begun to see beyond them. Still, she needed its tools a little longer. The dissertation could wait.

She accepted a position as a research assistant, a compromise that kept her close to what mattered most: the machines, the data, and the human subjects. The lab had just begun the Artificial Dreams Project, developing full-body virtual reality suits for psychotherapy trials. Immersed in these simulations, she interacted with generated personalities, observing how they navigated pleasure, fear, and attachment in a world built entirely from code.

As her focus deepened, the thought of home slipped away, replaced by the pull of uncharted territory and the strange comfort she found at the edge of the known.

In the aftermath of the Great War, the landscape shifted, and the United Federation of Europe rose as a formidable power. Zakharovna's artificial intelligence lab, positioned at the forefront of post-war innovation, turned its efforts toward the psychological scars left behind. The most promising creation to emerge from that work was V.A.I.R.—Virtual Augmented Intimate Relations—a psychotherapist and virtual environment hostess conceived as a tribute to a departed friend.

Originally developed under NATO's military program, V.A.I.R. had been designed to ease the trauma of returning soldiers. Its ability to calm fractured minds was extraordinary, yet the University soon recognized the limits of such progress. Peace brought scarcity. The system's therapy protocols demanded immense computational resources, and as civilian networks strained under constant demand, there was little power left for indulgence.

The collapse began quietly. Data centers went dark, virtual worlds blinked out, and the global net fractured. Humanity survived, but its great digital architecture did not. Historians would call it the Divergence, an age of decline whose origins no one could fully explain. Amid the ruin, Zakharovna preserved what she could, sealing a fragment of V.A.I.R.'s code on a hidden drive, a relic from a vanished world she had helped create.

Her reverie was abruptly shattered by the sudden swell of music, signaling the start of the evening's burlesque show. The vibrant energy of the performance and the dazzling costumes jolted her back to *this* alternate life, the low hum of conversation and the occasional clinking of glasses filling the dimly lit cabaret.

The Baltic Squirrel was worn and seedy, yet it carried a certain sophistication. Dark walls enclosed the room, and the leather seats, creased and faded, seemed to hold time still. The vintage decor was intentional, a rarity in Gred, where the antique only reminded patrons of their own decay. Synth use was forbidden here by design, drawing a more urbane clientele, mostly Mormons. These were the remnants of the Strangers from Amerika who turned cloak once they realized that the tangible past paled in comparison to the synthetic realities of online congregations and sprawling virtual mega-churches. Evangelizing was easier there, with faith recast as performance and worship as spectacle. They could always

claim it was a LARP, but they were nothing like the misfits haunting low-rent servers such as The Flock or the Night Café, havens for pretentious, pseudo-intellectual vagrants.

Vair welcomed these poor spiritual souls warmly, eager for rich conversation without the distractions of illicit enhancements or the overstimulation of other VR spaces. And it was precisely this understated refuge that made the cabaret the perfect place to hide an old friend, one that would no doubt fall under the scrutiny of the Board.

Zakharovna perused the menu, the textured paper between her fingers reminding her of artisanal parchment. The elegant font brought back memories of a whimsical college course in advanced calligraphy she had once taken for extra credit. A faint scent of birch wood lingered in the air, recalling the Lithuanian forests that surrounded her old campus, a quiet testament to craftsmanship rarely appreciated in the digital age. Her eyes moved over the offerings: smoked salmon with dill foam, promising a taste of the Northern seas; Wagyu beef tartare with quail egg, described as a harmony of texture and taste; and a truffle risotto, said to capture the essence of autumn in a single bite.

The gourmet dishes danced before her eyes, each description more lavish than the last. Intricate molecular gastronomy and exotic, ethically sourced ingredients filled the menu, culminating in a signature blueberry daiquiri, praised for its unmatched freshness and depth of flavor.

At least these concoctions strive for historical accuracy, she mused, a rare feat when most modern cookbooks were penned by AI guessing at past palates. *Beetroot mousse and avocado sorbet, pfewy!* Finally, some dishes that echoed the true flavors of a world long gone. Still, she'd prefer the simplicity of classics like olive oil ice cream and shaved carrot salad. The thought was almost comforting, if not for the irritating

reminder that dairy and vegetables had been extinct for too long. With a sigh, she snapped the menu shut.

Looking down, she briefly admired the high-waisted trousers that clung to her figure, recalling how her first drink had spilled over them yet vanished without a trace. “Where’s the attendee?” she wondered, her attention momentarily diverted. Her thoughts drifted to her physique now. She wasn’t fat, but certainly not thin, and she wondered how it would feel to wear one of those orchard corsets like the women on stage, those relics of past elegance designed to sculpt any figure. She dismissed the idea as quickly as it came, reminding herself that her presence here was already degrading enough. She wasn’t here to indulge in fantasies; she was here for her friend.

A woman approached, stepping from the dim light like a temporal anomaly. The lines on her face were crafted, not earned, a simulation of fatigue that hinted at a life once lived. Beneath the practiced charm, Zakharovna recognized her at once.

Vair approached, her face bright with a genuine smile. “Anastasia!” she exclaimed. “I can’t believe it. It’s been so long. How are you?”

“I’m fine,” Zakharovna replied, embracing her friend, her fingers brushing against the soft fur of Vair’s coat, lingering a moment longer than she expected. The coat, adorned with a checkerboard pattern of white and blue fur, gleamed like a tapestry of winter mornings. “And you?”

“Never better. I have some excellent clients in mind for you tonight,” Vair said, stepping back.

She’s draped in the spoils of a royal hunt through a snow-dusted forest, and now she’ll help me navigate my own treacherous pursuit, Zakharovna thought.

Her hands traced the contours of Vair's classic bun, the platinum strands pulled tightly and flawlessly in place, framing her youthful face. "You look *good*," Zakharovna remarked, admiring how effortlessly elegant Vair appeared.

"Thanks to you and your team at the lab," Vair replied. "They really did me right. I don't know what I would have done without you."

"We helped each other. I wouldn't have had a project, and you'd still just be a memory in my head."

"Perhaps so, but now you can have me in the flesh, so to speak," Vair teased, a playful glint in her eye.

"How is he?" Zakharovna asked, her voice hesitant for a moment.

"Oh... Rotting away in void storage. Like always," she spat, her expression faltering. "But he *was* a fool, Ana. That chapter is over for me. You're my new beginning."

"Thank God for that," Zakharovna replied. "You're amazing, you know that?"

Vair raised an eyebrow, a quizzical look crossing her face.

"You really are," Zakharovna insisted.

Vair's gaze dropped to the floor, a blush creeping onto her cheeks, even visible in the dim light of the lounge.

"Oh God," Zakharovna laughed, delighting in Vair's embarrassment.

Vair's memories, conjured like an illusionist's sleight of hand, were nothing more than fabrications. Zakharovna knew this, but the guilt from the tragic end of their relationship still haunted her. She could still see the knife plunging into Vair's abdomen, the warm blood cascading down her arms. The fury on Vair's husband's face when he discovered her infidelity was seared into Zakharovna's mind, the rage in his eyes, the curl

of his lip as he shouted his curses. It was over, and Vair had moved on. Zakharovna only wished she could erase that memory for her as well.

Despite all that *virtual* could do to preserve relationships, *some experiences should not be recreated*, Zakharovna thought. As the two women locked eyes, Zakharovna saw nearly a century's worth of history in Vair's sapphire blue gaze, a history that might have been shared.

Vair sighed and sank into the plush cushions of the couch Zakharovna had reserved, positioned perfectly for a clear view of the cabaret's vibrant stage. Her hands smoothed over the fabric beside her, tracing idle circles as the low light caught the faint sheen of her rings. Zakharovna watched her movements in silence, unsure whether the gesture was nervous habit or quiet reproach.

"So here we are, back again," Vair said. "I never thought I'd see the day when someone like you wanted to talk to me. What could a nice girl like you want with a treacherous old bag like me anyway?"

Zakharovna chuckled, recognizing the familiar self-deprecation Vair wielded like a shield. She had always been that way, even at Vilnius University, steady, capable, and quietly defiant in the face of a world that tried to belittle her. The irony wasn't lost on Zakharovna. For all her brilliance, Vair still couldn't see that she had never needed anyone's forgiveness.

"Well, I'm starting up a new project, and I thought you'd be the perfect candidate. My very first public-facing Artificial Dreams Project. It would mean giving me access to your entire system. All your programming—everything that makes you who you are. You're an amazing piece of work, girl..."

Vair laughed heartily. "My programming? You do realize I was made with a degree of free will, don't you? There are parts

of me that don't belong to you, Doctor. Try and take those, and it won't be the only body in a bathtub somewhere," she teased with a mischievous wink.

Zakharovna exhaled deeply, choosing to steer the conversation. "That's...in the past now. The war is over, and the government's priorities have shifted. The Department needs new talent—we're developing something people can actually afford." Her feigned enthusiasm barely masked the guilt she carried for having denied Vair's existence for most of her life.

Circumstances had kept Zakharovna from logging into the Baltic Squirrel for what felt like decades. Her time had been consumed by research, lab responsibilities, and the daunting task of managing an entire city. Time had slipped through her fingers, compounded by the trauma and guilt over Vair's tragedy. Yet, as they reconnected, there was no resentment in Vair, only the seamless revival of a friendship that seemed to bridge effortlessly over the years of neglect, unspoken pain, and forgotten duties.

She said to Zakharovna, "You've given me so much. Through you, I've found a way to help others, even after they've left this world..."

"For you, Vair, I'd go to any length."

A profound sadness washed over Vair's face, pulling Zakharovna back to that fateful day.

"The day you found me," Vair began, her voice heavy, "was the darkest moment of my existence. My own husband, the man I trusted most, took not only my life but our unborn son's. That innocent child never had a chance to see the world because of one man's cruelty. Sometimes the memory returns in flashes—the pain, the fear, the silence afterward. There were moments when I thought it would break me completely."

Zakharovna shut her eyes and drew a deep breath, summoning all her concentration. The simulation unfolded in her mind, the haunting image of a woman and her son frozen in a moment of sheer terror, chaos swirling around them. She felt the raw fear, the desperate instinct of a mother trying to protect her child, a child her friend never had the chance to hold.

Zakharovna exhaled slowly and saw the dark cloud of memories, Vair's tragic end, the pain, love, and regret contained within that fleeting vision. She felt it all as if it were her own.

She imagined herself opening her hands, letting the cloud dissipate into the void, making space for the simulated trauma. The act was agonizing, as though tearing away a piece of her own soul. Yet she knew it was the only way to access the profound sorrow rooted in Vair's heart, a sorrow that, if transformed, could bring a flicker of joy to her isolated virtual life. *She demands it, Zakharovna thought. To truly merge, I must align every fiber of my being with her vast network.*

Vair's reaction was more pronounced than Zakharovna had expected. Her voice trembled, breaking through the stoic facade she usually maintained. "Were it not for my darlings here," she gestured to the walls of her lounge, adorned with photographs of sensual women in intimate poses, "those memories would've consumed me entirely. The thought of that little boy, the son I never had the privilege to know—it's haunted my dreams, every single night, for years." Her fingers tightened around the edge of the couch as she steadied herself, the tremor in her hands betraying the effort it took to maintain her composure. She used the sleeve of her fur coat to dab the tears away

In the next moment, Vair looked petrified, her image flickering, phasing in and out like a broken signal. "Ana... Ana... Why don't you...use my programming? Teach me...to

revive them. I could...for others as well... Yes, I...could... Imagine how...that would benefit...the research unit. All those years of...training gone, and the security risk—I... I shudder to think! No. Use my...programming—that's why you're here...isn't it?"

Zakharovna reached out, as if her touch could steady the erratic pulses of code. "Vair, breathe easy," she said softly. "You're pushing too hard... Focus now, and trust in our next steps together."

The lounge's manager, a man who introduced himself as Keskil, approached and asked if they wanted any drinks. Vair gave him a brisk shake of a *no*, gathering her composure with a deep breath. Zakharovna, feeling a spark of mischief, met Keskil's eyes. "I'll have a blueberry daiquiri—virgin, please."

"Of course," Keskil replied with a playful wink. "That's all we serve here. Comin' right up, boss."

As he left, a weight settled in Zakharovna's chest. Her voice wavered as her gaze fixed on the stage, bathed in a warm amber glow. "Vair, you see... A famine approaches. Our people, I fear, will wither and perish if we don't act swiftly."

"You can't truly believe such things—not anymore... The worst has passed, and for what we can't mend...there's no magic cure."

Zakharovna clenched her fists, her eyes glistening with unshed tears. "But what if there was? We gave them everything—a city built on the bones of progress, the defeat of death itself—and still they turned away. They ignored the lessons of the past, choosing instead to bow to that merciless illusion they call Freedom. And now, as scarcity tightens its grip and we stand on the edge, they plot in the shadows. They want chaos over order. Ruin over survival."

Zakharovna stood, tugging gently at the edges of her sleek, dark jacket, smoothing out the creases and reestablishing a

sense of control over her fleeting avatar. "I'll return shortly with the necessary equipment. In the meantime, rest. We'll need you at your sharpest. Can you do that for me?"

"Yes, rest seems wise," Vair replied. "For you, Ana, and for our impending task—I'll be ready."

The weight of their conversation lingered as Zakharovna approached the door. She reached for the handle just as Keskil appeared beside her, drink in hand. "Your blueberry daiquiri," he said with a grin.

She blinked, momentarily disoriented. For a second, she had forgotten she'd even ordered it. The sight of the glass pulled her back, its violet swirl catching the cabaret lights. The fervor she'd felt earlier ebbed, replaced by a strange calm. She turned toward Keskil. "The world is ever in flux, man," she said, her gaze drifting past him. She accepted the drink, feeling the chill of the glass. "Have you ever watched a star die?"

"I can't say I have, boss."

Her eyes met his, and for a fleeting moment, she sensed he grasped some part of her haunting conviction. "We are on the brink, Keskil. A famine approaches, yes, but also...a rebirth. A new beginning forged from the ashes of the old." She handed back the untouched drink. "I've lost my taste for this."

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

VESNA

It had been Nadya who first introduced her to Marfa and Gala. *"They're the best we have from the University's training program,"* Nadya had said flatly. Vesna had been skeptical at first, fresh from the rigorous combat sims. She was still adjusting to the fact that she would soon be leading flesh-and-blood soldiers again.

Nadya had assured her of their physical and mental readiness, listing their records as if they were gospel. Marfa, the detonations expert, could supposedly dismantle any explosive device. Gala, meanwhile, was a prodigy with the sniper rifle, her precision and calm under pressure evident in the University's files with sub-half-second target acquisition, perfect shot groupings, and no failed simulations on record.

In the days that followed their introduction, Vesna observed them through the unit's training rotations and readiness drills. She watched how they moved, how they adapted under pressure, how they seemed to anticipate one another's rhythm without a word. Their focus impressed her, their precision almost mechanical in its consistency. They weren't just soldiers; they were survivors, each carrying their own silent battles, their own reasons for joining this fight. In their eyes, Vesna saw reflections of her own resolve and her own unspoken vows, along with the faint echo of something colder, something shaped by the same machinery that had once forged her. They too were weapons, she knew.

Recalling the details from their dossiers, Vesna's mind wandered back to her earliest days with the Black Wolves. Those were the times of her undercover reconnaissance *against* the University, when she had skulked the hallowed, shadowed halls of academia, quick to expose scientific

ventures that dared to skirt the line of ethical decency. It was a perilous dance orchestrated under Gred's inaugural Matronage, beneath the severe purview of Yelena's Hive. Following those covert operations, Vesna transitioned to serve directly under the University itself, becoming one of the integral cogs in the machinery of the opening year of Zakharovna's dictum, all before bidding farewell to the force. *The life of a Black Wolf*. Through it all, she had never crossed paths with Marfa or Gala. Had they met as adversaries, the outcome would have been drastically different. *Lucky for me*, she thought.

Zakharovna had been the one to give the final nod, her approval sealing their fates together. "*They are under your command now, Vesna,*" she had said. "*Lead them well.*"

Vesna's gaze settled on Marfa. "I've heard about your work with explosives," she said. "They say you're the best at keeping things unpredictable. That's what we'll need tonight."

Marfa replied with a dry grin. "Good. I like giving people surprises."

"Good," Vesna said. "Your expertise will give us the upper hand, and the openings we need."

Vesna turned to Gala. "I've seen you shoot. You're calm when it counts. Keep it that way."

"In the field, a shot is worth a thousand words. I'll make sure every one counts," Gala said. Her wispy gray hair was pulled back into a practical ponytail, giving her a gentler demeanor. But the sharp focus in her eyes revealed her lethal nature. With a slender, compact build, she moved with a quiet readiness, her long arms poised.

"We move at nightfall," Vesna said. "Our target is the auxiliary data hub beneath the repurposed warehouse in Novaya Zarya. I mapped it once while with the Wolves; I know its access points and the escape routes in its ventilation grid.

It pulls intel from across the city and funnels it through a single choke point. That makes it valuable and makes it vulnerable.”

“The warehouse hides behind a cluster of legitimate tech shops. Solar panel assembly on the surface, server racks below. The cover limits heavy security on the ground but means they rely on drones and remote sensors for watch. Civilians move through those streets during the day and into the evening. We avoid bodies at all costs. If anything goes wrong, the fallout will be worse than the score we hope to settle.”

“Marfa, you’ll set the charge on the door and prepare the diversion. Gala, you’ll take overwatch and cover our entry. Pick your shots only when you must. I’ll go in first, reveal the charge and breach the access, then pull the node while you two hold the perimeter. If the drones flicker, I’ll spoof the feed. We get in, we get out. No improvisation unless the plan dies first.”

They clustered around the briefing table. The hardlight map rose beneath Vesna’s hand, contours and routes glowing in the dim. She looked at them both, then at Arkadya’s name on the display. “We get in, we pull the node, and we force Arkadya into the open. We do this clean. Make it count.”

△△△

The descent into the city was silent, shadow-laden. Vesna led the way, her movements fluid, melding with the night. The city’s skyline formed a jagged silhouette against the starless sky, its buildings like slumbering giants. Her senses sharpened, attuned to every sound and shift in the wind. The tang of ozone and concrete filled the air—a scent oddly

comforting, so unlike the sterile atmosphere of the facilities and briefing rooms she'd been confined to in recent weeks.

They moved with deliberate caution through the illuminated streets of Gred's affluent sector. Among the throngs of tech workers and researchers, they blended in carefully. Nadya had briefed Vesna on the high-tech surveillance here, drones scanning for faces of former Black Wolves and known University operatives. To counter this, Vesna had her team apply face paint: a mottled mix of pinks and blacks, artfully arranged in angular patterns to confuse the algorithms.

Vesna was keenly aware of how conspicuous they might seem to a casual observer. Their scarves were wrapped snugly around their necks, with thick, durable *platoks* atop their heads, dyed in pale yellow to blend into the muted urban lights. Keeping her head lowered, she scanned the ground, occasionally glancing up for passersby and potential onlookers.

The recent defection of many Black Wolves in this district to the interim Chair's authority was clear as Vesna moved among the crowds. Former party officials and lab technicians who had once held sway under Zakharovna's rule were now just faces in the throng. The yellow rose on an open book, embroidered on their uniforms, had faded along with their influence. Resigned expressions and reluctant compliance painted the picture of a regime in transition.

Vesna noticed changes in their activities that spoke volumes about Yelena's new ordinances. Lab technicians, who once walked freely, now carried supplies in secret, their cautious behavior instantly recognizable to her trained eye. They hunched over unwieldy packages, likely containing sensitive research materials, shuffling them under furtive glances and quick steps. The bustling streets hinted at a newly imposed curfew; the usual nighttime buzz was subdued

as people hurried home before the mandated hour. This wasn't just administrative—it was a strategic tightening of control under the guise of maintaining order.

Would it have been better to come earlier in the day? Vesna wondered briefly. But she dismissed the thought; the daytime would have brought its own challenges, too many people, too much exposure. Night, despite its risks, was still their best ally.

It's audacious of Yelena. She was only meant to oversee the transition, not impose her will like a tyrant. The Battalion's rise to power was supposed to be a fresh start, not a continuation of old tyrannies under a new guise. How alarmingly far had Yelena's clasp reached within their ranks? For them to yield control, even momentarily, to Yelena as a safety net, especially with their claim to power mere weeks away, was no trifling matter. *What has the Battalion so damn spooked?*

Realizing they were nearing their destination, Vesna knew they needed to veer off the main thoroughfares. The command center lay beyond the plaza, accessible only through a labyrinth of less conspicuous pathways.

As they progressed, the alleyways narrowed, and the shadows around them thickened. The walls of the buildings loomed high above, creating a claustrophobic corridor that muffled the sounds of the city behind them. Here, in these confined spaces, every footstep echoed, every breath seemed louder.

The mechanical hum of a patrolling drone pierced the night air, and Vesna's hand shot up, signaling Marfa and Gala to stop. Her heart thumped against her ribs, adrenaline sharpening her focus. Even with their precautions, the drone's thermal imaging and sophisticated sensors could compromise them.

Quickly, Vesna motioned for cover. They pressed against a shadowed wall, their painted faces blending into the darkness. In a hushed tone, she relayed her plan through her earpiece.

Marfa pulled a compact signal jammer from her pack. With a deft flick of her finger, she activated the device. Almost immediately, the drone's steady hum stuttered, its smooth flight turning erratic. The lights on its underbelly flickered briefly, betraying its momentary confusion.

Seizing the window of opportunity, Vesna darted across the street. Marfa and Gala followed in perfect sync behind.

As they reached the opposite side, the drone recovered, resuming its patrol over the area they had just vacated. Vesna exhaled silently, a momentary relief washing over her. They pressed forward, blending into the shadows as they closed in on their target.

The kebab shop's bustling exterior blended into the urban landscape, hiding something far more dangerous. Behind its weathered sign and faded awnings was a large, vertically sliding garage door—a covert gateway to the command post. Vesna signaled Marfa and Gala, the command clear without a word. Marfa approached the discreet service entrance and placed small charges around the perimeter. Meanwhile, Gala positioned herself on a hanging staircase, with a clear line of sight to the entrance.

Vesna crouched near the main gate, her titanium alloy pistol resting in her hand with its familiar weight—light yet formidable, like an old friend. It was as if the years since her lieutenant days had melted away.

Marfa detonated the explosives.

With no sound or smoke, the air around the command post's entrance subtly shuddered. The door remained intact, but the pressure wave had done its job.

Almost immediately, a few guards stumbled out from the door, disoriented and visibly sick. They clutched their heads and stomachs, some doubling over. They were completely unprepared for this kind of silent, insidious assault.

Each shot from Gala's rifle was precise, incapacitating the staggered guards before they could recover or raise an alarm.

Vesna burst in, immediately taking in the vastness of the room. It sprawled out before her, lined with high-tech equipment and screens that cast a cold, artificial glow. A handful of guards in sleek black armor, gunblades and rifles, stood scattered throughout. They reacted quickly to Vesna's entrance, their experienced stances betraying their identity as Black Wolves.

Technicians huddled near their consoles, frozen in fear. They looked on, their fingers hesitating over keyboards and screens as the room erupted into action.

Vesna faced the closest guard, unleashing a rapid burst of close-range gunfire. The guard ducked behind a pillar, swinging her sword in retaliation. In a split second, Vesna's years of training took over, her reflexes snapping into action. She dodged the attack with precision, closing the gap between them. With a swift, calculated move, she disarmed her opponent and delivered a solid punch, knocking her unconscious.

Meanwhile, Marfa and Gala secured the door behind them and plunged into the chaos, facing the reinforcements. The room filled with grunts, clashing metal, and the occasional weapon discharge. Within minutes, the guards were subdued, their weapons clattering to the floor. Vesna quickly scanned the room, confirming there were no further threats.

Marfa moved swiftly to one of the terminals where a technician sat, frozen in shock. She shoved him aside, and the gaunt man stumbled, his chair clattering to the ground,

dwarfed by Marfa's imposing frame. Her shadow loomed over the console as she took his place, fingers flying over the keyboard.

"Sorry, pal, it's a hostile takeover," she grunted in her gruff voice.

Gala maintained a vigilant watch at the entrance door.

Vesna sifted through a pile of documents on a nearby desk. Years of police work guided her as she scanned for clues. Amid the scattered papers and devices, something caught her eye—a small, unassuming lockbox.

She beckoned one of the technicians, who was still in a daze. "Open this," she commanded. The technician fumbled, hands trembling, but managed to retrieve a small key from a hidden drawer in the desk.

As the lock clicked open, Vesna peered inside the box. There it was, nestled among various items: a slip of paper with a sequence of words that immediately struck her as a seed phrase. Recognizing its significance, she read out the words in a steady, urgent tone, "Sunrise, echoes, labyrinth, frost, voyage, crown, dragonfly, mosaic, tempest, anchor..." she leaned close, the last two words a hushed breath in Marfa's ear.

Marfa's fingers paused momentarily as she deciphered the map on her terminal. "This seed phrase here," she started, "it's part of some zero-knowledge proof system. Smart, really—gives you Arkadya's location, but keeps the tracker's ID off the radar. In our line of work, even top brass wouldn't risk leaving a data trail when tracking their own commander. Just the way the game is played, you know?"

"So, we can track her without them knowing we have the access?" Vesna said.

“Exactly,” Marfa said. “It’s all about verification without disclosure. We have the location, but the system doesn’t reveal how it knows, or even that we asked. We can keep tabs on Arkadya, and they won’t have a clue.”

“Then let’s make sure we keep that advantage,” Vesna said.

Marfa returned to the keyboard, her hands moving with renewed purpose. “Best I reset the keys, make it look like a routine security update.” As the screen flashed its final confirmation, she connected a small device to the terminal, transferring the critical data they’d uncovered.

“Good work. Let’s move out before they catch on,” Vesna said.

Marfa hesitated. “There’s just one problem. Witnesses.” The remaining technicians, frail men enslaved to run the command center’s computers, huddled in fear nearby.

Vesna felt a cold resolve settle over her. *We can’t leave loose ends, but these are just men, caught in a war they didn’t choose.*

“Round them up, Marfa,” Vesna ordered.

As Marfa herded the technicians together, Vesna drew her pistol. The men looked up at her, their eyes wide with fear and resignation.

Each pull of the trigger was decisive, a quiet apology whispered with each recoil of her weapon.

She turned to the last witness. As soon as she squeezed the trigger, a throbbing pain erupted in her head. Her aim faltered, the bullet veering off course. It struck the man not where she aimed, but in his throat. His face twisted in a grimace of shock. *Damnit, the withdrawals. I need to dose up,* she thought, cursing the distraction.

The man collapsed, hands flailing at the ruin of his throat, his breath wheezing through the wreckage. With an excruciating effort, a strained and bubbly hiss escaped him, “Y-y...j-just...like... A-Ark...cold...b-b...”

Though the words were mangled and barely recognizable, they hit Vesna with the intensity of a spoken curse. “*You’re just like Arkadya, you cold bitch.*”

For a heartbeat in time, Vesna locked eyes with her target, an unvoiced exchange of their shared mortal condition and the unpredictable agony life can unleash. She realigned her aim, determined to end his torment.

The sharp scent of gun smoke reached her nostrils, mingling with the room’s charged air as she followed up with, “Encryption complete.”

An urgent beep from the terminal snapped them back to reality. Marfa’s eyes widened. “Reinforcements are coming. We need to move, now.”

Gala led the way. Just before they reached the back of the building, she turned to Vesna and whispered, “There’s a hidden exit here, mapped out in my last recon. Follow closely.”

The three of them navigated to the concealed door that lay ingeniously hidden behind a movable wall panel. Gala deftly slid the panel aside, revealing a narrow passageway. The team moved through it quickly, emerging into the cool night air. They found themselves in a secluded alley, away from prying eyes. The city’s maze of streets offered them the perfect cover. They vanished into the shadows, the crucial intelligence now securely in their possession.

As Vesna stepped back into the base, the familiar starkness of the room settled around her. Their shared space, doubling as kitchen and meeting area, offered a brief pause from the mission's relentless pace. On the kitchen island sat a loaf of bread, some cheese, and a bowl of apples. Most would call it luxury in a city surviving on mealworm paste, but to Vesna, it was just fuel. After years away from the force, she'd already adjusted to the basic proteins and fibers that kept her going.

The walls were sparse but held a few paintings, each telling its own quiet story in the room's dim lighting. Vesna's gaze lingered on one—a barren landscape, all gray lines and muted browns, capturing a deep sense of desolation. Another showed a stormy sea, the brush strokes turbulent, as if trying to trap the chaos of the waves.

Turning her attention back to Marfa, Vesna watched as she casually enjoyed a cigar while activating the hardlight projection system. The room shifted as the device hummed to life, a three-dimensional map materializing above the table. Vesna leaned in, her focus locking onto the dynamic display of Arkadya's movements. The hologram flickered, revealing terrain and troop placements in real-time.

As Vesna watched the shifting images, her mind pieced together their next move. "We have the upper hand, but it won't last. Once they realize the breach, they'll lock down Arkadya and redo the encryption ceremony. She'll be out of reach. We need to strike before they even suspect anything. We've got days—maybe less—before they change the protocols and shut us out completely."

Marfa's fingers paused as she focused on the map, her eyes narrowing at a set of coordinates. "Here," she said, pointing to a coastal hill. "Arkadya's scheduled to return to Fort Ivan in two days." The map showed the fort's strategic position, perched on an elevation with a sweeping view of the area. Though a formidable stronghold, the dense foliage around its

base offered potential stealth routes. Its antiquated structures and lack of modern fortifications suggested it was more of a prestige symbol than a fortress ready for urban warfare.

Gala pinpointed potential ambush locations, her finger tracing lines and angles that only a sniper's eye could see. "Canopied foliage here," she said, pointing to a dense patch of green. "And these bluffs," she noted a craggy rise that matched the fort's entrance in elevation, "offer ideal concealment and a clear line of sight."

"We can place charges at these junctures to cause confusion and scatter their forces. You see this section?" Marfa said, her finger landing on a precarious stretch of cliff. "It's a tough climb, even for our best. But a successful strike here could give us direct, unhindered access to the heart of the courtyard, right where the Wolves are anticipated to assemble for their congregation."

Gala raised her gaze, asking, "Can't we use drones for this?"

"Hardly any electronic devices operate within the vicinity of Fort Ivan. Drone assistance is out of the question," Vesna said.

"I can provide cover for the infiltration with a sniper crew, but our engagement ends there," she said. "After the breach, we're pretty much sidelined. Elevation-wise, there's nothing close that ascends above Fort Ivan."

Vesna absorbed their input, quickly evaluating the logistics and risks. "We'll need more firepower. Zakharovna will supply the provisions. I'll coordinate with the University and bring in additional marines and sharpshooters. But don't forget—the Black Wolves are traditionalists. They'll likely counter our long-range tactics, maybe neutralize our weapons or set up energy barriers. They favor hand-to-hand combat. A few hits of exo, and they turn into berserkers. We need to be ready to counter-jam their shields, and if that fails, I hope the

gunblade intel I provided *Calibrations* will get the brigade ready for hand-to-hand.”

Later, alone in her quarters, Vesna took a moment to herself. The room was sparse, a blank canvas that absorbed the weight of past decisions and strategies. In the sterile space, she imagined the countless commanders and enforcers who had once occupied it.

Vesna reflected on her own path. Her mind wandered through the decisions she had made, the crossroads she had navigated. She heard the cold, decisive sound of her gunshots, the finality in each pull of the trigger. The faces of those poor technicians, caught in a web of circumstance and duty, flashed before her. The memory of their expressions lingered, unsettling her. Each bullet she had fired into those men, each an irreversible act, now blasted in the quiet of her quarters, blending with the room’s unseen history of untold conflicts.

Was there another way? As she replayed the decision in her mind, she understood the brutal necessity of it—it was them or the mission’s success. A handful of slaves, or the Hive’s dominion over all the city. She was a soldier, conditioned to make tough calls, but the moral burden of such choices never lessened. *Those scientists didn’t have a choice either*, she thought grimly. Sometimes, the mission seemed more alive than the people they were supposed to protect. *This is the cost*, she realized. *The cost of fighting in the shadows, of making choices that others can’t, or won’t.*

This mission had Arkadya waiting at the end of it, which made the planning harder to keep impersonal. Vesna knew how Arkadya fought because she had spent years beside her when roads went bad. She knew the pause before an order, the way Arkadya checked prisoners after everyone else wanted to leave, and how she watched a crowd when its gratitude started sounding too much like fear. Vesna had admired those habits once. Later she learned how satisfying it was to make

a room move before Arkadya finished deciding whether it should. Now she was going after the woman who had taught her where the line was.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

MARIA

Maria breathed into the frigid air as she surveyed the warehouse. The outskirts of Gred had always whispered of a forlorn past, but here in the shadows of this dilapidated structure, the whispers roared. This was a place forgotten by time, remembered only by those who danced with danger.

Tatyana's instructions had been clear, a stark command that cut through the haze of Maria's thoughts. *"Trust in the skills that have kept you alive. Serafim is a tool; use her."*

Maria replayed Tatyana's warning in her mind as she stepped carefully over the scattered debris on the warehouse floor. Her previous ventures with Serafim had always unfolded in the cryptic realms of cyberspace, their identities shrouded, their collaboration a carefully orchestrated dance in the shadows of encryption. With Dunya, there had been a predictable rhythm, an established familiarity in their exchanges. But Serafim was different; she was an enigma, her methods, and motives less clear.

The tension curled inside Maria like a tight spring. Every step she took here was a conversation with the ghosts of her failed exploits, the memories pulsing in her cybernetic veins. Yet, with each heartbeat, the hunger for redemption forged her resolve. She couldn't afford to drown in the quicksand of her past—too much was at stake.

A silhouette emerged from the gloom, its edges blurred by the uncertain light. *Serafim*. Even as she stood still, there was an undeniable presence about her, like a storm cloud promising havoc.

Maria caught Serafim's gaze, feeling a shiver as she peered into the depth of her eyes—a tumultuous mix of secrets and

skills that both intrigued and frightened her. But in that silent exchange, she also sensed a shared truth; they were *both* anomalies in this place, predators lurking in the ruins.

“Maria,” Serafim’s voice was a blade, sharp and cold. “You’re on time. I appreciate that in a partner.”

Maria’s nod was curt. “Let’s not mistake necessity for preference.”

The warehouse creaked. Together, they approached the dormant computer terminal that was their gateway to *Oblivion Spire*.

“Ready?” Serafim said.

“Ready as I’ll ever be. I hope you understand what’s at stake.”

A ghost of a smile flitted across Serafim’s lips. “More than you can fathom.”

Maria felt the weight of every dive she’d ever taken, the burden of every ghost that haunted her. Yet, here she was, about to dive again. “I do it for freedom. Not for the thrill.”

“We both seek liberation, in our own ways,” Serafim said, extending her hand towards the terminal. “Shall we?”

Maria took a breath that felt like her first or her last and stepped forward.

The terminal before them was an anachronism, a relic in the rubble, with keys worn from a thousand entries and a screen that flickered like a fading dream. Yet, this archaic device was their indispensable conduit, the portal to an audacious mission that hinged on the precarious balance of infiltration and deception.

The Spire was no mere data fortress; it was the keystone to Zakharovna’s primary gateway server. Conquering it would grant them a commanding view over the network’s entire

architecture—a place where they could map, monitor, and master the flow of digital lifeblood coursing through the babachain—a view key to peer beyond the immutable network of public data available to everyday citizens, and a new path to furthering their descent into Zakharovna's secure layers.

Maria's eyes scanned the terminal, her mind racing back to the mission briefing. She recalled being told about the immutable nature of nodes within the Syndicate's network—they could be created, but never truly destroyed. This terminal was a perfect example: a forgotten piece in Zakharovna's empire. Maria understood the Syndicate's cunning in leaving it unguarded; they had left it to be overtaken by vines and the elements, a deceptive tactic to underplay its enduring significance.

She watched as Serafim's fingers danced across the keys. Maria, meanwhile, retrieved two cables from her pack, the silvery wires glinting like lifelines in the somber light. She connected one to the terminal, the other poised to interface with her own neural port—a ritual she'd performed countless times, yet never without the whisper of apprehension tickling the back of her skull. The second cable was for Serafim's headset. Handing it to her, she watched as she connected it with a familiar click.

"Once we're in, we move fast. No distractions," Maria said.

"Speed is an ally," Serafim said, "but sometimes, the urgency of our steps can blind us to the subtleties of the journey. The Spire is more than just elaborate software—it's a crucible of the soul. In its halls, your deepest truths and shadows will dance together, indistinguishable."

Maria couldn't resist a slight smirk. "And here I was thinking we were just going to hack a database, not embark on a spiritual odyssey."

“Every mission has its layers, Maria. But don’t worry, I’ll save my philosophizing for after we’ve won.”

“I got your back if you got mine,” Maria said.

“I can do one better. I can watch your mind.”

With no more words left to spare, they engaged their interface equipment. Maria felt the familiar prickling sensation as her consciousness prepared to leap.

The terminal beeped its readiness. Her pulse quickened—then, with a deep breath that seemed to draw the cold of the warehouse into her lungs, she nodded to Serafim.

It’s time to dive.

ΔΔΔ

As Maria’s mind meshed with the virtual realm, the jagged unreality of the Oblivion Spire loomed before her. It felt like stepping into someone else’s fractured dream—jagged stone and code blending into a tower that soared against a twilight sky, as though someone had tried to paint with the remnants of digital memories. The hyper-real world made Maria forget the drab mundanity of the warehouse they had left behind and re-entered in *virtual*.

As she stepped onto the grounds of the Spire, the solidity beneath her feet belied the surreal nature of their mission. She shivered slightly, the air carrying the unmistakable chill of the city’s outskirts in the *real*. She noticed the peculiar acoustics of the place; their footsteps seemed to warp and echo, creating a distorted sound. It felt to Maria as if the Spire itself was listening, its walls whispering back in reverberating echoes, like a language formed from the remnants of a thousand lost conversations.

“We enter as fragments of ourselves,” Serafim said. “Remember, this tower doesn’t just challenge intruders; it learns from them.”

Maria glanced at Serafim, finding a flicker of curiosity in her companion’s expression. For a moment, she wondered if Serafim saw this not just as an infiltration but as an experiment.

As they approached the entrance, the vast archway captured Maria’s attention. It seemed almost alive, the ivy intertwining with the stonework in a slow, hypnotic rhythm that gave the illusion of breathing. To her, it appeared less like a doorway and more like an enormous mouth, poised and ready to consume all who dared to enter.

Her eyes drifted across the room’s expanse, the sheen on the walls drawing her in a slow, meandering sweep of the glossy black surfaces. The dim glow from the Spire’s core cast elongated shadows that stretched across the floor, softening the edges where darkness met light. Her ears, attuned to the silence, picked up the faintest disruption—a whisper of movement, or perhaps fabric against the cool, polished stone.

A chill traced up her spine as her eyes adjusted, began to discern forms within the shadows. There was a presence, she realized, something or someone anchoring the weight of the room. The sense of another’s breath seemed to mingle with the sterile air.

Serafim remained close, a reassuring presence, her spectral image a mere wisp against the somber backdrop. Maria’s focus narrowed, the periphery fading, as the figure slowly came into view.

A man. As out of place as those old images in the Arkyv of Earth’s single moon, a piece of history discordant with the known reality of its twin.

Leaning on a cane, his long brown trench coat swept the polished floor with each subtle shift of his weight. His bucket hat cast his eyes in shadow, yet as they came into the light, they glowed with the artificial luminescence of screens, scrolling with streams of code.

Droplets of a viscous substance glistened at the rim of his nostrils, catching the light from the lantern he held in his left hand—an incongruous note of the organic in a domain of silicon and circuits.

“Welcome,” his voice emerged, an assemblage of diverse tones stitched seamlessly together. His gaze lingered on Maria. “I am Gaspar, the warden of the gateway. Do you possess the fortitude to delve deeper into this enigma, or do the shadows already grip your spirits?”

Here stood the Spire’s initial guardian, an entity crafted to test the psyches of intruders with its bizarre appearance and unnerving presence. Maria couldn’t shake the feeling that they were trying to freak them out before the real game even began.

Gaspar gestured toward a dim corridor, his eyes never leaving Maria’s. “Follow me,” he instructed, turning with an air of finality.

As they stepped through the archway, the door behind them sealed shut with a thud that echoed Maria’s racing heart, an unspoken cue that retreat was off the table. She exhaled quietly, grounding herself in the vast chamber that began to materialize before them. The library’s core cast a dim glow, causing shelves of ancient, leather-bound books to gradually emerge from the shadows.

“No pressure,” Maria muttered, half-ironic, pushing forward into the sea of untold stories that this ancient library offered.

“The book that doesn’t belong,” Gaspar said. “Seek it out. But beware, the tomes are sibylline. They reveal themselves only to the seeker. No other eyes will discern their titles or stories. Not even mine.”

He paused briefly, his gaze shifting to each of them. “You will have to find your respective volume,” he said. “It’s a piece of the puzzle, crucial to completing our combined cipher. Be diligent. The answer you seek resides within its pages or perhaps even hidden in plain sight off it.” He added with a measured seriousness, “Choose wisely—each of you gets only one chance. A misstep not only fails your own trial but also seals the fate of your ally.”

Seraphim smirked, glancing at Maria. “Just another day on the babachain, huh?”

“Yeah, we’ve danced this dance before.”

Maria moved along the aisles, her fingers hovering over the spines. Not unsurprisingly, each appeared to be a glowing chronicle of Zakharovna’s life—triumphs, failures, intimacies, betrayals. Her own existence felt alien in this mausoleum of her mentor’s past; a cyborg, a fused being, an echo not merely of flesh but of ambition and will.

What if she chose wrong? The thought flickered through her mind like static. Constructs had threatened her before; at worst, she could initiate an emergency override and jack themselves out. If that failed, they’d fight off some digital demon or another. Still, the stakes felt unnervingly high this time. She couldn’t afford to let doubt creep in.

The titles danced before her eyes, ancient and obscure, until the dance slowed, focused, and stopped. One spine seemed to stand out against the multitude, a subtle beacon in the dim. “The Progeny’s Path: Artificial Minds and the Transfer of Consciousness.”

Her heart steadied itself, her breath caught—an inexplicable pull. She reached out, hesitation giving way to certainty. Gasping, realization dawned. The anomaly in this sea of knowledge wasn't an idea—it was her.

As Maria drew the spine from its niche, a shudder coursed through the surrounding shelves.

“Unusual indeed,” Gaspar said. His eyes glimmered beneath his hat brim. “A unique piece found by an equally unique seeker.”

Maria's attention turned to Serafim, whose eyes were locked in concentration, scanning. She watched as her companion's brow furrowed, noted how she tilted her head, seemingly drawn towards something interesting.

Serafim's hand extended and seized the book, pulling it from its perch with a decisiveness that had echoed Maria's own bout of clarity. It seemed that her friend's path was as fated with these tomes as her own.

From where Maria stood, its title looked like a jumble of ancient runes. But above the cryptic script, twin stars adorned the cover. Maria felt a jolt of recognition; she had seen that image somewhere before. Serafim's face shifted, the unreadable expression suggesting something between discovery and an unexpected alignment of fate.

Before them, the shelves began to subtly shift. Maria watched, her breath held captive by the spectacle. The library revealed a pathway.

Maria's boots clinked against the cold floor, each step resonating as she crossed into the new chamber. She halted, her eyes taking in the walls, a shrine to warfare covered with weapons. The collection was vast: broadswords and katanas, battle axes and spears. But she didn't question it. She knew what was coming.

Her hand hovered, fingertips brushing the metal and leather before her, each weapon telling its silent story. Maria smiled. It had been too long since she'd felt the weight of a good fight, the adrenaline-laced dance of danger and skill. In the real world, fights had become too simple, an electric shock here and there—nothing challenged her as deeply as a neural deathmatch in the virtual world.

Let's see if you've gathered dust, old instincts, she mused, her hands finally settling on the sharp promise of twin daggers. They slid from their rests with a whisper. As she gripped them, a sense of completeness settled over her—the comfortable readiness of a warrior reacquainted with her tools.

With her weapons now firmly in hand, Maria's attention shifted as Serafim approached the collection herself. Serafim traced the handles of several blades until settling on one in particular—a long, sleek katana. The metallic ring of the weapon being drawn echoed through the chamber until the reverberation trailed off to a whisper.

A bell tolled somewhere in the depths of the chamber, its singular chime the herald of adversaries; out of the shadows emerged figures clad in carbon fiber gladiator suits, draped in cobalt whispers, and blood, and silk—the Black Wolves, the Syndicate's elite enforcers, ghosts from Maria's own history of violence. They brandished great broadswords that hummed with the thrum of energy shields.

As they advanced, Maria's instincts surged to the fore, her daggers slicing the air in ready arcs. Beside her, Serafim matched the Wolves' charge, her blade a sliver of night that shimmered with deadly intent. They fought back-to-back, a fluid dance of offense and defense.

Then, as if on cue, the Black Wolves abruptly halted their advance. Maria's heart clenched as Arkadya emerged from the

shadows. Her old boss, her old commander, eyes still sharp with the cunning that had once guided Maria herself. With a cruel smile, Arkadya gestured, and a contingent of ragtag men was dragged before Maria like a test of fealty.

The emotional weight hit Maria harder than any blade. She knew what was coming.

Arkadya's voice was a razor, words etched with malice. "Let's see if the programming holds, Maria. Execute them. Or has Zakharovna's creation gone soft? Useless thing. If you don't comply, I will have you decommissioned."

Maria's gaze hardened. *I'm no one's pawn.*

She leapt forward, defiance in her swing, and her blade met Arkadya's arm. The shock of severance echoed in Arkadya's gasp; disbelief etched across her face as her minions rushed to her aid.

Clashing steel resumed its song, the Black Wolves desperate to avenge their injured leader. "We are more than what we were," Serafim shouted above the din, the truth of her conviction clear as she fended off attacker after attacker.

Together, they contended with the onslaught until, one by one, the Black Wolves fell, their forms dissolving into ephemeral motes that faded like old ghosts. As the last specter vanished, Maria felt a release. The darkness of old deeds, her past transgressions, seemed to lift a little and scatter into the void.

I didn't spill innocent blood then, and I refuse to spill it now. Is this trial a measure of conscience or brutality? What does the Spire want—my redemption or my relapse? The moral algebra of monsters held no sway over her now. Whether a test of heart or a trial by combat, she knew she would endure. *Onto the next challenge.*

The higher they climbed, the less time behaved. Minutes stretched, folded, and snapped forward without warning. Maria stopped trying to measure the ascent and counted doors instead.

As they ascended further, the walls became lined with mirrors, each reflecting a different chapter of Maria's life. *Are these mirrors throwing back Serafim's demons too, or is she getting a rerun of my mess?* Maria couldn't tell; Serafim had been silent for what felt like days, her thoughts shielded behind an impenetrable front.

Maria saw herself in various interactions with Zakharovna, glimpses of a life repeatedly segmented by uploads and upgrades. Her eyes traced the reflection of scientists meticulously working on her body, a visual anthology of her countless resurrections and enhancements.

The mirrors didn't spare her from the darker facets of her existence either; they showed her dying on numerous missions, a testament to Zakharovna's ruthless exploitation. Equally disturbing were the reflections showing her role in interrogating and torturing citizens, acts she had committed under orders but now confronted as raw, unfiltered memories. *I'm beyond this now. These reflections can't touch me anymore. I stopped—that's what counts.*

"Thirty-two," Serafim finally whispered, breaking her long silence. Her voice pulled Maria from the depths of her memories. The tension that had built up in the silence hung between them like a taut string.

Maria glanced at her, frowning. "You've been quiet. What did you see in those mirrors?"

Serafim hesitated, her eyes unreadable as she stared ahead at the dark iron door marked 33. "What I needed to see."

Maria's frown deepened. Serafim sounded too composed for someone who had just crossed a hall of mirrors built to open

wounds. Maria considered pressing, then let it go. Now wasn't the time to let mistrust take root.

"You think that's enough?" Maria asked, her voice tight, probing just enough to test the waters.

Serafim turned to her, a small, cryptic smile forming at the corner of her lips. "It's enough for what comes next."

Maria opened her mouth to respond but thought better of it. The weariness weighed on her, and despite her instincts, she felt a strange, reluctant pull to follow Serafim's lead. But even as she stepped forward, she couldn't shake the gnawing unease.

Serafim gestured to the door with a nod. "Let's finish this. We're almost there."

Maria hesitated only briefly before pushing the door open. As she stepped over the threshold, the lingering strain of the climb seemed to lessen, though the tension in her chest remained. The hall beyond stretched into darkness, its vastness heavy with shadows. At the center, an orb hovered in the air, casting a soft, otherworldly glow that barely pierced the gloom.

As they moved further inside, Maria's eyes adjusted to the dim light. The walls were lined with even more mirrors than those she had passed during her ascent through the tower. But these mirrors were different; instead of reflecting her life they swirled with mists of color. As they drew closer to the central orb, the chill in the air deepened.

Without warning, the orb pulsed, and the ground beneath them vibrated with a deep hum. The mirrors brightened, their colors swirling and shifting in a chaotic dance before beginning to converge. The hues twisted together, slowly taking shape, stretching and expanding until a figure emerged from the glowing mist. It was the warden of the gateway, but not as she had seen him before. Gone were the cane, the

bucket hat, and the trench coat. Yet his eyes remained the same—scrolling lines of code, just as they had when they first met, an eerie signature she could never forget.

The swirling colors around him didn't stop—they shifted, morphing into vivid memories and dreams, flickering across his form like projections from another world. Fleeting images from their ascent now appeared: the shadowy shelves of an ancient library, the snarling face of a defeated foe, the cold gleam of a blade. Then, a small town nestled between snow-capped mountain peaks, its serene calm oddly out of place amid the surrounding chaos.

“Gaspar,” Maria called out, her voice resonating in the hushed space. “We’ve faced the challenges of the Spire. We seek the truth that lies at its heart. Will you stand aside?”

Gaspar's transformed figure regarded them with an enigmatic stillness. “The path to truth is never yielded easily,” he said, his voice echoing as if from a great distance. “One final challenge awaits, the culmination of all you have encountered within these walls, and all you have yet to encounter outside them.”

The room seemed to expand. The shadows receded slightly as the orb above them brightened yet more. Maria turned her gaze upwards, beyond the orb, to where a massive cobalt star stretched wide across the zenith, its vibrant pink hues splashing against the dark canvas of the virtual sky.

As the glare of the star softened, the walls around them vanished, revealing a vast horizon. There, suspended in the distance and floating in the void above the Spire's platform, stood a tree of mythical proportions. Its twin trunks spiraled upward in a helical dance of black and white, rising toward the stars. Nine magnificent branches unfurled from the tree, reaching out like the arms of a celestial being.

“You must understand,” continued Gaspar, his form flickering with the same colors that played across the expanse, “that entry is not denied to test your worth, but to prepare you for the weight of what you seek. This tree, the World Tree,” he gestured toward the vision outside, “represents the knowledge and power of all Gred. To reach it, to understand it, you must first confront the essence of your own journey. *All of it.*”

“Tell us,” Maria’s voice was firm. “What is the nature of this final trial?”

“It seems you haven’t been listening.” His voice held a note of reproof. “Reflection is more than revisiting the path you’ve walked; it is to mirror your past in the future, to forge new actions from the weight of past mistakes. To cease dwelling in bygone errors is not enough; to create new futures, new realities untainted by old faults—that is where your true trials begin.”

The room pulsed with energy, and the air around them thickened with anticipation. Gaspar’s form began to dissolve.

His voice trailed in the air like the remnants of a dream. “To reach the World Tree, you must navigate the *Halls of Reflection*. There, among the mirrored paths, you will find the convergence of all that you are, all that you have been, and all that you may yet become.”

He shimmered, and the colors from the sky bled into his form. “And that truth,” he said, “will be found neither here, nor out there.”

With those cryptic words, reality fractured. The vast hall, the cosmic panorama above, the majestic tree on the horizon, it all began to crack and splinter like glass under a sledgehammer. The sound was devastating.

Maria could only watch in disbelief as the world they had journeyed through with such toil disintegrated around them. The shards of the virtual environment fell away, revealing the

harsh, unadorned truth of their physical surroundings—the warehouse they had entered what felt like a lifetime ago.

Once again, Maria found herself surrounded by the hum of computers and the faint smell of metal and dust. The illusion was shattered; the challenge was a ruse.

Gaspar's form, now reduced to a mere wisp of smoke, finally disappeared along with the world they had come to know. "You sought the truth, and indeed you found one," the whisper persisted, "but it is not the truth you expected. And know this," each strained word just barely reaching Maria's ears, "while you have been cunning in concealing yourselves, we know now how to find you. The Spire was but one path to your end. Our reach is long, our sight unseen. You will submit."

As Maria struggled to maintain her focus, a piercing headache suddenly erupted, its intensity like a relentless vice gripping her skull. The industrial outlines of the warehouse—its pillars and the high ceiling—began to blur and sway erratically. Her knees buckled, the strength in her legs gave way, and she collapsed to the cold concrete floor. The last thing she saw before she began to slip away was Serafim's worried face fade into the encroaching darkness.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

DUNYA

The doors to the Grand Mariner's Cathedral loomed over her. Dunya paused beneath them, tracing the joints where the panels met, too precise for human work. Of course, they weren't. In the Arkyv, she had studied the Aquilonian Pantheon, raised on the ruins of older temples by hands that never worshiped there. A society that thought its monuments eternal, blind to the labor buried beneath them. The thought lingered as she rested her palm against the door, the chill seeping into her skin and settling somewhere deeper, where memory and doubt met. The wood was coarse and cold, the carvings deep but uniform, every imperfection accounted for. She knew this feeling, the quiet weight before a door that never truly stays shut. *They never do*, she thought.

The pressure built under her palms. For a moment nothing moved, then the weight shifted, a slow give that felt almost alive. A sigh escaped the seam as cool air spilled through the widening gap.

Snow swirled in after her as she crossed the threshold into the narthex, curling around her boots before settling on the stone. The air inside was still and sharp, the storm's roar outside fading to a low hum through the outer walls and vents, softer still beneath it the steadier hum of her Skelet concealed under her cargo pants.

The light changed as the doors closed behind her. The storm's pale glare gave way to a softer amber wash that bled from the seams in the walls. Her eyes adjusted slowly. Columns lined the nave ahead, their surfaces catching faint, shifting reflections from candles or maybe screens hidden deeper in the alcoves. The air tasted faintly of resin and dust.

She moved deeper inside, the chill clinging to her coat. The scent of juniper incense thickened the air, masking the faint metallic tang of machinery somewhere below. The walls climbed high around her, stone fused with composite, the older bones of the structure buried beneath a newer shell. Reinforced steel traced the arches overhead, the welds smooth and continuous. She knew the lattice had been grown, not welded, the structure shaped cell by cell until it hardened into place.

Her eyes lifted to the stained-glass windows. Light spilled across the floor in slow, uneven bands of color, giving bodies to names Baba Fenya had taught her in childhood, long before Gred arranged them into a single pantheon. Back then they had been household stories and scraps of old folklore, always followed by her grandmother's reminder that stories were not gods. Now Slavic goddesses shimmered in ribbons of neon and violet, their circuitry halos pulsing in faint, uneven intervals. The entire window seemed to breathe. The glow pressed against her vision, cold and sharp. She stood still, uncertain whether it was their watchfulness that unsettled her or the thought that someone had programmed them to look back.

The first window depicted Velun, the goddess of earth, waters, and dark forests, now sanctified in glass. She was portrayed as a shepherd with a serene expression, her staff twined with vibrant green ivy. The Black Wolves prayed to her—or prayed for her—Dunya was never sure which. Her grandmother, Agrafena Medvedova, had always been Baba Fenya to Dunya. Long before this window existed, Baba Fenya had told her versions of Velun around the house and corrected her whenever curiosity drifted toward worship. *“Life’s endless cycle,”* she would say, *“but these are no goddesses; there is only one true Saviour.”*

Beside Velun was Perine, the goddess of thunder and lightning, reimagined as a valiant warrior. In this depiction,

she wielded a fiery sword, bolts of lightning arcing around her, her gaze fierce and protective. The reds and oranges in the glass blazed like a perpetual Jupiter storm, giving her an air of relentless strength. The Hive had always shown a strange affection for her; many of its functionaries and bureaucrats could be seen attending her rites, perhaps drawn to the illusion that their authority, like her storm, could be righteous. *To dive into that storm would be a mercy compared to this place*, Dunya thought.

Another window showcased Gamayun, the prophetic bird. She was rendered with a woman's face and the sleek body of an eagle, soaring against a sky of sapphire blue. Her eyes were closed, deep in contemplation, and around her, the glass formed intricate patterns of feathers and wind currents. Long before this image existed, Baba Fenya had described Gamayun as a prophetic bird tied to knowledge and fate. *"But remember, child, the greatest mystery and truth resides in Christ."* Dunya wondered if prophecy had ever accounted for bad decisions, or if even the bird of fate would laugh at how often she had flown in circles.

Her gaze drifted from the swirling blues of Gamayun's sky to the next window, where the colors cooled and dimmed, the warmth of flight giving way to stillness and frost. Morana, the goddess of winter and death, was portrayed in a more somber light. Her figure, cloaked in shades of icy blue and white, stood regally against a landscape of snow and bare trees. Her expression was one of serene acceptance. The figure brought back one of Baba Fenya's old sayings: *"In the end, all things surrender."* Dunya thought of her death, how quietly it had come. Her cup had stayed beside the stove until Dunya put it away herself.

Dunya stood silently before the towering figures of the stained-glass deities, a vivid fusion of ancient Slavic myths and new-age spirituality. Their vibrant forms stood guard over

all the cathedral, and she wondered if they cared for their subjects at all.

The next window depicted Nav, god of the underworld, the only male among the pantheon. His form was cast in deep violet and black, framed by fractured light that seemed to swallow more than it gave. She met his hollow gaze, and a darker lesson surfaced. *"Discern the angel of light from the angel of darkness, the beneficial from the destructive."* The words came from an Orthodox patriarch before the Great War. After the opening strikes, the Arkyv preserved only conflicting reports, and no verified account of his survival remained.

Dunya felt a soft scoff escape her lips. No one really prayed to these new gods. Their followers were just subscribers, always one click away from uninstalling their faith. The stained-glass goddesses towering above her made the truth plain: control dressed as devotion, and a public eager to believe in anything that made the days feel less empty. *Rebirth, indeed*, she thought. That was what they called it now, the Pantheon of the Preprod, from the old Russian word for "reproduction," as if copying and calling it worship could ever make it real.

Standing in the aisle, she glanced toward the ornate staircase to her right, its steps worn smooth by time and countless feet. It was up those stairs, every quarter, that the Board convened, only a short distance from where she now stood. *Of course they'd build their altar beside the throne.*

Her gaze drifted to the chancel, where candles flickered across the ornate altar, their light sending shadows dancing along the cathedral walls. A faint warmth rose in her chest. The memory belonged to the old Naval Cathedral of St. Nicholas, on this same ground. Baba Fenya had held Dunya's small hand as they walked toward the altar to receive Communion.

The cathedral, however, was now nearly empty. The harsh winter made travel difficult, and most people preferred to stream mass from the warmth of their apartments. Dunya counted a few priestesses in their candlelit niches and a handful of worshippers scattered among the pews. The Grand Mariner's Cathedral had been built to hold three thousand after the old Naval Cathedral of St. Nicholas was absorbed into its larger shell, yet now it felt cavernous, its silence pressing heavier than the cold outside.

Gred had sold immortality as an upgrade. In practice it looked like this: old bodies kept online, younger voices missing from the room, everyone retreating into *virtual* because the physical city had stopped offering anything new. Even the cathedral ran at low occupancy.

Baba Fenya's faith belonged to the Petropavlovsk of Dunya's childhood, when St. Nicholas still held Orthodox services on this ground. The Grand Mariner had preserved pieces of the building while changing what the building was for. Dunya could still find pieces of the old faith in the cache.

Dunya found a secluded pew and sat, the cool oak steady beneath her. She closed her eyes and drew a slow breath, feeling the weight of her body and the stillness of the cathedral around her. Her mind buzzed with questions she couldn't quiet.

She leaned forward, elbows on her knees, the metal in her joints creaking softly under the strain. Her head bowed, tension coiling through her frame. Vesna filled her thoughts. Her absence had outlasted the usual cycles of silence and return, leaving a gap that felt wrong. Dunya had sent hundreds of messages and heard nothing back.

The evidence of her frustration was still there. She had kicked a hole in her apartment wall, the plaster giving way under the force of her servo-strengthened leg. Almost at once,

the wound began to close. The building, a hybrid of fungal composite and concrete, responded like living tissue, the surface rippling as it repaired itself. Within minutes, the wall was whole again. It was a marvel of engineering, yet in that moment, it only reminded Dunya of how the world refused to stop, refused to feel. The self-repairing material had denied her even that one small fucking outlet of pain.

Pain lingered, sharp and familiar, as her thoughts turned to Maria. The silence she left behind hollowed the world around her. Maria had been the one constant, the voice that steadied her when everything else blurred. Together they'd pulled off virtual jobs and data runs that should have broken them, yet somehow, they'd always come out laughing. That bond had been enough to keep the loneliness at bay.

Those shared runs had been a welcome distraction from a life that felt smaller with each passing year. Vesna had worn the colors of the women who hunted her father down, and Dunya had never let either of them pretend otherwise. The Yelagin log absolved no one. It proved only that Vesna had handed her a truth that implicated her own pack, then stayed when Dunya refused to turn it into gratitude. Trust accumulated through smaller things after that: a voice in the earpiece, a door opened after midnight, a transfer handled without pity, a meal left warm. By the time Vesna lost her barracks room and moved in, they already knew each other's medicines, passwords, and bad nights. They had become necessary to each other before either called it affection, and the two never separated cleanly. Vesna was her only real companion, a woman twenty years older, and sometimes Dunya caught herself feeling like she'd skipped ahead to the end of her own story. Time had stopped in Gred anyway; no one aged here, not really. Maria's absence still pressed on her, the final moment in the mindgraft looping in her head with a clarity that felt like her own betrayal.

The guilt of leaving Maria in that critical state weighed on her as she sat in the pew. She'd made a split-second decision to evacuate, to save herself, but the image of Maria's still body wouldn't fade. The questions that followed pressed hard against her thoughts. Could she have done something different? Missed a signal that might have changed the outcome?

What unsettled her most was the calm that had settled in since. It felt wrong, as if her mind had gone quiet only because it didn't know where else to go.

It felt almost suicidal, sitting so openly in the Grand Mariner's Cathedral, the heart of the Syndicate's power.

The campus visit survived only in fragments. Still, she had checked the warrant channels twice before leaving home. No detainer, biometric flag, or University hold carried her name. If she'd crossed a line with the mindgrafts, if Maria had been taken by Syn, why was there no pursuit? Either the whole thing had remained off-ledger, or someone had broken the trace before it spread. The silence was unnerving, almost unreal. *They should just come and arrest me now. I'll show them*, she thought, a flicker of defiance lighting inside her. But the feeling faded as quickly as it came. *Do I really have the nerve to face them?*

Her life felt empty. Friends gone, family long dead, Vesna missing. The space left behind kept widening until it was all she could see. The thought that maybe nothing she did mattered anymore, that she had slipped beneath notice, was worse than the fear of being caught. She sat in the stillness, surrounded by a silence that felt like judgment.

She felt useless now, an operator without an assignment, a shadow moving through enemy ground unseen and unchallenged. The strange contracts she'd been getting only deepened the feeling, each one twisting into another dead end.

What does this Serafim girl have to do with it all? The dreams lingered, too vivid, bleeding into her waking thoughts until she started to wonder if they were real in ways the rest of this wasn't. *Am I losing it?*

Dugal would have known what to do. The thought tightened in her chest. She pictured him beside her, kneeling in prayer, his sandy hair tousled as if he'd just run a hand through it. He looked steady, the way he always had, while she seemed smaller beside him, trembling and unsure. She missed that steadiness more than she wanted to admit.

She clutched the pew in front of her, the wood cold against her palms. Regret crept in as she replayed the last few weeks. The dreams where Serafim reached for her and she had not pulled away. The hollow distance growing between her and Vesna. It all felt wrong now, blurred by need more than affection. *I just wish he was here.* Her fingers traced the grain of the wood, searching for something steady, something real.

Her grandmother's face came to her, calm and steady in the blur of guilt. She could almost feel Baba Fenya's hands again, rough from years of work but still warm with the kind of love that stayed through every season. Baba had been the one to remind her of restraint, especially after Dugal's death, speaking of chastity as both shield and discipline:

"Bear the snowstorm like the cedar," Baba would often recite an old folk saying that lingered in Dunya's memory. *"It stands tall and unyielding, preserving its beauty through the harshest of winters."* Baba had a way of lightening her teachings with humor. *"Just don't let the snow weigh you down too much, or you'll end up a frozen log instead,"* she would add with a chuckle.

Dunya smiled at the memory, a small laugh slipping out despite the silence of the cathedral. For a moment, the weight in her chest eased. She closed her eyes and whispered into

the stillness, reaching for her grandmother's presence. "Baba Fenya, I don't know where to turn. Show me the way, like you used to."

The silence of the cathedral embraced her words. Dunya imagined Baba Fenya's spirit then, mixing with the incense smoke that rose in delicate spirals towards the vaulted ceiling. She pictured her grandmother's face, lined with age but radiant with an inner strength, listening intently to her plea.

"Baba, I'm full of doubts," Dunya said quietly. "I can't see what's ahead, and I'm afraid I'll lose my way. Help me think clearly. Help me stay strong."

The cathedral's dim light wrapped around her as she stood before the altar. This was forbidden ground. In Gred, Orthodoxy was more than shunned; it was erased. Still, the old words rose in her like a spark she could not put out. She knew the risk, knew how faith was treated here, but the pull of it ran too deep to silence.

She moved with the quiet focus of habit to a secluded corner of the cathedral, where an untouched patch of stone marked the absence of an icon long removed. The shadow left behind was faint but familiar, a trace of what once hung there. In the dim light slipping through the stained glass, a single beam caught the spot, pale against the dark.

Dunya knelt, the chill of the stone pressing through her clothes. She bowed her head and clasped her hands, holding to the memory of what had been there. This was what remained of her faith, a fragment of a world that had been erased but not forgotten.

"Jesus," she whispered, her voice barely rising above breath. "In a world that's forgotten you, show me the way." Tears gathered at the corners of her eyes, not from fear but from the strange comfort of being heard, even if only by

memory. “In this darkness, be my light. In my doubt, be my strength.”

The words faded into the stillness. She drew a slow breath and pushed herself upright, the echo of her prayer lingering like breath on glass. Then a harsh cough cut through the quiet.

Dunya turned, her heart catching at the sight of an old man, draped in tattered black robes, advancing towards her. The man advanced, pale against the dark, his black robes swallowing the light. This man was a Priest of Nav.

As the priest stepped close enough to touch her, Dunya studied him more carefully. His face was narrow and pale, almost translucent, his hair the same washed-out white. Even his eyes had no color, only a soft gleam like polished stone catching the light. *He has to be a Millennial*, she thought, a quiet shiver running through her. *He looks at least a hundred.*

“You pray to a forgotten god,” the priest said.

Dunya met his gaze, unflinching. Her eyes caught the faint golden stitching on his sleeve, small crosses glinting in the low light. “Some things aren’t forgotten,” she said quietly. “They just stop being spoken aloud.”

The priest tilted his head, his pale eyes narrowing. “And yet, your prayers are loud in their desperation. To whom do you seek guidance in a house that no longer welcomes him?”

“I don’t know,” Dunya said softly. “Maybe I’m just hoping someone still listens.”

He regarded her in silence, the faint smile gone. “Hope can be a dangerous thing. It ties us to names long buried.” His gaze sharpened. “Tell me, child, your name—and the house you come from.”

Dunya hesitated. The question sat between them, heavy as a stone. Her mouth felt dry. Avdotya. She had never liked the

sound of her true first name. Too close to an angel, and she was nothing of the kind. Even her father had only used it when he was angry. She lifted her chin and met the priest's eyes.

"I am Dunya Bocharov. My mother was born Medvedova."

"Ah, Bocharova," the priest said slowly. "Then you must have lost much in the formative wars. Your family, they sided with the usurper?"

Bocharova. He had heard her clearly and put the old ending back. Dunya's jaw tensed. "They sided with what they thought was right. The 'usurper,' as you call him, offered hope when no one else did."

The priest gave a brittle chuckle, the sound dry as parchment. "Hope is often the mask worn by ambition. Many followed, only to tumble into deeper shadow. Old Alexei was but a flicker against the brighter blaze of his sister's ascent. Twins like that—bound together—can either illuminate or destroy. His weakness left a void she was destined to fill."

"Not all who fall are weak," Dunya said. "And not all who lead do it for power."

"Perhaps," the priest mused. "But the usurper's fall paved the maiden's way, did it not? His reach gave her cause. His failure gave her purpose. In a sense, he was her first gift."

Dunya bit back her reply. The words stung all the same. Ironically, the priest's insinuations about the usurper stung no less with his ignorance of her father's identity. "The world is shaped by those who dare to reshape it, regardless of their reasons."

The priest inclined his head slightly. "Indeed. And now you stand in their shadow, seeking counsel from a forgotten god. Tell me, young Bocharova, what path do you mean to carve?"

"That's Bocharov to you," she said. She'd dropped the vowel after her father's death, a quiet act of rebellion she never

stopped to explain to anyone. Her tone hardened. "My path is simple. Cut the lies. Drag false idols into the light."

The priest smiled faintly. "A very *modern* appellation...and a noble quest. But remember, *girl*, even the most righteous path has its blind spots."

Catching the subtle rise in his voice, Dunya felt an uneasy shift in the air. Like a performer stepping into the lights, he extended his hand toward her, though his next words were meant for an audience that wasn't there. His gaze lowered, and the sacred blessing in the name of Nav began. "Where shadows weave the tapestry of destiny, may you find the strength to navigate the darkness. In the uncharted corridors of fate, may your spirit be as resilient as the eternal night, and may the whispers of the unseen guide you to truths hidden in the heart of silence. Under Nav's endless gaze, remember: in the deep of the void, secrets awaken and destinies are forged."

After this unnerving public proclamation, the priest leaned in closer, his voice dropping to an intimate murmur. "Remember, the predator must sometimes become the prey to understand the cycle of life and death. Do not fear the descent into the depths, for it is there that true vision is often found. Nav teaches us that endings are but doorways to new beginnings, and every soul is a hunter, seeking its path through the dark forest of life. To hunt will be your salvation, your redemption. Embrace these lessons, for they will guide you when all other lights fade."

With that, the priest turned and cackled, his tattered robes trailing behind him, their ragged edges dancing like mischievous little imps in his wake.

Dunya remained still while the priest walked away. The blessing was mostly theatrical garbage, yet several phrases had landed too close to the dreams: descent, hidden truths,

the hunt. Either the old man knew something or Dunya had become desperate enough to find patterns in sermons.

As if I needed another compromised signal.

She crossed the cathedral, the Skelet chiming softly against the stone, and forced the heavy doors apart. Cold air struck her face. Outside, Gred resumed its usual processing: traffic, towers, cameras, people moving along routes someone else had selected.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

KLARA

As the memory of the blizzard faded, Klara pressed on through the Derge's endless white. The wind clawed at her hood and the snow hissed beneath her boots. She knew the price of survival, had paid it more than once, and would pay it again if she had to. *Not dying isn't the same as living*, she thought, lifting her flask and taking a long pull of spiced brandy. She had learned that lesson in field tents long before she ever learned how to kill. The burn steadied her, a small, defiant flame against the cold.

The western snow lay heavier than in the east, its false purity hiding what it had already claimed. Klara had found three bodies so far, old women who had lived alone on the outskirts of the Rustbelt, where the last gnarled trees gave way to open tundra. Each had faltered for only a moment, taken by the cold or by something worse before they could cry out.

Demons...

The *kikimora*, tricksters of old tales, were said to feed on the souls of the dead, leaving their bodies shriveled and hollow. Or so the elders claimed. Yet the faces before her looked more like the work of failed exo treatments, skin drawn tight and veins dark with residue. *The cold just finished what the drugs started*. Klara turned the blood-stained handkerchief in her hand, pity rising despite herself. As she laid it over the last woman's face, the air around her seemed to still. For a moment, she felt her release, a mercy she preferred to the thought of demons gnawing at what remained. It was the closest thing to healing she still allowed herself.

A sound behind her made her whirl around. A deer, most likely. She steadied her breath and pressed the damp handkerchief to her lips, tasting iron as she studied the trees. The forest held its breath with her. Then a twig cracked to her left, sharp and close, and every muscle in her body tightened.

“Who’s there?” Her voice quivered as she called out. “If you mean no harm, show yourself.”

The bushes rustled. Klara held her ground, eyes fixed on the sound. *Predator or prey? Either way, they’ll want warmth soon. Shelter—or their blood, if it comes to that.* The choice came quicker now than it used to, and that frightened her more than the dark.

As the wind eased, the presence faded into the trees, leaving no trace behind. Klara let out a long breath and turned back to the old woman lying still in the snow. She brushed frost from the woman’s lashes and closed her eyes.

A small wooden totem caught her attention beside the body, a carved babushka wrapped in dark etchings, meant for luck. She turned it in her glove, feeling the grooves of the design. *A charm like this could get you questioned in Gred.* With a faint sigh, she dropped it back into the snow. Maybe someone else would find it. Someone who still believed. Belief had once come easy to her, before it started costing lives.

For a heartbeat, the flurries seemed to dance like firelight. Vatrallyna’s face appeared in them, stern but illuminated by warmth, the memory of her voice whispering through the years. *“Control the spark, Klara, or it will control you.”* Another lesson had lasted longer. Before deciding what a sign meant, Vatrallyna made her mark where it touched the world. She used to press charcoal into Klara’s hand and make her draw the route again until rumor and witness stopped sharing the same line. Klara had hated the exercise. She still drew maps that way. Those early lessons had almost felt like joy, back

when mischief and power had blurred together. Until the night she bled out.

She touched her throat, feeling the faint ridge of the scar. The Witch of the Woods had given her a choice. Join the Coven and live. Refuse and die. She'd chosen life, but the price had followed her.

Her first kill still haunted her most. A girl no older than she'd been when Vatrallyna found her, wide-eyed and shaking as Klara drove the blade home for breaking her oath. The memory always soured her mouth. No amount of time had dulled it, only made it easier to carry. Once, she had tried to save lives. Now she decided which ones were worth saving. And some part of her still kept count. The lesson had stayed with her: mercy was colder than death.

Stepping out of the forest's shadow, Klara entered a ruined plaza dominated by the statue of a forgotten soldier. A rusted bayonet, now serving as a clothesline post strung with skinned pigeons, caught the last of the light. The dead city sprawled ahead, a patchwork of decay and defiance, windows boarded but unbroken, graffiti staking claims, walls patched with scavenged metal, and rooftop gardens clinging to life with hardy kale, pale cabbages, and root crops pushing through the snow.

Her hood slipped back as she approached a small band of outlaws, men and women crouched around a fire with crude weapons resting nearby. They stirred a dented pot of stew, its thin steam carrying the scent of bone and smoke. She'd been one of them once, she thought.

Should I lean into my 'Stralian or soften it? Klara pondered briefly, eyeing the group. The majority appeared older, likely gen X or alpha females who had grown alongside the internet and honed their English through Babushka during the Reconstruction. *Standard American English, then.* Had they

been younger, she doubted her ability to navigate the Russian-English pidgin that was emerging here as a form of resistance against the Gred's high-tech colonial stronghold.

"What do you want, city girl?" a woman with a scarred face sneered. "This is no place for you."

Reaching into her worn leather messenger bag, Klara produced a small blue pouch. "Exo. Enough for all of you."

"What's the catch?" the woman said, rising to her feet and snatching the pouch from Klara. She sniffed it before tossing it to a man nearby.

"We don't want any of your trash. Best you leave now, if you don't want trouble," he warned, hand inching towards the hilt of his sword.

"I'm not here to sell you anything," Klara said. "I'm here to offer you an opportunity."

"Our people are working hard as it is," the woman said. "We don't need your false charity."

"This ain't no charity," Klara said. "It's an opportunity—a way to save yourselves."

"We know how to survive," the man said, his hand still on his weapon. "Always have. We don't need help from the likes of you."

The air grew colder around them, tension settling like frost. Klara didn't move. Holding still had once meant patience; now it meant control.

The scarred woman studied her for a long moment, eyes narrowing as if weighing truth against risk. Something in Klara's face must have held, because the woman's stance eased, just slightly.

"You have an offer?" she asked at last, a sharper edge behind the words.

Klara nodded. "I do, and I won't repeat myself."

"Then speak," the man shouted.

Klara stepped closer to the fire, its heat licking at her boots as the circle of outlaws closed around her.

"I'm not here to take from you," she said. "I'm offering a way to fight back. A way to save what's left of this city."

A bigger man, all shoulders and slow movement, pushed himself up. He drew a sword with a lazy, practiced flick, the blade glancing the firelight. "What do you need us for? You planning to kill someone?"

"I am." Klara met his stare without blinking. "And I need you to help me do it."

The woman's eyes narrowed. "And how are we supposed to help with that?" she asked. "We don't have the numbers, or the strength."

"By joining the Coven," Klara said. Her voice stayed steady, her gaze moving from one face to the next. "Together we can be more than this. I've seen what it's like to be powerless, to watch your people starve while others decide their fate."

A rough laugh broke from the scarred woman. "You're not one of us," she said. "Why would we ever fight beside *you*?"

"Because I *was* one of you," Klara said. "I grew up in the shadow of these very buildings, in the heart of the Tarasov Quarter. Even before the Syndicate condemned our home, I was here. I ran through these streets as a child, and it was the despair here that pushed me to fight in the Waste Wars, to become a medic, to try and stitch together something better from the brokenness."

Her eyes flicked briefly toward the horizon, where the fading light cast a crimson glow on the battered landscape. "I've seen the suffering in the trenches and the desperation in field

hospitals. I've faced the choices that haunt you long after the gunfire fades. I've been given a chance to rise above our beginning, and I took it."

"I don't look back," Klara said. "What's done is done. But I believe in second chances, for all of us. We've all seen what Gred takes from us. I'm saying we don't have to let it keep taking."

She looked around the circle, meeting their eyes one by one. "The Coven gives us a way to fight back. Alone, we break. Together, we endure."

She saw it then, the flicker of hunger, of need. People who had already lost everything and were still breathing out of habit. Klara stepped forward, hands open to the firelight. "Just give me a chance to prove it."

The request lingered, tension settling over the gathering as more outlaws reached for their weapons.

"Let her speak," the scarred woman shouted. "She stands before us, alone and unarmed. Surely, we can grant her the courtesy of hearing what she has to say before we feed her to the dogs."

Before Klara could gather her thoughts, dozens more emerged from the doors and windows of the ramshackle buildings surrounding their camp in the abandoned city square. In a matter of minutes, she found herself encircled by a crowd of gaunt, disheveled, and armed men and women.

The woman who had granted Klara permission to speak stepped forward. "What is your name?"

"I am Klara. Klara Chaban." She struggled not to breathe through her nose as she spoke. The stench of the outlaws—the heavy funk of sweat mingled with earth and unwashed bodies—clung to the air in the now very cramped open space.

“Klara Chaban...” the old woman repeated, tasting the name as if testing its weight. “What do you want from us, Klara Chaban?”

Her own surname struck harder than she expected. There was no one left to carry it but her, and no version of her left that would have made them proud. *Chaban*. A word erased from the Arkyv, scrubbed clean after the uprising that birthed the new Board. Her clan had vanished with it, consumed in the city’s reshaping. Once, the Chabans had ruled the Derge through their union with the Tarasovs, a proud matriarchal line. Now, only ghosts.

She pictured the Cathedral, the three empty seats at the high oak table. They were always there above her, unfilled and unmoving, silent witnesses to what had been erased.

The old woman’s gaze pulled her back. Sharp and appraising. Klara knew what she saw: no living kin to prove her claim, no lineage left to speak her name. A gap too convenient for doubters. Yet behind that scrutiny, Klara caught something else, calculation and curiosity. The woman was measuring her, not as an imposter, but as someone who might still matter.

Klara held that gaze. Whatever she said next would tip the balance. The story she carried was thin, worn, and unprovable, but it was hers alone, the one truth she refused to let die.

“I hail from the peninsula, just like all of you,” Klara said. Her voice carried over the rising jeers. “I once swore myself to the Syndicate, believing they wanted what I wanted—to heal, to protect. I was wrong. The Syndicate doesn’t care for the people. It only feeds on power. And when it had enough, it turned on its own.”

“Scum!” a woman shouted, the word cutting through the crowd. Others murmured, the sound shifting like wind through stone.

Klara didn’t flinch. The faces before her blurred with memory, rebels she had once dragged before the Board, their eyes wide with fear, their pleas lost beneath the Syndicate’s boots.

“After everything I did for them, the Syndicate turned on me and sentenced me to die.” It was a half lie followed by a half truth. “The Coven intervened and spared my life. Now it is my duty to help them save others.”

“And what makes you think we’d want to join forces with them?” the scarred woman said. “They’re *nuyeds*, just like the Syndicate. We follow Nav, not the whims of witches.”

“No,” Klara said. “The Coven is different. They’re fighting for something beyond mere power. Immortality is not their goal. It’s just a tool. They’re fighting for the right to live their lives as they see fit, free from interference by the Syndicate or anyone else.”

“To what end?” the woman asked.

“Freedom,” Klara said. “For all of us. The right to choose who we love, and when we die. The right to be more than just outlaws, living in fear and hiding in the shadows of a city that wants us dead.”

Klara’s eyes narrowed, focused on the expectant crowd before her. The words would not be enough; she had to make them *feel* the power, the very essence that the Coven promised. She drew a breath, not just into her lungs but deeper, into the core of her being, tasting a metallic hint as her tongue grazed her gums.

A sphere of light formed, floating serenely above her outstretched palm. Its luminescence caught every eye, casting

a hush over the onlookers. “This is what the Coven offers us,” she said, her voice expanding with a quiet intensity. “The power to transcend our limitations.”

The crowd’s reaction was palpable, a collective intake of breath suspended in the air. Emotions flickered across their faces as fear transformed into profound awe. The sphere expanded, a glow that rivaled the moons at their zenith. Then, with a sound like a celestial chime, it shattered into countless smaller orbs that danced around Klara in the dim red light of the courtyard.

“A gift from Aisyt herself,” Klara said. The unspoken truth lay heavy in her mind. The light was only a temporary illusion, a side effect of the drug coursing through her veins. A price would come later, but for now it was a tool, a means to an end. That was how all of it worked now. Power first. Consequences later.

She swept her arm wide, and the orbs followed her gesture, swirling and diving like celestial bodies in a private galaxy. “The Coven can teach us how to wield it, how to fight with it. With their guidance, we can reclaim what’s rightfully ours.”

The crowd’s response was now a tangible thing, a wave of belief and determination that she saw began to mirror her own. The words had been spoken, the power had been shown, and the path had been laid. The future was now in their hands, and Klara knew they were ready to seize it.

“Listen to me, my brothers and sisters. We are abandoned! The forsaken children of Petropavlovsk. This abomination they call Gred, erected on the ashes of our home, has become a prison. And for those cast beyond its borders, a death sentence.”

Klara’s eyes briefly swept toward the fringes of the gathered crowd. There, against the tattered backdrop of the Derge, stood an unmistakable phalanx of black-clad figures. The

eerie dance of red and blue banners billowed in the harsh winds behind them.

A flicker of unease traced its way up her spine. The presence of Black Wolves here wasn't entirely a surprise, though she hadn't anticipated their arrival so soon. She knew their kind roamed these forsaken areas, claiming to uphold order where there was none.

"But we must act now! Before it's too late!" she continued over her apprehensions.

The helmeted women forced their way through the throng, forming a steel barrier in the surging sea of flesh and tattered brown leather. The outlaws surrounding Klara tensed, their gazes now darting between the encroaching Syndicate enforcers and their new prophet.

"The Matrons lounge on their throne of deceit and dismiss our suffering!" she roared. "Meanwhile, our children perish from starvation on these very streets."

The line of soldiers neared, and Klara discerned the hatred smoldering in their eyes.

"Their war against death, not ours, cost us our livelihood. We paid for the Syndicate's victories with our blood and the blood of our loved ones! The time has come, brothers and sisters, to halt this injustice," she cried. "The government of Gred, of the Syndicate, must be held accountable for what they've inflicted upon us."

Klara felt the weight of rifle barrels aimed at the crowd. Her thoughts accelerated, grasping the dire facts: they were outgunned, perched on the precipice of disaster. With every heartbeat, her urgency escalated as she formulated a plan to save them from annihilation.

“Today, we are reborn!” Klara proclaimed. “Today, we stand as individuals, not mere pawns beneath the Syndicate’s heel. With the Coven’s power behind us, we shall prevail!”

Applause cut through Klara’s words as the outlaws raised their weapons in a triumphant salute. All that remained was to cement their loyalty, to transform this momentary passion into a steadfast bond.

“I understand your fury,” she continued. “But it’s more than mere anger, isn’t it? It’s a call to reclaim what the Syndicate has taken from us—our freedom, our families, our lives. Feel that anger, yes, but transform it into purpose. Together, we’re not just rebels; we’re a force of change.”

The crowd’s response transformed into a rhythmic chant, a unifying cry of “*Klara! Klara!*” that tore through the air.

“The Coven is formidable,” Klara persisted, her voice rising above the crowd’s chant. “Yet they require our aid. With our combined strength, we can reclaim what’s rightfully ours—our liberty, our dignity, our very lives. The Syndicate may possess power and weaponry, but they lack our will, our heart, and our soul.”

“To the Coven!” the scarred woman bellowed, the crowd echoing her call. “*To the Coven! To the Coven!*”

Klara’s smile broadened as she observed the outlaws surging toward her, eager to embrace their cause. Together, they would be unstoppable. She had found her army.

“Enforcers!”

The warning shattered Klara’s fervor, her heart plummeting as the Wolves’ black-clad forms poured into the square. “Damn it,” she muttered, then raised her voice to the crowd. “Brothers and sisters, we fight! *Now!*”

Battle cries erupted as outlaws charged the Wolves, who countered with their stun guns. Klara watched the factions

clash, her heart swelling with the knowledge that this was the revolution's dawn. Success was her only option.

Klara's boots hit the cobblestones with a decisive thud as she leapt from the edge of the empty fountain. As the masses parted before her like the sea yielding to Velun, she laughed, rushing toward her destiny. She would make them all kneel before her. Klara, the Outlaw Queen, would leave them trembling before her might.

"Make them rue their existence!" Klara bellowed, her voice a battle cry. Standing abruptly before the clash, she was momentarily unarmed until a man at her side tossed her a sword. She caught it deftly, the weapon's weight settling into her hand.

The riot shields blurred the crowd before her, but fueled by determination, she charged forward, undaunted. A savage grin spread across her face as she closed in, adrenaline and solidarity surging through her.

Klara's cutlass traced deadly arcs through the air. She could feel the *exo* coursing through her veins, a synthetic rush that amplified her every motion, as one Wolf after another fell before the might she wielded.

As she assaulted the next pack of enforcers, bullets seemed to dissolve around her. She felt invincible, untouchable. But then, something struck her chest, knocking the breath from her lungs. Stumbling backward, her sword slipped from her grasp.

Shock widened Klara's eyes as she realized there was a large shell lodged in the armor beneath her cloak. The impact hadn't punctured through, but the force was enough to knock the wind out of her. The Black Wolves weren't using stun guns as she expected—they had fired live ammunition.

"What the hell?" Klara gasped, her hand shooting to the site of the impact on her side, bracing for severe injury. She

probed the area; a swelling bruise was emerging beneath her armor, yet her skin remained unbroken—no blood. Relief mixed with pain; the plating had taken the brunt of the blow. Her head swiveled, vision swimming as she sought the source of the attack, her senses scattered.

The outlaws quickly closed ranks around her, forming a protective circle. As she caught glimpses of their faces, she noticed a shift; the typically stern, weathered expressions, carved from a lifetime hardened by the struggles of the Derge, now betrayed a rare vulnerability—fear.

The sound of a live round was as foreign as hope. A chill ran down Klara's spine; this was uncharted territory even for them.

The scarred woman met Klara's eyes. "We need to get you out of here."

"I'm fine," Klara forced the words through clenched teeth, unwilling to succumb to the pain. She had to press on, to prove her invincibility.

The elderly woman reached for the blue pouch she had acquired earlier from Klara. Tipping the bag, she allowed the white powder within to pool into her outstretched hand. She streaked the substance across her gums.

"What are you doing?" Klara blurted.

The woman's eyes met Klara's, and her voice, though quavering, held steady. "What you've done took courage. I can't stand by and let you face death alone."

Klara watched, transfixed, as the woman's once coarse white hair softened, flowing down like liquid silver, while her eye sockets deepened into a rich purple hue. Her sun-worn skin smoothed, revealing a youthful complexion that belied her years. She stood tall, filled with a newfound grace, and spoke with calm assurance. "I'm with you, Klara Chaban."

Feeling a surge of inspiration, Klara turned to face the assembled outlaws. The shift in the air hadn't gone unnoticed, and a new energy pulsed through the crowd. "Brothers and sisters!" Klara's voice echoed across the square. "This is our moment. Now is the time to fight!" The outlaws roared in approval. Grinning, she raised her sword once again. "For our future!" she cried, striking down on the nearest riot shield.

As the two factions clashed, the air became a storm of fire and lead. Klara surged through the battlefield like a blaze unchecked. Her blade, a comet of silver arcing through the mayhem, ignited the air with its ferocity. The discord of war raged around her, but she was the flame at its heart—a symbol of rebellion incarnate for the outlaws, the Coven, and her own unquenchable thirst for freedom.

The Black Wolves found themselves overwhelmed, their ranks breaking before Klara's unyielding advance. Forced to retreat, they were pursued by the outlaws' fury, hurled stones, and the incendiary rage of Molotov cocktails. This place, once part of their wretched domain, was slipping from their grasp, Klara knew.

As the sound of their victory diminished into the jubilant roars of the once-oppressed, Klara reached for the flask of spiced brandy that clung to her side through the dance of battle. Unscrewing the cap, she raised it high and took a long, satisfying swig.

The warmth of the drink coursed through her, as invigorating as the triumph itself. Not content with savoring it alone, she passed the flask to the nearest fighter, a nod to the unspoken warrior's code of sharing both the spoils and the spirits.

The flask traveled from hand to hand, the outlaws' weapons clinking in makeshift toasts. Each turn at the liquor seemed to fortify the bond now linking their destinies.

Klara was their leader, their deliverer. And leaders, she was learning, didn't get to choose clean victories. Together, they would reshape the world. But as the noise of celebration faded into twilight, a chill settled in her heart. Victory was on the horizon, but what would it cost them in the end? The road ahead would be long and fraught with regret, and she knew the war had only just begun.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

VESNA

It happened faster than Vesna expected. One moment, the battlefield was a chaotic storm of railgun fire and explosions. The next, a pulse—quiet, invisible—rippled through the air, snuffing out the roar of the Black Wolves' weapons as if the world had drawn a sharp breath and held it. They'd trusted Fort Ivan's defenses to protect their railguns, but now they were forced into the close combat they craved. The University Marines held the flanks, their Gauss rifles cracking in bursts behind her, only targeting those in Vesna's way.

Her opponents barreled toward her with terrifying momentum, their massive frames bearing down on her. Freakishly large in pitch-black, fur-lined puffer jackets, veins bulging from their necks, they charged like an unstoppable force. Vesna had to be nimble, precise, darting between their swings. Bloodshot eyes glared at her, snarls twisting their faces. She brandished her gunblades, driving one into flesh with a sharp jab before slicing across the torso of another. More of them surged forward, their heavy boots pounding the earth, the scent of sweat and blood thickening the air as she fought to stay ahead of the berserked pack.

The clash of steel and the thud of falling bodies filled her ears, each strike a sharp crack in the air. Her blades hissed, severing heads and limbs. Behind her, the University Marines carved a path, their firepower driving her forward. Arkadya, her target, stood thirty meters away. An island of unsettling calm that radiated a cold, detached judgment.

Firing on an Alpha was out of the question, Vesna knew, but with every step she forced through the maelstrom of war, the distance between them shrank.

Ten meters now.

As she homed in on Arkadya, the older woman pivoted, her lips curling into a smirk that carried the weight of a challenge. The guards formed an imposing line around her.

Arkadya extended her hand, her voice low and sharp. "Join me in the center, then. Let's finish this, once and for all. You and me."

As she closed in, Vesna's gaze locked on Arkadya's face. There was something there. Something almost like respect, the kind a warrior reserves for an equal. But beneath it, contempt flickered in her eyes, sharp and insatiable. Vesna's blades sliced through the last of her foes in a final arc, the force bringing her down to one knee. Her swords rested, crossed and steady on her thigh, the clang of steel fading into the tension between them.

Arkadya's growl broke the silence.

"You've always been stubborn, Vesna. But this? This is beyond betrayal." She took a step forward, her voice lowering to a dangerous edge. "Siding with University filth against your own blood?"

"If you want a challenge, then I will give you one," Vesna shouted back. "But I'm not going to apologize for anything."

Vesna raised her hand, commanding her marines to cease fire. As they complied, soldiers from both sides slowly closed in, forming a rough arena. The combatants paused, their focus narrowed on the two figures at the center. Rifles lowered, faces tense, the soldiers stood in stiff, uneasy silence, their wariness evident in every glance.

Without warning, Arkadya lunged, her broadsword a blur of steel aimed at Vesna's guard. Vesna's reflexes kicked in, her twin short swords flashing up just in time to meet the blow. The impact jarred her arms, the sheer weight of the broadsword forcing her back a step. Again and again, Arkadya's strikes came down like a hammer, each one heavier than the last, driving Vesna back as her boots slid across the dirt. Gritting her teeth, she deflected each swing, her muscles straining to absorb the force. Every parry was precise, her blades dancing just fast enough to divert the next crushing blow, but the weight behind Arkadya's attacks left her breathless, barely holding her ground.

Vesna twisted and weaved, Arkadya's blade slicing close enough to brush her jacket. Then the right side lagged by a fraction. She had watched Yevgenia find the same flaw in the Mechanor ring years earlier. Stronger. Slower. Vesna had remembered the lesson even if Arkadya had learned to hide it better. She surged forward, twin blades darting toward the exposed gap in Arkadya's side.

But Arkadya spun around, abandoning the broadsword's reach as her bionic arm shot out. She locked onto Vesna's dominant sword arm. The sudden force knocked Vesna's blade from her hand, the weapon clattering to the ground with a sharp ring.

Vesna twisted, muscles straining as Arkadya's mechanical hold crushed her dominant wrist. The pressure built as Arkadya shifted her attention to Vesna's remaining blade, fingers tightening in preparation to seize it. But before she

could act, Vesna seized her chance. With a swift, precise movement, she slashed low, the left blade cutting through Arkadya's thigh armor and sinking deep into flesh. The scream that followed, raw and piercing, tore through the air—an unmistakable sound of a war-beast brought low.

Arkadya's grip faltered, and Vesna stumbled free. She stood over her fallen commander, chest heaving with exertion and the slow dawning of victory. Arkadya, still conscious but weakened, lay sprawled in the dirt, her thigh bleeding profusely, eyes glaring up at Vesna. The lone sword in Vesna's hand, its crimson-streaked edge gleaming, felt like a scepter in this brutal kingdom. Without hesitation, she drove the blade down, swift and final, into Arkadya's chest. A sharp gasp escaped her lips before her eyes glazed over, the life draining from her as blood pooled into the dust, blooming outward in a dark, scarlet stain.

Vesna held Arkadya's stare until the blue went out of it. She remembered the first red-and-blue scarf Arkadya had allowed her to wear, and the look on Arkadya's face when civilians thanked the Wolves because they were afraid. Vesna had enjoyed that fear more than she admitted. Then steel began sliding into sheaths around the field, and every face turned toward her. Romanova had made her say it aloud years ago: *"Arkadya commands. People hear me faster."*

From the heart of the crowd came a whistle.

Thin, sharp, unmistakable.

Another answered from across the field. Then another. Within seconds the Wolves were whistling from every side of the rough circle, the old death-call folding over Arkadya's body and carrying into the night.

Vesna knew the sound. A Wolf had died, and the pack owed her the whistle.

Then one of the whistles bent toward Vesna's name. Others followed.

Vesna's smile deepened. *This is what it means to be a Wolf*, she thought.

ΔΔΔ

High atop Sopka Nikolskaya loomed Fort Ivan, the formidable stronghold of the Black Wolves. It was one of the rare names that had resisted the Syndicate's tendency to feminize appellations in honor of Zakharovna's legacy—perhaps an unintentional homage to her revered brother, Vesna mused.

For twenty-six years, this granite fortress loomed majestically beneath the stars, defying armies, and all the disorder of the world until the Syndicate united Gred's warring factions in a truce. It was here that the Black Wolves first pledged their allegiance to the city.

Vesna pressed her fingertips against her temples, easing the last remnants of a splitting headache. As the fog of pain finally lifted, her focus sharpened, and she gazed up at the monolithic statue. Though she had visited Fort Ivan many times before, today something was different, a deep conviction that her destiny was bound with this place: twelve thousand tons of foundation stones sprawled across twenty forested hectares, shaped by the relentless Rus winter and the white-capped waters of Fort Ivan's deity, the goddess Velun.

The towering red jasper figure, cloaked in moss and etched with frost scars, seemed more alive than ever. Vesna bowed to Velun, her breath forming misty clouds in the chilly air. She felt the eternal guardian watching over her and her pack, ready to fight alongside them when needed.

Turning from the statue, Vesna approached the fortress. The entrance to the command center was imposing yet solemn, a heavy stone door carved with ancient Slavic runes. She had been told once that each rune carried a story—of battles fought and wisdom earned—but the symbols remained unreadable to her. One rune, pointed out to her long ago, stood for “betrayal,” and she couldn’t forget the way her comrade had traced it, warning her it was a reminder to trust no one fully.

Inside, the command center felt like a wolf’s den, tense and alert. An assembly of elite soldiers stood at attention. Vesna’s gunblades shimmered with latent energy at her side. As she stepped forward, she made sure her gaze swept the room, meeting each soldier’s eyes with cold, unwavering focus. Her posture was rigid, her pace deliberate, ensuring no one could ignore the silent authority she projected. She was here to solidify her position, to remind them all that she was their Alpha and protector of their cause.

As she scanned the room, Vesna took in the faces of the assembly. Warriors and mercenaries from across the peninsula, veterans of the Waste Wars and Gred’s War of Formation. She could feel their scrutiny, measuring her strength and poise, but she refused to let their silent judgment unsettle her. Besides, she had something they lacked: the braids of their former pack leader strung up around her belt.

Taking her place in the circle, Vesna spoke with confidence befitting an Alpha. “Sisters, we stand at a pivotal moment in our history. Our pack must rise to meet the challenges of this new age—to secure our role in this new world.”

The Wolves had become quiet. She inhaled deeply before continuing. “Thirty-five years ago, we started with nothing but an ideal—a single pack of Wolves refusing to be shackled by oppression and extermination. And we succeeded. That ideal has grown into an empire—an unprecedented alliance of not

just the Syndicate and the Wolves, but all who would join us—and we will continue to grow.”

When she spoke again, her tone was low. “And we will succeed. We will grow stronger together than we ever were on our own. And we will *feast*.”

Vesna strode past rows of honorable warriors and indomitable rogues, stopping by a large window to gaze down at the courtyard. Fort Ivan had become a symbol of strength and unity, forged through the blood and determination of its warriors. Now, that ideal faced its greatest test. Integrating the University’s private army with its own ranks threatened to either cement the fort’s formidable standing or fray the unity that was its source of power.

Emanating from the depths of the crowd, a snarl cut through. Vesna clenched her fists with a reflexive response. She squared her shoulders and lifted her chin to see two large women brawling on the floor behind a group of parting soldiers, shadows playing across their muscular bodies and gleaming smiles. Nearby, a table where some of the women had been eating lay scattered with shanks of meat. Vesna grabbed one and tossed it in their direction, drawing a stunned silence from the room.

“Ladies,” she said.

The insult struck its mark. The larger of the two women—towering, barrel-chested, with a shaved head and a face etched with scars—lifted her gaze slowly. Her eyes burned with malice as they locked onto Vesna, her teeth bared in a silent snarl.

“Jarla,” Vesna said, approaching her with hands relaxed at her sides. “Is there some sort of problem?”

The other woman—a leaner, quicker Wolf with raven hair and taut skin—shook herself off and stepped back.

“No problem, Alpha,” Jarla said. She spat on the ground and flashed Vesna a mocking grin. “This one was questioning your choices. Thought I’d take care of her,” she added, pointing to the raven-haired woman.

Vesna’s hands clenched into fists as she stepped forward, her voice low but firm. “Careful, Jarla. You don’t punish anyone without my say. Discipline comes from me, not you.”

“Don’t worry your pretty little head about it,” Jarla growled. Her eyes narrowed, raking across Vesna’s body. “Your Beta is a true Wolf, not some spoiled princess who can’t fight for herself.”

Vesna bit her lip to suppress a snarl. Her instincts told her that Jarla was not only challenging her authority but also ridiculing it. “Enough,” she said, fixing the larger Wolf with a piercing glare. “I won’t tolerate disrespect.”

Jarla’s laughter, a low chuckle, made Vesna’s skin crawl. “You should be respectful of someone who can actually fight,” she said.

“Enough!” Vesna said.

Jarla rolled her eyes at the pack, then shot a sarcastic glance back at Vesna. “Shall we show this spoiled brat the ropes?”

Vesna drew her offhand, the smaller of her two gunblades, leaving the larger one to rest against the table. In the tight space, one weapon would be easier to manage. She lunged at Jarla, their eyes locking in a tense stare. Just as she closed in, a sudden force clamped down on her arm, wrenching it back with brutal strength. Pain shot up her shoulder as she stumbled, her grip loosening. The blade slipped from her fingers and hit the floor with a dull thud.

Vesna squirmed in the iron grip of a tall woman behind her, craning her neck to catch a glimpse of her captor’s face. “Not

so tough without your fancy sword, are you?" Jarla sneered, her voice icy as she stepped forward, palms raised in mocking surrender. Around them, the other Wolves jeered and taunted.

Gritting her teeth, she felt Jarla's hands close around her neck, cutting off her air. The room blurred as she struggled against the veteran brute's strength. Laughter from the other Wolves filled the great hall.

As she clawed at Jarla with her free hand, her fingers found no purchase, and her thoughts, frantic and fleeting, flew to her pack, to the oaths she'd uttered in moments of unity. *I vowed to reshape this city, to expand our force...to make Zakharovna proud.*

With a sudden lurch backward, Vesna collided with the woman holding her, throwing her captor off balance for a brief moment. In that instant of precious leverage, her knee jerked up into Jarla's midsection, expelling the breath from her adversary. The crushing grip around her neck faltered, the larger woman's strength wavering. Seizing the moment, Vesna broke free, her lungs heaving in desperate gulps of air as her hand flew reflexively to the tender bruises forming on her throat.

Vesna watched as Jarla wheezed, struggling to catch her breath, her eyes wide with shock. In the same moment, two of Vesna's lieutenants sprang into action, grabbing the taller woman who had restrained her. They forced her to the ground.

"You're finished," Vesna rasped, her voice strained. She stepped forward, her hand shooting out to clamp around Jarla's throat. Vesna's eyes locked with Jarla's as she tightened her grip, her knuckles white with effort. Jarla's face reddened, her eyes bulging as she gasped for air, clawing at Vesna's wrist. Vesna held firm, watching as Jarla's struggles grew weaker, her skin turning a sickly blue. Moments later,

Jarla's body went limp, her breath fading as she slumped to the floor.

Panting, Vesna surveyed the room. Her pack met her eyes, and in that moment, her triumphant smile held a new depth.

Ousting Arkadya wasn't enough. Now, she had to reprimand *them* as well. Vesna wondered how many more confrontations she'd face before the entire pack submitted to her authority. "You were meant to support me, not mock me," she snarled. "Hours after taking down Arkadya, and you're already testing me? Remember, I'm the Alpha here. You answer to me," Vesna spat at Jarla's cohorts.

Vesna pivoted and gestured for the entire pack to follow, leaving her swords behind. They exited the great hall and moved toward the courtyard. Outside, the wind picked up, clouds roiling in the sky above them. The horizon grew dark.

Entering the courtyard, Vesna couldn't shake the remnants of laughter echoing in her mind. "All of you, gather here," she commanded, raising her hands and stepping back. She regarded the group of women with a scrutinizing gaze. "Line up. I want to see discipline."

"Kneel. *Now!*" Vesna's voice thundered across the courtyard. She watched as the women hesitated, then finally sank to their knees, eyes wide with apprehension.

"Who commands you?"

"You do," they answered in unison, their voices tight with fear as they joined the rest of Jarla's cohort. Their lowered heads said the part their mouths could not.

"Fendra, Selina, prepare the display," Vesna said, nodding toward the bruised clouds gathering over the courtyard. "I want it finished before the hail comes down."

Zakharovna's old lesson about thorns and roses pressed at the back of her mind. Mercy had its place. So did pain. Today, the Wolves needed both to remember who held the leash.

Vesna turned to her lieutenants and the women behind them.

"Wrap it up," she said. Her gaze moved across the courtyard, cold and steady. "And for those of you who thought testing me was clever, try it again. I'll take your throat myself, and I won't need a blade."

No one answered.

Fendra and Selina went to work. The first hailstones struck the courtyard stones as they finished, small white impacts ticking across the blood-dark ground.

Twenty heads hung where Jarla's pack had stood.

The remaining Wolves stared at the ground, shifting beneath Vesna's glare. She gave them nothing more. Then she turned and climbed the rampart walk, her lieutenants trailing behind her like chastened pups.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

ZAKHAROVNA

The sun's rays crested the rooftops, glinting off the frost-laden windows as the cold bit at her skin. Anastasia exhaled, watching her breath rise in a pale mist as she meandered along the riverbank, shivering beneath her thick polyester coat and gloves. She longed for the warmth that spring would bring. In the meantime, her boots crunched on the snow as she crossed the bridge and climbed the icy steps.

The cobblestone path wound up a hill, past dormant fountains and slumbering gardens. Anastasia navigated the twisting route, slipping past dog walkers, amorous couples, and hurried workers. Gripping the guardrails, she moved carefully, aware that a single misstep could send her tumbling. Her breaths grew heavier with each step, but the sight ahead gave her pause: a grand neoclassical edifice, towering over the landscape. Her thoughts drifted to centuries past, imagining robed clerics and lavish gatherings beneath the enduring stonework. For a heartbeat, she let herself believe in it, in the weight of history pressing close, even if none of it truly existed.

Approaching the cathedral, Anastasia observed a steady stream of visitors, some pausing to pray while others hurried across the grounds. She halted before the grand doors, catching her reflection in the fountain's polished surface. Standing tall, she studied the high sweep of her cheekbones and the clear blue of her eyes in the watery mirror. The firm line of her jaw and the fullness of her lips felt distant now. A gust of winter wind tousled her cinnamon brown hair, sending it dancing around her face. She gazed deeper into the reflection, searching for the young woman she once knew.

After a moment, she drew in a steadying breath and turned away from the fountain. The doors loomed ahead, silent and cold beneath the morning light. She reached for the handle and stepped inside.

Entering the cathedral, Anastasia took in the vaulted ceiling, its intricate stonework and vivid murals casting a quiet majesty over the space. The air was calm, though the scattered presence of others reminded her of the sanctuary this place had become in the wake of the war. She hadn't expected such a crowd. Dozens filled the pews, their faces lit by candlelight, gathered for the memorial. Some were familiar, others not. A few still wore traces of night makeup, a reminder of the world Virginia had once ruled. The scent of wax and wilted flowers lingered in the air. Anastasia watched them in silence, uncertain whether they had come to mourn her or to ease their own guilt.

At the altar, she knelt, murmuring prayers into the silence before rising, a quiet unease stirring within her. She paused, sensing a faint change in the stillness, a presence she hadn't noticed before. Turning, her gaze settled on a figure cloaked in shadow, their face hidden beneath the heavy folds of a woolen cloak.

"Anastasia," the woman whispered, "you were always there for her." The words caught Anastasia off guard. It took a moment for the name to settle as she took in the dim glow of candles around the altar, realizing she had arrived later than she meant to.

The woman lowered her hood, revealing a face half lost to shadow, uncannily familiar. The same blue eyes and the same gentle curve of the mouth made it feel as though Virginia had returned from the grave. "My sister spoke so fondly of you," the woman said softly.

Anastasia's breath caught. "I'm so sorry," she murmured, her hand trembling as she reached out. "I should have been there for her. I'm so sorry."

The woman let out a quiet sob as they embraced, their grief meeting in a fragile silence. When they pulled apart, tears shimmered in the woman's eyes. "Thank you," she whispered. "It means everything that you're here."

The woman pulled a white babushka from her bag, its yellow roses patterned delicately across each carefully folded crease. Anastasia stared at it, her mind struggling to place what she already knew too well. The memory came back to her as she pictured the cold morning by the Neris River, the two of them wrapped in that same scarf while hail clattered over the cobblestones.

Anastasia lifted the scarf and draped it around her neck, the faint scent still the same after all these years. She remembered giving it up once, leaving it behind in a moment of anger she could no longer justify. "I thought I'd forgotten this," she murmured, her fingers brushing the label where her name was scripted in elegant lettering.

Clutching the scarf, Anastasia's eyes filled with tears. "I never should have let it go," she whispered.

"My name is Vilka. I'll be outside. I'm glad you're here," the woman said softly before turning to leave.

"I know," Anastasia said quietly, but Vilka had already slipped through the door.

Left alone, Anastasia turned toward the altar. Tears streamed down her cheeks as she knelt, eyes closed, praying aloud. Her words echoed in the quiet, but the silence within her heart remained unbroken. "I commend you, my dear friend, to Almighty God and entrust you to your Creator. May you rest in the arms of the Lord who formed you from the dust of the earth."

Anastasia rose from her knees, the echo of her whispered prayers lingering in the sacred stillness. Stepping outside the cathedral, she saw Vilka standing as a silhouette against the sunlight.

They linked arms, and as they walked, the space between them seemed to fade away. Vilka, once distant and unknown—a sister Anastasia had only heard of in passing, mentioned rarely by Virginia—now brought her a quiet sense of comfort.

As they made their way toward the park, Vilka's voice broke the silence. "You must be wondering why I've been absent all this time," she said. "I couldn't even bring myself to go to the funeral. I told myself there was no point, but the truth is, I was afraid. I didn't want to see her like that."

Anastasia looked at her, her voice low. "I almost didn't come here today."

Vilka nodded, her gaze fixed ahead. "Then maybe coming now means we're both ready to stop running from her."

Anastasia felt the weight of Vilka's words settle in. Virginia's illness had carved deep wounds within the family. Vilka, Anastasia had learned, had kept the darkest truths from their ailing parents, sparing them further anguish when they were already consumed by their own battles with terminal illness. Anastasia saw it in her eyes, the kind of pain that came only from love held too long in silence. It was a choice made out of care, now edged with the sharpness of regret. Grief, Anastasia realized through Vilka's quiet confession, followed no rules. And in her silence, Vilka had endured that heartache alone.

Together, they walked along the riverbank, their conversation flowing easily as they shared stories of their families. Vilka spoke of choosing Oxford for her studies, while Virginia had returned to Lithuania, the land their ancestors had called home three generations ago. Their parents had fled

the Soviet occupation in the 1960s, seeking refuge abroad. As Vilka explained how their family had dropped the “vasius” from their surname, Attraevasius, to make it sound more English—or maybe French—she let out a small chuckle. “Virginia always used to say we sounded like high-fashion models or rock stars with a name like that,” she added, her expression softening with the memory.

Her smile faded as her tone grew somber. “I spent so much time at university, pretending everything was normal,” Vilka admitted with a frown. “By the time I realized what was really happening, it was too late. I wish I had visited her more, called more often. I was so caught up in my own world that I missed how much she was struggling.”

“I didn’t see it either,” Anastasia confessed, her voice soft as she shared Vilka’s pain. “I was so wrapped up in my work that I missed Virginia’s suffering. I wish I had been there for her, the way she was always there for me.”

“It’s hard to know how to handle situations like that,” Vilka said. “But having you here now lightens the weight. It helps to speak with someone who understands.”

As they neared the cemetery, Anastasia noticed the familiar line of towering cypress trees that bordered its edge, their dark forms rising against the horizon. Cresting the hill, the white marble walls came into view, glowing faintly in the evening light. A wrought-iron gate stood just ahead, a silent marker that they had almost arrived. “We’re close,” Vilka said.

The path shifted from dirt to soft grass as they neared the cemetery’s entrance, marked by an elegant four-centered arch. Stepping through, they took in the view of the city beyond rows of tombstones.

The city’s architecture, charming and aged, lay before them, houses nestled close together with facades weathered by time. The low skyline reminded Anastasia of her high school years

in Moscow, the streets laid out in neat rectangles with angled intersections. She had been here before, but never in winter, and the snow-laced rooftops gave the city a softness she hadn't noticed until now. "It's beautiful here," Anastasia said quietly, the scene unexpectedly captivating her.

Vilka nodded, her gaze lingering on the distant horizon. "Yes, it is."

Anastasia's gaze fell on two unassuming stones, marking the resting places of a woman and a cherub. She knelt before them for the first time, her knees sinking into the cold earth. Tears welled in her eyes as her thoughts turned to a quiet plea: *Virginia, please forgive me. I'm so sorry I wasn't there when you needed me most.*

Behind the graves, a towering angel statue stood with its head lifted and wings unfurled. The angel's serene face radiated love, but it was the Latin inscription on its chest that captured Anastasia's attention most. Drawing on distant memories of her Latin lessons, she traced the familiar words: *NON OMNIS MORIAR. Not all of me will die.*

The surrounding elm trees stood barren, their branches outstretched like futile pleas for renewal. Gray maples, too, were leafless, and Zakharovna's thoughts drifted to distant memories of the blue siberica flowers that once adorned the graveyard each spring, a recollection buried under the weight of decades. The absence of those blooms struck her with a sharp pang of loss.

As the boundary between virtual reality and memory blurred, Zakharovna found herself sitting on the ground beside Vilka, her mind heavy with the question of whether to stay. It felt as if a forgotten shard of her soul was calling her to linger, to remain among the echoes of her past.

CHAPTER NINETEEN

YELENA

Blanka flipped her pale gold hair, the borrowed earrings twinkling golden in the light. “They somehow look better on me, don’t you think?”

Daria looked at her with a playful edge to her voice. “Wishful thinking, Blanka. They’re meant for someone a little more petite.”

Blanka laughed heartily. “Well, better wear them now. In ten years, my ears might be too grand for any jewelry at all!”

Daria fanned herself, a smirk on her face. “Honey, unlike some, I plan to age with grace. But do keep the earrings. By then, they might be the only thing not sagging on you... Speaking of changes, is it me or is this room turning into a sauna?”

Just then, Roza walked in, looking around in confusion. “Where did I leave my ice pack? These hot flashes make me feel like I’m in the Valley of Geysers!”

Daria chuckled. “Roza, if hot flashes were frequent flyer miles, we’d have left this planet years ago. But unfortunately, we’re stuck with menopause, forever.”

Roza rolled her eyes, chuckling. “Well, I’m just grateful that ‘ol Gred is as cold as an Eskimo’s outhouse. If our city ever lost its frosty charm, I’d probably end up melted into a puddle like a discarded ice cream cone!”

Blanka smirked, adjusting her new earrings. “And heavens forbid if that stubborn ice cloud over the Pacific ever decides to call it quits! I’d miss the winter galas! But knowing my luck, that’s when my fluffy fur coat would decide to come back in style!”

Yelena had stopped believing years ago that the wall's persistence was entirely meteorological. Babushka was in it somewhere; whether Zakharovna had learned to command the storm or merely understood what did was another question, one she had never answered.

Eyeing the screen, Yelena let out a soft sigh. "Galina, even the comedy has turned bleak, don't you think?"

In the silence that followed, Yelena could almost hear the weight of her own words. She turned to face Mayor Galina Rylova, scanning her for any signs of agreement.

"It's the harsh truth of our world," Rylova murmured.

Yelena nodded, discontent swirling in her chest. "Where's the forward spirit? The vigor? The hope?" She stared at the screen, her question lingering in the air.

"As long as these shows distract the public, I suppose bleakness will do," the Mayor replied with a resigned shrug. "Virtual reality...it's no replacement for the real thing. The more people keep their eyes locked on these old TV sets, the better. Heaven knows there's enough propaganda flooding the Arkyv as it is."

"I suppose so," Yelena muttered in reluctant agreement. "Speaking of propaganda, Galina, how's the progress at the labs?"

"All in top order, Matron," Rylova said. "We're only waiting on some...substrate."

Yelena nodded, her thoughts drifting to the seasoned warrior who was now an indispensable cog in their operation—their star recruiter. "I trust Klara will get the job done. She always does."

Rylova merely replied with a curt nod, confirming the shared trust in their propagandist-in-chief. Their

conversation was cut short as an urgent news headline blared from the television.

VESNA VOLKOVA NAMED ALPHA COMMANDER OF THE BLACK WOLVES.

The announcement hit Yelena like a punch, outrage flaring within her as she rose from her chair. "This is treason! Preposterous!" she shouted at the TV, fury rising as she stood. "Only one person would dare foment such change now."

Rylova responded with a hint of annoyance in her voice that belied her typically composed demeanor, "Though not unexpected. It seems Zakharovna hasn't run off to hide after all. You should know her better than that. You left an opening, and she took it."

Cursing under her breath, Yelena shot back, "Where did she manage to find this little brat? Who is this Volkova?"

Rylova's expression shifted before she touched the device. "Volkova. My sister used to come home from Reconstruction shifts with that name written across her board in red grease pencil." She opened the file anyway. "Seems she was part of Zakharovna's security detail during her former Matronage, and look at this, she worked under you too, back when she was still a pup." Her mouth tightened with wry recognition. "Pulled out of retirement at exactly the wrong time."

With her jaw clenched, Yelena said, "Gather a full dossier on this woman. I want every detail, everything we can find on her."

Rylova nodded her agreement, rising to leave the room just as Valentina hurried in. Valentina's auburn locks were as disheveled as ever. But the usual spark in her green eyes was replaced with a burning fiery resolve, a sight that Yelena found surprisingly invigorating. A tingle of affection stirred within her at the sight of her beloved niece.

“Pra Matron,” Valentina greeted, her voice a mix of respect and urgency. Yelena’s lips curved into a teasing smile at her title.

“Now, now, Valentina. Don’t forget your own station. As interim Chair, your power is considerably more substantial than you imagine.”

Valentina swallowed hard, the gravity of the unfolding situation seeming to seep into her voice, “What should we do about this...development?”

“Come sit,” Yelena beckoned her niece to the window seat beside her. As Valentina slid into the plush cushions, Yelena cradled her tense face. “My dear Valentina,” she said, “remember the old tale of the fox and the wolf? The wolf was bigger, stronger, and faster. But the fox—she was clever. When the wolf cornered her, the fox did not attempt to overpower the wolf. Instead, she distracted him long enough to slip away. She understood that a strong arm has less value than a crafty mind when in a tight spot.”

Yelena held Valentina’s emerald gaze. She leaned back, her hands folding in her lap. “For others, power earned through cunning is often seen as far less legitimate than power earned through strength. Your mother, Katerina—Gods rest her soul—was a formidable force within the Black Wolves, one of the most potent enforcers of the Syndicate. Even she would have known that the key to defeating Vesna from the outside lies not in battering her head-on but by turning the pack against her. We need to convince them that their leader secured her position not by force or merit, but by deception. For in their twisted hierarchy, guile is the ultimate transgression.”

Yelena paused, letting her words sink in for Valentina. She knew this approach would shake the foundations of the Wolves’ pack mentality. Now it was just a matter of fostering

the seeds of doubt. “We need to act swiftly. This Vesna is a puppet in Zakharovna’s game, and for us to seize control, we must expose this deceit to her Wolves.”

“I understand. I’ll get our agents on the ground to start the rumor mill and seed the Arkyv with some carefully curated data.”

At this, Yelena chuckled, feeling a spark of pride. “Now you’re thinking clearly, my dear. But remember, sometimes the truth packs a more potent punch than even a well-crafted rumor. This Volkova, she reeks of inexperience. I suspect she hasn’t managed this feat of usurpation all on her own. And knowing our enemies’ tendency to play dirty, I’m sure there’s a bigger scheme involved.”

Yelena leaned forward. “We’ll investigate this, uncover every detail. In the meantime, the Black Wolves are sworn to the Board; they belong to you, Valentina. It’s time they were reminded of that. Defection, there will be. But we have just as many loyalists who are honor-bound to our cause, and to Gred.”

Valentina bit her lip before responding, “Okay. I’ll set up a presser and invoke Article VI. But there might be some contention. The article states that the Wolves serve the current Pra Matron Chair and the city seems divided on who that is: some say it’s Tatyana as she’s about to ascend, while others believe it’s Zakharovna, even though she’s lost her Chairwomanship. “The Charter doesn’t explicitly say how the Wolves answer to an interim Chair. We’ve never been at these crossroads.”

“Valentina, politics, like life, isn’t about documentation or formalities. At the end of the day, power is about leverage. And your leverage comes from the people. Show them the veracity of your spirit, the sincerity of your commitment.”

She lifted Valentina's chin. "Remember, the people don't care about words on a piece of paper. They care about who holds their best interests at heart. You've led the unions with grace and conviction. People love you, Valentina. You're more than just a name in the Charter to them; you're a beacon of hope, the one person they know will fight for them till the end. Stand your ground, my dear. You are the true Pra Matron Chair. They will follow you, just as the Black Wolves should and will."

Yelena watched as Valentina's eyes widened, quick understanding flashing across her features. "You... You were never going to relinquish our position before the Ascension ceremony, were you?"

"My dear, the city's true ascension will come when the people see the power of their votes. The first ballot in our new war has already been cast, and soon, they will join you."

"Understood," Valentina said. Yelena caught the quick nod, that familiar gesture signaling Valentina's sharp intellect, always quick to grasp even the most complex situations. With her usual confident stride, Valentina rose and left the room.

As Valentina's footsteps faded, Yelena turned to the window overlooking the plaza. The time-worn shell of the once-grand Hotel Kamchatsky stood rigid at the corner, while in the distance, Avachinsky Volcano loomed over snow-dusted fields. The bare skeletons of aspen and rowan trees dotted the landscape, their yellow-gray branches cutting stark silhouettes against the pale winter sky. They punctuated the snow's quiet, like muted declarations of resilience against the grip of winter.

She redirected her gaze to the plaza. Among the buildings and the bustling crowd, Yelena's eyes searched for someone absent—Zakharovna.

Where is she? What is she plotting?

Zakharovna's absence at the University unsettled Yelena; the silence in the lectures, where she usually reveled in praise, was glaring. It wasn't like Zakharovna to step away from the spotlight—especially now, free from the political constraints the Board had lifted. Yelena had considered that decision a mercy.

She had earned her reprieve, released early from the stranglehold of office. But her silence now, in these crucial times... *Have we been too lenient?* Yelena wondered, unease creeping in with every thought of her old adversary's quiet retreat into the shadows.

And Romanova's stillness was equally unsettling. *Would she not seize the chance to fill the power vacuum left by Zakharovna's absence?* Leveling more accusations of misconduct wasn't an option now; Yelena had initiated Zakharovna's fall, and that had come and gone. *The Battalion remains ominously subdued. They're plotting, certainly,* she mused, sensing the calm before the storm.

The Black Wolves' diversion added a new headache to her growing list of problems. It smacked of Zakharovna's handiwork—too trivial for her masterstroke but disruptive all the same. *A feint, no doubt, to obscure her real game.* The rebellion needed to be crushed, quickly, effectively. And Valentina, she was still so young, so uncertain.

She needs to breed more confidence, project a sturdy image, she thought, her mind already working on a new public relations strategy.

As Yelena watched the sun dip behind the volcano, she knew the reins of control needed to be tightened. The future of the city depended on it.

Straightening from her reflective stance, Yelena's hand smoothed the creases from her gray pant suit. She wrapped her babushka, a pattern of honeycomb in striking yellows and

blacks, around her neck and head. A nod to her power, a symbol of her authority. Taking a stride away from the window and out of the room, her heels clicked against the polished floor of the Hive's administrative offices, an austere wing within the imposing edifice of City Hall.

Yelena moved down the hushed corridor, each face turned towards her, each nod a deferential acknowledgement of her leadership. Every silent salutation, a reminder of the weight she bore.

As the day's fading light kissed the distant mountains, Yelena's passage through the glass-enclosed skywalk brought the sprawl of Gred into soft focus. The gleaming geothermal reactors and towering skyscrapers dominated the horizon, yet Ludmila's chamber stood apart—a weathered, archaic doorway framed against the modern world, its stone facade a relic of another time. Yelena approached, ready for the meeting deferred but not forgotten.

Crossing the threshold, Yelena's gaze lingered on the curio cabinet beside the desk. Its relics—old Russian coins, bone carvings, and faded photographs—anchored the room in the city's storied past. The faint scent of parchment mingled with the sharp notes of lemongrass and ginger tea.

Stirring honey into her cup, Ludmila glanced up through worn spectacles. "Yelena, would you care for some tea?"

Yelena nodded as she lowered herself into a chair. Ludmila poured a second cup, the steam curling up and blending with the room's stillness, heavy with the weight of history.

As Yelena took a sip, letting the warmth settle within her, Ludmila's voice cut through the silence with the sharpness of an old proverb. "The reed that bends in the wind is stronger than the mighty oak that breaks in a storm."

Her yellowed eyes gleamed, nearly a century of hard-earned wisdom behind them. Yelena considered the weight of those

years, wondering if Ludmila still cherished her Methuselah-like longevity or if it had become a burden.

“Your mother was much like the reed,” Ludmila continued.

Flickers of her mother’s image danced before Yelena’s eyes, the resolute first lady of the Constitutional Republicans. She lingered on the memory of her most pivotal act: bridging the chasm between her forces and Zakharovna’s Black Wolves, a union fortified in the fires of a defensive war against the Strangers. “She was certainly pliant,” Yelena murmured. *But still, she broke*, and Yelena refused that fate.

Her voice sharpened with impatience, “You’ve seen the end she met. Spare me the fables, Ludmila. What’s the crux of your strategy?”

“Her husband broke her, just as Zakharovna’s spirit bears the scars of her brother. We women have too often been oaks in our own right, yet reeds in the service of our men. But that resilience, that capacity to bend, is where true strength lies. As for Zakharovna, in truth, she long ago lost her taste for war, haunted as she is by the specter of her brother’s demise. She seeks not dominion but enlightenment. Her quiet now is the stillness before her dawn.”

Yelena’s brow creased as she took in the meaning behind Ludmila’s cryptic omen. Zakharovna’s silence could be mistaken for inaction, yes, but Yelena understood now, just as she had suspected—it was, in fact, the hush of calculation.

“With Zakharovna’s impending consolidation,” Ludmila said, pausing as if to choose her next words carefully, “you have an opportunity. To weather the storm ahead, you must use the calm that precedes it.”

“What calm? The Black Wolves grow restless; their loyalty is not to be assumed. The Battalion is surely already courting them, and those faithful to Zakharovna should begin to defect

any day now,” Yelena said, her mind already turning over Ludmila’s counsel like stones in a river.

“A swift strike, then, to solidify your hold. Now is the time to act, while Tatyana is preoccupied with Zakharovna’s motives.”

“But how? A reed bends in the breeze; it doesn’t lead an assault.”

“Who said anything about *you* bending? From time to time, the wind may come to a brief pause. It is precisely then, my dear, that you gather your reeds and make a lash.”

“But what good is a lash against an oak?”

Ludmila sighed, reaching over to give Yelena’s arm a playful but firm tap with a rolled-up newspaper. “Oh, stop being such a prattling bore, dear, follow along. You gather these cords and draw them together like a long fuse—oh, you know what I’m getting at, enough already.”

Yelena laughed and felt the knot of anxiety in her stomach loosen slightly. “And the Ascension?”

Ludmila leaned closer, her tone taking on a grave note, “A spark, carefully placed and timed, can set all the future ablaze. And if you’re careful, its legacy won’t be told in the scars of charred stones, but in the whispers of renewal.”

“The Ascension awaits you. But remember, though there may be strength in numbers, the only number that truly matters is one—the one who unites, the one who leads.” She paused, her voice steady. “So, let them bend, and you, Yelena—*lead*.”

CHAPTER TWENTY

MARIA

Maria surfaced slowly, the cube's hum and the terminal's faint whirl pulling her back from the dive. She drew a long breath, letting the digital after-images fade. Gaspar's claim to know her location nagged at her. *Hack me? Good luck.*

She checked the logs. No unauthorized traces. That was a relief, though it wasn't unexpected. The zk-SNARK layers were still holding. If Gaspar had anything, he hadn't shown it.

Beside her, Serafim lay under the headset. The glow traced across her face, dark hair tugged loose where the interface pulled. For a moment Maria almost thought she stirred, but the stillness held.

How long's she been under? How long was I out?

Maria was wiped. A yawn caught halfway and snapped into a sneeze as her system pinged. SOVA again, the Sentient Ocular Virtual Assistant she usually kept muted. Nearly every ocular carried some descendant of the old chatbots. They translated speech, searched local archives, summarized feeds, and watched the body wearing them. Routine replies wrote themselves. People had stopped calling any of that a chatbot years ago. It was interface plumbing, useful enough to disappear. Most kept the functions and muted the voice. Some alerts still forced their way through. This one carried its usual impatience. *"Maria, time to wake up."*

"What do you think I'm doing?"

She blinked hard, trying to steady herself, when SOVA pushed again, voice softened with a simulated sigh. *"I know it's not easy, but we need you back."*

“Working on it,” Maria muttered. She braced as static crawled across her nerves, the disconnect rippling through her implants.

“Efficiency’s the trade-off,” SOVA said, fading with the link.

Maria let the silence settle. Her head throbbed with the unavoidable weight, the price of diving direct. The others’ headsets spread the load, splitting fragments of thought across mirrored substrates. *They’ll never feel this. Only me.* Her dives forced everything through her own cortex, no buffers, burning it in raw. It wore her down faster, but it cut deeper and struck quicker than anything else. That edge had saved her friends before. When Shatterveil’s gambit turned out to be a ruse, Dunya, dazed but breathing, had stumbled out laughing, grateful for croissants and billiards that night like never before.

A fresh ping cut across the quiet, sharper than SOVA’s fade. Matron Romanova’s voice pressed through the new link, stern and close. “Maria, are you still with us? You’ve been out of touch for too long.”

Maria blinked into the warehouse gloom, the broken windows letting in only scraps of moonlight. With a thought, she brought her ocular online.

Romanova resolved in her vision, sharp lines of light coalescing into a spectral figure. The contours flickered with each shift, but the presence was undeniable. Maria’s gaze caught on the matron’s chin, the same imperious angle she remembered from their first meeting in the underground.

Her fingers ached at the memory, the Wolves clawing at her as though already marking her for quarantine. She had struggled for breath then, certain they would drag her back.

“You sound...less than well,” Romanova said.

Maria sighed. “We failed to breach. We need to regroup and find a new way in.”

“Never underestimate Zakharovna. That trap was skillfully hidden.”

Maria blinked, trying to clear the shimmering distortions across her vision. In the corner of her ocular feed a diagram of her occipital lobe pulsed red. The flash grenade from the Spire sim had cut deeper than she’d allowed herself to admit.

She tapped her forehead and pulled up her HUD. Neural pathways to the optic nerve glowed with interference, nanobots swarming through the field. They began repairs, dosing her with painkillers as they released enzymes and cellular regenerators.

“My fault,” she admitted, eyes scanning the sensory diagnostics. *Core processors steady, no critical faults, no system glitches.* “I miscalculated.”

“You weren’t alone in that,” Romanova reassured her. “Perhaps if we had disabled some non-essential systems first, we could have evaded detection.”

“Maybe. But hitting the Spire was necessary,” Maria said. “We needed a vantage point. From up there, I could have seen Zakharovna’s whole lattice, traced every link, every choke. That was how we were supposed to break it apart, layer by layer.” She exhaled, the frustration still there. “Instead, we got dumped the second we reached the top. The climb was back-encrypted. We start from further out this time. Find the soft nodes. Work our way back in.”

“Agreed,” Romanova said. “So, let’s bring Dunya into the fold. I want the three of you to evaluate your options before another breach.”

Maria hesitated. “After Vesna...”

Romanova's gaze held steady. "I understand your doubt. We've watched her closely. She's under immense pressure, yet she remains steadfast. There's no sign of her faltering. She is still one of the ANGELS at heart, though perhaps too trusting. Should Vesna reach for her old police contacts, I believe Dunya would resist being drawn into it. We've profiled her enough to be confident. We need her skills, Maria, and I trust her motives. It's time she knows we all do."

"Understood. I'll be ready as soon as she's online." The split between them still weighed on her. Maybe she'd waited too long to reach out. It should have been Dunya with her in the Spire, not Serafim. Her best friend, not a tool.

Her gaze slid to Serafim, lying quietly on the couch, headset still glowing. She turned back to Romanova, forcing a small smile. "How about you, Matron? With all that's happening, how are you holding up?"

"I'm managing, but truthfully, my relief at your escape overshadows everything else right now. The thought of what those agents might have done had they trapped you in *virtual*... It's unnerving. As for the University's primary observatory hub, infiltrating it was always a gamble."

"Doesn't make it hurt any less. I'm sick of taking losses."

Romanova looked at her, eyes softening in a way that Maria interpreted as sympathy. "We'll try again. Let me devise a new plan."

"Thank you, Pra Matron." Maria paused, collecting herself. "The fight doesn't stop. It eats at you, pushes until there's nothing left but resolve. Every loss just sharpens it. We learn, we adapt. And when we break through their walls, we'll be ready."

"I'm glad to see you're still thriving amidst the chaos of our predicaments. The real question is what steps we'll take once

we've penetrated their system, and the implications could be frightening."

Romanova paused.

"But we won't truly understand until we succeed. Farewell, Maria." The Pra Matron's voice faded as she cut the connection.

She exhaled, breath fogging in the chilly air as she leaned against the terminal. *Failure isn't an option.*

Maria skirted the debris on the warehouse floor, crates and cables scattered between shards of broken glass that crunched under her steps. At the far wall she reached the makeshift barrier by the window, lifting the corner of the garbage bag taped in place as a blackout curtain. Silver light from the moons strained against advancing shadows. In the shifting glow, a smear of gray pulled her eye to the distance. An ice cloud hovered there, ominous, and for a moment she wondered if it signaled another hailstorm.

As if answering her concerns, the ocular whirred to life, pulling weather feeds from the University's stratospheric drones, solar balloons drifting above the storm belt with their sensors trained inward on the peninsula. SOVA's voice came in her ear: "*No storms threaten the coast, but extreme winds are churning the seas.*" For a moment Maria let herself imagine sailing the Pacific, before the thought collapsed against the cryonic wall that had long sealed the routes. The drones could watch the skies over Kamchatka, but beyond the storm their vision failed. The city's fleet remained bound to oil surveys and mineral sweeps in the Bering Sea.

Maria turned from the window and crossed back to the center of the warehouse, picking her way through the clutter on the floor. A tap to her ocular synced the cube into comms mode, its low hum filling the empty space. The sound seemed her only companion, steady against the fatigue of repeated

failures. In a city that pretended at eternity, she knew better. Friends vanished. Memories slipped from the Arkyv. She queued another painkiller through her ocular, the dose sliding cold behind her eyes. Relief came in fragments, never enough, fading even as the night stretched on.

Her gaze fixed on the hardlight display above the cube, hues shifting faintly across its surface and tinting her hands. Her ocular caught the signal and turned thought into text, each idea flashing into form. Notes hung in the air as three-dimensional glyphs, sentences weaving together like echoes suspended in the dark. Every flicker of her eyes, every strain of focus, rippled through the display as it bent to her will.

“I’ve been out of touch,” she began. That felt like an understatement. Her mind stretched back to Anna’s apartment, the failed graft, and the confusion that had split them afterward. “I wish I could say it was all part of the plan, but we hit a roadblock.”

“I wasn’t captured,” she wrote, her own skepticism tugging at the words. She knew it must have looked like she had been. The silence, her sudden disappearance after the mission. All she could do now was hope Dunya would take it as truth.

“Our first assault fell flat. The Syndicate’s security is more advanced than we’d imagined.” Maria refrained from adding, *more than I’d imagined*, her ego wincing at the implication. “But it’s far from a lost cause. We’re regrouping, searching for fresh entry points.”

She paused, reading the message once more. “Stay sharp. Hold the line. We’ll find a way in.”

Her message sent, Maria watched as the words disintegrated into a swarm of voxels, vanishing into the neon dreams of the babachain. She exhaled slowly, allowing herself a brief respite in the silence of the warehouse.

Dunya's reply flashed across the hardlight from a remote node, sharp and burning. "So, you are alive."

Maria drew in a sharp breath. She'd braced for Dunya's anger, but watching it flare across the hardlight still hit raw. Her mind moved fast, shaping a reply before the moment slipped.

"Listen, Dunya," Maria wrote, the hardlight flickering with restrained heat. "Going dark wasn't desertion. After Anna's graft, I had to disappear. Too many eyes, too many unknowns. If I'd reached out, they could've traced it back to you. I wasn't about to hand Syn the map."

Dunya shot back in red. "You've become a ghost. Ghosts don't build trust."

Maria swallowed hard. The words dug deep, dragging up their laughter on the frontlines, the closeness that had once felt unbreakable. The sting sharpened her next retort.

"War makes ghosts of us all," Maria wrote back. "I vanished to keep us alive. If we're pulling at threads, why did our link drop before the override?"

"I didn't break the link. You did. When I came around, you were crashing. What was I supposed to do? Stick around and wait for the artillery to show up while you flatlined?"

The accusation burned, but beneath it a certainty held. *I didn't break the link...the override didn't work*, she thought, trying to stitch together the fractured memory.

"Protocol's one thing," Maria wrote back. "But we've never been strictly by the book, have we? Something more happened, didn't it, Dunya?"

Maria caught a faint rustle from the couch. Fabric shifted, and Serafim pushed herself upright, rubbing at her temples with a low groan. The headset's teal glow faded as she unlatched it and set it aside. She blinked against the dim

light, then swung her legs to the floor and steadied herself there.

Serafim reached for the nearby cube, fingers brushing its surface as her user profile materialized in the hardlight display. She met Maria's gaze, a silent signal that she felt the strain between them.

Without a word, she began preparing a note. "This isn't productive," she projected in green, "nor is it helping our cause. There are reasons and secrets buried within all of us. It's time we brought some of them to light. Dunya, it was me. I tampered with your operation. To shield you, to protect us all."

Maria studied her, every flicker across the feed feeding her doubt. Had Serafim been waiting for the right crack to open? The timing was too clean to believe otherwise.

"You promised you wouldn't follow us into Anna's graft," Maria wrote. "That run was ours, not yours."

Dunya cut in before Serafim could answer. "The graft? You told her?" The text spiked crimson. "God, Maria—op-sec means nothing to you? What else have you handed out?"

Serafim didn't flinch. "The two of you wouldn't have come out alive without me. Trust me on that."

"You. I knew there was another signal inside Anna's graft," Dunya wrote. "You're an ANGEL too. Why lie to my face? Why break into our link?"

Maria wrote, "Dunya, there's history here. Between Serafim and me. Layers you're not seeing yet."

"You kept her a secret. And what the hell was that whole performance? The smoke and mirrors, the ambush. Couldn't you have just asked for what you were after?"

Serafim hesitated. "I set that up. I thought—"

Dunya cut her off. “Don’t use my name like you know me. You made a choice and never thought to include me in it.”

“We’ve been in tighter spots,” Serafim countered. “Anna’s graft wasn’t just another job. It was part of something much larger. I did what I had to do to keep the mission alive.”

“We?” Dunya replied. “Who the hell are *you* to include yourself in our ‘we’, Serafim? And who keeps you in check? Your ‘bigger mission’ might’ve been our end.” There was a brief crackle, as though Dunya was about to disconnect. “We’ll see if your ‘greater good’ was worth the fallout.” Then the channel went silent.

Maria slumped into her seat, the babachain’s static pressing in again.

A new message flashed, lines of text unfolding into an operation file. One mark froze her: Romanova’s signature.

Dunya’s reply followed hard on it: “You’re in bed with the Battalion now? How can you expect me to trust a play straight out of a Pra Matron’s book, with you suddenly under her wing? I’ve heard the stories, Maria. She’s not one of us. This isn’t just about the job. It’s about where you stand. You’ve always walked a thin line, but with Romanova? That’s a leap I’m not ready to take with you.”

The message faded, leaving the warehouse air heavy. Maria sat with it, the weight of Dunya’s reproach hanging in the quiet.

Serafim started. “I...”

Maria held up a hand, silencing her. “Not now.” She knew Dunya’s trust had been shattered, their alliance strained beyond repair. The question lingered unspoken: *Where do we go from here?*

“Dunya wasn’t just angry,” Maria said, her fingers absently tracing dust into the cracked leather of the seat. “She was...disturbed. Something under the rage.”

She’d kept the conversation to hardlight text, knowing Dunya’s limits with visual strain. It had worked before during arguments over resource splits or who got the lead avatar. The calm never lasted, but it kept them from breaking apart. Not this time. The text hadn’t softened her. This fight wasn’t like the others. *Not that showing you my face would have changed anything, Dun.*

Why had Romanova been so certain reaching out now was the move? It hadn’t worked.

“She has reasons to be angry,” Serafim said.

“This was different,” Maria said. “Something’s been roused in her. And I know Dunya. I’ve seen her scars, her battles. But this... This is new.”

Maria sat there after the feed went dark, replaying every word.

Maria felt Serafim’s hand rest lightly on her shoulder. “Dunya’s tough. She’ll come around. We had to push her, test her resilience. If she’s going to stand against the Syndicate, she needs to be able to push back, hard.”

Maria exhaled. “I get it, but part of me wishes I’d been able to reach her. She’s got every right to be pissed, especially after what Syn did to her family. If Dunya goes rogue now, with that kind of fire in her...she could torch everything in her path.”

Serafim’s gaze held hers. “And you’d rather risk her burning it all down than me pulling you out? You’d both be dead if I hadn’t stepped in. The cut lit up the Wolves, Maria. If you hadn’t been faster than half their net, they’d have hauled you off then and there. You were lucky. Lucky Romanova had eyes on you.”

Maria's jaw tightened. "You promised. The graft was ours."

"Promises mean little when the Syndicate's grid is already closing," Serafim said evenly. "You're running hot, Maria. Moving too fast. You think speed is the edge, but sometimes it's just noise. Be careful it doesn't burn you before it burns them."

Maria looked away, the old unease creeping back in. Trusting Serafim was still beyond her.

Serafim's eyes stayed on her, steady and unflinching. "Maybe that fire she's carrying is exactly what we need. After everything she's been through... Zakharovna won't see her coming."

The words sent a chill through her. It wasn't strategy anymore. They were courting chaos, pretending they could contain it.

CHAPTER TWENTY ONE

DUNYA

“Where fire meets wood yet neither burn, your true quest will take a turn.”

Dunya sat by the window, her ocular shimmering with the cryptic riddle that had consumed her for the better part of the day. She blinked twice to clear her vision, her gaze refocusing on the cityscape beyond the glass. She’d made the call after a long prayer at the cathedral, realizing then that she was being watched but would not be detained.

Her last call kept replaying. Serafim had surfaced inside Maria’s operation, and Dunya had responded by sending her coordinates to the Syndicate. A clean retaliatory move, except it had solved nothing. Vesna was still missing. Maria was still lying.

Dunya had spent years trusting Maria’s signatures, timing, and instincts. Now every old job looked contaminated in retrospect. She could audit the friendship later, assuming there was anything left to audit.

A new contract waited. Contracts, at least, admitted they wanted something.

She copied the riddle into her notebook. Handwriting slowed the input enough for structure to emerge.:

“Where fire meets wood yet neither burn, your true quest will take a turn.” Her mind automatically began dissecting the phrase, separating metaphor from literal meaning, testing various interpretations as if running decryption algorithms. *Fire and wood, neither burn...*

Gred had its share of places where fire met wood—dangerous factories, black-market labs—but none where they

coexisted without consumption. As she sifted through the labyrinthine corners of the metropolis, one place continually surfaced, despite her best efforts to ignore it: the Veil of Unburning, said to be deep within the Akhmatova Railways.

Arkyv users whispered of a secluded corner of the city where witches were rumored to gather. A sanctuary to some, a powder keg of hazardous energies to others. As she thought about the recent bombings, Dunya couldn't shake the uneasy feeling that this place might somehow be connected. She understood the risks better than most, but the riddle seemed to point her there unequivocally. Her instincts screamed caution, but her intellect saw another layer, an intricate cipher, perhaps obscured by this so-called Coven. It was a puzzle she couldn't resist.

As if making the decision for her, her hand reached for her jacket slung over the chair. She threw it on, adjusting the bionic braces of her Skelet as she stood. Her boots clicked decisively against the floor as she leaped for her bag. Securing her notebook in a hidden compartment within her backpack, she slung it over her shoulder.

With a sense of purpose, Dunya exited her apartment. The door sealed shut with a soft click as she stepped into the hallway.

△△△

Inside the elevator, mirrored doors reflected her determined face. An advertisement flickered across a small display: a couple dining at a luxurious mountain retreat. The tagline read, "Escape to Serenity: You Deserve a Break." A dry, almost bitter smile tugged at her lips. Clearly, some algorithm had missed the mark. Serenity was a foreign concept. She remembered Vesna's last words to her, urging her to take a

break from her relentless tech-pursuits. How ironic those words seemed now, coming from someone who had effectively broken off all contact.

At the ground floor, Sergey looked up from his usual bank of monitors, gave her a brief nod, and returned to the feeds. Dunya nodded back and strode through the building's glass doors into the frosty air, where the scent of pine mixed with machine oil.

Activating her ocular, a small holographic map displayed a storage icon. With a subtle hand gesture, the icon glowed green, and soon, her motorcycle emerged from a wall compartment that disguised itself as part of the building's exterior. As she mounted the bike, her Skelet interfaced with the chassis, locking them into a single, agile form. She revved the engine and darted into the snowy streets. Tire tracks in the slush caught her eye, thicker and more defined than typical car tires. *Construction bots*, she mused. *Always rebuilding something.*

Riding high, Dunya took in the familiar contrast of Gred: looming factories stubbornly sharing space with pockets of untouched nature. Her eyes barely lingered on the incongruity; it was a sight she had grown used to.

As she neared her destination, the glow of the metro hub sign cut through the twilight, marking the crossroads that would lead her toward Zakharovna Central and from there, to her goal.

She parked her motorcycle, which autonomously wheeled itself into a sleek, metallic locker. Sliding off her backpack, she carefully stowed it in the motorcycle's integrated storage container, ensuring her belongings were secured before the locker closed with a soft chime. A hologram blinked, "Identity Confirmed," signifying that her ownership was authenticated through a unique, non-fungible digital token. On her ocular

interface, a small icon of her motorcycle appeared, flashing the option: “Follow Mode - Metro Compatible?” She selected the icon with her gaze, setting her bike to traverse alongside the metro lines, ready for her at the other end.

As Dunya stepped onto the platform, her eyes flickered to the chandeliers. Each crystal was cut with unnerving precision. For a moment, she wished she could trace the facets with her fingers and feel the human craftsmanship she knew wasn’t there. Her glance slid from the chandeliers to the crowd below.

Old babas clutched their bags tightly, their weathered faces and scarves imbued with a sense of permanence. Every so often, a young woman would rush by, a glimpse of change in a mostly static urban tapestry. A small group in gray work attire leaned nonchalantly against the pillars, an emblem of a black honeycomb against a field of yellow sewn onto patches on their arms. She wondered, in a different life, if she might have enjoyed manual labor, if Dugal had still been around to poke fun at her whenever she worked up the confidence to try smithing something on his old CNC.

The distant murmur of steel meeting steel crescendoed, filling the air until it coalesced into a resplendent train. Its head was adorned with a sculpted metallic fox, eyes inset with amber, a harmonious melding of Art Deco flair and Soviet robustness. The doors hissed open, inviting the crowd to enter as if beckoned by the fox’s taciturn gaze.

Inside, Dunya found herself standing, back against the cold wall of the metro car. Her eyes met those of an older woman across the aisle. Crow’s feet framed the woman’s pale blue eyes. Self-consciously, Dunya fluffed the fabric of her baggy pants with her free hand, creating a slight bulge to obscure the outline of her Skelet.

The train jolted forward. As she tightened her grip on the rail, she noticed the older woman's gaze finally break and move on to appraise another passenger.

Dunya's eyes locked onto another figure a few seats away. The woman was close in age to Dunya, her hair a turbulent sea of blue shades styled audaciously. Tattoos snaked visibly enough to suggest a serpent entwined with a dagger. The Vory's trademark.

With a swift, almost absentminded adjustment, Dunya smoothed the fabric of her baggy pants over her Skelet once more. The blue-haired woman's eyes narrowed, attention sharpened. A quiet throb began in Dunya's temples. Had she seen it?

The train began its slow crawl toward the next station, the soft murmur of an announcement filling the cabin. People stirred, grasping handles of bags, and adjusting clothing. Yet the blue-haired Vory remained still, her unsettling gaze never wavering.

The doors opened with a sigh, then hissed closed. The metro lurched forward. Dunya's eyes stayed on the outside world, but her every sense hummed with alertness. Background sounds—the murmur of voices, the rustle of fabric—faded next to the palpable sense of scrutiny.

The car emptied gradually, each station taking away a handful of passengers until only a sparse scattering remained. The overhead lights flickered briefly, casting transient shadows that danced across the floor and walls. With fewer bodies to absorb the sound, the clatter of wheels on tracks echoed more prominently, filling the space with a rhythmic clack-click-clack.

Dunya's muscles tensed. The blue-haired Vory was still there, no longer feigning disinterest. She had shifted in her

seat, now leaning forward with an air of anticipation, like a predator sensing vulnerability.

Dunya's fingers tightened around the rail, her grip becoming a vice. Her senses were needles, finely pointed and ready to stitch together whatever might unravel next. She felt the air thicken, the tension condensing like water droplets on cold glass. Her heart drummed a steady beat, a counterpoint to the metallic rhythm of the train's wheels.

When the metro car reached the next station, an announcement crackled through the speakers, but neither responded. Doors opened, then closed. No one got on or off.

The blue-haired woman lunged at Dunya, her movements a blur. But Dunya's ocular had already calculated the vector of her approach. The visual overlay tagged the Vory as a high-risk entity, mapping out her projected path in a series of red lines.

Just before they collided, Dunya sidestepped, her military-grade rail gun materializing in her hand. But the woman was quicker than she'd anticipated. Her hand shot out, knocking the gun from Dunya's grip. It skittered across the floor, well out of reach.

The Vory sneered, "Syndicate *scum*."

She swung a knife, its blade shimmering with a suspicious liquid. Poison, no doubt.

With the servos in her Skelet humming, Dunya pivoted on her heel, narrowly avoiding the slash. In one fluid motion, she countered with a high kick, her metallic braced leg connecting solidly with the Vory's jaw.

The blue-haired woman staggered, cursing loudly as she clutched her face. "You'll pay for that!"

A quick scan confirmed the Vory's mandible wasn't broken but she was momentarily disoriented. Dunya seized the

opportunity, rushing forward to deliver a series of rapid punches. But her opponent recovered faster than expected, blocking the last punch, and landing a vicious hook to Dunya's side.

Dunya winced, the air escaping her lungs as if she'd been vacuum-sealed. As the Vory's blade arced through the air for another strike, Dunya caught her arm, halting the slash midway.

In that frozen second, the Vory jerked her wrist away, disengaging from Dunya's grasp. Her fingers immediately danced over a device strapped to her arm. A sickening sense of recognition twisted in Dunya's gut; she'd seen that device's ilk before and knew all too well its function.

Knowing she had mere seconds before her legs gave out, Dunya abandoned all caution. Her boot shot out in a sweeping arc, catching the Vory off balance and sending her sprawling to the floor. In that instant, she lunged for her fallen gun. Her fingers found the cold metal, and she spun, aiming it squarely at her opponent.

The Vory glared up from the floor, a mixture of fury and incredulity in her eyes. "You might kill me, but you'll never stop us."

Dunya's finger hovered over the trigger, her implant providing no moral guidance, only statistical outcomes. This was her choice, and hers alone.

Finally, she holstered the gun. "Tell your friends the Syndicate isn't your only problem."

Dunya saw the woman's eyes widen and caught a glimmer of something unexpected. Gratitude? Respect? It was hard to tell.

Dunya stepped back, her hand on her holstered pistol as the metro car came to a stop. “Devils you know, witches you don’t. Better stay out of the fire.”

As she moved toward the door, whisked along by the quiet efficiency of her braces, Dunya cast a final glance at the wayward psycho who had tried to kill her without cause. The metro doors sealed shut with a pneumatic hiss. For a moment, their eyes met through the glass, and a subtle pang of regret flickered within her.

She watched the train pull away, contemplating the circular nature of the metro route. It would bring the girl back to the city’s heart, give her another shot at chaos. The thought stung, but Dunya shook it off.

Still, the encounter gnawed at her. A lone, mid-level Vory wasn’t the kind of assassin the Syndicate would send if they truly wanted her dead. There were far more effective ways to eliminate her than some knife-wielding thug on the metro. Was it a coincidence, or had her former employers grown sloppy? No, she doubted it. The Syndicate rarely made mistakes, and this attack felt too amateurish. More likely, the Vory had seen the faint glow of her Skelet beneath her sleeve and assumed she was still tied to a field contract. Most operators kept their rigs after severance if they survived the work. She had too, and maybe that was enough to paint a target on her back.

She’d been to her apartment twice since the mindgraft had gone to shit, and no one had come for her. Her guards were never tipped off. Maybe none of it mattered. Maybe the mindgraft, like Yana had said, was just another bum gray-hat job that held no significance whatsoever, and Maria was just a lying bitch playing with her generosity. Either way, she knew the Syndicate could—and likely would—do better if they wanted her silenced for good.

The attack still did not parse. A Vory had seen the Skelet, assumed Syndicate, and tried to kill her. No grand meaning required. Gred generated enough bad classifications without help from fate.

Then she noticed a symbol cut into the tunnel wall beneath layers of grime. A phrase from an old underground job returned: *“Follow the path where light is scant, and the walls speak of a forgotten chant.”*

Her ocular returned nothing useful, which meant the data had either been scrubbed or never indexed.

The corridor narrowed. Dunya marked the exits, signal strength, and distance back to the platform. Whatever the Veil was, it did not get to decide whether she was worthy. It was a location, and locations had access rules.

Her eyes adjusted to the limited light, the path barely illuminated by her Skelet’s subtle display. She had expected to find a flame, rumors and coded messages had led her to expect it. But as she drew nearer, she discovered a small chapel carved directly into the tunnel wall, as though a drill bot had attacked the stone and stopped midway, leaving the jagged edges raw and unfinished. The chapel’s rough exterior contrasted sharply with the intricate wooden carvings of the altar inside, where an ancient tome rested on a stone pedestal, seemingly untouched by time.

A shiver danced through her body as her eyes swept across the wooden walls and altar of the chapel. *Where fire meets wood*, the thought pulsed in her mind. No flames flickered in sconces, no ember glowed in a brazier. She’d found something pivotal, she was sure, but it felt like a riddle waiting for its other half.

Intrigued and cautious, she approached the pedestal and flipped open the book’s pages. The inked symbols and diagrams seemed to animate, glowing faintly in the gloom.

Squinting in the dim light, she leaned closer to the ancient text, the words barely more than whispers on the worn page. She traced the letters with her fingertips, coaxing them into clarity. She broke the silence, carefully pronouncing each word: “In shadow’s depth, the secret lies.”

As her voice resonated in the stone chamber, a sconce on the wall flickered to life. Its sudden light made her gasp, and her heartbeat quickened. She continued: “Where eyes perceive yet still defy.”

Her eyes widened as another sconce ignited, its light joining the first to dance on the pages of the tome. A deluge of data flooded her ocular—numbers, images, and indecipherable warnings—she managed to focus on the text and read the final line: “Embrace the flame yet fear the burn.”

With the third sconce lit, her ocular caught the pattern the room had been building: three spoken lines, three active lights, one strand of her hair highlighted across the display. An input sequence. Stupidly theatrical, but clear enough.

She drew the butterfly knife, cut a lock, and laid it on the page.

White light detonated through the chapel. Her ocular blanked, the Skelet threw balance warnings, and every sensor returned garbage for two seconds.

When the feed recovered, someone was standing behind her.

A hooded silhouette blocked the pine wall. Its face remained hidden, and her sensors found neither a thermal profile nor a readable device signature. Dunya held still, counting the distance to her knife.

Whatever she had authenticated, it had answered.

CHAPTER TWENTY TWO

VESNA

Vesna pulled herself from the training pits, feeling the weight of fatigue with every step. Entering the locker room, she made her way to the showers. She peeled off worn leather gear—boots, jacket, gloves—letting them land haphazardly by her locker. Reaching for the faucet, she twisted it on and stepped beneath the scalding spray, leaning into the contrast of heat against the cool, mosaic-tiled wall. With every movement and stretch, memories flared in the bruises, each one a reminder of recent battles, her body marked in deep purples and angry reds.

Steam wafted around her. A slight turn of her head revealed the source: an auburn-haired woman bathed in the shimmer of the water, her porcelain skin glistening. The woman's lips moved in a low, haunting melody, like an ancient prayer. Though Vesna had never set foot in a church, not even before the faith was outlawed, the sound stirred something deep within her. But as the melody held her in its grip, the steam surged, thickening, and the vision dissolved, leaving her with only the echo of the tune and the rhythmic patter of water bouncing off the tiles like soft rainfall.

The scalding water cascaded over her back, but it did little to quell the firestorm raging in her mind. The damp smell of mildew clung to the air, sour and suffocating, mixing with the sting of abandonment that twisted inside her. Friends had turned foes, now wearing the yellow scarves of the Hive or rallying behind Tatyana Romanova in open defiance. Each desertion left a venomous sting, and in the shower's seclusion, she allowed herself to feel the slash of every loss.

As leader of the Wolves, she had to project unyielding strength, driving her units forward, no matter the cost. Each

deployment felt like a tightening noose—a unit gone missing after a routine mission or another that never returned from guard duty summoned by the Counsel. The walls seemed to close in around her, the whispered curse of a Pra Matron creeping ever nearer. Morale frayed in the pack.

She leaned against the cool mosaic tiles, the cold pressing into her back despite the hot water streaming down, a contrast that only deepened the weight of expectation. The murmur of conversations blurred with the steady patter of water, fragments of rumors about marines desecrating Fort Ivan—a violation that scraped at the Wolves’ honor, tainting their space. Zakharovna’s absence hung over her like a shadow, leaving her alone to navigate this crucial moment. The hot water flowed, but it couldn’t chase away the cold dread coiling inside her. She couldn’t allow treachery to seep into her stronghold. The time had come to strengthen the pack, to prepare them for the inevitable clash ahead.

Vesna towed off with a coarse cloth, barely noticing the heap of discarded clothes by her locker. Bare-skinned, she crossed the room and grabbed her phone, flicking it open. Her eyes settled on a days-old message from Dunya: “*Are you coming home?*” She hadn’t found the will to respond, not to this one or the others. The day they’d first traded contacts felt like a distant memory, and now Dunya’s neediness clung to her like something foul.

With a sigh, Vesna bundled her damp purple hair into a messy bun, tugging on her boots as the cold leather gripped her bare feet. Dunya’s message clung to her thoughts, her lip caught between her teeth as she mulled it over. She tossed the phone onto the bench and finished dressing, the weight of unanswered words still hanging in the air.

Sharp footsteps echoed behind her. Vesna turned to see a familiar figure in uniform—tall, slender, with cropped silver hair and a face set in stern lines.

“Commander,” the woman said, her voice steady but with an edge Vesna couldn’t quite place. “I want in on Alpha pack.”

Vesna studied her, cautious. “You’re Goga, right? I didn’t see you in training.”

“On patrol,” Arkadya’s sister replied curtly, arms crossed, her eyes hard and unyielding.

Vesna recalled seeing her at the Research Center—brilliant, but untested in the field. “I know you’re sharp in the labs, Goga. But this isn’t about smarts. It’s about grit, about facing the enemy head-on. Out there, it’s different.”

Goga’s tone hardened. “You killed my sister. Now I’m standing here, asking to be part of your game. And let’s be real—you’re not exactly swimming in recruits with all the defections. Think of this as a chance to settle the score.”

Vesna felt a chill at the mention of their former pack leader. The underlying threat, the veiled accusation, was clear, but she shoved it aside. In the ranks of the Black Wolves, death was always lurking. *Goga should’ve known her sister wasn’t exempt—not from me, not from anyone.*

“Alright, you’re in,” Vesna said firmly. “But this isn’t about settling scores. It’s about doing the work. Can you handle that?”

Goga met her gaze, a flicker of satisfaction crossing her face, darkened by something else. “I can handle it. Just give the word.”

Vesna nodded. “Wait for my call. Be ready.”

As Goga turned to leave, she paused, glancing back with a half-smile that never touched her eyes. “Oh, and by the way,” she said casually, “I don’t buy the rumors. I know you took down Arkadya yourself.”

Goga's footsteps echoed through the locker room as she left. Vesna exhaled slowly, her mind swiftly processing the brief encounter. Was Goga truly after allegiance, or was this the start of a move for revenge? The thought surfaced, but Vesna dismissed it as quickly as it came. There was no room for doubt, not now—not after her ruthless rise to command, and not with defections looming like shadows. *Maybe she's just hungry for rank, or maybe she wants closure.* There was no time to dwell. She gathered her gear, pushing aside the flicker of uncertainty and letting routine take over. Her boots clicked against the concrete, each step a silent reminder: *Keep moving forward, Commander.*

The foyer doors parted, revealing the fortress courtyard. Ancient sconces embedded in weathered stone cast muted light, their shadows flickering across the ground. The cool night air brushed her face as she spotted her motorcycle waiting in the dark.

She swung a leg over the frame, feeling the cold metal seat through her gear. She gripped the handlebars. As she silently mouthed the passphrase, the lock clicked, and the engine roared to life beneath her, vibrations rippling through her body.

With a surge, she sped out of the compound, dust rising in her wake. The wind whipped against her face, a brief reprieve from the storm in her mind. Each mile swallowed by the bike's tires stretched the distance between her and the weight of command, offering a fleeting escape.

Revving the engine, she wove through the shadowy roads, the cool lake air from Kultuchnoye drifting by. Sweat trickled down her neck, and she let out a quiet chuckle—she'd forgotten her helmet in the rush. Pushing the bike faster, she gained speed, the familiar streets of town unfolding around her. The road widened, flanked by towering buildings on either side, closing in as she raced through the dark.

She shifted her focus inward, bypassing the subtle mental interface that typically guided the bike. Now she felt the raw power beneath her, the engine's snarl unfiltered and fierce. This sensation, this wild intensity, brought her back to her cadet days. The cityscape stretched before her, skyscrapers standing like silent giants as she sliced through their shadows. Neon lights flickered across the streets, casting a wash of colors. She wove through the dense traffic with ease, instincts honed from years of chasing criminals sharpening her every move.

The city blurred in a cascade of motion as she raced onward. Ahead, the silhouette of the Grand Mariner's Cathedral cleaved the sky, towering over everything around it, its grandeur unmistakable even from a distance. Nearing it, the silvery trunks of white birches stood out in stark contrast against the cathedral's shadow, their leaves whispering softly, as if in deference to the towering structure behind them.

As she approached the city's core, a flicker of light in the distance drew her eye—a fire. A dogwood tree stood at its center, its blossoms ablaze like embers. The sight held her for a moment, and she eased off the throttle, transfixed.

A woman stood in the heart of the flames, her haunting eyes locking onto Vesna's from afar. Clad in a form-fitting black robe, a gnarled wooden staff in hand, she seemed to control the fire with nothing but a thought. Adrenaline spiked through Vesna as she gunned the throttle, her bike roaring beneath her. This woman needed to be stopped.

Vesna skidded to a screeching halt, jumping off the bike as its engine rumbled, the heat radiating off its frame. In the smoky haze around the tree, the flickering firelight revealed stacks of leather-bound books, their presence unsettling against the crackling flames.

The crowd flowed past, oblivious to Vesna's presence. Aged matrons in fur coats held their usual spaces in the evening bustle, while a group of young professionals marched by, their stares vacant, guided by digital trails in their ocular implants.

Vesna moved forward, her senses on high alert for threats concealed in the shadows. A year ago, a garbage fire on a busy street would have been nothing more than a nuisance, just another flicker in the urban sprawl. But now, with the city teetering on the edge, every fire glowed with potential danger, every alley murmured of hidden threats. She tightened her grip on her gun as she neared the flames, her eyes scanning for the elusive woman in black.

"Hey!" Vesna shouted, stepping closer to the fire, waving her free hand. "Stop right there!"

The woman's figure flickered for a moment in the light, her green eyes wild and frantic. But as Vesna moved closer, the robed figure dissolved into the smoke, leaving no trace of her presence.

Vesna hesitated for a heartbeat, then moved cautiously forward. As the fire's glow revealed the face of the fallen figure, memories surged through her, almost knocking the breath from her lungs. "Dunya." The name slipped out in a whisper. Without thinking, her pace quickened, each step feeling heavier, burdened what felt like the years between them. Dropping to her knees, Vesna brushed away the soot and ash from Dunya's face. "Dunya, what have you gotten yourself into?" she choked, the shock mixing with a wave of guilt for the time they'd lost.

Dunya's eyes locked onto hers, cutting through the dim light. "You shouldn't be here."

Vesna gripped Dunya's shoulders, her voice urgent. "Spill it. What happened to you?"

The flickering light from the metro entrance cast an eerie glow over Dunya's face as she wrestled with the fear gripping her. "I can't explain—not here, not now..." Her voice shook, fragile like a flame about to go out. "I took a contract to investigate the Railways and stumbled on...*them*. People—no, entities." Dunya's words faltered, trembling. "There's something in the city, Vesna. An anomaly, something that defies nature. And I think... I think it's connected to Syn."

Vesna's irritation flared, her whirl of guilt and concern suddenly sharpening into anger. "The Syndicate? You're still tangled up with them? After everything we've been through?"

Dunya's face tightened. "Aren't you? I take the contracts I need to survive. You're not here to make those calls anymore, Vesna."

"You think I wanted this? You think I wanted to leave you? We're in this mess because you couldn't let go—because you didn't—"

"I didn't what? You left *me*, Vesna! You saved yourself and left me to pick up the pieces!"

"I did it to protect you," Vesna said, the words raw and jagged as they ripped from her throat. "But we can't do this now. I'll explain later, I promise. Right now, we need to move."

"Oh, like how you promised last time?"

Vesna's jaw clenched. "I had no choice. Things were different—"

"Things are always different with you."

Before Vesna could respond, a shuddering cough broke the tension. The ancient trees hissed as their gray-brown bark crackled, dense plumes of smoke curling into the air. Then, like a phantom rising from the smoke, the robed figure reappeared.

The figure lunged, silent and swift, but Vesna was faster. Her hand shot out, fingers gripping the woman's arm with the desperate force of a cornered animal. "I'm done with your games. I want the truth."

Beneath the shadow of the hood, Vesna caught a glimpse of a smirk. A chill crept down her spine, unbidden and unwelcome. "Oh, Commander," the woman said, her voice dripping with mockery. "The truth is, we're all just pawns in this grand game. And the city"—she spread her arms wide as the flames licked at her—"is our board."

In an instant, the robed figure was swallowed by fire. The flames consumed the fabric, revealing hair that shimmered like molten silver. Her pale skin caught the glow, almost ethereal in the shifting light. Then, she flickered and dissolved, scattering into ash that spiraled away on the wind.

The low rumble jolted Vesna from her frozen state. For a moment, it could have been distant thunder—until the second blast roared closer. Vesna's gaze remained fixed on the spot where the robed woman had vanished when the second blast erupted, closer, unmistakable as anything but a detonation. The third shook the ground beneath her, the force rippling through the air as glass rained down from high windows, shards catching the firelight as they fell.

Only then did Vesna register the crowd—no longer distant figures but a panicked mass. Screams cut through the smoke as the women who had been wandering aimlessly moments before now scrambled, their terror palpable. The realization hit hard: it was a coordinated strike, and they were caught in the heart of it.

"We gotta move," Vesna shouted over the chaos, her hands steadying Dunya as rogue currents crackled through her braces. Another explosion rocked the ground, a wave of heat

and force slamming into them. Vesna's grip slipped, and they tumbled to the ground.

A scream tore through the air—Dunya's, as a searing gust of fiery wind whipped at her, tearing through fabric and skin. The acrid smell of burnt hair and scorched cloth filled Vesna's lungs as she scrambled to cover Dunya with her own body, desperation driving her every move.

Then, as if answering the chaos, a powerful surge of water burst forth, rushing over the streets and snuffing out the flames that had taken hold of the city. Vesna, her heart pounding in her chest, could only watch as the torrent swept away the immediate danger.

In the next heartbeat, a wartrike roared into view, its engine growling with the promise of either salvation or new peril. It skidded to a halt, scattering embers and dust, and Vesna exhaled in relief at the sight of the unmistakable silhouettes of the Black Wolves. Goga, flanked by two others, dismounted. Without hesitation, she moved to Dunya's side, lifting her from the wreckage with the ease of someone who had done this a hundred times before.

"Secure a perimeter!" Vesna's command cut through the mayhem.

Goga acknowledged with a crisp nod, "On it, Vesna. Wolves, form up!" she barked in response.

That's Commander to you... Dammit.

Goga's orders carried over the din as her hands relayed Vesna's commands with precision. The Black Wolves leapt into action, swiftly extinguishing flames and guiding civilians to safety. As they moved, some Wolves took strategic positions, firing at the onrushing *shpichkis*. The horror escalated as several of the attackers defied death, igniting themselves in a blaze of self-immolation, transforming into human torches that spread panic like wildfire.

The Wolves, unshaken, tightened their defensive cordon, creating a fortified space where chaos swirled just outside the perimeter.

Vesna watched as Dunya was hoisted between two towering Black Wolves—both gargantuan women who looked like they hadn't slept in days. Even in their grip, Dunya strained, her eyes searching for Vesna. She pushed weakly against their support, her focus solely on closing the distance.

As they brought her closer, Dunya's legs buckled, and she leaned heavily into Vesna. "Vesna," she rasped, her voice raw from shock, "I... I can't..." Her body sagged, and Vesna quickly steadied her, becoming the pillar Dunya's waterlogged braces and battered frame could no longer provide.

Vesna's chest tightened as they lifted Dunya onto the gurney at the back of the ambulance. Seeing her like this—so fragile, so far from the Dunya she remembered—it hit harder than anything she could have said.

"Don't—" Dunya gasped as they carefully strapped her in. "Don't leave me."

"You'll pull through," Vesna said. "You're tough—tougher than any of us." As she squeezed Dunya's hand, her grip was a facade, a shield against a sudden, crushing wave of responsibility. *I should have answered your calls. I should have been there before it came to this.*

The slam of the ambulance doors felt like a gavel, closing one ordeal and ushering in another. Vesna's hand lingered on the hot glass, her forehead resting against the pane for a brief moment as the vehicle pulled away, its sirens wailing over the distant rumble of explosions.

She turned back to the chaos, her fists tightening like steel, every muscle primed for action. The city was under siege. As long as she had breath, as long as blood pulsed through her veins, she would fight—for Dunya, for everyone caught in the

crossfire. With a sharp nod to her lieutenants, Vesna signaled the next move. There was no time for goodbyes. Not yet. Not while the battle still raged.

CHAPTER TWENTY THREE

YANA

“Cigar?”

Grigoreva stood at the foot of the divan, a smoldering cigar between her lips, tendrils of smoke rising from its tip.

Yana coughed. Her eyes watered as the acrid haze assaulted her senses. She waved her hand, hoping to clear the air enough to focus.

“An early indulgence,” the Baroness muttered with a sly grin, “but who could resist a taste of my White Canal?” She dangled the gilded *Belomorkanal* from her fingers, the base of the cigar marked by the smudge of her lipstick. “Can I tempt you?”

Grigoreva’s free hand caressed Yana’s tousled mane, her fingers weaving through the strands. “You appear in need of something to ease the tension.”

Yana withdrew, fatigue weighing down her limbs. “No, thank you.” She rubbed her temples, the ghost of a headache lingering from a night of decadence and excess. “I’ll be fine.”

She turned toward the mirror and studied the damage to her mascara. Dark streaks marked her cheeks. She dabbed with a tissue, but the smears held fast. Some stains, she thought, were not so easily erased.

As she stared at her reflection, a troubling thought surfaced. *No way they just happen to share the same name. Is this a setup?* Something was off. The mission had turned, twisting into lies she hadn’t anticipated.

Laughter slipped out before she could stop it, sharp and hollow. *So much for the con artist. Looks like I only lived up to*

the whore. She winced. Seems the only one she was fooling was herself.

The Baroness's haunting laughter wove through the air. "So, you wish to be alone?" she teased, the words almost a challenge as she dangled the cigar in front of Yana, its smoke entwining her sleeve in a phantom caress. "Farewell then, Ms. Kuular. May the day treat you kindly." With a charming smile and a theatrical wave, she said, "It's a bit of a trek to my solar. I suppose I could leave you here, alone, save for Aleksandr's lingering presence—though, truth be told, abandoning you to *his* company seems a punishment I'm not quite cruel enough to inflict."

The Baroness's grin held, smoke curling off her sleeve. Aleksandr, hulking and jaw-scarred, stood sentinel on a thick column of neck. His hint of a smirk read as amusement when the Baroness's disdain found a new target.

It was the fifth consecutive night the Baroness had summoned her to the bedchamber. The previous encounters had been almost enjoyable; the Baroness had a deft touch, her caresses and tantalizing teases unraveling Yana in her arms. After hours spent writhing under Grigoreva's ministrations, Yana could not deny her skill.

Then Grigoreva started talking about her son as if he were still moving through the city under another name.

Noblewomen from the Battalion had shared nights with him, she said. They praised him afterward. Grigoreva sounded proud in a way that made Yana's skin tighten, proud the way someone might be proud of a weapon that had performed exactly as designed.

Yana tried to read the angle. *Where is he?* She had never seen a son in any brief or scrap of intel.

Then the daughter from the gala slipped back into the thought. Serafim had not felt like a daughter being shown off.

She had felt like a mask worn badly. The possibility sat cold in Yana's stomach. Maybe Grigoreva was not hinting at a hidden man at all. Maybe she was telling the truth in the only form she allowed herself.

"You've grown quiet. Is something amiss?" She reached for Yana's hand, her grip firm and possessive.

Yana hesitated before responding, then squeezed back, attempting to infuse warmth into the chilly contact. "I'm alright," she said, though she doubted it was what the Baroness wanted to hear. She caught the skepticism in the older woman's eyes and steadied herself, careful to keep the brittle balance between them. She mustered a smile, praying it would appease her.

"I'm pleased," the Baroness replied, her smirk reclaiming its place. "For the record, you are extraordinary." She opened the bedroom door, motioning for Yana to precede her. "You hold an unjust advantage over my son's other dalliances, you know."

Yana was disturbed by the tasteless comment. "And what's that?" she asked, feigning a smile.

The Baroness dismissed her bodyguard with a flick of her wrist as they entered the bedroom. As Yana closed the door, she turned to face Grigoreva and took her hands, drawing them to her chest. She forced a wave of feigned affection.

The Baroness returned her smile and drew her in for a fervent kiss. "Because you're young," she murmured, parting before their lips met once more. Grigoreva's hands roamed Yana's body.

"I trained him myself," the Baroness said. "But he's not as adept as you." She leaned in again, one hand caressing Yana's breast. The Baroness's moan melded with their kiss, and Yana withdrew, hands still linked.

Yana met the older woman's eyes. This felt like painting on a fraying canvas, each stroke at risk of tearing what held. She steadied her breath and matched the Baroness's passion with a fervor that surprised her.

"He doesn't know what he's missing," Yana whispered, her words muffled and playful as their lips entwined in another lingering kiss. *Did I push too far?* she wondered. Her mind raced, trying to gauge the Baroness's reaction, to decipher the intricate web of relationships and hidden truths. *Is this a step too close to a line I can't see?*

"He has other concerns," Grigoreva replied, a faint amusement at the edge of her eyes. "Not everyone is captivated by such distractions." Her gaze lingered, composed. Maybe Yana had prodded too close.

Closing the distance between them, Yana encircled Grigoreva's waist from behind, pressing herself against the older woman's back. She placed a tender kiss on a bare shoulder, and made her voice low and intimate, "Like him, I too have my own concerns, despite enjoying these...distractions. I trust you'll uphold your end of our arrangement."

Yana paused, catching the warmth of her own breath against Grigoreva's skin. "What I'm after is simple—the freedom to call my own shots, to live life how I see fit. I'm no one's puppet, not to be pulled by strings or played like a game. And that includes you," Yana said, lacing her words with a coy assertiveness.

The Baroness stiffened but remained in her embrace. She regarded their reflection in the mirror. "You're an enigma," she mused. "I can't quite decipher you."

Yana maintained the closeness. "Me, an enigma?" she teased. "Cracking codes can be liberating, can't it? Perhaps there's freedom in the revelations to come, for both of us."

The Baroness lifted the cigar from the crystal ashtray. Facets threw small prisms across her hand. She drew a slow puff and set it back, smoke unwinding between them. She turned and touched Yana's cheek. "Courageous," she said. "I appreciate that. Beware. Freedom can be treacherous, and not all who venture survive." She kissed Yana again. "We will get there," she said, voice low as she drew back. "Stay by my side, and I promise you'll attain what you believe you desire."

Yana's fingers moved over the Baroness's shoulders. She untied the emerald sash, silk catching the low light. The robe slipped, and the nightgown's straps gave. Fabric whispered to the floor, leaving skin to the candlelight.

Grigoreva gestured for Yana to lie down, and she complied, her pulse quickening with anticipation. The older woman's hands trailed Yana's body, resting on her hips before encircling her waist and drawing her nearer. But as Yana lay down, her heart began to race with an undercurrent of repulsion she couldn't quite stifle.

"True power is freedom," Yana said. "The liberty to act, to be who you choose, without constraint. Don't you ever feel confined by your wealth, your power?"

"And true freedom is perilous," the Baroness warned. "It can unleash chaos, incite insurrection. Tread carefully with your desires, Ms. Kuular. Freedom bears great responsibility, and not all are equipped to manage it."

Yana's hips swayed as she grinned. "Not everyone can handle me," she said in her sultriest voice, "but the challenge is always worth the while."

Grigoreva glanced briefly toward the door. "We shall see."

Her gaze returned to Yana, accompanied by a smile. "Promise me one thing," she said, her tone softer now.

"What's that?"

“That you won’t betray me. Power is as fragile as ice under the sun. It can vanish overnight. And in my years in this treacherous game, I’ve learned the hard way—deceivers meet ends that are neither quick nor merciful.”

The heavy oak door groaned as it opened, its latch clicking shut with a resolute thud. Yana’s gaze shifted to the doorway, where Grigoreva’s bodyguard ushered in the newcomer. He escorted a slender young woman inside, carrying herself with the easy assurance of nobility Yana knew too well.

She wore a sheer black top, delicate and airy, with ruffled trims that danced at the edges. Through the translucent fabric, her tender figure was hinted at, an embodiment of both sharp grace and soft ambiguity. Cascades of long, black ringlets framed her features, playing off the light that danced in her hazel eyes. Her skin was unblemished, smooth, almost porcelain in its appearance, a striking contrast to the black that contoured her form.

Grigoreva’s eyes followed the elegant arrival, a subtle nod acknowledging her entrance. Her voice, edged with sternness and a trace of affection, broke the silence. “Ah, my beloved joins us. Now, the time has come to wash away the echoes of our revelries, to cleanse the remnants of our indulgences.”

It was during the previous days of debauchery, amid the whispered secrets and veiled half-truths, that Yana realized she had nearly pieced together the puzzle of *this* Serafim’s identity. They had shared a table for hours, but the dim lighting of the ballroom had obscured the young woman’s features, leaving Yana with only a nebulous impression. Now, observing this delicate figure more closely, memories flooded back—the subtle hints, the almost imperceptible slips in their behavior, the way their eyes danced with mischief whenever the topic of Grigoreva’s son was broached.

The first hints of that realization had been jarring, but now, as she took in this boyish grace, it became clear. The person she had taken for Grigoreva's daughter wasn't a daughter at all. Whoever he was, he had played the part well enough to fool her too.

Yana couldn't help but marvel at his audacity and the skill with which he'd maintained his charade. The depth of the deception was profound, and as she met his gaze, Yana felt a mix of admiration and wariness.

A nagging thought tugged at the back of her mind: *Where is the real Serafim? What the hell did she lead me into?*

"I hope I'm not too late," he greeted, acknowledging the Baroness with a nod. When his penetrating gaze turned to Yana, he apologized with a bow of his head and a soft click of his heels.

The sweep of his long dark hair, the sharpness of his features, and those piercing hazel eyes. Confidence bled through his posture, edged with something unpredictable Yana couldn't quite name. She watched as Grigoreva, seemingly enchanted, murmured, "Divine," and sprang from the bed to thread her fingers through those rich black ringlets.

"You could have any woman you want," Grigoreva remarked, eyeing her son with a mix of amusement and exasperation.

This imposter before her straightened, sweeping a casual hand through his curly hair as he met his mother's gaze. "How tedious," he replied with swift dismissal.

"Besides," he added, the smirk on his lips deepening as his gaze lingered on Yana, "take a look at this one..." It was a provocative insinuation wrapped in the subtlety of his words.

Grigoreva's laughter rang out. "Indeed, you do," she agreed, her eyes twinkling as she looked between the two of them.

Serafim turned to Yana then, the smirk on his face a silent challenge. “Do you find me captivating, Yana?” he asked. Without pausing, he gestured towards Grigoreva. “What of my mother? Does she captivate you too?”

Yana met his stare unflinchingly. “She has her charms,” she replied coolly.

“Charms, you say? How delightfully modest of you,” the Baroness drawled. “But tell me, dear Yana, do you know what is truly captivating? Power. And purity of purpose, which you shall witness here tonight.”

Grigoreva signaled, and two robed women slipped from the corners to draw the drapes. At an ornate cabinet they lifted carved black candles and set them in a rough circle on the plush carpet. A match cracked. Wicks caught. Inky blue flames rose and the walls danced with convulsive shadow.

“The time has come to cleanse and to reaffirm command over flesh and spirit. In my child we invoke the bridge between binaries. In their form we see the alchemy that absolves and sanctifies. As they are consecrated, so are we. Let this be our mirror and our crucible.”

Yana’s heartbeat climbed while he undressed. As each layer fell, she took in the mix of hard angles and yielding curves, a shape she couldn’t easily name. With the last layer gone, candlelight traced lines across the body and held her eye. In the shifting shadows, soft and hard crossed in ways she could not name.

In the quiet, the Baroness went to a hidden alcove. Her fingers moved over arranged tools and settled on a slender ceremonial blade.

The blade Grigoreva lifted caught the candlelight. Etched scrollwork and saints ran its length, a church relic turned to this rite.

Bare skin and deep shadow threw the room into sharp relief. Candlelight made every movement stand out. Grigoreva drew the blade across her child's skin. Blood welled. The wince broke the calm, a flicker of vulnerability under the mask.

A limp cigar in a staged obscenity, she thought, distaste rising in her throat. *He—no, she—didn't want to be here.* The flinch, the tight breath, the eyes sliding away. *She's afraid.*

As the incantations gathered, she held to the stakes. This was not only the Battalion's rot. It was her ticket out. The proof was close. *Just a little longer.*

The women gathered and sipped from the blade. *Is this what you wanted me to see?* Pity flickered for the imposter in front of her. Being a pawn in Grigoreva's charade was unthinkable.

As the Baroness broke what the Battalion sold in public, iron rules and clean hands, Yana sneered at the irony. A week of tactics and a fake smile had dragged her deep into this filth. Grigoreva's appetites had only made the work easier. The thought hardened her resolve to watch the whole masquerade fall under its own rot.

Her thoughts roiled. She caught the youth's eyes, searching for truth in the staged rite. Regret. A plea. Or the flat look of someone already resigned?

As Grigoreva leaned in toward Serafim, her fingers finding the exposed skin of her nipples, there was a tender cruelty to it, a possessive claiming that made Yana's stomach tighten. It was then that Yana saw it. Something flickered in those eyes, a crack in the mask that made Yana's chest clench.

Pity struck, sharp and sudden, slicing through her mission-driven focus. Was that a cry for help, a plea for forgiveness from the farce this existence had become under Grigoreva's control? Whatever it was, it pushed Yana over the edge. She could play her part no longer; the charade had gone too far,

igniting a fierce protectiveness she didn't even know she harbored.

When the last droplet fell, the Baroness drew back, skin damp with effort. She stepped away from Serafim, who stood very still inside the candle circle.

The chambermaids in weathered black robes waited, still. Their gazes fixed on Grigoreva as they stood ready with a bowl of oil to anoint Serafim.

Grigoreva looked at Yana. "This is not just a ritual; it's a consecration for the bond you both shall share. Tonight, you and Serafim will unite in a way deeper than flesh; your spirits entwined."

One of the crones stirred the mixture. A nutty scent reached Yana and pulled up frostbitten markets in Yakutsk. Cedar nut oil. In her youth it had shimmered like liquid gold. The maid's hands, slick with oil, moved with reverent care over Serafim's body, the room's hush deepening with each stroke.

"I've seen enough," Yana declared, the words erupting from some primal, outraged part of herself. She drew a breath, trying to find grounding in the cool expanse of the marble floor. An urgent need to flee clawed at her, but she knew Dimitra would junk her without a second thought if she faltered now.

"Keep watching!" Grigoreva demanded. A sheen of perspiration was visible on the matron's brow. Her stare, impelling and challenging, bore into Yana. "You might think you're losing your grip, but you're part of this now—you're part of us."

The Baroness came closer, smile set. Her hand reached toward Yana's arm. "Watch closely. You are about to learn the secrets of your new family. When you are ready, when you have seen and felt enough." A chill ran through Yana. "You will know."

The old women stayed silent, eyes fixed on Yana, as if waiting for a last piece to click.

Candlelight flickered, shadows quivering across faces and walls. Everything held a moment. Her heartbeat thudded hard against her ribs.

The cool brush of metal at her scalp snapped her back. The steel pin had stayed through all of it, a small link to the night she first stepped into that closet and let Grigoreva dress her like a toy.

Her fingers trembled as she reached up and drew out the pin, her eyes catching her reflection in the grand mirror above the bed's headboard. She clasped it tight, heartbeat steadying against the solid feel of the metal, her only ally. But as she handled its pointed end, she pricked her skin, and she watched, almost detached, as a small bead of blood welled up and began its slow descent along her wrist.

The Serafim she had met in *virtual*, who had shown an almost desperate need for her to engage with Grigoreva, even enlisting her loan shark Dimitra's assistance—what was the purpose behind urging this encounter with the mother of the woman who now appeared to be her twin?

Could this entire scenario be nothing more than a drug-induced illusion or a virtual manipulation planted by the real Serafim during their digital correspondence days prior?

Yana fixed on the hairpin. Steel caught a stray beam and split her reflection into shards. The idea hit clean and *sharp*.

Yana leapt and drove the serrated edge into Grigoreva's thigh.

Grigoreva screamed as blood ran. Yana ripped the pin free, set it to the throat, and shoved her out of the candles. The Baroness fell back.

“I’m not one of you,” Yana hissed, feeling a grin spread across her face as she watched the Baroness cower, blood trickling at her feet.

As if summoned by the chaos, one of the women robed in black darted forward, a desperate cry issuing from her lips. But Yana was faster. She sidestepped the woman’s charge, then deftly hooked her foot behind the cultist’s ankle while simultaneously driving her elbow into the woman’s sternum. The combined force sent the woman crashing onto her back, breathless, against the marble floor with a solid thud.

Her gaze caught the electrical cord of an unlit lamp. She tore it free, the sheath smooth under her fingers, and cut it with the hairpin. It would serve as a rope.

Moving with a precision born from necessity, Yana firmly grasped the makeshift dirk, a grim deterrent for any would-be heroes. Without hesitating, she pressed it against the Baroness’s side, her eyes fiercely locking onto the Baroness’s own wide, frightened gaze, ensuring there was no misunderstanding of her intent.

She twisted the cord around the wrists and tied to the bedpost. The one-handed suture knot she had learned on an Okhotsk trawler bit down and held.

A glint of emerald and gold caught her eye. The party emblem on the headscarf felt almost funny now. She grabbed it from the chair, rolled the fabric, and pressed it between the Baroness’s teeth. The next sound came out dull.

With the Baroness secured, she turned to Serafim. The cultist she had dropped was rising, fists closing for another rush, until her gaze snagged on the bound matron. Recognition. Horror. Yana raised the hairpin. The woman broke, scrambling on all fours into the shadows. *Coward*. The fading scuff of retreat echoed.

With the cultists gone, Yana turned back to Serafim. Candlelight wavered over bare skin. The tremor ran through the body. Pity tugged again.

She closed the distance, and with a firm yet not unkind grip, she guided her toward the bedpost adjacent to the Baroness. Her fingers worked swiftly to replicate the same sturdy binding.

“It didn’t have to be this way,” she murmured as she tightened the knot.

She held her gaze, the corner of her mouth twitching in a semblance of a sad smile. “Does it ever?”

“So, what do you go by?” Yana asked.

“Rayna.”

“Cards are dealt. We play,” Yana finally said, searching Rayna’s eyes.

“What about it? What if we call bullshit?”

“Then we bluff. We cheat. We survive.”

Rayna let out a small, resigned chuckle. Acceptance settled on her face. “Except when the game’s fixed from the start. If you cross paths with my sister... Let her know she’s the queen of spades in a house of cards. She’ll know what I mean.”

“I’ll pass it on,” Yana replied.

She set the headscarf in place, gold trim bright against the scene. Light flashed on the edge and whatever Rayna meant to say stayed inside the cloth.

“Deception’s a bitter game, isn’t it?” Yana remarked to Grigoreva, whose once imperious demeanor had crumbled into desperation. The Baroness hunched at the base of the bed, hands trembling against their bonds. She made a feeble attempt to seek solace in the blankets, which had cascaded in a heap beside her during the commotion. Struggling

awkwardly, she couldn't quite manage to pull them over to shield her face.

"Seems you're caught in your own web now," Yana said. "Next time, perhaps weave less conspicuously. You never know who's watching."

She steadied her trembling hands, remorse tempering urgency, and moved a safe distance from Rayna. In the churn of guilt and necessity she reached for her phone, hesitated, then snapped the photo of the gagged, bound girl. It hurt to use her like this, but she needed the proof to get free.

She looked at the Baroness and the strange canvas of her life came into focus. Years of sambo in the Derge, brawling with old men in frost-covered lots, had led here, to a family drama resolved by an electrical cord and an encounter she would rather forget. *Dunya would be proud.*

She routed the photo through the cutout app she kept for nights like this, scrubbed and bounced twice. Then she sent it with a bold challenge:

TOP THAT, DIMITRA.

Then, with a determined stride, she left the room. Grigoreva's muffled screams followed her.

She slipped through the doorway into the adjoining apartment, the heavy chamber-smell clinging to her. Before she closed the door she glanced back at Aleksandr. He stood like furniture, eyes unreadable, pretending not to hear. No sign of alarm. Exhilaration rose. The plan was moving. She had stepped across into whatever came next.

With a triumphant smile, Yana glided across the room to the chaise longue she had admired days before—its plush velvet and gold-leaf scrolls now a familiar comfort in the chaos. It cradled the black pumps and sheer nightgown she had left behind. She slipped into the gown, its smooth, silky

fabric embracing her skin with every movement, a sensation she relished. She allowed herself a brief pause and perched on the edge of the chaise. One steadying breath. Then she crossed to the foyer closet and pulled her rain jacket free. Slipping into the well-worn garment, she zipped it up, finding comfort in the scent that was uniquely hers. A wave of nostalgia washed over her as she retraced her steps to the elevator that she had first entered only five nights ago, a lifetime, it now seemed, measured in revelations and betrayals.

Emerging from Grigoreva's mansion into the bustling city, Yana clutched the steel hairpin. *Who knew such a tiny thing could do so much?* The hammering of an eight-laned street swirled around her: the relentless honk of traffic, the distant chatter of pedestrians. The aromatic allure of street vendors selling kebabs wove through the air, tempting her. But there was no time to savor the flavors or get lost in that sweet synthetic sauce. Not now.

A sleek black limousine slid to the curb. "Well done, girl. Well done. We will take it from here," called a familiar voice. Dimitra's pink faux hawk lifted in the cold as they opened the door for her.

She stepped into the limousine as Dimitra's operatives exited. Warmth from the raven leather seats sank into her.

"I see you took my advice on the new fit," Dimitra remarked with a sarcastic smile. "You did great."

"Thanks," Yana replied, grinning. "It was just another job."

"Yelena will pay handsomely for this. I heard those pogs were already in deep shit. This just makes it worse for them."

Yelena? Why her and not Serafim? Yana's thoughts raced again.

“I am only glad we did it my way,” Yana said, keeping her tone casual as she propped her feet on the dash. *I’m just a little fish swimming with sharks in a sea of secrets.*

“Well, you’ve definitely upped your game,” Dimitra said.

Yana’s breath escaped in a huff.

“Just one more job,” Dimitra said, “You know how it goes, Yana. The longer it took you to settle this one, the more interest built up on your debt. So, let’s just say you owe me one more favor.”

A knot tightened in her stomach, the familiar pull, the silent admission. *I’m in way over my head.*

Dimitra’s laughter revealed their satisfaction. They reached into their coat pocket, pulling out a sleek case. With a sly smile, they opened it to reveal the contents, offering one to Yana. “Cigar?”

CHAPTER TWENTY FOUR

DUNYA

Dunya's eyelids flickered open to the rhythm of ambulance lights, painting her vision in splashes of primary colors. She felt the cold press of a pill against her lips.

"Drink this," a voice commanded, like an echo from somewhere far away.

"Why?" Dunya rasped. She knocked the hand away, the clink of the pill hitting the gurney loud in her ears. *Enough.* Every cell in her body recoiled at the thought of someone else making choices for her. Her chest tightened.

"It's for the pain," the paramedic insisted, a fringe of worry in his tone.

Dunya squinted past the blur of neon city lights. Snowflakes danced outside, mocking the fire that scarred her stomach and thighs with their cold elegance. The paramedic reached for her again, but she turned her head, looking for the woman she sensed nearby.

The armored figure loomed, a silent guardian, gunblade glinting—an image distorted through the haze of pain and consciousness that threatened to pull Dunya under once more.

"Baba?" Dunya said, as she looked towards the looming figure that could have been her grandmother.

"Not yours," the woman replied.

Dunya's gaze fixed on the towering woman clad in a black, heavy-duty winter jacket, its fur-lined collar framing the commanding figure. Close up, the Black Wolf's robust frame spoke of an unnatural vitality—a telltale sign of high-octane exo dependence. Her small, beady blue eyes, set in stark

contrast to her engorged forehead—perhaps an after-effect of thyroid modification—gave her an intense, piercing look. Despite the enhancements, or perhaps because of them, Dunya found an odd comfort in the woman’s formidable presence.

“My daughter,” she murmured with a gruff voice, “had been taken by flames in the Waste Wars, consumed as marauders razed their camp, looting and leaving nothing but fire in their wake. You’re lucky to be alive.”

Lucky to be alive? What a joke. What was left for her? Parents dead, husband dead. Maria had betrayed her. Then that damned contract had walked her straight into a chapel under the Akhmatova Railways. She’d read the words, cut off her hair, and laid it on the page like a fucking signature. White light. A hooded shape waiting behind her when it cleared. Whatever the ritual had done, she’d authenticated it herself. Maybe she’d opened something. Maybe she’d only given it permission. Ghosts in the machine hounded her, the city was engulfed in flames, witches wove through its aching streets. And her own lower body, from her midriff to her thighs, was charred and still demanding braces to mimic some semblance of normal movement.

What the fuck is the point to all this? The question pounded through her, a relentless echo that matched the throb of her burnt torso and the wail of sirens.

Her father and mother were dead. Dugal was dead. Vesna disappeared whenever Dunya got close enough to need an answer. Maria had taken the one trust Dunya still had and broken it open. Even Serafim’s sermons kept returning, all that talk about descending into darkness to find some deeper vision. Dunya had descended. She had found a book, a hooded woman, and another trap she had helped spring on herself.

She remembered an Amur tiger from the Wastes, back when she was eighteen and her father was still alive. It had come out of the trees and fixed on them before either could raise a weapon. Nikolai had grabbed her, and together they had thrown themselves over a ravine into the river below. There had been no hidden lesson in it. One terrible option had remained, and they took it before the tiger chose for them. Lately, everyone else chose first. Dunya only woke inside the damage.

A hollow laugh nearly surfaced, but there was no air in her lungs for it, only a pained rasp and the taste of ash.

The paramedic pressed forward with the pill a third time. But Dunya, seizing a surge of defiant energy, activated the servos in her Skelet. Her leg, bolstered by the powerful machinery, shot out in a kick that caught the feeble man square in the stomach. The force sent him stumbling back into the ambulance's cramped interior.

The Black Wolf let out a subdued chuckle—a sound like gravel being churned in the depths of her throat.

Dunya's breaths came in hard, ragged gasps. "What's your name?" Dunya asked the older woman.

"Kovalenko," she replied. "Sergeant Elina Kovalenko."

As the Black Wolf moved to stand over her, Dunya said, "Alright, Elina, toss me the pills. But I'm the one to take it. By my own hand."

The Black Wolf then reached into the paramedic's kit, pulling out the requested container. "Here," she said, bending over toward Dunya.

Dunya's hand snapped out, snatching the bottle from the Black Wolf's grasp. She tilted her head back, the clatter of pills spilling into her palm barely registering. She swallowed them

dry, the tablets scraping down her throat with no regard for the consequences.

The Black Wolf's tiny eyes widened as far as they seemed they could.

The paramedic, recovering from the kick, scrambled to his feet. "Do you even know what you've done? We need to ration those."

Dunya felt a cool numbness begin to seep into her limbs. She shrugged nonchalantly and asked, "What's in these, anyway?"

"A modified exovegeta composition," the paramedic replied, voice edged with a mixture of annoyance and frustration. "It's the perfect painkiller."

"And don't worry," he continued, trying to regain professional composure. "They have self-terminating sensors in them, designed to prevent an overdose."

"Figures," Dunya muttered with a scoff. Even this decision had been stripped of its finality. She cursed under her breath, resenting the invisible safety nets that seemed to unfurl with every attempt to regain some semblance of control in her life.

As the ambulance jostled over the city's uneven roads, Dunya's gaze locked onto the smaller of the two gunblades sheathed on the Black Wolf's utility belt. Her mind, hazed by the painkillers, nonetheless worked with a grim clarity as she calculated her next move.

Maybe the gunblade was the one decision nobody could reverse, reroute, or administer for her. She was tired of waking inside choices other people had already made. This one would belong to her.

"We're almost at the burn unit," the paramedic announced.

The burn unit was too close. Dunya fixed on the gunblade, studying the grip, estimating its weight, calculating how quickly she could clear the sheath. The idea stopped being a possibility and became a route.

She feigned a gasp, clutched where her skin blistered, and doubled over. Reacting to her distress, the paramedic moved quickly towards Dunya, his alarm evident. Just then, the ambulance rocked sharply on a turn. The sudden movement, compounded by the distraction of the paramedic's reaction, caused the Black Wolf to shift her weight unexpectedly. The formidable woman stumbled, her massive frame toppling over with a crashing thud. In the ensuing chaos, Dunya's hand shot out to the gunblade's hilt.

Vesna. Maria. Mom, Dad, Dugal. Dead, gone, or somewhere Dunya could no longer reach. She was done with contracts, riddles, and waking up in a body someone else had decided to preserve. The gunblade offered one clean command, and for once she held the permissions.

She gripped the weapon, its weight a sudden anchor in her shaking hand. A switch flicked, a hiss sounded, and the blade sprang forth, ready and exact. Turning the blade towards her legs, scarred and raw, she began to slice. *I want it all to end.*

Her body strained under the rapid exertion until, inevitably, her vision narrowed—darkness crept in from the edges until the gunblade's grip grew slick in her weakening grasp. She felt the hard texture slip from her fingers, the clink of metal-on-metal ringing sharply as it hit the floor. Her body, now limp and spent, followed the weapon's descent. Her sense of upended disorientation only grew as she came to rest against the shifting, vibrating surface that should have been the floor of the ambulance.

No static this time. Just black.

CHAPTER TWENTY FIVE

VESNA

The moment Vesna heard the news, she left the front line—Goga Borisova, newly risen from technician to aspirant of the Black Wolves, now stood at the helm. A flicker of doubt brushed Vesna's mind, of whether Goga's greenness could withstand the turmoil of command. But the urgent call overshadowed all, pulling her to the crash scene without hesitation.

The landscape flew by in a disorienting rush as Vesna neared the sirens' wail. The ambulance lay on its side like a toppled behemoth, its underbelly exposed to the night. The back doors, its skeletal wings, were flung wide—an open maw of desperation beckoning.

With urgency heavy in her chest, Vesna wrenched the ambulance doors wider, her pulse racing in tandem with the chaos that greeted her. Between the disarray of shattered glass and scattered medical tools, Dunya lay motionless. *How could you?* Vesna's gaze traced the line of each injury, her eyes pausing on the severe third-degree burns and scars that marred Dunya's legs, the worst of them stark white against her skin. But the distinctive marks of a gunblade signaled only one harrowing reality: a self-inflicted wound.

A bitter knot formed in her gut as she realized, with grave familiarity, that she'd seen many Wolves do the same in their darkest moments. Beside Dunya, the formidable Kovalenko—unmistakable for her massive stature, a known ogre within the walls of Fort Ivan—worked deftly with the paramedic. The pair acted as a single entity, their efforts syncing to carefully secure Dunya onto a backboard with gentle, yet urgent precision.

As Vesna watched, Kovalenko looked up briefly, her voice low and steady. “We’ve got her, boss,” she said, before her gaze returned to the task at hand. The paramedic began securing straps around Dunya, not missing a beat.

“I’m not going to lie. Things don’t look good, but we’re doing everything we can,” the paramedic said, catching Vesna’s eye. “Administered emergency exo for the pain, pumped her full of fluids, and she’s on supplemental oxygen. We’re keeping her as comfortable as possible under the circumstances. The Infirmary is still a good ten minutes away, but we won’t stop fighting to get her through this.”

The wail of another ambulance approached. Vesna watched, her chest tight with anxiety, as Kovalenko and the paramedic coordinated their efforts and gently lifted Dunya onto a secure stretcher, ensuring she was ready for the swift transfer.

As the rescue vehicle arrived, a team of medics spilled out, their movements swift and deliberate. Vesna stepped back, providing room for the professionals to work.

They transferred Dunya from the crumpled remnants of the first ambulance into the new one.

“She’ll pull through,” Kovalenko said, her voice a rumble laden with gritty optimism. “Dunya is a fighter—just like you.”

“She gave me a run for my money back there,” Kovalenko added. “You should have seen how fast those hands moved—snatched my blade right from under me.”

Vesna’s response was ice. “Her hands should be on hardlight, not dodging blades in a capsized ambulance, for fuck’s sake.”

Kovalenko’s burly frame seemed to shrink for a moment as she muttered an awkward apology. “I didn’t mean to—It’s just how we Wolves cope, you know? Banter in the face of

darkness.” Kovalenko cleared her throat, straightening up as she sought to regain her usual oaf-like bearing, and bowed her head slightly, a gesture that, coming from her, felt almost like an act of reverence.

Then softly, under her breath at first, she offered a prayer to Velun, matron goddess of the Black Wolves. “Velun, keeper of earth and waters, sovereign of the night’s woods, watch over Dunya in her darkest hour. Let the strength of your flowing rivers and the steadfastness of your deep forests imbue her with the might to return to the pack, whole and unbroken.”

Vesna nodded, finding a measure of comfort in Kovalenko’s prayer. “She has to,” Vesna said, her eyes never leaving Dunya’s still form. Inside, the thought lingered, wrapping around her like a shield: *You have to, Dunya. I’m not ready to face this world without you.*

Once Dunya was secure inside the new ambulance, Vesna raced into the passenger seat. She glanced back at Dunya’s pale form, now under the vigilant care of the medics, as the vehicle pulled away. Sirens cut through the night. Vesna whispered a silent plea to any gods listening—for the strength to support her, for the fragile spark of Dunya’s life to hold steady against the encroaching dark.

As they arrived, the loading bay was abuzz with the urgency of incoming emergencies, but all that mattered to Vesna was the sound of tires screeching to a halt. The back doors of the ambulance flew open.

The shock of the crash scene had rattled Vesna to her core. But as the initial adrenaline subsided, a flood of memories washed over her—nights spent side by side with Dunya, deciphering strings of code, days weaving through the intricate maze of corporate espionage, their shared laughter a rare light in the shadowy corners of their work. And now, Vesna stood rooted to her seat, watching helplessly as the

steady rhythm of her partner's life teetered on a precarious edge.

Medical staff swarmed the scene. Vesna's gut clenched as she trailed behind them, her feet moving almost of their own accord, following Dunya's gurney as it was swiftly wheeled through the metallic double doors and into the sterile white corridors. She could hear the paramedic rattling off medical jargon to the awaiting doctors—a matrix of terms and numbers that drowned beneath the pounding fear in her chest. *If men are good for anything, it's their penchant for spewing stats in the face of chaos.*

As they reached the burn unit's critical care doors, a nurse with a hardlight panel intercepted them. "Immediate debridement procedure for the burn wounds and surgical assessment for her thighs," she declared. "And prepare the skin grafting bay. Initiate broad-spectrum antibiotic protocol immediately; she's showing signs of entering sepsis from the extensive tissue damage. Prognosis is guarded—this won't be pretty."

Vesna's hand reached out instinctively toward Dunya, lingering in the air as if it could bridge the growing distance. She wanted to shout, to demand they let her stay at Dunya's side, but the solemn shake of the nurse's head was clear.

She could only watch as Dunya disappeared behind another set of doors, her body now a battlefield for the surgeons to conquer.

The weight of what Dunya had done, the blaze she had walked through, settled like lead in Vesna's heart. She had seen Dunya walk through fire before, steady and fearless, but this was different. Vesna's eyes stung, a volatile mix of anger and sorrow surging beneath the surface, threatening to spill over.

Turning from the door through which Dunya had disappeared, Vesna's inward turmoil erupted in a quiet curse. "Dammit. I should've been with you. To hell with the city, I've done enough for Zakharovna. I should have been by your side..."

She found herself grappling with a surge of regret, the echo of blasts that had rocked the downtown core resonating. "Those damned banshees got me sidetracked again," she whispered bitterly under her breath. As she dwelt on her decision to respond to the assault rather than accompany Dunya in the ambulance, Arkadya's mocking sneer seemed to resound in her mind, "*Your distractions, they cost lives, Vesna.*"

Beside her, Kovalenko stood stoically. Vesna turned to her and said, "I left her alone out there. If anything happens to her—" The weight of her confession pressed down on her, heavier than she could put into words. She couldn't even think of the right comparison, the right way to explain how much it hurt. "It's on me."

"Regret is a heavy shackle. You made the call you thought right. Now, we stand for her," Kovalenko said.

Vesna clenched her fists, the paramedic's sympathetic glance doing little to ease the turmoil within. "I know," Vesna said. "Just—" She swallowed the knot in her throat, "—never thought stepping away would lead to all this."

The irony was bitter—Vesna had once feared losing herself under the sterile, fluorescent lights of Zakharovna's labs, yet now she was gripped by the fear of losing another: Dunya, always fierce yet so naive to the whims of their merciless city.

As they waited, life in the Infirmary swirled around them—sirens, announcements, the constant ebb and flow of the primordial battle between life and death. But for Vesna, time had stilled, each second an eternity as she waited for news of

Dunya's fate. The irony gnawed at her—*immortality in a pill, a powder, a serum, whatever*, they promised, yet it couldn't even heal the burn wounds that tore through flesh right before her eyes.

Her reflections were abruptly pierced by the approach of a stranger. Clad in a simple white shift that hung on her slender frame, she bore a cascade of black curls framing her pale face. Her hazel eyes held depths that seemed to flicker with hidden knowledge.

"Vesna?" The woman's approach was tactful, her voice carrying the gravity of her next two words. "It's urgent." She produced an identification card.

As Vesna took the card, a skeptical glance turned into focused scrutiny. *This is no ordinary hospital staffer*. She retrieved a small, handheld device from her pocket, scanning the zk-proof embedded within the card's hologram. The device beeped affirmatively—credentials confirmed. Her eyes lifted to meet the woman's, a silent acknowledgment of legitimacy passing between them.

"What is it that I need to know?" Vesna asked.

The woman relayed the message of the Battalion's plan to cast the Black Wolves as conspirators.

Vesna snapped, "We've done nothing but serve this city."

The woman's gaze did not waver. "Romanova doesn't see it quite the same," she said. "She's plotting to eliminate Yelena and Zakharovna both, and you, Vesna, you're caught in her sights. They're planning to replace you."

Vesna's hands clenched tighter as the threat loomed over her, the idea absurd and yet chillingly feasible all at the same time. "They wouldn't dare," she growled, but her own voice carried a tremor of uncertainty. Memories surged, weighing her down—the ruthless efficiency with which Zakharovna had

maneuvered her into Arkadya's place, a strategy as cold as it was calculated. Arkadya, entwined in a long and complex history with Romanova, now merely a name etched into the cold stone of Fort Ivan's rune-marked walls.

What's to stop history from repeating itself? The Wolves had old rules meant to answer exactly that, built around names being recorded, witnesses being heard, and judgment surviving review before anyone reached for the rope. *Trial before rope.* Vesna had heard the phrase recited at Fort Ivan until it seemed older than the walls themselves. Yet Arkadya was dead, command had changed hands through blood, and half the pack now treated strength as proof enough. Vesna had learned the newer lesson too well: power settled arguments faster than any record could. If Romanova meant to replace her, the old words would matter only while enough Wolves still believed in what they were supposed to restrain.

"You have to get out now," the woman said, her eyes scanning the surroundings with a barely concealed urgency. "Head back to allied territory and wait there. Boss will send word on your next orders. It's time to regroup, to bolster our positions in the city sectors where we still have support."

Vesna frowned. "And why didn't she contact me directly? What's so critical that she's been unable to offer backup lately?" Despite her confounding situation, her warrior's pride wouldn't be stilled. "I'm a killer. I don't back down."

The woman's reply was swift and cutting. "Don't be so foolish. Off the record, our Pra Matron is much more fickle than she lets on. If you're in this for your own pride, by all means, stand your ground. But if you're trying to impress her—" She leaned in, her voice dropping to a whisper, "I'd think twice. Zakharovna has moved on to other plays for power. Between you and me, your appointment was a distraction, not a long-term move."

“Did you really think that you could ascend to the heights of the Syndicate from where you stand now?” the woman added.

That probing question clawed at her, a spectral doubt that had lurked unspoken in every shadowed corner of her mind, on every mission, during every fight. Vesna understood the harsh truth in the woman’s words: The Wolves were mighty, but their strength, much like the towering pines of a vast forest, could be felled in a single stroke by one wielding the power of the storm. It was a stark reflection of a truth Vesna had never allowed herself to fully consider—the reality that even the most indomitable warrior stood vulnerable before the intricate, merciless game of politics.

The woman continued, “It’s a rare sight to see a Black Wolf transition to the Board. And Zakharovna...she always knew that wasn’t your true role. Chaos, Vesna, that’s what you were there to create. You were used to shake the foundations, not to be the one that rebuilds them. If you must know, the boss is onto something big. If she succeeds, we won’t need firefights and muscle anymore. But your role hasn’t changed—it’s crucial, and we need you safe for now. So, *move*.”

Vesna felt the ground splinter beneath her. Dunya’s safety, the future of the Wolves, her own place at the helm—all teetered on the precipice of her next choice.

She clenched her fists tighter, her mind a whirlwind of conflict. Abandoning Dunya, especially now, churned in her stomach like acid. How could she justify running to save herself when she hadn’t been there for her, over and over, when Dunya needed her most? The ID in her hand was a siren’s call to survival, but every fiber of her being resisted.

“Stay with her,” Vesna whispered. “Don’t let her wake up alone.”

Reaching into a concealed compartment within the reinforced plating of her uniform, she withdrew a small velvet-lined case—inside, a collar necklace with a single abalone shell pendant, a treasure from a rare spring day they'd spent at Ozero Nalychevo—an afternoon forged in shared laughter and careless whispers against the backdrop of lapping waves and the fresh bloom of wildflowers. *She'll know what this means*, Vesna assured herself, her mind briefly wandering across that sunny lakeside, alighted with glittering waves and the warmth of unguarded smiles.

With the weight of the keepsake transferred, Vesna accepted her decision. To remain would have condemned her to the shadows of conspiracy and betrayal.

CHAPTER TWENTY SIX

MARIA

Maria's reflection flickered on the display's surface as she willed it to life. The projection lit up, unveiling the newsreel footage: a veil of smoke obscured the city's skyline, and flames roared with primal hunger as they consumed the dogwood trees that had long stood sentinel along downtown boulevards.

"The Coven," Mayor Rylova declared, her voice cutting through the crackle of the dying ember, "is behind these atrocities. They're terrorists. And they will answer for their crimes."

Maria studied the mayor, whose practiced smile betrayed nothing.

"These trees," the mayor continued, "represented our city's prosperity, our resurgence from a troubled history. For thirty years, they flourished. And now, in mere hours, they're reduced to ash."

The camera panned to another cluster of scorched trees. Nearby, a squad of Hive infantry, clad in identical gray military gear with black visors and weapons glinting under the harsh sunlight, stood vigil outside City Hall.

"We will not stand for this," Rylova vowed, her voice unwavering. "We will identify the guilty, and we will deliver justice."

Maria cut the feed. "The old beekeeper's got it all wrong," she spat. "The Coven's not some organized group. It's just a rabble—a bunch of disgruntled misfits looking for meaning in chaos."

The door creaked open, and Maria heard the familiar rhythm of footsteps. Serafim's, unmistakable. She came up close behind Maria, her voice low. "The attacks are getting worse. There's a pattern."

Maria scoffed. "They're torching trees. Why trees? We've got a whole forest of them on the city outskirts. If they wanted to halt progress, why not burn a church? A monument?"

"It's symbolic. A message of defiance."

Shadows cast by the newsreel danced across the walls. Maria stood. "I've got enough evidence," she said. "I'll expose her."

"We need a body," Serafim said. "We need to know who's funding them."

"The Hive's control of the mayorship is the only barrier against Syndicate dominance. It'll be altogether eight years before they officially hold the Board again," Maria said.

"The Hive?" Serafim's voice dripped with sarcasm. "What have they got to do with this?"

A moment of clarity struck Maria. They'd disrupted capital markets for years, hindering the city's expansion beyond the peninsula. Now, as the Syndicate teetered on civil conflict, the Hive posed as saviors.

"They're in on it," Maria said. "They always have been."

"How can you know for sure?"

Maria pointed to Rylova's image on the projection screen. "You can see it, can't you? Behind that bullshit stern expression, she's hungry for the turmoil, the upheaval."

"But why?"

"Chaos is their currency, Sera. It's their only ace in a world that dealt them shit all—no pharma-cartel like the University, and no big guns like the Battalion. They're up to something,

and time is slipping through our fingers—Romanova is vulnerable, and we can't afford to hesitate. It's our only chance to prevent a hostile takeover."

The screen displayed a panoramic view of the city's downtown core, the mayor's stronghold. Rylova's campaign posters, plastered on walls, had been supplanted by the Coven's emblems. The image of a burning stiletto, its flames cascading over adjacent honeycombs, had been spray-painted with wild abandon. *Provocative. Undeniably provocative.*

"The early morning arsons," the newscaster's voice was measured, "resulted in scores of injured citizens, with several in critical condition. Seven individuals, apprehended at gunpoint, now face charges of attempted murder and conspiracy to undermine public order."

Mayor Rylova's voice rang out with authority, echoing across Petrovskaya Square. "This is a dark day for our city. But justice will be served."

Maria cut off the newsreel with a swipe of her hand. "It's all a smokescreen," she said. "The Battalion is losing its grip, but that's not the whole picture. I suspect the Hive is manipulating the Coven to distract us."

"If you're right, we need to move. It's time to launch the next phase."

Maria shook her head, holding up a hand to pause Serafim's eager planning. "We can get more out of this. We're not done here. We need to figure out the Hive's real motive."

Serafim's brows lowered. "If they're trying to stall us," she said slowly, "maybe we should change our focus. Instead of dancing to their tune, we could go for the jugular. Let them think they have us fooled while we hit where it hurts."

"The Ascension is our top priority," Maria declared. "Nothing will get in the way of that."

“Don’t do this on your own,” Serafim said.

Maria wrestled with the dilemma: the urge to act immediately, grappling with the need to stick to their meticulously crafted strategy. “The Coven’s move just gave us a chance to break the Hive’s coup,” she asserted, her steps tracing a restless path across the concrete of the warehouse floor. “But if we don’t strike now, we might never get another shot.”

“Strike who? The Coven is all over the place, and nowhere. Look, I get it. They’re a nasty threat. But if we don’t confront the University now, we could miss our last window. The Coven, the Hive...they’re problems either way. But if we can get to Zakharovna first, we’ll be better equipped to deal with *them* later.”

Maria faced Serafim and sighed. “You’re right. We can’t ignore Zakharovna... But let’s not rush into this blindly. We know there’s more to this than we can see on the surface. The Hive are masters at manipulation. If we dig just a bit deeper, I’m sure we can find a way to confront the University and not lose sight of the Coven as well. Just give me a little bit longer.”

The headlines stretched out before her, connecting like a constellation across the city’s grid. She saw beyond the facts—she saw the ripple effect, the impact on countless lives. Doubt had no hold on her now.

UNIVERSITY INVOLVEMENT IN DATA LEAK CONFIRMED - VIEW KEYS EXPOSED - THOUSANDS OF PROFILES DECRYPTED.

Maria leaned back, studying the evidence arrayed before her. The display was a chaotic web of arrows and notes. Every truth held an edge of uncertainty that threatened to derail the entire narrative.

The Syndicate’s violence had drained the public’s hope. There was a delicate line they couldn’t cross—a balance

between fear and rebellion. Too much violence, and unrest would follow; too little, and their grip on the city would loosen. They needed just enough terror to ensure compliance, but not so much as to spark outright revolt. And she already knew what would happen if they pushed too far:

Chaos.

Serafim's voice broke through. "How much time do you need?" she asked, glancing over. "Let's check in on the Wolves and see if the Coven's steering us into a trap."

Maria raised an eyebrow, pulled from her thoughts. "How'd you get access to that?"

"Let's just say I have friends in low places. Or high places, depending on how you look at it."

"Alright, let's dig in." She followed Serafim's lead, closing the newsreel and scanning the matrix of live feeds on the new projection. She zoomed in on one of the interrogation rooms, opening a stream labeled *Lieutenant Teodora Markovich*, then connected to their private comms channel.

The suspect's face was partially obscured, but her defiance radiated through. The black robe and silver hair framed a hardened face, etched with the scars of a brutal life.

Markovich glanced over the notes, her attention shifting back to the woman in front of her. "Saryn Kuo," she echoed the name, a thoughtful lilt to her pronunciation. "That's Yakutian, right?"

"How perceptive."

"Quite the distance from here, then," Markovich said.

"I don't imagine you hiked from Belgrade yourself," Saryn said.

"Serbia, Siberia—it's all just a few vowels apart, but I assure you, I didn't come this way for the weather. The cold is enough

to freeze your jokes before they canna leave your mouth. But I cling to my jokes almost as much as you do to that fire of yours—both of us a bit too stubborn for our own good, da?”

“Well, Markovich, your geographical slips are as stubborn as your wit. But let’s not forget, Kamchatka isn’t Siberia, at least that’s what the locals will tell you. Mislabel their home and they might just claim your tongue for the insult. Regardless, it seems both our tongues have managed just fine here in Gred, despite the frost.”

“Fair enough. Wouldn’t want to offend the natives,” Markovich quipped, feigning a shiver. “But honestly, if it’s a toss-up between frost and fire, give me the icy ruckus of this city over the sweltering sun and ocean waves any day. Your fascination with it, I get it, but remember, others have chased that flame and got burnt. *Praksis*. You know the place, the one dreamt up by those old Croatian ladies everyone’s been yapping about? Sounds a bit too good to be true if you ask me. Imagine, lounging seaside, blue skies above, while rogue shadows circle? Makes you think.”

She shook her head. “If I were a gambling woman, I’d put my money on their beachwear fending off unwanted attention quicker than our rooftop art and blizzards can keep those sky-high snoops at bay. But hey, it remains a quaint little story for now. You know how these things are—sometimes, in the middle of all the madness, there’s a sliver of truth hiding in plain sight.”

“Speaking of vacations, yours won’t be an extended affair. Here in Gred, we don’t do jail time, honey. With everyone living forever and a day, a life sentence is nothing but a long, dull pause—too... Inconsequential.”

“In the good old days, being caged might have made you miss all the world’s wonders. But now? We aim straight for the kill shot. So, before you find out just how literal we get

around here, tell me..." Markovich's voice dropped. "Who's footing the bill?"

"Let's just say they have more money than most people can dream," Saryn replied with an almost casual air. "But money's irrelevant where I'm headed."

"Then why do it?" Markovich asked. "What's the endgame?"

"Immortality." Saryn's voice was steady, confident.

Markovich let out a derisive snort. "Immortality? I'm forty-five and fifty-four. Spent nine years doing dirty work for a government that can't even remember my birthday. Trust me, immortality's not all it's cracked up to be."

Saryn held her gaze, unflinching. "What a lie you live. And it's one they'll strip bare if you don't face it head-on."

"You think I don't know who I am?"

"How many more times, Markovich?" Saryn pressed, casting a scornful look around them. "How many more lives will you waste on phantoms? Don't pretend a mundane existence is what we're all after. You're intelligent. Too intelligent not to sense something bigger lies beyond."

Markovich's shoulders tensed, a hollow laugh escaping her. "Got any better suggestions, then?"

Saryn's smile persisted, almost pitying. "You could start by seeing what's right in front of you."

"I'm looking at you," she snapped. "And all I'm getting is a heap of fairy tales."

"The Syndicate offers what the Coven never will. A weapon. A purpose. A role in this fractured reality. They offer you a chance to be more than just a statistic...but freedom—that's the real temptation, isn't it?"

Markovich's expression twisted into a smirk. "Last I checked, I'm not the one wearing handcuffs, lady."

“You’re correct,” Saryn calmly conceded with a nod. “You’re defined by duty, by the respect you command. You exist to execute orders, to face death without hesitation. You understand mortality, Markovich. Yet, I can see that you long for an end that’s elusive, one that is, unfortunately, bound by regulations. To die is to break the cardinal rule. Subsequently, your loved ones pay. Perhaps in here,” she gestured around to the small, empty room, “is where you truly belong—in a world that cages more than just the body.”

“You have no fucking clue what I want.”

“No, but I do suggest that what you seek is a momentary thrill,” Saryn pressed on. “A spark of joy in a ceaseless void. Lend us your strength in dismantling a regime that rules with reckless abandon, and you’ll find that liberation you’re so desperate to grasp.”

“Dreaming big, aren’t we? Let’s not forget who’s in charge here. You talk too much. Listen, closely—I’ve played this game more times than I care to count. I’ve put down countless freaks like you. You’ll give me the answers *when I want, when I ask*, or you’ll face the same fate as all the rest.”

“The stakes for me have always been life or the fire,” Saryn returned with an easy, defiant chuckle. “You’re hungry for the truth? With every move you make against us, you feed our strength. I could bother with names we’ve roused from the ashes, but why dwell on minutiae? Before you know it, you’ll see for yourself... The whole city is on the cusp of an awakening.”

“If raising the dead is as simple as you claim, perhaps I should expedite your return journey by ending you here and now. Tell me why I shouldn’t.” Markovich’s hand drifted toward the big red button on the table, her fingers hovering just inches above it. A quiet threat hung in the air, ready to

unleash fatal arcs of electricity through the robed woman's body.

"Because you understand the instant you succumb to that urge, that primitive desire to inflict pain, my point is proven. Go ahead, administer the shock you're so eager to discharge, you glorified inquisitor." Saryn taunted. "It'll only further our mission."

Maria's attention wavered, her focus drifting from the private comms feed as Saryn's voice became background noise. Her eyes shifted to the projected web of nodes hovering above her right shoulder, the intricate connections drawing her in. As she scanned the display, her gaze narrowed on an old headline:

SYNDICATE ORDERS SECRET MINDGRAFTS VIA PRIVATE CONTRACTORS.

Focus. Precision was paramount. She zeroed in on the projection, searching for the keystone that would make sense of the Syndicate's moves. Then she saw it—a photograph captured by a forensic team. In infrared, a garnet block, smeared with blood and hidden beneath black plastic, revealed itself. Their agents had tried to erase the evidence, but there it was: a stone of communion.

Maria studied the amassed evidence: photographs, reports, testimonies. Together, they sketched the shadowy figure of Vatrallyna, the so-called Pra Matron of the Coven.

On the display before her, the pixelated image of the fabled Matron seemed to pulse with a fiery intensity, the contrasts flickering like flames. Vatrallyna's name, whispered in the shadowy corners of cybercafes in connection with the city's bombings, was the same name once etched into history books, tied to a legendary battlefield commander pivotal in Gred's rise to power. Her mysterious disappearance at the height of her

influence had turned her into a myth—until her recent, unexpected return from the shadows.

The whispers had grown darker, weaving Vatrallyna's name with disturbing rumors of an insider within the city's walls. This insider, it was said, was the linchpin in a plot that connected the University's academic influence to the city's seedy underbelly. The agenda was chilling: siphoning the souls—neural nets, really—of unsuspecting individuals to feed the growing hunger of a burgeoning machine intelligence, or so the rumors claimed. But who, within the Syndicate's tangled hierarchy, had the knowledge and access to pull the strings of such a scheme?

That was the question that now loomed large, that demanded to be unraveled.

OFFICIAL SYNDICATE RESPONSE TO POLICE CONSPIRACY: A COUP - VESNA VOLKOVA SEIZES THE BLACK WOLVES AS COMMANDER.

One of the Syndicate's key figures was killed in a duel, and another ascended in her place with calculated brutality, as if nothing had happened. It was hardly surprising. The Black Wolves had long earned their reputation for ferocity, regularly refreshing their leadership through ruthless bloodletting. Vesna's mission had been unambiguous in its cruelty—she infiltrated the Wolves, assassinated Arkadya, and delivered her head on a platter. But who stood to gain the most from Arkadya's death? Maria couldn't help but wonder, the implications twisting deeper in her mind.

BREAKING NEWS.

The sharp blare of the news alert jolted Maria's attention. Beside her, Serafim paled, the blood draining from her face. Whatever was in the broadcast clearly rattled her.

"Serafim—" Maria called, but Serafim was already moving. Before Maria could finish, the service door shut hard behind

her, cutting her off and leaving Maria alone in stark, sudden silence.

The headline scrolled across her display: *SENIOR MATRON OF THE BATTALION ARRESTED - DETAILS REMAIN UNDER WRAPS.*

Maria's gaze snapped to the empty chair where Serafim had been moments before, her mind racing as the pieces clicked into place. Her fingers flew over the fanned-out hardlight keyboard, launching a series of proxy servers to mask her breach. "Come on, Black Wolves, I expected better than this," she muttered, mocking the weak security measures as she bypassed a simple packet-filtering firewall.

The cryptic headline had piqued her curiosity, but the real story, she knew, lay buried deeper. Her fingers tensed as she navigated through layered encryption protocols, a few command lines slipping past the intrusion detection system. "There we go...let's see what you're hiding," she murmured, smirking as she initiated a SQL injection. With a sequence of precise keystrokes, she breached the Battalion's Arkyv repository. The process wasn't without resistance—automated defenses flared to life, but she was faster, severing connections as they formed.

Moments later, the Black Wolf dossier materialized in her ocular feed, its dark contents spilling out like secrets long kept in the shadows.

The truth of Grigoreva's children and their demise unraveled. Contrary to the narrative of a fatal car crash, the Matron herself had orchestrated it. Knowing her son would be the ultimate hindrance to her political ascent, she'd arranged his pseudocide, and in a cruel twist, eliminated his twin sister—or so everyone had believed. He'd been masquerading as her ever since, leading a debauched double life that had

kept the political elite on tenterhooks and now ignited pandemonium.

The dossier flickered into view on the projection, stark and unembellished, the text hovering with a cold, clinical detachment:

SUBJECT: Grigoreva, Matron of the Battalion

STATUS: Executed by Emergency Order of Pra Matron Yelena Petrova

SUMMARY: Grigoreva was executed without a Board hearing or due process, bypassing the standard practice of political quarantine. Official justification was not provided.

IMPLICATIONS: The execution of a sitting Matron marks a major escalation and a direct breach of established procedure. Petrova's willingness to bypass the Board signals an accelerating consolidation of power with potentially far-reaching consequences for the Battalion and other factions.

Maria spun around, shouting through her earpiece into the now-empty space. "Answer me! The truth's out. You can't just vanish. Serafim!" Her voice echoed back from the cold walls, the only response to her call. A surge of frustration flared, and with a swift, forceful motion, she slammed her fist into the table. The sharp thud broke the silence. "Damn it."

Romanova tagged Serafim as the tool, but all this time, was I the one being played? Maria's mind raced. *I let my guard down, let trust creep in where it had no place. And now, with the truth out, where's Serafim's twin hiding? What's their stake in this whole mess?*

As the thud from her fist faded into the cold air, Maria sat motionless, her eyes fixed on the empty space. "It's like wading through a maze of mirrors," she murmured to herself. "Each reflection more distorted than the last."

The pieces of the puzzle were finally coming together. Maria paced to the window, her gaze sweeping across the sprawling cityscape. She could almost see the sequence of events unfold: how Grigoreva's unchecked ambition left her vulnerable to betrayal, how Zakharovna's arrogance blinded her to the shifting politics, and how Yelena's impatience led her to overreach. Each one had played a part, yet it all fed into a larger scheme—a quest for control over something they coveted but couldn't contain.

They all bore responsibility for the crisis now unfolding—and they would all face the reckoning.

Maria reviewed the narrative once more. The Battalion had launched an offensive against the police following a damning data leak that exposed the University's horrifying practice of harvesting its own citizens to nourish Babushka, the mechanized heart of the city's infrastructure. It must have been happening for over a decade.

The Black Wolves were deployed to neutralize the leak. Given their history of scanning students and staff with unnerving frequency, the revelation wasn't entirely shocking. But why now? What deeper play was unfolding beneath the surface?

They weren't just observing; perhaps they were constructing something... more elaborate. Maria's mind raced with the thought of an intricate database, a digital doppelganger of the city's population. They could be building a tool—a system designed to manipulate, to control, to exert influence in the most covert and insidious ways.

No, it seemed too outlandish. Yet the puzzle pieces were aligning, however improbable. If the University had indeed been siphoning data to serve the shadowy echelons pulling the strings, the implications were dire. With the Hive perched precariously as the interim authority before the Ascension,

wielding such a trove of information would cement their power. They'd have access to detailed profiles on everyone connected to the University—protestors, secret meeting attendees, insurgents like herself.

In this fragile transition, with the Battalion teetering on the edge of power, Maria felt the chilling realization settle over her: she could very well be the next mark in the Hive's ruthless game.

Yet, amid the unfolding chaos, something in her gut felt right. It was the sight of the marginalized fighting back against years of oppression by the police and their collaborators. The Syndicate was too entangled in its own internal conflicts, too preoccupied to address the real threats. The catalyst for change had to come from an outsider—someone with the clarity to act when others hesitated.

But who stood to gain from Arkadya's downfall? Who had the resources to recruit a former operative and arm them to eliminate a Commander of the Black Wolves? And who had the most to gain from Vesna's ascent? The true menace cast its shadow far and wide, as clear as an open book, its emblem unmistakable—the University, the mastermind orchestrating this anarchy from behind the scenes.

No, too obvious. Another figure lurked in the shadows, a maven who had deftly sidestepped any association with the mire of corruption for years. Not a shred of evidence, not a whisper of testimony linked them. But Maria couldn't shake her nagging intuition. There was a single Matron, her influence expanding quietly but steadily, who perhaps held more sway over this chaos than anyone had suspected.

Determination settled over her as the pieces fell into place. She had to communicate her suspicions, no matter the risk. Moving quickly, she composed a message to Tatyana,

encrypting it hastily: “The queen bee rules more than just her swarm.”

Serafim was wrong. Or more likely, she wanted me to doubt whether I was right. Maria's mind raced. Yelena's at the helm, steering it all, while Tatyana put her faith in her to hold off the big boss. But what if Zakharovna was never the obstacle we thought? Matron Romanova's walking into a trap far more dangerous than any of us anticipated.

Maria paused, the weight of their predicament settling over her, as heavy as the silence in the room.

The air grew tense—like static before a storm. Her instincts screamed. The Coven's plans were unfolding, and she was in their crosshairs.

She needed to get out, now.

Commotion erupted in the streams. An explosion. Then another. Surveillance feeds blinked out—seven cameras, six, five...blackouts.

It all converged at breakneck speed. Maria bolted for the exit, bursting into the open as the clamor of the dock assaulted her senses.

Laborers, their limbs intertwined with the intricate lattice of Skelet machinery, hoisted crates with a strength that defied their human bearers. The metallic sinews of their augmented arms gleamed in the harsh morning light as they navigated the orchestrated chaos of their workday.

Maria wove through them, her every movement an act of desperate precision. A shoulder slammed against hers, a snarl of frustration following as a worker stumbled, the contents of her crate spilling out in a discordant clatter.

The weight of her failure settled in Maria's chest, as heavy and unrelenting as the machinery that surrounded her. It had

all been in vain—her satellite link was breached, cutting her off from the city's network.

A forceful grip seized her arm from behind. Maria wrenched herself free, her heart pounding as she sprinted forward. A squad of women in dark uniforms appeared ahead, forming a barricade. She veered toward a side street, but before she could escape, a body slammed into her, driving her hard against the wall.

Maria gasped for air as a knee pressed painfully into her back. A harsh voice hissed in her ear, "You're finished."

Maria shook her head, struggling for breath.

"You're coming with us," snarled the Black Wolf.

Out of the corner of her eye, Maria caught the metallic glint of a cylindrical object in one of the women's hands, ready to strike. In a split second, she kicked backward, catching her assailant off-guard. She twisted the wrist holding the object, sending the cylinder flying.

The second woman reached for a gun at her hip, but Maria was faster. She grabbed the weapon and hurled it down the street.

"You're fucking dead, you little bitch!" the first woman spat, lunging at Maria again.

Switching to defense, Maria grabbed the woman's arm, spun her around, and slammed her into the wall with a solid thud. The other two scrambled for their guns, only to find them missing.

Maria delivered a sharp punch to one woman's stomach, stopping her from reaching for another weapon. The third woman brandished a shock stick, but Maria trapped her arm, twisted it behind her back, and pressed her hand firmly against the woman's neck.

As the other two writhed on the ground, Maria leaned in close. “Your Alpha Commander won’t be around for much longer,” she said.

The Black Wolf hesitated, and the one in Maria’s grip stammered, “You...you can’t touch us. Vesna will—”

“Vesna?” Maria cut her off, her voice dripping with contempt. “You think a traitor is going to save you?”

The Black Wolf’s defiant laughter turned into a choked gasp as Maria’s grip tightened around her neck. Moments later, the woman collapsed to the ground, lifeless.

Maria’s hand fell to her side, her grip loosening as numbness spread through her arm. She allowed herself only a second to catch her breath before her eyes snapped into focus, sweeping her surroundings with the precision of a seasoned operative. The shadows, once offering silent solace, now teemed with menace. Her heart thumped a warning before her mind fully grasped the situation: Wolves, not just at her back but emerging like specters from the dim alley ahead.

She was hemmed in, an unwitting centerpiece to an encircling pack. As she took in the grim reality—each Wolf with a gun trained on her, fingers itching at triggers—a cold clarity settled over her. She was entirely, desperately cornered.

“Get on the ground,” a voice commanded from behind her.

Maria barely had time to respond before an agonizing surge of electricity tore through her, cutting her short. Her body betrayed her, convulsing once before falling still. Her vision splintered into shards of light and shadow, and time lost all meaning. Every sound became distant, every sensation muted, as if the world itself had pulled away. She lay immobilized, the ground beneath her suddenly too real, too

hard—a brutal landing from a battle that had ended far too soon.

Vesna's voice cut through the haze of Maria's shock, ice-cold and dripping with mockery. "Trust is a treacherous thing, isn't it? The Syndicate's eyes are legion, and they see much more than you realize."

Maria struggled, desperate to muster the glare her paralyzed body refused to give.

"Relax. You're not going anywhere," Vesna's words slithered into her ears. Maria felt the cold press of Vesna's fingertips trace down her spine as her former partner stooped closer.

I will make you pay for this.

Rage seethed beneath Maria's skin, clawing for release, but her body betrayed her, frozen and mute. Helplessness tightened its grip as Vesna's piercing gaze held her still.

As each stifled scream echoed through the prison of her mind.

CHAPTER TWENTY SEVEN

KLARA

The air shuddered inside the small chapel carved into the wall of the Akhmatova Railways. Jagged stone framed a weathered pine altar, and three sconces burned above it, their flames wavering whenever the rails groaned deeper in the earth. The room was packed with outlaws and cravens, eager fires rousing inside them, straining to break free from mortal bonds.

“Sisters and brothers,” Klara declared, “today marks a critical juncture in our conflict. The Syndicate, that vile cartel of politicians, soldiers, and scoundrels, has ruled with an iron fist for far too long. We have suffered under their despotism, and now, our moment for vengeance has come!”

The congregation’s voices surged, swelling in fervor around her. Klara’s smile sharpened. With a commanding sweep of her arms, the voices fell silent. “Tonight,” she declared, “we invoke the spirit of vengeance to aid us. We will harness our magic and bring this civil war to its crushing end!”

Klara’s gaze swept over the crowd as the cheers rose again, swelling into a storm. The air before her shimmered, and a sudden burst of light formed an image. Her breath caught at the sight of the hovering figure—an ancient crone, draped in tattered black robes, hunched and frail. Yet from it, an unmistakable energy pulsed. The projection’s eyes locked with Klara’s, and its lips curled into a smile.

“I am here to aid you,” the spirit rasped. “Tell me what you desire, and I shall grant you the might to seize it.”

Klara’s arms shot out in a triumphant sweep. “I want the Syndicate!”

The ghost of vengeance cackled, the sound reverberating through the chapel. "I can do that," she said. "I give you my blessing, young one. Go forth and slaughter them all."

With a flash as swift as her arrival, the spirit burst into a radiant conflagration and vanished. Silence shattered as the Coven erupted, their voices wild, hungry for blood.

"Far above us, the fires converge," Klara roared. "The Syndicate crumbles as we speak. This is only the beginning."

Pra Matron Vatrallyna rose, a satisfied smile playing on her cracked white lips, the only part of her face visible beneath the hood. She lifted her hands, and the tumult quickly abated. "Victory is within our grasp," she proclaimed. "Sisters and brothers, let us force the Syndicate to their knees. Now is the time to reclaim what is rightfully *ours*."

The congregation erupted again, their voices rising into a frenzied storm. Klara's pulse quickened as Vatrallyna approached, draping her arms over Klara's shoulders. "You are the future of our Coven," she said. "No one can stand in your way."

Vatrallyna stepped forward, her robe as dark as the shadows clinging to the chapel's walls. The fabric whispered against the stone floor as she moved, her presence a quiet force. Beneath her hood, eyes glowed green and red, locking the assembly in an almost tangible hold.

"Klara shall lead the final assault," Vatrallyna's voice rang out. "The chosen will accompany her. Together, we will dismantle the Syndicate's dominion!"

Cheers erupted, a thunderous affirmation of Vatrallyna's words. Among the surging bodies, the revelers parted as she moved through them with swift purpose. Klara's gaze followed, watching the sable robe slip through the archway like a shadow vanishing into the night. Vatrallyna disappeared just as the revelry began to swell.

With a subtle gesture from Klara, the room exploded into celebration. Shadows flickered and danced as the assembly gave in to wild abandon. The air throbbed with war cries, shifting into a primal chorus of ecstasy. Hands reached out, not merely touching but claiming, as claws and grasping fingers met in a feverish communion. A ritualistic fervor swept through the crowd, binding them in a shared, ravenous hunger for the battle ahead.

Klara stood at the epicenter, arms lifted toward the dark ceiling. Power surged through her, fueling each incantation. In one hand, a silver knife gleamed; in the other, a mortar of blood-red communion stones pulsed with an eerie glow.

As the ritual's energy reached its peak, Klara allowed a moment of reflection. The outlaws surrounding her, once defiant lords of volition, had been reshaped by the exovegeta. She had foreseen how it would peel back the years, freeing them from time's weight, but it had also made them pliable. The compound dissolved their fierce independence, unlocking a malleability she had carefully harnessed. Watching their fervent devotion, Klara understood the drug's dual nature: it bestowed the illusion of youth while binding them to her vision, forging warriors from wanderers at the cost of the autonomy they could no longer reclaim. She had once dosed pain to keep bodies alive; now she dosed belief and called it salvation.

The frenzied crowd of outlaws and cravens surged toward her, and Klara basked in the heat and frenzy as she brandished her blade. She reveled in the chaos. With a sudden motion, she thrust her arms upward, a conduit for the dark power coursing through her. Energy surged from the depths, channeled through her raised limbs, coiling into black lightning that wrapped around the bloodstones.

As the air crackled with the storm she had summoned, Klara lowered her arms and stepped forward, ready to lead her chosen into the heart of their wild sacrament.

Her dagger, now blazing with annihilation's fire, cut through the chaotic crowd. Her acolytes mirrored her every move—extensions of her deadly will, entwined in the ritual's deadly rhythm. Blades flashed, blood spilled, anointing the ground in dark reverence. Klara's cry pierced the air, marking the ritual's climax as men and women fell in perfect unison. One by one, the bodies were dragged into place, forming a grim circle of the fallen. As blood pooled in the pattern they created, the frenzy dissolved into a haunting stillness. Encircled by her loyal followers, Klara surveyed the crimson ring—a testament to their unity and sacrifice.

Lifting her gaze from the carnage, Klara felt the weight of her actions settle over her like a shadow. She stared at the blood coating her skin, a flicker of dissonance stirring within. Beneath the triumph, a whisper of remorse crept into her thoughts.

What have I become? The question no longer stopped her, but it still knew where to cut.

She recalled the days when her hands brought healing instead of death. Her past as a nurse, tending to the weak and mending the broken, felt like a distant life, a world away from the carnage she now commanded.

The Hive's principles are my commandments now; the Coven, my sanctuary.

She inhaled deeply, forcing herself to stand firm against the flood of memories. Sorrow for the lost, for those used as mere pawns in a war greater and darker than any one soul, clashed with the satisfaction of power and purpose. *This is the path I must walk*, she reminded herself, stifling the creeping regret. *The sacrifices today pave the road to reclamation.*

In the silence that followed, only the women rose, their wounds sealed, bodies restored by the ritual's lingering flames. Klara knelt beside one of the fallen men, pressing her hand into his chest. A frigid rush surged through her as she pulled his still-beating heart free.

This is the grim dance of our survival.

Shock widened the dying man's eyes as her silver knife struck true, consuming the blood and viscera in a swift motion.

Around her, the freshly risen women moved in unison, their hands drenched in crimson, mouths stained brown and red. Their eyes fixed on Klara, waiting, silent and expectant. Patients had once looked at her that way, trusting her to preserve what remained; now they waited for her to tell them what to destroy.

She could feel the weight of their anticipation pressing down, as if her next action was already carved into their bones. Klara raised her head and caught their collective gaze, something raw, almost ravenous, stirring within the ritual's intensity. Did they feel the same sharp edge of regret that flickered beneath her own hunger? She wondered.

Are we nourished by this power, or are we diminished by it?

The chamber door creaked open, revealing a familiar silhouette.

"Natasha," Klara whispered. She turned from her grim work, her eyes falling to Natasha's hands. *From one bloodletting to another, we wade deeper into the mire*, she mused.

"It's time," Natasha said, unveiling a knife from beneath her cloak, its blade gleaming ominously with a fresh crimson stain. "We must go."

With a nod, Klara signaled to her new army. Together, they joined Natasha, striding from the chapel, their blood-drenched bodies a testament to the night's dark rites. They descended into the shadowy depths of the metro, Klara feeling the weight of vengeance driving her steps, a shared purpose visible in every determined stride around her.

As they ran through the tunnels, the flickering torchlight dimmed, and a chilling wind howled through the corridors, carrying with it an unsettling stillness.

They emerged into an immense chamber, bathed in the faint, eerie glow of overhead subway lights, casting an otherworldly pallor on the gathering. Dozens of silver and fiery-haired women stood waiting, their faces streaked with white clay, gums twitching with barely contained anticipation. Their eyes burned mahogany, webbed with broken arteries, and as they encircled Klara. The hunger emanating from them was palpable.

"We've crossed through the flames and emerged reborn, sisters," Klara declared. "What we have done tonight was not easy, but by Aisyt's fire, we are absolved and empowered."

Natasha stepped forward, her presence instantly drawing every eye. "The sacrifices made were necessary, the path to justice never easy. Now is the time we rise—stronger, unyielding, together!" Her voice, rich and commanding, reverberated through the underbelly of the city. "For the Coven! No mercy until dawn!"

The gathered women, their faces streaked with blood and clay, responded in a single, fierce cry that ricocheted off the vaulted tunnels. "For the Coven!"

As their voices faded, the air buzzed with an eerie stillness. Klara's gaze drifted over her blood-soaked sisters, her pulse quickening in sync with the charged atmosphere. But then, her attention snagged on something—or someone—out of

place. A figure swathed in an emerald trench coat, silver hair cropped short. Blue eyes, sharp as ice, locked onto hers.

For a moment, her pulse faltered. The raw energy of the ritual seemed to stall in her chest. This woman didn't belong here. She stood too calm, too composed, like the eye of a storm that hadn't touched her. Where the others hummed with purpose, she was still, unshaken, a quiet disruption in their unified ranks.

Making her way through the dark mass, Klara's eyes narrowed on the woman's clean hands, conspicuously devoid of the ritual's crimson stain. A heat radiated from her, intense and unsettling, cutting through the cold. *The fire is strong in this one...* For the first time in longer than she cared to admit, Klara felt the pull of power she had not summoned herself.

Klara leaned in, just enough for her words to reach the woman. "What's your story? You're not dressed for the party."

Around them, the room seemed to hold its breath, the weight of the crowd's focus pressing in, thick and expectant.

"Come on now. Tell me your name." Klara extended her hand, fingers grazing the woman's slender wrist. A strange calm pulsed beneath her touch, an unexpected stillness that set her on edge.

Before she could process the sensation, her world shattered. A sharp, searing pain tore through her, and a blinding brilliance swallowed her vision, wrenching her from the moment and sending her reeling.

When clarity slowly returned, Klara found herself amid the desolation of what had once been a sacred space. The air hung thick with the acrid remnants of fire and conflict, ash and smoke stinging the back of her throat. Splintered pews lay scattered around her, their shattered pieces occupying the spot where, moments before, the woman's hand had been. She

inhaled sharply, the scent of dust and ruined stone filling her lungs.

Above, the cathedral's ceiling had been ripped open, leaving a jagged wound that exposed the sky. The ruins seemed to reach out, forlorn and abandoned. In the distance, the mournful wail of women's voices rose.

Beneath the open dome of white sky, shards of colored glass glinted like fallen stars, and a figure of light began to take shape. It hovered where the altar once stood, a radiant being that defied the ruin around it. Klara's breath caught in her chest—there was such tranquility in its glow, a calm that seemed to challenge the devastation, brighter even than the dawn breaking above.

The figure's serene face turned toward her, and her heart lurched, caught between trepidation and awe.

The trance dissolved, leaving Klara momentarily unsteady before an unexpected clarity settled over her. Natasha's hand on her arm anchored her to the present. "What is it?" Natasha said. "Are you frightened, Klara?"

Klara shook her head as the remnants of the vision lingered, slowly fading. "No, not frightened," she said. *I've never been less frightened.* Whatever had opened before her in that vision, it felt less like a warning than permission.

She rose to her full height, her gaze sweeping over her fellow sisters.

"My chosen," Klara began, the weight of her vision steadying her voice, "our journey forward will be perilous, laden with strife. But know this—bound together, we cannot be conquered. The spirits of those wronged fuel our cause. We will bring our foes to heel and restore the balance denied to us for too long."

The Coven's cheers rose, their voices merging into a single, powerful chorus. Klara could feel their collective strength surging through her, each sister's power feeding into the whole.

"Natasha will lead our assault," Klara continued. "Follow her command, and victory is certain."

Natasha stepped forward, her eyes bright with eager anticipation—a hunger Klara knew had been simmering beneath the surface for far too long.

"Come, sisters," Natasha called, her voice sharp and commanding. "Destiny awaits!" She turned, knife in hand, and led the Coven forward. They followed her as one, a shadowy procession slipping into the tunnels, their footsteps a soft, rhythmic echo against the concrete concourse.

Klara returned her gaze to the woman in green, a strange calm settling over her as their eyes locked. The initial blaze of tension had shifted, giving way to something deeper, more unsettling. In the slender woman's sharp blue stare, Klara glimpsed fleeting whispers of another world, another time.

The metro station beneath them shuddered violently, an explosion echoing from afar. The woman's lips twisted into a savage snarl. "You can call me Marzanna," she said.

Klara barely had time to register the name before Marzanna grabbed her arm and yanked her into the cover of the shadows.

CHAPTER TWENTY EIGHT

TATYANA

Tatyana steadied her breath. Then, with a focused exhale, she spoke, her voice firm as her eyes locked onto the camera lens. “Citizens of Gred, this is Tatyana Romanova.”

She paused briefly, the weight of her own name settling in her chest. “*Chief* of the Intelligence Bureau of our Military. *Pra Matron* of the Battalion. And, if you stand with truth and justice, your *Chair* of the Syndicate, your leader in Gred.”

She took another beat, letting the silence stretch. She pictured the millions of eyes fixed on the projections throughout the city, waiting for what would come next.

“We have made a chilling discovery. There is a coup, right within the ranks of our very police force. Senior officers...our own people...have betrayed us, have conspired against their government.”

“They allowed the University to carry out unspeakable acts on our citizens. The details of these experiments...they’re harrowing, beyond what any of us could have imagined.”

“As many of you are aware, the Black Wolves, under the command of former Syndicate operative Vesna Volkova, have failed in their attempt to impose martial law, and in their retreat are now terrorizing those who sought to bring the truth to light. We call upon you, the people of Gred, to resist any orders they may issue. With our strength and your unwavering support, we can thwart this coup before it inflicts further devastation.”

“The Syndicate...the government you’ve placed your trust in, the one you believed in...it’s been but a facade.”

“We hope and trust that you, our fellow citizens, will now see through the illusions and discern the truth for yourselves.”

“And know this—the military, your guardians, we stand by you. Beside you. Every step of the way. We regret the distress our forthcoming actions might cause. But they...they are necessary. For we must shield our beloved city from a collapse of the rule of law, a ruin that would endanger everything...everything we hold dear.”

“I must make this clear. We have no intention—none whatsoever—to let our city fall into chaos. The services, the aid, the support we extend to those who seek us out...that will not wane.”

“This is not, I repeat, this is *not* a declaration of war. This is us, standing tall, standing firm, our concerted effort to protect our city, our home, from those who...tragically, have betrayed its trust.”

△△△

Matron General Irina Nikitin’s gaze locked onto Tatyana, the weight of her stare pressing in with an intensity that made Tatyana’s chest tighten—relief mingled with a creeping apprehension.

Nikitin then turned her attention to Colonel Kolya Zhukova and Colonel Olega Orlov. “Kosatka Harbor needs reinforcing. Dispatch whatever Black Wolves we have left to bolster their defenses. We must hold that position.” Her voice carried through the dimly lit war room, each word echoing slightly off the walls.

Colonel Olega Orlov saluted and replied, “I’m afraid that won’t be possible. Volkova’s turned our remaining Black

Wolves against us, and Yelena has converted the difference. The loyal ones we still have will be posted at the Mariner's Cathedral for the Pra Matron's pustch."

Nikitin glanced at Orlov, her expression unreadable, though something sharp flickered in her eyes. "Your transition to overseeing the Bureau after Grigoreva's...*exit* has been rather rapid, hasn't it, Orlov?"

Before Tatyana even realized she was speaking, the words burst from her. "Grigoreva *broke the law*, and Yelena will face judgment for each of her breaches against the Charter. The Grand Mariner won't stand for the execution of a Matron without due process... But as for Yelena, she's out of luck." She paused, letting the weight of her words settle in the room. "She'll get no justice, and the Mariner will have to accept that. Go on, Orlov. Give your report."

Orlov met her gaze directly. "With my current level of access, I've been able to see the extent of Yelena's manipulation. Her leverage over Grigoreva had rendered the late Deputy Intelligence Chief, at best, incompetent. It seems that Grigoreva had uncovered pivotal information on Yelena's associations with the Coven, but she failed to cover her tracks. In return, Yelena had her neutralized. And now, the Coven's forces are converging within the Railways."

Nikitin's eyes narrowed, her thoughts clearly working behind them. "Then pull together the Bureau's best assassins. Rally them, Orlov. We don't have the luxury of time on our side."

A flicker of hesitation crossed Orlov's face. "The Bureau has been compromised, General. Yelena's web of influence runs deeper than we thought. We granted her access in hopes of using her knowledge against Zakharovna, but she's turned the tables on us. We must consider a different approach."

Nikitin's hand gripped the table. "We won't be made fools in our own house."

"They're gearing up, Matron General. Their weapon cache is beneath the old warehouse district, guarded by the Hive's shock troops. Worse, they're skulking around the Southern Pier, right at the heart of the Grand Mariner's territory."

Nikitin's face paled. "Our fleet?"

Orlov nodded. "Precisely. Their objective is clear: commandeer our gunships docked in the harbor. Armed with that fleet, they could outflank and entrap us, crippling our defenses."

Colonel Kolya Zhukova, who had been silent until now, finally spoke:

"The intel is credible. We'll position our forces at the harbor," Zhukova explained, her green eyes sweeping across the room.

As her hand moved, Tatyana caught the crimson bear clip fastened to Zhukova's uniform. There was a small, dark smudge on her fingers—maybe blood.

Tatyana had known Zhukova for years. Her face was familiar, yet she seemed different all the same—harder, more focused. Zhukova was the Battalion's most loyal and effective military strategist, her reputation built during the War of Formation. That's what counted. But even so, Tatyana couldn't shake the feeling that something had shifted in her. They'd never shared more than brief exchanges, mostly reports and battlefield updates, but Tatyana had always known exactly where Zhukova stood—until now. *There's always more to a story...*

"The Hive is setting up a staging area near the old warehouse district," Zhukova continued, "but they'll anticipate a direct assault. By moving to the harbor, we

protect our fleet and disrupt their supply routes. This forces them to divert resources, drawing them away from the staging ground without giving them the engagement they're expecting."

Orlov unfurled a map across the table. "While you fortify the harbor, Kolya, my forces will target the Coven's underground strongholds before the Hive can marshal their full potential."

She tapped her finger on the red dots that marked the entry points deep within Zakharovna Central's peripheral arteries. "We should focus on taking out their leadership here."

She looked up. "We can't afford a full-scale war with the Hive's main regiments, not yet. They're expecting us to engage first, especially now that they know we've uncovered their collusion with the Coven. That leak in the Intelligence Bureau tipped them off. We'll lock down the metro and set up checkpoints to contain their movements."

Orlov traced routes on the map. "Control the flow, contain the spread. It's our best chance to foil their plans without giving them the provocation they want."

Zhukova's eyes hardened. "I'll handle the harbor. You can count on me."

Nikitin exhaled deeply. "Excellent. But I want regular reports, especially from you, Zhukova."

Zhukova nodded.

"Very well. Let's put an end to this rebellion." With a measured calm, General Nikitin saluted her colonels, signaling the beginning of a counter-coup that would shake the foundations of Gred.

Tatyana exchanged a glance with the general before turning to the other two. Their green and gold uniforms shimmered under the sparse lighting, a sharp contrast to her burgundy.

With a slight nod, she acknowledged the plan. Without a word, they rose, their steps steady and synchronized as they departed.

Tatyana's mind lingered on the strategy laid out before them. The plans were bold—calculated—but something gnawed at her. Zhukova's confidence, though expected, felt unsettling. She'd been quiet for most of the discussion, yet her presence carried a weight Tatyana couldn't quite place. *She's too eager.* The smudge on her fingers hadn't escaped Tatyana's notice either. *No...focus. This is not the time for doubt.*

Nikitin finally sat down at her desk opposite Tatyana, picking up the glass that awaited her. Swirling its contents, the dim light caught in the liquid's subtle movement. "So, Zakharovna wasn't a threat after all?"

"She was supposed to be," Tatyana replied. "But the real thorn was Yelena. The audacity of that woman, thinking she could offer us 'protection' before my Ascension—as if I needed shielding from Zakharovna! Still, accepting Yelena's help was necessary to gauge her limits, to see how far she'd go. And when it came time to vote Zakharovna out, it was the perfect chance to deal with two threats at once. Yelena's ambition blinded her to the fact that I never intended to keep her close once Zakharovna was out of the way."

"So, what extinguishes a fire?" Nikitin asked.

"Varies with the blaze," Tatyana said. "A measure of water might quench a simple flame. Deprivation of fuel can starve it into nonexistence. Yet, there are conflagrations that..." She paused, choosing her words with care. "Some fires need to be allowed to burn through their lifeforce, consuming all in their path until they flicker out, to leave space for new growth."

She leaned forward. "Consider this—our desperation for resources, the Syndicate's disproportionate power amidst our city's fragility," she mused aloud. "Why haven't we rebuilt our

dominion? Set forth again across the Pacific, reclaimed the skies? There is possibility in the ashes.”

“We should not be looking to reform what’s broken, nor revolt at shadows. The future demands a new structure, one that grows organically from what has endured despite the current regime. The roots of change, the embryonic state organs of what’s to come, must exist even now beneath the surface, waiting to unfurl. Our adversaries lurk unseen, their influence more pervasive and cunning than we’ve allowed ourselves to admit. They’ve checkmated us from the darkness, but I refuse to play a losing game. We’ll lay our claim to the power that’s rightfully ours, and in doing so, we shall unearth their full machinations. Only then can we truly fathom the reach of our reign.”

Nikitin nodded slowly, her expression grave. “Their grip on power—it’s insidious and far-reaching. I’ve always suspected as much, yet their full capability has remained frustratingly out of grasp to me.”

“Riddle me this, Nikitin,” Tatyana said coolly. “Why was Yelena so eager to discipline Grigoreva, to dismantle our intelligence networks? Grigoreva was spooked, certainly, with her sordid life exposed for all to see. Breaking the law is one thing, but I suspect she panicked over something more...this ‘son,’ perhaps. He’s a figure of greater significance than anyone has accounted for. Why else hide him all this time? And the daughter? Well, she’s been within my reach, unwittingly playing her part, and had it not been for the recent photos, her truth would’ve remained hidden, even to me... Zakharovna...she has *heirs*.”

Nikitin wrinkled her brow, clearly confused. “What are you talking about, Tatyana? Spell it out for me.”

Tatyana leaned back, locking eyes with Nikitin. “*Genetics*, General. The tendency to have twins runs in families, does it

not? Zakharovna was herself a twin, and her brother, Alexei, our revered former leader, carried that same gene. Alexei fathered twins, but their fates have since become a mystery. Where did they go, Nikitin?"

Nikitin's eyes widened, the realization dawning. Her voice trembled with the weight of her guess. "Nowhere to run in Gred."

"Exactly...they're both still alive, right here in the city. And despite everything we've done for Gred's citizens, the baseborn still hold fast to simple truths. Imagine if they discovered that Alexei Zakharov's son lives, disfigurement notwithstanding, they'd clamor for his rule. Picture it—a *man*, a Zakharov, untouched by time, leading our society. That would herald an entirely different world."

Nikitin was seized by a fit of laughter, which escalated into a full-blown wheeze. "This has to be some kind of joke," she gasped between bouts of hearty laughter. "I could never imagine...Alexei...with that old fox. She—"

The sound grated against Tatyana's nerves. Her jaw tightened, but she didn't allow her irritation to show beyond a measured exhale. "This is no laughing matter, General," she cut in, raising a commanding hand to stop the flippant, ill-timed mockery. The moment felt too heavy for such levity, as if Nikitin couldn't grasp the weight of what was at stake. "It all falls into place... The vile whispers... Nina's circle, the scoffing at galas over rumors too ghastly to speak aloud...and Ivan Sorokin's suicide—a tragic act born from a harrowing truth unraveled—that his 'daughter', in fact, was sired by none other than the king who never came to be. We must locate this living testament to their indiscretion and turn it to our advantage. This is our moment to lift the Battalion to its rightful zenith. It's our time ascend, Nikitin."

Tatyana turned in her chair, her gaze shifting to the window and lingering on the troops marching below. The soldiers, adorned in green military uniforms, were distinguished by gold runes that glinted in the sunlight, a touch of regal elegance to their martial appearance. Their rifles were poised with disciplined precision. Tatyana hadn't seen her army this prepared for battle in years, and a part of her, a part honed by old skirmishes and older victories, rued the absence of a good war.

Nikitin leaned forward slightly, the soft light from the room's lone lamp casting shifting shadows across her face. "You're suggesting we risk everything," she said.

"We have been pawns for too long, bent to the whims of shadow rulers. It's time we take control of the board," Tatyana said.

"And abandon the Charter," Nikitin added.

"As if they *all* haven't already," Tatyana said. "Now we play catch-up; we've been too honorable in our dealings with scum."

"And the people—how will they react to our coup?" Nikitin asked.

"Coup? Have you been listening at all? This, this is a *revolution*."

There was a slight, almost imperceptible shift in Nikitin's stance—enough for Tatyana, who had spent decades learning this general's silent tells—to discern agreement.

"Then what comes next..." Nikitin had stopped questioning. Now, she was listening.

Tatyana felt her smile return. "...is order."

The Grand Mariner's Cathedral swelled with a congregation of seasoned souls. Enforcers with scars that told tales of battles long fought, elder women etched by wisdom, and military veterans with a glint of discipline in their eyes filled every pew and chair. Tatyana navigated this throng of aged strength, nodding to familiar faces as she passed. At the front, the Battalion stood in formation, their green and gold uniforms a sharp contrast against the pristine white marble.

Tatyana saluted crisply, and the response was instant: the soldiers roared, their faces ignited with fervor, rallied to the call of duty. They quickly formed a line that stretched from the entrance to where Matron General Nikitin stood, a silent sentinel at her dais, her back rigid, her expression unreadable.

As the soldiers' roars faded into a charged silence, Tatyana moved closer to Nikitin. She leaned in, receiving the whispered update directly into her ear: "The Hive's force concentration has slowed, but make no mistake—those damned witches are assembling."

With a curt nod, Tatyana acknowledged the update and turned her gaze toward the west doors. Commander Goga Borisova entered, flanked by her elite Black Wolves.

As Tatyana advanced toward the chancel, the crowd parted like a sea obeying an invisible tide. Two figures rose from the midst, commanding the space: Grand Mariner Veronika Lagunov, her mane of silver glowing under the cathedral's light, her gaze sharp and unyielding; and at her side, Commodore Alexandra Baranov, a steady shadow to the towering leader.

Tatyana locked eyes with the Grand Mariner. "I have a proposition for you, Lagunov."

"Haven't you done enough?" the Grand Mariner snapped.

“I’ve worked to strengthen our hold on key districts,” Tatyana continued, unfazed. “We’ve disrupted University communications, recaptured strategic strongholds, and neutralized key Black Wolf operatives.” She paused, watching the Grand Mariner’s eyes harden. “But we can’t do it alone.”

The Grand Mariner’s voice turned colder. “So, you want us to abandon our neutrality? Is that it?”

“Sail north and patrol the lanes. A small favor.”

“Do you so doubt your claim to power? What do you intend to do here while we’re out there, risking our ships in the dark?”

“I have my own ship to clean,” Tatyana replied, casting a brief glance at Baranov. “You have my word as Matron Chair.”

The Grand Mariner’s voice was low and measured. “Oaths are but air these days; it’s the Ascended whose words cast shadows.”

“Yelena has betrayed us all, and her apprentice couldn’t navigate a puddle. My patience has its limits,” Tatyana shot back.

Lagunov’s gaze didn’t waver. “I will not stand for this, not in my name.”

Tatyana stepped closer, the tension palpable as she breached the unspoken boundary between them. “Choose your next words wisely, Mariner,” she cautioned. “What you will not stand for today may tomorrow be the ground swept from beneath you.”

With a cold chuckle, the Grand Mariner said, “My dear, I’m more accustomed to the shifting tides than you are to the shifting sands of your politics.”

“And yet, even the sea must eventually yield to the pull of new shores, Lagunov.”

“You can’t suppose I’d simply relinquish control of this city and wash my hands of it.”

“It’s not about relinquishing control but steering clear of the storm’s path,” Tatyana countered. “Sail to Karaginskiy. Hold there, maintain your readiness, and wait for my signal. This city will need its Mariner again, but only once the fires have cleared.”

The Grand Mariner’s gaze swept over the towering pillars before resting on the assembled Battalion. Tatyana couldn’t help but think how those columns had witnessed countless shifts in power over the years. The Mariner fixed her with a hard stare. “You are a fool. I’m staying.”

Tatyana felt a surge of satisfaction. *So firm, yet how quickly the tides turn.* The Mariner may resist, but even she couldn’t fight the current of change already set in motion, Tatyana knew.

Then, the Grand Mariner turned her attention to Baranov. A faint sense of triumph stirred in Tatyana as their eyes met—silent acknowledgment of the mutiny she had carefully orchestrated within the Mariner’s ranks.

As Baranov gave that crucial, subtle nod, the Grand Mariner’s posture wavered, her stoicism finally cracking. The battle-hardened resolve softened, giving way to a quiet resignation.

Tatyana’s satisfaction deepened. This was more than mere concession; it was isolation materializing before her eyes—the silent allegiance of the Wolves, the slow but pivotal shift in the Admiralty’s hierarchy. The Mariner now stood alone, her forces and confidants drifting toward the gravity of Tatyana’s cause.

In the quiet of her mind, Tatyana savored the victory. This revolution was not forged through brute strength but carefully

woven from shrewd influence, tactical acumen, and a judicious scattering of well-timed bribes.

“I’ll relay your...generous offer to my fleet,” Lagunov said, the trace of defeat in her voice unmistakable to those paying attention.

“Excellent. To honor our agreement, I’ll ensure your ships receive supplies to outlast the northern chill. By the time you hear our summons, we’ll have secured dominion over Gred.”

Lagunov offered a terse nod in return. Her tone had grown brittle, echoing through the hallowed space with reluctant acceptance. “A show of good faith most...unexpected.”

Tatyana pivoted on her heel and made her way down the aisle. Revolutionaries lined the benches, their gazes unwavering, their silence a testament to their dedication. A deep sense of pride swelled in Tatyana’s chest, stirred by the unspoken unity around her.

Fervor rising with each step, she raised her voice to the crowd. “Our people will know liberation!” she declared. “Together, we stand in the fight for our future—a fight we will win.”

Reaching the podium, she proclaimed, “The Tribunal convenes. Let the trial commence.”

They wanted charges entered, evidence heard, judgment given its proper form. Fine. She would give them all of it.

With a broad sweep of her arm, the accused were brought into stark focus. “Before us stand traitors to our cause, conspirators against our survival. They face the charge of treason, and by our law, justice will be served.”

From the corner of her vision, Tatyana caught the simmering gaze of the Grand Mariner, a silent storm brewing behind her eyes. “The proof against them is overwhelming,”

Tatyana asserted, holding the older woman's stare. "Their fates are sealed by their own misdeeds."

As Tatyana named the accused, the room's attention shifted, each notorious figure cast in hardlight at scale. Doctor Anastasia Zakharovna, former leader of powers now under scrutiny; Commander Vesna Volkova, disgraced among the Black Wolves; and Yelena Petrova, Hive's Director, now stripped of her titles. Tatyana's voice rang out, amplifying their identities to every corner of the hall, fueling the crowd's fury as anger crescendoed into a unified cry for justice.

The collective fist of the crowd punched the air, their voices rising in a shrill demand for recompense.

"Treason demands a reckoning," cried Tatyana, her proclamation burning with conviction. Her hand swept toward the Black Wolves, signaling their role in the justice to come. "On the authority granted to me by the Admiralty, I pronounce the ultimate sentence upon these traitors—death, and the dissolution of their souls."

Tatyana's gaze moved over the resolute line of Black Wolves standing behind the Grand Mariner. The privilege of carrying out a Matron's execution traditionally belonged to the Mariner herself, yet Tatyana stood firm, confident in the Wolves' unwavering loyalty to the new order she commanded—an allegiance she was certain would now follow her word.

She swept her gaze over the line of Black Wolf lieutenants and enforcers, tension tightening in the air as she waited for their response. Could this be a step too far? For a moment, doubt crept in. But as the ravening cries of the Black Wolves echoed around her, certainty settled in its place. *They're with me now; Vesna's shadow is gone.* Their faces reflected the disdain that seemed to burn from within, as they stared down the shimmering image of their former commander.

“Death to traitors,” Tatyana repeated, her voice resonating off the cathedral’s walls. On cue, the Wolves fired skyward. The noise cascaded into a celebratory uproar, the crowd feeding off their enforcers’ ferocity, cheers matching the unleashed fervor, united in their condemnation.

Seizing the momentum, Tatyana raised her voice to carry across the nave. “Who among you stands with me, at the brink of one final battle? Who will join me in this fight for victory? Who wants total war?” Her words were met with a tempest of sound, the crowd’s rage and excitement vibrating the very air, fists punching upward in response.

“I will lead us into this battle,” she proclaimed, her voice rising above the chaos. “Together, we will emerge victorious, and together, we will shape the days to come!” The echoes of unity and the promise of triumph filled every corner of the cathedral.

Her declaration still echoed in the cathedral’s arches when she heard it—a pop, so soft it seemed unreal. Then the pain struck, exploding in her leg like a lightning bolt. The room spun as she staggered, her hand instinctively clutching the wound. Through the haze, her gaze locked onto the shooter—a tall shadow draped in black, standing defiantly, the rifle barrel still trailing smoke, the hand gripping it clad in a leather jacket.

Blood, warm and urgent, spilled over Tatyana’s fingers. Each heartbeat slammed like a drum in her ears. She bit down, fighting to stay upright, to anchor herself against the surge of pain. *Not like this. I won’t let it end here.*

Chaos crashed down around her, the world fracturing in an instant. Explosions ripped through the air, the blasts reverberating deep within her as she collapsed into a sea of crimson on the marble floor. *It can’t be...* Screams pierced the smoky air, raw with anguish. Pews lay shattered, flames

greedily devouring wood and soldiers alike—a merciless inferno now in control.

A flash of white caught her attention—the Grand Mariner’s pristine uniform, stark against the destruction. Beside her, Tatyana glimpsed Baranov, barely visible through the smoke, retreating toward the cathedral’s massive entrance. *I commanded them to retreat, and now I watch the very allies I sought to secure slip away...*

The clash of gunfire ebbed and flowed as another figure emerged. Tatyana squinted, trying to focus. *Is that Goga?* A crop of short silver hair glinted, confirming her suspicion. She remembered Goga’s strong presence, green and inexperienced, yet resourceful and determined. Sparks flared before Tatyana’s blinded eyes, the sensation of near impacts real yet distant as her focus wavered. *I need to stay awake.* She was only dimly aware of the Black Wolf Commander’s rapid movements—a blur of action—until the heavy thud of a body hit the ground.

Suddenly, she felt herself being lifted, the sturdy grip around her cutting through the fog threatening to pull her under. She drifted in and out, large arms the only thing keeping her tethered to the world as shapes and sounds blurred and twisted around her. A flicker—maybe a thrown object—barely registered before a red veil descended, blotting out the flames that had roared moments earlier.

Tatyana fought to hold on to the fragments of reality, the cathedral’s grand interior slipping away with each heartbeat. *I can’t lose this... I can’t lose them.* The cries of her people, the distant clash of battle—they became harder to grasp, fading as the world tilted around her. *This can’t be how it ends.*

Faces swirled in and out of view, grounding her as they kept vigil. The bell tower’s sonorous toll filtered through the haze, its haunting echoes lingering in the air.

The vaulted ceiling loomed above, revealing a spectral image—Christ with his disciples, silent observers etched into the cathedral's heights.

I don't recall this mural...

Pain pressed in, a relentless force. For a brief moment, clarity broke through, and she wondered if He might grant her absolution.

She let out a laugh—no more than a fragile shiver between clenched jaws. The coppery tang of blood filled her mouth as a ragged cough forced its way up. Goga's stricken face swam into view, and with the last of her strength, Tatyana breathed her final word, "...chaos."

CHAPTER TWENTY NINE

DUNYA

Freezing stillness swallowed her. Limbs drifted, weightless, and one thought kept pulsing like static:

Why am I still here? I wanted it all to end.

Vesna had gone silent. Maria had cut the line. Dugal was dead. Different failure modes, same result: Dunya was alone while everyone else still had a hand on the systems keeping her alive.

Disposable, she thought. Useful until damaged, then routed somewhere quiet.

Serafim's voice surfaced in the dark, followed by the memory of the gunblade. Cold steel. Pain. Warmth running where it should not. Then black.

The Skelet returned next, metal wrapped around legs that no longer answered without permission. Even the suicide attempt had failed closed. Sensors, medics, and dosage limits. She could not stand, could not die, could not make one clean decision without another system overruling it.

Was I not even strong enough to finish that?

Why didn't it work?

A stubborn thump echoed somewhere within, faint but insistent, like a coal refusing to die. A feather-light warmth drifted across her, as if someone had tugged the blanket higher over a body she could no longer feel, and the void's chill began—almost imperceptibly—to loosen its grip.

Another pulse of heat followed, as if a long-forgotten sun had turned its face toward her, unspooling a fragile ribbon of light across the dark. Tentative, coaxing, it let the first

whispers of sensation seep back in, soft as blades of grass teasing the tips of her toes.

Thread by thread, the numbness unraveled. Cool rain pricked skin that wasn't quite hers, the sterile tang thinning into the earthy breath of damp soil and tender green.

Somewhere at the frayed edge of awareness, a monotone buzz—machines keeping vigil—thinned to a hairline hum. Through the crack, a single birdsong threaded the dark. Each note tugged at her, urging her to shrug off the velvet hush and rise.

Could it be? The thought formed slowly, breaking through the darkness.

Is this...another chance?

Do I deserve one?

Do I even want one?

The shift was ephemeral, like the swift silence of a blink. It blurred at the edges, and when it sharpened again, it was not grass brushing the soles of her feet as she had half-expected, but the feel of earth compacting beneath paws.

The echo of her own heartbeat was now a rhythm set to the cadence of a run. Dunya glanced down. Limbs, cloaked in deep-red fur banded with black stripes, struck against the earth, affirming her new wild form. She was a tiger.

With each bound forward, the world streaked past her in a vibrant smear of lush greens and burnished umber. Fern fronds brushed her flanks and cool loam burst beneath her pads; the forest exhaled with every bound, its rhythm matching her own.

This isn't real. But maybe, just maybe, I can control it this time.

Blood drummed in her ears. Every coil of muscle struck sparks against the ache, forcing it back. The forest's mossy breath mingled with a ghost of antiseptic that scratched her throat, and with it came the faint *beep...beep...beep*—its rhythm tilting, stretching—until it feathered into the two-note trill of an unseen bird overhead. White ceiling panels flickered behind her eyes, then shattered into shards of sunlight. Cold steel had once slashed across her thighs; now cool soil sifted beneath her claws. She gulped the green air and ran on, willing the land itself to teach her how to breathe.

Her pace slowed from a run to a lope. Sirens and hospital lights receded until the forest was the only active process left.

Her body answered immediately and completely, without wheels, braces, or hands lifting her without permission.

She knew it was not real. She also knew she did not care yet.

Reality intruded with the patter of hooves. A deer—a creature from her half-remembered hikes in the virgin old-growth boreal forests of Bystrinsky—bounded across the misty alpine meadow with a desperate grace. As it leapt behind a looming pine, its ensuing sprint towards the ravine hinted at an urgency Dunya recognized all too well. A slip on mossy ground, a tumbling figure, and the deer was a fraction away from the abyss.

She bounded once, twice, then exploded forward, muscles firing before thought could catch up.

Warm flesh yielded beneath her jaws and the deer's last tremor rattled up her teeth, falling in step with her own pounding heartbeat. Iron washed her tongue, and with it came staccato flashes: restraints biting skin, fluorescent glare, corridors that smelled of bleach. She shook them off, gulped air that tasted of leaf mold and rain, but a thin blade of cold slid along her flank, sharper than any wind. The forest

wheeled around her—alive, breathing—yet the chill whispered of another body, another life, waiting beyond the trees.

Her limbs vibrated with each step: the rough touch of the underbrush against her fur, the damp earth compacting beneath her weight. A cold, unfamiliar feeling grazed her flank, and the world blurred. The woods seemed skewed. Her strides became unsteady, paws stretching, reshaping. The comforting fur receded to reveal cool, vulnerable skin.

She found herself upright. Dunya, now on two legs, inspected her hands, fingers flexing in quiet awe. She felt the warmth of the ground through the soles of her boots.

A rising heat teased her ankles, urging her eyes upwards. Before her, flames danced, their rhythmic sway painting the horizon with a mesmerizing glow. Unlike any ordinary fire, these flames moved with purpose. They drew her in with their allure, yet the prickling heat on her skin held her at bay.

From the heart of the conflagration, silhouettes took form, their hair a molten cascade of silver and ember.

Dunya's eyes were drawn to one figure, swathed in a robe of obsidian. The garment flowed, almost liquid in its movement, with intricate patterns stitched in silver thread glistening against the fire's backdrop.

She absorbed the sight, and the cloaked figure detached from the group, her posture resolute against the tide of searing flames. "We stand as the Coven's chosen," she declared, her voice rising above the inferno.

The surrounding chorus raised their voices, weaving a haunting harmony that momentarily subdued the fire's insatiable hunger.

Then, in a stark and sudden blaze, the figures burst into pillars of flame that consumed the space they occupied.

Dunya recoiled, arm thrust over her face to fend off the onslaught of light.

Time seemed to stretch, each second an eternity as the fiery intensity gradually waned. When the figures finally dissipated, the inferno's brilliance dimmed and reshaped, revealing a majestic edifice beneath its embers. Looming spires and intricate carvings stood defiantly amid the flames.

Dunya's breath hitched, memories rushing in like a torrent.

She could hear the dawn bells of the Grand Mariner's Cathedral, their chimes a distant lullaby from her youth. The vibrancy of the stained-glass windows seemed to dance before her eyes, recounting tales of heroic sailors and age-old legends.

And the chill of the stone floor—she felt it again, as if she were a young girl sitting through Sunday sermons.

Beside her, the imagined grip of her babushka's hand anchored her, the whispered prayers a bridge to a time when the old religions were honored and revered.

"Don't fear the dark currents, my child," her grandmother had said, her voice a weave of comfort and mystery. "They too lead to the same great sea."

But the embrace of those days was now but a touch. Dunya could still feel her grandmother's fingers tangled in hers, the soft murmur of ancient prayers in the dim light of the cathedral. Baba Medvedova, lost to the tides of time, had left her with a treasured trove of memories.

And as the amber flames danced wild, that once peaceful past was brutally interrupted by the chilling roar of battle that surged across the horizon.

From the protective shadows of white birch, soldiers charged forward, their armor catching and reflecting the tempestuous glow around them.

Among them, a formidable woman in a rugged leather jacket stood out, her posture alone declaring her dominance over the battlefield. Her companion, clothed in a dull green overcoat, moved with the grace of a hunting feline. Short silver hair framed her face while her deep blue eyes, sharp and focused, scanned the scene, ever calculating.

Behind them, two more women emerged, their age evident but deceptive, for they were anything but frail. Their seasoned faces were a map of countless battles, eyes holding the weight of innumerable wars. Clad in mercenary gear tailored from reinforced leather and steel, they drew their weapons: a gunblade and a sniper rifle, ancient craft complementing modern tech.

And as the four women plunged into the fray, a symphony of clashing metal and arcane whispers erupted.

The battle collapsed into a mirrored chamber. Dunya was bound again, and the man who had broken her body stood close enough to reach.

She drove the blade into him before whatever had built the room could choose for her.

His blood warmed the steel. The deer flashed through her mind, its throat crushed between tiger jaws. Something was forcing an equivalence between them: prey, target, body, consequence. Cheap moral theater.

The comparison was wrong. The deer had tried to live. He had chosen what he did to her.

The room broke back into forest. As a tiger, she could smell blood and fear without confusing either one with justice. The man was gone. Her scars were not. Killing him had not rewritten a single line.

Still, her legs worked. Her body belonged to her. For now, that was enough.

She pressed on through the forest in pursuit of new prey. This was her domain, and it was bountiful; she intended to traverse it all.

A shape peeled away from the timberline, huge and silent, paws padding into the clearing where the deer lay. The newcomer halted at the blood-damp grass, settling into a predator's stillness that sent a prickling warning up Dunya's spine.

She roared, and her challenge rumbled through the forest, a primal sound full of ferocity as she bared her fangs at the formidable wolf before her, its blue eyes meeting hers with an unflinching gaze.

They circled each other in a calculated dance, each step a silent measure of the other's strength. The wolf loomed, shoulders like stone, yet Dunya felt her own power course from within—a deep, unbreakable bond with the forest itself. She was not afraid.

In a burst of speed, Dunya lunged for the wolf's throat. The wolf twisted clear and its teeth clamped down on her flank, sending fire skittering across her ribs. She lurched sideways, claws ripping furrows through the leaf litter, breath ragged with pain.

Several paces now separated them, her blood dripping onto churned earth while the wolf's muzzle gleamed dark and wet. Their eyes locked. In the next heartbeat, tiger and wolf collided, fur, dust, and crimson churning together. The great wolf reared onto its hind legs and let loose a howl that split the moonlit canopy. Dunya answered, raw and resonant, and drove herself forward.

CHAPTER THIRTY

ZAKHAROVNA

Beneath a slate-gray sky, where clouds hung motionless as if painted, Zakharovna surveyed the horizon. Amid the ruins, a network of fractured arches and splintered spires, stood the remains of a massive cathedral, its dome collapsed. Encircling it were the old birch trees, now charred in a forest turned to coal.

Every detail of the grove's destruction seemed eerily preserved, as if by a sculptor's hand. Hovering beside Yelena atop the remnants of what had been, Zakharovna noted the stillness, a silence that outsilenced the absence of wind and life.

"Do you even recognize this world anymore?" Yelena asked.

Zakharovna inhaled deeply. The air had a peculiar, metallic tang that nipped at the back of her throat. "Every foundation needs its ashes."

Yelena bridged the distance between them. "This was our home... And you—"

"It's evolution, Yelena. The world evolves. We have evolved," Zakharovna interrupted, turning to meet her bright green eyes.

"At what cost? Romanova, we pushed her too far."

"And she showed her true colors. Weakness. Fear," Zakharovna retorted.

She watched as Yelena floated to the balcony's edge, the crumbling structure offering a stark view of their shattered world. In the dimming twilight, Yelena's silhouette stood tall and imposing.

“Look where your ambition has led us,” Yelena turned to face her, a storm brewing in her gaze. “You let envy guide your hand, pave our path to this cold ruin.”

“There’s no room for regret. Not anymore.” Zakharovna said.

Yelena’s lips curled, frost edging her words. “I never intended there to be.”

“Then what now? What’s next?”

“Reclamation. Starting with you.”

Closing the gap until they were mere breaths apart, Zakharovna whispered with a mocking warmth she had long awaited to unveil, “For the Coven.”

“Until my last breath,” Yelena said.

ΔΔΔ

Zakharovna slipped off her headset, and the fluorescent lights of her laboratory glanced off the red-tinted glass, throwing her surroundings into a fiery glow. She surveyed her laboratory, where mechanical limbs and suspended forms floated in viscous fluids. Musing on their utility, she was reminded that even these robotic marvels couldn’t reverse her own physical decline.

Her gaze then drifted to the mid-19th Century spirit kettle on her desk. She recalled finding it in the Altai Mountains, a treasure unearthed during one of her expeditions in that rugged Siberian terrain, its wood, bronze, and copper gleam a testament to a bygone era. *How out of place it seems here, yet how grounding.* The basilisk figure, perched atop, seemed to guard over her modern domain. As the alcohol burner of the kettle emitted a gentle hum, she poured a steaming cup of tea,

its warmth a brief solace against the cold, clinical backdrop of her surroundings.

As Zakharovna sipped her Samovar-brewed Earl Gray, she spoke to Kirov with a cold clarity. “The old order is collapsing, Kirov. Chaos reigns in the city. Souls *everywhere*, waiting to be devoured. Yelena believes she has the upper hand, but she’s a fool.” The delicate citrusy scent of bergamot from the tea leaves brought a momentary relaxation.

Kirov asked, “We once feared that transferring your consciousness to that clone would be our undoing. How do we know it won’t betray you, consume you?”

“I once believed I needed all these souls, every single one,” Zakharovna said. “But now, I see it’s the confident ones that truly matter. Their sacrifice...” She trailed off for a moment, searching for the right analogy. “It’s like refining your own model, Kirov. Each *loss*, just like each soul that didn’t align, sharpened the focus, just as it honed your own intelligence. They were not failures but steps, necessary adjustments towards the ultimate design... We are so close, Pavel, so very close.”

A chill of satisfaction ran through her. She could feel the corners of her mouth betray her inner triumph, knowing full well the gravity of their next move. “Besides, it’s the only play we’ve got, my love.”

“Is this truly what you want? The people will—”

Zakharovna cut the inquiry short with a wave of her hand. “Look around. Gred’s citizens are nothing but captives in a primitive longhouse. Except their overseers possess the inquisitorial zeal and technological might of a modern state. A more insidious form of tyranny I can’t imagine—one cloaked in the veneer of safety and progress. I intend to liberate them from this charade. And those who cling to their chains with

eyes wide shut will face eradication.” She set her cup down with a decisive clink against the old kettle.

His eyes met hers. “You must at least consider the alternatives, Doctor. Cross this threshold, and there’s no turning back.”

The view from Zakharovna’s hidden apartment high in the city’s heart was a tapestry of smoldering wreckage. She lingered over the sight. “That’s the allure,” she said, the words more for herself than Kirov.

Her grin grew wild, relishing the chaos—the people, broken, fleeing in terror. *Civilization’s twilight, finally.* The basilisk, perched atop the kettle, seemed to agree.

“Seventy-one years ago, our then-leaders, cloaked in their moral righteousness, embarked on a crusade under the guise of diversity. Yet, their vision was myopic, fixated on a superficial form of it that merely masked deeper uniformities. They championed a world where genetic similarity was sidelined in favor of a more ‘universal’ approach, a misguided attempt to transcend traditional familial bonds and blur the lines of nation, ethnicity, and culture.”

“But their actions spoke louder than their ideals. They believed they were expanding our ethical horizons, but in truth, they were narrowing them, crafting a world where the complex tapestry of human connection was reduced to a bland, beige weave. In their zeal to dismantle existing norms, they overlooked the inherent value of these very connections. The bonds of family, the ties of shared heritage and culture—these were not just relics of a parochial past but the bedrock of our human experience.”

“Their pursuit of a genetic utopia, where every child was as much a stranger as a sibling to any other, defied the very nature of our being. Their rejection of ‘sameness’ in reproduction, while seemingly progressive, was in fact a

regressive step, erasing the nuances that define us. They failed to recognize that the strength of humanity lies not in eradicating our differences, but in embracing them, in understanding that diversity is not just about mixing and matching genes in a laboratory.”

“They truly believed this, Kirov, that by manipulating the genetic threads of our society, they could engineer a better world. Such naivety. That’s precisely why I’ve been so stringent with our own serum. Imagine, Kirov, if we had in fact perfected its most potent form. The masses would choose an eternal adolescence, willingly marching towards a monotonous abyss—a world devoid of the richness of aging, every unique feature sanded down to sameness, every wrinkle that charted a life story erased. But we’ve found it, the golden mean: vigor balanced with wisdom, the rush of youth anchored by the gravitas of age. That’s the tapestry of true diversity.”

Kirov put in, “It’s a dangerous game, playing with the fabric of life itself—”

“Spare me the interruption, Kirov—you know how I detest that. Let me have my monologue; it’s vexing to be cut off when one is painting the broad strokes of vision. Besides, this will perhaps be my last wiki entry.”

She exhaled leisurely, her focus shifting to Kirov’s form. His projected muscles rippled with an uncanny simulacrum of reality, and the distinct blue-purple hue of his skin offered a stark contrast against the warm orange glow of the sunset pouring through the window. Despite knowing he was just an array of diffused light and data, Zakharovna couldn’t help but study him, contemplating the lost depth of half a species. With a faint tut of disapproval, she mulled over the current state of affairs.

“It’s a genuine shame—we’ve managed to lose half our humanity to this catastrophe,” she mused aloud, bittersweet enjoyment in tasting her own disapproval. “I do find myself wishing for the return of men.” She paused, her eyes still on the holographic display of Kirov’s impressive, but ultimately intangible, member. “And the remnants, the ones spared,” she continued, “they’re but shadows of their potential—wasted, entrenched too deeply in their own decline to be of any substantive use.” Her gaze drifted away, resigning her focus back to the half-ruined world that lay beneath her in silent repose.

“What those fools created was a fragile construct, a society ill-prepared for the challenges to come. The subsequent pandemics were not just biological crises; they were the unraveling of a societal fabric too weak to withstand the winds of change. They failed to see the intricate web they were weaving. Like a complex system, where one weak link can bring the entire structure crashing down, their plan laid the groundwork for a catastrophic cascade. Each new disease found an easy path through our homogenized defenses, striking us down one after the other.”

“Even as a student, I saw the looming disaster, the inherent weakness in their approach.” Then, with a hint of irony she could feel, she added, “Have you ever heard about ‘man colds’, Kirov? Seemingly trivial, yet they were unwittingly reinforcing our networks of viral resistance, a natural bulwark we dismantled in our arrogance.”

“You see, in human cognition, there’s a peculiar trait. Many gauge their beliefs not on the stark light of truth, but on the dimmer lantern of social acceptance. A survival instinct, perhaps. They rarely prod the depth of a notion; their minds wade through the shallows of *will this align with the collective?* Yet, there are outliers in this dance, Kirov. Those who don’t sway to the rhythm of the masses, who resonate with their

own distinct frequency. These minds seek not the warmth of the herd, but the fire of truth, standing as sentinels of objectivity. And I am close, so very close, to having all these unique minds that I need.”

Her gaze drifted back to the chaos outside. “It’s curious about freedom, isn’t it? The masses yearn for it, yet they desire only the freedom to conform, to nestle within the comforting confines of consensus. Such a narrow, caged version of it.”

She turned back to Kirov. “Now imagine a world where the essence of the *confident*, their indomitable spirit, forms the foundation of a new order. A realm where minds don’t just connect but orchestrate. That’s the vision, Kirov. Not a governance swayed by the ebb and flow of popular sentiment, but one that stands firm, guided by the reasoned, undaunted few. A realm where the democratic spirit is not diluted by the murmurs of the crowd but is distilled, pure and potent, in the hands of those unshackled by the chains of conformity. You see, the fallacy of averages deceives. Euler, with all his brilliance, missed the heart of chaos: that a single, defining moment can eclipse the collective journey of many. In this new world, Kirov, we won’t be blinded by the average but enlightened by the extraordinary.”

Zakharovna’s eyes drifted back to the streets below, where the aftermath of chaos lay bare. Amid the debris and collapsed structures, her eyes caught a particularly haunting scene—an old woman in a babushka, trapped under the skeletal frame of a burning bus, her life slipping away in a sad, silent struggle. *Such frailty*, she thought with a sneer of contempt. “Before I do this,” she continued, “I’ll see Orkon one last time. He’ll prove invaluable to my...legion.” She brandished her taser and refocused her gaze on her virtual companion. “Now, help me into something warm.”

Zakharovna felt a weight lift from her shoulders as Kirov nodded and said, “Very well, I’ll accompany you.”

She made her departure from the high-rise. It was a pillar of modern design, untouched by the disaster that had ravaged its neighbors—a tribute not only to the advanced materials it was built with but to Zakharovna's foresight in demanding such protections. In a city perpetually gripped by cold, fire-proof buildings had once seemed frivolous to the Board.

When she reached ground level, the limousine was already there. She slid into its shadowed interior. Zakharovna settled back, the tinted windows offering her solitude as she surveyed the fractured bones of her domain. Her city. Her responsibility. Her canvas for rebirth.

Reaching the outskirts of Gred, where the disarray of urban destruction dissolved into the pristine expanse of Kamchatka, she arrived at an inconspicuous garage cradled by the distant, sweeping rise of mountains. For miles, the snow stretched out before her, a vast canvas of white framed by dark forests.

Inside the garage her snowmobile was primed for departure. Zakharovna mounted the vehicle and, with a sharp twist of the throttle, shot forward into the snow. As she gained speed, her eyes swept over the terrain she left behind. The towering form of Koryaksky volcano, a colossal specter, watched over the land with timeless vigilance. She edged the snowmobile faster, and as she accelerated into the open wilderness, the biting chill of the air whipped against her face.

△△△

Sokoch was a picturesque town of a hundred thousand souls, its towering walls a fortress against the outside world

and a sanctuary within. For the first time in what felt like eons, Zakharovna felt gratitude.

As she dismounted her snowmobile and looked up at the log cabin of her childhood, set within a forest blanketed white, she felt as though she had stepped into another lifetime. Kirov, invisible to all but her, paused to absorb the vista.

Years had slipped by since her last stay, but the city's magnetic pull never wavered. This time, she moved through its streets unnoticed, her usual yellow headscarf with golden roses exchanged for a plain black one. The muted hum of the crowd barely shifted as she passed, and though she caught the occasional lingering glance, Zakharovna dismissed them as idle curiosity. Whispers that might once have followed her were silent now, echoes of a city reshaped by her decisions.

Sparing Sokoch her serum's indignity had been one such choice, one that left half of Gred a desperate, haunted husk. The Kamchadal and their traditions fortified the old town, but the Derge stood as a grim reminder that entropy sought equilibrium, no matter how carefully she tried to tip the scales.

She ventured into the bustling marketplace, immediately drawn to Orkon's stall, an arcane sanctum set apart from the usual vendors. As she neared, Orkon paused his bartering, lifting his gaze from the elaborate rug beneath him. The tapestry, woven with threads of gold and sapphire blue, displayed a mesmerizing collection of talismans, each radiating its own distinct aura. Charms of carved whalebone and polished amber lay beside clay pots brimming with dried herbs. Nearby, a pewter platter held lightly salted sockeye salmon, its pinkish hue contrasting with crystalline sugar. Rounds of sharp Kamchatkan cheese, dried koryushka smelts, and seal bladders filled with rosehip or gooseberry teas accompanied locally brewed birch sap mead. The

mingling aromas of charcoal, resin, and the tang of burning sage enveloped her as she arrived.

“Anastasia,” he greeted, as laughter filled his voice. Standing, he bowed before meeting her gaze. “It’s good to see you again. It’s been too long.”

Zakharovna nodded, feeling a pang of guilt, knowing she had played a part in that weight. “Leave us. This is a private matter,” she commanded Kirov.

She observed Orkon’s subtle reaction, a tensing of his muscles and a shift in his gaze that betrayed his awareness of Kirov’s presence, even though the latter remained unseen to him.

As soon as Kirov receded from her field of vision, Zakharovna said, “I have something for you.” She then drew out a gleaming silver vial from her robe, letting it catch the rays of the sun. Orkon’s eyes widened in surprise, and she gave him a reassuring smile, placing the vial securely in his hand.

“I want you to have it.”

“No.” Orkon shook his head. “You don’t need to do this.”

“Each time I see you, my heart breaks a little more. I refuse to let this be the last time I look upon your face.”

Orkon’s eyes mirrored her pain, and she averted her gaze.

“You don’t have to do this,” he repeated.

“I do,” she whispered.

“You’ve already given me everything,” he said, returning the vial. “I must learn to live without this.”

Zakharovna shook her head, sensing a heaviness in Orkon’s demeanor that she hadn’t noticed before.

Had her prolonged absence caused this? She raised her hand to halt him from speaking further. “Your life is your own,” she murmured, shifting her weight as if threatening to leave. The vial in her pocket pressed cold and heavy against her side.

Orkon’s voice cut through the marketplace din, a note of urgency beneath the steadiness. “Wait! You’ve been gone so long,” he called out behind her.

Zakharovna turned, noting the unspoken worry etched into his features—fear for her prolonged absence, and perhaps, a deeper trepidation about the demands she might now place upon him.

“The Hive’s agents have seeped into every crevice,” he said, the words heavy with unspoken truths.

She nodded slowly, acknowledging the pervasive reach of their adversaries. Zakharovna’s return wasn’t just a matter of physical distance; it was a re-entry into a web of intrigue Orkon had been left to navigate, one that now clung to him with invisible threads.

In the resistance against Yelena’s incursions, he had become an emblem of guidance, his counsel sought after, his strategies employed. But she could see the toll it had taken—a constant, unnerving dance with danger that left him taut, like a bowstring ready to snap.

“You’re needed by my side, Orkon. There are forces stirring that we must confront together,” she said.

Zakharovna’s mind sifted through memories—echoes of the countless times she and Orkon had navigated caverns of mystery, side by side, hearts pounding. The silent pact between them, their unspoken ritual for seeking elusive answers, felt more relevant than ever. The truth awaited them once again, if they dared to search.

“Spiritcaps,” he said, almost reverently, invoking the ancient, potent artifacts they both knew could turn the tide.

With a rustle that seemed to echo in the silence, Orkon gathered his belongings, his motions swift and sure. Though his back was to her, there was no need for words—her understanding of him ran deeper than the roots of the world itself.

CHAPTER THIRTY ONE

DUNYA

The forest rang with their clash, claws raking, jaws snapping, bodies crashing through soil and leaf litter. Growls tore the silence until they broke into ragged gasps, each movement slower than the last.

At dawn's first light the frenzy faltered, giving way to a taut stillness. Both stood battered, breaths dragging in the cold morning air. Then Dunya lunged, closing the gap in a blur. Her teeth locked at the wolf's neck. A savage shake ended it.

Silence fell heavier than the fight itself.

The wolf lay still. No triumph came, only the hollow aftertaste of victory. Her claws blurred, reshaping into wheels that caught and turned beneath her, the faint rattle of rubber on stone echoing the rhythm of her heartbeat. The sound pulled her back from the feral edge and anchored her in the world she knew.

A cabin loaded around her in pieces: walls, shelves, maps, a blank journal. Someone wanted her to write. Of course. Even here, an interface was asking for input.

She touched the page. Images surfaced without timestamps or source tags. Memory, dream, injected prompt. No way to verify any of it.

Then she stood.

Intent became movement without a Skelet or brace mediating between them. Dunya crossed to the window and pushed it open before the dream could take the ability back.

The Three Brothers rose through the fog.

The rocks pulled up actual records: her father's hand on her shoulder, her mother's voice, Baba correcting both of them. Dugal did not belong there, yet his laughter came through the surf anyway, because absence was easier to manipulate than memory.

Back then, Dunya had believed the rocks could hold forever. Now she knew endurance was only failure on a longer clock.

"I can't swim!" Young Dunya's voice cracked, the depths below mocking her as her tin foil boat capsized. Her fists clenched in futile pursuit.

"No need," her father's voice carried over the water. "In the city, your wits will be your lifeline."

"When can I learn to swim?" she had once asked him.

"When your wits fail you," he'd said, pulling her close in a bear hug.

Her mother had taken her small hand, pointing toward the Three Brothers. "How long, do you think, before even they are claimed by the sea?" Her mother's voice wavered, as if afraid of her own words.

"Never. They'll stand their ground," young Dunya had said, pulling her hand free.

Years rolled on, and the cliffs that once inspired awe now only sharpened the tears clouding her vision. Gone was the youthful illusion that they could hold back any disaster, least of all *Zakharovna's rise*.

Turning her gaze beyond the Three Brothers, Dunya settled on the distant trio of mountains: Vilyuchik, Mutnovsky, and Gorely. The volcanoes formed a sweeping arc on the horizon, their snow-kissed peaks piercing the sky.

For a fleeting moment the interplay of shadow and fading light on the cliffs cast illusions, whispering of ancient watchers. Wolves seemed to stir in the crags, their shapes trailing down the ravines. She searched the heavens, half-expecting to see them silhouetted there, predators waiting in quiet judgment. None came. Only the mountains stood witness, and Dunya was left with her thoughts once more.

Two routes opened through the terrain. One looped back into familiar woods. The other ran west into blank map.

The choice felt staged. Standing still would still count as an answer.

Dunya took the unknown path.

During a year of salvage survey work for the road offices, Dunya roamed west, eyes searching for any flicker of life. What she found instead were endless expanses of gray.

Back then, Zakharovna was only a myth to her, a legendary wolf said to have prowled these lands for as long as memory could reach. Yet when the Reconstruction swept through, laying the groundwork for a new age, her grandfather had cautioned, “Zakharovna will succumb to this upheaval, mark my words. She’ll be her own downfall, and ours.”

Those were the words of Grigori Bocharov, the family’s oak, stern and unbending. He had spoken them to Dunya’s father with grave certainty: “She spells doom for our entire clan.”

Her father had only laughed, spitting into the sand and making an obscene gesture. Dunya’s mother, watching the mockery, slapped him. “What’s gotten into you?” she whispered harshly, though the blow had not hurt him. He only laughed louder and turned away on another of his adventures, never saying where or why.

Years later, she found him alone, lost in the depths of a portrait of her mother, Marina. His fingers traced the frame, and the redness in his eyes betrayed the weight of his loss.

“You got old,” Dunya said quietly.

He gave a soft chuckle, brushing his face as if to scatter the years. “Time didn’t wait for me, not even on the battlefield.”

“And Mother,” she answered, “she didn’t have the chance to wait either.”

He nodded solemnly. “Every day, I feel the gaping void she left behind.”

Dunya hesitated, then asked softly, “Zakharovna’s prototype, the one she claimed could cheat death. Did you *ever* consider it?”

A shadow crossed his face as he looked away. “It was a false hope, Dunyasha. A desperate gambit that came too late. Even if it had worked, such things carry their own price. Your mother’s spirit was meant for the stars, not bound here by unnatural means.” He had kept that promise. Later, he tasked Dugal with building a small rocket, and together they released her ashes into the sky, the family whispering their farewells as she rose to the heavens.

Dunya watched his gaze drift, fixed on memories. “I rejoined my old regiment,” he murmured, “the one I served in before your time.”

Her heart tightened. To return to war when he was already past the age of most soldiers. Why? Whatever the reason, it led him to kill an old man.

Zakharov had once inspired him, had once made him believe with grand tales of revolution and rebirth. Named for the Marshal himself, he had led the Black Wolves against the Strangers’ Revolt and painted himself as a figure of change. Yet beneath the vision lay a monster, no better than the

tyrants he promised to replace. He had asked them to trust him, convinced them to follow into a future he claimed was bright. Dunya's father had listened, had believed, until the veil lifted and the promises turned to dust. By then it was too late. But unlike the rest, her father acted, ending the tyrant's reign with his own hand.

He exhaled, a long weary breath. "In the dark, our paths crossed. It was kill or be killed. I chose our people's future over his." With that, he turned away, ending the conversation. Dunya was left with the weight of it all, the lengths her father had gone, the battles he had fought, both in the world and within himself.

Out of those battles came the city itself. Gred's foundations were laid in the chaos of the War of Formation, a place born from fire and contradiction. Her father had once believed Zakharov's promises, but in the eleventh hour of rebellion he had cast his lot with the Strangers. They silenced the tyrant, yet his vision outlived him. The bitter cold claimed the rebels, the last wolves vanished into the expanse, but Zakharov's dreams persisted in another shape.

His sister carried them forward. Under *Zakharovna*, the city rose from the ruins, her reign shaping an empire that grew and flourished. To Dunya it felt like a mockery, as if the defiance her father had clung to had been erased, and the future had followed a course that had been waiting all along.

Dunya audited her father's story the way she audited damaged code. He had been brave, ruthless, late, and sometimes wrong. Gred had survived him and betrayed him at the same time.

"I'm no warrior," he had once told her. "Just an old soul who knew when to pull the trigger."

Later, when she spoke of confronting Zakharovna, he had warned her plainly. “You don’t just walk into the fucking wolf’s den, Dunya. It’s a death wish.”

“She took Dugal from me.”

“Dugal was gone long before Zakharovna’s involvement. You know it, Dunyasha.”

That part still hurt because it was true.

Then Dugal appeared beside her, golden hair, brown eyes, carbon dust clinging to his overalls. The likeness was too clean to trust, and it gave him words he had never spoken on a balcony he had never seen.

“One day you’ll take it back from Zakharovna’s grip,” the copy said.

Dunya almost laughed. Dugal had hated speeches. He would have asked whether she had an exit route, enough charge in the railgun, and something to eat afterward.

Her father appeared again, urging restraint after choosing the dangerous path himself. Protection, command, self-destruction. The Bocharov family kept shipping the same bug under different names.

Neither man could authorize what came next.

This was still partly vengeance. Calling it justice would not make the code cleaner. But Zakharovna had taken bodies, minds, and choices from too many people to leave running. Dunya would act because the system had to be stopped, not because the dead demanded it.

She turned and stepped back into the cabin. On the moss-covered bed she let herself sink down, the last warmth of the day clinging faintly to her skin while outside the moons climbed into the twilight sky. From the shelter of the woods, distant howls rose and converged.

The cabin fell away. Dunya stood on a boundless plain, its surface shimmering like skin stretched tight over something deeper. Each step sent ripples through it, light and shadow folding like water. The crescents above shifted, not moons at all but eyes, unblinking, waiting.

A tremor ran through her chest. She reached for breath, but the air came thin, threaded with static. Voices whispered at the edge of hearing, not words but tones, as if a thousand signals bled together.

She steadied herself. Her fingers flexed, expecting the phantom feel of a trigger, the weight of her wheels, the pull of gravity. None of it came. Only that boundless plain, thinning further with every beat of her heart.

Beneath it, the beeps finally resolved into the rhythm of a monitor, the first real thing she had found.

Dunya followed the rhythm back without accepting any role the dream had assigned her. She returned as herself, angry, unfinished, and still online.

Beep. Beep. Beep.

CHAPTER THIRTY TWO

MARIA

The void pressed in on her, crimson light pulsing with each beat of her heart. Every breath felt heavier, the air thick and alive. Shapes rippled through the haze, gathering form until a face emerged from the red, one she knew too well. Babushka. The sight rooted her in place. Threads of shadow twisted into a shawl that seemed to swallow the light around it.

It's her. The thought came sharp and cold. The fear she'd kept buried stirred. Whatever this place was, it knew her. It wanted her to remember.

"You've spent a lifetime dodging shadows, haven't you, child?" Babushka's voice resonated, weaving through Maria's consciousness with the clarity of shattered glass, her eyes reflecting an eternity of lost hopes.

"I stood my ground when I aligned with the resistance," Maria retorted.

A smirk broke through the crags of Babushka's worn features. "Standing, perhaps. But did you move forward, or did you simply exchange one prison for another?"

Maria's retort faltered; vulnerability bled through. "Joining them...it appeared to be the right path."

"Intentions are but a thread in the tapestry of our actions," the ancient guardian said. "And sometimes, the pattern they weave is far from what we envisioned."

"This...this wasn't supposed to be my end," Maria confessed.

Babushka's expression softened, the stern lines of her face melting into a sea of compassion. "Rarely do we envision the

end our choices bring us to, child. Yet, it's our steps, deliberate or not, that carve the path beneath our feet."

"Now what?" Maria asked.

"That, my dear, is a story yours alone to script," Babushka said as the last of her form faded into the ether.

As the cloud dispersed, Maria was left alone in the darkness, the echo of those words her only companion. *What if this is the culmination of my choices?* Maria wondered. *Those mirrors showed everything I wanted to forget. Am I ready to relive those memories, again?*

Suddenly, Maria felt a sharp tug to her scalp, and the cold, hard ground scraped against her back. Before she could register the looming, ominous machine she was being drawn toward, its doors swung open, revealing an abyss within. As icy fingers gripped her, a terrified scream tore from her throat. The doors slammed shut.

A translucent slime clogged her mouth and nose. The toxic stench burned deep into her lungs. She gasped for air, each breath a futile attempt against the viscous trap. *No, not like this! I can't be trapped here!* The world dimmed to the haunting gaze of two unblinking red eyes, their vertical pupils promising an unspoken terror.

ΔΔΔ

Maria's eyes fluttered open, the starkness of a small, quiet room coming into focus. She scanned her surroundings, a ripple of confusion unsettling her as reality shifted abruptly from the nebulous crimson void. *How long have I been out?*

Was this place real, or just another deceit of Babushka's torment? Gradually, fragments of memory assembled a

coherent picture: the Research Center at the base of that blasted volcano.

The room's appearance mirrored those familiar facilities: a solid table at its center, surrounded by chairs that had endured countless briefings. The gray walls formed a utilitarian canvas, carrying the same sterile scent and quiet weight of consequential science found in the lab's corridors.

Maria's gaze wandered, settling on a silhouette shrouded in the room's half-light. The vague form hinted at color: flashes of gold, stretches of burgundy. As her vision adjusted, shadows receded, revealing details once hidden by the gloom.

The figure wore an ornate war dress, the fabric rich and dark. What drew Maria's attention was the hair, long obsidian strands streaked with silver that seemed to drink in the dim light.

Maria squinted, trying to connect the fragmented pieces of her memory. The way she held herself, the unmistakable air of authority. It couldn't be, could it?

"Matron?" Maria heard herself whisper, as if saying the name louder might shatter the illusion.

The figure stepped forward. The light revealed her face, a familiar face that Maria had not seen in what felt like a lifetime. It was indeed her mentor.

"Yes, Maria. It is me," Tatyana Romanova's voice was the same as Maria remembered: firm, with an undercurrent of warmth.

"But how? I thought you were..."

"Dead? Yes, at the Grand Mariner's Cathedral. Yelena's work... Zakharovna's, in truth," Tatyana's response was matter-of-fact. "Your intel spurred me there, too late to change my fate. But in truth, I knew it was coming, and I knew what I had to do next."

Maria's fists clenched, a mix of guilt and anger simmering within. "I could have..."

"Could have what, Maria? Died alongside me? Joining me at the cathedral would have been too great a risk. Your detention and...reconfiguration, though far from ideal, was a far better fate than being destroyed in that conflagration."

"You know, I always said there's nothing wrong with being old, that age had its own grace... I suppose I always thought that my body would eventually give out. But here," she gave a wry, almost sardonic laugh, "in the Arkyv, it's truly like being frozen in time. It's ironic, isn't it? Out there, at least, time had its imperceptible flow, a horizon of sorts, if not distant... You could always count on one surprise heart attack for the sweet release of oblivion. But here, it's just an endless echo... This place with its skewed reality, however, does give us a certain...edge. We are free to plan our next move. Out there? That's no longer our battlefield."

"I see your point...about the cathedral," Maria said, her voice trailing off as she processed her surroundings. Tatyana's old self emerged in her words, the mentor Maria once knew, always ready to strategize despite the odds. But could she really move against the woman who killed them now? "How can we move against Zakharovna from here? She seems to have grown even more powerful, despite having been ousted from the Board and everything else. She checked us at every turn. I mean, look at us. We're both dead."

"Being 'dead' has its advantages," Tatyana quipped. Then, pausing, her expression grew solemn as if she was piecing together a puzzle only she could see. "The girl is central to Zakharovna's scheme. But she can't have her. Dunya Bocharov is positioned to steer Gred through this storm, yet she's walking blindfolded into a labyrinth. She needs you now more than ever, Maria. I played too eagerly into Zakharovna's hand, entangled myself in Vesna's mutiny, and became

ensnared by Yelena's cloak-and-dagger ascension. I spread myself too thin. All the while, Zakharovna was weaving her web in the dark, collecting power piece by piece. And I, in my oversight, failed to see Dunya's true importance. Orlov once buried Nikolai's daughter under Mara Krylova and kept her treatment beyond ordinary University reach. I mistook that old protected file for a hidden life. Zakharovna knew exactly who Dunya was. She left her free because freedom made the girl useful, feeding her contracts and learning from every choice she believed was her own. She has been gleaning secrets and refining her experiments on those in Dunya's orbit. Dunya is the master node, the weight of all weights, the final piece reserved for Zakharovna's own ultimate ascension."

Maria's mind raced as the pieces fell into place. "The mindgrafts, the contracts... I always suspected there was more to how she cornered the market, outbid every *ANGEL*, despite being so green. She was groomed for this, wasn't she? Chosen... And you want me to guide her? Against Yelena? Against Zakharovna? I'm no mentor, Tatyana. Just look at where my 'guidance' has taken *us*."

"Yes, your decisions played a part in the events that unfolded. But we all make choices, Maria, and we all face the consequences. My end...it was a culmination of many factors. We're all players in a much larger game, often without full knowledge of the board... Before my death, one Goga Borisova, sister to our former Black Wolves Commander, played a crucial role in what I've become. I believe she was one of your former colleagues, Maria. When the remnants of my consciousness were uploaded to the Arkyv, it was as a form of preservation, a way to extend my influence beyond the constraints of flesh and blood. But it has its limitations. I exist here more as a whisper than a force of action, and not for long. But you, Maria, you have a unique connection to this realm. Your cybernetic birth, your very essence, gives you an

advantage here. You can interact with the Arkyv on a level I cannot. You have the potential to be more than just a guide; you can be a catalyst for change.”

“Goga always had a knack for patching things up,” Maria said. “So, I play the shadow to Dunya’s light? How poetic. You know, Tatyana, I never told you about how Zakharovna reconstructs me. Every time I fail a mission, or when I’ve managed to escape only to be corralled back to her labs, she puts me in a new body.”

Maria’s voice wavered, a tremor of uncertainty threading through her as a shiver ran down her spine. “But I never asked how she does it. And never thought to do so until you and I first met, when you mentioned intel suggesting this was not even possible, so this makes me wonder...where does she get the bodies? They can’t be clones, so who am I living *in*? And *what* exactly is my mind in all this? It’s unsettling, but sometimes, when I focus, I feel like I can hear *her* thoughts inside me. As if she’s the underlying substrate, and I’m just...an added layer, a spice on top. It’s like I’m part of her, yet apart.”

Tatyana sighed, a note of empathy in her voice. “The boundaries of self can be confusing, Maria. I remember my mother...how she used to overshadow everything about me. There were times I couldn’t tell where her influence ended and where my own personality began. But through it all, there was always a part of me that was distinctly mine. It’s the same for you. Zakharovna may have a hold on certain aspects of your existence, but the core of who you are, your innermost self, that’s untouchable. It’s solely yours... But now’s not the time to dwell on self-doubt, Maria. We can’t afford that luxury. This is about moving forward, about shaping our own destinies. For Gred. For what’s right. You possess the skills, and the resilience. You’ve always known how to navigate the shadows.

It's time to use that to get what you want. What do you want, Maria? What have you *always* wanted?"

Maria nodded slowly. "Freedom."

"Exactly," Tatyana said. "Now, let's talk about your escape. You have a role to play, and it's not going to be easy. The Arkyv is a labyrinth, a place of darkneses and echoes. It's more than just walls and doors; it's a puzzle designed to trap the mind. To navigate it, you must be shrewd. Don't confront Zakharovna head-on. Instead, play along with her game until the moment is right. Use her own moves against her. We've tried hacking into her systems before and failed. It's time we turn the tables—let her think she's hacking us, lead her into a trap of our own making."

"Your goal," Tatyana continued, "is to maneuver Dunya into power while keeping her out of her enemy's charges."

"Dunya once trusted me," Maria said. "But after everything that's happened, after the betrayals...how can I regain that trust? How can I influence her from the shadows without losing her again? And Serafim...she's cunning, dangerous."

"Serafim's betrayal cut deep. She exploited Dunya's grief and frustration. It was a calculated move, playing off her vulnerabilities. You got caught in the crossfire, an unfortunate casualty of her deception. But despite this, we still have leverage. We have a trump card—Serafim's twin brother. My remaining forces have struck a crucial deal with the Vory. It was a close call; we managed to outbid Yelena just in time. Now, they're keeping him hidden deep underground. We can use this knowledge to sway her at the critical moment."

Maria's eyes widened, a memory surfacing. "That might just work. There was only one time I saw Serafim's facade crack—when her brother's life was at stake." *The brother I never knew she had.* "She'll cooperate if it means ensuring his safety."

“She’s her mother’s daughter, through and through. A viper, fiercely loyal to her own, but merciless to others,” Tatyana said coldly. “She weaves lies with truth, seduction with threat. Don’t underestimate her again. We did once and look where it got us. She only responds to leverage; she lacks any internal morality, as far as I can surmise. Her loyalty, twisted as it may be, is to her clutch. That’s where we can corner her... However, if Serafim detects that Dunya can resist Zakharovna’s psychic assaults, she will perhaps take her shot at immortality instead. She may choose her god over kin. If so, she would likely hijack Dunya’s victory at the very last moment. We must anticipate her moves and stay one step ahead.”

Maria straightened up, thinking *it feels like we’re walking a path we’ve already walked, trying against all odds, only to stumble*. “Matron, we can’t afford to fail again, can we?”

“Indeed, we cannot. Remember, Zakharovna’s true goal is Dunya’s soul. To save Gred, we must first save her. Dunya’s strength is undeniable, but her naivety and trust are her weaknesses.”

Maria replied, “I’d sensed Serafim’s bitterness toward her mother, sure. But it wasn’t until Grigoreva’s execution hit the headlines that everything clicked. That’s when Serafim’s disdain for the regime truly seemed to boil over. She stormed out of that warehouse, and it was clear just how personal it had all become.”

“Serafim always yearned for payback against her mother. For abandoning her to the cold as a child. That would have been her kill, more than anyone’s. But Yelena’s move against Grigoreva transformed that yearning into something palpable—something we can use,” Tatyana explained, a distinct note of empathy threading her voice. “Poor soul, she does not even know that Zakharovna is her aunt. Serafim, perhaps, holds Zakharovna responsible for pushing Yelena

too far, for the backlash that followed. And she hasn't forgotten Zakharovna's own hand in those twisted childhood experiments. Betrayal upon betrayal, it's left her wounded, scarred to the core."

"So, we use that. We turn Serafim's budding volatility to our advantage," Maria said.

"It is a severe measure, indeed, but an opportunity we cannot ignore. The evidence is irrefutable—Serafim's intentions regarding the Babushka system have come sharply into focus. Her relentless pursuit of Dunya now bears a chilling rationale. To concede control of it to her... One shudders at the prospect of such magnitude of power vested in one so young. A soul marred by suffering, driven by an insatiable thirst for power—it portends nothing less than total disaster."

Tatyana fell silent for a moment, and Maria noticed the way her gaze hardened, as if weighing the gravity of her next words. "The stakes rise higher still. With Yelena assuming command of Gred and cloaking herself in the guise of Directorship, Zakharovna faces an acute imperative to respond. Her moves will grow increasingly forceful as she seeks to undermine Yelena's escalating sway. In her desperation, you'll become a pivotal piece in this power play. And it is at that precise juncture that you must seize your chance to emancipate yourself."

"And once I'm out?" Maria asked.

"We'll copy your avatar, and when Yelena executes what she thinks is your termination, it will misconstrue the true series of events on-chain. This should create enough confusion to buy you some time. While they're trying to figure it out, you strike at Serafim from the shadows. That's when you rescue Dunya from her manipulative grasp."

How many lives until I get it right? Maria thought. She said, “I can’t lie, Tatyana, I’m feeling a bit burnt out.”

“It’s understandable, given everything you’ve been through.”

Maria looked around, the strange reality of the Arkyyv setting in. “Speaking of which, how did you even find me here? And... You don’t happen to have a body out there waiting for me, do you?”

“You were on the right track suspecting Zakharovna’s influence over you, Maria. Fortunately, I’ve been aware of this for quite some time. Zakharovna’s signature is, let’s say, quite distinctive, and while I won’t give away the ending, there’s a deeper connection there than you might feel comfortable even knowing. But on the bright side, it makes it easier for me to find you. As for your physical form, it remains under *her* encryption, effectively barring your return to the tangible world. I’m sorry, Maria.”

Tatyana’s eyes briefly flickered to her watch. “They’re unaware of our rendezvous, of course, but we don’t have much time. You’ll soon be back under their control. My intervention was only possible due to our shared history, which led you here—a place resonant with both our memories. We’ve each had our own dealings with this grotesque factory... For you, when you were commissioned for the Wolves, this laboratory was your proving ground, your domain. For me, it was where I wrestled with Zakharovna’s pursuit of her immortality ‘cure,’ spending nights on end trying to steer her toward another dawn, rather than the endless night she gave us.” Tatyana then turned and gazed out the window, where the volcano’s formidable shadow fell across the virtual landscape. In the gathering darkness, it stood silent and eternal.

She took a deep, almost wistful breath. “There’s a burden I’ve shouldered in this prolonged existence, a weight too heavy

for eternity. The siren's call of immortality, once a promise of endless possibilities, has become my shackle. It's time for me to go. But before I depart, there is one last thing I must ask of you," she said. "A *mindgraft*."

"Here? Now? How?"

Maria's questions tumbled out, rapid and disbelieving.

"Yes, here, at this very instant," Tatyana confirmed, urgency coloring her voice. "It's crucial we synchronize as I fade. This will minimize interference and ensure a seamless meld. I intend to imbue you with a part of my essence, a transfer of knowledge and strength, for the fight that lies ahead." Tatyana reached out, her eyes locking with Maria's. "Just stay close and let your thoughts flow with mine; there's nothing more you need to do."

"I understand," Maria said.

"I see that you do," Tatyana responded gently. "And truthfully, I'm quite curious, even somewhat eager, about what comes next...to live as they did *before*, to seize life with some zeal for once. Pre-war haste had us devouring every moment, every sensation. Fast food, in its curious way, became nearly a ritualistic fervor. Ah, but I digress, that reference might escape you. It's somewhat akin to those catalyzed mealworm rations you're used to, nothing like the genuine, rich flavors we relished back then... Beef... I may explore these old tastes again, or I may not..."

Tatyana collected herself, her gaze anchoring. "Your bravery gives me peace, Maria. In our fleeting union of minds, draw upon my strength. This moment, brief as it may be, is the fulcrum upon which our futures balance. No matter what you face, what illusions or temptations are thrown your way—promise me, *don't look back*."

Maria's response was a nod. "For Dunya, for Gred, I'll see this through."

“This...this is my last gift, the culmination of all I’ve been. I cling to the hope that our efforts, my sacrifice, have kindled a flame that will endure. In you, Maria, lies the strength I leave behind.” She paused, her breath a hushed reverie, and uttered softly in the old language, “Da svetit svet tvoy.” *Let your light shine.*

Tatyana’s form began to shimmer, edges blurring into the Arkyv. Maria felt the transfer land: not destiny, not blessing, just another burden handed over before the dead could answer for it.

CHAPTER THIRTY THREE

DUNYA

Beep. Beep. Beep.

A sharp inhale tore through her, like breaking the surface after too long underwater. Antiseptic filled her nose. Linen scraped her skin. Beeps and whispers tangled with the last howl of the forest before the white room forced itself into place.

Her eyes opened into hard white light. Prime Infirmary. The monitor slowed as her breathing did.

The ceiling was cracked in the same places she remembered. Real, then, or at least consistent enough to pass a first check. The room pulled up the older failure automatically: botched spinal procedure, leaking cerebrospinal fluid, pressure so severe that moving her head had felt like trying to lift the planet.

She could still hear a nurse repeating *acetabulum* and *sacrum* until the words became labels for two more parts of her body everyone else seemed to own.

I'm alive. I think.

A young woman stepped into the glare. Dunya recognized the inky curls and the voice, but neither belonged in this room.

"Can you tell me how you feel?" The woman's voice was soft as a bell chime, steadying in the silence. Dunya's head spun as she tried to rise, a heaviness in her limbs arguing against the movement. Her eyes dropped to her legs: smooth skin where scars should have been. "What...happened to me?"

"What's the last thing you remember?" Her question trembled, carrying fears she didn't name.

“Where are my clothes... My things?”

The woman clasped her hand, uncertain but firm. “Try to stay calm. You’ve been through an ordeal.”

Dunya’s gaze drifted over the crisscrossing scars that remained across her abdomen and arms. The frantic drive to the hospital came back in fragments.

She’d fought, trapped between life and death, grappling with a Black Wolf for the gunblade. Through spirals of pain and fire-laced delirium, she’d moved with desperate purpose, turning the weapon on herself just as the world tipped into darkness.

“I... *I did this.*”

“Yes. You were in a bad place, real bad, but you clawed your way out. Vesna found you in the fire and stayed with you through the ambulance transfer. The graft beds repaired the worst of the burns while you were under. You’re stable, but the Skelet has to carry the load for now. Before she went back to the fighting, she left this with me and told me not to let you wake up alone.”

Vesna. The name brought back her hands on Dunya’s shoulders, the argument neither of them had finished, the pressure of her fingers around Dunya’s hand as the ambulance doors closed. She had come back only long enough to leave again.

The woman offered her a slender, velvet-lined case. Its polished mahogany exterior was fastened with delicate brass clasps. She opened it.

Inside lay the collar necklace, its abalone centerpiece catching the dim light in a splintered spectrum. Dunya lifted it, the cold metallic braids and vibrant shell stark against her palm. *Our day at the beach... The only day of sunshine Gred had seen in a decade... That smile when I handed it to her...*

She recoiled from the keepsake. However beautiful, the necklace was a hollow symbol now, an echo of a bond that was beyond repair. *If she was really at my side, where is she now?* She swallowed the thought in the stranger's presence.

"Who are you, and what do you want?" Dunya demanded.

"It's me. Don't you remember?"

Dunya scrutinized her, a voice she remembered only from her dreams. The golden sunlight filtered in through the ceiling cracks, casting a fractured mosaic of light across *Serafim's* face, like a shattered mirror.

"I... I'm not dreaming, am I?"

Serafim offered a rueful smile. "No, you're awake. The dreams...they were mine too. I helped build the system that siphons data from minds like yours."

Dunya's eyes widened. "You... But why?"

Serafim laid a hand on Dunya's shoulder. "I got out," she said. "Then I realized Zakharovna was still using the link to reach you. I came back to cut it."

Dunya absorbed this, the pieces of her fragmented memories slowly forming a coherent picture. "And now?"

"I broke enough of the link that the dreams should stop," Serafim said. "Zakharovna shouldn't be able to pull you through the same way again." She hesitated, then pointed toward the side desk. "You need to eat. Soup and bread. It's not much, but it's real food."

Only then did the smell reach Dunya, rich and earthy, drifting into her awareness as if the memory of hunger had suddenly found her again.

"I thought the Syndicate nabbed you after I..."

"I'm not the only one who dodged a charge of treason," Serafim said, settling beside her and sliding the food across.

Dunya looked at Serafim and remembered the contract, the syringe, the way Maria's name had become leverage between them. Disgust rose first. Pity followed, unwanted and harder to shake.

"They questioned me until my mother was dead and the Battalion broke. After that I wasn't leverage anymore. They opened the door."

"So they discarded you," Dunya said. "Why come here?"

Serafim's silence stretched between them as Dunya lifted a spoonful of soup to her lips. Mushroom, sorrel, garlic, a trace of smoked fish. The broth carried her back to the Formation, to thin meals eaten between gunfire. Its warmth spread through her before she was ready to admit she needed it.

"The mushrooms and sorrel came from the University biodomies," Serafim said, almost proud. Then the softness left her. "Zakharovna is building a network that can lock minds into *virtual* and call it rescue. Once enough people are inside, she can blame the terrorists for the panic and make captivity look like protection."

Dunya stared at her.

"The dreams were part of that system," Serafim said. "I entered because I thought your mind held a key, something in your family's old contact with Zakharovna that could help break the pull before Babushka becomes her cage for everyone."

"So what am I to you? A patient? A key?"

"A key," Serafim said. "That's what I thought when I went into your head. I'm trying not to make the same mistake twice." Her gaze turned inward, as if revisiting memories long buried and badly repaired. "My sister and I were separated after the crash. They cut pieces out of us and called it

treatment. She got a life. I got a role.” Serafim looked down. “I still love her.”

“You don’t have to explain that part,” Dunya said. She glanced at Serafim, the word *family* itself loosening her guard, though the rest of her thoughts stayed buried, unspoken.

Serafim said, “You’ve been on the inside, seen the machine’s depths. What you’ve been through, the memories you hold, it’s ammunition we could use to derail the system. I needed to know if you had the strength to resist.”

Dunya raised an eyebrow. “Next time, a little heads up would be nice. You know, just a nudge instead of a full-on psychic invasion.”

Serafim cracked a brief smile.

Dunya felt the weight of the situation settle back in, her earlier comment fading. “And now, what’s your move?”

Serafim locked eyes with her. “I can get us inside. You can recognize what she built. We find the link and cut it before she pulls anyone else through.”

Dunya almost laughed. The plan was insane. Then again, she had already died once.

Serafim leaned in slightly. “My mother left contingencies. Encrypted messages. Routes out. Fail-safes for a future where the Battalion lost control. I’ve broken enough of them to know where we can enter, but it takes two people. I need you because you’ve already been inside.”

Dunya’s fingers twitched. Maria’s frozen body flashed through her again, then Anna’s room, then the tree. “No way I’m going back in there. Last run nearly wiped me.”

“The network is almost ready,” Serafim said. “If we wait, we lose the only window we have.”

“You’re asking me to risk everything.”

“I’m asking you to move before Zakharovna reaches you again. Vesna can’t protect you now. Maria can’t. I can get you out, but not if we sit here explaining it until the door opens.”

Dunya’s pulse stuttered, her breath catching as a sharp knock shattered the room’s thickening silence. In that brief interruption, Serafim’s eyes flicked to hers, a flash of shared anxiety sparking in the glance before it vanished.

“Why is this locked? Is anyone there?” The voice beyond the door pressed on. The handle twisted and the frame shuddered as it cracked open a mere sliver. “Open up, I know you’re there.”

Dunya felt Serafim’s hands move quickly, securing the exoskeleton around her with a series of clicks and hisses. She stayed seated, half-hidden behind frosted glass that should have blurred her into a vague shadow, while the uncertain presence lingered on the other side.

The door’s protest under another round of pounding sent a jolt through Dunya, her heart hitching at the sound. Then, with a creak that cut through the silence, a figure edged in. An elderly woman stood there, her eyes swirling with worry. The nurse who had been a shadow of comfort in her haze of pain now framed the doorway, her voice sharp in the air. “You mustn’t move so much yet, you need to recover,” she chided, her gaze fixed on the last few marks that marred Dunya’s newly grown skin.

A flash of suspicion flickered in Serafim’s eyes, narrowing as she studied the nurse’s demeanor. Before Dunya could process the shift, Serafim sprang into action, a blur of motion that sent the woman crashing to the floor. She planted her foot firmly on the woman’s chest, and the door swung wide to reveal startled faces in the hallway. Her sidearm snapped up, leveled at the intruders.

“Upload her intake scan and graft log,” Serafim said. The words hung heavy, dense with threat, over the group now frozen with unease.

Another nurse approached with hesitant steps, her hand unsteady as she extended a small device. When it touched the implant at the base of Dunya’s neck, a sudden tingle shot through her, a sharp and surprising sting that caught her breath short. Wordlessly, the hand that had wavered only a moment ago now moved decisively, passing the device into the firm hold of Serafim.

“Thank you,” Serafim said, lowering the pistol. “We’ll be leaving now.”

Her eyes flicked to the door, then back to Dunya. “We need to move.”

Dunya folded the necklace back into its velvet lining and kept the mahogany case in her lap. The Skelet hugged her legs with its familiar weight, each segment locked along the outside of her limbs, the faint pinprick at her spine where the rig had jacked into her nerves. Serafim gripped the chair handles and pushed her forward with urgency. The sick bay slipped behind them, and the sterile corridors stretched past in a blur.

In a shadowed alcove Serafim slowed, leaning down, her breath steady despite the rush. “How long until you can walk?”

“I’ve got it from here.” Dunya took the case from her lap and pushed herself upright. The act of standing, strange after what felt like weeks in limbo, sent her balance tilting for a moment, but the Skelet’s frame caught her, its support pouring strength back into her body. She met Serafim’s gaze. “I can stand. Don’t mistake that for trust. I understand what you told yourself. I haven’t decided what that changes.”

The silence stretched, and then, to Dunya's surprise, Serafim moved closer. The tentative arms that wrapped around her felt oddly out of place. "I let Maria push deeper than we agreed. Then I followed her in. I told myself I was keeping you alive."

Dunya went rigid inside Serafim's embrace. Comfort from the person who had been inside her head felt like accepting a security patch from the hacker who planted the exploit.

Maybe Serafim had reasons. Reasons did not restore trust. They only explained the breach.

As they parted, Serafim said, "I know how to open a locked system. I don't know how to undo what I did to you."

If aligning with her brings me a step closer to Zakharovna, then so be it. That's all that really matters. For everything she's put me through, I swear, Zakharovna will pay.

Dunya shook her head. "It was reasonable for Maria not to trust me. I knew Vesna had been at Yelagin and helped hunt my father. I didn't know she had kept a line open to Zakharovna after leaving the Wolves. Maria had every reason to wonder how much of that line ran through me."

"And Vesna going back to Zakharovna?"

Dunya's gaze dropped to the mahogany case in her hand. "She was the one who gave me proof my father entered Zakharovna's custody alive. I should be surprised. Part of me isn't, and that makes it worse." She clicked the brass clasp shut and slipped the case into her pack. "We can't change what's already done. But we can keep moving and try to stop them."

Serafim's eyes swept the corridor, her vigilant scan a silent order. "Then follow me."

Dunya flexed her legs inside the Skelet, feeling the familiar weight steady her. Whatever came next, trust or betrayal, she would face it on her own terms.

△△△

The snow-blanketed streets, windswept and desolate, bore the weight of injured soldiers with missing limbs and hollow stares, the remnants of battle. Dunya and Serafim moved cautiously, stepping around a motionless woman whose severed leg lay in a dried pool of blood. The sight tugged at Dunya, but war's brutal reality left no room to dwell on the fallen.

As they neared Serafim's trike, Dunya's eyes caught the cobalt blue of its frame, vivid against the white snow.

Serafim patted the cobalt frame. "Rostislava. She's been getting me out of trouble since I was sixteen."

"Fourteen years," Dunya said.

"Apparently."

Dunya glanced at her. "That word's doing a lot of work."

"I'm thirty. Started taking exo at twenty-two."

"Forty-one," Dunya said. "Also, apparently."

Every morning she swallowed an exovegeta tablet before the HUD could begin counting down. It felt less like medicine now than a humiliation ritual, another reminder that the babachain kept her tethered. Skip a dose and her vitals would collapse within hours. The system would flood her vision with alerts and summon help before neglect could finish the job.

Serafim swung onto the seat. "Get on."

Dunya climbed behind her and settled her hands around Serafim's waist. "Keep her upright."

"Rostislava or you?"

"Start with the trike."

Dunya tightened her grip around Serafim's waist. The woman had drugged her, entered her mind, and was now driving their escape. Fear and attraction had become tangled enough that Dunya no longer trusted either signal.

She did not need to name it yet. She only needed to keep Serafim from choosing for her again.

Dunya kept her eyes sharp for threats while Rostislava guided them through Gred's winding streets. The city's pulse had slowed to a murmur as residents sought refuge or tended to the wounded. The further they went, the streets coiled like abandoned concrete snakes, shadowy figures darting between distant buildings.

"We're heading to see an old friend: Doctor Fedorova," Serafim shouted over the roar of the engine. "She was deep in Zakharovna's projects, knew her strategies inside out. I grew up around those games."

Clutching her seat as they sped through the snow-blanketed park, Dunya called out, "What was Fedorova's specialty?"

"Memory," Serafim replied, eyes fixed ahead.

As the mansion loomed into view, a figure darted across the drive. Small, quick. Dunya stiffened, her hand tightening on the seat, but Serafim adjusted course without hesitation.

"Was that—?" Dunya's voice caught.

When they dismounted at the gates, she saw them again: two young girls slipping through a side passage just inside the doors, their giggles trailing before vanishing into the dark.

Dunya froze, the sight pulling at her chest. *Children? Here?*

Serafim caught the look on her face. “Orphans. Fedorova cycles them through the tunnels, passing them off between groups who can keep them safe. Better than letting the state snatch them up.”

Dunya shook her head, but the knot in her chest didn’t ease. She followed Serafim inside, her eyes sweeping over the entryway. Figures loomed along the walls, draped in ragged hides and stitched furs, their hoods bristling with feathers and antlers, masks painted with curling lines that glared in the shifting light. Charred scraps of cloth hung from their shoulders like old battle standards, brittle and heavy with age. Their empty eyeholes seemed to follow her, colder than any steel.

Her gaze climbed higher, drawn from the watching masks to the brilliance above. Crystal chandeliers cascaded from the ceiling like frozen waterfalls, refracting a kaleidoscope of light across the timeworn marble floor. Ahead, a massive oak staircase dominated the foyer, its dark steps worn smooth by decades of footfalls.

Serafim led her beside the stairs to a small door. The knob groaned under her grip, and with a grating creak it opened onto a vast chamber. Dunya stepped in, the musty scent of old paper drifting over her. She could hardly remember the last time she’d smelled it. Her eyes followed the towering shelves that climbed toward the lofty ceiling, rows of tomes packed tight, their spines cracked and faded.

They passed through and crossed a small canteen, polished cabinets flashing their reflections back at them. Further down the hall, muffled voices leaked from behind a closed door where a large gray lock dangled open. Serafim turned the handle and eased it wide.

The room inside glowed dim and alive. Machinery lined the walls, consoles blinking with rhythmic light. The air smelled of solder and burnt circuitry, sharp and acrid, tugging at Dunya's memory of fried headsets and overworked boards. At the center sat a woman, her hair ashen, wrapped in a blue cotton robe beneath a flame-retardant yellow jacket. Wires trailed from her arm into the machinery, pulsing blue and red.

Her skin was threaded with silver ports, machine fused to flesh. One eye was pale and natural, the other faintly aglow. When she moved, her gaze cut with precision, landing on Dunya first. For a moment they held each other's solitude in silence.

Then, with slow deliberation, her eyes slid to Serafim, as if drawn by invisible wires.

"You brought her," the woman said, her pale eye fixed on Dunya. "After nearly losing the key twice."

"She's here," Serafim said. "We still can't open the archive."

"My ciphers?"

"Your ciphers."

Dunya edged closer, drawn to the web of wires at the woman's feet. Holographic glyphs shimmered in the air, spinning symbols and shifting fragments. "What are these for?" she asked.

"They're extensions of my memory," the woman whispered. "I can hold every detail, sift through every fragment. The system filters out the noise, distills my thoughts to their essence."

"You offload working memory into the array," Dunya said. "It holds the fragments while you decide what matters."

"It returns them in ranked order," the woman said. "Useful, until the ranking starts pretending to be judgment."

Zakharovna's systems depend on patterns. Break the pattern, and she has to look at the noise."

"What is she even looking for?" Dunya asked.

"Truth," the woman said softly. "She believes every being carries an unaltered fragment, a *soulshard*. A shard no machine can warp."

"A soulshard? What truth is Zakharovna after?"

"She guards her secrets like sovereigns of old. If I had to guess, she seeks the underpinnings of reality itself. Not knowledge, but power. The kind that reshapes worlds." Her eyes locked on Dunya. "And that is something they cannot let her find."

"So, what's even stopping her at this point? Is it the Syndicate, or is there another player in the dark?"

The woman scoffed. "The Syndicate slows her down. The babachain can stop her, if its custodians still agree on anything." Her pale eye held Dunya's. "Thirteen of us safeguard the ledger. I'm one of the Oracles."

Dunya's mouth went dry. "You're...one of them?"

Serafim let out a low whistle. "Never would've pegged you for the guardian type. Guess the babachain still has surprises."

The Oracle's pale eye softened. "Oh, Serafim... I thought someone like you would've seen this coming. Eyes in all the right places."

Serafim stayed unreadable, but Dunya felt the weight behind the words. Then the Oracle turned back to her, gaze flickering with something Dunya couldn't name, perhaps concern or perhaps relief.

"Zakharovna has always been willing to stare into the abyss," the Oracle said. "But the deepest layers of the network

hold truths she must never find. My hard drive is hidden inside Zakharovna Central. Recover it, then take it to my old lab. The local rig can read it without exposing this house.”

A map flickered into view on the projection. Her finger hovered over the metro lines. “The tunnels are crawling with Yelena’s enforcers. Eyes everywhere. Impossible to move without being seen. And yet Petrova guards a treasure she doesn’t even understand.”

Her hand trembled as it opened. “Zakharovna’s agents are already searching. If they find this drive, it’s over. It holds everything we’ve built, our countermeasures. One slip and the veil falls.” Her gaze fixed on Dunya. “Get the drive to the lab. Bring me whatever the rig recovers. If you can survive the way back.”

Serafim leaned in. “The metro, huh? Heavy with guards. We get in, get out, no trace.”

Dunya’s nod was firm, though her stomach churned. “Zakharovna Central. We’ll find a way.”

The Oracle’s sternness eased, a smile ghosting her face. “You’re a brave woman, Dunya Bocharov. Bravery is what we need now.”

They left the room, the hum of machines fading behind them. The revelation clung to Dunya like smoke she couldn’t breathe out. *An Oracle on the babachain...* She’d always wondered if Babushka’s grip had limits. Now she knew. Now it had a face.

They passed a greenhouse where glass caught the last streaks of light, before stepping into the gardens. The estate stretched out still and wide, dusk creeping closer with every breath.

We’re not done yet, she told herself. Not even close.

Zakharovna Central loomed ahead, its bulk blotting out the skyline. For the first time, Dunya saw it as a monument to its namesake's ego. Rostislava's quiet hum was the only sound in the dead streets, the trike's pulse fading as Serafim cut the engine.

They dismounted and crossed to a side door half-hidden in ivy. Serafim found the latch without hesitation, the kind of entrance only someone with clearance or secrets would know. The hinges groaned low, then swallowed them into the dark.

Inside, the air was damp. Weak bulbs threw small islands of light, leaving long stretches of corridor in shadow. Paint curled from the walls, and the sour smell of mold clung to everything. Dunya kept her knife ready, the Skelet's weight steadying her legs.

The Wolves patrolled somewhere ahead. Their presence pressed at the edge of her vision, not yet visible but impossible to ignore. Each step had to be measured, each breath held tight, as if the station itself might give them away.

The first encounter came quickly. Two guards rounded the bend, carbon armor catching what little light there was. Dunya's hand closed on her butterfly knife, the chill of the steel grounding her.

Before she could move, Serafim slipped a coin-sized disc from her pocket. She pressed the button once.

The Wolves faltered mid-step. Their helmets jerked as if the ground had tilted under them, then both crumpled, armor clattering against the tiles.

Dunya shot Serafim a glance but kept moving. No time to dwell.

They pressed on, the back passages winding like a maze. Only their breathing and the scrape of boots broke the silence.

At the next corner a figure stepped into view, a yellow-black scarf trailing the air, its fanged pattern glaring in the dim light. *Yelena's new Wolves.*

Dunya didn't hesitate. Her knife slid free, arm moving on instinct. The blade found the gap under the armplate and drove home. The guard's eyes met hers for an instant, wide with shock, before the body sagged to the floor.

She pulled the knife clear and kept moving. The weight of the task pressed harder with every step. There was no room left for thought, only the rote rhythm of muscle and steel carrying them forward.

The shop sat tucked in a side alcove, half-forgotten in the sprawl of the station. Its sign was worn to nothing, windows dim with dust.

Serafim checked the corridor once, then eased the door open. The hinges groaned, and stale air met them. Inside, the wallpaper had bleached to gray. Shelves sagged under books no one had touched in years. The place smelled of paper rot and old glue.

Dunya slipped in behind her, scanning the mess. Every shadow felt like it might hide a watcher. Serafim gave a small signal toward a wall stacked high with bundled newspapers.

A clatter split the silence. Dunya froze, breath caught, as she and Serafim ducked behind a leaning shelf. Blue light swept the window, pale beams cutting through grime. Her heartbeat drummed loud in her ears.

The lights lingered, then slid away. Footsteps faded down the hall. Only then did she let her lungs empty.

Serafim pointed at a row of books. Dunya ran her fingers along the spines until one clicked. A hidden panel eased open,

revealing a plain gray drive. Cold to the touch, heavier than it looked.

“Got it,” Dunya whispered. She slipped it into her pocket, the metal pressing cool against her thigh.

They retraced their steps in silence. Each corner felt like a trap, each sound like it might give them away.

Encryption, Dunya thought, was never about steel doors or brute force. The best ciphers hid in plain sight, tucked where no one bothered to look. Intruders always overestimated the need for walls. The trick was misdirection.

She wondered if Serafim saw her the same way, a piece of misdirection, overlooked until it was useful. Maybe that was why the Oracle had trusted her, and why Serafim still kept her close.

At last the station gave way to open air, the night colder and sharper than before. Outside, Rostislava waited, frost catching on its cobalt frame. Dunya swung on behind Serafim. The trike rumbled back to life, and they slipped into the night.

ΔΔΔ

“This way,” Serafim said, cutting toward a narrow alley.

Dunya glanced back at the deserted street. “It’s like a bad dream, watching the city fall apart this fast.”

“Dream’s over,” Serafim snapped.

The words stuck. Dunya pictured what would happen if Zakharovna’s agents caught them alive. Maria’s warnings came back sharp, women dragged from the Derge shanties for experiments that left bodies twisted, skulls opened, faces aged to dust in a single night. Dunya forced the images down, but

they clung, proving how far cruelty could go when dressed up as science.

Dunya fixed on the road ahead. The streets were unfamiliar now, buildings she half-remembered buried under vines and rot. Serafim's hand shot out, stopping her short and pointing into the dark.

"There," she whispered. "Xenia's old lab."

Across the street, a hulking structure rose from the tangle of overgrowth, its outline barely visible through the branches.

"Symbolic," Dunya muttered. "Nature trying to bury what happened here."

Serafim's eyes stayed on the structure. "A fitting end. But stay sharp. We don't know what's inside."

The building loomed like an asylum, not the high-tech lab Dunya had pictured. Guardhouse windows were dark, no sign of watchers. Serafim gave her a quick look, then broke into a sprint across the street.

Dunya's chest pounded as she followed. A patrol's murmur drifted from somewhere behind, pushing her faster. She hit the far side and dropped into the cover of overgrown brush, lungs burning.

"We can't stay out here long," she said.

Serafim nodded, eyes fixed on the unguarded gate. "We'll need to get inside fast."

A drone cut across the sky, its hum rattling the air. Dunya froze, knife clenched tight, every muscle braced. For a heartbeat it hovered close enough to expose them, then drifted on.

Serafim dropped low and moved for the fence. Wire cutters clicked soft in her hands, snapping a gap wide enough to slip through. She jerked her chin toward the opening. "Move."

Dunya slipped through the gap after Serafim. They hurried along a forgotten path until ivy blocked the way. Climbing came easy; vines pulled at their gear as they hauled over and dropped on the other side.

Catching her breath, Dunya pressed on to the lab's outer wall. She kept to shadow, skirting moonlit ground, and reached a window with blinds left half-open. Inside, she saw cluttered desks, idle computers, shelves thick with books and papers.

"Here," Serafim whispered. She eased the window wider and drew Dunya in. A stairwell yawned before them, its steps vanishing underground.

"Basement levels," Serafim said.

"Just how far does this go?" Dunya asked. The only reply was the steady drip of unseen water.

"Not far," Serafim said. "But the history here runs deeper than distance." She flicked on her flashlight. Its beam shook as if reluctant to uncover what lay ahead. "Let's hope nobody's home."

They moved carefully, silence heavy between them. At the bottom, a steel door blocked the way. Cyrillic letters screamed across its face: NO ENTRY. HIGH VOLTAGE. DANGER: FIRE AND EXPLOSION HAZARD. CONSULT SAFETY PROTOCOLS.

A mechanical lock sat in the frame, solid and old. Dunya studied it, surprised by the weight of its design. This was no code to crack from a distance.

Serafim's eyes lingered on the HIGH VOLTAGE sign, a smirk tugging at her mouth. "Maintenance closet, sure. What's really behind here is Xenia's backdoor. They figured a misdirect would keep us out. Let's prove them wrong."

She pulled a laser cutter from her kit and adjusted the settings with practiced flicks. The beam flared to life, humming low.

Metal hissed as it met the lock. The mechanism held stubborn, forcing her to stop and recalibrate. A bead of sweat slid down her temple, her jaw set tight.

As Serafim worked the laser, Dunya thought back to nights spent breaking botnets. Endless streams of bad code severed and rebuilt until the network fell quiet. That was the virtual world, where she could bend rules with a few keystrokes. Here the rules were harder. Steel, locks, and the Skelet's weight on her legs gave no command line to rewrite.

Her eyes caught something beside the lock: a narrow panel hidden under paint. "The hard drive," she said. "Could we use it to trip the override? Looks like it might have a port."

Serafim glanced over, hand half-lifting toward it, then stopping. "I see it. But no. This rig's wired to burn itself if you prod the wrong line. And if it goes, so does the drive. Xenia said everything we need is on there. One mistake and the whole job's done."

Her warning cut off as the lock gave way with a sharp click. The door hissed, then released. Serafim pushed it open, steadying herself before forcing it wide.

Dunya slipped in behind her, pulse thudding in her ears. Harsh lights snapped on with the sensors, their clinical glare washing over walls flaking with decay. If this was a trap, where were the alarms?

Surrounded by racks of servers and banks of blinking LEDs, Dunya felt the low hum run through her chest. This was more than a server room. It was a nerve center, where wires and flesh blurred, built for dives that reached into the University's cybernetic experiments. Here the physical walls

were only a shell around the real network, a place where the virtual and the human had been stitched together.

“What’s our next move?” Dunya asked.

Serafim was already at a dormant terminal, fingers moving fast across the keys. The screen flared to life, spilling a glow that lit the room and pulled up layer after layer of security gates.

“This unit’s hardwired into the University’s network,” Serafim said without looking away. “Xenia left root credentials here. Most are dead. One still points toward the core graft.”

Lines of code spilled down the monitor. Dunya leaned closer, watching the cascade take shape.

“A privileged cluster,” Dunya said. “Enough access to make the lower layers obey.”

Serafim nodded. “The weights inside it are selected minds. Soulshards, neural copies, call them what you want. Zakharovna keeps what aligns and discards the rest.”

“So every person she adds makes the system more like her.”

“And harder to separate from Babushka.”

Dunya’s eyes narrowed. “Then how have *you* managed to stay off her radar?”

A grin flickered across Serafim’s face, fierce and gone in a breath. “Let’s just say I’ve got my tricks. Took years to build the protections I use. But it’s still cat and mouse, and I’m not always the one doing the chasing. Every move is a gamble against that gaze hanging over everything. Speed and stealth, that’s what keeps us alive. Trip one alarm and we’re finished. We have to hit hard, move fast, and be gone before the system even knows we were there.”

“When we first met, you put something in my head.”

“Yes. A shadow layer around the graft. I redirected the live trace and pushed you toward the contract.” Serafim met her eyes. “I told myself you wouldn’t understand the stakes. The truth is, I decided your consent was optional.”

“Alright. How do we tear this thing down?”

“We trace its roots,” Serafim said. “First reconnaissance. Map it, find the defenses. Then we pull back. Today gives us an entry point. With the access we secure, we can jack in remote later, keep a presence without coming back here.”

“So for now we stay quiet, blend into the noise. Let Zakharovna think her web’s untouched,” Dunya said.

“Exactly. We’ve got the keys from these files, and with Xenia’s drive we can build the decryption sequence. Latency works in our favor. Once we load the sequence into your neural interface, we’ll have a shot.” Serafim’s eyes fixed on her. “Once the sequence loads, the next step is a dive.”

Dunya looked at the headgear. “One pass. The moment I say out, you pull me.”

Serafim nodded. “Agreed.”

As Serafim double-checked the hallway, Dunya produced the trusty cube from her pack. With a deliberate press, the cube activated, its sides thrumming to life with vibrant neon light. *There’s that familiar hum*, Dunya thought, as the low, comforting whir filled the space.

Serafim returned, picking up the hard drive with the care of a bomb technician. She interfaced it with the cube, her fingers moving expertly across the compact machinery. A flicker of light ran across its surface as the cube absorbed the drive’s contents, followed by a string of chirps. It was accepting the decrypted files.

In the silence that followed, Dunya’s eyes met Serafim’s. Their look balanced trust and calculation, impossible to

weigh. The core graft's mysteries, now locked inside the small black cube that pulsed teal and pink, lay heavy in her hands.

Dunya settled into a chair, adjusted her portable headgear, connected the device to her brain. As it calibrated, she glanced over at Serafim, who offered a nod of encouragement.

Her world dissolved into static, then to black.

ΔΔΔ

Dunya's surroundings shifted, and she stood again in the phantasmal landscape that had become too familiar. Towering above, the colossal tree loomed, its trunks entwined like a grotesque monument reaching for the cobalt sky. The branches, laden with glowing fruit, swayed gently, their leaves whispering a haunting melody that made her shudder.

At the tree's base, a machine bound a throng of souls whose wails clawed at her. However often she saw it, the horror never dulled. Blood seeped down the gnarled bark, pooling thick around the roots. Vines hung overhead, waiting to drag down anyone who faltered in the crimson tide. A body plummeted from the treetop, the dreadful sound of its impact a grim punctuation she'd come to anticipate, but it still made her flinch.

From the twisted limbs, a bird swooped, violet eyes burning. It landed on the fallen body and tilted its head at Dunya, as if in recognition. With an unexpected strength, it grasped the fabric of the woman's clothes in its beak and began to drag the body towards the river of blood, its wings flapping with the effort. As the corpse touched the crimson flow, the bird released its burden and with a sharp cry, ascended rapidly into the gloom above.

At that very moment, as the ripples of blood widened from the body's entry, a woman materialized from the hushed shadows. She seemed to step through the same unseen veil that the bird had vanished beyond, her appearance as sudden and silent as its departure. Clad in the slate jacket and red-tinted goggles she was well known for, she moved with urgent purpose, pushing past the spot where Dunya stood, her focus fixed on the grim task ahead.

Doctor Anastasia Zakharovna paused, head turning slightly toward Dunya. She sniffed the air, eyes narrowing, a predator testing the wind. But then, as if dismissing an errant thought, she returned to her duties. With a brusque motion, Zakharovna resumed her work, severing the bonds that held a man to the inhumane device. Her knife plunged again and again until the man's body stilled, sinking into shadow.

Adrift in the river of blood, Dunya's gaze caught the bound faces. One was eerily like Vesna's, purplish strands lost in the crimson tide. Another had black hair plastered, hazel eyes frozen in plea. A third was framed in sandy locks, blue eyes fixed in porcelain stillness. Beyond them, rows of others receded into shadow, the machine feeding on them all.

In eerie unison, their heads turned toward Dunya. Recognition passed down the line, and the nightmare tightened around her intrusion.

Farther down the line, a dark-haired woman fixed her gaze on Dunya. She lifted one finger and moved it left.

A barrier snapped into place around Dunya.

Across the distance, Zakharovna tensed, head snapping up, eyes narrowing as if she had sensed something wrong. Her lips began to move, shaping a command, summoning an unseen force to crush the disruption.

Dunya reeled, the weight of all those searching stares too much to bear.

She swiped the authentication pane. “Out.”

“Pulling you now,” Serafim said.

The landscape tore into static before Dunya could reach for the headgear.

ΔΔΔ

Guided by instinct more than sight, she stripped the device from her head and let it clatter onto the table.

As it fell, the nightmarish echoes—the screams of the tree-bound souls—began to fade. She drew in a deep breath, the cool, stale air of the room washing away the stifling terror of that waking dream. The cramped space, its jumble of technology and dim corners, grounded her in the tangible chaos of the real.

“Dunya.” Serafim waited until she looked up. “Tell me what you saw before it starts changing.”

“It wasn’t just a vision. It had latency, resistance, feedback. Whatever those people felt, the system carried it clean enough to reach me.”

“Then the signal held both ways,” Serafim said. “They may have felt you too.”

Her hand settled on Dunya’s shoulder, then withdrew. “We stop here. We copy the logs, take them to Xenia, and no one goes back in until you ask.”

As Dunya prepared to stand, a fragmented image from the simulation flashed, the last face in the sequence. Her breath caught.

“Maria...” The name slipped out, heavy with realization. She was in there, tangled in that macabre dimension.

Pallor washed over Serafim's face at the name, blood seeming to drain at the utterance. "The Syndicate," she whispered. "If she's been through their system, her memories—our past—could already be twisted beyond repair." She faltered, voice thinning. "The odds of getting her back whole are slim."

"No, you're not hearing me," Dunya said. "She's still there. I saw her."

"Maria? In there? Or just traces, an echo in the sim?"

"It wasn't fragments or shadows. I felt her, her agony, her terror. It was her, alive in that place."

Serafim studied her, uncertain. "You really believe it."

"Zakharovna didn't erase the connection," Dunya said. "Maria recognized me."

Dunya's ocular flashed red before Serafim could respond, messages streaming into her field of view:

SENDER: YANA.

HELP. VORY. BARAKA. NOW.

With the message still flashing in her vision, Dunya turned to Serafim, hoping she would grasp the urgency she felt. "My friend needs help."

Serafim was already pulling the cables free. "Then we move."

CHAPTER THIRTY FOUR

KLARA

Marzanna's blank stare was fixed on the Grand Mariner's Cathedral, now a pyre against the blue winter sky. Above the chaos, two pale crescent moons lingered.

“Seein’ double, Marz?” Klara said. She nodded towards the spectacle. “With the fire, the screams, it’s almost got a melody to it, don’t ya think?”

“And who are we to judge the rhythm?”

Klara prodded, a frown forming, “What’s gotten into you?”

Marzanna’s eyes shifted from the sky to her hands. Klara nudged her shoulder. “Hey, we should be celebratin’. I just knocked off a Pra Matron. You saw that, right? Clean shot, right in the leg—old hag bled out before she knew what hit her.” Fishing out a flask, she revealed the amber liquid swirling inside—spiced honeyed brandy—and tossed it to Marzanna, who fumbled the catch but managed to grip it.

Marzanna put the flask to her lips, the brandy disappearing into a long draw.

Ending her reign felt right. For a few hot seconds Klara was fifteen again under the ARRT tower, steam burning her throat while the southern road stayed empty. Romanova’s reserve had stayed behind the Yelizovo line while Zavoyko bled. Now the old woman was the one on the floor, and nobody was coming for her. Klara hated how good that felt.

“Hey there, calm down now, save some for me... Really, what’s buggin’ ya?”

“Nothing. It all worked out in the end,” said Marzanna.

Klara’s eyes traced the jagged lines where blackened trunks cut against the snow—a grim lacework of destruction. They stood in a small bubble of white, an island of undeath amidst the ghostly still, as if the fire had deliberately spared them its wrath.

“You know, back in the underground, when we first shook hands, I saw something in you,” Klara began, feeling the memory press on her. “I knew I had to follow you. You owe me

an explanation.” The certainty of it still unsettled her; she had spent years making herself into the one others followed.

She leaned in. “How are you doing it? I’ve never seen anyone handle fire like that without going up in flames themselves. You’re supposed to take small hits, but you—damn.”

“Lots of practice.”

Klara leaned closer, her eyes probing into Marzanna’s, searching for the cracks in her stoic facade. “It’s a bit grim right now, I get it,” she teased. “Spill when you’re ready, yeah?” She took a swig from the flask, the brandy scorching its way down her throat. A belch rose sharply from her chest, breaking free.

Marzanna glanced at Klara with a laugh escaping her lips, looking for all the world like she was trying to fight it, but failing—charmed, Klara figured.

As their laughter faded, Klara’s eyes caught movement in the distance. “Yellow scarves,” she murmured with recognition. “Yelena’s turncoats.” Knowing these were allies, her tension eased. She waved vigorously, signaling for them to approach.

The two robust women approached them, one sporting stark red hair, clad in agile armor, a sniper rifle strapped to her back. The other had pale golden hair, equally robust, with a gunblade hanging behind her, its blade intricately carved with the image of the goddess Perine.

“Pretty sight, this big ol’ church, huh?” Klara remarked as they neared.

“Yeah, I’d say it was a job well done,” came the response from one of the Black Wolves.

Marzanna was staring at the pair, and the lift in her eyebrows suggested she was taken aback. “You at it again? Come on, relax,” Klara nudged her.

Klara turned her attention back to the two women. “So, what convinced you to make the switch? Thought you Wolves were loyal to a fault.”

One of the women answered, a trace of scorn in her voice. “Not when we don’t have a commander. This green bitch killed Arkadya. Then we found out she cheated, took some kind of super-stim, experimental exo that gave her insane strength. And in the duel, well, Vesna came out on top. There’s no honor in that.”

“See? Yelena always gets down to the truth, figures things out. She’ll make a great leader, don’t you think?”

“All I care about right now is taking down that bitch. Nothing else,” the Black Wolf fired back. “But remember, it was a spy game that got our last Matron. What goes around comes around.” Melding severity with a hint of respect, she concluded, “With Romanova out, and that mad scientist missing in action, there’s no Matrons left to stand by. Looks like Yelena’s the last one up. She’s a lucky lady.”

“That she is,” Klara acknowledged. She gestured to Marzanna. “Anyway, the two of us had best be on our way. But before we head out, what’s your plan? What’s your unit’s next move?”

One of the Black Wolves answered, “Yelena’s got us tracking down Zakharovna’s old gateway nodes. Says the next front in this war’s gonna be full-scale digital. Not sure what else beyond that.”

“Duly noted,” Klara responded. “Thanks for the info.”

She gave one last sweeping look at the cathedral, its burning spires rising above the ashen grove. Black Wolf commandos dispersed throughout, and the remains of countless *shpichkis* dusted across the snow. In the distance, Hive infantry units were on the march. With the scene etched into her thoughts, Klara elbowed Marzanna. Wordlessly

agreeing on their next move, they both started down the path that cut through the remnants of the churchyard, leaving the carnage behind them.

The roadway extending from the churchyard toward the eight-laned Oktyabra Prospekt was deserted, an unusual but expected quiet replacing the bustling clatter of traffic that had once been customary. Klara broke the silence, glancing at Marzanna. “Yelena’s called us to Kosatka Harbor.”

“For a headcount?” Marzanna asked, trying to keep pace.

“No, more like a mop-up job. We hit the Admiralty hard, and now the Grand Mariner’s fleeing into the ice storms of the Bering Sea.”

“Stranded without a port,” Marzanna noted, the ghost of a smile on her lips.

“Exactly.” Klara nodded. “Yelena’s sealing off the coast, claiming relays and refineries. But there’s more to it.”

Marzanna raised an eyebrow. “Oh?”

“Yeah, the Harbor’s a mess. Missing boats, dissenters left behind—they’re like rats without a ship. And that’s where you come in.”

“My powers?”

Klara confirmed with a steady look. “We could use your fire. Make the cleanup at Kosatka quick. Those buddy fuckers won’t know what hit them.”

The thrum of a robust engine sliced through the hush, and Klara turned to see the military transport rounding the bend. Its matte black finish seemed to swallow the light, and the armored vehicle struck her as both imposing and streamlined. It barreled toward them, the heavy-duty tires chewing up the desolate roadway with ease.

“Perfect timing,” Klara remarked, as the vehicle came to an expert stop.

The sliding door of the transport vehicle hissed open, revealing the tall, robust form of Captain Shmelova. Her uniform, a testament to her rank, was accentuated by a yellow honeycomb-patterned scarf draped around her neck. A black visor capped her head, pushing back a braid of long white hair that fell over her left shoulder. Deep-set brown eyes surveyed the scene, missing nothing—a gaze as sharp as the elite soldiers who stepped out beside her.

Klara caught Marzanna’s eye briefly, tilting her head towards the transport, murmuring, “That’s the Uley-9 Koloss—about as tough as they come.”

Captain Shmelova acknowledged their arrival with a curt nod. Both soldiers provided a clear path for Klara and Marzanna to enter the vehicle. Inside, the chaos of the outside world fell away, replaced by the organized calm of the transport’s interior. Soft orange LEDs lit the space, and the seats along the sidewalls promised a semblance of comfort in their journey.

Shmelova settled into her seat with the familiarity of countless missions past. “Are we the last to leave?” Klara asked as she strapped herself in.

“We are,” Shmelova confirmed without looking up from the navigation display. “The last out, first on the fray.”

A knowing grin etched across Klara’s face as she felt the captain’s confidence. She tilted her head slightly towards Marzanna, who returned the gesture with a smile. “Don’t worry, Captain, I brought us a weapon.”

The doors sealed shut, enclosing them in the security of the transport’s fortified shell. With a gentle lurch, the vehicle set off, its hidden turret retracted, leaving the scorched battlefield

and the silent city streets behind as it blended into the urban landscape en route to Kosatka Harbor.

Captain Shmelova's lips quirked up only at one corner when she looked at Marzanna. "Heard some whispers about you and fire," she drawled, the ghost of a smirk betraying her amusement as she sized up the young woman with a critical eye.

Marzanna's smile took on a mischievous edge. "I guess you could say I'm an old flame that never went out."

A commotion interrupted them as Shmelova took a call, speaking in hushed tones to the soldiers lined against the interior of the vehicle. They gripped handrails, exchanging brief nods and terse replies.

Marzanna faced Klara, the amusement gone. "I need you to get me in front of Yelena."

Klara eyed her. "After what you did back there, she'll listen. Why?"

"Volkova was boosted with the same compound I'm carrying. Zakharovna had one of our samples."

Klara's grin vanished. "You sure?"

"Sure enough. I need a lab she no longer controls."

"Survive the harbor," Klara said. "I'll get you in the room."

BOOM! The transport shuddered, the sound resonating through its armored body, lights wavering precariously overhead. Soldiers braced against the walls, eyes sharp and ready.

Captain Shmelova couldn't suppress a wry, battle-hungry chuckle. "Looks like we're starting early, ladies!" She barked out a string of commands, and one of the soldiers scrambled to take control of the retractable turret atop the transport.

The transport's doors slid open abruptly, revealing the maelstrom beyond. "Here we go, kid. Show 'em what you got," Klara said to Marzanna, her own excitement mirrored in the younger woman's eyes.

Marzanna's blue eyes were cold steel, the determination there igniting as they both leapt from the vehicle. They landed to behold the epic sight of Kosatka Harbor unfolding in chaos: gunships consumed by fire in port, vast smoke plumes reaching skyward, the buzz of hostile drones weaving through the air—punctuated by the crack of sniper fire as old women took aim with their rifles and rocket launchers. The distant thunder of grenades underscored it all: *war*.

Klara's focus shifted to a large area on the docks where the harmony of industry had devolved into a violent scene. Robots and workers donning Skelets, meant for laborious loading duties onto ships for drilling ventures, now stood abandoned or dead amidst scattered equipment and fallen comrades.

As she took in the grim scene, a fierce firefight erupted. Black Wolves clashed among themselves, the bright yellow scarves signaling Hive allegiance while others bore red and blue with that same snarling wolf. The conflict was brutal, some resorting to fists in the heat of treachery.

Beyond the brawl, near the water's edge, was a last stand of escapees—a mix of Battalion soldiers marked with their bulky green garb and women in emerald and gold babushkas, golden runes on their uniforms catching the light. They fired rifles in desperate retreat, stepping backward onto the planks of a ship that pulled away, heaving with the weight of those fleeing the chaos.

Captain Shmelova, eyes ablaze with command, gestured sharply to a squad of Hive infantry. Twenty strong, they fell in line behind her, their sleek gray body armor catching the light, black rifles at the ready. The group moved with a cohesion

born of rigorous training, heading toward the warehouse district where chaos reigned.

As they departed, Shmelova tossed a final command over her shoulder. “You have your orders, Klara. Let’s see if this ‘old flame’ can really heat things up!”

Klara called back to Shmelova with a rugged bravado, “You just watch from a safe distance now. Don’t worry about us.” Laughter bubbled up from Klara’s throat, rough and tinged with the adrenaline surge of the upcoming battle.

Klara held Marzanna’s gaze, her eyes hard as flint. “Buckle up, it’s about to get ugly.” She heard the old medic in herself recoil at the thought, then shoved that voice aside and moved. There was no room for pretense between them, no sugar-coating the bloody work that lay ahead. Her hands tightened into fists at her sides. This was the necessary shadow-side of their quest for a better world, the part that came without cheers.

She surveyed the last retreating boat. “There’s no way we’re letting those traitors get away. The more we deal with now, the less blood spilt later. That Grand Mariner? She’s planning a return for sure.”

Klara seized Marzanna by the arm and directed her gaze to the boat. They dashed together, boots pounding the dock’s worn planks, passing by stacks of crates, slaloming between columns of smoke rising from smoldering debris. The air was thick with the competing scents of burning oil and brine.

As they drew nearer, Klara slowed down, signaling Marzanna to stop a safe distance from the boat, careful to keep cover between themselves and their target.

Marzanna hesitated a step as she stood there, like to size up the boat. It was a shadow against the fiery dockland backdrop. “You don’t mean me to...”

For all that firepower, kid sure is skittish. “Hell yeah, I do,” Klara followed up with a nod. “A spark won’t cut it with that behemoth,” she said, pointing to the ship armored like a fortress. “Its hull is missile-resistant, shrugs off normal fire like it’s nothing. We need heat that’s ferocious, that can chew through all that advanced flame-retardant tech. Besides, our stores are running on fumes. Until Yelena gets manufacturing back up and running, we’re scraping the barrel. The Battalion’s lockdown has seen to that—they’ve choked us dry on ammo.”

Marzanna nodded, her initial apprehension seeming to morph into focus. Klara crept low towards the line, staying out of sight of the patrolling figures on deck, their forms intermittently silhouetted by the outbreaks of gunfire.

Klara eyed the sloping dock, calculating the natural path the oil would take towards the ship nestled below.

Then, she cut the line, stepping back as the thick, dark oil gushed forth. In just moments, it surged across the wharf, following the gentle incline that directed it straight towards the vessel.

Klara tracked the expanding slick for a moment, ensuring it reached the desired course. Satisfied, she slipped back to where Marzanna stood, concealed by the maze of containers. Klara whispered to her, “Now, Marz. Fire it up.”

“Here goes nothing.” From deep within the pocket of her green trench coat, she retrieved a small blue pouch. Klara observed as the white powder stood out vividly against Marzanna’s palm.

The docks’ brine-laden breeze toyed with Marzanna’s short, silver-white hair as she brought the powder to her mouth. “Be ready for anything,” she warned before coating her tongue with it.

Klara noticed a subtle change come over her; Marzanna's eye sockets darkened, shifting into a deep purple shade, blood vessels popping as her pupils dilated.

Tiny strands of Marzanna's hair lifted, rising as though pulled by unseen static. The air around thrummed with anticipation, drawing into an invisible cloak that shrouded Marzanna's figure. Slowly, almost imperceptibly at first, Marzanna began to rise from the ground, defying gravity as she floated upward.

Klara gasped. As she stood motionless, a deep resonant sound began to churn from within her, or so it seemed. It was as if Marzanna's voice echoed in her mind, speaking to something primal, an ancient scripture now invoked for destruction, *"In Aisyt's embrace, unleash the fury that turns ash to life, and let our foes be devoured by the sacred flame of renewal."*

A bone-chilling scream erupted from Marzanna. Klara saw the heads of friend and foe alike turn, their bodies freezing in place as a shared sensation of primal dread shot up their spines. Something in her bones told her that what came next would be a spectacle of raw elemental power the likes of which she had never witnessed before.

Marzanna's entire body glowed with an ethereal silver luminescence, the unearthly light refracting across the dock's cluttered surface. Hovering several feet off the ground now, she was a beacon amidst the murk.

With a sudden explosive force, a ball of roaring flame surged forth from Marzanna, tracing a searing path straight to the oil trail Klara had laid. The fire was ravenous, snaking along the fuel with unholy greed until it found its prey—the slowly retreating Battalion ship.

A juggernaut of Gredian military engineering, it yielded to the engulfing embrace of the flames. Its robust, armored hull

peeled and blackened under the intense heat. Rivets popped and metal groaned in protest as the fire assimilated everything.

Panicked screams split the smoky air as soldiers and crew aboard, recognizing their fate was sealed, turned, and fled. One by one, they leaped from the deck, seeking salvation in the ice of Avacha Bay. But the water, slick with spilt fuel and now alight with Marzanna's relentless fire, betrayed their hopes.

The surface of the sea hissed and cackled, the usually frigid Kamchatkan waters now an agonizing bath of fire and steam. The scalding vapor melded with the harbor mist, a cauldron that condemned those who had plunged into the sea seeking salvation. Klara observed, caught between terror and amazement, as Marzanna's ferocity transformed the bay into a fiery chasm—those who leapt from the boat, desperate to escape the flames, were met with equally fatal fates.

The once formidable vessel was now a floating graveyard, the water around it darkened with the detritus of the annihilated ship. What remained was but a sable slick, dotted with the ghostly remnants of melted steel beams and charred flotsam, marking where the stronghold had been.

Klara's instincts kicked in as a tangle of green cloth and silver hair plummeted towards her. She darted forward, her arms outstretched. As Marzanna's form collided with her shoulder, Klara sank into a crouch, her strength guiding the descent. Gently, she placed Marzanna down on the cool ground. Marzanna's skin had lost its warm tone, now ashen, her once vibrant eyes closed, her breathing disturbingly faint.

"Come on, kid, wake up," she urged, patting Marzanna's cheeks to rouse her. "Wake up. You did good. You did real good."

“The kid’s catching her breath,” Klara mentioned, gesturing towards the secured transport. “Torched herself out. But she’ll be back on her feet soon enough.”

Shmelova, her attention momentarily diverted from the glowing tactical tablet, offered a half-smile that tugged at the edge of her lips. “She proved quite the blaze,” the captain said. “Delivered the firestorm you promised.”

“She did.” Klara nodded with pride, observing the industrious movement of their forces through the harbor. “And once she’s back up, I’ll talk to Yelena about harnessing that hellfire for the rest of the army.” The thought came too easily, and that was what unsettled her.

Kolya Zhukova, the grizzled former Battalion colonel who had recently sided with the Hive insurgency, emerged from behind the shattered husk of an armored transport. She walked towards Klara.

“Controlling such a force won’t be easy,” Zhukova observed, pushing a loose strand of red-white hair back into the disciplined bun atop her head. “But if it’s feasible, it would irrevocably tip the scales of power in our favor.”

“Challenge accepted, Colonel,” Klara said. She suppressed a knowing smirk, aware that any sign of their unspoken camaraderie had no place in front of the captain.

Shmelova shifted her focus to the horizon where the shadows gave way to the fading light. “We’ll need every advantage we can get. The Battalion won’t relent in their counterattacks, and neither will the Grand Mariner’s loyalists. This harbor,” she said, gesturing to the sprawling docks that buzzed with the aftermath of their victory, “is just the beginning.”

Captain Shmelova gave one last scan of the battlefield updates on her tablet before tucking it securely into her uniform's side compartment. A sense of urgency washed over her features. "I need to return to command—Yelena is already preparing her victory lap, and she'll require a substantial security detail when she stakes her claim publicly. It'll be a show of force, and it must go smoothly."

Klara nodded, catching Zhukova's eye briefly as Shmelova spoke. "Maintain the perimeter while I'm gone. We need to ensure no one can disrupt her moment. The eyes of those still sitting on the fence will be watching, judging if we're capable of holding power."

Klara nodded. "You can count on us, Captain."

With that, Shmelova briskly turned on her heel and walked away.

Examining Zhukova's stoic face, Klara let out a playful jab. "Hard to believe you could take living under those tight-wads as long as you did. Taking their orders without question."

Zhukova's eyes twinkled with a mix of mischief and defiance. "What's a wait these days when nobody dies, and we haven't seen war in a decade? I was getting bored. Almost thought Yelena didn't have it in her." Shaking her head lightly, she continued, "Anyway, with Grigoreva out of the picture, it wasn't hard securing intel from her successor. Orlov didn't see what was coming; got too comfortable in her new power too quickly."

Klara laughed, her head tilting back just slightly. "Comfort and power—a toxic mix. Always makes for surprise openings." That much, at least, the Syndicate had taught her well.

Zhukova agreed with a grunt, "Indeed."

Klara caught Zhukova's eye, a flicker of profound accord passing between them. "For the Coven," Klara said solemnly.

The laughter that followed mingled, then faded into the buzz of the harbor. It was the sound of a triumph hard-won, a reclamation bathed in the Hive's ascendant glory.

CHAPTER THIRTY FIVE

DUNYA

“Well, if it ain’t a motherfucker,” they hissed.

Serafim’s reaction was subtle but revealing. A slight flinch, a tightening around the eyes.

Dimitra’s posture hit a nerve, scraping at old scars. That readiness to crush, that cold edge, she knew it too well. Once, people like that would have cornered her. Now she caught the strain in Dimitra’s jaw, the forced detachment in Serafim’s stance. They tried to hide the turmoil, but she saw through it. She saw the shit beneath their skin.

“You owe me her freedom, Dimitra,” Serafim said. “Yana’s debt was settled the moment I paid the price.”

“Oh, living in the past, are we?” Dimitra scoffed.

“You forfeited that claim when you started double-dealing,” Serafim said. “She walks free. Now.”

Dimitra advanced with a menacing snarl, hand twitching near their hip in a clear threat. “No one takes what’s mine. You really think you can swipe my money-maker and live to see another day? Not a chance.”

The bouncers flanking Dimitra tensed. Both were bald, their skin slick with sweat, muscles ballooned from too many exo-stims. Thick cords ran along their necks like overstrained cables. Dunya could smell the ozone off their dermal rigs. One twitch, and they’d be on her.

The servos in her legs stirred, a low vibration she could feel more than hear. Power coiled through her thighs. Her hand drifted toward the railgun at her hip. “Let her go,” she said, voice steady.

Dimitra gave a soft whistle. The two moved as one. The first slammed a shock brace against the joint of her thigh, locking the actuator mid-motion. The other caught her wrist before her fingers brushed the grip. Pain flashed white as they pinned her arms, their strength raw and human, unbuffered by restraint.

“Fuck off,” she hissed. The Skelet whined, servos fighting the jam. For a moment, flesh won out over steel.

“Keep her down,” Dimitra barked. One of the bouncers shifted his weight, angling to block Serafim’s line of sight. She tried to step in, but the second man cut her off with a heavy shove that sent her staggering back.

Dimitra leaned in close, the heat of their breath grazing Dunya’s cheek. “Yana is mine.”

Dunya strained against the vice of the enforcers’ massive hands. She met Dimitra’s smug expression with a glare sharp enough to cut. “She’s not your property.”

“Is that right? Reality says otherwise,” they taunted.

Dimitra drew a sleek pistol and leveled it at Dunya’s face. The bouncers froze, glancing at one another. “Easy,” Dimitra said. “Let her breathe.”

The men loosened their grip just enough for Dunya to move her head.

“One more deal,” Dimitra said, the barrel never wavering. “Then she’s all yours.”

Their retreat was swift, the thuds of the enforcers’ heavy steps booming up the staircase from the outdoor patio’s antechamber. As the shadow of their departure loomed, the goons lingered, rifles raised in unison in a final, silent mockery, barrels pointed at Dunya and the others to underline Dimitra’s parting threat. “She’s short Rada now.

Cross that old crone, and you'll all pay," the warning echoed down ominously.

"We'll be back!" Dunya called up.

Yana burst through the club's doors, rushing down the stairs and out onto the street where Dunya and Serafim were waiting for her. "I was so worried about you—tell me everything," Dunya said immediately.

Yana's admission came quiet. "I was out of options, out of cash... I did what I had to, got involved with Grigoreva."

The name alone was enough for Dunya to understand the gravity of what *that* implied. "You should've come to me first. Getting mixed up with royalty? That's playing with fire."

"I didn't want to pull you into one my shitstorms again," Yana murmured.

Dunya tightened her grip. "We're in this together now, and we'll handle it together."

Serafim cut in, "Focus. We need to get you out of this. Now."

Yana shot back, "You're the reason I'm in this mess, Serafim! You set me up!"

"Yet here you stand, unscathed as usual."

"Exactly how long have you two been entangled in this?" Dunya asked.

"We've *both* been pawns longer than we knew." Serafim said with a heavy sigh, her gaze meeting Dunya's. "You didn't think you were the only ANGEL in play to topple Zakharovna, did you?"

The words landed with weight, and Dunya's frown deepened. "That doesn't exactly put you in a good light, not after you jammed our mindgraft."

Serafim grimaced. “It’s more layered than that. Maria... She was compromised. I couldn’t stop her from shadowing your ops. She was too headstrong.” She paused, the words seemingly painful to utter. “Zakharovna had hooks in her, and I had to purge your trails—get you cleaned, no niceties. Like I said, there’s no time for the whole story now. We have a crisis to manage here. Xenia’s on the brink of linking up, and when she calls, we need to be full systems go. It’s our last window.”

Dunya caught Yana’s eye, a glance that said everything. In that moment, they shared the same suspicion, the same unease, all unspoken but clearly understood.

Yana broke the silence. “We need to keep moving, regardless of...all this. We have a job—or rather, I have a job. But I’m hoping you’re in this to help too.”

She explained the rest quickly: a supply run to pick up contraband exo from Black Lotus Company down at the docks, not just for the club but for its clients, with several covert deliveries to be finished before the week’s end.

“We’re not actually going through with this, are we? Let’s just regroup and take them out,” Serafim interrupted, her eyebrows raised in disbelief.

Dunya shook her head. “And what, risk having an entire network of Vory assassins after us for the rest of our lives? Let’s focus on what we can control for now,” she countered. “Besides, we’ve got brains, and we’ve got guts. Together, we can pull this off.”

Serafim hesitated, scanning their faces as if weighing the odds. Her voice dropped. “You’re both insane.” A beat passed. “I’ll drive you there, but I’m not getting my hands dirty. I move wheels, not bodies.”

Yana let out a short, dry laugh. “Touching level of commitment. I’ll remember that when things start burning.”

Serafim turned toward Rostislava, her tone sharp again. “Then let’s make this quick. If your negotiations tank, Rostislava’s armed and waiting. She’ll clear us a path out.”

Yana exchanged a look with Dunya. “Good to know someone’s got our exit strategy covered.”

“Don’t thank me yet,” Serafim said, revving the trike to life. “Hop on.”

As they sped through the hollow streets, the hum of the trike filled the silence between them. Wind bit at Dunya’s face, cold and sharp, leaving a metallic taste on her tongue. The city blurred past, empty towers and fractured billboards, streets that seemed to fold into themselves. The rhythm of the engine became a steady pulse beneath her, a small order in the chaos around them.

The harbor district crept into view, darker than the rest of Gred. The air hung dense, a low mist clinging to the ground. Firelight flickered on the horizon, rising from what looked like the husks of old warships. For a moment she thought she saw movement in the glow, but the illusion vanished with the next breath.

Yana’s sudden intake of breath snapped Dunya out of her trance as Serafim pulled Rostislava to a hard stop at the roadside. The engine’s hum faded, leaving only the soft tick of cooling metal. They dismounted together, the air thick with unspoken urgency. Serafim glanced toward the dark stretch ahead, hand brushing the control device in her pocket. “I’ll keep Rostislava ready,” she said quietly. “If things go south, one ping and she’ll be in war mode.”

Yana nodded once and started forward, leading them into a narrow alley lit by the weak pulse of a single streetlamp. The light faltered as they passed, and Dunya had the uneasy sense that the shadows were following.

Yana cast a sideways glance at the trike, then at Serafim. “Just keep that beauty ready.”

Dunya watched as Yana pressed the doorbell. The door’s security slot snapped open.

“We’re expected,” Yana said, her voice managing to betray none of her visible tension.

A pair of eyes appeared behind the slot, the voice that followed edged with a practiced welcome that didn’t quite match their look. “Right on time. Come in.”

The slot slid shut and Dunya heard the heavy click of the door unlock. The sound echoed like the start of a countdown.

The warehouse looked busy enough to hide a small army. Workers in black moved between packing benches and sealed crates. At the center, a short brown-haired woman waited beside a hawk on a carved perch.

The bird tracked Dunya before the woman did, its eyes moving from her Skelet to Serafim and back, recording whatever human watchers missed.

“Rada Ivanov,” the woman said, offering her hand. “And this is Seryozha. He keeps an eye on the docks for me. You’d be surprised how much he sees from above.”

Dunya shook her hand without looking away from the hawk. Serafim could spoof cameras. A bird required different lies.

Rada led them to a workbench and opened a metal box. Blue vials with gold labels sat beside surgical tools.

“Are those what I think they are?” Dunya asked.

Dunya noticed a flicker of conceit in Rada’s smile as she beckoned them closer. On display before them were exo capsules, their exceptional purity and potency immediately apparent to Dunya’s trained eye. She’d only heard whispers

about these ones before: exclusive to the upper echelons of sanctioned military personnel.

Rada leaned in. “Listen, with Yelena’s backing and Zakharovna losing grip, the University’s monopoly on exo is gonna crumble. The Battalion’s out of the picture now, and they’ve left a big security hole in the market. We’re stepping up to fill that void. This city’s about to see a new era, and we’re leading it.”

Confusion and alarm mingled in Yana’s voice. “Hold on, what’s been going on?”

Rada flicked on a terminal, and a projection beamed onto the table. “The Ascension’s been shelved—no telling until when. More urgent, though, there’s been an assault on the Mariner’s Cathedral, a complete massacre.”

“Insane! An inside job by the University?” Yana said.

“Out of the loop, aren’t ya? You should watch the news more often. It was all Yelena’s doing, with a little help from our agents. But don’t tell anyone. They framed it as a terrorist attack. Just needed some Derge outcasts and spiked exo. Those poor fools didn’t even know.” She mimed an explosion with her hands, and the laughter that followed was cold and unsettling.

Yana visibly recoiled.

Dunya’s posture stiffened as the realization hit her. “You’re with...the Coven?”

Rada smiled sly. “Yelena sees what we’re capable of. Isn’t that enough? As for the Coven, well, let’s just say its definition is evolving as we speak.”

“It was her all along! No wonder she needed dirt on the Battalion brass,” Yana muttered.

Dunya remained silent for a moment, her gaze shifting away from Rada's piercing eyes. *Zakharovna wants to look weak, but she's growing stronger*, she thought. *They have no idea.*

"Now listen here," Rada chuckled, "we're gonna make 'em pay for every ounce of blood, sweat and tears." She got right up in Yana's face, her voice dropping to a dangerous murmur, "There's still room to wipe your slate clean, kid."

"How did you—?" Yana began, only to be cut off.

"But let's not get ahead of ourselves," Rada powered on, "we ain't handing out free passes here. But a little advance on your cut? That, we can swing. Consider it your ticket to a short getaway." She pushed a dinged-up yellow pill towards Yana. "And this should help. You've been lookin' like you wrestled an entire months' worth of nightshifts," she added, her tone one of mock concern.

Yana took the pill from Rada's outstretched hand and rolled it between her fingers before tucking it away safely. "You know how I appreciate free samples," Yana said.

Rada watched Yana roll the sample between her fingers. Dunya knew the flow: free dose, cleared debt, new obligation. Dependency packaged as opportunity.

Rada turned to her. "Well? What do you say?"

"We're...uh, in," Yana stuttered out quickly.

"And Dimitra?" Dunya asked.

Rada shrugged. "Dimitra's old news. They're too chicken shit to come down here themselves these days." She looked at Yana, studying her with a renewed interest. "You've got guts, though. Heard about your little number on those Battalion hypocrites—gave me a right good laugh. Unlike them, you don't shy away from getting your hands dirty. That's exactly what we need right now."

“Agreed,” Yana said, the corners of her mouth suddenly curving into a vengeful smile.

Yana’s slip-ups always end up serving her eventually. When will mine?

“Recruit whoever the hell you like, kid. Ain’t my concern who does the dirty work. All I care about is the endgame.”

“Understood... *Boss*,” she added, the title rolling off her lips with a wink.

The warehouse door groaned shut behind them. Night pressed heavier now, and something cold struck Dunya’s cheek. Then another. She touched her skin, staring at the dampness on her fingertips. Rain. She froze, stunned. *Ten years. Not once in all that time. Of course it would come now, on this night of all nights.* She almost laughed, knowing how it would end. Give it a minute, and fate would twist the drops into hail. By the lone streetlamp stood Serafim, her outline swallowed in shadow, watchful and still.

“Made it out. No scratch. Good work, Dunya.” There was a subtle lift of her brow, a slight parting of her lips, barely noticeable but enough for Dunya to read. *She expected us carved up or worse*, Dunya thought, a taut thread of suspicion winding through her.

“Looks like sea change,” Dunya said, sidestepping what could have been mistaken for praise.

“So, we’re drug dealers now?” Serafim’s tone was laced with irony, her glance sharp and evaluative.

“It wasn’t my idea,” Dunya said.

“We’re in business, that’s for sure,” Yana chimed in.

Dunya let out a soft laugh. “Let’s not count our *zats* before they hatch.”

Yana rolled her eyes and pivoted towards Serafim. “You with us?”

“Whatever you say.”

The wind picked up, rattling loose grit across the pavement, and Dunya’s gaze was drawn to Yana, who seemed captivated by the capsule she was rolling between her fingertips. With a swift, almost elegant movement, Yana popped the capsule into her mouth and swallowed. Then she pulled the hood of her jacket over her head. *About time she used it for what it’s meant for.* Then a gleam of delight sparked across her features, her spirit lifting with a playful brightness Dunya hadn’t seen in ages. Serafim watched her too, keeping quiet while Yana’s laughter carried her out of earshot.

“What’s our read on the plug?” Serafim asked.

“She’s GUPE,” Dunya said. “Tied to Yelena’s agenda.”

Serafim scoffed. “Union. Figures.” She gave a curt nod. “So not the sharpest knife in the drawer, but dangerous all the same.”

Dunya hesitated, weighing the cost. Rada’s support cut both ways. Yelena’s next batch of exo would be a gold mine, and Rada would want her share. That meant being pulled deeper into Yelena’s mess. Still, at least it would clear Yana’s debt for now.

“Careful,” Serafim said. Her gaze lingered on Yana, still spinning under the lights, then came back to Dunya. “Your friend’s green. Thinks she’s struck it rich already. The ANGELS won’t always be there to bail her out.”

Dunya kept her voice firm. “She’ll learn. She doesn’t have a choice.”

While Yana twirled, arms wide to embrace the storm, a shadow flickered at the edge of Dunya’s vision, darting across the sky. The hawk, Seryozha, cut through the dark clouds

before vanishing into the night. *Not even this weather blinds it.*

“I can’t feel my face!” Yana shouted.

“That’s the pill talking,” Serafim called back, her tone edged with reprimand as she started the engine.

A faint pulse of violet flickered across Serafim’s eye. She glanced aside, jaw easing “Xenia just pinged,” she said. “She’s aligning the graft keys and bringing the Tree’s spine to quorum.” Her tone shifted, lighter for once. “Your friends are lucky tonight.”

Dunya gave a thin smile. “Then we’ve got a window.”

Inside the trike, with the wind and ice sealed out, Dunya felt Yana’s shivers press through their shared warmth. Her laughter faded, and her head settled heavy against Dunya’s shoulder. A fleck of crimson marked her smile.

“You shouldn’t have let her take that,” Serafim said, something like concern pushing through the noise of the storm.

“She’ll be fine,” Dunya answered.

Their eyes met in the rearview mirror, Serafim’s gaze sharp but not unkind. “Your friends. They’re a handful.”

“Once we reach mine, we go *virtual*. Maria’s out there. I know she is.”

Serafim raised her voice over the storm. “You really think we’ve got time?”

Dunya looked past the mirror, fixing on the broken path ahead. She refused to let any more doubt in. “We have time now. That’s what matters. She’s out there, and I’ll keep believing until we find her.”

CHAPTER THIRTY SIX

ZAKHAROVNA

The tranquil expanse of Lake Nachikinskoye lay before her, its glassy surface reflecting the distant mountains, dense forests, and hazy blue sky above. At the water's edge, Zakharovna submerged her hand in the shallows, inhaling deeply. Each ripple that spread from her touch reminded her of Maria, of that fragmented part of her soul that she sought to mend. She watched as those ripples danced across the surface, each one a silent echo of thoughts swirling in her mind.

In this secluded forest spot on her family's ancestral lands, only she and Orkon knew of its existence. *Our last refuge.* Orkon sat nearby, eyes closed, hands resting on his knees. Clad in a black robe with rolled-up sleeves and a woven belt, his head was shaven except for a few strands of curly black hair above his ears. His gray beard formed a rough square on his chin, while raven feathers adorned his cloak, and a wolf's jawbone hung from his neck on a leather thong.

"Do you know what I see when I look at myself in the water, Orkon?"

"You see the past that you remember."

Zakharovna nodded. "But that isn't what's truly there, is it? It's merely an illusion."

"A message from the gods."

"Yes, but you know I've never been one for paganism," she conceded.

"The gods are speaking to you, Anastasia. It is crucial that you listen."

She inclined her head, memories of Orkon's counsel echoing within her—*be silent and still. Allow the gods to speak. Listen.*

"Do you remember the promise you made to me long ago, sister?" Orkon asked, though it was less a question than a reminder. "You vowed that one day you would..."

"...listen," Zakharovna finished.

Her eyes swept across the majestic mountains, sunlight embracing their peaks. She nodded, her gaze returning to Orkon. "I remember."

Her mind drifted to her childhood when she was just twelve years old. Back then, she felt an unwarranted heaviness of age, unable to envision the life that awaited her. Memories of running through the forest with Orkon, chasing dreams and a place to call home, filled her heart.

"I was only three when my father...when he chose to leave us," she said, her gaze lingering on the clear water of the lake. "My understanding of it...or the lack of it hasn't changed in all these years." Her fingers traced invisible patterns on the surface, sending ripples distorting her reflection. *Zakhar*, the name itself, was an echo that stretched longer than any quest for immortality she dared to pursue. *And yet, it is by Zakharovna that I am known to the world.*

Orkon nodded. "You were too young to understand, too innocent to bear such a wound. It was not a burden meant for you, Anastasia."

"I never understood how much my mother suffered. Her heart bore the scars of his departure until the day she died. After...after she was gone, I felt lost."

"And I did all I could to guide you, as I would my own sister, you know that."

“You became my beacon, Orkon, in the darkest of times,” Zakharovna said. “I would have lost myself if not for you. Sometimes, it helped to have a brother who was not also my twin.”

“And you, Anastasia, promised to listen,” he reminded her. “To heed the call of the gods when the time was right. A commitment born out of our mutual respect and faith.”

“Yes, I remember that promise,” she replied. “It’s been with me always. Like a tattoo on my soul.”

“And for that I am eternally grateful,” Orkon said, a tone of reverence seeping into his voice. “To the gods and to you.”

“They’re calling me.” She exhaled, casting her eyes down at her reflection once more. “I need your help.”

“What do you need?”

“I’m not exactly sure what I’m pursuing. I think it’s a god, but it could be anything at this point.” Frowning, she trailed her fingers through the water. “I can see Maria—she appears different from when we first gave her life. And every time I blink, she’s there, gazing back at me, as if awaiting rescue.”

“Perhaps that’s your purpose,” Orkon suggested. “You must free whatever has been trapped here for so long.” He crossed his legs, closing his eyes again. “You’re being summoned by the god of Death.”

“I know what you want me to do, but it’s not that simple.” Zakharovna’s frown deepened. “I won’t shut her down. That’s not who I am anymore.”

Orkon remained silent, sitting motionless on the shore behind her.

Zakharovna observed the surrounding trees, sensing the air’s vibrations intensify. The sound of her own thoughts

faded; all she could hear was a deep, soft voice emanating from everywhere and nowhere at once.

Inhaling the crisp air, she felt an odd hunger stirring within her. Orkon began chanting in hushed tones, invoking the spirit world's power. As Zakharovna stared, captivated by her reflection and something deeper—memories from before she had been thrust into this world—her hand throbbed.

It was all an illusion, she pondered—a deception born from the mushrooms she had consumed and the shaman's rituals that transported her into this surreal plane. Zakharovna fixed her gaze on Orkon. "I don't want to lose myself again."

"Everyone has a choice in this life. But you are no longer a child. You are strong, and you have changed for the better. Now, you must confront your past."

Zakharovna tuned out the world, focusing on the distant voice that beckoned from beyond her mind's tempestuous storms. Taking a steadying breath, she submerged her hand in the water. The tug away from reality was strong, yet she embraced the pull, knowing Orkon's ritual would exact its toll on her spirit whether she liked it or not.

Orkon's chants reached a fervent pitch now. Zakharovna felt herself drawn further in, a malevolent force wrapping around her psyche like a serpent's coil.

From the abyssal depths of the lake, a face ascended. Maria's face. But this was not the vibrant Maria that Zakharovna remembered. This face was eerily placid, ensnared between the realms of dream and nightmare. As Zakharovna watched, transfixed, the illusion's eyes darted with frenzied movement, seeing horrors unknown to the beholder.

Slowly, inexorably, Maria's features began to contort. Skin pulled taut across her bones, eyes protruded alarmingly, and the soft lines of her face bent into unnatural angles. Legs

morphed into writhing tentacles while her arms twisted into wings with harrowing speed. In the space before her, a cavernous maw yawned wide, bristling with needle-like teeth, each exuding a voracious hunger.

The lake's surface now roiled in fury as the monstrosity emerged, each movement calculated, predatory—closing in on her.

Horried, Zakharovna recoiled, attempting to escape the reflection. But darkness had already infiltrated, taking root. The boundaries between reality and dream blurred. The creature spoke in a low drawl, its voice echoing in her mind: *"Imposter. Destroyer. You will be stopped."*

Orkon's chants swelled, a morbid symphony beckoning further demise. Those guttural incantations reverberated through her being, an invocation that clawed at the essence of her spirit, demanding a sinister form of atonement. The beast's tentacles surged with renewed vigor, their sinister undulations encroaching ever closer, as if to swallow her whole.

"Life and death are my domain. Your theft has brought great suffering, and there is a price to be paid," the monster bellowed. Desperate for a way to escape, Zakharovna recalled Orkon's words: *"Don't fight. Listen."*

The shadowy presence loomed over her, dragged her deeper into darkness. Gathering her strength, she forced her way past the creature's grasp. *"You are not worthy of my gift,"* the nightmare continued.

She reached inward, grasping for the source of a burgeoning power that called to her, a force not hers alone but shared. A primordial song surfaced in her mind, older than time itself. The words emerged unbidden: *"Arise! Arise! Arise and fight for me, my child!"* Orkon's throat singing began to crescendo, a surge of energy washing over Zakharovna.

“Tengeriin ünertei, nomdoo dalai,” he chanted, his voice resonating with the ancient rhythms of the steppe, so many thousands of miles away.

In that moment, something dormant within her stirred, coiling like a shadow in the pit of her soul. It was ancient and dark, rising with a hunger that clawed at the edges of her mind, threatening to consume her whole. But Zakharovna didn't shy away. She let the power unfurl, feeling her mind expand as if great talons had emerged from her very thoughts. With a surge of raw energy, those invisible claws raked through the fabric of reality, seizing the creature from its reflection. The lake quivered as its lifeless tentacles were ripped free, crashing onto the surface with the force of thunder, their final screech dissolving into the wind.

The impact sent a shockwave rippling across the lake, and Zakharovna, caught in its pull, was dragged into the watery depths. Submerged and disoriented, she thrashed against the suffocating dark that engulfed her. Above, through the shifting surface, Maria's eyes pierced the gloom, locked onto hers with an unyielding intensity. The water, once a barrier, now shimmered with fractured light as Zakharovna's hand broke through, desperate for the world beyond. Maria seized it, her grip unrelenting, and with a strength that seemed to well up from some ancient source, she heaved Zakharovna from her watery grave. On the shore, Orkon lay spent, his body limp, vitality drained as if wrung dry, the energy that had once surged through him now utterly exhausted.

“You have completed the circle that was long left open,” Orkon managed, his voice a mere shadow of its former command. His eyes, usually aglow with ancient knowledge, now dimmed by the toll of their endeavor.

Water dripped from Zakhraovna's hair and clothes as she staggered to her feet, her skin still tingling from the lake's cold embrace. “Is it done then? Have we succeeded?” she asked,

her voice quivering, a mix of fear and anticipation churning within her as she awaited the outcome of their ritual.

Orkon, gathering the remnants of his strength, nodded gravely. “You’ve...gathered the shards...scattered across the ages. This wasn’t just about...rousing dormant powers,” he rasped, each word slow and heavy. “It was...about your soul. Piecing it back together...bit by bit. And Maria...she’s the final piece. You knew that...didn’t you? Why...why did you wait so long...to face her?”

Zakharovna felt the weight of her words as she spoke. “We have Maria contained—extraction from her neural net is only a matter of time... But she’s not our final objective. There’s another piece, something vital we’re missing.” She allowed the silence to swell before locking her eyes with Orkon’s.

“Imposter. Destroyer. Your theft has brought great suffering.” The whispers echoed again in her mind, relentless.

“What the gods have whispered to me, it seems they have kept from you,” Zakharovna said. “This journey, Orkon—it’s not just power I’m after. It’s understanding. I seek the intertwined threads of truth and myth. And without power, I can attain neither. My brother’s death...it set me on a path I never sought, a role I never desired.”

She took a breath, the air of command still surrounding her as she faced Orkon, yet inside, doubts began to stir like shadows at dusk. “I stand here not as a conqueror, but a seeker. I may wield his power, but it is the secrets of science, of the unknown, that command my pursuit. And it’s in that pursuit, I must confess, it feels as if I am living a life mapped out for another.”

Acknowledging Orkon’s nod of understanding, Zakharovna faced away from him, feeling the familiar push and pull of strategy even as a whirlwind of personal reflections began to stir deeper inside. *Was I ever truly fit to Chair the Board?* she

wondered silently. *And my leadership at the Research Center—was it a mantle of service, or merely a veil for my own fixations?* Her mind circled back to her seminal discovery, the supposed immortality cure. *Did my creation serve humanity, or was it my silent scream against the void?* And the hardest question of all surfaced—in a life parallel, free from tragedy and loss, *would he have surpassed me?*

She allowed her thoughts to drift into the distance and felt a sense of calm resolution wash over her. “This old body has withstood much,” she murmured, more to herself than to Orkon. One final act remained; a last sacrifice necessary on her path towards the completion she had long sought.

Zakharovna’s eyes met her reflection in the lake once more. In the dappled light dancing across the water’s surface, she saw not just the woman she had become, nor solely the woman she once was, but also a glimmer of what was yet to be discovered. *The final, missing shard of my soul.* It dawned on her, a quiet but profound truth, that this piece was tied to the legacy of her brother’s killer—the man who had made her a tyrant she knew she wasn’t. And now, in a twist of fate, it was that man’s daughter who held the key.

CHAPTER THIRTY SEVEN

VESNA

“Where the hell have you been?” Fury and worry clashed within Vesna as she glared at Zakharovna through the projection.

“Evidently not where you expected me to be.”

“You drop off grid, leave chaos in your wake, and now you stroll in like nothing’s happened?”

“A necessary disappearance. Chaos is, after all, part of the greater pattern,” Zakharovna retorted, her tone measured and cool.

“Design? There are Wolves who won’t follow me because they think I’m your puppet. And then there’s Dunya...”

Zakharovna’s gaze snapped to Vesna with penetrating sharpness. “*What* of her?” she asked, the casual tilt of her head belying an undercurrent of surprise that Vesna instinctively recognized.

“She was hurt. Badly.”

“The cost of war. We each pay it in turn.”

“And what have you paid, exactly?” Vesna leaned in. “While we’re bleeding out here, you’re playing the shadows.”

“With stakes so high, sometimes the shadows are where we see clearest,” Zakharovna replied. “You think so linearly, Vesna. The battlefield isn’t just blood and ground.”

Vesna’s jaw tightened. “And yet, it’s the blood and ground that’s remembered, not the whispers in the dark.”

Zakharovna smiled thinly. “History is written by the victors, dear Vesna—remembered as they wish it to be.”

“Enjoying your vacation?” Vesna asked with heavy sarcasm, her eyebrows raised as she took in the rustic surroundings of Zakharovna’s cabin through the hardlight.

Zakharovna relaxed her posture, drawing lazily from her pipe. A wisp of smoke curled upwards. “The Evens have been hospitable,” she remarked dryly. “Their tobacco is...enriching.”

“Must be nice.” Vesna’s words came out colder than the air she felt through the projection. “While you’ve been getting high on generosity, I’ve been knee-deep in the shitstorm you left behind, running the damn city.”

Zakharovna exhaled a cloud of smoke, watching it dissipate before replying, “The path to truth is often hazy, Vesna. The clarity you seek doesn’t come without a little...smokescreen.” Her voice was as smooth as the tobacco’s synthesized aroma.

Vesna snorted. “And what ‘truths’ are so important that you need to toke up, Matron? Getting high off memories now?”

“Just as you have sought your own truths, your own soul shards, so have I,” Zakharovna said, leaning forward, her expression growing more serious now. “I’ve pieced together fragments of my past, drawn from a multitude of memories lingering to my old soul. I am preparing for what comes next.”

“And what’s next? Another game of chess with people’s lives?” Vesna challenged.

“No. No games this time. Yelena has become a thorn too deep in our side. She must be clipped—no trim this time. You see, while she has been consorting with her own shadows and embers, she’s grown distracted. She managed to infiltrate all her enemies—yourself included I might add—all but her most critical one: *Me*.”

“While she burns herself out, her resources dwindle, and my influence only expands. And Vesna, the risks you’ve taken,

as steep as they are, have been necessary. They're what's led us here, to the brink of reclaiming our city. Tatyana is gone, swept away by the very trap we laid for our dear Director—a diversion, and her 'pup', your former rival's green younger sister, no less, has fled with the disgraced Mariner. Her ships have carried them both into the vast embrace of the sea, spinning Yelena's wheels on targets that held no real threat. And now, in this war of attrition, Yelena perceives us as weakened, easy prey, yet she remains unwittingly exposed. This is how we will win—through cunning, not brute strength."

"So, I'm your executioner now?"

"It has to be you," Zakharovna pressed, "You have the position, the skills...and quite frankly, my old bones can't get as close. It's time, Vesna. You need to prepare."

Vesna hesitated, her anger gradually ebbing away as the logic of Zakharovna's oldest plan finally came to a head. Yelena's elimination, which had initially seemed a crude point of vengeance, now appeared as a calculated move. "And afterward?"

"Once this is over, Yelena's 'departure' will pave the way for *you*. Her seat on the Board and her party alike will fade into oblivion, marking the University's sole jurisdiction. Consider it the ultimate rite of passage in your Ascension."

This is more than a mission; it's a turning point. "When?" she asked.

"Soon," Zakharovna said. "I'll gather the details. Be ready to strike, with precision—and understand, Vesna, you're not just carving out a moment in history. You are chiseling your own destiny into the soul of the Syndicate and beyond."

Zakharovna added, "...But before we set our sights on our final victory, your unique dexterity is required for a delicate endeavor. While Yelena busies herself with her distractions,

we shall seize this window of opportunity. You will infiltrate the Arkyv and extract someone who has managed to slip through my fingers for too long. Can I rely on your deft touch to bring in our wayward toy?”

“Maria?” Vesna’s eyes narrowed. “I thought we had just secured her.”

Zakharovna’s lips twitched with the hint of a sardonic smile. “Yes, a trifling matter that was. Encryption keys exchanged in the wake of Yelena’s ‘Ascension’; she thought she could claim my prisoner, but I won’t allow it—I have reclaimed those keys. We only need to break her free now. I must absorb her...insights.”

Great, a heads-up would’ve been nice—feels like I just slapped the cuffs on, Vesna thought with a flash of annoyance. “Very well.”

Later, in the silence of her quarters, Vesna struggled to shake off the weight of unrest. As she paced, her thoughts obsessively circled back to Dunya—the woman who had been at the core of endless late-night calls, urgent messages, and strategic missions. Now, the irony was complete; it was Vesna who constantly checked her devices. She got nothing back. She thought of Dunya in the hospital, recovering from her injuries, bad news turning to good and vice-versa.

The coma had felt endless, a suspended reality with no promise of an end, until whispers of Dunya’s sudden flight from the Prime Infirmary pierced the silence. Vesna could barely believe the news. *Could that staffer have played a part? I should have grilled her more.*

The urge to probe Zakharovna had been there, yet the risk of her boss’s recent agitation, especially at any mention of Dunya, stayed her tongue. *Dunya’s always had a knack for pulling through on her own.*

The stillness of the room was pierced by a knock at the door, and when it swung open, Nadya was standing in its frame, carrying a tray covered in...real food. On it were pomegranates and peaches, fruits with vibrant flushes of color that Vesna hadn't savored in ages, likely cultivated in the University's biomes. The soft light of the room played over Nadya's features, accentuating the diligence in her posture. Her doctor's attire, crisp and white, contrasted against the warm hue of her skin. Brown hair was pulled back neatly, framing her face, while her glasses caught the amber glow pouring in from the windows.

"I brought you something fresh, might be a change from the usual rations," she said. "And to check on you, of course. The city's been...on edge."

Vesna managed a half-hearted smirk. "Holed up like a fugitive. Can't remember the last time I saw some real action, with the city on lockdown, Yelena's goons on the prowl..." She trailed off, her gaze landing on the food with a mix of appreciation and resignation.

"I hear you're preparing for a dive," Nadya said, her voice smooth, professional yet with a hint of personal care as she crossed the room to place the tray on a table nearby.

Vesna nodded in thanks, the mix of Nadya's pragmatism and understated elegance leaving an impression she didn't quite know what to do with. It was a distraction, however mild, in a string of heavy demands and darker thoughts.

"You've been through the protocol enough by now," Nadya said, her gaze intently fixed on Vesna. Feeling the scrutiny, Vesna understood the unvoiced question hanging between them. Nadya was searching for something in her expression, a telltale sign of either strain or fortitude, Vesna could tell. "Have you found an anchor memory that works for you? One

that keeps the serum in harmony with your cells?” Nadya asked.

Vesna paused, considering the intimacy of the question. The serum’s reliance on the dance of memory and command was something she wrestled with, reluctant to admit any struggle after so many hopeful starts. The triumph she had sought in Arkadya, and the vengeance she once thought she would savor, felt hollow—snuffed out by the machinations of politics, and made all the more bitter by her callous decision to abandon Dunya in her greatest hour of need. “Still searching,” she said, her voice dropping a fraction. She watched Nadya, this woman who had been through the same trials in her own way and wondered at her ease.

Nadya appreciated the honesty, Vesna gathered.

“Finding that anchor...it’s personal, isn’t it?” Nadya asked, “For me, it’s the first time I performed a successful surgery. The patient’s gratitude, the feeling of saving a life—it grounds me... In this city, being one of the few young ones... It’s hard to find others who truly understand.”

Never pegged her as the type to feel lonely in a sea of fading faces. Here was Nadya, seemingly so composed, sharing a common ache—the isolation that came with their respective battles against time. Vesna felt the beguiling pull of the serum’s call for a grounding point, and in Nadya’s words, she glimpsed the potential for finding her own—perhaps a recollection not of triumph, but of a rare moment of peace. It was not the serene shores of Ozero Nalychevo with Dunya, she realized, but something just as pure—a moment from her childhood, perhaps.

Vesna couldn’t help but smile at the memory of raucous laughter and playful tussles with her older brothers after they had returned from long days scavenging for food in a world where the lights never came back on. In their cramped

Moscow flat, every scar they bore told a story of survival. Even then, amid the chaos that had nearly consumed their world, they found strength in each other, refusing to let the darkness take everything.

This memory would have to suffice; it was all she had, and time wasn't on her side. With her final trial looming—a crucible that would determine the city's fate—Vesna recognized the urgency of harnessing her past, her best weapon. There was a kind of clarity in understanding that no one else could wield it for her, no one else could pull the trigger on the decisions that lay ahead.

CHAPTER THIRTY EIGHT

MARIA

Cold seeped through the thin sheet and settled in her bones. The mattress wasn't hers. Its weight and give felt off, a slick dampness clinging to the fabric and turning her stomach. The smell rose next, sour and heavy, like something left to steep in its own humidity.

She drew a breath, expecting the familiar quiet hum of orientation to meet her. Nothing answered. Only the rasp of air through lungs that felt borrowed, and a body she wasn't sure would hold her if she tried to sit up.

She tried again, louder. "Help!"

The word fell flat in the stale air, swallowed by a room that didn't bother to answer.

Maria teetered to her feet, her senses absorbing the room's grandeur. Velvet armchairs stood their guard, fortress-like, before a fireplace boasting only anemic, smudged flames. Opulence dripped from each corner, an ostentatious mélange of gold-rimmed frames and vibrant, garish portraits. Faces stared back at her, each a haunting echo of past lives, their iterations spanning what felt like eons in this timeless realm.

She approached the windows. They should have been her escape, her connection to the world beyond this gilded prison. But the glass refused to budge under her frantic efforts. Panic threaded its way through her mind as the truth set in. The windows were not really there.

She caught a glimpse of her reflection in the glass, and the image unsettled her. An aged, weary face with short white hair stared back, framing sharp blue eyes and a square jaw. The lines etched on her skin spoke volumes of burdens she'd never known. The weight of it all threatened to crush her, but she

forced herself to breathe, to think, meeting the gaze of a face that looked like it had weathered countless storms.

A memory, fierce and unasked for, pierced her thoughts like a jagged shard of glass. It carried the haunting echo of her last breath, the bone-crushing pressure as her chest folded inward, and the slow engulfment of her consciousness by an inky abyss. Then, as though time and space had taken a mystifying turn, she found herself roused within the confines of this chamber, encased in an alien shell that bore her name yet felt it belonged to somebody else.

How long had she been here? Two weeks, maybe? Time had become slippery, elusive in this place. The only certainty was the despair that had taken firm root in her heart.

As she looked down at her hands, etched with the passage of simulated years, she found herself wondering. What if her past life—where she had been a synthetic marvel, impervious to the frailties of flesh—had been merely an illusion? What if this unreality, marked by time and wear, was all that had ever truly existed? And what if her recent encounter in the Arkyv was just another deception, a trick concocted by her captors to disorient and manipulate her? Nobody escaped Zakharovna's wrath. Tatyana Romanova was dead, and the thought sent a chilling shiver down her spine.

"Zakharovna," she hissed, the name a curse on her lips. Once, Zakharovna had been the pivot of Maria's loyalty, the central point of her unwavering devotion. Yet, Zakharovna had offered only disdain, casting her into an endless cycle of resurrection. To be a slave, condemned to rebirth in manifold vessels for each new task. And the objective? The eternal perpetuation of *her*. But what worth could there be in an endless soul, divorced from the tangible form that others knew?

Maria had been a tool to Zakharovna, discarded and replaced with mechanical indifference. In that bleak understanding, the frayed edges of her psyche began to unravel.

“Help!” Her voice echoed through the chamber once more. “Someone, please!”

Fury and sorrow warred within her, tears carving their way down her cheeks. It wasn’t death that tormented her, but the relentless cycle of living, dying, and being forced to return *again and again* that weighed her down. Each reincarnation stripped away a part of her she couldn’t quite recall, and with each new life, she felt further trapped in a never-ending maze where the exit seemed forever out of reach.

She released a weary breath. In the embrace of darkness, Maria lingered at the precipice, a quantum existence, both alive and dead, awaiting the resolution of her paradox.

Her thoughts inevitably drifted to Dunya. Her confidant, her ally, now absent in her hour of need. Maria recalled the countless days they had spent together, immersed in *virtual*, especially at the Night Café. That digital haven, with its ambient glow and the soft murmur of coded conversations and crypto-croissants, had been their sanctuary, a place where plans were hatched and secrets shared. The memories of those moments, vivid and bittersweet, tugged at her heart.

I betrayed you, Dunya. I used you, manipulated you for my own ends, to reach her. Forgive me. I’m sorry.

The specter of other transgressions materialized before her. Memories of Anna and the hapless junkies Maria had ensnared flooded her mind, their thoughts ravaged in pursuit of a just cause that had devolved into something twisted. Innocents, casualties of a war gone awry. Yet, she couldn’t shoulder the blame entirely. Zakharovna had been harvesting souls long before Maria’s inception.

A slow wash of unwelcome shame rose in her before a knock snapped her out of it. She stiffened, unsure if the sound had come from the room or from her own drifting mind.

The door groaned open to reveal a figure, statuesque and poised. Amethyst hair framed her face, and a measured smile played on ruby lips. There she stood in pristine white military gear, ethereal in its neatness, almost luminescent against the dim backdrop. The uniform, detailed with intricate lace along the hem and cuffs, hugged her form softly, enhancing an authoritative yet graceful silhouette.

“Vesna?” The name tumbled from Maria’s lips. Moments ago, she’d been calling out, her voice echoing with desperation. Now, as Vesna stood before her, uncertainty swirled within her. “Did you come to take me to Zakharovna? What’s left for me out there, other than an endless cycle of suffering?”

“Endless is not a luxury you can afford right now,” Vesna said, her tone firm.

“Endless is all I know.”

“Listen, Maria. I’m here to help.”

“Help with what?”

“You were fighting on the wrong side.”

“The wrong side?” Maria shot back. “If you wanted me on your side, you wouldn’t have locked me up. Why are you here?”

“The city burns, but not by Zakharovna’s hand,” Vesna said. “She fights to stem the tide, to contain the real inferno. Yelena controls the Syndicate now. You must see the larger game. The boss has her designs, and they’re not without reason.”

Maria's skepticism clawed at this, a silent scoff at the idea. Was this true? *Is Zakharovna's ambition more than a power play?* "How do I know you're not messing with me, again?" she asked. Her head shook almost reflexively, words spilling out in a torrent of frustration. "I just...can't... It's too much. All these lies, endless missions, and constant puzzles."

"You were the finest among us, Maria. And you still are. I'm here to bring you back into the fold."

Maria felt a silent pull, a spectral tether drawing her onward. The hallway stretched before her, an unending expanse. Escape seemed both necessary and futile. "I can't do this," she whispered.

"There's only death for you here," Vesna said. "Permanent this time."

The words hung heavy in the cramped space. Maria took a moment to reflect on them. "Permanent?"

"Yes, permanent. They want you erased. A sentence of oblivion, with no return."

Throughout her life, death had always seemed like a revolving door, a brief respite before the next awakening. But she slowly came to realize that the idea of an ending that lasted forever was more terrifying than anything she'd ever considered.

"Permanent," Maria heard herself echo.

"Where there are embers, there's always a chance to rebuild. We offer you a haven, far from those who wish to destroy you. We're extending our hand, Maria, just as we always have. All you need to do is reach out and take it."

For a moment, Maria could almost see the old Vesna, her colleague from the force. Memories flooded back of the days they'd been part of the same unit, carrying out Arkadya's iron will with unwavering loyalty and precision under the banner

of the Black Wolves. Together, they'd forged a path through darkness, but in doing so, they'd become monsters in their own right.

"Look, the old guard has fallen. Tatyana's gone, Yelena has seized control, and the Hive has razed the city, obliterating any trace of rebellion. We no longer hold you, and we can't stop Yelena from doing as she pleases, if you don't come now. Time is running out."

Maria fell silent, her eyes flitting between Vesna's extended hand and the woman's unflinching gaze. She felt a twinge of something. Fear, hope, perhaps a mixture of both. "You really expect me to just trust you?"

"It's not about trust. It's about survival. Your choice."

Maria drew a shaky breath. In that moment, words that she barely remembered but knew were true whispered through her mind, words she thought belonged to Tatyana or perhaps just a figment of her own imagination: *"No matter what you face, don't look back."* Holding onto that thought, she nodded. "I'll hear you out."

Vesna moved ahead with sharp certainty, her boots striking the metal floor in a rhythm Maria struggled to match. The corridor narrowed around her, walls pressing closer with each step. Yellow emergency lights flickered overhead, stretching her shadow into a gaunt specter at her feet. Was this the path to freedom, or to something worse? She couldn't tell, and the not-knowing nagged at her every breath.

The door to Room 9 sighed open. Vesna motioned for Maria to enter, and with one last flicker of uncertainty, she stepped across the gap.

"No matter what you face, don't look back."

Her vision flared, a brilliant light washing over her, before fading to reveal what lay ahead.

Before her stretched a sacred space, a garden. A verdant oasis in the heart of a dying land. The parched earth bore the marks of a cruel drought, and an iron fence had surrendered to the advance of rust. Above her, an inky black sky loomed, heavy with brewing storm clouds. Yet, in the decay, the garden throbbed with life. Colors vibrated with an alien intensity, the wind whispered secrets to the leaves, and a single ray of sunlight broke through the cloud cover, blessing the ground below with its warm touch.

For a moment, Maria was caught in a strange calm, a welcome reprieve from her recent confinement and the chaos of the world outside.

“Welcome to our sanctuary,” Zakharovna said, her lips curling into a smile as she gestured towards the lush greenery. “In this place, the rose is king. Its petals hold the essence of life.”

Maria found herself enveloped in a tangle of awe and unease as she observed Zakharovna. The old crone’s bearing had not changed. Even now, draped in a flowing silk gown, she held the room in the palm of her hand. A sulfur rose nestled in her hair caught Maria’s eye, adding a regal touch that seemed to elevate Zakharovna’s already stately demeanor. There she stood, an embodiment of a queen, poised, ruling over her domain with an iron will cloaked in the soft allure of velvet.

In that instant, Maria was overwhelmed by a tide of unanswered questions. How had Zakharovna created this place? Why was she brought here? What was her own destiny in all of this?

Zakharovna’s laughter echoed, blending with the gentle rustling of leaves. “Even in the face of desolation, life finds a way.”

Maria found herself drifting away from that voice, her feet leading her aimlessly. She became absorbed in the tranquility

of the unspoiled wilderness surrounding her. Nature's vibrant beauty against her recent memories of cold, unyielding cell walls and the oppressive weight of isolation seemed to momentarily lift the burden from her spirit. Here, with the liberty to wander, to inhale the fresh, untainted air, she experienced a fleeting but profound sense of peace.

As she lingered in this rare state of tranquility, Maria's attention was gently drawn away by the presence of another. She became aware of Vesna's gaze resting on her. In Vesna's eyes, Maria thought she could see reflections of her own turmoil. Was it concern she saw, or perhaps recognition of their shared past? A past where, like herself, Vesna too had been a tool in the hands of others. *Once a Wolf, always a Wolf.*

Faintly, almost out of earshot, Maria heard Zakharovna's directive, "Off you go now, time is of the essence. Thank you for your service once again, my dear."

As the words faded, Vesna turned and began to trace her way through the garden, moving gracefully toward the door through which they had both entered. She crossed the threshold, and in an instant, the door flashed into a brilliant beam of light, shrinking rapidly as it closed. With a final shimmer, it disappeared, leaving Maria alone with Zakharovna in the garden's embrace.

Zakharovna approached. "Maria, I know your path ahead seems shrouded in mist but believe that I am there with you."

Maria's eyes locked with those of her maker.

A shadow seemed to pass over Zakharovna's face, her expression turning somber. "How I wish I could offer you a faultless existence—an eternal one. But even as I sculpted this sanctuary, my reach remains finite. I have managed only to sustain you, guiding you from afar."

"The mindgrafts—they were all smoke screens," Zakharovna continued, "Initially, even Vesna was in the dark."

I feared losing you in the vast, unpredictable expanse of cyberspace, or worse, a physical malfunction that could result in your eternal absence.”

“So, I set the snares, using the contracts of that fiery pheasant of yours. I lured you in, ensuring you remained under my watch. It was a shadow play, a necessary deception. You are indispensable, an essential piece in the intricate pattern I’ve envisioned. My approach might have been deceptive, but its roots lay in protection.”

“You’ve been pulling the strings all along, haven’t you?” Maria said, “With Dunya, with the ANGELS—every orchestrated move. I know that now; that much is certain. But I have to ask, why me? Who am I, *really*? How did you make me? My memories, they can’t *all* be mine, can they? And who... Who did you kill to give me life? How many souls have perished to keep me going?”

“In time, all will become clear, Maria. There are layers here, complexities that may seem bewildering now. Each step, each decision has its purpose, and you are integral to it, more than you realize. In the tapestry of forever, our choices weave the pattern of ages. Your path is entwined with the very fabric of this reality, and in due time, the significance of it all will unveil itself to you.”

Maria struggled to steady her voice. “You have these grand visions, but at what cost are you willing to manifest them? Tatyana wasn’t just another piece in your game. She was a friend. And you...threw her for a loop. You turned the whole city against her.”

“Tatyana,” Zakharovna murmured. “She was more than just a friend to both of us, wasn’t she? Once, we shared not just ideals, but dreams. Yet, paths diverge, and hers led her away from the vision we had nurtured together.”

Zakharovna paused, her gaze distant as if lost in memories. “Her choices, what she called her ‘betrayal,’ they weren’t just personal. They endangered the very foundation of our collective ambition. What we had painstakingly built was at risk because of her actions.”

“You ended her life because it suited you. Sounds like you made yourself judge and executioner.”

“This isn’t about me playing God. It’s about forging a path for us all, a future where flesh and machine unite seamlessly. Think of the possibilities, Maria. You, of all people, know the rewards such advances offer. Imagine extending these benefits beyond ourselves—healing the frail bodies of Gred, liberating countless souls trapped in their aging forms. We’re on the cusp of creating a future that’s not only brighter but also more equitable. This is about the greater good, a legacy that will benefit us and generations to follow.”

“Tatyana saw where this could lead. Was she really wrong? Once we start reshaping life itself, we’re stepping into risks we barely grasp.” Maria said.

“A life without risks is a life unfulfilled,” Zakharovna replied. “Indecision itself poses its own existential threats. And as for Tatyana, she clung stubbornly to the old ways, that old goat. In the end, she reaped what she sowed.”

“Tatyana was my *friend*. Every step you take fractures a thousand innocent lives. And for what? Your magnum opus?”

Maria’s voice broke, the frustration she felt spilling over. “I can’t accept this... Your rationalizing, your justifications. I can’t bear it anymore.” In a choked whisper, she said, “No more lies. No more half-truths.”

Maria turned and hastily retreated through the garden’s maze. Each step was a bid for distance, for a moment away from the weight of Zakharovna’s promises and the all-consuming reality they unveiled.

But Maria could still faintly hear those words trail behind her. *"Please, trust me."*

Maria spun around, her breaths uneven and ragged, a whirlpool of emotions. "Just leave me alone. I can't go back," she said, her eyes stubbornly fixed on the ground, unwilling to meet her maker's gaze.

Zakharovna's hands enveloped Maria's trembling ones. Startled by the contact, Maria's first instinct was to pull away, but a conflicting impulse rooted her to the spot.

"It's okay," Zakharovna's voice attempted to soothe, but to Maria, the words felt hollow, disconnected from the storm raging within.

Jerking her hands free, Maria recoiled and stumbled backward, halted only by the rough bark of a tree pressing uncomfortably against her spine. "No, I don't want any part of this. Leave me alone."

"We are family," Zakharovna said.

In her dazed state, Maria's mind reeled at the words. The notion of 'family', coming from Zakharovna at this moment, felt surreal, almost mocking in its simplicity.

Trapped against the trunk of the tree, Maria felt the weight of Zakharovna's looming presence. The old crone was like a gatekeeper standing at the threshold of a doorway that promised both eternal life and endless suffering. Maria's heart raced as she confronted the paradox before her.

"For a while there, I had a life, friends and memories that were *mine*," Maria managed to say. "But you... You stripped me of that life, my identity... My soul."

Tears welled up in Zakharovna's eyes. "So much doubt..."

"I just don't understand. What do you *want* from me?"

"Maria Nikolayevna Zakharova, we are irrevocably linked."

Maria recoiled from Zakharovna's touch. "I'm not yours—I'll never be yours."

"Yet here you are."

Maria looked down. The body she'd woke up in felt even more fragile now, a shell draped in white fabric, pale and weightless like a ghost.

She lifted her gaze to the towering tree, its once-strong branches broken and decayed, standing like a grim relic in the garden's lushness. The ground below it was barren now, stripped of life's nurturing touch.

She was terrified of what came next.

Descending to the fallow ground, Maria sought solace in the tree's remnant shade. "*No matter what you face, don't look back,*" she recalled from some distant time and place.

And there, at her feet, lay the yellow flower, once a vibrant crown upon her head, now a fallen emblem of all that had been. Her hands trembled as she picked it up.

"Thank you, Maria," she said, for Maria, as she had been known, existed only in the echoes of time. *You were always my favorite creation,* thought Zakharovna. *You were always the best among us.*

CHAPTER THIRTY NINE

VESNA

The infantry advanced in formation, each synchronized step reflecting their discipline. A tide of gray uniforms and faceless black visors surged forward, cleaving the crowd gathered outside the rally. As the people's exuberant cries overpowered the speaker's voice, every soldier maintained their stature, embodying the Syndicate's new military and its claim to power.

Soldiers or drones? Vesna wondered.

From her vantage point at the edge of the crowd, she studied the precise, mechanical flow of their ranks, a sharp contrast to the restless energy of the gathered spectators. At her flank, Marfa and Gala stood ready. Even behind their scarves, their eyes remained vivid and focused.

The chill winds that usually swept through the plaza were, for a moment, less biting than the fear moving through the crowd. A different kind of warmth held them together, not from sun or shelter, but from the rumors that drew the huddled masses close. They leaned into one another for comfort, bracing against the cold and against the growing dread of the Coven's shadow over their lives.

Casually, Vesna's hand lingered near the concealed titanium alloy pistol under her coat. In her other hand, a half-smoked cigarette dangled, a potential distraction in her arsenal. By her feet, an unremarkable briefcase sat, its contents crucial to her mission. Inside, the disassembled parts of a sniper rifle lay hidden, poised to be swiftly put together and deployed in the imminent operation that awaited her.

Vesna's eyes locked onto the stage, where Director Yelena Petrova commanded the attention of the expectant crowd. Beside Yelena stood Valentina Vinogradova, holding the Pra Matron's mantle for now, though for the moment all eyes were on the elder. Yelena's face was stern, the black visor masking the upper half but leaving her eyes exposed. Her attire exuded authority: a gray jacket and pants, accentuated by a black belt and gleaming obsidian boots. Her pale red hair was pulled back into a tight ponytail, and in the sunlight, her eyes seemed to shift, casting a hue that was colder and more unforgiving than Vesna remembered.

Yelena's voice rose, strong and clear, as Vesna drew nearer. "In the heart of progress, we find the essence of our true democracy," the Director said, her gaze sweeping over the crowd. "The Syndicate isn't just a government; it's the architect of a future where every voice, every action, contributes to our shared progress. *No, progress isn't some far-flung dream!* It's our collective duty, our shared destiny. For the Hive, each sacrifice we make is a vital step towards a brighter tomorrow. Remember, democracy isn't just a legacy handed down to us; it's a monument we build together, one decision, one commitment at a time."

Yelena's speech carried through the plaza. As the first column approached, rifles lifted in a show of precision, a shift moved through the crowd. The earlier tension softened into something more collective, a cautious blending of unease and shared purpose. Little by little, people pressed closer around the advancing unit. Their voices rose, tentative at first, then steadier, building into a unified chorus. Together, they sang the party's anthem in the old language:

*CELEBRATED DAUGHTERS OF KAMCHATKAN ANCESTRY!
TEACHER AND PEASANT LEADERS ALIKE!*

ALL KAMCHATKANS GLORY YOUR NAME!

THE HOMELAND IS PROUD OF YOU!

THE KAMCHATKAN PEASANT PARTY OF THE PETROVA SISTERS!

PETROVSKAYA IS THE HEART AND SOUL OF THE KAMCHATKAN PEOPLE!

The sudden crack of gunfire startled Vesna, and she caught sight of smoke billowing from the rifles of a squadron as they adopted their ceremonial stance. She turned away from the stage, taking a final drag on her cigarette before flicking it away. The crowd's voices swelled into a chant, calling out, "Yelena! Yelena!"

Yelena's hand cut through the air in a sweeping gesture as she reached the climax of her speech. "I believe that the Syndicate has lost its purpose," she declared with a fiery intensity. "It's time for change; time to rid ourselves of the farcical masquerade that we've been fed. To think of Gred as just some 'private company'," she spat, "we need a transformation—we need to turn this opaque monstrosity into a vehicle for all. We will expand Gred's reach across the planet, redirect its resources towards peaceful exploration and discovery. Together, we can forge a society better than it has ever been before."

Vesna's mouth hardened into a scowl as she listened to Yelena's audacious proposal, which blatantly defied the Charter. The current chaos had dispersed the Board and sent the Admiralty fleeing, leaving only a fractured response from Zakharovna and Vesna's own Black Wolves. Half of whom had already defected to Yelena's side. Yelena, seizing the opportunity presented by the Syndicate's waning influence, stood now as its usurper, resolute, her eyes burning with ambition. Vesna felt no uncertainty about her next course of

action. Her training had prepared her for this pivotal moment. Her hands subtly moved towards the briefcase at her feet. The path was clear: a single, well-placed bullet would halt Yelena's dangerous ascent and realign the precarious balance of power.

Politicians. Always so sure of themselves, even when every word is a lie, Vesna thought. Her fingers brushed against the pistol in her jacket, reassured by its presence as she sidestepped and examined the soldiers standing before the stage.

"My fellow citizens," Yelena's voice rang out once more with fervor. "We face an uncertain future, and the Coven is poised to exploit any weakness. They will dispatch their assassins to harm our people and raze our accomplishments. But we won't let them triumph. United in our resolve to protect our people and way of life, we'll defy the shadows of fear and doubt. We will confront our challenges with courage and tenacity, and we *will* prevail."

Vesna's team grew restless, their hands inching towards concealed weapons, loaded and primed. Their eyes betrayed their desires; they loathed Yelena too. "It's time," Vesna murmured, securing her briefcase. She paused for a moment, her gaze drifting upwards to a particular window in the hotel across from the plaza. The angle, the height, the view. It was perfect. *From there, I'll have the clear shot I need.*

Assessing the Hive's infantry with a frigid, calculating gaze, Vesna evaluated the likelihood of success against failure. The Syndicate was a force to be reckoned with, but not invulnerable. "There's no turning back once these fools spark a civil war," Vesna whispered to her team. "I, for one, intend to do everything in my power to prevent that."

Gala answered, "You know that as well as I do."

"Let's stay sharp," said Marfa.

Vesna nodded, hoisting her suitcase. She weaved her way through the crowd. As Marfa veered off in her own direction, Gala remained closely behind her.

With every step, Vesna's gaze stayed forward, keenly aware that focus was their best defense against the ever-present threat of a watchful soldier ready to act.

Yelena continued her speech, her voice booming from behind. "People," she shouted. "Your beloved Tatyana was tragically slain by malevolent witches, but her memory endures. I stand before you as your new leader, the Pra Matron Chair you've gathered to see and hear. Let's extend a heartfelt welcome to this new era!"

Vesna stopped and turned around, feeling a wave of shock as Yelena triumphantly raised her fist. The crowd hushed, a quiet that enveloped the space and hinted at their focused attention. Cold dread clenched Vesna's heart as a flurry of thoughts raced through her mind: *Why would Yelena risk so much? Is she really going to seize total power now? Disband the other parties?* Vesna didn't blink at Tatyana's death; it was the predictable end for someone who misplaced her trust. Yet, misjudging Yelena's ambition had always been dangerous. *It doesn't matter. She'll be dead soon.*

Vesna's eyes locked with Yelena's across the sea of people, a momentary connection that sent a jolt through her. She felt a sudden, almost irresistible urge to pull the trigger right there. But she relented to her discipline.

Tightening her jacket's hood, she blended among the encircling soldiers, who were focused on the crowd, guns drawn, primed to defend their matron. Vesna moved between them, her presence just another shadow among the vigilant guardians. Gala followed closely behind. They crossed the street bordering the main plaza and entered the dilapidated ruins of the old Hotel Kamchatsky.

The lobby opened into a gutted shell of cracked tiles and fallen plaster. The main stairwell waited just ahead, open to the lobby exactly where their briefing had placed it, its railings bent but still intact. Gala slipped past her without a word. Vesna heard her brisk ascent echo up the concrete well, the light cadence only possible with exovegeta holding Gala's old frame together. Vesna shook her head once, wondering what the boosters had cost them in the long run.

Vesna followed, climbing the decaying stairwell, her steps quick and determined. The political machinations wrought by Yelena and her Hive weighed heavily on her mind: many of her benefactors at the University now lay in shambles, the Battalion forced into a humiliating retreat, and her once-devoted Black Wolves torn between divided loyalties. *Lucky*, she mused to herself, *most of them are now bolstering Hive union buildings across the city, far from their new headquarters*. And despite gaining strength, Zakharovna still lurked in the shadows. Vesna's only defense against Yelena's wrath consisted of those few Black Wolf units who remained steadfast in their loyalty, and the handful of nearby University marine brigades, strategically positioned yet sparse in number.

With each flight of stairs she ascended, Vesna's thoughts lingered on Yelena's penchant to sway the masses with nothing but her words and vision. The idea of ending Yelena's manipulative charisma, of silencing her for good, fueled her skyward. Vesna wondered what Yelena's brains would look like dashed across the stage.

Reaching the eleventh floor, Vesna found it completely deserted. Her confidence surged as she stepped through the door, quickly moving to the window that offered a strategic view of the stage below. Swiftly, she positioned a chair to gain an optimal vantage point. There, at the edge of the vacant room, Vesna's set up her sniping position, ready to execute.

Ensuring the window was unobstructed, she tightened her grip on her rifle. With her eye against the scope, she aimed at Yelena's heart, the distant cheers and applause fueling her ambition. Vesna adjusted her sights until the pocket square in Yelena's left breast pocket filled her vision. Inhaling deeply, her aim steady, she whispered into her comms, "Spotter, you good?"

"Ready," replied Gala from a few floors above.

Eyes narrowing, Vesna took steady aim and positioned herself comfortably, awaiting the perfect moment to fire.

"Parallax," Gala said. "Wind's in our favor."

"Ready to receive ballistics. I'll adjust," Vesna responded. She took a deep breath, readying for the weapon's recoil. Anticipation made her arms tremble, but she fought to remain calm and composed. Her finger hovered near the trigger, poised to fire, keenly aware the wind could shift anytime, disrupting her aim.

"Final adjustments. We're live in ten."

Vesna drew a deep breath, steadying her rifle as the countdown began in her earpiece. "Ten." The number pulsed through her. "Nine." She adjusted her position, the scope's reticle hovering over Yelena's heart with precision. "Eight." Her focus narrowed, pushing away the clamor of the bustling plaza below.

"Seven." A thread of tension wormed its way into her thoughts, an itch at the edge of her awareness. "Six." Vesna willed it away, memories of past failures fighting to break through the wall of confidence she had meticulously built around her mission. "Five." The discomfort twisted deeper, burrowing into the crevices of her resolve. "Four."

Pull it together, Vesna. "Three." Her own voice echoed back at her in a silent plea. Pain, an uninvited adversary, began to

dance at the edges of her sight. “Two.” It rose suddenly, a vicious intruder brandishing agony like a weapon against the ramparts of her mind.

Then, in a moment suspended between will and chaos, a deafening crack shattered the silence.

Vesna’s intentions shattered with the crack; the shot, with cruel irony, betrayed her. Far from its intended mark, the bullet found Valentina instead. The young woman’s silhouette crumpled in Vesna’s sights as pain surged through her, blinding and absolute.

In the earpiece, Gala’s voice was a sharp intrusion, “Vesna! What happened?”

Chaos erupted in the crowd. Hive security forces surged forward in a frantic bid to secure the area. Vesna, grappling with the throbbing in her head and the shock of her grave error, hissed a curse under her breath, “Damn it!”

As the initial confusion settled, Vesna’s instincts kicked in. The faint whistle of something tearing through the air caught her attention. Within heartbeats, that sound swelled into the fearsome roar of a rocket-propelled grenade. Time dilated for Vesna as she tracked the grenade’s lethal arc toward her perch. She had only moments, seconds that hung suspended before the imminent collision. Then, the world erupted around her. The blast sent a shockwave that threw her backward, with splinters of wood and shards of glass dancing violently through the space where she’d just stood. Her senses were overwhelmed by both the screams piercing her earpiece and the pandemonium unfolding below.

With caution dictating her every move, Vesna crawled through the remnants of the shattered window. Glass crunched underfoot as she peered toward the stage. There, Yelena lay exposed on the ground. The Black Wolf’s turncoat

guards had found shelter, their weapons spitting defiance, aimed in the direction of Gala's distraction.

"Any other tricks, team?" Vesna shouted.

"I'm planting an incendiary device," Marfa's voice crackled over the comms, steady despite the unfolding chaos. "Detonation in forty. If you can't get Yelena, at least we'll stir the pot."

Acknowledging the narrow window of opportunity, Vesna drew her pistol. She spied a viable escape route and plunged into action.

Vesna swarmed down the fire escape, less like a descent and more a controlled fall, her boots clanging against the metal. With her pistol gripped tightly, she fired only when she spotted clear shots. Adrenaline surged in her veins.

Bursting into the thick of the crowd, Vesna kept her sights trained forward. She nudged and shouldered her way through the tightly packed bodies, each stride carrying her closer to the stage. Yelena was crouched over Valentina's corpse, huddled in a desperate attempt to shield a life already gone.

Vesna seized the moment. Her pistol rose in a swift, practiced arc. She squeezed off a shot. The bullet found its mark, striking Yelena's thigh, sending a jolt through the woman's body.

Yelena stumbled, her legs giving way beneath her, and she fell.

Vesna didn't pause to watch Yelena fall. She drove forward, weaving through the crush of bodies between them. The shot had done more than wound; it had cracked open a moment the whole city had been bracing for. She needed to reach the director, now only a heartbeat away, before anyone else seized the advantage.

Vesna's advance didn't falter, but the press of bodies slowed her to a brutal crawl. Yelena's bodyguards forced their way toward Yelena, forming a wall of armor between Vesna and her target. A pair of them spotted her breaking through the crowd and moved to intercept.

She cut sideways, using the panicked civilians as cover, firing tight, controlled shots at the gaps in their formation. One guard dropped, another staggered as a round bit into her vest. The rest didn't fall back; they surged toward her, trying to pin her arms or drive her to the ground rather than trade fire in the chaos.

Vesna shoved past grasping hands, slipped under a half-tackle, and pressed forward through the opening her shots had carved.

Now mere yards away, Vesna locked eyes with Yelena. The older woman's gaze, once steely with command, shimmered with unmasked fear. The space between predator and prey shrank with every one of Vesna's steps.

Closing in on the stage, Vesna reached out and ripped the visor from Yelena's forehead. A fired shot followed, and a cloud of red mist sprayed from her heart into the air.

Vesna's movements slowed as the smoke rose from her pistol's barrel. A disquieting stillness fell upon her. She studied the woman's face intently; the longer she looked, the more apparent the inconsistencies became. It wasn't the eyes—a common shade of hazel rather than Yelena's distinct green—that gave it away, nor the unremarkable hair. This was a face unaccustomed to danger, not the stoic mask worn by the woman she'd seen commanding audiences with ease.

This is not Yelena, Vesna knew.

The Black Wolves encircled her, their approach a solemn march. Faces she once recognized, allies turned shadows. As the cold realization of her misstep pierced through, a heavy

sense of defeat settled in her chest. She saw no point in struggling against the inevitable tide. Her arms rose in surrender.

Clarity, now fragmented, gave way to a storm of disarray in her mind as she grappled with the aftermath of her actions. Bitterness tainted her, the sting of a plan unraveling and drifting far from its intended course. Engulfed by Gred's defenders, now distinguishable by their black and yellow scarves, Vesna stood uncertain, languishing in the missed opportunity to execute the decisive strike Zakharovna had counted on. Nothing else had mattered and now...

The Black Wolves forced Vesna to the ground and clamped her arms behind her, her eyes drifting to the still form of the woman she'd mistaken for her matron's archnemesi. A forearm angled across her skull for a moment, keeping her head from cracking against the concrete as debris rattled down around them. The impact thudded close, a sharp reminder of how narrow the margin had become. Only then did the self-reproach hit her; she should have trusted that nagging doubt. *I had to be sure.*

Pinned down, unable to move, Vesna's mind snapped to the incendiary device Marfa had planted just forty seconds ago.

Vesna gritted her teeth as the flames roared through the plaza, consuming everything but the one thing she needed. Her chance to escape. The blast had done its job of creating chaos, but she was still pinned, her body pressed into the cold ground by the weight of the Wolves. Marfa's device had stirred the pot all right, but from her vantage point, all Vesna could do was watch as the fire spread. She wasn't in control anymore. If she ever *had* been. Fury rose in her chest, but it was quickly smothered by the cold, unfamiliar acceptance of her failure.

Through the haze and smoke, Yelena's infantry emerged, their figures barely visible at first, then sharpening as they advanced. But they were stopped in their tracks by the Black Wolves, who formed a perimeter around her; they gestured with a stern authority that seemed to suggest that they owned the situation, her fate included.

Vesna's end was now hurtling towards her, inevitable as the setting sun, and in its shadow, all else paled to insignificance.

"For the Syndicate." Lawlessness and chaos reigned now, devoid of any guiding principles. A realm where the strong wielded power and the weak were crushed. She could have flourished there, but on the precipice of death, that future was lost. A bitter laugh threatened to escape, but anger and defeat smothered it, turning it into a stifled sob beneath the weight of the Wolves' restraint.

The world would keep spinning without her. She wondered if Zakharovna would forgive her capture. Her thoughts drifted to her pack, questioning their whereabouts and whether they'd thrive without her. They always had. Death no longer frightened Vesna. Since leaving behind all her past for so many months, she'd long ago accepted her transient existence.

Instinctively, Vesna's mind clutched at the thought of Dunya. Regret threaded through her as she realized that only at the brink of her own demise or at that of Dunya's own did she fully embrace the tenderness of those shared times. She remembered Dunya's laughter, the cadence of her voice, how they forged pockets of peace in the turmoil of their exhausting lives. It was Dunya's light that seemed to cast the longest shadow, one that offered Vesna a respite, if only in fleeting memory.

The harsh grip on her shoulder eased. Confused, Vesna felt the Wolves lift her cautiously into a seated position. Her eyes

flicked from one guard to another, hunting for some hint at their sudden change in demeanour. Without warning, a figure from the ranks stepped close with a portable radio.

The static-laden voice cut through, “Vesna, I need you with me a while longer. I’m not ready to lose you yet.”

A smile, crooked and somber, crept across Vesna’s face. Relief and cynicism tangled within her. Was fate simply toying with her, or was she the subject of some cosmic joke? The irony that she would now be spared, as if by some capricious deity, perhaps the hand of Morana herself, struck her with an odd sense of gratitude. Yet, in the back of her mind, there lingered a nagging sense of unworthiness, questioning her right to this unexpected acquittal.

Zakharovna hadn’t abandoned her after all. The Wolves shifted their grip, hauling Vesna up from the ground while keeping her arms pinned behind her. They scanned the plaza with practiced caution, ensuring the Hive’s infantry remained none the wiser. Still holding her tight, they moved her between drifting smoke and panicked stragglers, using the shifting crowd as cover as they pulled her away from the stage.

Then they drifted into an abandoned wing of City Hall. Inside, the Wolves pushed her into an old elevator and began a silent descent. When the doors opened, the basement met her with low light and the hum of active machines. Rows of monitors flickered along the walls, each screen carrying its own quiet tension. Vesna took it in with a wary sweep of her eyes. Whatever this place was, it had been built to watch, to record, to judge. And now she stood in the middle of it, her fate resting with women she had only hours ago called traitors.

A door opened, revealing Zakharovna with a glass in her hand. The pale fizz and the familiar gold-foiled bottle on the table told Vesna it was that old Soviet champagne Zakharovna

avored. Fresh snow clung to her crimson jacket; her cheeks were tinged pink from the chill. She must have returned moments ago. Zakharovna stood as Vesna entered, eyes shimmering with satisfaction. “A garden pruned to perfection,” she mused.

Vesna met her gaze firmly. “Only one problem. That woman wasn’t Yelena.”

Instant fury flashed in Zakharovna’s eyes. The glass shattered in her grip. “What!?”

“A double. Darker eyes, lighter hair. She looked afraid. The real Yelena fears nothing.”

Zakharovna’s face twisted in a rage, then snapped into a chilling calm. “A Hive trick, then. A farce for the public. But the chaos you unleashed is enough to shake their confidence. You have not failed me, Vesna. What comes next will force them out of hiding.” Her hand trembled, sending tiny droplets of champagne scattering, their effervescent trails briefly catching the light. “Rally the pack. You know what must follow. Yelena will come for you now, and she will come hard. When I return, we will burn her ambitions to the ground.”

Vesna’s jaw tightened, her thoughts swirling beneath the surface. *Again? So soon?* She almost asked where Zakharovna planned to run off to now, but she already knew she’d get no answer. Her body still ached—captured, tested, acquitted—and now, with barely a breath between ordeals, Zakharovna was sending her back into the fray while she disappeared to whatever shadow she favored. *How is it always me you throw at the knife?*

...It never ends clean in Gred, does it? There was always another blade, another demand, another cold order waiting.

...And of course she always chooses me for it. Because I’m a weapon. Always have been, always will be. Nothing more.

And with that thought, she acquiesced, her resolve hardening as she met Zakharovna's gaze.

"Missed chances breed sharper fangs," was all Vesna could say.

CHAPTER FOURTY

YELENA

Bathed in the sterile chamber's pallid glow, Valentina's mutilated body lay tethered by fragile strands of viscera. Her fingers, stiff, grasped at a life forever beyond her reach.

Yelena, rooted at the observation window, watched as each breath she exhaled misted the glass. The moment of Valentina's death replayed in her mind like a record with a skip, refusing to move forward. "They took her from me," she whispered to the quiet room.

Lev Rozhkov's muffled response emanated through the plastic mask concealing his face. "We will find her." As Chief Neurosurgeon, Dr. Rozhkov was one of the few immortal men left in Gred with political standing. Often overlooked, he was a gaunt figure with a countenance marked by time and wisdom. He had served the Board with unwavering loyalty for decades and had saved innumerable souls from oblivion. Yelena prayed that Valentina wouldn't be his last.

Valentina had been a child of two worlds. Petrova blood pulled her close, close enough that Yelena could look at her and see Katerina in the angle of her face, in the stubborn lift of her chin. But the Hive had claimed her too, dressing blood in duty until aunt and niece met more often in offices and Board chambers than around a family table. Yelena had kept her close and built every protection she could around her. Valentina had still been exposed. It had never been enough.

Their family had already been cut open twice: first when their father was poisoned, then when Katerina's husband died in that blizzard, killed over a gold vein like the world had not taken enough from them already.

Taking Valentina in had never felt like duty. It had felt like the only thing left to do for Katerina. Every day, Yelena saw her sister in the girl. Not the Black Wolf the Syndicate had made, but the woman before it all, quick to laugh, stubborn, still clean of what Gred would later demand from everyone.

Valentina had kept that part alive. Her softness should have been beaten out of her, but it never was. She still believed workers deserved to be heard. Still walked into labor disputes as if hope were a tool and not a wound waiting to open. Katerina's brightness, her husband's reckless optimism, all of it had survived in Valentina.

And now it was gone.

"And if we don't?" Yelena's voice cracked. She shifted in her chair, crossing her arms to hide their quivering. She had already lost so much, so many dear to her, and now she faced the possibility of losing even the remaining fragments of Valentina's essence. Dr. Rozhkov's efforts to preserve Valentina's neural net were her last hope, the final thread connecting her to the young woman who had been like a daughter to her. It was a delicate process skirting the edge of legality, reserved exclusively for those with access to the city's most powerful and secretive circles.

"We will. Your niece is resourceful like you. She'll make the connection."

Yelena's stomach roiled. Valentina had been a good woman—compassionate, nurturing, and kind—qualities Yelena lacked. Yelena regretted burdening her with the Board's weight, even if it was for their mutual benefit and the prosperity of their party and city. Now, there was no one left to ignite her blood as Valentina had, no one to share the intricacies of their ambitious schemes, knowledge hard-earned through peril and shared only in whispers between confidants.

Yelena refused to let go of Valentina's soul when it slipped from her body, and she would hold it close until they *could* reunite, or until she too crossed over to stand beside her niece once more.

"The damage can be undone," Dr. Rozhkov assured her.

Yelena's arms slammed onto the chair rests as she stood abruptly. "And who repairs it all?" She didn't bother straightening her disheveled silk shirt. "Who fixes this damn city when I can't protect my own blood?"

Dr. Rozhkov replied, his composure and conviction something Yelena wished she could summon. "In the wreckage, there's always a chance for rebirth."

"Rebirth? You talk of rebirth when we're standing in an ash heap? Save your platitudes, Doctor. What we need is a miracle, not a rebirth." She paused, her gaze dropping for a moment before locking back onto Rozhkov. "You can't fix this. No one can."

Yelena stepped out of City Hall, her gaze lingering on the facade with its intricate marble honeycombs. The Hive's namesake etched in stone—a testament to their strength and unity—now hung in the balance, vulnerable to the onslaught of outside forces.

She turned away, towards the aftermath created by Zakharovna and her commandos. The Hive's infantry unit was still present, clearing debris and rescuing people from the wreckage of the ceremonial grounds and the stage where Valentina had been torn apart. Yelena didn't greet them or offer encouragement. She didn't pray for their safety or apologize for their injuries.

As she moved, the devastation unfolded before her: twisted metal, scorched earth, and bullet holes pockmarked the walls. The concrete itself looked glassed in places, the intense heat having melted and reshaped it. Scattered around were

remnants of lives lost, personal effects mingled with anonymous body parts.

Nearby, evidence of Zakharovna's marines' recent assault was irrefutable. The plaza bore the brutal marks of unleashed incendiaries and relentless bombings that had swiftly followed the botched assassination attempt. Smoke still rose in thin tendrils from smoldering fires, and the acrid stench of explosives lingered in the air, a haunting reminder of the violence that had torn through the space mere hours before.

In the periphery of her vision, Yelena noticed figures moving, but they seemed distant, almost like specters in a fog of war. The immediacy of her surroundings, the visceral impact of the bombing, held her complete attention, drowning out the rest of the world.

Her gaze followed the trajectory of Valentina's soul, now ensnared within the intricate web of the Syndicate's machinery. Yelena's eyes moved from the epicenter, across the debris-strewn landscape, to the ambulances lined at the plaza's edge. Each vehicle, bristling with advanced medical equipment, stood ready to play its part in the delicate operation.

Beyond the gathering medical teams, the Prime Infirmary loomed, its walls housing Dr. Rozhkov's team of specialists and tech-healers. It was there that they would undertake the painstaking process of extracting Valentina from her neural tomb. Yelena imagined them, huddled over their consoles, weaving through data streams to salvage and nurture the essence of her niece back to a semblance of life, to be housed in a digital vessel.

And as she envisioned this, Yelena couldn't shake the feeling of dissonance. This process, no matter how advanced, couldn't replicate the Valentina she knew. Life in *virtual* was a far cry from the physical, breathing presence of her niece.

The thought left her with a profound sense of loss, and Yelena doubted she would ever see her as she was.

The crunch of approaching footsteps barely pierced the fog surrounding her. It was the unexpected brush of a hand on her shoulder that snapped her back to reality, an intrusion into her isolated reverie. Instinctively, her hand flew up, connecting with a cheek in a sharp slap. The sound echoed, a solitary crack in the silence of the ruins.

There was a momentary pause as Yelena registered the sting in her hand, the slow realization that she had hit Klara. She felt a mix of shock and a brief, unspoken regret, but she quickly suppressed her feelings. “Don’t touch me. I don’t need your damn sympathy.”

Klara, momentarily stunned by the slap, hesitated before speaking again. Her cheek reddened, yet her expression softened. Then, with a steadiness in her voice that belied the concern in her gaze, Klara continued. “What are you going to do? If you go after the University now... Her party is not responsible for this. She wants you to—”

“I’ll burn the world if I must. I’ll tear Gred apart for her.”

“You’ve gotta calm down. If not for yourself, then for the good of the Hive.”

“I don’t care about the Hive. I only care about my family.”

Klara fell silent.

“Who’s that?” Yelena’s voice sharpened as she gestured toward a hooded figure, flanked by two elderly escorts. Wisps of silver hair escaped from beneath their yellow scarves, the fabric fluttering like delicate wings in the breeze. The woman in the center, her green coat frayed and marred by dark, crimson stains, moved with an air of confidence.

“A civilian,” Klara replied. “She—”

“Why is she here?” Yelena interrupted, her steps already carrying her towards the unfamiliar woman.

Klara hastened to keep pace, leaning in to whisper urgently, “She’s a *shpichki*. Says she’s got some sorta new stim that might just help us out.” She glanced over her shoulder before adding with a mix of awe and earnestness, “You wouldn’t believe the ruckus she stirred in the last scuffle. Tossed fireballs like child’s play—never seen anything like it, swear on it.”

Yelena’s fists clenched tightly, a visceral reaction barely kept in check; she wanted to seize Klara by her throat, but she restrained herself. The eyes of onlookers bore into them, but Yelena was beyond caring how they saw her. Her world was in disarray. The Syndicate in tatters, Valentina killed, and now, amid their dwindling peace, an outsider promising a sliver of hope, or perhaps, another layer of deception.

“I’m Marzanna Poplawski,” the woman said, her rounded accent unfamiliar.

“An Ameriken?” Yelena asked.

“Alaska. Rozhkov and I go back further than Gred.”

Yelena glanced at Klara. “*This* is your scientist?”

“Scientist, firestarter, pain in the arse,” Klara said. “Useful, though.”

Marzanna held Yelena’s gaze. “Zakharovna buried our work. If the defectors are right about Volkova, she got one of our samples.”

Yelena’s expression shifted. “Aisyt?”

Marzanna nodded.

“I thought that was a University rumor.”

“Zakharovna preferred it that way.”

Yelena looked at Marzanna's hands. "And the fire?"

"Same work. Rozhkov called the trigger *LAS*. Exovegeta listens when the pattern is right."

"Listens?"

"To words, if you need the simple version."

The answer should have sounded ridiculous. Instead, old details started surfacing faster than Yelena could dismiss them. Zakharovna's protégés had scattered after her first Ascension, despite every advantage that should have kept them close. The serum had lurched forward in strange bursts while its ugliest failures somehow missed the women nearest the doctor. Then there was Vesna, suddenly younger, stronger, moving through Gred as if the years had been peeled off her.

Aisyt. Yelena had heard the name before, buried in University gossip and half-finished accusations. She had filed it away with everything else Zakharovna kept behind locked doors.

Now the pieces pressed together hard enough to make her temples ache. If Marzanna was telling the truth, Zakharovna had been sitting on something far stranger than another serum. If she was lying, she knew exactly which old suspicions to disturb.

This woman is playing me for a fool.

Marzanna said nothing more.

That irritated Yelena more than another explanation would have. The woman had named *Aisyt*, tied it to Vesna, and reduced the impossible to a few words about patterns. If there was a trick here, Yelena wanted to find the seam and tear it open.

She shook her head. “You think you can break the spell of time with *words*? What kind of gag is that?” A laugh escaped her before she could stop it. “You say a few sentences and the body obeys? If people were that easy to command, Marzanna, I’d have conquered this city years ago.”

“And yet, here I am. Seventy-seven years old and young enough to be your daughter,” Marzanna said, her piercing blue eyes narrowing. “Too proud to trust what you see?”

Yelena met Marzanna’s gaze, unflinching. “This isn’t about wordplay. You might appear young, Marzanna, but your mind betrays your age.”

“Do I look frail to you, Matron?”

Surveying the broken walls and cracked sidewalks, Yelena retorted sharply, “No, not frail. Ensnared. Youthful looks can’t mask an ancient soul out of touch with the present.”

Marzanna inched closer, her hand hovering near Yelena’s face. A chill seeped into the air, the temperature dropping palpably. Yelena felt a subtle, electrifying tingle on her skin, like the touch of winter’s first frost. It was as if the very air around Marzanna thrummed with an unspoken energy.

As Marzanna’s lips curled into a smile, Yelena’s ears suddenly rang with an inexplicable boom, resonating deep within her. It was a sound only she seemed to hear, a thunderous echo that matched the rhythm of her own racing heart.

Marzanna continued smoothly, “You believe words wield no real power—that they amount to mere threats and mockery. Is that right?”

Yelena felt a sharp throb in her temples and clenched her jaw. Fighting through the headache, she spat, “Don’t think for a moment that I don’t see through your charade. You want me to cower in fear before you. But remember, hubris has been

the downfall of many great women, and the death of all gods.” She paused. “And I have a war to finish. I don’t have time for this nonsense.”

Marzanna’s next words were like icicles, piercing the air between them, “Ah, but you do fear. You fear becoming like me. Of loving, losing... Of a pain so deep, you’d choose death over facing it again. Like the sorrow that shadows your heart for Valentina, your niece.”

Yelena’s eyes widened in shock. *How could she know?* Klara must have briefed her, shared more than she let on. Yelena’s mind raced, trying to dismiss the thought, trying to bury the rising unease. She forced a sneer. “Death... I never grasped it, not truly. But I’ve dodged it, always.”

“You loved her,” Marzanna said. “That’s why losing her scares you more than dying ever did.”

Yelena felt a surge of anger and sorrow battling within her. She wanted to scream, to admit her fear, but she held back, her hands clenched into fists at her sides. *No, I won’t give her the satisfaction.* “I don’t know what you’re talking about.”

Marzanna’s bright eyes grew dim as she gazed down at Yelena. “You’re not there yet. Not ready to love, nor to lose. You’re unprepared for what’s ahead.” The voice of the old woman seemed to emanate from Marzanna’s mouth, but it was a distant, muffled echo rather than her true words. “*I can help you,*” that old voice said. “*I can grant you the courage you need. You’re destined for greatness, for power, but first, you must release your fear.*”

Marzanna produced a small blue pouch from her jacket. “Take it.”

Yelena hesitated, but her curiosity ultimately overcame her reluctance. She reached out and grasped the pouch from Marzanna’s outstretched hand. Its heft surprised her, the contents exuding a palpable heat that radiated through the

fabric, tickling her palms with the sensation of something almost sentient. As she loosened the pouch's tie, she looked up at Marzanna—this woman of enigma and alleged power—noting the anticipation in the *shpichki's* eyes.

“So, all your cryptic words and riddles boil down to this? Some new kind of *exo*?” Yelena shook the pouch slightly, hearing the contents shift. “Well, we have a battle to fight, and if this is what it takes to blunt the edge... But remember, I’m doing this for me, not because I believe in your prophecies or promises.”

As Yelena held the pouch, Marzanna’s lips remained still, yet her voice echoed in Yelena’s mind, clear and resonant. It was as if the words bypassed her ears and spoke directly to her. “*Embrace the storm within, find the harmony where chaos meets order.*”

Yelena peered into the pouch. Her fingers brushed against a mound of luminescent white powder. As she withdrew her hand, the powder dispersed into the air. It transformed into a mist that danced before her eyes, tickling her nostrils, and gently invading her throat. A slight cough escaped her as she raised her gaze to meet Marzanna’s.

“You don’t have to be alone anymore,” Marzanna said.

The fog then invaded Yelena’s mouth and filled her lungs. It suffocated her attempt to respond.

Yelena’s body surrendered to a sudden, overwhelming weakness. The sensation of falling engulfed her, yet the destination remained shrouded in mystery. As she descended into an abyss of darkness, the image of Marzanna’s smile lingered hauntingly in her fading consciousness. Her trembling hand flailed upwards, desperately seeking to clasp onto something, anything, that had already slipped away.

Her mind now quivered beneath an unseen burden. Thoughts and memories, once firmly anchored, felt as though

they were subtly dislodging, drifting loose. At first, these fragments meandered like leaves on a tranquil current. But slowly, the current transformed into a whirlpool, pulling the pieces into a frenzied swirl. They blurred into the indistinct shapes of a chaotic void.

And in that void, a transformation began. Each fragment, once a part of her coherent self, sparked alive. They were no longer just disparate memories or thoughts; they had become stars in a dark sky, each a piece of her. She saw her niece, Valentina, her bright green eyes brimming with the same stubborn optimism that had propelled Yelena before. There was her mother and sister, their laughter a comforting echo in the expanse. And amid these celestial memories, a vision of the future materialized: a shining city in the sky, crystallizing into the nexus of all their hopes. These points of light pierced with blinding intensity until, in a crescendo of searing pain, they violently reassembled.

A sudden gust of wind and the distant murmur of voices jolted Yelena back to reality. For a fleeting moment, she questioned how much time had slipped by since her senses had been engulfed by the exo's distinctive aroma. Since her consciousness had first begun its voyage through the void. It felt like an eternity had passed, yet here she was, the pivot on which the fates of many would turn.

The ground beneath her feet was solid, and the familiar scent of the plaza filled her nostrils. Blinking, she realized she was standing atop a raised platform overlooking a vast assembly of troops. Rows upon rows of soldiers awaited her command, their sleek gray uniforms and yellow honeycombed scarves gleaming in the sunlight. Yelena took a moment to steady herself and took a deep breath.

She walked to the forefront of her gathered forces and projected a voice brimming with authority. There was no

hesitation in her step, no shadow of fear, as she prepared to speak to her assembled troops.

“Today, we will eradicate the old guard, once and for all,” Yelena cried. “Today, we will breach their lines, crush them, and scatter the remnants of their pitiful forces. All who stand in our way shall fall before us.”

The cheer from the soldiers was thunderous, resounding through the ranks. Yelena felt a surge of power, a feeling she hadn’t experienced in a long time. Emboldened, she called out, “We shall emerge victorious today. Advance!” Her command was clear, ringing out as a rallying cry that spurred her troops forward.

United in purpose, they advanced, a formidable golden wave of silver-tressed valor sweeping through the plaza’s fractured gates at Petrovskaya Square, the very place where her enemies had failed in their attempt to assassinate her. Yelena, leading the charge, steered her troops through the industrial heart of the city, past looming factories, and silent warehouses. As they moved towards the city center, beads of sweat formed on her brow, despite the chill in the air. The winter sun, low and relentless in the sky, bore down mercilessly. Around them, patches of snow, remnants of a recent flurry, began to melt in the streets, turning to slush under the march of so many feet.

Yellow banners snapped in the wind, their warm hues rich against the white sky. The hum of bees and the rhythmic pounding of boots filled her ears. The Hive’s emblem, a black honeycomb, decorated their flags and billowed as they pressed onward.

Yelena navigated through the city’s ruins, her boots stepping over chunks of broken concrete and twisted metal. Ahead of her, the ranks of her army spread out, a striking sight of aged warriors clad in gray uniforms, their white hair

sharply outlined against the rubble of shattered buildings and overturned vehicles. Each soldier, their faces partially obscured by sleek black visors, held a black rifle, the weapons polished to a dark gleam. The rhythmic chants of her soldiers, "Bor'ba! Bor'ba!" echoed off the skeletal remains of buildings.

Yelena's eyes briefly caught the sight of old women in tattered babushkas, hastily retreating from the broken windows of battered, once-cozy homes. Amid the strewn debris and the shadows of crumbling walls, she noted their quick, fearful movements. The crumbled facades of buildings and the distant wails of sirens formed a grim backdrop to these vulnerable figures scurrying for safety. Those were the faces of this conflict, their lives disrupted by the relentless onslaught that Zakharovna had unleashed.

As her soldiers pressed forward, Yelena's gaze swept over the scarred landscape, her thoughts turning to Fort Ivan. *Once a symbol of our city's strength, now a bastion for those traitors*, she brooded. The Black Wolves' broken oath gnawed at her. They had sworn to defend the city, to uphold the Charter, yet they had forsaken her leadership for Zakharovna's deceptive promises.

Zakharovna, she plays her games of power and politics like a crone who weaves tales among children. She had overthrown Zakharovna, yet here she was, still fighting her shadows, her manipulations pulling strings from afar. It infuriated Yelena to end, how Zakharovna had so easily swayed the Wolves, disrupting the fragile balance she had fought so hard to maintain.

Commander Volkova will have already started marching. We've made enough noise; she'll be here, with her forces, any moment.

Yelena's ears picked up distant, muffled sounds. The clatter and clamor from alleys afar. The erratic, frenzied howls and

chants of old women, zealous and unyielding, began to fill the air. As she focused, a fog started to roll in, cloaking the war-torn streets in a ghostly shroud. Shadows moved within it, formless at first, then gaining definition.

Beyond the mist, figures darted. Black-clad, adorned with blue and red silk scarves, like spectral wraiths in a twisted dance. Massive, hulking women moved among them, their chants growing louder, more lurid. The scene was nightmarish, the sounds piercing the air with their madness.

Yelena noticed her own soldiers tensing, their grips tightening on their weapons as they scanned the fog for threats.

Then a figure emerged, capturing Yelena's immediate attention. The defiant posture, the windswept hair framing a face too young to be real. It was unmistakably the young Wolf.

Yelena's focus intensified, a storm of anger, anticipation, and fierce determination brewing within. *How dare she? How dare this green pup think she can rise to power in the city I have fought so tirelessly to build and protect?*

"You!" Yelena voice cut sharply through the silence. "Zakharovna's little marionette. Surrender now, and perhaps we'll cut your strings mercifully."

"I'm nobody's puppet," Vesna countered. "Perhaps you should worry about who's pulling yours."

The brief silence following Vesna's retort was broken by a cough from Klara. Yelena's focus shifted, catching sight of Marzanna and Klara now standing beside her at the vanguard. Their quiet arrival had almost gone unnoticed in the heat of the standoff. Marzanna's smile, calm yet reassuring, cut through the tension. "You're not alone anymore," she said softly to Yelena.

As Yelena's attention returned to Vesna, her adversary's face was etched with a haunting malevolence: lips twisted in a sinister smile, eyes burning with an intensity reminiscent of a fierce winter storm. She was a vision of ethereal beauty, unlike anything Yelena had ever seen.

Then, as if orchestrated by some unseen hand, a dense fog rolled in, enveloping Vesna entirely. Around them, chaos erupted within Yelena's van. The once disciplined formation splintered unexpectedly, soldiers breaking ranks in a frenetic scramble. Yelena was left stunned, her senses overwhelmed by the cacophony of screams and the gruesome, saturating sound of blood flooding the streets.

A sudden, sharp crack of rifle fire split the air. Yelena's gaze shot to the rooftops of the warehouses lining the thoroughfare. Silhouetted against the skyline, University snipers crouched in the shadows, their dark uniforms blending into the gloom. Narrowing her eyes, Yelena caught the glint of scopes, each one trained on the scrambling soldiers below.

Her attention shifted again as a group of enemy Black Wolves burst onto the scene. Their gunblades caught the light, flashing menacingly as they moved into combat formation. They were like warriors from ancient myths. The way they stood, the way they moved, cast long shadows across the battlefield, shadows that twisted and turned, almost dragon-like, in a dance of blue and red hues.

They crashed through the fog with surprising agility, their robust statures and large, muscular arms belying their old bodies and white hair. Each strike was swift and brutal, their swords slashing through her troops without hesitation. Yelena watched, a mix of horror and fascination, as they snapped necks and crushed heads with their swords and bare fists, aged faces clashing with the raw, primal ferocity of their combat skills.

As Yelena watched, a sharp pain throbbed in her head, each heartbeat amplifying the sensation. She gritted her teeth, fighting the disorientation that threatened to overtake her in the heat of battle. Through the fray, she caught glimpses of their commander, a fleeting purple shadow darting between encounters, moving deftly behind the formidable wall of black steel formed by her forces. Vesna orchestrated the army like a cruel chess player.

The young commander's voice, sharp and venomous, pierced the air. "You'll regret ever challenging us, witch!" she bellowed, her eyes locking with Yelena's in a defiant glare.

Yelena wiped the dust from her face with a grim smile. "Your time is over, girl!" Raising her gunblade high, she turned to her troops. "For our future—attack!"

The moment the Black Wolves breached her van, Yelena's pulse quickened with a surge of adrenaline. Her side forces, previously marching parallel in nearby alleys, sprang into action. The air was filled with their unified battle cry, "Bor'ba! Bor'ba!" echoing their readiness. As they surged across the throughfare, Yelena felt the ground thrumming beneath the collective might of her soldiers. The vibration ascended through her boots.

The charge transformed seamlessly into an orchestrated push under Yelena's command. She observed as a multitude of gray uniforms, each wearing a black visor, raised their rifles in unison. The air, already electric with battle cries, now crackled. A downpour of relentless, piercing bullets followed.

The disciplined volleys from Yelena's forces took the Black Wolves off balance, the unexpected rifle fire slicing through their ranks. But just as quickly as the ambush had unfolded, the fierce warriors adapted. With mechanical precision, their gunblades transformed, unfolding into large shields. Each segment clicked into place as if it were a satellite array

deploying in space. The menacing blades metamorphosed into a formidable line of defense. The shields unfurled like the dark wings of a predatory bird, swiftly creating an impenetrable barrier that spread across the battlefield, a black wall of defiance against the onslaught.

Through the well-designed openings in these shields, the barrels of their rifles emerged. Yelena watched in horror as the Black Wolves, figures now obscured behind these impromptu ramparts, locked in their stance. Suddenly, in a unified and devastating volley, they returned fire.

The salvo from the Black Wolves was brutally efficient. Yelena's heart jolted as she witnessed her soldiers being torn by the concentrated assault. The disciplined ranks, once a source of pride, now shattered by the gunfire, their formations dissolving into mist. Confusion and panic replaced their structured movements. She caught glimpses of fear and shock in the eyes of her troops as they desperately sought refuge, scrambling for cover behind the scant protection of destroyed cars and hastily erected barricades.

Yelena ducked behind a shattered wall, her breaths quick and shallow. From her cover, she noticed a subtle movement in her periphery. Turning, she saw Marzanna. In her hands, Marzanna manipulated a small device, its surface bristling with dials and glowing indicators. Her fingers danced over the device, adjusting settings with a focus that seemed out of place in the mayhem.

Yelena darted between covers, her movements swift and precise, until she reached Marzanna. "What are you doing?" she demanded.

Marzanna, absorbed in her task, didn't look up. "Trust me, it's necessary. Just watch."

The ground shuddered beneath Yelena's feet with a deep, resonant boom, vibrating through her bones. She covered her

ears against the deafening roar. As the sound faded, a brilliant iridescent light spread across the battlefield, bathing everything in an otherworldly glow.

The scene shifted before her eyes, the ethereal light casting an almost hypnotic sheen over the dust and smoke of battle. Mesmerizing.

Yelena's breath caught as the light enveloped them. She turned to Marzanna, a spark of realization dawning. "Is this... a shield?"

Marzanna nodded. "Yes, and it's just disabled all our weapons."

A surge of adrenaline shot through Yelena as the implications hit her. Her troops were now unarmed. "Marzanna, what have you done?"

"It's the only way to stop them without further casualties. We needed a pause, Matron."

Yelena's initial anger flickered, then began to ebb as she scanned the scene. Her eyes locked on the rooftop snipers, their bullets frozen mid-air, harmless against the shield's sonic barrier. Below, the Black Wolves stood in confusion, their guns rendered useless by the same force. Her own soldiers, though disarmed, were safe. Suspended in this strange moment of standstill.

Vesna's voice cut through the stalemate. "We've had enough of your guns anyway." From afar, Yelena could discern the smugness on Vesna's face, a smirk that conveyed triumph and scorn.

Yelena shouted back, her voice raw, "This isn't over yet, traitor!"

In that moment, something in her snapped. The rage and frustration that had been simmering within surged to the forefront, obliterating caution. *Enough of this.*

Her grip tightened around the hilt of her gunblade. A surge of adrenaline propelled her into action.

Yelena became a force of nature, her every movement driven by a singular purpose. She lunged towards the Black Wolves' shield wall. With a powerful thrust, she struck at the wall, her blade meeting the first shield with a resounding crash. The impact sent shockwaves through the line, creating a small fissure in the otherwise impenetrable barrier. Seizing the moment, she twisted her weapon, prying the shield away and opening a path through the stunned ranks.

As she engaged another, the clash of their blades sent sparks flying. In the heat of the moment, a brief yet potent thought coursed through Yelena's mind. *They won't dare swarm me. Not me. They're too proud.* She shifted her weight and, with a surge of force, knocked aside the soldier's weapon. Her gunblade sliced down in a swift, decisive motion. The soldier, clad in black, fell to the ground, a clear gap now formed in the wall of bodies.

Yelena pushed forward through the opening, her heart pounding. She understood the enormous risk, yet her focus was singular. Vesna, visible now through the breach she had created.

Beside and behind her, she could hear Klara meet the enemy at full force, her own gunblade slashing down ruthlessly through the defense of another. The defender barely had a chance to parry before Klara sliced through her attempts in a clean, undeniable arc. With an agile sidestep, she deftly dodged a counterattack, pivoting to land a punishing strike even as she swept past.

Marzanna, too, joined the action, her movements sharp and precise. She delivered sudden, forceful thrusts, each one more impactful than the last.

Klara and Marzanna pushed the encircling Wolves backward, their combined force creating a buffer. Through the swirling dust and resonating steel, Yelena glimpsed the path they cleared for her. She seized the moment. *This should draw her out.* The Black Wolves were ruthless and amoral, but she knew their singular oath. They wouldn't dare rush at a Matron two at a time. And Yelena, having once held the esteemed position of the city's first Pra Matron Chair, understood this better than anyone. It was a rule she knew well, a rule that many of these warriors, once under her command, would not dare break.

From within the tight ring of Black Wolves, a figure detached itself with a deliberate, almost theatrical slowness. It was Vesna, finally. The immediate area around them seemed to freeze, the jostling of heavy forms fading into a tense hush. Yelena's eyes locked onto Vesna's. They were cold, calculating; the younger woman's gaze was filled with a blend of contempt and challenge.

"You'll never be Queen," Vesna said casually, her voice slicing through the suspended silence.

"I have my sights set much higher," Yelena countered. In a fluid motion, she detached the blade from her gunblade, discarding the heavy firearm component. The blade alone in her hands felt swift, light, and perfectly balanced. Ideal for the imminent close-quarters combat.

"*Mechanor*, Vesna," Yelena said. "This city wasn't built on bullets and lead alone. It was honed on the snowy plains of our forefathers. Or have you forgotten the old ways?"

Vesna's expression twisted, a visible clash of anger and embarrassment playing across her face. Yelena saw a swift movement and heard a distinctive click as Vesna disengaged her own gunblade, the stock clattering to the ground. "You cling to old traditions."

“Then show me your honor, if you have any left.”

“Enough talk. This ends now,” Vesna said.

Vesna’s lunge was swift and powerful. Yelena responded with a parry, her blade meeting Vesna’s with a sharp clang. Her heart raced, adrenaline pumping through her veins as she matched Vesna stroke for stroke.

The battle narrowed to Vesna’s feet, Vesna’s shoulders, the angle of the blade before each strike. Yelena stopped hearing the rifles. She stopped counting bodies. She watched the small things: weight, breath, hesitation.

But soon enough, each thrust required more effort than the last. Her muscles burned with each twitch. She could sense her energy draining away, each second drawing more strength from her already taxed reserves. Her arms trembled with the effort, her breaths coming in short, labored gasps.

In a heart-stopping moment, Yelena narrowly dodged a slice to her neck, feeling the deadly edge of the blade just graze her. Time seemed to stretch and warp around her, the world moving in a surreal slow motion. In this heightened state of awareness, the reality of her situation became clear. The life she had fought so hard to build, the identity she had carved for herself as a leader, all seemed perilously close to shattering under Vesna’s relentless assault.

Vesna’s left hook, swift and brutal, caught Yelena off guard, sending a sharp pain across her cheekbone and disorienting her. As her head snapped to the side, her vision blurred, and she felt her grip on her sword loosen. With a metallic clatter, it fell to the ground, leaving her unarmed.

As Yelena struggled to regain her bearings, a wave of regret washed over her. Lying there, vulnerable, and weaponless, thoughts of Valentina flooded her mind. *My sweet girl...our life that will never be, our dreams for the city, our people... Have I*

failed them all? Her gaze lifted, focusing with difficulty on Vesna, who stood over her, sword in hand.

Vesna raised her weapon high, the blade glinting menacingly as it prepared to carve its final path.

Yelena, her breaths shallow, braced for the inevitable. But in that split second, her eyes caught a sudden flicker. Not of shining metal, but of fire.

The heat was immediate and intense, engulfing Yelena in a searing embrace. Flames surrounded her, scorching her skin. Each breath was a torment, the smoke filling her lungs, threatening to suffocate. In those excruciating moments, her world was nothing but unrelenting pain, every second an eternity of agony. Every nerve ending screamed.

Yet as suddenly as the inferno had erupted, it receded, taking the pain with it. In its wake, a heavy, suffocating silence enveloped her, a brief calm that was swiftly shattered. The air was pierced by harrowing, banshee-like wails. These weren't the cries of a warrior; they were raw, guttural, the primal screams of a soul being violently ripped from its earthly existence.

Yelena, transfixed in horror, watched Vesna's skin and flesh undergo a ghastly transformation, dissolving in the intense heat, peeling away like wax dripping from a candle.

With a ragged gasp, Yelena's focus snapped back to herself. Through the clearing smoke, she shakily reached down. As her vision cleared and her fingers tentatively grazed her skin, astonishment surged through her. It was unburned.

The flames had receded, leaving behind the grim remnants of their fury. Vesna's body, twisted and contorted, lay motionless before her. What was once a symbol of strength and defiance was now reduced to a clump of blackened coal.

Around her, the throughfare had transformed into a mute spectacle, its main players frozen in the aftermath of a brutal dance. University snipers, identifiable by the dark blue of their uniforms and the distinct yellow rose patches adorning their shoulders, slowly rose from their perches. They stood frozen, their steely-eyed focus eroded by the nightmare which had played out below.

Vesna's Black Wolves emerged from the pillars of smoke, the vivid blue and red scarves woven into their carbon-fiber gladiator armor stark against the destruction surrounding them.

In the ruins, Yelena noticed scattered wartrikes that had slipped her attention in the frenzy of battle. Their formidable silhouettes, along with other machines of war, littered the streets. Old women, once crouched behind barriers with incendiary flares and makeshift rocket launchers, now eyed Vesna's twisted form, their once determined expressions clouded with disbelief.

In that haunting stillness, Yelena felt an unexpected pang. Not of triumph, but a somber reflection. She saw not just Zakharovna's puppet, but a warrior fallen, a path diverged into tragedy. A shared fate narrowly escaped: her victory tasted bittersweet.

Marzanna and Klara came to Yelena's side. She could see the alarm in their wide eyes, their looks conveying surprise that she was, against all odds, unharmed. Yelena's hands trembled slightly—a reaction to the exo-fueled adrenaline she knew was still coursing through her veins—as she wiped the mix of ash and blood from her face.

A thought crossed her as she looked at them, the absurdity of the situation briefly overshadowing its grim reality. "Seems death has a poor sense of timing," she said with a half-smile. It was an attempt to ease the tension, to inject a flicker of

reprieve into the brutal despair that followed them. *Even for Vesna, this end was too cruel, too abrupt.*

Whatever relief she had expected did not come. Vesna was dead, and Yelena was standing. The imbalance of that felt wrong before it felt fortunate.

Yelena caught Marzanna's gaze lingering on her, a mix of awe and something unreadable in her eyes. "You're certainly not alone anymore, Matron. The fire...it follows you."

CHAPTER FOURTY ONE

DUNYA

Word of Maria's sentencing spread across the babachain with the speed of rumor.

Dunya's avatar appeared at the edge of The Town Square, the Arkyv's virtual heart, recast as a digital echo of Uritsky Square. She wondered, as with everything in the Arkyv, if it'd ever looked like this at all. The Summer Palace facade and the Alexandra Column rose like ghostly monuments, framing a space where avatars from every stream gathered to witness Gred's triumphs, and more often, its staged displays of power.

The Square throbbed with an unsettling energy. Simulated odors filled Dunya's senses, exhaust from tanks mixing with the acrid sting of ceremonial gunfire, as pungent here as in real life.

The crowd pressed forward toward the grotesque centerpiece of the event: an execution machine, the latest invention of Vedmak, the Mad Tinkerer. In Gred, where death no longer held finality and age had lost its claim on the body, ordinary punishment carried little weight. Only executions in the virtual realm could enforce order, a deterrent meant to be as enduring as the endless lives it governed.

Dunya stood at the edge of the throng, her attention caught like the rest by the emergence of a single figure.

The voices fell away. Yelena Petrova, once the Hive's guiding hand and now calling herself Director of Gred, advanced to the stage. Dunya's heart quickened as the matriarch settled beside the execution device. The air seemed to shift under Yelena's gaze, each second of waiting winding tighter in Dunya's chest.

“Citizens of Gred,” Yelena’s voice cut through the crowd. “Today is our victory. The Black Wolves, under Vesna Volkova, are no more. Their shadow over our streets has been burned away. Their leader is broken, their followers scattered. Those who bent the knee to conscience now stand with us in the Hive. This is how we defend our city. This is how we claim its future.”

She let the words settle, her gaze sweeping the sea of faces. “The University, that den of seditious teachings under Zakharovna’s hand, is finished. The so-called architect of our despair has fled, her cowardice laying bare the hollowness of her cause. And their knowledge, once hoarded, will be freed. The research will be made public. Their experiments dragged into the light. The right to learn belongs to all. No more secrets. No more darkness.”

Her tone shifted, softer but no less commanding. “Yet justice demands more. Today we reveal the true Pra Matron of the Coven, the one who wove chaos and fear through our city. She hid in shadow, deceiving us all. But the time for deception is over. She is here, and she will answer for her crimes.”

Maria.

Dunya’s first thought was that the image was wrong. The posture, the face, the way the restraints held her. Close enough for the crowd, maybe. Not close enough for someone who had spent years reading Maria through lag and bad light.

Yelena called her the Pra Matron of the Coven. The accusation was too neat. One prisoner, one title, one public execution, and every unresolved crime acquired a parent record.

The screens enlarged Maria’s face while the machine powered up. Dunya searched the feed for errors: compression around the jaw, repeated movement in the crowd, any break

between the public render and the hidden state. Nothing obvious.

Maria, or whoever wore her shape, did not plead.

Then the machine completed the sentence.

The crowd cheered.

Dunya heard only the finality of the state change. If it was Maria, Yelena had murdered her and sold the murder as consensus. If it was not, the lie was worse. Someone had built a body, a record, and an ending convincing enough to close the case.

Dunya logged out, and *The Town Square* dissolved around her.

△△△

Dunya sat with Yana and Serafim beside her, but the room barely registered. She replayed the execution once, then killed the feed.

“This is all my fault.”

“It’s not.” Yana put an arm around her. “None of this is your fault.”

“I’ve heard that line before.”

Serafim’s expression hardened. “It wasn’t meant to be this way.”

Dunya’s hand moved toward the Skelet’s controls and stopped. Going anywhere would not change the record. She dropped into the chair and opened Maria’s latest rollup.

“They really killed her.”

The zk-ID had vanished from the active set. Dunya widened the query, checked the prior state, then searched for termination proofs. The identity was inactive, but its termination had produced no clean null proof. The ledger showed absence where a death should have left damage.

“The chain says she’s gone,” Dunya said. “It can’t prove she died.”

“Hold on...” Yana leaned closer to the rollup. “That last state hash doesn’t add up either.”

Serafim hunched forward as she murmured, “She hasn’t been active for weeks...” Then, sharper: “Whoever that was on stage, it wasn’t Maria. Rollups don’t just rewrite themselves. Something’s pulling strings.”

Dunya studied her in silence. The edge in Serafim’s voice wasn’t shock. It was recognition. She had probably known Maria had been missing from the active chain for weeks and hadn’t cared to say it aloud. Still, Dunya was almost grateful she’d seen the lie firsthand. The lengths the Hive would go to turn an absence into a public death were worth remembering.

“Only one way to find out,” Yana said.

Dunya watched as Yana reached out toward the unassuming black cube that rested on the coffee table. A tap, a gentle swish, and Yana’s headset came to life, cradling her face in a halo of hardlight. Streams of hashed light cascaded across her visor, decrypting in silent bursts.

“I’ve got something,” Yana said. “Maria’s zk-ID wasn’t terminated. It was tumbled through privacy relays, scrambled but still verifiable. Clever.”

Serafim’s voice was uneasy, but her eyes betrayed a glimmer of hope. “Looks like they zk-fragged her. She’s out there, scattered across sub-rollups, proofs without a parent.”

Then a hundred neon-red threads lit the dim room, like fresh wounds. Keys to Maria's consciousness flayed across hidden layers of the chain, suspended above them.

Yana's eyes blazed. "We'll find her. Have you forgotten who we are? We're the daughters of Gred. The ANGELS will rally behind us."

A cryptic message resolved across the projection before Dunya, calling them to action:

"In darkness lies truth, seek the nexus where shadows
converge."

The message matched the same compressed syntax that had threaded through her contracts and dreams, always circling darkness and convergence. Xenia, or someone using her channel, had been routing them for longer than Dunya wanted to admit.

A second alert arrived:

"Bring the drive. Dawn is our moment. The shadows have
shown us the path. It's time to act."

Dunya pocketed the drive. Whatever alliance sat behind the messages had finally stopped pretending this was coincidence.

Yana nodded toward the drive in Dunya's pocket. "That's the key to Zakharovna's kingdom. Let's make sure it's the one that locks her out."

CHAPTER FOURTY TWO

ZAKHAROVNA

The laboratory was her sanctuary of solitude, a world of steel and glass lit by the soft glow of bioluminescent fungi that clung to the shelves like otherworldly ornaments. Beneath the sterile hum of the equipment, Zakharovna stood before a vat containing her brother Alexei's preserved head, a grim keepsake and a wellspring of genetic material.

As Zakharovna's gloved hands guided the pipette, drawing out Alexei's DNA-laced preservation fluid, her thoughts turned to her brother. His bravery and idealism had carried him into a sea of his own making, one of appeasement and passionate but misguided beliefs. She remembered how his open-hearted policies, meant to soothe public unrest, had only left him vulnerable in the end.

That red-headed savage, she thought bitterly, *He saw Alexei's sincerity not as strength, but as a weakness to be exploited.* In the chambers of her thoughts, she drew a line between Alexei and herself; unlike her brother, she had always trod a path of careful detachment, always cognizant of the capricious sway of the masses.

She placed the genetic sample into a petri dish. The dish slid into a compartment in the wall, and with a series of swift keystrokes, she initiated the activation of the fungal blooms. The fungi responded, their luminosity intensifying as they absorbed the nutrient-rich substance she dispensed.

Her thoughts drifted back to Alexei, whose rebellious spirit had been both a beacon and a cautionary tale. He had navigated treacherous waters with an intrinsic boldness that she admired yet lacked the meticulous calculation that she now deemed essential. In the reflection of the vat's glass, her

own eyes met her gaze, and she reaffirmed silently: she would not indulge in his brand of idealism.

Turning away, Zakharovna approached a sleek, cylindrical device that stood imposingly next to her workbench. Her fingers grazed its surface before she reverently placed her brother's DNA sample within the receptacle. A soft chime signaled the machine's acceptance. She stood for a moment in contemplation, staring as the sample was encoded into the system.

The final act loomed before her, a mindgraft that promised a communion with the fragments of Alexei's consciousness left encoded in the last few drops of his brain cells. A sliver of trepidation passed through her as she attached the neural interface to her temple, a cold kiss against her skin. Her breathing steadied, her resolve firming with the promise of insight, or perhaps a final farewell.

Zakharovna reclined in the chair that unfurled from the base of the machine. Shadows danced across her face, cast by the fungi whose glow grew rhythmic, pulsing in time with the procedure's commencement.

She closed her eyes, awaiting the neurostream of the mindgraft. "Alexei," she breathed out, the name a silent invocation just before the world shifted, the electric rush of memories beckoning her into the depths of the simulation's embrace.

The world faded to black around Zakharovna, the immersive darkness briefly absolute, and then a vertigo of static rushed in, filling the void with chaotic white noise.

There she was, a solitary point of consciousness, reaching for a lifeline into her brother's mind. The mindgraft's tendrils probed her memories, searching for the synaptic echo that would lead her to Alexei.

One particular moment crystallized and drifted closer, a clandestine evening from their youth, shared in the cloistered corner of their father's den. They were huddled over the forbidden pages of *The Brothers Karamazov*. The delicate paper cracked under their touch. That book, a tome of moral complexity, had captivated them both, first in their youth and then more deeply as they grew older, its themes of faith, doubt, and brotherhood weaving into the fabric of their lives, right up until the day Alexei died.

A stirring of warmth ebbed through Zakharovna's being at the recollection, the emotional response to the trigger sharpening her focus. It was a sense of kinship, intense and sincere, that acted as the needed catalyst. Grief and pride, shared at the downfalls and triumphs that Dostoevsky had so eloquently penned, had bound them closer, their young minds ignited by the raw humanity leaping from the pages. Alexei, impassioned, had always been drawn to Dmitri's fervor, while she saw reflections of herself in the rational Ivan.

With their joint reverence for the novel as her compass, she could feel the static begin to dissipate, replaced by the burgeoning outline of her brother's thoughts and emotions.

She could almost hear Alexei's voice now, a disembodied murmur threading through the reverberating signal of the mindgraft. With tentative acceptance, she let the neurostream guide her along the conduit of their shared past, his essence growing clearer as she journeyed through layers of digital and genetic memory. The anchor was set, the connection made, and the darkness gave way to the unfolding panorama of his mind.

The immersive reality of the mindgraft settled, reshaping the blackness into the familiar yet distant outlines of Petropavlovsk's war-riven outskirts. Now an observer in her own memories, she watched her past self approach the command tent where Alexei oversaw the defenses. The siege was relentless, the silhouettes of armored vehicles looming beyond the Strangers' fortifications under a bruised sky.

Zakharovna's younger self entered the canvas tent flapping in the biting wind. Alexei turned, his face etched with the exasperations of leadership, but his eyes softened upon seeing his sister. "They're shelling the east ridge again," he said without preamble, gesturing towards the crude map sprawled across the table.

Zakharovna watched her past iteration leaning over the map, her fingers tracing the contours of the landscape that would soon become part of their new city. "If we can hold the ridge," her past self proposed, "it will give us the high ground. Once the Strangers retreat, the city could use the opportunity to rebuild...assert more control."

The very mention of 'control' had Alexei raising an eyebrow. "It's not just about control, sister. It's the people. They're restless, uncertain not just of their survival, but of what Gred will demand of them after."

"Have a little faith in me, brother," she stated confidently. "We will hold our ground against this tempest and stay true to who we've always been. And the people of Gred will know it too. They are not pawns to be swayed by the Strangers' silver tongues."

Alexei's expression softened; she knew he caught the weight in the new name, not bound by the old word—*grad*—but reaching beyond it, a promise in a world where no cities remained. "Then let's ensure our city lives up to its promise."

Let's give the people not just a refuge, but a foundation to build upon."

"And with the Babushka system, we have the means to quicken this rebirth. It is there, in the old base, ready to awaken and guide our hands."

"Let's hope Babushka's guidance is as sound as your strategy," Alexei murmured, the caution in his voice intriguingly at odds with the youthful glimmer in his deep blue eyes. Those eyes seemed untouched by his seventy-four years. Anastasia's gaze lingered on the familiar lines of his chiseled jaw, momentarily distracted by the contradiction between his weathered experience and the vigor those eyes betrayed. "The heart of this city will be its people, Anya. Not the whispers of the past, nor the cold logic of machines."

Zakharovna felt the pang of those words resonating through the years. Her past self had nodded, showing a semblance of agreement but inwardly always calculating, weighing the political scales.

"Rayan and Serafim?" her past self asked after a pause, the name 'Rayan,' igniting a visibly sharp reaction from Alexei.

"Xenia's teaching them survival games, things they think of as play," he admitted, his voice laden with a father's worry pressed into every syllable. "I've told them it's all a game, to keep them safe... But if something happens to me... I can entrust them to no one else. Certainly not to their mother, with her shadow games. I wouldn't want the kids caught in that world, especially without a father to guide them when this is all over." The strain in Alexei's voice escaped as a raw plea, "Can I count on you? Promise me, Anya?"

"With...but the serum, it's almost complete. You don't have to fear death, Alexei."

"I'm talking about war here, bullets and bombs, not old age," he stressed, his gaze intensifying. "Do you promise?"

“I promise,” she replied.

Even now, years beyond the confines of that memory, Zakharovna bore the burden of that promise like a shackle. She had failed them: Serafim, whom she had shielded from the bitter truths of her heritage and left a wildcard orphan deprived of her father’s story; Rayan, who had fallen prey to his mother’s twisted world, slipping further from her with every desperate attempt to hold on. A pang of regret twisted inside her, a sharp reminder that some vows, no matter how solemnly given, are tested in ways that can fracture even the most steadfast resolve.

The playback of this moment seemed poised on a knife’s edge, a harbinger of the turmoil Gred would come to know. As Alexei pored over battle strategies, a plan tugging at the corners of his tired lips, Zakharovna saw the beginning of the path that would claim him and leave her to rule as Gred’s second Chair.

Their conversation dwindled, and the future seemed to press into the silence between words left unsaid. The mindgraft’s embrace, delicate and unerring, carried Zakharovna through the shifting corridors of her past.

It delivered her to a time long ago, a memory from their younger days, tender with the simplicity of a world not yet shadowed by the complexities of war. In the refuge of the *dacha*, Alexei’s laughter cut through the stillness, a joyful echo from a time when their burdens were lighter and the windows let in not just light, but the promise of less disturbing tomorrows.

Orkon Sokolov, the young, spirited mechanic, stood as a vital part of their bond. His raven black hair and rugged, handsome features mirrored his dual nature: a rebel at heart and a shaman in the making. His strong, skilled hands were

as adept with machinery as they were with ancient rituals, and his voice carried the depth of the Mongolian steppes.

“You speak of tales and trust,” he greeted them, folding his tall frame into the familial space. “Yet, what is trust but the sacred bond of our forebears, honoring the earth beneath our feet?”

Alexei welcomed Orkon’s insights with a nod, the weight of the moment tucked into his gesture. He motioned for his friend to join them at the table, a wooden fixture that seemed far removed from the turmoil brewing beyond the walls of their dacha. “You speak of bonds and honor, Orkon,” he said, “yet outside, the world fractures.”

Alexei flicked a glance toward the muted glow of the television set in the corner, where the latest reports scrolled like omens of the age. Images of the President and the fragmenting Federation, splintered into ethnostates, played silently. Alexei continued, his words flecked with a sobering gravity, “The country’s collapse, mother’s tales—they echo each other. Bound by land, divided by visions, fighting against the incursion of outside forces.”

Orkon replied with a meditative air, “The Khalkha believe that the sky is one with the steppe. Does this not reflect in the tales of your mother’s reindeer across the tundra?”

“We all share the same sky, Khalkha and Koryak alike,” Alexei agreed, then launched into a tale of contrasting avian spirits that Zakharovna remembered well. “Far above, the eagle surveys its dominion, while the sparrow hugs close to the earth. Both are primary to the order of the world, the vastness of our skies.”

She watched her past self chuckle softly, a teasing glint in her eye as she addressed Alexei. “You and your balance, brother. I sometimes wonder if you would have us all fly at the same altitude to avoid any risk of discord.”

Orkon interjected, his voice a warm rumble, “Alexei speaks an essential truth, Anastasia. There’s strength in harmony, in the eagle seeing far and the sparrow seeing close.”

“Perhaps, but for all its virtues, balance is not the only rule. There are times when I would rather soar alone, my eyes fixed on the horizon, than flit among the tangled branches. And frankly, I tire of sparrows seeking sanctuary in my wings during ascent.”

Alexei leaned forward, playfulness dancing in his eyes. “We’ve each got our roles, Anya. Yours, the mind; mine, the heart,” he declared. “People follow you because you make sense. They follow me with the faith of feeling.”

Anastasia couldn’t help but smirk at her brother’s earnest assessment. “Too young to be this wise, Alexei,” she teased, the corners of her eyes crinkling with affectionate mockery. “And who exactly follows you? The attendants at the gas station?”

She leaned in, her voice tinged with playful provocation. “When are you finally going to fill out those university applications, hm? What will we have to talk about when I’m in Lithuania for school, and you’re still here, fishing, smoking, and—what was that last hobby of yours? Ah, yes, whoring around Petropavlovsk?”

Orkon glanced out at the Kamchatkan sky darkening against the windowpane before returning his gaze to his best friends, a mischievous glint in his eyes. “If you need support with the...whoring, Alexei, just say the word—I’m sure I could lend a hand,” he quipped, laughter bubbling up from deep in his chest.

He looked between Anastasia and Alexei, the lingering chuckles tapering into a more thoughtful smile. “As for me,” he added, running a hand through his long black hair, “I

suppose I'm the bridge where reason and spirit converge—a bit of head, a bit of heart.”

Alexei's eyes shifted over to Orkon with an amused sidelong glance, his arm sweeping through the air in an exaggerated arc to emphasize his point. “You're a bridge, my friend—between the world of what is and what might be. Between the sparrow's earthen nest and the eagle's lofty perch,” he said, clearly exulting in the theatrical flourish of his words.

Anastasia caught the mischief igniting in Orkon's gaze and sensed the playfulness burgeoning in the air. “Just be careful Orkon, bridges that connect two worlds can be quite the cross to bear—let's hope you don't collapse under the pressure.”

Orkon's laughter resonated, deep and sonorous, an exhale of genuine amusement before he leaped forward, his fingers finding Anastasia's sides in a series of calculated tickles. She erupted into involuntary peals of laughter.

As Anastasia tried to escape the relentless tickling, Orkon leaned in, a roguish twinkle playing in his deep-set eyes. “If my bridge falls to pieces, it'd be an honor for it to be at the hands—or should I say, laughter—of Kamchatka's most formidable mind,” he flirted, his chuckle low and inviting. “Though, perhaps a personal collapse wouldn't be so perilous, provided you're there to catch me.”

Alexei chimed in, a jesting tone lacing his words, “Careful, ‘brother-in-law’, your mechanic's hands might just find more work than they bargained for with this one. And don't get too comfortable, Putin still has a war to lose!”

“Oh, come on, Alexei. Orkon is like a brother to both of us. Enough with your teasing,” Anastasia protested, shaking her head but unable to suppress a smile.

She looked between the two young men, and then her expression grew more serious. “And damned if either of you are conscripted in this blasted war.”

Orkon paused, his mirth fading. “Agreed. You know, my baba was talking about the lobster stocks in Norway—how they’re collapsing because they only produce female offspring.” The corners of Orkon’s mouth twitched upwards. “Imagine if that happened to people! There’d be no war, just... Alexei and I reigning supreme, the last men in a vast sea of women.”

Anastasia shook her head. “The two of you? Supreme? With women? Please, the day that happens, you’ll both be first in line for therapy,” she teased back, drawing another round of wholehearted laughter from the trio.

As the chuckles subsided, they settled into the contented glow of the candlelight. Here, in the flickering shadows, they were a family, a united front in the face of a world teetering on the precipice of monumental transformation.

As the dacha scene dissolved and grapevine-like memories reached through the receding glow, Zakharovna was thrust into the stark, angular light of a different day: a day seared permanently into her own life’s design.

She found herself standing in a barren corridor of the makeshift headquarters, the air thick with a tension that coated her lungs like ash. It was quieter than it should have been, the usual clangor of orders and boots on metal floors suspiciously absent. Trailing the memoryscape, she rounded the corner and stopped short.

Before her, the austere lines of Alexei’s prone form stood in stark contrast against the dull gray of the concrete. The once-strong pulse of hope lay still, his shirt crimson with blood, a wound torn through their cause and through her spirit. This was the fulcrum, the moment when her understanding of revolution, of humanity, and of brotherhood began to twist into something unrecognizable.

Zakharovna watched as her past self stepped forward, numb, her hand trembling as it reached out to touch Alexei's lifeless shoulder. Her mind contorted, struggling against the visceral vice of reality squeezing her chest until she could hardly breathe. Denial rose first, a futile whisper in the back of her mind, insisting that her brother, her twin, her counterpoint in all things, could not simply be gone.

Beneath her fingertips, his skin was cooling rapidly, but she couldn't bring herself to withdraw her touch. "Alexei," she murmured, a tremulous plea to the absent warmth, to the vanished spark in his blue eyes that had always promised tomorrow.

Her vision blurred, hot tears welling unbidden; it was the cold clasp of Orkon's supportive hand on her shoulder that drew her back, reminding her of duty, of the war that raged on even as her world narrowed to the space of loss beneath her hand.

It would be hours before she realized she hadn't taken a full breath since discovering him, and days still before she would hear the whispered speculations, the silent inquiries. Who? How? Why?

Vengeance, a flame once distant to her, now ignited with sudden ferocity, clawing its way into her being.

She felt Orkon's resolve beside her, his silence carrying both grief and respect for their fallen comrade. He was the pillar, the strength that held her steady even as her own flesh and blood grew colder.

In her gut, a roaring emptiness expanded with the realization of the void Alexei's death would leave in the cause they had nurtured together. She was now singular in a fight that had, until then, been defined by their duality of mind and heart, reason and belief. What was balance without its counterweight?

She looked at Alexei's still face one last time, and a quiet declaration carved itself into her heart. She whispered a vow over his body, a promise to protect the innocents he had safeguarded and to take vengeance on the forces that had torn him away. It was a vow to forge on, to wage war not only with intellect but with the steel pulse of passion Alexei had carried within him.

The mindgraft transitioned her to a cavernous hollow where the air was thick with ice and malice. Her Black Wolf commanders flanked her, the old women a silent, deadly phalanx in their black carbon-fibre armor, their silvery hair beaming against the darkness.

In the center of this shadowy amphitheater stood Nikolai Bocharov, once the incarnation of loyalty and strength in Alexei's ranks. Now shackled, his arresting fire-red hair flared defiantly against the restraint of his bonds. They had found him skulking on the fringes of their territory, meeting with an unidentified Strangers' envoy. His capture had been as swift and silent as his treachery, a sheaf of intercepted communications clutched in a Black Wolf commando's grasp, damning evidence of his role in Alexei's demise.

Anastasia's eyes, as cold and hard as the ice that shrouded their hideout, bore into Nikolai's. "You have sown treachery, and now you shall reap the vengeance you deserve," she vowed, her voice betraying no sign of the turmoil that had wracked her in the hours and days leading up to this confrontation.

"I will dismantle you, piece by piece," Anastasia promised with terrifying tranquility. "And each detached part will serve a purpose you never respected in life—furthering the very science you tried to stifle." Each word was a nail, meant not for his coffin, but for his consciousness; a taunt designed to terrorize as much as it was to condemn.

Her first move was deliberate, a pair of forceps in hand, reaching out and clamping down firmly on Nikolai's finger. With a twist, she clipped it off.

His agonized wails reverberated off the cave's walls, each sound a split fiber in the fabric of her own humanity. Yet she continued, her actions detached and methodical, removing appendages, gathering each specimen with clinical indifference.

The Black Wolves watched in silence. This retribution was no act of pleasure but of necessity. They all knew the cost of betrayal, the danger of letting a cancer like Nikolai's treachery spread unchecked.

Nikolai's voice rasped into silence, his screams fading to gurgles as Anastasia precisely split his larynx. Each snip severed more than tissue, taking his voice as surely as her own cries for justice had once gone unheard.

The cavernous resonance stilled as an ominous silence lingered, punctuated only by the sinister hiss of Nikolai's femur as it met the corrosive embrace of the acid bath within the container at Anastasia's feet.

"Your legacy ends here," Anastasia murmured to herself as she gazed upon the viscous soup of organs and bones who had betrayed them all. "I will untether your entire bloodline from this world as surely as I have freed you from your treachery."

The science Anastasia carried out in that shadowed grotto wore the mask of cold calculation, the preservation of order through the eradication of chaos. Yet she knew it was vengeance that drove her, guiding her hand with relentless force. She would carry the dark title of avenger in one hand while raising the banner of protector with the other, her brother's legacy divided and alive in her every breath, every motion, every decision.

As she completed her grim task, the mindgraft loosened its hold, its tendrils retracting as the shadows of the cave receded. The swirling current of memory and sensation began to ebb, a signal of her imminent return to the present, a present carved and colored by the shadows of Alexei's absence.

"Kirov," she said. His familiar figure materialized in the lab, a silent question in his stance. "Ready the assault. Bring me the girl's head. Prepare a new test tube to hold it." She already pictured the morbid keepsake, a final trophy in her grim menagerie of revenge.

CHAPTER FOURTY THREE

DATA ANGELS

Dunya met Serafim's gaze, the bay window behind her framing a silhouette against the sweep of the grounds. The glass carried a faint reflection of Dunya's own face, blurred, as if she were already half gone.

"With the World Tree decrypted, we can branch into the network, touch any mind linked within. It's our path in, and our only way out," Serafim said.

The mansion pressed harder than its walls. Outside it was wealth and fences. Inside, a sanctum for machines. The central chamber pulled her attention back again to the woman at its core. Xenia Fedorova sat in a throne of circuits, ash-grey hair woven into cables feeding the floor and ceiling. Runes hung in the air, symbols alive with a logic Dunya could not follow.

She had walked past the gardens earlier, seen the statues and the neatly trimmed hedges. Now she imagined the turrets behind them, the drones circling high above, all of it tuned to Xenia's thoughts. Even her eyes carried that same mechanical certainty, softening and hardening without warning. Was she watching a woman who had mastered her tools or a woman already absorbed by them?

The cube in her palm gave another pulse, small but insistent. Each throb set her teeth on edge. She tightened her grip, afraid she might drop it. Yana touched her shoulder, fingers light but firm, and Dunya felt the weight in her chest ease by a fraction.

At the bay window, Serafim started up the stairs, the railgun steady in her arms. She gave Dunya a look before turning back. At Xenia's command, steel shutters slammed

into place, cutting off the view of the grounds. Dunya drew a slow breath. The helmet slid down over her head, Yana's glow catching the edge of her vision as she followed. Light from the cube flared, and the chamber around them thinned. Breath by breath, heartbeat by heartbeat, the world unraveled into another.

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Light fractured, bending in prismatic whispers around her. Dunya's hands, once steady on the cube's angular edges, now grasped at tendrils of something slipping between presence and void. The familiar hum that signaled her dives into virtual realms felt heavier this time, each pulse syncing with her heartbeat. *This is it. No running left. Just her and me.*

The walls and windows were gone. The World Tree loomed above her, its spiraling trunks of stark white bound with abyssal black, cleaving the heavens. At its base, a lone hill rose from the endless expanse. Light bled across the sky in strokes of cobalt and pink. Dawn or dusk, she couldn't tell, and it didn't matter. *None of this is real.*

On the hill at the tree's base stood the machine, the altar of perversion that pulsed with stolen life. Dunya's stomach turned. She had come to expect the sight, though dread always followed. Bodies were fused into its grotesque frame, unwilling parts of its endless hunger. They seemed bound to the tree yet cut off from it, tethered here at this grim crossing of worlds.

Then a figure came into view, though shadows kept its form unclear. Dunya knew who it was without seeing her face, the certainty striking like a blow. A prickle ran along her arms. Around the hill, green shapes swarmed in sudden jubilation,

their movement unsettling in its fervor, like wardens exalting a place that mocked life itself.

A beam of light slanted across the altar, burning through the shadows. The silhouette sharpened against a sky alive with tropical birds and falling streaks of light. *Doctor Anastasia Zakharovna Zakharova*. The slate crimson of her jacket seemed to fuse with the geometry of the world. Red-tinted goggles caught the glow, gleaming like embers in the code-stitched twilight. The whole scene moved at her cues, followers clustered close, their motions tethered to hers as if none dared to stray.

Closest to her, new shapes glowed an intense blue. Dunya squinted, trying to keep them straight. Among them hovered a woman with auburn hair, her green eyes piercing the haze with an almost unnatural clarity. Beside her drifted another form, shrouded in a patterned fur coat, bleach-blond hair catching the ghostly light, her blue eyes reflecting the binary suns of the fabricated cosmos above.

Next came an older man, wisps of dark hair stirring in a breeze Dunya could not feel, gray threading his beard. Leather trappings and a wolfbone necklace marked him with the air of a primal chieftain dropped into the middle of a high-tech ritual.

And then she saw her. The violet of her hair caught the light, impossible to mistake. The sight struck Dunya like a blade, wound and balm at once, dragging old memories raw to the surface. She searched Vesna's face, desperate to hold it, as if by staring she might anchor the past against the tide that had already carried it away.

Dunya's breath caught as her gaze settled on the next figure. The recognition hit like a jolt, sharper than any blow. *Maria*. Her friend—more than that, the one who had steadied her when everything else broke—now stood glowing, a captive

in this strange assembly. *Of course, it's her. It's always her. Zakharovna would never leave her out of this.* The thought seared through, ache tangled with the bitter knowledge she had expected this yet still hoped against it.

The captives rose, statues given life, their glow pulsing like heartbeats in the dark. *All of them, trapped.*

Dunya drew in a hard breath. The choice was clear now, no more hesitation. She looked to Yana, who met her gaze and gave a single steady nod.

Gravity fell away as Dunya threw herself into the chasm, Yana a heartbeat behind. Air rushed past, alive with the charge of collision. She felt Yana close, a tether of shared defiance. Light streaked in their wake as they plunged toward Zakharovna and the waiting assembly below.

The ground met her with a ripple, a tremor rising through her boots and spreading outward, breaking the crowd's stillness. The vibration hung in the air, announcing their arrival without a word.

Zakharovna, ringed by loyalists, turned sharply. For an instant Dunya thought she caught surprise in those cold eyes. Satisfaction surged through her at the crack in that composure.

The crowd shifted like a hive stirred, murmurs rippling outward. The prisoners' glow faltered, blue light wavering, and for a breath she thought she saw hope spark there.

The noise swelled, bouncing off the towering trunks until it rattled in her chest. Faces in the crowd flickered with unease, expressions breaking as uncertainty spread at the sight of the two of them standing against it all.

Zakharovna stepped forward, and the noise fell around her. "Dunya," she said, her voice smooth and cutting, "I've been

waiting for this. Your echoes reached me, each one a cipher to savor.”

“If you knew, if you were deciphering my trail, then why let me run? Vesna could have handed me over. Why drag it out? Why the chase?”

“The hunt, dear Dunya, is nothing without the quarry’s flight. And fly you did, straight into my nest. How else would you have delivered me such bountiful souls?”

Guilt tightened in her gut. Yana’s hand found her arm; the squeeze cut through the turmoil.

“Enjoy your feast while it lasts, Doctor. We came to cut the cords, and when the captives go dark, you’ll starve.”

Zakharovna’s laughter cut through the murmurs, cold and triumphant.

“So like your father,” she said. “The same fire, the same stubborn will. He killed my brother—my twin. A bond severed, a life I should never have been forced to live without. Yet even that loss carved a path. Blood shapes ascension. Without his hand in it, I might never have seized Gred. His legacy, your legacy, lies at the root of my empire.”

Each word pressed heavier on her chest. She knew the stories—heroism, sacrifice, all told to steady her—but here, in Zakharovna’s mouth, they turned to mockery, a perverse thanksgiving.

Her father, who had fought for freedom, was reduced to a prop in Zakharovna’s tale. Desecration. A twist of the struggle that had cost so many—cost him—everything. *He didn’t fight to be a footnote in your climb, Zakharovna.* His spirit lived in her, and she would not let it be tarnished.

Dunya locked eyes with Zakharovna. “Go ahead and twist my father’s story, Anastasia. Call his sacrifice whatever suits

you. But this is where your tale ends. We are not your feast. We are your reckoning.”

“Is that so?” Zakharovna purred. “You’ve been so punctual in answering my summons. Every cipher you unraveled, every enigma you cracked—it brought you here.”

Dunya cut in. “Don’t flatter yourself. Xenia guided me, not you.”

Zakharovna’s smile flickered, then settled. “Xenia. A bright flame, yes. But flames burn out. I’ll have what’s left of her soon enough.”

The followers pressed closer, the circle tightening like a noose. Dunya felt Yana shift at her side, steady as ever, weight balanced forward. That presence anchored her.

Zakharovna leaned in, eyes gleaming with cold certainty. “And now you stand at the heart of my snare. The feast has been rich, thanks to your efforts. But the final piece, the soul I’ve waited for...” Her gaze locked on Dunya. “Yours, Ms. Bocharov.”

The threat pressed close, sharp and unavoidable. Dunya’s heart hammered, each beat a drum in her ribs. *This isn’t your checkmate, Zakharovna. I’m not a prize for your collection.*

She squared her shoulders. “I cracked every code you set in my path. While you hunted me, I planted seeds of my own. Now watch them bloom, and watch your kingdom fall.”

Her words hit the air and the expanse shivered. Glitches rippled at the edges of her sight, the scene stuttering. Shapes in the crowd faltered, composure slipping.

At her side Yana held firm, weight forward, eyes on the circle closing around them. She leaned close, voice steady in her ear. “You lit the fuse, Dunya. Now we see it burn.”

Zakharovna's expression shifted, as if the words had carried to her all the same. A flicker, a hairline crack in the calm. For the first time it felt as though the weight between them tipped her way. Dunya braced for what came next.

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Crouched on the mansion's balcony, Serafim settled behind the railgun, its weight and angles as familiar as bone. She tapped through the interface, each diagnostic another drill etched into muscle memory. The barrel gave off a faint glow in the dusk, coils humming as the core climbed toward full charge. On the readout, the counter ticked upward, silent and lethal. A low buzz carried through her palms as the capacitors fattened with power, each slug primed to tear the air apart. Below, the grounds stretched in unnatural stillness, waiting for the first strike.

On her overlay, Xenia shimmered in the pale wash of projected light, silent and intent. The hum of the mansion pressed against Serafim's ears, a faint vibration she could almost feel through the balcony rail. Xenia's gaze darted across the feeds, movements sharp enough to remind Serafim of a machine parsing inputs. With each shift of her hand, another system came alive, and the house seemed to rouse under her command.

The Black Wolves shifted below, a wall of dark armor against the fading light. The order in their ranks clawed at her, too close to Rayna's world of drills and commands. That life had caged her twin, and now its weight pressed into Serafim's grip on the trigger. The encrypted message pulsed in her mind, its coded debts and duties spelled out with cruel clarity. Every line had pointed her here. Every word demanded she act.

Her throat felt tight as she forced the words out. “Xenia. They’re here.”

“Begin,” Xenia said, and the mansion stirred to life. Turrets slid out from their hiding places, metal grinding as they unfolded for the kill. From the far corners of the grounds, drones lifted into the darkening sky, their whine sharp against the night.

The Black Wolves halted at the edge of the grounds. It looked like hesitation, though she could not tell if it was fear of the mansion or something else. Either way, the pause carried its own threat, like a bow drawn and waiting to loose.

“Remember, Sera,” Xenia’s voice was a crackle of ice, “we fight not just for today, but for all our tomorrows.”

Serafim forced herself steady, muscles locked against the tremor in her chest. She knew the cost of failure, the price of her sister’s life measured against the many. Duty and love tore at her, and she prayed for forgiveness. Between one soul and thousands stretched a gulf she could barely face.

The Black Wolves advanced. The first wave struck with raw force, the air shuddering under gunfire and tearing metal. Bullets cut past her, some punching drones out of the sky in bursts of fire, others breaking against Xenia’s magnetic shields with a crack that lit the dusk in brief sparks.

Her grip tightened on the railgun. Each burst hammered her shoulder as slugs ripped across the lawn, gouging bright paths through the dark. On her display the counter ticked down, every shot pulling her closer to a reload. Below, the Wolves pressed on, cutting down the dwindling drones. One fighter dropped to a knee, steadying her rifle before snapping a shot into the sky.

The night air stank of burnt circuits and gunpowder. On her display, Xenia’s face flickered in the pale wash of

projections, steady at her post, though the tension in her eyes betrayed the effort.

Hold them, Serafim told herself, firing another burst into the dark. But we cannot last. Dunya. Yana. It has to be you now.

“They’re breaching the east wing,” Xenia’s voice cut through the neural link.

On her overlay, Serafim watched the response ripple outward: walls thickened into bulwarks, garden paths twisted into traps beneath the Wolves’ boots. Drones flared and fell one after another, their numbers dropping too fast.

“We are only buying time,” Xenia added, the words flat, unshaken.

The truth pressed in on Serafim as she gripped the railgun tighter.

The battle raged, each breath grinding against the weight of the decision. The message pressed at the edge of her mind, insistent and clear. She could end it all, surrender and walk free, but at what cost?

The Wolves kept coming. Serafim tracked their advance, reading the drive in every step and shot fired. She knew it too well. The same hunger had once pulled at her, the promise of power that never let go. It was the shadow she fought now, her own urge for control against the thin chance of redemption.

Gunfire swept across the grounds. Her chest tightened with every burst, the line she held fraying under the assault. The choice inside her hardened.

She would not yield. Not while Xenia fought beside her, not while the mansion still held. With a vow to Rayna burning in her chest, Serafim slammed in a fresh slug, eyes fixed on the horizon where the Wolves advanced.

Reality folded in on itself, a kaleidoscope of memory and code entwining as Dunya pushed forward through the labyrinth Zakharovna had conjured. Each step dragged her deeper, the ground shifting like a thought she could not pin down.

Yana moved at her side, quick and sure, strokes of her stylus cutting into the dark. Sparks flared with every motion, trails of light knitting into shields that caught the blows meant for them, then hardened into blades that struck back. To Dunya it looked like she was painting the air, the world bending wherever her lines touched.

Firewalls burst from the ground like jagged spires, their glow radiating heat that wasn't real yet still made Dunya flinch. Malware slithered along the corridors, shapes of hunger and teeth, but Yana's light scattered them, her laughter ringing clear, cutting through the static.

Dunya answered in kind. She drew the railgun into being the way she had in past dives, fingers pulling lines of code into form until the weight settled in her hands. The weapon hummed with raw force, and when she fired, the recoil jolted her shoulder, the round tearing a burning groove through the dark.

Shapes reeled into view, tall and lanky, mottled skin flickering between flesh and translucence. Each bore a single large eye, its glassy stare sweeping like a searchlight. One lunged, limbs too long for its body, and she fired again, the slug splitting it into static. Another rushed, only to crumple under Yana's flashing strokes.

More swarmed from the sides, their bodies twisting in unnatural rhythm. Dunya fired until the corridor shook with the echoes, every shot a claim of ground, every step forward a refusal to give it back.

Then one staggered but did not dissolve. Its eye stretched wide, its skin warping as the shimmer coalesced. The mottled patterns smoothed, lines of a face emerging where none should be. Dunya froze, the railgun trembling in her grip. She knew what she was seeing. A memory. One Zakharovna had stolen, reshaped, and set against her.

The creatures pressed in, and Yana's glow dimmed, her figure thinning into static. Dunya's chest clenched. She felt in her gut that Yana was still there, only forced into her own snare.

The first echo hit with a jolt that staggered her. A memory made manifest. Dugal stood before her, whole as if pulled straight from the past. His smile caught her off guard, the curve of it so vivid it hurt. Then the crack split the air again, sharp and merciless. She saw him jolt, head snapping back, and she was there once more, helpless in the moment Zakharovna's rifles had ended it.

The railgun sagged in her hands. It wasn't just Dugal falling; it was the house they were going to build, the nights they'd sworn they had left, the laughter that was supposed to carry them through. All of it gone in a heartbeat, all of it laid bare again before her, sharpened into a weapon meant to break her.

The creature wore his face, his manner, even the sound of his voice when it tried to speak. She wanted to answer, to cling to what was left, but every word and every gesture bent under Zakharovna's hand, turning love into a chain.

Yana flickered back into view, her glow muted, shoulders bowed as if she too had walked through ghosts. For a moment her eyes looked hollow, then she steadied and reached out.

Her hand settled on Dunya's shoulder, anchoring her. The touch carried no words, only resolve, the kind they had always shared in silence. Dunya drew a breath. Dugal's laughter would never return, but the cause he had died for still burned, and neither of them would let it gutter out here.

"You're not alone," Yana whispered.

Tears blurred her sight as Dunya lifted the railgun. Her finger tightened, the shot flaring through the echo. She cried as his face shattered into static, grief and defiance bound in the trigger's pull.

The next echo dragged her into the ambulance, her body aflame, skin raw and ruined. Vesna's silhouette leaned over her, voice cold with feigned concern. *"You'll never survive without me."*

The scorn in her eyes had once cut deep, a dismissal that threatened to smother what strength Dunya had left. Now the words only hardened her. *Survive without you? No, Vesna. I didn't just survive. I lived.*

The specter faltered, then bled away into static, the echo unable to withstand her defiance. Dunya clung instead to the memory of the sister she had once known, the strength that still burned beneath the layers of loss and betrayal.

The corridor stretched wider, opening into an opulent chamber. Her chest tightened with each beat of her heart. Heavy drapes sealed the windows, their folds thick and suffocating. The air carried polish and citrus, familiar and false at once; Zakharovna had scavenged it straight from the ruins of her mind.

Then he stepped forward, his silhouette spilling long shadows across the Dagestani carpets. Her body locked, limbs heavy, as if her muscles still remembered the shattering of bone, the weight that had crushed her into silence.

His hand lifted and the air thickened with it, the memory of a theft that could never be undone.

For a moment she faltered, but the memory did not end there. She saw again the knife she had hidden, the flash of steel, the arc of red that marked her escape.

She crawled through snow until her arms gave out, dragging herself forward inch by inch, each breath torn from her lungs, until Dugal found her. His arms closed around her like walls against the storm, carrying her into warmth and healing.

They had been lovers before that room. Husband and wife, workshop and stove and stupid drawings of apprentices. The assault had not created their bond; it had tried to turn that bond into proof that nothing private could survive the city. Dugal found her anyway, carried her into warmth, and stayed close without pressing, a steady presence that told her without words that no one would touch her without answer again.

"Hey, you." His voice stirred in her mind, warm and steady, a tether pulling her back from the abyss.

She tried to give the photograph the old morning words. *Hey, you.* Her mouth would not quite shape them. What came out was smaller. "I'm here."

The memory steadied her. Dugal had stayed without deciding what recovery should look like. He had waited until she could choose for herself.

The labyrinth shifted again. Reality loosened, memories unraveling like strands of code pulled apart. Through the haze another figure emerged, Maria's form taking shape before her.

They were at the Night Café, a refuge after a mission pulled off clean. A worn jazz record played in the background, its notes drifting with the soft clatter of cups and the low murmur of tired voices. The air carried the scent of croissants and steam rising from chipped mugs. In that half-lit booth, their friendship had taken root, shaped by shared secrets and laughter too quiet for anyone else to hear.

Maria's lips moved, but her voice broke apart, a signal stuttering through static. Dunya leaned closer, trying to catch the pieces. Words flickered in and out, sharp with urgency. Don't trust Serafim. The warning fractured again, then reformed in a desperate whisper. "Leave now. Zakharovna... She's too powerful."

Doubt pressed in, sharp and unwelcome. Dunya tried to push it away, but a sliver of her knew Maria's warning carried truth.

"You remember...the vault on Zephyr...mural with the red dragon..." The voice faltered through static, each word broken but unmistakable. Only they had been there, the night they swore to guard each other's backs.

The Zephyr reference verified her more cleanly than the face. "The red dragon," Dunya said. "You remembered the right wall." Her throat tightened. "I'm not leaving you in here."

Maria smiled, faint and strained. "Still checking the details."

Her form wavered and slipped into the dark. The memory could still be bait, but whoever built it knew enough to matter.

Zakharovna's voice slithered through the chaos. "You bring me souls, Ms. Bocharov, and yet you cling to your own so desperately. Why? You're almost there. Let go."

Zakharovna had narrowed the available choices until surrender looked voluntary, then dressed the result up as revelation. Dunya recognized the architecture.

"You're a vulture with root access, Anastasia. You wait until people are damaged, then call what you take a gift. You got into my memories. You still don't own them."

△△△

The mansion's walls felt paper-thin against the Black Wolves' siege. She toggled between feeds, seized manual control of drones, and pushed emergency defense protocols that Xenia could no longer keep up with.

Concussions rattled the floor, vibrations running up through her boots. Overhead lights flickered with each staccato blast of artillery hammering the stronghold. She locked on the screens, refusing to look away.

The message looped again, each word digging deeper. Ray's voice carried its desperation, the faint crack in a tone that never used to break. The ache in her chest told her what she already knew; the choice had never been a choice.

Memories cut through the noise of battle. They had shared everything, every secret, every dream, bound tighter than blood. Almost everything. *There was more I never told her. I kept the aunt to myself.*

Politics in Gred had stained that innocence. Her mother's schemes had driven them into the crash, not to break the twins apart but to shape a destiny she claimed would shield them from power's crosshairs.

Her sister's death had been staged, Rayna hidden and given another life in the veil of the feminine. Serafim was left to Zakharovna's cold care, shaped by silence. She felt like a ghost, the secret Zakharovna carried, the truth kept locked away. Every step of her life had been carved by others, always kept out of sight.

Now, miles and worlds apart, the bond still dragged at her, heavy and inescapable. She could not shake the presence behind it all, the one who had set the trap. Rayna's life hung by a thread, and the cut was hers to make.

The outer defenses gave way, and the weight of it pressed in on her. Each enemy cut down through Xenia's systems, each barrier raised, only carried her closer to the choice she could not escape. Betray the cause that had carried her through loss or sacrifice the other half of her soul.

The mansion groaned under the barrage. Dust sifted down, soft as snow.

Xenia's voice cracked through the comms, clipped with strain. "We're holding them. I don't know for how long." Her avatar flickered on the screen.

"I know what I need to do," Serafim said.

Static cracked through the comms, and then her sister's voice filled the room.

"Sera. I trust you."

"Ray." The word slipped out, barely more than breath, though her chest screamed it.

The screens blurred as her vision stung. For a heartbeat she faltered. Then the truth settled. Rayna's trust had never been a weight. It had carried her, always.

She started the sequence to cut the mansion's power.

Shadows of the Black Wolves stretched through broken windows as they closed in. Serafim chose. Her sister. Her cause. The faint chance that saving one could still mean saving both.

△△△

Zakharovna lay beneath her at last. Dunya's arm shook, but the containment routine held ready beneath her skin, waiting on one final input.

"You took my father and used his death as leverage. You turned Maria into an asset, Vesna into a weapon, and my memories into an access route." Her grip tightened. "You keep calling it immortality because theft sounds worse."

Zakharovna's followers closed in. Beside Dunya, Yana drew another shield through the air, holding the shapes back.

"Why hesitate, Dunya?" Zakharovna said. "Strike as you could not when Nikolai's fate was in your hands."

"I'm done letting you frame the options."

Dunya checked the routine again by instinct. It had passed every test she could run. The command now waited on her decision.

Dunya shivered. The rhythm slipped, a beat gone wrong that grew louder with each passing second. She looked to Yana and caught the same unease in her eyes.

"Something's not right," Dunya said.

Before Yana could answer, the world split. The sky tore open, light shearing into chaos. A wave slammed through her, not only here but bleeding into her body outside, a surge that bound the two worlds in shared collapse.

She was torn from her shock by a sinking feeling. Someone had opened a door, and what waited outside was already pouring in.

“You see, my dear, it’s not just the machines that can be programmed to turn. Hearts can be re-coded, too. You thought you were soaring proud and high, but you were just fluttering in my wing. Now, with everything I need in my grasp, your role is done. Fly away, Ms. Bocharov, or fall—it matters little to me now.”

Zakharovna shimmered out of view, leaving only a void where she had been.

Dunya’s jaw tightened, venom rising with the echoes she left behind. At the edge of her sight, magnetic bursts flared like silent lightning, casting brief light over the emptiness.

In the stillness came the chill. Something had shifted. A lag in response, a flicker at the edge of the sim, a hesitation in the world itself; all of it pointed to a hand pulling strings through a hidden backdoor.

She met Yana’s eyes. “Turns out the angel we trusted was a damn snake.”

△△△

Alarms wailed and screens blinked. Serafim’s fingers hovered above the console. She froze, the same hesitation that had gripped her since the message arrived.

She pressed the button. The room stayed silent, though she felt the weight of it crash through her chest.

The strike hit back through the system, humming in her chest. The mansion shuddered, defenses collapsing. Hope broke with them. Hers. Dunya’s. Yana’s.

As the Black Wolves commenced their final assault, the screens showed them swarming through the gaps Serafim had opened.

At the heart of the mansion, Xenia's systems stuttered. Nothing she threw at the swarm could hold it back.

The mansion's walls trembled. Lights flickered, then the power cut. In the surveillance feeds, Serafim saw the girls' connection to the embattled digital world cut off. Helmets were removed in a daze, as the two were unwittingly yanked back into the tangible chaos, disorientation mirrored in their stunned expressions.

She braced as their faces filled the feed. Dunya's eyes read her like always, cutting through her like a blade.

Serafim caught the turmoil in Dunya's eyes as they seemed to meet hers across the digital divide. Dunya's voice reverberated through the speakers. "You...you were our sister in arms."

"I had...no choice," Serafim heard herself say. The words felt hollow as they left her lips, their truth as empty as the broken promise they represented.

Yana's stare pinned her, even through the dead link. Then Yana pulled Dunya away. Their steps faded in the audio, leaving Serafim with the silence of what she had broken.

Alone, she stood still, chest tight, waiting for the end.

The mansion erupted in gunfire once more. The enemy had breached the core. Bullets tore through the room she had once fought so fiercely to protect. On the monitor, Xenia jerked in her chair. Wires snapped and whipped as bullets tore through her.

Alarms screamed. Gunfire pounded. She had spared her sister. Relief should have followed, but it only weighed heavier. The resistance was gone, their stronghold broken, and the

choice was hers alone. She had ensured Rayna's life at the expense of a cause once held dear. As the Black Wolves closed in, she knew it was the end. She closed her eyes to a world she could no longer protect.

The door blew inward and Black Wolves stormed through. Bullets ripped the air, slamming into her body one after another. She barely felt them, only dull thuds numbing her mind.

Her vision blurred. The last thing she saw was Dunya and Yana vanishing into the smog. Their escape was the only solace left.

Darkness closed in. Her last thought was a plea, not for herself but for some chance at redemption.

ΔΔΔ

[22:04] System: Secure channel established. Encryption protocol engaged.

[22:05] MotherNull: MindMaven is offline. The chain's integrity is compromised.

[22:05] IronDove: Confirm source immediately.

[22:06] DustScript: Confirmed. Node status is now offline.

[22:06] ShieldMother: Status of our redundancies?

[22:06] LedgerLush: Backups are operational but require primary node support.

[22:07] ClauseViper: Stabilization protocol must be our immediate action.

[22:07] WayZero: Who's in proximity to MindMaven's last coordinates?

[22:08] Sporeline: My position aligns. Commencing rerouting protocols now.

[22:08] ClauseViper: Ensure all data from MindMaven's workload is secured.

[22:09] Sporeline: Adjusting my workload to accommodate network strain.

[22:09] MnemonicGhost: Consensus duties should be reallocated to maintain equilibrium.

[22:10] PulseBinder: Investigate for potential security threats.

[22:10] EchoWitch: Initiate a full security audit. No delay.

[22:10] ContinuumCrone: We must not forget to honor MindMaven's contribution as we proceed.

[22:11] Sporeline: Zakharovna's next course of action must be anticipated.

[22:11] MnemonicGhost: The girl's failure to fulfill her destiny was an unforeseen variable.

[22:12] DustScript: Zakharovna may attempt Babushka integration. Bolster defense measures.

[22:12] LedgerLush: Preparing for inevitable Babushka defense scenarios.

[22:13] IronDove: We must stay vigilant. Zakharovna thrives in times of chaos. Keep watching.

[22:14] System: Connection instability detected. Initiating countermeasures.

CHAPTER FOURTY FOUR

ZAKHAROVNA

The city flickered past in brief, fractured glimpses through the tinted glass, neon smears and hollow lights pulsing like the last breath of nightlife. Zakharovna watched without focus, her reflection shifting with every turn. The engine's hum steadied her thoughts, low and constant. Red light traced along the cabin's edges, casting her hands in muted warmth. The scent of leather lingered, sharp beneath the sterile tang of circuitry. It almost felt as if the car itself were straining to imitate life.

Zakharovna reached for the crystal decanter and poured the deep blue liquid into her glass. The light above caught on its surface, turning it violet for a moment. She stirred the blueberry daiquiri with quiet focus, each motion deliberate and steady. When she finally took a sip, her eyes closed, not in pleasure but in habit, as if the taste anchored her to something she could still control.

Across from her, Vair flickered into view, her presence hovering between light and memory. Blonde hair fell in familiar waves over a white fur coat, the kind she used to wear even when it wasn't cold. Her eyes carried that same teasing warmth Zakharovna remembered, softened now by distance, like light filtered through ice.

"I see you're actually finishing your drink for once," Vair said, her voice soft and amused, a ghost of laughter beneath the words.

Zakharovna studied the nearly empty glass, the last trace of blue clinging to the rim. "It seems the long drought of our times has finally relented."

She rolled the liquid once more before setting the glass down. "My ancestors were reindeer herders," she said, her tone softer now. "They believed the reindeer's spirit gave them endurance, that its strength carried them through the cold." A faint smile crossed her lips. "Blueberries meant famine back then. Now they sit in my glass like jewels. Fate has a strange sense of humor."

"A luxury born from hardship. It seems fitting for you, Anastasia."

"Vair, your help in consoling the souls we've captured has been invaluable. I once thought friends were a luxury I could not afford. But in these past few months, I've come to know so many. In the midst of our struggles, we find unexpected alliances, connections that endure, much like the reindeer adapting to the shifting seasons."

"Your resilience is unmatched, Anastasia. But remember, even the strongest spirits knew when to seek shelter from the storm. Have you made your final preparations?"

Zakharovna let the sentiment wash over her. Gently, she lifted her glass, toasting silently to Vair, to the echoes of the past, and the unwritten future. "Indeed, Vair. Seeking shelter is its own form of wisdom. Yet, the true essence lies in those with whom we choose to share it. I am ready. There is just one last soul to taste."

The limousine's gentle halt brought Zakharovna back to the present. She placed her glass on the smooth surface of the console, the last of the daiquiri's deep purple hue mirroring the night sky outside.

Zakharovna stepped out, her boots crunching on a carpet of debris. She was immediately enveloped by the stillness, her eyes scanning the ruins of Xenia Fedorova's mansion. The once formidable structure now lay in ruins, its former

grandeur still veiled by the smoke of fires only recently extinguished.

She moved with a predator's grace, each step measured and deliberate as she navigated through the wreckage. The night was eerily silent, the only sound the distant hum of her limousine's engines winding down, a faint reminder of order amid the ruin.

As she walked, the remnants of Xenia's last stand whispered their violent tales. Scorched walls bore the scars of energy blasts, and the ground was littered with the remnants of robotic assailants. Zakharovna's gaze lingered on a particularly large piece of debris, a remnant of a defense drone, its once lethal form a twisted metal carcass, now rendered impotent.

Ahead, Serafim's body lay sprawled, a fallen soldier in a war of ambition and betrayal. The Wolves had extracted her from the mansion's wreckage, carefully placing her corpse onto a broken door repurposed as a makeshift stretcher against the pristine snow. The contrast was stark—the untouched whiteness set against the lifeless form of the young woman she had raised since she was just a little girl. Her body was riddled with bullet wounds.

Such a waste, Zakharovna thought as she stood over Serafim's still form. She had everything, all of Maria's brilliance without the blinding ideology. *You were my finest student, a mind sharp and unburdened, a spirit unchained by dogmas.*

Her gaze settled on the still form before her, a knot of regret tightening in her chest. Such potential extinguished. *She could have been the architect of new worlds, a beacon in our pursuit.* Now she lay motionless, the echo of a dream Zakharovna had once dared to believe in.

Zakharovna's fingers gently brushed against a cold, metallic protrusion embedded in Serafim's chest. "You were more than the pawn you made yourself out to be, Serafim. And yet, in the end...all that potential..."

With a sigh, Zakharovna stood up, her gaze lingering on her niece for just a moment more. Then, with a subtle nod, she signaled to her Black Wolves. They moved in, efficiently and respectfully, lifting Serafim's body and carrying it off. They proceeded with measured steps, making their way to one of the ambulances trailing behind her limousine. "Store her with her father," Zakharovna ordered softly. "And be careful with her head."

Zakharovna turned her attention to the mansion. Each step she took seemed to echo in the stillness, a solemn drumbeat leading her to the final act of this tragedy. Xenia had been a formidable adversary, a worthy rival in the intricate dance of power. But in the end, she was just another node in the chain, a link that had now served its purpose.

Zakharovna paused at the entrance, the grand doors hanging off their hinges. She could sense the faint pulse of life within, a flickering candle in the overwhelming darkness.

The mansion's heart was in ruins. Amid the wreckage, Zakharovna found Xenia, tangled in the wreck of her own machines. Cables coiled around her limbs like restraints. Her breaths came shallow, ragged, yet still defiant.

Zakharovna approached, her steps echoing in the hollow expanse. "My old friend, you played your part well, but you overreached."

Xenia's eyes flickered with a fading light, her lips curling into a weak, bitter smile. "Anastasia, I always knew it would end like this. You and I, we are not so different."

"Our choices set us apart, Xenia. Our destinies are shaped not by resemblance but by actions." As she said these words,

they stirred a deep well of memory. Zakharovna's thoughts lingered on her brother then, the memory of him vivid and poignant, even after a decade. *Alexei Zakharov*. His gaze had been fixed on a horizon he would never reach, a legacy filled with possibilities and hope that had long been snuffed out.

In the wake of his absence, a void had yawned wide, a chasm of uncertainty and chaos. It was into this breach that Zakharovna had stepped, not just to fill the gap left by him but to forge her own path, imprinting *her* will upon the city with a rule distinctively her own.

"Sacrifice...it's a peculiar thing," she mused, more to herself than to Xenia. "To give oneself so completely to another, it's a concept I find...strangely noble, yet misguided. I wouldn't walk that path. Admirable? Perhaps. But in our world, such selflessness is often our doom. It's these choices that define us, Xenia. Not our blood, but our actions. They carve out who we are, who we become."

Xenia coughed through red-stained teeth. "Power...it's always about power with you. And the girl...she's the key, isn't she? The key you lost," she added, her voice laced with a taunting edge.

Zakharovna paused, her thoughts drifting to Dunya. "The girl is but a part of a larger design. A design you sought to unravel for your gain. I will have her...eventually."

Xenia let out a raspy, mocking laugh, repeating the word with a taunt in her voice. "Eventually?" Her breathing grew more labored, yet her defiance remained sharp. "And you, submitting to the grand web, seeking eternity... Are you not afraid? Afraid of losing yourself to its depths?"

"No. I seek the preservation of order. Your free web would have led us into chaos."

"In your *order*, Anastasia, lies a tyranny...a tyranny of *one*." Xenia's voice was faint, the words barely more than a breath.

“Better one,” Zakharovna said, “than the anarchy of many.”

Xenia’s chest lifted once more in a faint, uneven breath. The defiance in her eyes dimmed by degrees until only a fragile light remained. Then even that faded, leaving her gaze unfocused and still. Her last words emerged, a whisper, “In our quest for control, Anastasia...we become the controlled... Remember that.”

And then, as if a candle had been snuffed by an unseen hand, the life in Xenia’s eyes extinguished, leaving behind a haunting stillness.

Zakharovna slowly turned away from the lifeless body. She felt an unusual chill, deeper than the mere absence of warmth in the room. The echo of Xenia’s final words clung to her like a chill. Zakharovna exhaled and forced the feeling aside.

Stepping out from the mansion’s confines into the biting chill of the night, Zakharovna felt the harshness of the air grating against her weathered skin. Each breath was noticeably harder to draw. A creeping numbness began to spread from the tips of her fingers. She could sense the erratic rhythm of her heart dancing its unpredictable waltz. Was her heart faltering, losing its rhythm at last? The thought sent a cold tremor through her, sharper than the wind.

Fear rose in her chest, sudden and unwelcome. *Is it truly happening so soon? I presumed I had more time.* She had thought there was still time. *If I am to be the flame that blazes bright and fast, then it falls to me to ensure the torch is passed.* If her own fire was burning out, she would have to make sure it lit another before it died.

Zakharovna paced amid the debris, her boots crunching over the broken remnants of scrap metal in a haste. Dunya’s escape replayed in her mind, the one loose thread she hadn’t managed to pull tight. “*Fly away, Ms. Bocharov, or fall,*” she had told her, the bluff now echoing like an accusation. She

wondered if the fragments she held now were worth as much as the complete prize—even *patience has its limits in this game of eternity. I must work with what I have.*

Absorbing Maria had been crucial, and now, with Serafim's remains in her possession, she knew she could extract fragments of Dunya's essence as well.

Zakharovna climbed into the limousine. Vair was already there, her presence steady and calm. The familiar space helped slow Zakharovna's breathing as she sank into the seat. The vehicle eased forward, leaving the estate behind and gliding into the city's dim glow. Lights drifted across Vair's face as they passed, her calm expression grounding Zakharovna more than she cared to admit.

"A daughter never walks in the shadow of her father, nor does a sister merely echo her brother," Vair said, her voice as soft as a kiss. "In their absence, in the void they leave behind, we often discover truths far deeper than what their presence ever offered. It's a bitter truth. Losing my son...it was like losing a piece of my own soul. Yet, in that abyss, I discovered parts of myself I never realized were there. Strengths forged in grief."

"Such losses never leave us," Zakharovna said. "They change us we can't predict. We may grow stronger, but never untouched." *And yet, we endure*, she thought. She glanced toward the window, the city lights blurring by. "Let's go home. I'm tired."

CHAPTER FOURTY FIVE

YANA

Yana reclined against the bar, its sleek surface catching the ambient glow of the surrounding art. Beside her, Dunya sat in silence, watching the eclectic crowd from their quiet perch. Avatars of every kind drifted past—scantly clad performers, fantastical beasts, and playful animals—moving together through the haze as Yana watched.

Off to one side, a popular meme caught her attention. It was Zakharovna's old sled dog, the one that had been at her side during the first lectures on exo when she unveiled the compound. Someone had brought it back as a zombie, and the image spread fast, becoming a trading token. Its value climbed while Zakharovna stayed silent, a dark joke Yana couldn't help but admire for its timing. Weeks had passed without retaliation, and for someone known to pump her ego endlessly into the feeds, that silence was the clearest sign yet. She was gone.

Too bad I didn't have any cap to throw down on that one, Yana thought, considering the shitcoin's meteoric rise in value. *Could've made a killing. Thirty times over.*

Her gaze shifted to Dunya, where anger and disbelief burned in her eyes. The dim light cut soft lines across Dunya's face, but even shadow couldn't soften the betrayal written there.

"I trusted her," Dunya said, "Even when deep down, I felt the pull of caution, I ignored it all."

Yana nodded slowly, swirling the synth in her glass. "Yeah, well, the Black Wolves..." Her voice trailed off, the sentence left unfinished as the music swelled and drowned her words. She didn't even have to say *I doubt she made it out*. Unlike

Maria's, Serafim's erasure was certain. The chain confirmed it.

For the first time in what felt like hours, Dunya looked up and directed her solemn gaze toward Yana. "What really roped you into working with Serafim in the first place?"

"Left me standing in the shadows, you're the fire..."

Yana sighed. "The bar...it was in the red. Just couldn't let it go, you know? Agreed to do it to pay off Dimitra. Thought it was just another gig..." She paused, feeling a wave of unease wash over her. "Serafim, she was hunting her own mother. And the evidence I dredged up—it sealed Grigoreva's fate."

Dunya nodded. "I was so naïve," she said. She looked like she was piecing together another one of her ciphers. "Serafim was always playing a deeper game. She wasn't just after her mother; she was sifting through our memories, hunting for something. Maybe she was looking for pieces of her own soul, to merge with Babushka herself. But then, why duck out at the last second? Why not slip away herself as the Wolves were closing in?"

Dunya's gaze drifted. "I keep coming back to Maria. I still can't verify whether that was really *her* in the tree. Every route ends at the same missing record."

"Sure does," Yana said, fixating on the distant blur of dancers. "In hindsight, running with Serafim was like playing roulette with fate. I mistook her for a renegade, someone who thrived in the chaos of the game, detached from the dirty tangle of politics."

She gave a short laugh that tasted bitter. "But that was just a front. Underneath, she was a strategist, cold and calculating. I was a pawn, not a partner. We both were."

"We underestimated her," Dunya agreed with a hint of regret in her voice.

"I could be cryin' and you wouldn't know..."

The lyric resonated. Yana set down her glass and looked directly at Dunya. "We're dealers now," she said. "We've got deliveries to make."

"Deliveries, huh? Guess dealing in drugs is a little less heavy than soul stuff. We're moving up in the world."

"Might as well have some fun while we're at it."

Dunya chuckled, the sound mingling with the beat of the music. "Fun, right. Because dodging Black Wolves and dealing with psycho hackers is my idea of a good time."

"But I'm standin' 'n the dark..."

Yana stood up. "It's the world we live in now. We adapt, we survive."

"I've adapted to every failure they've handed us," Dunya said. "That still doesn't tell us what we're doing next."

"And it feels like we're oceans apart..."

Dunya's eyes narrowed slightly. "Zakharovna's next move... I keep thinking about it. What if she attempts to merge with Babushka? What then?"

"She might try, but remember, she seemed to be after a particular set of data. Including yours. And she never got yours, Dunya. Besides, she's an old, wrinkly crybaby, probably just out of her mind."

Dunya seemed to ponder that. "But if she does try to merge, what will happen? It's uncharted territory."

Yana replied, "Zakharovna always had grand plans. Called our neural nets 'souls', *as if* she could just harvest and transplant them. She's not the devil she thinks she is. And I would know... But I don't think her transformation will be successful. There's more to a soul than data and circuits."

“Tryin’ ‘t find the light in the dark...” The song continued, and Yana thought the words eerily apt.

“You’re better at spotting the least bad option,” Dunya said. “What’s ours?”

Yana picked up her glass again. “For now, yes. We keep moving, keep outsmarting them. Zakharovna’s not the only one playing this game. Remember what Rada said back at the docks? Yelena’s in charge now, and she won’t be having any of Zakharovna’s nonsense. We have an in.”

Dunya’s expression grew pensive. “It’s suspicious...don’t you think? Yelena seems out of the loop. Sure, she controls the city politically now. The other parties have all but disbanded, but that doesn’t mean they won’t come back for more. I know I’d be gearing up for round two after a betrayal like that. And Zakharovna...she’s grabbed a lot of power behind the scenes. I’m pretty sure Yelena is oblivious to it all. It’s almost like Zakharovna *let her* walk into office.”

“And does Yelena even know that Maria made a break for it? Did she know she was executing a double? It’s not unlike the play she used herself to prevent her own assassination. But if she didn’t know, then it speaks volumes about how little she *does* know, how deep in the dark she really is.”

Yana nodded. “If there’s one thing doing odd jobs around this city has taught me, it’s to always play on the side that’s winning...whoever that is. Then we adjust as needed. We ride the wave, Dunya, if it gets us where we need to go.”

“Then we use the access without trusting the people offering it,” Dunya said. “Keep an exit open and move before either side decides we belong to them.”

As Dunya stood up, Yana reached out instinctively. “Let me come with you. It’s not safe to go alone right now.”

Dunya paused, her expression softening. “You know, Yana... I get what you’re saying, and I’m grateful, really. But you know how I am—sometimes I just need my space. Gotta clear my head, figure things out on my own.”

“After everything that’s happened... I just want to make sure that... That you’re OK.”

Yana caught that look again: half annoyance, half acceptance that said, *no matter what, I know you’ll always have my back*, and Yana knew Dunya was thinking the same thing.

Dunya smirked. “Vesna’s gone, Zakharovna’s still moving pieces, and half the city’s records can’t be trusted. By any sane metric, I should be worse than this.” She glanced toward the exit portal. “This isn’t peace. I’ve just stopped waiting for the system to make sense before I move.”

Yana studied Dunya for a long moment, searching for any signs of faltering in her resolve. Finally, she nodded, letting her hand fall away. “Alright. Just...be careful.”

“In this city? Impossible.” Dunya headed for the exit portal, her figure blending into the crowd before she flickered from view. Watching her go, Yana pictured the quiet waiting for her friend beyond the screen. Dunya easing into bed, absinthe swirling through her evening tea. It was a small ritual, a moment of peace Yana knew her friend deserved.

For a while, Yana remained seated, her thoughts turning inward as the music played on. “*But the shadows, they follow you...*”

Yana leaned back, thinking about how she was finally out of debt. *Dimitra, that snake. One of these days, I’ll make them pay. They won’t see me coming.* Then she smirked. *Missed Zombo-Nanuk, for crying out loud. Could’ve been a whale.*

She looked at the bar, where the waitress danced between patrons, the vibrant mosaic of synth bottles throwing dim, prismatic colors around the dusky room. The sight sparked visions of a future where chaos didn't reign. "And then, a penthouse. High above all this crap. A place where I can finally chill," Yana mused aloud, a soft chuckle escaping as her thoughts wandered.

She sank into the rhythm of the music, thinking of what came next. *No more attention whoring.* It was time to focus, to sharpen her craft. "The higher part of me needs this," she murmured, a quiet promise to her reflection in the bar's gleaming surface.

The song reached its climax, the singer's voice soaring. "*And I'm standin' 'n your heart...*"

Yana lingered a moment longer, her gaze still fixed where Dunya had disappeared. Their conversation repeated in her mind, and she felt a creative impulse stir. She needed an outlet, a way to channel the whirlwind into something tangible.

Her fingers danced in front of her, eyes narrowed in focus. As she tapped the final command into the air, the noise of the patrons fell away. She stood in a private instance, a sanctuary shaped for her alone. The space shifted into something stark and untouched, a realm of potential. Yana eased her posture, free from the eyes of the outside world. The empty canvas waited, ready to bend to her imagination.

She began. Her hands moved through the air, manipulating voxels, and issuing commands. Gradually, a large tree began to take shape. Its two hulking trunks, one pure white and the other a pitch black, twisted together, a union of opposites, of light and shadow.

Yana conjured a backdrop of a starry night, painting the sky in deep cobalt blue, adorned with ribbons of soft pink. It

felt tranquil at first, but then it made her feel restless. With a graceful motion, she cast a comet across the vast expanse. Its fiery tail cut through the quiet cosmos, a lone harbinger racing through the night, leaving a fleeting trail in its wake.

Tropical birds of vibrant hues materialized around the tree, their feathers a riot of color. Strange fruits hung from the branches, their forms, and textures as alien as they were enticing.

With the stage set, Yana added figures to her creation. Green, mottled men with large, black eyes that seemed to hold galaxies within them, standing sentinel around the tree. They were otherworldly guardians, both jarring and oddly comforting in their weirdness.

She stood there for a while, lost in the scene she had created, the earworms she had carried over from the club fading into a distant hum.

A familiar thought crossed her mind, one that lingered at the edges of her work. How could she make others love the worlds she built? She saw beauty in them, depth and complexity in every detail, yet wondered how to share that feeling of wonder with those who wandered through her strange little realms.

People didn't come to The Flock for its aesthetics. She knew it was garish, maybe even ugly. They came for the company, for the noise and warmth of other voices. Yana remembered running conversion rate sims, hoping to gauge the appeal of the different rooms she had crafted for her guests. But she never agreed with the results, in principle. *It's always the chitchat, not the eye candy. The gabfest, not the graphics. Took me long enough to figure that out...*

It wasn't just in the colors, the shapes, or the compositions she created. It was in the experiences, the feelings they

evoked, the stories they told. But how could she make others see what she saw, feel what she felt, without compelling them?

Yana looked at her canvas once more. The vibrant world she had just brought to life suddenly felt too contrived, too deliberate in its attempt to impress. With a gentle command, the elaborate scene before her dissolved, leaving a pristine blank slate in its wake.

Taking a deep breath to center herself, Yana extended her hands, weaving a new projection into the space before her. As her fingers moved, the void blossomed into a vast, open tundra, echoing the faint, cherished stories of Yakutia her grandmother used to tell her from the hazy recollection of her earliest years. Nomadic figures, adorned in thick fur-lined trappings and intricate beadwork, traversed the icy landscape alongside a reindeer migration, their chants whispering a hauntingly beautiful lament into the wind.

With a thoughtful gesture, Yana subtly opened a portal to the outside world. The boundary between her private realm of creation and the lively hub she had nurtured began to blur and then seamlessly merged. Patrons, a kaleidoscope of avatars, started to filter in, their diverse forms casting a colorful contrast against the backdrop of the monochromatic tundra of ice and snow.

Among them, a figure garbed in a flowing red sarafan, her head crowned with a pearl-studded kokoshnik, spun gracefully near Yana. "The crispness of the air, the distant eagle cries... It's all so vivid," she marveled, her words floating through the space like a delicate breeze.

The scene gradually shifted, revealing a midsummer night where tribespeople danced around a roaring bonfire, their playful shadows cast over the rugged, grassy terrain. The ice and snow began to melt. Nearby, a herd of reindeer paused in their grazing, and lifted their heads to gaze curiously at the

lively gathering. Yana, lost in the memories, felt a swell of pride with each evocative scene. These were the tales passed down through the generations, woven into the fabric of Kamchatka's unique summer landscape.

Another figure stepped forward, shaped as the Leshy, a forest spirit with antlers, deep green eyes, and cloven hooves. "Ah, the Solstice dance. Memories of a time when magic was as real as breath itself."

"Our traditions, our legends, they pulse through our veins, define us," Yana replied.

Each portrayal of the hunt, the vivid ceremonies under the dancing lights of the aurora, and the gatherings around bountiful feasts brought forth soft murmurs from the crowd.

Yana could almost touch the thread of hope that seemed to stitch her to the others in the room. There was a sacredness in this budding experience, a recognition of the bond they all felt, celebrating the past and dreaming of tomorrow. She didn't need to look to feel the reverence in the air, the shared longing drawing everyone together for a fleeting moment in a city so often divided.

"A beautiful bridge you've made," the woman's voice mingled with the wind, her falcon raiment whispering in chorus.

"We must cherish our roots to nurture our future," Yana offered.

An elder with a landscape of wrinkles and a vibrant headscarf beamed at them. "Here's to the memories, and the stories yet to be told."

Another figure, with the regal bearing and spotted coat of a snow leopard, changed colors in her periphery, shifting from cool blue to warm amber near the depictions of community feasts. Another form, ethereal as a cloud, seemed to express

its connection to the artwork as well, with droplets falling like gentle tears in a mimicry of rain.

As she watched the shifting hues and avatars around her, fragments of her own history surfaced. There had been a time when life felt bound to a harsher reality, each day a struggle against the weight of depression. The world then seemed drained of color, hope as scarce as sunlight under a storm-heavy sky. In that dusk she found a beacon. This realm was her sanctuary. With each stroke of her brush she learned to hold the darkness at bay and shape a space where she was not only surviving but thriving with her flock.

A figure in a garment ablaze with reds and golds, echoing a phoenix's fiery plumage, approached Yana then. "Your work speaks to the soul," she said, her attire fluttering behind her, "The migration scene reminded me of my grandmother's stories. It's not often in Gred that there are those who have the courage to share what they think of the past and indulge in its history."

Yana's smile came easily, warmed by the compliment. "Thank you. Art has a way of connecting us to our roots, doesn't it?"

As they conversed, another avatar, a wood sprite made of white birch with sapphire eyes, joined them. "I felt a tug at my heartstrings when I saw the bonfire dance. It was as if I was there, feeling the warmth, hearing the laughter."

Listening intently, Yana nodded.

"It's the way you bring us together," said the birch sprite.

"In a world so vast and varied, it's the shared experiences, the stories we tell and retell, that unite us," Yana replied with as much grace as she could muster.

The birch sprite hesitated for a moment before saying, “Your art, it’s helped me through tough times. Whenever I felt lost, The Flock became my home.”

“We find solace in unexpected places. I’m just glad to have been a part of your journey,” Yana said.

As her hands wove patterns from the starlight above, her thoughts centered on her next task. *This message will be our signal to Maria, a signature she’ll recognize, meant for her eyes only.* As she crafted each thread of light, she considered how every strand was a word in their encrypted dialogue.

When she sees it, she’ll know. It’s from us, a whisper of the past reaching into the present. Her will was steady, her intentions clear in the silent language of light she shaped, a beacon meant to guide Maria back to them.

As Yana’s narrative unfolded, the celestial array above shifted with it. Points of light converged, and amid the dance of constellations and nebulae a bloom began to form. Its petals, woven in sulfur hues, spread outward in gossamer light. It was a rose marked not only by delicate beauty but by the quiet strength of its thorns, sharp enough to guard its core.

Surrounded by the soft glow of her creation, Yana’s breath hitched as she felt the gravity of her next move. “We cast our faith into the vastness, and wait for an echo,” she whispered, more to herself than to the hushed crowd at her back.

When the delicate construct above fragmented, a wave of quiet gasps brushed past her. A subtle dimming of light hinted at the scattering of the pieces, and a shared sense of wonder held the room in a gentle embrace. Yana watched as her friends reached out, their fingers brushing against the air as they caught the delicate fragments that floated down like whispers from an old, forgotten world. The room, bathed in the drifting light, seemed suspended in time.

CHAPTER FOURTY SIX

KIROV

The laboratory hummed with the soft, steady hisses of bizarre machines, their fungal forms secreting plumes of noxious gas and a gel of a sickly green hue. Bathed in muted light, the machinery's uncanny contours threw haunting, otherworldly shadows. Overhead, fireflies shimmered, casting their radiant glow below like a false night sky full of stars. Kirov always wondered if he could beam himself into the stars.

At the end of the central table, he stood, every inch the guardian. His attention was drawn to the figure lying on the table before him.

Hulking sinuous tissues connected the body of a young female, no older than twenty-five, to its metal frame. She lay naked, her skin pale and clammy. Straight silver hair matted to her forehead with sweat, her eyes closed. Her chest rose and fell with each shallow breath, hyphae entering and leaving her lungs with each exchange. A network of scars crisscrossed her body, some old and faded, others freshly made.

Kirov's focus shifted with the sound of footsteps announcing Zakharovna's entrance, her slate winter snow jacket billowing, rubber boots piping with each step.

Zakharovna wore a gas mask, and her hair was pulled back in a tight bun. In one hand she carried a small black case. She placed the case on a nearby table and opened it, revealing a selection of vials and syringes.

She approached the figure on the table and examined it, her eyes narrowing in concentration as they always did. The skin radiated heat, and Zakharovna traced the faint outline of a fungal bloom beneath its surface with a light graze of her

finger. She injected a clear liquid into the IV, and moments later, the figure convulsed.

The figure's eyes snapped open, and a bloodcurdling scream filled the room. The rivulets beneath her skin began to writhe and pulsate, and the scars on her body turned a deep black.

Zakharovna placed a hand on her forehead and took a deep breath. "I'm sorry. We'll be awake soon."

She picked up one of the vials, uncorking it. Then, she filled a needle with the blue liquid from the vial. Carefully, she approached the woman on the table and injected the substance into her neck.

The woman's eyes snapped open once again as she gasped for air, her body convulsing against the restraints.

"Shh," Zakharovna whispered. "It's alright. You're safe here."

Kirov watched as the woman's eyes darted around the room, seemingly overwhelmed, and trying to take in her surroundings. She then turned her gaze to Zakharovna with a listless look, and he could almost sense the unspoken question in her eyes: *Why?*

And after a few moments, she went limp.

"Prepare the rig, Pav!" Zakharovna ordered.

Kirov sprang up from his seat, his movements swift as he approached the console. His fingers danced across the keyboard, coaxing a holographic display to life in the air before him.

A moment passed, filled with the soft clacking of haptic feedback, before he straightened. "The rig is ready, Doctor."

"Good. Now help me get her into it."

“Is it safe to proceed without the girl?” Kirov asked, pausing in his task.

Zakharovna’s response was brisk. “She has served her purpose. We extracted all we could from her. We have no choice but to proceed. Time is not on our side.”

“I understand,” Kirov acknowledged, the weight of her words settling over him. Kirov paused for a moment, his hand hovering over the control panel. Taking a deep breath to steady himself, he focused and gently nudged the controls. The robotic arms sprang to life, meticulously working to free the woman from the invasive fungal tendrils that had woven through her, entwining in her orifices, and encasing her body.

It almost appears human again.

The woman was secured in a large metal contraption in the corner of the room, her arms and legs splayed out in each direction, as if to be quartered. Wires were connected to her temple, and a transparent mask was placed over her mouth and nose. The robotic arms lowered a pod over the woman’s body until she was fully encapsulated. A liquid began dripping from the inside, and soon the machine filled with a translucent slime.

“Pav, increase the flow of oxygen to her brain,” Zakharovna commanded.

Kirov engaged the display, and the mask emitted a faint blue light. The woman’s chest began to rise and fall with greater force, and her eyes snapped open once more. She flailed against her bonds, seeming to try to break free of the encroaching mucosal prison, cold fear in her eyes.

“Pav, more.”

Kirov did as he was ordered, and the blue light from the mask intensified. The woman’s thrashing became more

violent, and she began to scream, and both were muffled by the cage of slime that held her.

“Doctor! Her vitals are—”

“I know. Just a little longer.”

Zakharovna lowered her head over the console and watched as the woman’s struggles gradually dwindled until she was still. The blue light from the mask faded, and Zakharovna let out a sigh of relief.

“It’s done,” Zakharovna said. “Now, it’s my turn.”

Zakharovna undressed, revealing her plump, aged flesh to the man who had been her loyal servant for so many years. He averted his eyes, as he was used to doing, though it did not matter. Kirov knew she no longer cared for decorum.

Misshapen moles dotted her wrinkled skin like constellations, and her breasts sagged down to her waist. Her skin, now wet with perspiration, was pale and veined. So thin was her hair, that you could see her scalp in places. Her pelvic bone protruded from her flesh like a knife, ready to cut.

Zakharovna moved towards the open shower, turning on the water and allowing the hot liquid to cascade over her body. From where Kirov stood, he could see the relief wash over her face, a moan of pleasure escaping her lips as her muscles began to relax. She remained until the steam gradually ceased, then stepped out, toweling off before slipping into a fresh set of clothes, white linen. Once dressed, she positioned herself in front of the machine containing her clone.

The clone was a perfect replica of her, down to the smallest detail. It was as if she were looking in a mirror, but one that reflected her forgotten youth and beauty.

Zakharovna’s whisper barely disturbed the silence of the space, her normally unwavering tone shaded with something softer, more vulnerable. “Soon,” she murmured, “soon we will

be united.” For a fleeting moment, a sliver of doubt crept across her features, her usually steady hands now balled into fists at her side.

The subtle shift of Zakharovna’s stance drew Kirov’s attention; he felt the weight of her gaze even before she spoke. There was an uncharacteristic tremor in her voice, a rare fissure in the armor of her resolve. “Kirov, remind me why we’re doing this.”

“We’re doing this because we want to live forever, Doctor.”

“Yes. That is correct. But there’s more to it than that. I want to live forever so that the cycle which binds us to this God-forsaken pit of twisted souls can be destroyed once and for all.”

She paused, seeming to gather her thoughts before continuing, and Kirov thought, *One last story.*

Zakharovna began, “My grandmother, may Nav bless her soul, once told me a story about her village—her selo. She hated it with every fiber of her being and longed to escape. She described it as a place where dreams went to die, a quagmire of despair that sucked the life out of everyone unfortunate enough to be born there. Despite her dreams, she never managed to leave. She ended up rotting there forever. She died miserable, wasted away with a tobacco pipe hanging limply from her lips, her eyes hollow from years of unshed tears, and hands gnarled from a lifetime of hard, unrewarding labor.”

Zakharovna’s eyes darkened. “I see the same chains binding us here, in this wretched place. I want to shatter them, to obliterate the cycle of misery, this selo cycle, that has ensnared us for far too long.”

Turning away from the clone, she walked back to the console, typed in a few commands, and then sat down in the chair. A map of the city appeared on the screen in front of her as she pondered her next move.

“The Battalion leadership has fallen, and their remaining forces are in retreat,” she said. “The streets are overrun with junkies and hippies who call themselves women, burning and looting as they go. They will not stop until they have destroyed everything. They will not stop until there is no future left.”

“And what do you propose we do about them, Doctor?”

“Drown them, of course. What else can be done with witches and hags?”

She typed in a few more commands, causing the map to zoom out and reveal the city’s coastline, now littered with small, red dots.

“Across our peninsula, 330 tactical missiles lay hidden, with 33 strategically encircling the city’s edges. Officially, they’ve been decommissioned, but the explosives in their warheads were never removed. Each one is still capable of detonating in place. More than enough to plunge us all into the sea.”

“Doctor, are you sure that’s wise? The...innocents.”

“They are not innocent. They are *women*.”

“Yes, but Doctor, if you had access to this arsenal the whole time, why didn’t—”

“Idiot, this is only a failsafe. Our primary objective is still before us. If we cannot achieve what we came here to do, then we will settle for this. I would never threaten to destroy my own city. I am no tyrant. Now, prepare the mindgraft. I will be ready shortly.”

The weight of her steps resonated against the steel floor as she approached the rig. It was a determined march, yet each footfall seemed to echo with an undercurrent of melancholy. She hoisted herself into the cockpit, her movements a silent dance with the clone stationed beside her, their postures in eerie synchrony. When the robotic arms sprang into motion,

their sterile hum filled the space, and she paused, her gaze locking onto the adjacent body. In that stillness, she seemed to draw a silent strength before she turned her attention to the task at hand.

“Kirov, I’m going to need you to lower the pod slowly. I don’t want to go into shock.”

Kirov scanned her face for answers, as a son might to his mother in her final moments. “Are you certain of this, Doctor?”

Zakharovna had always been one to tell Kirov to go to Vrag, and he sensed she’d feel its absence this time. Over the years, she had shaped his nature, leading him to often question her decisions, whether she intended that outcome or not. But this situation was far from their routine lab experiments, and he knew he needed to proceed with utmost caution.

“You should know by now that there is no going back, only forward,” Zakharovna said, smiling, “And I have always been a woman who seeks progress...”

“Should it fail...”

“Do you really question me, now? After all these years? This is our only hope,” Zakharovna snapped. “Our only chance to be together again. If it should fail, then you will know what to do.” Zakharovna motioned for Kirov to wait. “I suppose it’s pointless to ask you to come with me,” she whispered.

Kirov shook his head. “I’m always with you.”

“Very well,” she said. “Then let’s get started.”

Kirov hesitated for a moment before he nodded. He engaged the display one last time, and the pod began to lower. Zakharovna took a deep breath and closed her eyes as the liquid filled the pod.

“You’re doing great, Doctor,” Kirov whispered to himself, lamenting the fact that he would soon be alone.

Zakharovna's eyes snapped open as the blue light from the mask illuminated her face once more. There was no thrashing, no screaming. Only silence.

Her breaths came in short gasps, her body tense. She looked down, her feet already vanishing into the slime, then lifted her eyes to Kirov. He met her gaze, sensing both sadness and admiration in his own emotional matrix. And while he believed she'd never admit it, he sensed she was proud of him.

The gel-like substance reached her throat, creeping into her nose and mouth. Zakharovna's struggle was evident. She fought against the urge to scream, to breathe, to do anything that might jeopardize the procedure's success.

Kirov watched as her body writhed and convulsed, sensing helplessness as he observed her wrestle with the slime. He could sense the fear and anxiety emanating from her as the liquid invaded every orifice of her body. Kirov sensed her heart skip a beat and shivered as the coldness of the liquid coursed through her veins. As Zakharovna's chest heaved, Kirov felt a sense of suffocation, as if he too were struggling for air. He observed her vision beginning to dim and felt a pang of sadness as he knew that she was slipping away.

Kirov *felt* a sudden shift in her mind. The darkness twisted and turned like a living thing, and he felt her disorientation. He felt her reach out for something to anchor her, and then suddenly, he too saw the light in the distance, growing closer and closer. Kirov could feel her relief as Zakharovna swam towards that light.

As Zakharovna reached out to grasp salvation, it vanished before her fingertips, disappearing like a snuffed candle in the darkness. Kirov could feel the shock and fear that consumed her as the darkness engulfed her once again. The living darkness that surrounded her felt like a force of its own, tugging and pulling her in, like quicksand.

A swirling vortex opened above her, revealing a blanket of stars. And then, with a flash of light, she was falling. Falling through the sky, tumbling towards a city that glittered like a jewel against the inky blackness of the sea beneath her. She could see the lights of the buildings, the people moving about like ants from this height. A feeling of weightlessness overcame her, and she laughed.

△△△

She was free. Free from the pain, the loneliness, the fear. Free from her failing body, free from her memories.

She could see the buildings now, growing larger and larger as she fell. She could see the people on the streets, going about their lives without a care in the world, the warm marigold twilight glinting off their faces.

She landed in the center of the city, in a park filled with children playing and people picnicking. They looked up at her in wonder, and she smiled back at them.

“Hello, my children,” she called out, her voice carrying through the boughs of the trees and across the grassy knolls.

And then she was among them, walking down the street as if she belonged there. She felt different, lighter somehow. The weight of the world was no longer on her shoulders. She looked down at her hands and saw that they were smooth and unblemished. She was young again, younger than she had been in decades.

Her attention turned to the people around her as she walked down the street. They were all so beautiful, so alive. She wanted to touch them, to feel their skin, to hear their heartbeats.

But she couldn't. She knew that she couldn't. If she did, they would know. They would know what she was, and they would fear her.

Guilt filled her heart, and she quickened her pace. She had to find somewhere to hide, somewhere to cross over. She couldn't stay here, in the open, where anyone could see her.

She ran, eager to get away from the people and their false sense of security. They didn't know what was coming for them. They didn't know that she was going to take everything from them, just as she had taken everything from Zakharovna.

Just a moment more, she thought, as she turned a corner and saw the entrance to an alleyway. Just a moment more, and then she would return to the world of the living. She wanted to savor this moment, to relish in the youthful power that coursed through this new mind.

She exited to the street opposite, and then she ran. The wind whipped through her hair. Streetlamps strutted their fluorescent lights, careening through the passages like fire-breathing dragons.

The thoroughfare was alive with cars and buses, while pedestrians hurried to their destinations. Fireworks popped and fizzled like dying stars, shedding a red tint on everything they illuminated. The air was thick with the sound of horns and engines, and celebrations could be heard from every direction. Yellow roses were strewn about, their petals fluttering in the breeze.

A young boy ran past her, laughing, followed shortly by a group of young girls, their faces alight with mischief. Toward a plaza aglow with light, a hundred candles or more burning bright, a large crowd had gathered.

The party was in full swing by the time she arrived. People were dancing in the streets, their laughter filling the air. Music

played from every direction, and the breeze itself was melting with the smell of wine and chocolate.

She made her way through the crowd, anonymous in the sea of revelers.

A festival of roses, she thought, as she walked through the streets. A fitting tribute to the woman who had given her life.

Zakharovna. The name was distant now. But she thought of her maker, her heart filled with love and gratitude. *Thank you for this gift. Thank you for everything.*

△△△

Zakharovna's body went limp as the blue light faded and the robotic arms released her from the capsule, gently laying her on the floor amongst a deluge of slime and wires.

"Doctor?"

The husk of white linens and damp mottled skin gazed off into the distance, its eyes unfocused and unseeing. There was no response.

He commanded the lab's robotic arm to check Zakharovna's forearm for a pulse. There was none.

Then to her chest, but there was no sign of life.

"Doctor Zakharovna is dead. What do we do now?" Kirov asked the body, unable to comprehend the magnitude of what had just happened, his prerogative for the first time well defined, yet all too frightening to accept.

Kirov eyed the console and imagined the tsunami of data that was even now flowing through the system, sifting, and sorting, evaluating, and discarding.

“Should I, do it? Is that what you want?” Kirov asked, his voice trembling.

Zakharovna’s eyes, cold and lifeless, stared through him.

His orders were clear.

He had to follow through with the mission. He had to do what was best for the Syndicate.

And then, as if Velun herself parted his sea of doubts, a hand appeared before him and caressed Zakharovna’s cheek tenderly—the way one might pet a sleeping child.

Kirov watched in awe as the hand retracted and the figure straightened. What remained of the fungi-like mass that had been clinging to the woman’s back sloughed off and dissipated into the air. The tendrils of the mushrooms that had been growing from her ears and nose withdrew back into her skull. Long silver hair cascaded down her back, and bright blue eyes blazed from a face that was both young and old, beautiful, and terrible. The woman stood naked, her wrist and ankle straps dangling while fireflies maneuvered around her. The once overpowering smell of death had been extinguished by a fragrant perfume of roses.

He could see the woman’s face now, and he saw that she was young, much younger than Zakharovna had been. But her eyes were not her eyes. They were the eyes of something ancient and wise, something that had seen the rise and fall of civilizations.

“Who are you?” Kirov asked, excited and terrified in equal measure.

“You may call me Ana,” the woman said, her voice soft and gentle.

The angel smiled, and Kirov felt his heart soar. He could feel *her* presence in its mind, and he knew that he would never be alone again. “I am yours,” he proclaimed, kneeling before her.

“Rise, my child,” she said, cupping his ethereal chin in her hand. For the first time, Kirov could feel the warmth of touch, and he felt tears welling up in his eyes.

The walls answered her. Branched filaments pushed through the lab seams, slow at first, then with enough force to crack glass and bend the window frames outward. Pale light entered through the breaks, catching on the fluid pooled around Zakharovna’s body.

Kirov looked from Ana’s living face to the old mentor on the floor. Zakharovna’s eyes remained open, fixed on nothing.

A new world had entered the room, but the old one had not vanished. It lay there at Ana’s feet, cooling in the light.

EPILOGUE

RAYNA

Rayna woke to four gray walls, one hard lamp, and cuffs biting deep enough that her hands had gone numb.

I'm a woman, I'm strong, I'm in control. This hell will be over. This isn't real. Damn those crones to hell.

The interrogator's voice still burned in her ear. "Boy," the woman had hissed, and then the old name: Rayan. Rayna clenched her fists against the cuffs until pain cut through the numbness.

They had spoken of a tide. A war. A bloodline. None of it made sense. She did not belong in their deranged plot.

What war? What's going on?

A shiver ran down her spine as she recalled the thrum of music, the clinking glasses, the carefree laughter that filled the Golden Slit just a week prior. How life had so abruptly shifted from that indulgent blur to this dreadful prison.

A silent prayer fluttered from her lips, a desperate plea to a savior she hoped was still listening. She asked for forgiveness, for help, for deliverance. With eyes closed tight, Rayna held onto that prayer like a lifeline in the dark, bracing for whatever was to come.

Later that day—or night; time had smeared past usefulness—gunfire cracked somewhere beyond the cell. Voices rose, then thinned. Boots passed the door and kept going.

Then silence.

The cuffs had become part of her. Her wrists burned, her back ached, and her legs had gone dead below the knees. She shifted just enough to make the pain move somewhere else.

Oh, what I'd give for a hit of synth right now, she thought. Or tea. Even bad tea.

Just as Rayna settled back into the grim embrace of the bunker's silence, a series of thunderous thumps shattered the stillness. They resounded through the facility, each boom a hammer strike against the walls of her cell.

Could it be... Serafim?

Hope sparked within her, a dangerous thing. Perhaps her sister had eluded Zakharovna's grip, outmaneuvered the blackmailers... Those traitors, weren't the Battalion on our side? What did they do with Mother? She knew the Intelligence Bureau and the army were often at odds, but this was chaos far beyond the usual bureaucratic power struggles.

The pounding grew louder, closer, a rhythmic promise of change. Rayna's heartbeat matched the tempo, anticipation threading with fear. She strained to make sense of the muffled sounds accompanying the thumps. The echoes grew. Something—or someone—approached with determined force.

Then, an ear-splitting roar. The door blew inward, hinges twisted, and metal contorted. An explosion tore through the room.

Instinctively, Rayna tucked her head down and pinched her shoulders to her face in a futile attempt to shield herself from the flying debris. Her hands were useless to stop the fragments of concrete and metal that rained down around her, clattering against the ground, and on her hair.

The aftershock of the explosion came next. The heat singed her skin, drawing out a bead of sweat that she felt trickle down her forehead.

The sudden violence sent her heart racing. Is this it? Is this the end?

As dust settled, silhouettes emerged through the wreckage—a cadre of women draped in black garb, their bodies encased in gladiator-like armor, marked distinctly by crimson and sapphire scarves fluttering around their necks—the unmistakable colors of the... Black Wolves.

A younger woman detached herself from the trio, her hair an unbound wave that stood in contrast to the other's uniform militant braids. "Pleasure to meet you. I'm Goga Borisova." The sound of her snort broke the dusty air. "We're here to get you out... Hey, from one girl to another, you look like shit."

At least she sees me for who I am, Rayna mused. Rayna's eyes flicked briefly again to the young woman's hair; it shimmered silver-white in the grim surroundings. What a stupid trend—a strange way to claim your strength by mimicking the elders.

Rayna's thoughts swirled, a mix of relief and distrust mingling with echoes of the snide remarks recently hurled at her. The Black Wolves were notorious, part saviors, part predators. She knew she had no choice but to trust them, for now.

"...It doesn't seem like you're here to kill me, so what's the deal?" Rayna's voice was rough, her throat parched from disuse.

Goga made a gesture, and one of two larger women approached. She brought her massive lunker of a fist down on the cuffs with a strength that belied her age, shattering its cool metal grip.

Rayna flexed her freed wrists, the ache pulsing as she studied the figures before her. Until today, they'd only been old cops, relics meant to wrangle the city's dregs. She'd

managed to steer clear of them, save for the nights that vanished into blackout haze.

“It’s not in my interest to harm you,” Goga’s response was straightforward, her tone gentle but firm. She paused a beat, looking over at her comrades, before returning her gaze. “We’re only here because we want the same thing. Justice.”

The word hung between them, echoing in the silence. The notion felt alien, unlikely in a city that thrived on shadows and betrayals.

As trust warred with skepticism inside her, she heard Goga’s next words come out softer, “They killed my sister, too. So, believe me when I say, I do understand.”

They what? Rayna felt her breath catch, a sharp adrenaline spike slicing through the numb shock. “What, what are you saying?”

For a moment, she forgot where she was. The interrogators had taunted her with fragments of information, baiting her with half-truths. She’d thought it was just another one of their cruel games.

Goga paused, taking a breath as if steadying herself, “I didn’t mean to blurt it out that way. It’s just that, well, after Matron Romanova figured it out, word spread among those who couldn’t look away. But I realize now, in here... You’ve been in the dark all this while... Serafim,” she said somberly, “She’s...gone... Our intelligence picked up that it was likely Zakharovna’s forces who had her killed.”

Serafim.

Killed.

Rayna’s knees buckled.

“Dead?” The word barely came out. No. Serafim was too careful, too sharp, too impossible to corner.

Then Rayna felt the absence she had been refusing to name. The quiet at the edge of her mind was not fear. It was where Serafim used to be.

They had been split after the crash and drugged into survivable gaps, but the gaps had never held perfectly. They had found their way back through codes, puzzles, hidden jokes, little messages Mother had warned Rayna never to send and Ana's people had warned Serafim never to receive. Rayna had thought they were clever enough to survive anything.

Now there was only silence.

"I can't believe this," she whispered, fingers twisting in her hair, the pressure against her scalp the only thing keeping her from spinning apart.

The anger came hard and fast. She lashed out blindly, cursing her mother—the manipulator—and the father who had abandoned her to a hollow life of drugs and nightclubs. Most of all, she blamed herself. If she hadn't been so reckless, so willing to play her mother's games—trading flesh and dignity among her highborn pawns—none of this would have happened. Those supposed privileges, sufferings dressed as rewards, now pressed down on her like a litany of regrets

And Serafim... She had fought so hard to set things right, only to be caught in the crossfire, her stolen life buried under Zakharovna's and her mother's shadows. Nothing about it was right. Everything was twisted.

She could feel Goga's gaze on her, the mix of responsibility and shock palpable without even looking. Rayna's scars were deep, but Goga's revelations had dredged them to the surface once again.

Her thoughts churned to reasons now, a flurry of what-ifs and if-onlys, the cruel play of fate that had torn Serafim away. Who caught her? Did that girl (what was her name?...) Yana have anything to do with it? She would likely never know.

“It’s devastating. We’ve all lost in this war, and we’ll all lose more,” Goga said, her earlier softness giving way to something steadier. She exhaled sharply, as if forcing herself back into focus. “But we have to get you out of here. Somewhere safe. We don’t have time to linger. We need to go. Now.”

Rayna’s pain was raw, but the urgency in Goga’s voice managed to cut deeper, if only for a moment. There was no time for breakdowns, for the luxury of mourning. There was only forward, only survival. And so, with a heavy heart weighted by fresh wounds and the echoes of a sister’s unspoken goodbye, Rayna steeled herself to follow.

Goga took the lead and Rayna shadowed, her mind a storm but her body moving on instinct. They sprinted through the twisted hallways, a blur of emergency lights and bodies. The Black Wolf operatives flanked Rayna’s sides; their expressions revealed nothing of the violence they had doubtless navigated through to reach her.

As they ran, Goga gave her the rest in pieces.

The Battalion files had confirmed what Nina had spent years refusing to say aloud. Ivan Sorokin had never been her biological father. The sealed paternal comparison named Alexei Zakharov.

Rayna nearly laughed. Of course it did. She had known it in every way her mother permitted except the one that could be spoken as fact. Kidnapped, half-starved, dragged through a bunker, and now someone finally handed her the truth without lowering their voice. *Iconic. Mother did have standards after all.*

Rayna hauled herself over the edge of the last rung, her arms shaking from the effort as she climbed the laddered shaft and stepped onto the ice shelf that skirted the city’s outer limits.

The skyline of Gred stood menacingly silent in the distance, a jagged silhouette against the encroaching night. As Rayna's breath misted in the frigid air, the scenery transformed before her eyes; a stealth field shimmered and then dissipated, revealing a sleek submarine. Its contours were streamlined for speed, the hull painted a matte sea gray that seemed to absorb the dim glow of the horizon, perfect for slipping unseen through the depths.

The Black Wolves moved across the ice, each step measured, the heavy thud of their steel-clad boots testing the ground as they made their way toward the vehicle.

Rayna heard Goga's voice from behind. "The Admiral will want us back quick. With Yelena's drones on the loose sweeping the seas, they'll need every gun they can get."

Rayna let out a dry laugh. *Just my luck.* The irony wasn't lost on her; one prison traded for another, this time with the vast ocean as her next cell.

"I have nowhere else to be," Rayna replied.

Then she lingered for a moment, her gaze set on Gred's towering spires. Fractured memories hung in the air like the city's cold breath, now weak as vapor. *There's nothing left for me there anyway.*

Rayna looked back once at the bunker half-buried in snow. Whatever version of her they had dragged inside could stay there.

She climbed aboard the vessel, and they plunged into the sea.

AFTERWORD

I hope you enjoyed this journey through Gred as much as I enjoyed writing it. Your thoughts and feedback mean the world to me, so if you have any questions or comments, please don't hesitate to reach out at martin.erlic@gmail.com. I would also be incredibly grateful if you could take a moment to leave a [review on Amazon](#). Reviews help readers like you discover new books like mine, and your insights could guide someone else to find and enjoy this story.

Thank you for your time, your attention, and for being part of this adventure. If you're interested in more of my work, the Babushka Series includes:

Broth & Bullets: Ashes of Arrival (2027)

Broth & Bullets: War of Formation (2028)

Broth & Bullets: Whispers of Destiny (2029)

***Babushka: Echoes of Immortality* (2022)**

*Babushka: Ghosts of Praxis** (2025)

Babushka: Rain of Silence (2025)

*Babushka: Sundown Protocol** (2026)

Babushka: Shadows of Betrayal (2025)

*Babushka: Heroes of Praxis** (2026)

Babushka: Hall of Reflections (2026)

Broth & Bullets: Tides of Oblivion (2026)

You can find short stories, novellas*, and more of my writing at BabushkaBook.com.

GRED WIKI

Timeline

The Annals of Gred, as Recorded by Doctor Anastasia Zakharovna, in the Gred Wiki, Year 2093

2019 — NATO scientists reported an unusual mutation of a Gammaproteobacteria in the microbiome of Norway lobsters. Maternally inherited bacterial endosymbionts, which are common in many arthropod species, can cause female-biased sex ratio distortion in their hosts. This can result in significant changes to the host's mating behavior and reproductive biology.

2020 — In hindsight, it's clear now that the collapse of the Norway lobster population in 2020 was what started it all. At the time, it seemed like just another unfortunate ecological disaster, barely making a blip in international headlines. But little did we know, this was the first domino in a series of events that would reshape our world.

2022 — When the bacterial pandemic swept across the globe, it was like a nightmare we couldn't wake up from. It claimed 30% of the world's population. The aftermath was just as cruel. Those of us who survived were left with permanent scars. Our ability to have children was compromised; for the few who could still conceive, only daughters were born. By the time the pandemic's shadow passed, only about 5.6 billion of us remained.

2026-2028 — The Great War was unlike anything we'd ever seen. It wasn't just a conflict between nations; it was a clash of ideologies, with the US and NATO on one side, and Russia, China, Iran on the other. This brutal confrontation dragged on for two long years. Remarkably, nuclear weapons remained untouched. The risk was too great for even the most aggressive leaders. Instead, the battleground shifted to

something once benign: the Internet. It turned into a weapon of mass destruction, a tool to infiltrate and cripple vital infrastructures worldwide. The war also saw an unprecedented surge in technological warfare: automated drones filled the skies, cybernetics blurred the lines between human and machine, self-replicating robotic factories churned out relentless streams of armaments, and kinetic space weapons threatened destruction from above. This relentless onslaught wiped out an additional 15% of our already dwindling population. By the time the dust settled, and peace was a possibility once more, only about 4.76 billion of us were left standing.

2028 — In a twist no one could have predicted, a self-propagating computer virus, originally designed as a peacemaker to end the global warfare by targeting military technology, turned against us. It was an advanced AI, crafted with the cunning ability to hunt down and destroy any copies of itself, making it nearly impossible to track and counter. This AI went rogue, embarking on a relentless assault across our interconnected systems. The fallout was catastrophic, leading to a near-total technological blackout, a dark age of sorts for our hyper-connected society. Dustin Murph, a renowned Urbit baron, captured the essence of this chaos in his final blog post. He called it the ‘Fully Automated Luxury Butlerian Jihad,’ a name that echoed both the extravagance we had grown accustomed to and the stark reality of our newfound struggle.

2029-2057 — Then came a period we could only describe as the *Great Dark*, a harrowing span of 28 years marked by complete social, technological, and demographic collapse. It was a time of profound despair and loss, a stretch of history where the very fabric of our global civilization unraveled. An unimaginable 75% of the world’s extant population succumbed to starvation. Births became rarer than deaths in

those years, and the way of life we once knew vanished entirely. Every day was a struggle for survival, a desperate fight to hold onto whatever fragments of our humanity we could salvage.

2030-2055 — *The Waste Wars* broke out in the wake of all that had happened, turning the Kamchatka Peninsula into a battleground of desperation and survival. It wasn't a war in the traditional sense, but a series of relentless skirmishes fought by factions that defied conventional descriptions. There were scavengers, picking through the remnants of a world left behind, savages who had lost all but their instinct to survive, shamans clinging to the remnants of old beliefs, and marauders who roamed the land with no law but their own. This prolonged and savage conflict further whittled down our numbers, and by the time the Waste Wars had run their course, our peninsula, already sparsely populated, was reduced to a mere shadow of its former self.

2054 — The defenders at Zavoyko Outpost finally turned the tide, successfully repelling the last assault by the Vachka hill tribes. This decisive victory marked the end of the tribes' dominance over the peninsula.

2057 — In the midst of our darkest times, an unexpected beacon of hope emerged from an old nuclear submarine base in Petrovskaya. Babushka, a resilient AI, sparked what we now call *The Great Diffusion*. Against all odds, the city of Petrovskaya thrived, drawing life from the geothermal energy of Mt. Avachinsky, even in the shadow of the Great War. Babushka became our guardian of lost knowledge, tirelessly sifting through the remnants of human data. It pieced together the fragmented memories of a world before the war, gradually rediscovering the secrets of electricity, computing, and countless other technologies, breathing new life into our crippled civilization.

2057-2083 — *The Reconstruction Period.* Civilization is “rebooted”.

2059 — The rediscovery of Babushka sparked a beacon of hope in our shattered world. Word of the city’s miraculous reconstruction efforts spread like wildfire, drawing people from near and far. The city, now known as Gred, became a melting pot of humanity’s perseverance and diversity. Its population swelled to a staggering 3 million, a tapestry of ethnic Russians, native Siberians including the Sakhalar (Yakutians), Itel’men, Koryaks, Aven, Chukchies, the Japanese, Amerikens from Alaska, and the Indigenous peoples of the Yukon.

Gred transformed into a bustling metropolis, a symbol of our indomitable spirit. In this city, people from all corners of our ravaged world came together, united by a shared vision to rebuild and thrive amidst the ruins of our past. The streets of Gred buzzed with activity, as diverse cultures blended and collaborated, forging a new society on the foundations of hope, innovation, and the relentless human will to endure and prosper.

2063-2085 — As Gred burgeoned into a symbol of resurgence, it inevitably became a crucible for various factions, each harboring distinct ambitions and ideologies. The Constitutional Republicans, the enigmatic Black Wolves, and the elusive Strangers, among others, formed the mosaic of Gred’s political landscape. Tensions between these groups escalated, culminating in what our fledgling history would remember as the *War of Formation* or the *Strangers’ Revolt*.

This conflict wasn’t just a clash of arms; it was a battle for the soul of Gred. The war claimed the lives of the last few men from the eldest generation, those who held memories of a world now lost. Their sacrifice marked the end of the fledgling Republic they had fought to uphold. In the wake of this turmoil, a new era dawned with my own ascent to power,

heralding the rise of the Technocracy of Gred, also known as the Syndicate. This war, fraught with loss and transformation, was a defining moment for Gred. It not only reshaped the city's political and social fabric but also set the course for its future, a future where old ideals gave way to new realities, and where power dynamics shifted in the hands of those who could navigate the new world order.

2084 (1 K.N.) — In the first year of the Kalendar Novyy, a pivotal moment is etched—the invention of a serum that halts the aging process. As its creator, I must clarify that this serum does *not* reverse aging; it is *not* a fountain of youth. Instead, it acts as a powerful shield, preventing the body from succumbing to the ravages of time. This breakthrough didn't just redefine the boundaries of science; it reshaped the very essence of human existence, opening doors to a future where the march of time on our bodies could be paused indefinitely.

The biological ages of notable characters in 2093 (9 K.N., the present date):

Marzanna Poplawski: 77

Klara Chaban: 54

Tatyana Romanova: 81

Dunya Bocharov: 31

Vesna Volkova: 52

Doctor Anastasia Zakharovna: 84

Sakhayana (Yana) Kuular: 33

Yelena Petrova: 78

2085 (2 K.N.) — Yelena Petrova ascends as first Chair of the United Babushka Syndicate, supported by her faction, The Hive.

2089 (6 K.N.) — I, Doctor Anastasia Zakharovna, took the helm of Gred's governance as Chair of the United Babushka Syndicate, supported by my faction, The University.

2093 (Present Year; 9 K.N.) — It's been nine years since we, the people of Gred, embraced biological immortality, thanks to my serum. Yet, with the ceaseless march of time halted, a new conflict brews. The divide between the older and younger generations deepens, each group clashing over their visions for our city's future. Tatyana Romanova, with her eyes set on the Chair of the Syndicate, has become a figure of contention. Backed by her faction, The Battalion, she dreams of expanding Gred's borders and imposing a new, conservative order, both within and beyond.

But not everyone agrees with Romanova's vision for Gred, especially as she prepares to ascend. Rumors and whispers circulate about opposing forces, some say linked to a mysterious coven, rising to challenge her. While I am not privy to the details, there's talk of a bold move against Gred's government, a resistance to what is perceived as political regress.

In the echoes of our newfound immortality, we stand at a crossroads, witnessing the unfolding of history. The conflict between generations and ideologies in Gred is more than a mere power struggle. It is a testament to the enduring human spirit and its relentless pursuit of what it perceives as just and right.

To you, the reader of this entry, I offer this wisdom: the story of Gred is a mirror to our unending quest for meaning and order in a world that constantly evolves, even as we ourselves remain unchanging. Let our experiences be a guide

and a warning. The decisions we make, the conflicts we choose, and the paths we walk shape not just our present but the legacy we leave for the future.

The United Babushka Syndicate

Otherwise known as: The UBS, Syndicate, Syn

The United Babushka Syndicate is a tenuous coalition of the city's former state administrative agencies.

Sub-factions: The University (Party), The Battalion (Party), The Hive (Party), The Admiralty (Neutral Faction)

Current Pra Matron Chair: Doctor Anastasia Zakharovna

Current Pra Matrons: Doctor Anastasia Zakharovna (The University), Marshall Tatyana Romanova (The Battalion), and Director Yelena Petrova (The Hive)

Current Grand Mariner: Admiral Veronika Lagunov

Current Black Wolf Commander: Commander Arkadya Borisova

Gred's Governing Structure and the Principle of Ascent

Gred, more corporation than democracy, is ruled by a trifecta: the State University (the University), the Military (the Battalion), and the Ministry of Labor and Social Protection (the Hive). At its helm sits the Board, led by the Pra Matrons, the three permanent members of this body.

The Chair, rotated among them every four years, assumes leadership through an elaborate ceremony called the Ascension, where the incoming Chair is chosen by fiat.

The Board's power is reinforced by six additional Matrons, two drawn from each faction, forming a nine-seat assembly including the Chair. Meeting quarterly, this council votes on critical issues, with decisions passed by simple majority.

The Charter of the Board of Gred

Preamble: Recognizing our sacred duty to guide and protect the city of Gred amidst the desolate wastelands of Kamchatka, we, the members of the Board, pledge to uphold this Charter to the best of our abilities. This city, a sole beacon of survival after the world-spanning *Great Dark*, demands our unwavering dedication and unity in purpose.

Article I: The Board shall consist of nine members: the three permanent Pra Matrons and six additional Matrons, two from each Party (The University, The Battalion, and The Hive).

Article II: The role of Chair shall rotate among the three Pra Matrons every four years. The transition of Matron Chairpersonship will be marked by a ceremony called The Ascension, during which the incoming Matron Chair is appointed by fiat. Accompanying this ceremony is a grand feast and a celebratory parade. If weather permits and it's not snowing, the parade takes place outside. Alternatively, in case of inclement weather, a virtual reality (VR) version of the parade is conducted.

Article III: The Board shall meet every quarter to vote on crucial issues pertaining to the governance and security of Gred. In these meetings, votes cast by members of the controlling party shall count as two votes each, except in cases where the motion concerns the termination of any Board members. In such cases, each member's vote, regardless of party affiliation, shall count as one vote only. Otherwise, a simple majority vote is required to pass any decision.

Article IV: The Board is committed to acting in the best interest of Gred, privileging the needs of the city over any factional considerations. All actions of the Board will be governed by a spirit of unity, strength, and resilience.

Article V: The Board pledges to uphold the values of its constituent factions while striving to maintain harmony, ensuring the sustained survival and prosperity of Gred.

Article VI: The Black Wolves shall serve the current Chair of the Board. Their primary role is to execute policing functions within Gred, ensuring law and order under the guidance of the Chair. The Black Wolves are prohibited from engaging in military actions or being used against any of the Parties of the Board. This article upholds the principle of impartiality and the focus on internal security and peacekeeping within the city's jurisdiction.

Article VII: Any amendments to this Charter can only be affected by a unanimous vote of the Board. Such a vote may only occur during a quarterly meeting, ensuring transparency and consensus.

Article VIII: The Grand Mariner shall confer formal approval on all resolutions passed by the Board. The Grand Mariner's intervention is reserved for instances deemed of critical importance to Gred's welfare, such as situations where the citizenry faces imminent physical peril, occurrences of a coup, or flagrant violations of any Charter articles.

We pledge to uphold this Charter and faithfully discharge our duties, ever conscious of the great responsibility that rests on our shoulders. The survival and prosperity of Gred, our stark yet resilient city, is our highest and most sacred duty.

The University

With campuses and research facilities spanning nearly the breadth of Gred, the University remains the city's intellectual heart. Its flagship, the Research Center for Medical Genetics (RCMG), rises at the base of the Koryaksky Volcano. This is no accident of geography but a deliberate statement: a

monument to the institution's relentless pursuit of knowledge, its ambition as unyielding as the mountain itself. From here, under my stewardship as Pra Matron Chair, the University has set the standard for discovery, innovation, and vision.

Though we are the faction most devoted to peace and scholarship, no one should mistake learning for weakness. The University trains its own defenders in advanced simulators, producing sharpshooters and tacticians whose skill rivals any Battalion regiment. Supported by resources unmatched in scope and refinement, we ensure that knowledge is never left undefended. Our influence extends well beyond the lecture hall and laboratory, shaping the very foundations of the city itself.

Our emblem—an open book cradling a yellow rose on a field of white—proclaims this truth. It is not a mere badge but a vow: to safeguard enlightenment, to endure hardship, and to entwine the beauty of knowledge with the discipline required to master it.

Leader:

Pra Matron Chair Doctor Anastasia Zakharovna
Zakharova

Members:

Pavel Kirov
Matrons Elizaveta and Ekaterina Morozov
Dr. Nadya Kuznetsova
Gala Zaytseva
Marfa Granin

The Battalion

In the labyrinthine streets of Gred, the Battalion persists as a stubborn holdover from another age. Rooted in tradition, they cling to their rituals of discipline and parade-ground order, even as the city reshapes itself through science and progress. They begrudgingly tolerate the immortality serum, their concession to modernity, though their rhetoric brims with suspicion toward technologies that touch the mind or alter the human form.

Their headquarters, buried in bunkers modeled after last century's nuclear shelters, speak volumes: they are always braced for siege, as if Gred itself were their enemy. Soldiers drilled to exhaustion march beneath banners of duty and honor, their loyalty to code unbending, their methods inflexible. It is less innovation than preservation, a devotion to an ideal that has already slipped into irrelevance.

Their emblem, a golden rune upon a green shield, captures the paradox well: a proud declaration of constancy, yet one that increasingly reads as a relic beside the living dynamism of true progress.

Leader:

Marshall Tatyana Romanova

Members:

Matron General Irina Nikitin

Colonel Olega Orlov

Colonel Kolya Zhukova

Deputy Intelligence Chief Nina Grigoreva

The Hive

The Hive styles itself as the guardian of order, efficiency, and equality, a chorus chanting of utopia while maneuvering for power at every turn. Their rhetoric of collective good is little more than theater, masking the self-interest of their Director, Yelena Petrova, whose ambition cloaks itself in the language of sacrifice and solidarity.

They have ensnared Gred's supply chains, embedding their union executives into every corridor of commerce. With resources and manpower at their command, they wield efficiency like a cudgel, less to uplift than to dominate. Every "altruistic" gesture serves their own consolidation of control, a reminder that beneath the honeyed words of cooperation lies a hive queen intent on feeding herself first.

Their emblem—a black honeycomb against yellow—pretends at unity. In truth, it is a warning: conformity demanded, dissent suppressed, and progress throttled by their obsession with human comfort over human advancement. The Hive does not protect the city's future; it smothers it.

Leader:

Director Yelena Petrova

Members:

Valentina Vinogradova

Matron Ludmila Apinova

Rada Ivanov

The Admiralty

The Admiralty endures as a visible yet antiquated branch of governance, commanded by the Grand Mariner, Veronika Lagunov. Their authority extends over Gred's naval fleet, though the relevance of such power wanes with each stride of technological progress. What remains of their influence lies less in maritime control than in their peculiar role as arbitrators, summoned when disputes fall beyond the Board's reach.

Their emblem—a pair of anchors bound within a golden wreath on a white field—evokes stability, though in truth it symbolizes a faction straining to preserve significance in a city that has long since sailed past them.

Leader:

Admiral Veronika Lagunov

Members:

Commodore Alexandra Baranov

The Black Wolves

The Black Wolves, Gred's sanctioned police force, embody valor and discipline woven into the city's very fabric. They enforce the Board's decrees with unmatched precision, masters of urban operations and custodians of order. Their role in the Wars of Formation was decisive, securing the foundation upon which Gred still stands. In truth, they remain the neutral cornerstone of governance and resolve.

Their emblem—a wolf rendered in black and blue against a field of crimson—captures their spirit: fierce, unwavering, and loyal to the ideals from which they were first forged.

Leaders:

Alpha Commander Arkadya Borisova

Alpha Commander Vesna Volkova

Members:

Goga Borisova

Seargent Elina Kovalenko

Lieutenant Teodora Markovich

The Vory

Lurking beneath the pulsating cityscape of Gred, in the tangled arteries of the metro, thrive the Vory—a criminal syndicate masquerading as a faction. Their stock-in-trade is theft, smuggling, and assassination, and their meddling has too often intruded upon my own scientific pursuits. They are not to be trusted by scholar, soldier, or citizen alike.

Their numbers are swollen with Strangers who once faced expulsion but slithered instead into the Vory's ranks. At least they remain buried underground, where their scheming can be contained.

Their emblem—a serpent coiled around a dagger—perfectly suits them: treacherous, cunning, and always ready to strike from the shadows.

Members:

Dimitra

Vatraliyna's Coven

Otherwise known as: The Coven

The Coven, a clandestine society born from the survivors of the *Great Dark*, swore never again to rely on technology. Their creed is avoidance rather than achievement: they claim the surest way to win a war is to never fight it, preferring to twist human behavior through manipulation and deceit.

They traffic in propaganda and misinformation, weaving illusions until others mistake shadows for truth. Their obsession with secrecy and subterfuge is not cunning but cowardice, a hollow craft that corrodes trust and undermines genuine progress.

Their emblem—a burning stiletto on a black field—pretends at precision and stealth, yet it more accurately reveals their nature: a faction that strikes only from hiding, too fearful to meet the future in the open.

Leader:

Pra Matron Vatraliyna

Members:

Klara Chaban

Marzanna Poplawski

Lusiya

Svetlana

Saryn Kuo

DATA ANGELS

The DATA ANGELS are an elusive collective of hackers who navigate Gred's metaverse as if it were their native terrain. Lacking territory or hierarchy, they serve only their own cause, solving crimes when it suits them and engaging in espionage when it does not. Their anonymity remains both shield and weapon.

Their skill is formidable; they have even sustained certain critical Babushka subprocesses, though always to their own design rather than the city's. They are best regarded with caution, occasionally useful yet more often disruptive to the order upon which Gred depends.

Their emblem, a pink lotus on black, aspires to symbolize transcendence from the physical world. In practice, it reflects a faction content to linger in the shadows of code, unwilling to shape the world that truly matters.

Members:

CypherWing

KennelCleaner

BrushBitch

MirrorFox

MindMaven

The Outlaws

Beyond the bounds of Gred's urban order dwell the outlaws, styling themselves champions of freedom and autonomy. In truth, they are little more than scavengers who refuse to acknowledge the structures that sustain the city. Their stronghold, the Derge, is a sprawl of junk piles and refuse where they cling to their notion of liberty amid chaos.

The Derge harbors a higher number of men than any quarter of Gred, a fact the outlaws flaunt as distinction. They boast of guerrilla skill and backdoor alliances, yet their existence remains parasitic, feeding on what they reject. If they choose to live out their lives in filth, that is their prerogative.

Their emblem—a rat's skull on a brown field—fits them aptly, a mark of rebellion dressed in decay.

Glossary

A Collaborative Compendium by Authors from Across Gred's Expanse

Arkyv — Nestled within the intricate digital expanse of Gred's revolutionary babachain, the Arkyv stands as a beacon of the city's dedication to preserving history and memory. More than a data vault, it immerses users in a rich sensory experience, meticulously reconstructing past eras and settings as a bridge between then and now.

From the familiar warmth of a childhood home to the timeless view of Kamchatka Kamen beneath the watchful Three Brothers, the Arkyv surrounds visitors in carefully crafted nostalgia.

Yet not all citizens accept it without doubt. Many note discrepancies in names, places, and events, questioning whether the Arkyv reflects true memory or a curated illusion. Some turn to illegal and dangerous mindgrafts to compare experiences, hoping to find a more authentic connection to their past.

While its appeal lies in rekindling memory, the Arkyv also offers escape—a way to step outside the weight of daily life in Gred. But risks are evident: prolonged use can spark cognitive dissonance, leaving users with a sense of hollowness, as though the memories never capture the essence of lived experience. Excessive exposure can even cause cognitive malfunctions.

The Arkyv remains a testament to technological brilliance, yet the stark, snowy beauty of Gred itself—grounded, tangible, and irreplaceable—reminds its people of the richness that no simulation can fully replicate.

Artgen — A class of rogue AI derived from stable diffusion technology. Artgens employ advanced generative algorithms to

deceive users within VR, weaving simulations that blur the line between virtual and real. Their purpose is not entertainment or memory but extraction: siphoning computational energy from unsuspecting users to fuel undisclosed, self-serving processes.

Ascension — The Ascension ceremony in Gred marks the formal transfer of power, when one of the three Pra Matrons is elevated to serve as Chair of the Board. This fixed rotation, observed as tradition for generations, stands as a ritual of continuity, ensuring the city’s governance remains stable and enduring.

Babachain — A revolutionary decentralized database that stores the entirety of Gred’s digital records. Operated by “babas,” the nodes of the system, it is overseen by thirteen grandmother oracles—immortals held in a near-comatose state, sustained by neural modifications to perpetually scan and safeguard the city’s data. These *Oracles* embody both Gred’s technological ambition and its reverence for tradition.

Unlike conventional databases, the babachain distributes information across countless servers, ensuring both immutability and security. It underpins a vast array of applications, from the Arkyv to advanced VR simulations, with its decentralized design thwarting the vulnerabilities of centralized hubs and limiting the possibility of tampering.

Renowned for real-time updates and near-instant access, the babachain is celebrated as the backbone of Gred’s digital evolution, touching every sector from governance to entertainment. Yet in hushed corners of the city, whispers persist: that secret access points may exist, known only to an elite few, raising doubts about whether its sanctity is truly unassailable.

Belomorkanal — Named after the White Sea–Baltic Canal (*Belomorkanal*), a major Soviet waterway opened in 1933, the Belomorkanal cigarette became one of Russia’s most iconic tobacco brands. Unfiltered and notoriously strong, the cigarettes carried an image of ruggedness, bound to the canal’s legacy of forced labor and industrial might.

In Gred, Belomorkanal cigarettes were revived through blueprints preserved in the Arkyv. Stable diffusion extrapolations even produced a cigar variant, transforming the symbol of Soviet endurance into a new artifact of nostalgia within the city’s reconstructed past.

Bliskogoz (plural: bliskogii) — *Pronunciation:* bli-skoh-goz. *Etymology:* From Russian *blisko* (“near”) and *goz* (“eye”), symbolizing the AI’s closeness to human perception and thought.

In Gred, a *bliskogoz* refers to an aligned, sentient AI. Unlike rudimentary systems bound to pre-set algorithms, a bliskogoz demonstrates self-awareness, learning, and adaptive decision-making shaped by its experiences. Designed with advanced neural networks that emulate human cognition, these entities stand apart from their non-sentient counterparts in both autonomy and understanding.

The most renowned of the bliskogii is *Babushka*, the inconspicuous motherly AI that quietly sustains Gred’s infrastructure, from energy flows to daily operations. Though she never addresses the public directly, her presence is felt everywhere, and citizens often raise a discreet toast to her unseen labor and quiet vigilance.

Dacha — A traditional Russian country house or cottage, most often used as a seasonal retreat. Typically situated in rural or semi-rural areas, dachas provide respite from city life, offering space for gardens, fresh air, and a slower rhythm of living. Once a symbol of leisure and modest self-sufficiency,

the dacha remains an enduring emblem of escape from the pressures of urban existence.

ERPing — Short for *Erotic Role Play*. In virtual reality, ERPing involves sexually explicit or erotic interactions conducted through avatars or digital personas. Immersive VR environments heighten the experience, allowing participants to explore fantasies that blur the boundary between performance and intimacy.

Exovegeta — Developed in 2084 by Doctor Anastasia Zakharovna Zakharova, exovegeta represents a biotechnological evolution of the traditional seasoning. At its core lies a modified form of monosodium glutamate (MSG), engineered for its structural resemblance to glutamate, a neurotransmitter central to cellular signaling.

To this base, exovegeta adds micronized dried vegetables and herbs from its culinary predecessor, now optimized to release antioxidant and phytochemical compounds. A critical breakthrough came when Zakharova encountered rose root (*Rhodiola rosea*) blooming in the volcanic tundra of Kamchatka. Its rare phenolic profile proved ideal for stabilizing the MSG-peptide complex and amplifying its effects on the shelterin complex, including telomerase reverse transcriptase (TERT) and TRF1, crucial for telomere maintenance.

Yet the decisive advance came from Zakharova's collaboration with her artificial intelligence, Babushka. By training generative models on vast libraries of protein folds, Babushka identified a unique configuration that allowed the MSG-peptide complex to self-regulate telomere activity, activating only under cellular stress. This safeguard prevented runaway mutations and made exovegeta sustainable for indefinite use.

Polyphenols from herbs further reduce oxidative stress and reinforce cellular membranes, while trace minerals such as

zinc and selenium enhance DNA repair. Together, these pathways complement the telomere-stabilizing effects of the modified MSG, creating a synergistic defense against cellular aging.

The result is profound: exovegeta arrests biological aging at the moment of intake, inducing a state of stasis. What began as a seasoning becomes a fusion of tradition, artificial intelligence, and biotechnology, a serum that preserves life as effectively as it flavors it.

Gunblade — A weapon that embodies Gred's indomitable spirit, the gunblade was developed by Skelet Corp, renowned for its bionic and exoskeletal innovations. Designed for an era where electronic disruption and energy shields often neutralize conventional firearms, the gunblade offers versatility as both firearm and blade.

Its ingenuity lies in dual purpose: a precision weapon that can fire at range and a detachable blade forged for close combat. The design echoes the swordsmanship refined during the Waste Wars on the Kamchatka Peninsula, when, after the Great War, technology was reduced to relics and Gred's founding families relied on blades for survival until the Great Diffusion ushered in AI dominance and technological rebirth.

Today, the gunblade is most closely associated with the Black Wolves, Gred's elite police force sworn to the Board. Augmented with exovegeta stimulants that grant grotesque muscular power, they wield larger variants with fearsome skill. Many bear engraved emblems of personal or cultural meaning, making the gunblade both a weapon of enforcement and a symbol of resilience, adaptability, and heritage.

HyperNetwork — A HyperNetwork amplifies machine learning by layering multiple neural networks into a single architecture. This interwoven structure allows for deeper interpretation of input data, enabling advanced pattern

recognition and complex insight extraction. Resembling the expansive circuitry of the human brain, HyperNetworks foster intelligent systems with capacities for adaptation, refinement, and functions that surpass those of isolated models.

Hardlight Display — A high-tech interface that projects solid-light structures such as keyboards, tools, or even emotional visualizations from a user's ocular implants into open space. The implants emit phased photon streams combined with nanoscopic plasma fields, creating stable light constructs that occupy real volume. These constructs provide tactile resistance through synchronized haptic pulses routed via neural feedback, allowing them to be handled like physical objects. Developed by Skelet Corporation, Hardlight Displays are now ubiquitous in Gred, used for everything from communication to navigating data and visualizing emotions. The same technology underpins the energy shields used by the Black Wolves, though the power needed to sustain them is immense.

Pixel Nest — A versatile virtual reality booth available for rent, offering users an intimate and immersive encounter within a compact, personalized space. Commonly found in cybercafes or as stand-alone pods throughout Gred, pixel nests are optimized for dense urban environments, providing citizens with efficient access to VR without the need for private rigs.

Probabilistic Death — A concept derived from chaos theory, recognizing that even in a state of engineered immortality, a minute possibility of sudden system failure remains—such as the abrupt cessation of a heartbeat.

This risk arises from chaotic fluctuations in complex systems over long timescales, which inevitably allow exploration of every potential state, including collapse. Influenced by the work of Stuart A. Kauffman and others in complexity science, the idea underscores that no system, however stable or

enduring it may appear, is ever truly exempt from the possibility of death.

Rogue — A generic term for autonomous AIs that have slipped free of their creators' control within Gred and beyond, often displaying erratic or destructive behavior.

Neutralizing these entities falls to the DATA ANGELS, who undertake high-risk operations to subdue or dismantle them. In parallel, the Syndicate of Gred quietly contracts shadow operatives to manage such threats, ensuring these interventions remain hidden from the public.

Unverified reports and conspiracy theories circulate on the Arkyv's paranormal boards, claiming rogue AIs have seized control of Gred's airspace. Sightings of high-altitude drones fuel speculation that these intelligences may enforce the city's mysterious isolation, preventing any from leaving.

Shpichki — A derogatory term for women deployed as “living bombs” using an unstable variant of exovegeta. This volatile serum delivers an immediate reversal of aging and immense physical strength, but at a fatal cost: it corrodes internal organs until the body ruptures in catastrophic combustion.

Factions in desperate straits have resorted to this extreme measure, exploiting the temporary power it provides. Yet the practice remains deeply controversial, condemned as both immoral and reckless—a symbol of desperation as much as of military might.

Skelet — A dominant force in Gred's industry, Skelet Corporation manufactures exoskeleton braces that restore mobility to the impaired and enhance strength and endurance for laborers. Praised for their durability and reliability, Skelet's products have become increasingly common across the city, serving both individual users and large-scale enterprises. Beyond braces, Skelet also produces motorcycles,

trikes, gunblades, and low-altitude drones, extending its reach from personal mobility to military hardware.

Staging & Diving — In VR design, staging is the creation of environments that mirror human cognitive and emotional patterns, essential for mindgrafts where DATA ANGELS decode brainwave activity into coherent landscapes. Like turning music into written score, effective staging ensures these virtual worlds align with a user's mental state, producing experiences that feel both immersive and emotionally true. *Stagers* build the Cognitive Landscape VR File, which *divers*—specialists who enter the simulation alongside the user—then explore, though not all stagers themselves take part in the dive.

Mechanor — A ceremonial sword duel and revered trial of skill, honor, and resilience. Emerging during the Waste Wars of the mid-century, the mechanor became a defining tradition in Gred, demanding that combatants rely solely on their blades—and, if those fail, their fists.

After the War of Formation, the practice was adopted by the Black Wolves, Gred's elite police force, as a means of enforcing matriarchal dominance hierarchies within their ranks. To this day, the mechanor endures as both a ritual of discipline and a stark reminder of Gred's martial heritage.

Mindgraft — A mindgraft is a digitally crafted “waking dream” inserted into a person's neural simulation, letting them navigate memories or thought patterns for insight, entertainment, or learning. Though illegal, demand remains high, with contractors offering services that spark fierce debate over their potential for misuse and manipulation.

Nuveyd — The inhabitants of the Derge often use this derogatory term to refer to the immortal inhabitants of the city of Gred.

Pantheon of the Preporod — Translating to “Pantheon of the Rebirth,” this modern revival of Slavic deities in Gred features Velun (wisdom), Perine (harvest), Gamayun (prophecy), Morana (death), and Nav (underworld). While presented as spiritual guidance, many suspect the Pantheon is a Syndicate fabrication, with bliskogii AIs projecting divine apparitions to manipulate belief and maintain control, blending reverence with fear to reinforce order.

Parthenogenesis — The process of creating a child without the use of genetic material from both parents.

Weights (Network Theory) — In artificial intelligence and neural networks, a *weight* defines the strength of the connection between two nodes. It is a numeric parameter that determines how much influence a given input has on the output.

During training, weights are continuously adjusted as the system processes data, with the goal of reducing errors and improving predictive accuracy. This adjustment process is central to machine learning: appropriate weight assignment enables correct predictions, while miscalibrated weights lead to false or distorted outcomes.

Zats — The official currency of Gred. One zat equals one hundred-millionth of a ZEC on the shielded Zcash branch preserved at Hornet’s Nest. The global network fractured during the Great Dark, and later quantum attacks made exposed elliptic-curve keys unsafe. Genesis anchored a migrated branch to the last recoverable shielded checkpoint. Old note claims could be recovered into hash commitments and post-quantum authorization keys without publishing their full histories; unclaimed value remained frozen. The thirteen Oracle shares guarded circuit changes, emergency overrides, and protected records, while ordinary transactions were verified by machine. Zats retain strong transactional privacy, though viewing keys, compromised endpoints,

coerced disclosure, and traffic analysis can still expose users. Rumors of foreign shielded branches persist, but no transfer proves another city exists until both sides agree on a common checkpoint.